

HARRY POTTER AND DEATHLY HALLOWS BOOK I, BY J.K. ROWLING TEXT
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 WHITE TOMB THE EITHER MINISTER IT WAS NEARING MIDNIGHT AND THE
 PRIME MINISTER WAS SITTING ALONE IN HIS OFFICE, READING A LONG
 MEMO THAT WAS SLIPPING THROUGH HIS BRAIN WITHOUT LEAVING THE
 SLIGHTEST TRACE OF MEANING BEHIND. HE WAS WAITING FOR A CALL FROM
 THE PRESIDENT OF A FAR DISTANT COUNTRY, AND BETWEEN WANDERING

WHEN THE WRETCHED MAN WHELD TELEPHONE, AND TRYING THE SUPPRESS UNPLEASANT MEMORIES OF WHAT HAD BEEN A VERY LONG, TIRING, AND DIFFICULT WEEK, THERE WAS NOT MUCH SPACE IN HIS HEAD FOR ANYTHING ELSE. THE MORE HE ATTEMPTED THE FEELS HIM THE PRINT IN THE PAGE BEFORE HIM, THE MORE CLEARLY THE PRIME MINISTER COULD SEE THE GLOATING FACE OF ONE OF HIS POLITICAL OPPONENTS. THIS PARTICULAR OPPONENT HAD APPEARED IN THE NEWS THAT VERY DAY, NOT ONLY THE ENLARGE ALL THE TERRIBLE THINGS THAT HAD HAPPENED IN THE LAST WEEK AS THOUGH ANYONE NEEDED REMINDING! BUT ALSO THE EXPLAIN WHY EACH AND EVERY ONE OF THEM WAS THE GOVERNMENT'S FAULT. THE PRIME MINISTER'S PULSE QUICKENED AT THE VERY THOUGHT OF THESE ACCUSATIONS, FOR THEY WERE NEITHER FAIR NOR TRUE. HOW IN EARTH WAS HIS GOVERNMENT SUPPOSED TO HAVE STOPPED THAT BRIDGE COLLAPSING? IT WAS CATASTROPHIC FOR ANYBODY THE SUGGEST THAT THEY WERE NOT SPENDING ENOUGH ON BRIDGES. THE BRIDGE WAS FEWER THAN TEN YEARS OLD, AND THE BEST EXPERTS WERE AT A LOSS TO EXPLAIN WHY IT HAD SNAPPED CLEANLY IN TWO, SENDING A DOZEN CARS INTO THE WATERY DEPTHS OF THE RIVER BELOW, AND HOW DARE ANYONE SUGGEST THAT IT WAS LACK OF POLICEMEN THAT HAD RESULTED IN THESE TWO VERY NASTY AND WELL-PUBLICIZED MURDERS? FOR THAT THE GOVERNMENT SHOULD HAVE SOMEHOW FORESEEN THE FREAK HURRICANE IN THE WEST COUNTRY THAT HAD CAUSED SO MUCH DAMAGE TO BOTH PEOPLE AND PROPERTY? AND WAS IT HIS FAULT THAT ONE OF HIS JUNIOR MINISTERS, HERBERT CHURLEY, HAD CHOSEN THIS WEEK TO ACT SO PECULIARLY THAT HE WAS NOW BEING THE ONE SPENDING A LOT MORE TIME WITH HIS FAMILY? A GRIM MOOD HAD GRIPPED THE COUNTRY. THE OPPONENT HAD CHUCKLED, BARELY CONCEALING HIS OWN BRUTAL GRIN, AND UNFORTUNATELY, THIS WAS PERFECTLY TRUE. THE PRIME MINISTER FELT IT HIMSELF; PEOPLE REALLY DID SEEM MORE MISERABLE THAN USUAL. EVEN THE WEATHER WAS DISMAL; ALL THIS CHILLY MIST IN THE MIDDLE OF JULY. IT WASN'T RIGHT, IT WASN'T NORMAL. HE TURNED OVER THE SECOND PAGE OF THE MEMO, SAW FEEL MUCH LONGER IT WENT ON, AND GAVE IT UP AS A BAD IDEA. STRETCHING HIS ARMS ABOVE HIS HEAD HE LOOKED AROUND HIS OFFICE MELANCHOLICALLY. IT WAS A HANDSOME ROOM, WITH A FINE MARBLE FIREPLACE FACING THE LONG SASH WINDOWS, FIRMLY CLOSED AGAINST THE UNSEASONABLE CHILL. WITH A SLIGHT SHIVER, THE PRIME MINISTER GOT UP AND MOVED OVER TO THE WINDOW, LOOKING OUT AT THE THIN MIST THAT WAS PRESSING ITSELF AGAINST THE GLASS. IT WAS THEN, AS HE STOOD

WITH HIS BACK TO THE ROOM, THAT HE HEARD A SOFT CHUCK BEHIND HIM. HE FREEZE, NEAR THE MERE WITH HIS EYES SCARED-LOOKING REFLECTION IN THE DARK GLASS. HE KNEW THAT CHUCK, HE HAD HEARD IT BEFORE. HE TURNED VERY SLOWLY THE FACE THE EMPTY ROOM. 'WELL' HE SAID, TRYING THE SLOWEST BREATH HE FELT, FOR A BRIEF MOMENT HE ALLOWED HIMSELF THE IMPOSSIBLE HOPE THAT SOMEONE WOULD ANSWER HIM.

HOWEVER, A VOICE RESPONDED AT ONCE, A CRISP, DECISIVE VOICE THAT SOUNDED AS THOUGH IT WERE READING A PREPARED STATEMENT. IT WAS CHIMPING AS THE PRIME MINISTER HAD KNOWN AT THE FIRST CHUCK FROM THE FREELING LITTLE MAN WEARING A LONG SILVER WIG WHO WAS DEPICTED IN A SMALL, DIRTY OIL PAINTING IN THE FAR CORNER OF THE ROOM. THE PRIME MINISTER OF MUGGLES, WAGENT WE MEET, KINDLY RESPONDED IMMEDIATELY, SINCERELY, FLUDGE. THE MAN IN THE PAINTING LOOKED INQUIRINGLY AT THE PRIME MINISTER. ER, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER, LISTEN. IT'S NOT A VERY GOOD TIME FOR ME. I'M WAITING FOR A TELEPHONE CALL, YOU SEE FROM THE PRESIDENT OF

THAT CAN BE REARRANGED, SAID THE PORTRAIT AT ONCE. THE PRIME MINISTER'S HEART SANK. HE HAD BEEN AFRAID OF THAT. BUT I REALLY WAS RATHER HOPING THE SPREAD WE SHALL ARRANGE FOR THE PRESIDENT THE MIGHTY THE CALL. HE WILL TELEPHONE TOMORROW NIGHT INSTEAD, SAID THE LITTLE MAN. KINDLY RESPOND IMMEDIATELY THE MR. FLUDGE. I AM VERY WELL, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER WEABLY.

YES, I AM SEE FLUDGE. HE HURRIED BACK TO HIS DESK, STRAIGHTENING HIS TIE AS HE WENT. HE HAD BARELY RESUMED HIS SEAT, AND ARRANGED HIS FACE INTO WHAT HE HOPED WAS A RELAXED AND LIVELY EXPRESSION, WHEN BRIGHT GREEN FLAMES BURST INTO LIFE IN THE EMPTY GRATE BENEATH HIS MARBLE MANTELPIECE. HE WATCHED, TRYING NOT TO BETRAY A FLICKER OF SURPRISE OR ALARM, AS A PORTLY MAN APPEARED WITHIN THE FLAMES, SPINNING AS FAST AS A TOP. SECONDS LATER, HE HAD CLIMBED UPON A RATHER FINE ANTIQUE RUG, BRUSHING ASH FROM THE SLEEVES OF HIS LONG PIN-STRIPED COAT, A LIME-GREEN KILT HAT IN HIS HAND.

AH PRIME MINISTER, SAID CHERNELIS FLUDGE, STRIDING FORWARD WITH HIS HAND OUTSTRETCHED. GOOD TO SEE YOU AGAIN. THE PRIME MINISTER COULD NOT HONESTLY RETURN THIS COMPLIMENT, HE SAID NOTHING AT ALL. HE WAS NOT REMOTELY PLEASED TO SEE FLUDGE, WHOSE ECCENTRIC APPEARANCES, APART FROM BEING DELIBERATELY ALARMING IN THEMSELVES, GENERALLY MEANT THAT HE WAS ABOUT TO HEAR SOME VERY BAD NEWS. FURTHERMORE, FLUDGE WAS LOOKING DISTINCTLY CAREWORN. HE

WAS THINNER, RAUER, AND GRAYER, AND HIS FACE HAD A CRUMPLED LINE.
THE PRIME MINISTER HAD SEEN THAT KIND OF LINE IN POLITICIANS
BEFORE, AND IT NEVER SEED WELL. "HOW CAN I HELP YOU?" HE SAID,
SHAKING FUDGE'S HAND VERY BRIEFLY AND GESTURING TOWARD THE
HARDEST OF THE CHAIRS IN FRONT OF THE DESK. DIFFICULT TO KNEEL
WHERE THE BEGIN, MUTTERED FUDGE, PULLING UP THE CHAIR, SITTING
DOWN, AND PLACING HIS GREEN KNEELER UPON HIS KNEES. "WHAT A WEEK,
WHAT A WEEK" "HAD A BAD WEEK THEN, HAVE YOU?" ASKED THE PRIME
MINISTER STIFFLY, KEEPING THE CHIN UP BY THIS THAT HE HAD WHITE
ENOUGH ON HIS PLATE ALREADY WITHOUT ANY EXTRA HELPINGS FROM
FUDGE. YES, HE CHURCH, SAID FUDGE, RUBBING HIS EYES WEARILY AND
LOOKING NERVOUSLY AT THE PRIME MINISTER. I'VE BEEN HAVING THE
SAME WEEK YOU HAVE, PRIME MINISTER. THE BRICKDALE BRIDGE THE
KINGS AND VANCE MURDERS NOT THE MENTION THE RICKLES IN THE
WEST COUNTRY YOU OR YOU I MEAN THE SAY, SOME OF
YOUR PEOPLE WERE WERE INVOLVED IN THESE THESE THINGS, WERE
THEY? FUDGE FIXED THE PRIME MINISTER WITH A RATHER STERN LOOK.

HE CHURCH THEY WERE, HE SAID. SURELY YOU'VE REALIZED WHAT'S
GOING ON? I HESITATED THE PRIME MINISTER. IT WAS PRECISELY
THIS SORT OF BEHAVIOR THAT MADE HIM DISLIKE FUDGE'S VISITS SO MUCH.
HE WAS, AFTER ALL, THE PRIME MINISTER AND DID NOT APPRECIATE BEING
MADE TO FEEL LIKE AN IGNORANT SCHEMER, BUT HE CHURCH, IT HAD BEEN
LIKE THIS FROM HIS VERY FIRST MEETING WITH FUDGE ON HIS VERY FIRST
EVENING AS PRIME MINISTER. HE REMEMBERED IT AS THOUGH IT WERE
YESTERDAY AND KNEW IT WOULD HAUNT HIM UNTIL HIS DYING DAY. HE HAD
BEEN STANDING ALONE IN THIS VERY OFFICE, SAYING THE TRIUMPH
THAT WAS HIS AFTER SO MANY YEARS OF DREAMING AND SCHEMING, WHEN
HE HAD HEARD A VOICE BEHIND HIM, JUST LIKE TONIGHT, AND TURNED TO
FIND THAT LITTLE LITTLE PORTRAIT TALKING TO HIM, ANNOUNCING THAT
THE MINISTER OF MAGIC WAS ABOUT TO ARRIVE AND INTRODUCED HIMSELF.
NATURALLY, HE HAD THOUGHT THAT THE LONG CAMPAIGN AND THE
STRAIN OF THE ELECTION HAD CALLED HIM TO THE GOD. HE HAD BEEN
LITERALLY TERRIFIED TO FIND A PORTRAIT TALKING TO HIM, THOUGH THIS
HAD BEEN NOTHING TO FEEL HE FELT WHEN A SELF-PROCLAIMED WIZARD HAD
BEHIND HIM OF THE FIREPLACE AND SHAKEN HIS HAND. HE HAD REMAINED
SPEECHLESS THROUGHOUT FUDGE'S KINDLY EXPLANATION THAT THERE
WERE WITCHES AND WIZARDS STILL LIVING IN SECRET ALL OVER THE WORLD
AND HIS REASSURANCES THAT HE WAS NOT THE EITHER HIS HEAD ABOUT

THEM AS THE MINISTER OF MAGIC THEIR RESPONSIBILITY FOR THE WHOLE
 WIZARDING COMMUNITY AND PREVENTED THE NON-MAGICAL POPULATION
 FROM GETTING WIND OF THEM. IT WAS, SAID FLUDGE, A DIFFICULT JOB THAT
 ENCOMPASSED EVERYTHING FROM REGULATIONS AND RESPONSIBLE USE OF
 KREHMSTICKS TO KEEPING THE DRAGON POPULATION UNDER CONTROL
 (THE PRIME MINISTER REMEMBERED CLUTCHING THE DESK FOR SLOPPERT AT
 THIS POINT). FLUDGE HAD THEN PATTED THE SHOULDER OF THE STILL-
 BLINKSTROCK PRIME MINISTER IN A FATHERLY SORT OF WAY. NEXT THE
 WHIRRY, HE HAD SAID, IT S HODS-EN YELL LL NEVER SEE ME AGAIN. I LL
 ENLY EITHER YELL IF THERE S SOMETHING REALLY SERIOUS GOING ON OUR
 END, SOMETHING THAT S LIKELY TO AFFECT THE MUGGLES THE NON-
 MAGICAL POPULATION, I SHOULD SAY, OTHERWISE, IT S LIVE AND LET LIVE.
 AND I MUST SAY, YELL RE TAKING IT A LOT BETTER THAN YOUR
 PREDECESSOR, HE TRIED TO TELL ME BUT THE WINDS, THOUGHT I WAS
 A HAZARD PLANNED BY THE HYPOTHESIS. AT THIS, THE PRIME MINISTER
 HAD FELT HIS WHISK AT LAST. YELL RE YELL RE NOT A HAZARD, THEN?
 IT HAD BEEN HIS LAST, DESPERATE HOPE. NO, SAID FLUDGE GENTLY, NO,
 I M AFRAID I M NOT, LEND. AND HE HAD TURNED THE PRIME MINISTER S
 TRAIL UP INTO A GURGLE. BUT, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER BREATHLESSLY,
 WATCHING HIS TRAIL CHEWING ON THE CORNER OF HIS NEXT SPEECH,
 BUT WHY WHY HAS NOBODY TOLD ME ? THE MINISTER OF MAGIC
 ENLY REVEALS HIM-HER HIMSELF TO THE MUGGLE PRIME MINISTER OF THE
 DAY, SAID FLUDGE, POKING HIS HAND BACK INSIDE HIS JACKET. WE FIND IT
 THE BEST WAY TO MAINTAIN SECRECY. BUT THEN, BEATED THE PRIME
 MINISTER, WHY HASN T A FORMER PRIME MINISTER WARNED ME ?
 AT THIS, FLUDGE HAD ACTUALLY LAUGHED. MY DEAR PRIME MINISTER, ARE
 YELL EVER GOING TO TELL ANYBODY? STILL CHORTLING, FLUDGE HAD
 THROWN SOME FUEL INTO THE FIREPLACE, STEPPED INTO THE EMERALD
 FLAMES, AND VANISHED WITH A WHISPERING SOUND. THE PRIME MINISTER
 HAD STOOD THERE, BLITZ MENTHERLESS, AND REALIZED THAT HE WOULD
 NEVER, AS LONG AS HE LIVED, DARE MENTION THIS ENCOUNTER TO A LIVING
 SOUL, FOR WHO IN THE WIDE WORLD WOULD BELIEVE HIM? THE SNEAK HAD
 TAKEN A LITTLE WHILE TO WEAR OFF, FOR A TIME, HE HAD TRIED TO
 CONVINCE HIMSELF THAT FLUDGE HAD INDEED BEEN A HALUCINATION
 BRIGHTENED BY LACK OF SLEEP DURING HIS GRUELING ELECTION
 CAMPAIGN. IN A VAIN ATTEMPT TO RID HIMSELF OF ALL REMINDERS OF THIS
 UNCOMFORTABLE ENCOUNTER, HE HAD GIVEN THE GURGLE THE HIS DELIGHTED
 NICK AND INSTRUCTED HIS PRIVATE SECRETARY TO TAKE DOWN THE

PORTRAIT OF THE LELY LITTLE MAN WHO HAD ANNOUNCED FLUDGE'S ARRIVAL. THE PRIME MINISTER'S DISMAY, HOWEVER, THE PORTRAIT HAD PROVED IMPOSSIBLE TO REMOVE. WHEN SEVERAL CARPENTERS, A JOINER AND AN ART HISTORIAN, AND THE CHANCELLER OF THE EXCHEQUER HAD ALL TRIED UNSUCCESSFULLY TO PRIZE IT FROM THE WALL, THE PRIME MINISTER HAD ABANDONED THE ATTEMPT AND SIMPLY RESOLVED THE MORE THAT THE THING REMAINED MUTE AND SILENT FOR THE REST OF HIS TERM IN OFFICE. OCCASIONALLY HE COULD HAVE SWORN HE SAW BLITZ IN THE CORNER OF HIS EYE THE ECLIPSE OF THE PAINTING YAWNING, OR ELSE SCRATCHING HIS NOSE; EVEN, HENCE ON TWICE, SIMPLY WALKING BLITZ OF HIS FRAME AND LEAVING NOTHING BUT A STRETCH OF MILKY-BROWN CANVAS BEHIND. HOWEVER, HE HAD TRAINED HIMSELF NOT TO LOOK AT THE PICTURE VERY MUCH, AND ALWAYS TO TELL HIMSELF FIRMLY THAT HIS EYES WERE PLAYING TRICKS ON HIM WHEN ANYTHING LIKE THIS HAPPENED. THEN, THREE YEARS AGO, ON A NIGHT VERY LIKE TONIGHT, THE PRIME MINISTER HAD BEEN ALONE IN HIS OFFICE WHEN THE PORTRAIT HAD ONCE AGAIN ANNOUNCED THE IMMINENT ARRIVAL OF FLUDGE, WHO HAD FIRST BLITZ OF THE FIREPLACE, SHEDDING LOTS AND IN A STATE OF CONSIDERABLE PANIC. BEFORE THE PRIME MINISTER COULD ASK WHY HE WAS DRIPPING ALL OVER THE ADMINISTER, FLUDGE HAD STARTED RANTING ABOUT A PRISONER THE PRIME MINISTER HAD NEVER HEARD OF, A MAN NAMED SERPENTIS BLACK, SOMETHING THAT SOUNDED LIKE

HEGWARTS, AND A BOY CALLED HARRY POTTER, NONE OF WHICH MADE THE REMOTEST SENSE TO THE PRIME MINISTER. I'VE JUST COME FROM AZKABAN, FLUDGE HAD PANTED, TIPPING A LARGE AMPLINT OF WATER BLITZ OF THE RIM OF HIS JOINER HAT INTO HIS POCKET. MIDDLE OF THE NORTH SEA, WELL KNOWN, NASTY FLIGHT THE DEWENTERS ARE IN LIPHEAR HE SHEDDERED THEY'VE NEVER HAD A BREAKOUT BEFORE. ANYWAY, I HAD TO COME TO YOU, PRIME MINISTER. BLACK'S A KNOWN MURDER KILLER AND MAY BE PLANNING THE REIGN OF TERROR WITH. BUT HE CHARGED, WELL THEN I'VE KNOWN WHO TOLD-KNOWN-WHO IS? HE HAD GAZED IMPASSIVELY AT THE PRIME MINISTER FOR A MOMENT, THEN SAID, WELL, SIT DOWN, SIT DOWN, I'D BETTER FILL YOU IN. HAVE A WHISKY

THE PRIME MINISTER RATHER RESENTED BEING TOLD TO SIT DOWN IN HIS OWN OFFICE, LET ALONE OFFERED HIS OWN WHISKY, BUT HE SAT NEVERTHELESS. FLUDGE PULLED OUT HIS HAND, CHIRLED TWO LARGE GLASSES FULL OF AMBER LIQUID BLITZ OF THIN AIR, POLISHED ONE OF THEM INTO THE PRIME MINISTER'S HAND, AND DREW UP A CHAIR. FLUDGE HAD

CHILD SHOULD, WHEN WAIT LIST HERE MOMENT? FLJGE HAD VANISHED IN A SWIRL OF GREEN SPARKS, WHATEVER THE PRESS AND THE HYPOTHETICAL MIGHT SAY, THE PRIME MINISTER WAS NOT A FOOLISH MAN. IT HAD NOT ESCAPED HIS NOTICE THAT, DESPITE FLJGE'S ASSURANCES AT THEIR FIRST MEETING, THEY WERE NOW SEEING RATHER A LOT OF EACH OTHER, NOT THAT FLJGE WAS BECOMING MORE ALISTED WITH EACH VISIT, LITTLE THOUGH HE LIKED THE THING ABOUT THE MINISTER OF MAGIC HER, AS HE ALWAYS CALLED FLJGE IN HIS HEAD, THE EITHER MINISTER, THE PRIME MINISTER CHILD NOT FELT BUT FEAR THAT THE NEXT TIME FLJGE APPEARED IT WOULD BE WITH GRAVER NEWS STILL. THE SIGHT, THEREFORE, OF FLJGE STEPPING OUT OF THE FIRE HERE HERE, LOOKING DISHEVELLED AND FRETFUL AND STERNLY SURPRISED THAT THE PRIME MINISTER DID NOT KNOW EXACTLY WHY HE WAS THERE, WAS ABOUT THE WORST THING THAT HAD HAPPENED IN THE COURSE OF THIS EXTREMELY GLIMMY WEEK. THEN SHOULD I KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON IN THE ER WIZARDING COMMUNITY? SNAPPED THE PRIME MINISTER NOW. I HAVE A FEELING THE RAIN AND WHITE ENOUGH CONCERNS AT THE MOMENT WITH-OUT

WE HAVE THE SAME CONCERNS, FLJGE INTERRUPTED. THE BRICKDALE BRIDGE DIDN'T WEAR OUT. THAT WASN'T REALLY A FLOODING. THESE MURDERS WERE NOT THE WORK OF MUGGLES, AND HERBERT CHARLEY'S FAMILY WOULD BE SAFER WITH-OUT HIM. WE ARE CURRENTLY MAKING ARRANGEMENTS TO HAVE HIM TRANSFERRED TO ST. MUNGUS'S HOSPITAL FOR MAGICAL MALADIES AND INJURIES. THE MOVE SHOULD BE EFFECTED TONIGHT. WHAT DO YOU I'M AFRAID I WHAT? ELISTED THE PRIME MINISTER. FLJGE TOOK A GREAT, DEEP BREATH AND SAID, PRIME MINISTER, I AM VERY SORRY TO HAVE TO TELL YOU THAT HE'S BACK. HE- WE-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED IS BACK. BACK? WHEN YOU SAY BACK HE'S ALIVE? I MEAN

THE PRIME MINISTER GRIEVED IN HIS MEMORY FOR THE DETAILS OF THAT TERRIBLE CONVERSATION OF THREE YEARS PREVIOUSLY, WHEN FLJGE HAD TOLD HIM ABOUT THE WIZARD WHO WAS FEARED ABOVE ALL OTHERS, THE WIZARD WHO HAD COMMITTED A THOUSAND TERRIBLE CRIMES BEFORE HIS MYSTERIOUS DISAPPEARANCE FIFTEEN YEARS EARLIER. YES, ALIVE, SAID FLJGE. THAT IS I DON'T KNOW IS A MAN ALIVE IF HE CAN'T BE KILLED? I DON'T REALLY UNDERSTAND IT, AND DUNNO WHERE WHEN TO EXPLAIN PROPERLY BUT ANYWAY, HE'S CERTAINLY GET A BODY AND IS WALKING AND TALKING AND DRINKING, SEE I SUPPOSE, FOR THE PURPOSES OF OUR DISCUSSION, YES, HE'S ALIVE. THE PRIME MINISTER DID NOT KNOW WHAT TO SAY TO THIS, BUT A PERSISTENT HABIT

HE WISHING TO APPEAR WELL-INFORMED AND ANY SUBJECT THAT CAME UP
MADE HIM LAST AFTERNOON FOR ANY DETAILS HE COULD REMEMBER OF THEIR
PREVIOUS CONVERSATIONS. IS SIRILUS BLACK WITH ER ER-
WITH MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED? BLACK? BLACK? SAID FLUDGE DISTRACTEDLY,
TURNING HIS KNEELER RAPIDLY IN HIS FINGERS. SIRILUS BLACK, WELL
MEAN? MERLIN'S BEARD, NEH, BLACK'S DEAD, THINGS BEHUT WE WERE ER
MISTAKEN ABOUT BLACK, ER WAS INNOCENT AFTER ALL, AND HE WASN'T IN
LEAGUE WITH ER-WITH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED EITHER, I MEAN, HE ADDED
DEFENSIVELY, SPINNING THE KNEELER FASTER STILL FASTER, ALL THE EVIDENCE
POINTED WE HAD MORE THAN FIFTY WITNESSES BUT ANYWAY, AS
I SAY, HE'S DEAD, MURDERED, AS A MATTER OF FACT, THE MINISTRY OF
MAGIC PREMISES, THERE'S GOING TO BE AN INQUIRY, ACTUALLY. THE
HIS GREAT SURPRISE, THE PRIME MINISTER FELT A FLEETING STAB OF PITY
FOR FLUDGE AT THIS POINT. IT WAS, HOWEVER, ECLIPSED ALMOST
IMMEDIATELY BY A GLEAM OF SMUGNESS AT THE THOUGHT THAT, DEFICIENT
THOUGH HE HIMSELF MIGHT BE IN THE AREA OF MATERIALIZING BEHUT OF
FIREPLACES, THERE HAD NEVER BEEN A MURDER IN ANY OF THE
GOVERNMENT DEPARTMENTS UNDER HIS CHARGE. NOT YET, ANYWAY
WHILE THE PRIME MINISTER SLURP-TITIVELY THOUGHT THE WHOLE OF
HIS DEED, FLUDGE CONTINUED, BUT BLACK'S BY-THE-WAY NEH, THE POINT IS,
WE'RE AT WAR, PRIME MINISTER, AND STEPS MUST BE TAKEN. AT WAR?
REPEATED THE PRIME MINISTER NERVELY. SURELY THAT'S A LITTLE BIT
OF AN OVERSTATEMENT? ER-WITH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED HAS NEH
BEEN THINED BY THESE OF HIS FOLLOWERS WITH KNIFE BEHUT OF AZDARAN IN
JANUARY, SAID FLUDGE, SPEAKING MORE AND MORE RAPIDLY AND TWIRLING
HIS KNEELER SO FAST THAT IT WAS A LIMEGREEN BLUR. SINCE THEY HAVE
MOVED INTO THE OPEN, THEY HAVE BEEN WRECKING HAVOC. THE
KNEEDDALE BRIDGE HE DID IT, PRIME MINISTER, HE THREATENED A MASS
MURDER KILLING UNLESS I STOOD ASIDE FOR HIM AND GOOD GRIEF,
SEE IT'S YOUR FAULT THESE PEOPLE WERE KILLED AND I'M HAVING THE
ANSWER QUESTIONS ABOUT LISTED RIGGING AND CHARGED EXPANSION
POINTS AND I DON'T KNOW WHAT ELSE? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER
FLURRIEDLY. MY FAULT? SAID FLUDGE, CHEERING UP, ARE YOU SAYING
YOU WOULD HAVE LAYED IN THE BLACKMAIL LIKE THAT? MAYBE NOT,
SAID THE PRIME MINISTER, STANDING UP AND STRIDING ABOUT THE ROOM,
BUT I WOULD HAVE PUT ALL MY EFFORTS INTO CATCHING THE BLACKMAILER
BEFORE HE COMMITTED ANY SUCH ATROCITY? DO YOU REALLY THINK I
WASN'T ALREADY MAKING EVERY EFFORT? DEMANDED FLUDGE HEATEDLY.

EVERY ALIEN IN THE MINISTRY WAS AND IS TRYING TO FIND HIM AND HIND UP HIS FOLLOWERS, BUT WE HAD TO BE TALKING ABOUT ONE OF THE MOST POWERFUL WIZARDS OF ALL TIME, A WIZARD WHO HAS ELUDED CAPTURE FOR ALMOST THREE DECADES? SHE I SUPPOSE WILL BE GOING TO TELL ME HE CAUSED THE HURRICANE IN THE WEST COUNTRY THEN? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER, HIS TEMPER RISING WITH EVERY PACE HE TOOK. IT WAS INSULTING THE DISCOVERY THE REASON FOR ALL THESE TERRIBLE DISASTERS AND NOT THE BE ABLE TO TELL THE PUBLIC, ALMOST WORSE THAN IT BEING THE GOVERNMENT'S FAULT AFTER ALL. THAT WAS THE HURRICANE, SAID FLUDGE MISERABLY. EXCUSE ME? BARKED THE PRIME MINISTER, NOW POSITIVELY STAMPING UP AND DOWN. TREES UPROOTED, RIVERS RIPPED OFF, LAMPPOSTS BENT, TERRIBLE INJURIES. IT WAS THE DEATH RATERS, SAID FLUDGE. HE-WH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED'S FOLLOWERS, AND AND WE SUSPECT GIANT INVOLVEMENT. THE PRIME MINISTER STOPPED IN HIS TRACKS AS THOUGH HE HAD HIT AN INVISIBLE WALL. WHAT INVOLVEMENT? FLUDGE GRIMACED. HE USED GIANTS LAST TIME, WHEN HE WANTED TO GET THE GRAND EFFECT, HE SAID. THE OFFICE OF MISINFORMATION HAS BEEN WORKING AROUND THE CLOCK, WE'VE HAD TEAMS OF INVESTIGATORS BUT TRYING TO MODIFY THE MEMORIES OF ALL THE MUGGLES WHO SAW WHAT REALLY HAPPENED, WE'VE GOT MEET OF THE DEPARTMENT FOR THE REGULATION AND CONTROL OF MAGICAL CREATURES RUNNING AROUND SOMERSET, BUT WE CAN'T FIND THE GIANT

IT'S BEEN A DISASTER. WILL YOU T SAY? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER FLURRIEDLY. I WON'T DENY THAT MISERABLE IS PRETTY WELL AT THE MINISTRY, SAID FLUDGE. WHAT WITH ALL THAT, AND THEN LESSING AMELIA BONES. LESSING WHO? AMELIA BONES. HEAD OF THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT. WE THINK HE-WH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED MAY HAVE MURDERED HER IN PERSON, BECAUSE SHE WAS A VERY GIFTED WITCH AND AND ALL THE EVIDENCE WAS THAT SHE PUT UP A REAL FIGHT. FLUDGE CLEARED HIS THROAT AND, WITH AN EFFORT, IT SEEMED, STOPPED SPINNING HIS SWEATER HAT. BUT THAT MURDER WAS IN THE NEWSPAPERS, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER, MOMENTARILY DIVERTED FROM HIS ANGER. OUR NEWSPAPERS, AMELIA BONES. IT JUST SAID SHE WAS A MIDDLE-AGED WOMAN WHO LIVED ALONE. IT WAS A A NASTY KILLING, WASN'T IT? IT'S HAD RATHER A LOT OF PUBLICITY. THE POLICE ARE BAFLED, YOU SEE. FLUDGE SIGHED. WELL, OF COURSE THEY ARE, HE SAID. KILLED IN A ROOM THAT WAS LOCKED FROM THE INSIDE, WASN'T SHE? WE, ON THE OTHER HAND, KNOW EXACTLY WHO DID IT, NOT THAT THAT

GETS HIS AND FLINTHUR THEWARD CATCHING HIM, AND THEN THERE WAS
EMPELINE VANCE, MAYBE SHE DIDN'T HEAR ABOUT THAT ONE. "H-
YES I DID!" SAID THE PRIME MINISTER. IT HAPPENED JUST ABOUT THE
CORNER FROM HERE, AS A MATTER OF FACT, THE PAPERS HAD A FIELD DAY
WITH IT, BREAKING UP LAW AND ORDER IN THE PRIME MINISTER'S
BACKYARD. AND AS IF ALL THAT WASN'T ENOUGH, SAID FLIDGE,
BARELY LISTENING TO THE PRIME MINISTER, WE'VE GOT DEMONTHURS
SWARMING ALL OVER THE PLACE, ATTACKING PEOPLE LEFT, RIGHT, AND
CENTER. SINCE UPON A HAPPIER TIME THIS SENTENCE WOULD HAVE
BEEN UNINTELLIGIBLE TO THE PRIME MINISTER, BUT HE WAS WISER NOW. I
THOUGHT DEMONTHURS GUARD THE PRISONERS IN AZERAN, HE SAID
CALMLY. THEY DO, SAID FLIDGE WEARILY. BUT NOT ANYMORE.
THEY'VE DESERTED THE PRISON AND JOINED THE-WE-TH-NEED-RE-
NAMED. I WON'T PRETEND THAT WASN'T A BLOW. BUT, SAID THE PRIME
MINISTER, WITH A SENSE OF DAWNING HORROR, DIDN'T YOU TELL ME
THEY'RE THE CREATURES THAT DRAIN HOPE AND HAPPINESS OUT OF
PEOPLE? THAT'S RIGHT, AND THEY'RE BREEDING, THAT'S WHAT'S
CAUSING ALL THIS MIST. THE PRIME MINISTER SANK, HEAD-DOWN, INTO
THE NEAREST CHAIR. THE IDEA OF INVISIBLE CREATURES SWEEPING
THROUGH THE THINGS AND COUNTRYSIDE, SPREADING DESPAIR AND
HOPELESSNESS IN HIS VESTERS, MADE HIM FEEL SLIGHTLY FAINT. NOW SEE
HERE, FLIDGE. YOU'VE GOT THE DEE SOMETHING? IT'S YOUR
RESPONSIBILITY AS MINISTER OF MAGIC! MY DEAR PRIME MINISTER,
YOU CAN'T HONESTLY THINK I'M STILL MINISTER OF MAGIC AFTER ALL
THIS? I WAS SACKED THREE DAYS AGO! THE WHOLE WIZARDING
COMMUNITY HAS BEEN SCREAMING FOR MY RESIGNATION FOR A
WENTNIGHT. I'VE NEVER KNOWN THEM SO UNITED IN MY WHOLE TERM OF
OFFICE! SAID FLIDGE, WITH A BRAVE ATTEMPT AT A SMILE. THE PRIME
MINISTER WAS MOMENTARILY LOST FOR WORDS. DESPITE HIS INDIGNATION
AT THE POSITION INTO WHICH HE HAD BEEN PLACED, HE STILL RATHER FELT
FOR THE SHRIMPEN-LOOKING MAN SITTING OPPOSITE HIM. I'M VERY
SORRY, HE SAID FINALLY. IF THERE'S ANYTHING I CAN DO? IT'S VERY
KIND OF YOU, PRIME MINISTER, BUT THERE IS NOTHING. I WAS SENT HERE
TENTNIGHT THE EVENING YOU LIFTED THE DATE AND RECENT EVENTS AND THE
INTRODUCED YOU TO MY SUCCESSOR. I RATHER THOUGHT HE'D BE HERE BY
NOW, BUT HE CHURCH, HE'S VERY BUSY AT THE MOMENT, WITH SOMUCH
GOING ON. FLIDGE LOOKED AROUND AT THE PORTRAIT OF THE LITTLE
MAN WEARING THE LONG CURLY SILVER WIG, WHO WAS DIGGING IN HIS EAR

WITH THE POINT OF A FINGER, CATCHING FLUDGE'S EYE, THE PORTRAIT SAID, HE'LL BE HERE IN A MOMENT, HE'S JUST FINISHING A LETTER TO DUMBLEDOORE. I WISH HIM LUCK, SAID FLUDGE, SHEDDING BITTER TEARS THE FIRST TIME. I'VE BEEN WRITING THE DUMBLEDOORE TWICE A DAY FOR THE PAST MONTH, BUT HE WENT TO FLUDGE. IF HE'D JUST BEEN PREPARED TO PERSUADE THE KING, I MIGHT STILL BE. WELL, MAYBE SCRIMPGEOR WILL HAVE MORE SUCCESS. FLUDGE SLID INTO WHAT WAS CLEARLY AN AGGRIEVED SILENCE, BUT IT WAS BROKEN ALMOST IMMEDIATELY BY THE PORTRAIT, WHICH SUDDENLY SPOKE IN ITS CRISP, OFFICIAL VOICE. THE PRIME MINISTER OF MUGGLETS, REQUESTING A MEETING, URGENT, KINDLY RESPOND IMMEDIATELY. RUFUS SCRIMPGEOR, MINISTER OF MAGIC. YES, YES, FINE, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER DISTRACTEDLY, AND HE BARELY FLINCHED AS THE FLAMES IN THE GRATE TURNED EMERALD GREEN AGAIN, RESEALING HIS LIPS, AND REVEALED A SECOND SPINNING WIZARD IN THEIR HEART, DISCHARGING HIM MOMENTS LATER WITH THE ANTIHUGO RING. FLUDGE GOT TO HIS FEET AND, AFTER A MOMENT'S HESITATION, THE PRIME MINISTER DID THE SAME, WATCHING THE NEW ARRIVAL STRAIGHTEN HIS LIPS, LISTEN TO HIS LONG BLACK BEARDS, AND THEN ARRAISE. THE PRIME MINISTER'S FIRST, FLEETING THOUGHT WAS THAT RUFUS SCRIMPGEOR LOOKED RATHER LIKE AN OLD MAN. THERE WERE STREAKS OF GRAY IN HIS MANE OF TANNED HAIR AND HIS SLIGHTLY EYEBROWS; HE HAD BEEN YELLOWISH EYES BEHIND A PAIR OF WIRE-RIMMED SPECTACLES AND A CERTAIN RANGY, LEOPARD GRACE EVEN THOUGH HE WALKED WITH A SLIGHT LIMP. THERE WAS AN IMMEDIATE IMPRESSION OF STRENGTH AND THOUGHNESS; THE PRIME MINISTER THOUGHT HE UNDERSTOOD WHY THE WIZARDING COMMUNITY PREFERRED SCRIMPGEOR TO FLUDGE AS A LEADER IN THESE DANGEROUS TIMES. HOW DO YOU DO? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER POLITELY, HOLDING OUT HIS HAND. SCRIMPGEOR GRASPED IT BRIEFLY, HIS EYES SCANNING THE OTHER, THEN PULLED OUT A WAND FROM UNDER HIS BEARDS. FLUDGE THOUGHT YOU DO EVERYTHING? HE ASKED, STRIDING OVER THE OTHER AND TAPPING THE KEYSTONE WITH HIS WAND. THE PRIME MINISTER HEARD THE LATCH CLICK. ER YES, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER, AND IF YOU DON'T MIND, I'D RATHER THAT OTHER REMAINED UNLOCKED. I'D RATHER NOT BE INTERRUPTED, SAID SCRIMPGEOR SHORTLY, HE WATCHED, HE ADDED, POINTING HIS WAND AT THE WINDOWS, SEE THAT THE CURTAINS SLEPT ACROSS THEM. RIGHT, WELL, I'M A BUSY MAN, SEE LET'S GET DOWN TO BUSINESS. FIRST OF ALL, WE NEED TO DISCUSS YOUR SECURITY. THE PRIME MINISTER DREW HIMSELF UP TO HIS FULLEST HEIGHT AND REPLIED, I AM

PERFECTLY HAPPY WITH THE SECURITY I'VE ALREADY GOTTEN, THANK YOU VERY MUCH. WELL, WE'RE NOT, SCRIMGEUR CLUT IN. IT'LL BE A PHEER WHEEHLIT FOR THE MUGGLES IF THEIR PRIME MINISTER GETS PLUT UNDER THE IMPERILS CURSE. THE NEW SECRETARY IN YOUR ELITER OFFICE

I'M NOT GETTING RID OF DINGSLEY SHACKLEBOLT, IS THAT WHAT YOU'RE SUGGESTING? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER FENTLY. HE'S HIGHLY EFFICIENT, GETS THROUGH TWICE THE WORK THE REST OF THEM

THAT'S BECAUSE HE'S A WIZARD, SAID SCRIMGEUR, WITHOUT A FLICKER OF A SMILE. A HIGHLY TRAINED ALWHEE, WHO HAS BEEN ASSIGNED THE YOU AND YOUR PROTECTION. NOW, WAIT A MOMENT? DECLARED THE PRIME MINISTER. YOU CAN'T JUST PLUT YOUR PEOPLE INTO MY OFFICE, I DECIDE WHO GOES FOR ME. I THOUGHT YOU WERE HAPPY WITH

SHACKLEBOLT? SAID SCRIMGEUR COLDLY. I AM. THAT'S THE SAY, I WAS

THEN THERE'S NO PROBLEM, IS THERE? SAID SCRIMGEUR. I WELL, AS LONG AS SHACKLEBOLT'S WORK CONTINUES TO BE ER EXCELLENT, SAID THE PRIME MINISTER LAMELY, BUT SCRIMGEUR BARELY SEEMED TO HEAR HIM. NOW, ABOUT HERBERT CHURLEY, YOUR ILMINER MINISTER, HE CONTINUED. THE ONE WHO HAS BEEN ENTERTAINING THE PUBLIC BY IMPERSONATING A DUCK. WHAT ABOUT HIM? ASKED THE PRIME MINISTER. HE HAS CLEARLY REACTED TO A PHEERLY PERFORMED IMPERILS CURSE, SAID SCRIMGEUR. IT'S ADDED HIS BRAINS, BUT HE COULD STILL BE DANGEROUS. HE'S ONLY HALLUCINATING? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER WEARILY. SURELY A BIT OF A REST. MAYBE GET EASY ON THE DRINK. A TEAM OF HEALERS FROM ST. MUNGUS'S HOSPITAL FOR MAGICAL MALADIES AND INJURIES ARE EXAMINING HIM AS WE SPEAK. SO FAR HE HAS ATTEMPTED TO STRANGLE THREE OF THEM, SAID SCRIMGEUR.

I THINK IT BEST THAT WE REMOVE HIM FROM MUGGLE SOCIETY FOR A WHILE. I WELL. HE'LL BE ALL RIGHT, WHEN T HEY? SAID THE PRIME MINISTER ANXIOUSLY. SCRIMGEUR MERELY SHRUGGED, ALREADY MOVING BACK TOWARD THE FIREPLACE. WELL, THAT'S REALLY ALL I HAD TO SAY. I WILL KEEP YOU POSTED OF DEVELOPMENTS, PRIME MINISTER. ER, AT LEAST, I SHALL PREFERABLY BE THERE ELSY TO COME PERSONALLY, IN WHICH CASE I SHALL SEND FLUDGE HERE. HE HAS CONSENTED TO STAY ON IN AN ADVISORY CAPACITY. FLUDGE ATTEMPTED TO SMILE, BUT WAS UNSUCCESSFUL; HE MERELY WHEEDED AS THOUGH HE HAD A TEETHACHE. SCRIMGEUR WAS ALREADY RUMMAGING IN HIS POCKET FOR THE MYSTERIOUS POWDER THAT TURNED THE FIRE GREEN. THE PRIME MINISTER GAZED HEEPLESSLY AT THE PAIR OF THEM FOR A MOMENT, THEN THE WORDS HE HAD FELT THE

SUPPRESS ALL EVENING FIRST FROM HIM AT LAST. BUT HER HEAVEN'S
SADNESS SHELL BE WIZARDS? SHELL CAN DO MAGIC? SURELY SHELL CAN SHUT
HIMT WELL ANYTHING? STRINGHELMER TURNED SILENTLY IN THE SILENT
AND EXCHANGED AN INCREDIBLES LOOK WITH FLORCE, WHO REALLY DID
MANAGE A SMILE THIS TIME AS HE SAID KINDLY, THE TRICKLE IS, THE
EITHER SIDE CAN DO MAGIC THEM, PRIME MINISTER. AND WITH THAT, THE
TWO WIZARDS STEPPED BACK AFTER THE EITHER INTO THE BRIGHT GREEN FIRE
AND VANISHED. SPINNER'S END MANY MILES AWAY THE CHILLY MIST THAT
HAD PRESSED AGAINST THE PRIME MINISTER'S WINDMILLS DRIFTED OVER A
DIRTY RIVER THAT WHELD BETWEEN EVERGREENS, RUSTY-STRAWN BANKS,
AN IMMENSE CHIMNEY, REIK OF A DISUSED MILL, REARED UP, STAGNANT AND
HEMLOCK. THERE WAS NO SOUND APART FROM THE WHISPER OF THE
BLACK WATER AND NO SIGN OF LIFE APART FROM A SCALING FEEL THAT HAD
SLID DOWN THE BANK THE NIGHT PREVIOUSLY AT SOME OLD FISH-AND-CHIP
WRAPPINGS IN THE TALL GRASS. BUT THEN, WITH A VERY FAINT POOP, A
SLIM, HUNDED FIGURE APPEARED HIMT OF THIN AIR IN THE EDGE OF THE
RIVER. THE FEEL FREEZE, WARY EYES FIXED UPON THIS STRANGE NEW
PHENOMENON. THE FIGURE SEEMED TO TAKE ITS BEARINGS FOR A FEW
MOMENTS, THEN SET OFF WITH LIGHT, FLICK STRIDES, ITS LONG CHAIR
RUSTLING OVER THE GRASS. WITH A SECOND AND LARGER POOP, ANOTHER
HUNDED FIGURE MATERIALIZED. WAIT? THE HARSH CRY STARTLED THE
FEEL, NOW CREEPING ALMOST FLAT IN THE UNDERGROWTH. IT LEAPT FROM
ITS HIDING PLACE AND UP THE BANK. THERE WAS A FLASH OF GREEN LIGHT,
A YELP, AND THE FEEL FELL BACK THE GRIND, DEAD. THE SECOND FIGURE
TURNED OVER THE ANIMAL WITH ITS TEETH. LIST A FEEL, SAID A WOMAN'S
VOICE DISMISSIVELY FROM UNDER THE HEDD. I THOUGHT PERHAPS AN
ALIBI Cissy, WAIT? BUT HER HILARIOUS, WHO HAD PALSED AND
HEADED BACK AT THE FLASH OF LIGHT, WAS ALREADY SCRAMBLING UP THE
BANK THE FEEL HAD JUST FALLEN DOWN. Cissy NARCISSA LISTEN THE
ME THE SECOND WOMAN CALLED THE FIRST AND SEIZED HER ARM, BUT
THE EITHER WRENCHED IT AWAY. COME BACK, Kella? SHELL MUST LISTEN THE
ME? I VE LISTENED ALREADY, I VE MADE MY DECISION. LEAVE ME ALONE?
THE WOMAN NAMED NARCISSA GAINED THE TOP OF THE BANK, WHERE A
LINE OF OLD RAILINGS SEPARATED THE RIVER FROM A NARROW, CHECKED
STREET. THE EITHER WOMAN, Kella, FOLLOWED AT ONCE. SIDE BY SIDE THEY
STOOD LOOKING ACROSS THE ROAD AT THE WHEELS AND WHEELS OF DILAPIDATED
RICKS BUSES, THEIR WINDMILLS BLIND AND BLIND IN THE DARKNESS. HE
LIVES HERE? ASKED Kella IN A VOICE OF CONTEMPT. HERE? IN THIS

MUSCLE BING-HILL? WE MUST BE THE FIRST OF OUR KIND EVER TO SET
FEET BUT NARCISSA WAS NOT LISTENING; SHE HAD SLIPPED THROUGH
A GAP IN THE RUSTY RAILINGS AND WAS ALREADY FLIRRYING ACROSS THE
ROAD. LISSY, WAIT! BELLA SCREAMED, HER HEAD STREAMING BEHIND, AND
SAW NARCISSA DARTING THROUGH AN ALLEY BETWEEN THE HOUSES INTO A
SECOND, ALMOST IDENTICAL STREET. SOME OF THE STREETLAMPS WERE
BROKEN; THE TWO WOMEN WERE RUNNING BETWEEN PATCHES OF LIGHT
AND DEEP DARKNESS. THE PURSUEE CALLED UP WITH HER PREY JUST AS
SHE TURNED ANOTHER CORNER, THIS TIME SUCCEEDED IN CATCHING HOLD
OF HER ARM AND SWINGING HER AROUND SEE THAT THEY FACED EACH
OTHER. LISSY, YOU MUST NOT DO THIS, YOU CAN'T TRUST HIM THE
DARK LORD TRUSTS HIM, DOESN'T HE? THE DARK LORD IS I BELIEVE
MISTAKEN, BELLA PANTED, AND HER EYES GLARED MOMENTARILY
UNDER HER HAIR AS SHE LOOKED AROUND THE CORNER THAT THEY WERE
INDEED ALONE. IN ANY CASE, WE WERE THERE NOT THE SPREAD OF THE PLAN
THE ANYONE. THIS IS A BETRAYAL OF THE DARK LORD LET GO,
BELLA! SNARLED NARCISSA, AND SHE DREW A HAND FROM BENEATH HER
HEAD, HOLDING IT THREATENINGLY IN THE OTHER'S FACE. BELLA MERELY
LAUGHED. LISSY, YOUR ELDER SISTER? YOU WOULD NOT THERE IS
NOTHING I WOULD NOT DO ANYMORE? NARCISSA BREATHED, A NOTE OF
HYSTERIA IN HER VOICE, AND AS SHE BRIGHTENED BEHIND THE HAND LIKE A
KNIFE, THERE WAS ANOTHER FLASH OF LIGHT. BELLA LET GO OF HER SISTER'S
ARM AS THE LIGHT FLARED. NARCISSA! BUT NARCISSA HAD RUSHED AHEAD,
FLICKING HER HAND, HER PURSUEE SCREAMED AGAIN, KEEPING HER
DISTANCE NOW, AS THEY MOVED DEEPER INTO THE DESERTED LABYRINTH OF
BRICK HOUSES. AT LAST, NARCISSA FLURRIED UP A STREET NAMED
SPINNER'S END, EVER WHICH THE TINKERING MILL CHIMNEY SEEMED THE
HEAVY LIKE A GIANT ADMONITORY FINGER. HER FEETSTEPS ECHOED ON
THE CORKERS AS SHE PASSED HOWLED AND BROKEN WINDMILLS, UNTIL SHE
REACHED THE VERY LAST HOUSE, WHERE A DIM LIGHT GLIMMERED THROUGH
THE CURTAINS IN A DOWNSTAIRS ROOM. SHE HAD KNOCKED ON THE DOOR
BEFORE BELLA, CLINGING UNDER HER BREATH, HAD CALLED UP. TOGETHER
THEY STOOD WAITING, PANTING SLIGHTLY, BREATHING IN THE SMELL OF THE
DIRTY RIVER THAT WAS CARRIED THEM ON THE NIGHT BREEZE. AFTER A
FEW SECONDS, THEY HEARD MOVEMENT BEHIND THE DOOR AND IT OPENED A
CRACK. A SLIVER OF A MAN COULD BE SEEN LOOKING OUT AT THEM, A MAN
WITH LONG BLACK HAIR PARTED IN CURTAINS AROUND A SLENDER FACE AND
BLACK EYES. NARCISSA THREW BACK HER HAIR. SHE WAS SO PALE THAT SHE

SEEMED TO SHINE IN THE DARKNESS; THE LONG BLONDE HAIR STREAMING
BEHIND HER BACK GAVE HER THE LOOK OF A DRIVEN PERSIAN. NARCISSA
SAID THE MAN, OPENING THE DOOR A LITTLE WIDER, SHE THAT THE LIGHT FELL
UPON HER AND HER SISTER THERE. WHAT A PLEASANT SURPRISE?

SEVERALS, SHE SAID IN A STRAINED WHISPER. MAY I SPEAK TO YOU?
IT IS URGENT. BUT OF COURSE. HE STEPPED BACK TO ALLOW HER TO PASS
BETWEEN THE DOORS, HER STILL-FROZEN SISTER FOLLOWED WITH HEART
INVITATION. SNAPE, SHE SAID CLUTCHING AS SHE PASSED HIM. BELLATRIX,
HE REPLIED, HIS THIN MOUTH CURLING INTO A SLIGHTLY MEETING SMILE
AS HE CLOSED THE DOOR WITH A SNAP BEHIND THEM. THEY HAD STEPPED
DIRECTLY INTO A TINY SITTING ROOM, WHICH HAD THE FEELING OF A DARK,
PADDED CELL. THE WALLS WERE COMPLETELY COVERED IN BOOKS, MOST OF
THEM BOUND IN OLD BLACK OR BROWN LEATHER; A THREADBARE SHA, AN
OLD ARMCHAIR, AND A RICKETY TABLE STOOD CRUMPLED TOGETHER IN A POOL
OF DIM LIGHT CAST BY A CANDLE-FILLED LAMP HUNG FROM THE CEILING. THE
PLACE HAD AN AIR OF NEGLECT, AS THOUGH IT WAS NOT USUALLY
INHABITED. SNAPE GESTURED NARCISSA TO THE SHA. SHE THREW OFF HER
COAT, LOST IT ASIDE, AND SAT DOWN, STARING AT HER WHITE AND
TREMBLING HANDS CLASPED IN HER LAP. BELLATRIX WHEEZED HER FROZEN
MOUTH SILENTLY. DARK AS HER SISTER WAS FAIR, WITH HEAVILY LIDDED EYES
AND A STRENGTHY LAD, SHE DID NOT TAKE HER GAZE FROM SNAPE AS SHE
MOVED THE STAND BEHIND NARCISSA. SHE, WHAT CAN I DO FOR YOU?
SNAPE ASKED, SETTLING HIMSELF IN THE ARMCHAIR OPPOSITE THE TWO
SISTERS. WE WE ARE ALONE, AREN'T WE? NARCISSA ASKED QUIETLY.

YES, OF COURSE. WELL, WHORMTAIL IS HERE, BUT WE'RE NOT CHINTING
VERMIN, ARE WE? HE POINTED HIS FINGER AT THE WALL OF BOOKS BEHIND
HIM AND WITH A BANG, A HIDDEN DOOR FLEW OPEN, REVEALING A NARROW
STAIRCASE UPON WHICH A SMALL MAN STOOD FROZEN. AS YOU HAVE
CLEARLY REALIZED, WHORMTAIL, WE HAVE GUESTS, SAID SNAPE LAZILY. THE
MAN CREEPT, HUNCHBACKED, DOWN THE LAST FEW STEPS AND MOVED INTO
THE ROOM. HE HAD SMALL, WATERY EYES, A POINTED NOSE, AND WORE AN
UNPLEASANT SIMPER. HIS LEFT HAND WAS CARESSING HIS RIGHT, WHICH
HEHEED AS THOUGH IT WAS ENCASED IN A BRIGHT SILVER GLOVE.

NARCISSA: HE SAID, IN A SLEAZY VOICE. AND BELLATRIX: FEEL
CHARMING WHORMTAIL WILL GET US DRINKS, IF YOU'D LIKE THEM,
SAID SNAPE. AND THEN HE WILL RETURN TO HIS BEDROOM. WHORMTAIL
WINCED AS THOUGH SNAPE HAD THROWN SOMETHING AT HIM. I AM NOT
YOUR SERVANT: HE SLEAZED, AVOIDING SNAPE'S EYE. REALLY? I WAS

UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT THE DARK LORD PLACED THEM HERE TO ASSIST ME. THE ASSIST, YES BUT NOT THE MAKE THEM DRINKS AND AND CLEAN THEIR FEELSE? I HAD NO IDEA, WHORMTAIL, THAT THEY WERE CARRYING MORE DANGEROUS ASSIGNMENTS, SAID SNAPE SILENTLY. THIS CAN BE EASILY ARRANGED: I SHALL SPEAK TO THE DARK LORD I CAN SPEAK TO HIM MYSELF IF I WANT THEM. HE CHUCKLED THEY CAN, SAID SNAPE, SMILING. BUT IN THE MEANTIME, BRING US DRINKS, SOME OF THE ELDER WINE WILL DO. WHORMTAIL HESITATED FOR A MOMENT, BEHAVING AS THOUGH HE MIGHT AGREE, BUT THEN TURNED AND HEADED THROUGH A SECOND HIDDEN DOOR. THEY HEARD BANGING AND A CLINKING OF GLASSES, WITHIN SECONDS HE WAS BACK, BEARING A DUSTY BOTTLE AND THREE GLASSES UPON A TRAY. HE DROPPED THESE ON THE RICKETY TABLE AND SLURRIED FROM THEIR PRESENCE, SLAMMING THE DOOR-COVERED DOOR BEHIND HIM. SNAPE FILLED BOTH THREE GLASSES OF BUBBLING WINE AND HANDED THEM TO THE SISTERS. NARCISSA MURMURED A WORD OF THANKS, WHILE BELATRIX SAID NOTHING, BUT CONTINUED TO GLEAM AT SNAPE. THIS DID NOT SEEM TO DISCOMFORT HIM; ON THE CONTRARY, HE SMILED RATHER AMUSED. THE DARK LORD, HE SAID, RAISING HIS GLASS AND DRAINING IT. THE SISTERS CHEERED HIM. SNAPE REFILLED THEIR GLASSES. AS NARCISSA TOOK HER SECOND DRINK SHE SAID IN A RUSH,

SEVERUS, I'M SORRY THE CHIEF HERE LIKE THIS, BUT I HAD TO SEE THEM. I THINK THEY ARE THE ONLY ONE WHO CAN HELP ME SNAPE HELD UP A HAND TO STOP HER, THEN POINTED HIS WAND AGAIN AT THE CONCEALED STAIRCASE DOOR. THERE WAS A LOUD BANG AND A SHRIEK, FOLLOWED BY THE SOUND OF WHORMTAIL SLURRYING BACK UP THE STAIRS. MY APPEALS, SAID SNAPE. HE HAS LATELY TAKEN TO LISTENING AT DOORS, I DON'T KNOW WHAT HE MEANS BY IT. THEY WERE SAYING, NARCISSA? SHE TOOK A GREAT, SHUDDERING BREATH AND STARTED AGAIN. SEVERUS, I KNOW I MIGHT NOT BE HERE, I HAVE BEEN TOLD TO SAY NOTHING TO ANYONE, BUT THEN THEY MIGHT BE HERE WHO THEY THINK? SPARKED BELATRIX. PARTICULARLY IN PRESENT COMPANY? PRESENT COMPANY? REPEATED SNAPE SARDONICALLY. AND WHAT AM I TO UNDERSTAND BY THAT, BELATRIX? THAT I DON'T TRUST THEM, SNAPE, AS THEY VERY WELL KNOW? NARCISSA LET OUT A NOISE THAT MIGHT HAVE BEEN A DRY GIGGLE AND COVERED HER FACE WITH HER HANDS. SNAPE SET HIS GLASS DOWN UPON THE TABLE AND SAT BACK AGAIN, HIS HANDS UPON THE ARMS OF HIS CHAIR, SMILING INTO BELATRIX'S GLEAMING FACE.

NARCISSA, I THINK WE MIGHT BE HEAR WHAT BELATRIX IS WHISPERING TO

SAY, IT WILL SAVE TEDIUMS INTERLUPTIONS. WELL, CONTINUE, BELLATRIX,
SAID SNAPE. WHY IS IT THAT YOU DO NOT TELL ME? A HUNDRED
REASONS? SHE SAID LULLABY, STRIDING HEFT FROM BEHIND THE SEAT THE
SLAM HER GLASS UPON THE TABLE. WHERE THE START? WHERE WERE YOU
WHEN THE DARK LORD FELL? WHY DID YOU NEVER MAKE ANY ATTEMPT THE
FIND HIM WHEN HE VANISHED? WHAT HAVE YOU BEEN DOING ALL THESE
YEARS THAT YOU VE LIVED IN DUMBLEDORE S POCKET? WHY DID YOU STOP
THE DARK LORD PROCLAIMING THE SHOCKER S STONE? WHY DID YOU NOT
RETURN AT ONCE WHEN THE DARK LORD WAS REBORN? WHERE WERE YOU
A FEW WEEKS AGO WHEN WE BATTLED THE RETRIEVE THE PRINCIPLES FOR THE
DARK LORD? AND WHY, SNAPE, IS LARRY PETER STILL ALIVE, WHEN YOU
HAVE HAD HIM AT YOUR MERCY FOR FIVE YEARS? SHE PALSED, HER CHEST
RISING AND FALLING RAPIDLY, THE CHEER HIGH IN HER CHEEKS, BEHIND
HER, NARCISSA SAT MUTELESS, HER FACE STILL HIDDEN IN HER HANDS.
SNAPE SMILED. BEFORE I ANSWER YOU HEY YES, BELLATRIX, I AM GIVING
THE ANSWER? YOU CAN CARRY MY WORDS BACK THE THE OTHERS WHEN
WHISPER BEHIND MY BACK, AND CARRY FALSE TALKS OF MY TREACHERY THE
THE DARK LORD? BEFORE I ANSWER YOU, I SAY, LET ME ASK A QUESTION IN
TURN, DO YOU REALLY THINK THAT THE DARK LORD HAS NOT ASKED ME
EACH AND EVERY ONE OF THESE QUESTIONS? AND DO YOU REALLY THINK
THAT, HAD I NOT BEEN ABLE TO GIVE SATISFACTORY ANSWERS, I WOULD BE
SITTING HERE TALKING TO YOU? SHE HESITATED. I KNOW HE BELIEVES
YOU, BUT YOU THINK HE IS MISTAKEN? FOR THAT I HAVE SOMEHOW
FINDING HIM? FOUND THE DARK LORD, THE GREATEST WIZARD, THE
MOST ACCOMPLISHED LEGIMENS THE WORLD HAS EVER SEEN? BELLATRIX
SAID NOTHING, BUT MOOED, FOR THE FIRST TIME, A LITTLE DISCOMFORTED,
SNAPE DID NOT PRESS THE POINT, HE PICKED UP HIS DRINK AGAIN,
SIPPED IT, AND CONTINUED, YOU ASK WHERE I WAS WHEN THE DARK
LORD FELL, I WAS WHERE HE HAD ORDERED ME TO BE, AT HOGWARTS SCHOOL
OF WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY, BECAUSE HE WISHED ME TO STAY UPON
ALLS DUMBLEDORE, YOU KNOW, I PRESUME, THAT IT WAS HIM THE DARK
LORD S ORDERS THAT I TOOK UP THE POST? SHE NODDED ALMOST
IMPERCEPTIBLY AND THEN OPENED HER MOUTH, BUT SNAPE INTERRUPTED
HER. YOU ASK WHY I DID NOT ATTEMPT TO FIND HIM WHEN HE VANISHED,
FOR THE SAME REASON THAT AVERY, YAKLEY, THE CARPENTERS, GREYBACK,
BLINDS HE INCLINED HIS HEAD SLIGHTLY THE NARCISSA AND MANY
OTHERS DID NOT ATTEMPT TO FIND HIM, I BELIEVED HIM FINISHED, I AM NOT
PROUD OF IT, I WAS WRONG, BUT THERE IT IS. IF HE HAD NOT FORGIVEN

WE WERE LEFT FAITH AT THAT TIME, HE WOULD HAVE VERY FEW FOLLOWERS LEFT. HE DID HAVE ME, SAID BELLATRIX PASSIONATELY. I, WE SPENT MANY YEARS IN AZKABAN FOR HIM. YES, INDEED, MOST ADMIRABLE, SAID SNAPE IN A RARED VOICE. HE CHOOSE, WELL WORTHEN T A LIFE HE LIVED THE HIM IN PRISON, BUT THE GESTURE WAS UNDOUBTEDLY FINE.

GESTURE? SHE SHRIEKED, IN HER FLURY SHE LOOKED SLIGHTLY MAD.

WHILE I ENDURED THE DEMENTHERS, WELL REMAINED AT BEECHWARTS, COMFORTABLY PLAYING OLIMPEDEHRE S PET. NEET ELITE, SAID SNAPE CALMLY. HE WOULDNT GIVE ME THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS HER, WELL KNOWN. SEEMED THE THINK IT MIGHT, AH, BRING ABOUT A RELAPSE TEMPT ME INTO MY OLD WAYS. THIS WAS YOUR SACRIFICE FOR THE DARK LORD, NEET THE TEACH YOUR FAVORITE SUBJECT? SHE REEDED. WHY DID WELL STAY THERE ALL THAT TIME, SNAPE? STILL SPYING HIM OLIMPEDEHRE FOR A MASTER WELL BELIEVED DEAD? HARDLY, SAID SNAPE.

ALTHOUGH THE DARK LORD IS PLEASED THAT I NEVER DESERTED MY POST; I HAD SIXTEEN YEARS OF INFORMATION HIM OLIMPEDEHRE THE GIVE HIM WHEN HE RETURNED, A RATHER MORE LIKELY WELCOME-BACK PRESENT THAN ENDLESS REMINISCENCES OF THE UNPLEASANT AZKABAN IS.

BUT WELL STAYED YES, BELLATRIX, I STAYED, SAID SNAPE, BETRAYING A HINT OF IMPATIENCE FOR THE FIRST TIME. I HAD A COMFORTABLE HER THAT I PREFERRED THE A STINT IN AZKABAN. THEY WERE REHLINDING UP THE DEATH EATERS, WELL KNOWN, OLIMPEDEHRE S PROTECTION KEPT ME OUT OF LAIL; IT WAS MOST CONVENIENT AND I USED IT. I REPEAT: THE DARK LORD DOES NEET COMPLAIN THAT I STAYED, SHE I DO NEET SEE WHY WELL DO. I THINK WELL NEXT WANTED THE KNOWN, HE PRESSED HIM, A LITTLE MORE HEEDLY, FOR BELLATRIX SEEMED EVERY SIGN OF INTERRUPTING. WHY I STOOD BETWEEN THE DARK LORD AND THE STRICKER S STONE. THAT IS EASILY ANSWERED. HE DID NEET KNOWN WHETHER HE COULD TRUST ME. HE TEHLIGHT, LIKE WELL, THAT I HAD TURNED FROM FAITHFUL DEATH EATER THE OLIMPEDEHRE S STEHCE. HE WAS IN A PITIABLE CONDITION, VERY WEAK, SHARING THE BODY OF A MEDICINE WIZARD. HE DID NEET DARK REVEAL HIMSELF THE A FORMER ALLY IF THAT ALLY MIGHT TURN HIM OVER THE OLIMPEDEHRE FOR THE MINISTRY. I DEEPLY REGRET THAT HE DID NEET TRUST ME. HE WOULD HAVE RETURNED THE FEWER THREE YEARS SEHNER. AS IT WAS, I SAW ONLY GREEDY AND UNWORTHY HURWELL ATTEMPTING THE STEAL THE STONE AND, I ADMIT, I DID ALL I COULD THE THWART HIM. BELLATRIX S MOUTH TWISTED AS THOUGH SHE HAD TAKEN AN UNPLEASANT DOSE OF MEDICINE. BUT WELL DIDNT RETURN

WHEN HE CAME BACK, YELL DIDN'T ASK HIM AT HENCE WHEN YELL
FELT THE DARK MARK RETURN. CORRECT, I RETURNED TWO HOURS LATER.
I RETURNED MY DUMBLEDORE'S ORDERS. MY DUMBLEDORE'S ? SHE
BEGAN, IN TERMS OF HISTRAGE. THINK? SAID SNAPE, IMPATIENT AGAIN.

THINK? BY WAITING TWO HOURS, JUST TWO HOURS, I ENSURED THAT I
COULD REMAIN AT HOGWARTS AS A SPY? BY ALLOWING DUMBLEDORE THE
THINK THAT I WAS ONLY RETURNING THE THE DARK LORD'S SIDE BECAUSE I
WAS ORDERED TO, I HAVE BEEN ABLE TO PASS INFORMATION TO
DUMBLEDORE AND THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX EVER SINCE? CONSIDER,
BELLATRIX! THE DARK MARK HAD BEEN GROWING STRONGER FOR MONTHS,
I KNOW HE MUST BE ABOUT TO RETURN, ALL THE DEATH EATERS KNOW! I
HAD PLENTY OF TIME TO THINK ABOUT WHAT I WANTED TO DO, THE PLAN MY
NEXT MOVE, THE ESCAPE LIKE RABBARIFF, DIDN'T IT? THE DARK LORD'S
INITIAL DISPLEASURE AT MY LATENCY VANISHED ENTIRELY, I ASSURE YELL,
WHEN I EXPLAINED THAT I REMAINED FAITHFUL, ALTHOUGH DUMBLEDORE
THOUGHT I WAS HIS MAN. YES, THE DARK LORD THOUGHT THAT I HAD LEFT
HIM FOREVER, BUT HE WAS WRONG. BUT WHAT USE HAVE YELL BEEN?
SNEERED BELLATRIX. WHAT USEFUL INFORMATION HAVE WE HAD FROM
YELL? MY INFORMATION HAS BEEN CONVEYED DIRECTLY TO THE DARK
LORD, SAID SNAPE. IF HE CHOOSES NOT TO SHARE IT WITH YELL

HE SHARES EVERYTHING WITH ME? SAID BELLATRIX, FIRING UP AT HENCE.
HE CALLS ME HIS MOST LOYAL, HIS MOST FAITHFUL. DOES HE? SAID
SNAPE, HIS VOICE DELICATELY IMPLICATED THE SLIGHTEST HIS DISBELIEF. DOES
HE STILL, AFTER THE FLASH AT THE MINISTRY? THAT WAS NOT MY
FAULT? SAID BELLATRIX, ALLURING. THE DARK LORD HAS, IN THE PAST,
ENLISTED ME WITH HIS MOST PRECIOUS IF LUKES HADN'T

DIDN'T YELL DARE DIDN'T YELL DARE BLAME MY HUSBAND? SAID
NARCISSE, IN A LOW AND DEADLY VOICE, LEANING UP AT HER SISTER.

THERE IS NO POINT APPERTAINING BLAME, SAID SNAPE SPEEDILY.
WHAT IS DONE, IS DONE. BUT NOT BY YELL? SAID BELLATRIX FLIRTUOUSLY.
NO, YELL WERE HENCE AGAIN ABSENT WHILE THE REST OF US RAN DANGERS,
WERE YELL NOT, SNAPE? MY ORDERS WERE TO REMAIN BEHIND, SAID
SNAPE. PERHAPS YELL DISAGREE WITH THE DARK LORD, PERHAPS YELL
THINK THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD NOT HAVE NOTICED IF I HAD MIXED
FORCES WITH THE DEATH EATERS TO FIGHT THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX?
AND PARDON ME YELL SPEAK OF DANGERS YELL WERE FACING
SIX TEENAGERS, WERE YELL NOT? THEY WERE MIXED, AS YELL VERY WELL
KNOW, BY HALF OF THE ORDER BEFORE LONG? SNARLED BELLATRIX. AND,

WHILE WE ARE IN THE SUBJECT OF THE HERD, YOU STILL CLAIM YOU CANNOT REVEAL THE WHEREABOUTS OF THEIR HEADQUARTERS, DON'T YOU? I AM NOT THE SECRET-KEEPER; I CANNOT SPEAK THE NAME OF THE PLACE, YOU UNDERSTAND WELL THE ENCHANTMENT WORDS, I THINK? THE DARK LORD IS SATISFIED WITH THE INFORMATION I HAVE PASSED HIM IN THE HERD. IT LED, AS PERHAPS YOU HAVE GUESSED, TO THE RECENT CAPTURE AND MURDER OF EMMELINE VANCE, AND IT CERTAINLY HELPED DISPENSE OF SIRILIS BLACK, THOUGH I GIVE YOU FULL CREDIT FOR FINISHING HIM OFF. HE INCLINED HIS HEAD AND TEASED HER, HER EXPRESSION DID NOT SOFTEN. YOU ARE AVOIDING MY LAST QUESTIONS, SNAPE. HARRY POTTER, YOU COULD HAVE KILLED HIM AT ANY POINT IN THE PAST FIVE YEARS, YOU HAVE NOT DONE IT, WHY? I HAVE YOU DISCUSSED THIS MATTER WITH THE DARK LORD? ASKED SNAPE. HE LATELY, WE I AM ASKING YOU, SNAPE? IF I HAD MURDERED HARRY POTTER, THE DARK LORD COULD NOT HAVE USED HIS BLOOD TO REGENERATE, MAKING HIM INVINCIBLE. YOU CLAIM YOU PRESERVE HIS LIFE OF THE BODY? SHE REPLIED. I DO NOT CLAIM IT; I HAD NO IDEA OF HIS PLANS; I HAVE ALREADY EXPRESSED THAT I THOUGHT THE DARK LORD DEAD, I AM MERELY TRYING TO EXPLAIN WHY THE DARK LORD IS NOT SHOCKED THAT POTTER SURVIVED, AT LEAST UNTIL A YEAR AGO. BUT WHY DID YOU KEEP HIM ALIVE? I HAVE YOU NOT UNDERSTOOD ME? IT WAS ONLY DUMBLEDORE'S PROTECTION THAT WAS KEEPING ME OUT OF AZKABAN; DO YOU DISAGREE THAT MURDERING HIS FAVORITE STUDENT MIGHT HAVE TURNED HIM AGAINST ME? BUT THERE WAS MORE TO IT THAN THAT, I SHOULD REMIND YOU THAT WHEN POTTER FIRST ARRIVED AT HOGWARTS THERE WERE STILL MANY THEORIES CIRCULATING ABOUT HIM, RUMORS THAT HE HIMSELF WAS A GREAT DARK WIZARD, WHICH WAS WHY HE HAD SURVIVED THE DARK LORD'S ATTACK. INDEED, MANY OF THE DARK LORD'S OLD FOLLOWERS THOUGHT POTTER MIGHT BE A STANDARD APPEALING WHICH WE COULD ALL RALLY AROUND MORE. I WAS CLUELESS, I ADMIT IT, AND NOT AT ALL INCLINED TO MURDER HIM THE MOMENT HE SET FOOT IN THE CASTLE.

HE CHUCKLED, IT BECAME APPARENT TO ME VERY SOON THAT HE HAD NO EXTRAORDINARY TALENT AT ALL. HE HAS FIGURED HIS WAY OUT OF A NUMBER OF TIGHT SITUATIONS BY A SIMPLE COMBINATION OF SHARP WIT AND MORE TALENTED FRIENDS. HE IS MORE THE THE LAST DEGREE, THOUGH AS EGOISTICAL AND SELF-SATISFIED AS WAS HIS FATHER BEFORE HIM. I HAVE DONE MY UTMOST TO HAVE HIM THROWN OUT OF HOGWARTS, WHERE I BELIEVE HE SCARCELY BELONGS, BUT WILL HIM, HE ALLEYS HIM TO BE KILLED

IN FRONT OF ME? I WOULD HAVE BEEN A FOOL THE RISK IT WITH
DUMBLEDORE CLOSE AT HAND. AND THOUGH ALL THIS WE ARE SUPPOSED
THE BELIEVE DUMBLEDORE HAS NEVER SUSPECTED YET? ASKED BELLATRIX.

HE HAS NO IDEA OF YOUR TRUE ALLEGIANCE, HE TRUSTS YOU IMPLICITLY
STILL? I HAVE PLAYED MY PART WELL, SAID SNAPE. AND YOU
EVERMORE DUMBLEDORE'S GREATEST WEAKNESS! HE HAS THE BELIEVE THE
BEST OF PEOPLE, I TOLD HIM A TALE OF DEEPEST REMORSE WHEN I THOUGHT
HIS STAFF, FRESH FROM MY DEATH EATER DAYS, AND HE EMBRACED ME WITH
OPEN ARMS. THOUGH, AS I SAY, NEVER ALLOWING ME NEARER THE DARK
ARTS THAN HE COULD HELP, DUMBLEDORE HAS BEEN A GREAT WIZARD. HE
YES, HE HAS, WHEN BELLATRIX HAD MADE A SCATHING REPLY, THE DARK
LORD ACKNOWLEDGES IT, I AM PLEASED TO SAY, HOWEVER, THAT
DUMBLEDORE IS GROWING OLD, THE DUKE WITH THE DARK LORD LAST
MONTH STROKE HIM, HE HAS SINCE SUSTAINED A SERIOUS INJURY BECAUSE
HIS REACTIONS ARE SLOWER THAN THEY ONCE WERE, BUT THOUGH ALL
THESE YEARS, HE HAS NEVER STOPPED TRUSTING SEVERUS SNAPE, AND
THEREIN LIES MY GREAT VALUE TO THE DARK LORD, BELLATRIX STILL
LOOKED UNHAPPY, THOUGH SHE APPEARED UNSURE HOW BEST TO ATTACK
SNAPE NEXT, TAKING ADVANTAGE OF HER SILENCE, SNAPE TURNED TO
HER SISTER, WHEN YOU CAME TO ASK ME FOR HELP, NARCISSA?
NARCISSA LOOKED UP AT HIM, HER FACE EMBLENT WITH DESPAIR, YES,
SEVERUS, I. I THINK YOU ARE THE ONLY ONE WHO CAN HELP ME, I
HAVE NOWHERE ELSE TO TURN, LUCIUS IS IN JAIL AND. SHE CLOSED
HER EYES AND TWO LARGE TEARS SEEPED FROM BENEATH HER EYELIDS, THE
DARK LORD HAS FORBIDDEN ME TO SPEAK OF IT, NARCISSA CONTINUED,
HER EYES STILL CLOSED, HE WISHES NONE TO KNOW OF THE PLAN, IT IS
VERY SECRET, BUT. IF HE HAS FORBIDDEN IT, YOU MIGHT NOT TO
SPEAK, SAID SNAPE AT ONCE, THE DARK LORD'S WORD IS LAW,
NARCISSA GASPED AS THOUGH HE HAD DELUGED HER WITH COLD WATER,
BELLATRIX LOOKED SATISFIED FOR THE FIRST TIME SINCE SHE HAD ENTERED
THE HOUSE, THERE? SHE SAID TRIUMPHANTLY TO HER SISTER, EVEN
SNAPE SAYS SHE YOU WERE TOO NOT TO TALK, SHE HAD YOUR SILENCE?
BUT SNAPE HAD GOTTEN TO HIS FEET AND STRODE TO THE SMALL WINDOW,
PEERED THROUGH THE CURTAINS AT THE DESERTED STREET, THEN CLOSED
THEM AGAIN WITH A JERK, HE TURNED AROUND THE FACE NARCISSA,
PRELIMINARY, IT SHE HAPPENS THAT I KNOW OF THE PLAN, HE SAID IN A
LOW VOICE, I AM ONE OF THE FEW THE DARK LORD HAS TOLD,
NEVERTHELESS, HAD I NOT BEEN IN ON THE SECRET, NARCISSA, YOU WOULD

HAVE BEEN GUILTY OF GREAT TREACHERY TO THE DARK LORD. I
THOUGHT YOU MUST KNOW ABOUT IT? SAID NARCISSA, BREATHING MORE
FREELY. HE TRUSTS YOU SEE, SEVERUS. YOU KNOW ABOUT THE
PLAN? SAID BELLATRIX, HER FLEETING EXPRESSION OF SATISFACTION
REPLACED BY A LOOK OF MISTRUST. YOU KNOW? CERTAINLY, SAID
SNAPE. BUT WHAT HELD YOU BACK, NARCISSA? IF YOU ARE
IMAGINING I CAN PERSUADE THE DARK LORD TO CHANGE HIS MIND, I AM
AFRAID THERE IS NO HOPE, NONE AT ALL. SEVERUS, SHE WHISPERED,
TEARS SLIDING DOWN HER PALE CHEEKS. MY SON MY ONLY SON

DRACH SHOULD BE PROUD, SAID BELLATRIX INDIFFERENTLY. THE DARK
LORD IS GRANTING HIM A GREAT FAVOR, AND I WILL SAY THIS FOR
DRACH: HE ISN'T SHRINKING AWAY FROM HIS DUTY, HE SEEMS GLAD OF A
CHANCE TO PROVE HIMSELF, EXCITED AT THE PROSPECT. NARCISSA
BEGAN TO CRY IN EARNEST, GAZING RESPECTFULLY ALL THE WHILE AT
SNAPE. THAT I REALISE HE IS SIXTEEN AND HAS NO IDEA WHAT LIES IN
STORE? WHY, SEVERUS? WHY MY SON? IT IS TOO DANGEROUS! THIS IS
VENGEANCE FOR LUCIUS'S MISTAKE, I KNOW IT! SNAPE SAID NOTHING,
HE LOOKED AWAY FROM THE SIGHT OF HER TEARS AS THOUGH THEY WERE
INDECENT, BUT HE COULD NOT PRETEND NOT TO HEAR HER. THAT I KNOW
HE'S CHOSEN DRACH, ISN'T IT? SHE PERSISTED. THE POLISH LUCIUS?

IF DRACH SUCCEEDS, SAID SNAPE, STILL LOOKING AWAY FROM HER, HE
WILL BE FAVORABLE ABOVE ALL OTHERS. BUT HE WON'T SUCCEED! SHEED
NARCISSA. THEN CAN HE, WHEN THE DARK LORD HIMSELF ?
BELLATRIX GASPED; NARCISSA SEEMED TO LOSE HER NERVE. I ONLY MEANT

THAT NOBODY HAS YET SUCCEEDED. SEVERUS PLEASE YOU
ARE, YOU HAVE ALWAYS BEEN DRACH'S FAVORITE TEACHER. YOU ARE
LUCIUS'S OLD FRIEND. I SEE YOU. YOU ARE THE DARK LORD'S
FAVORITE, HIS MOST TRUSTED ADVISER. WILL YOU SPREAD TO HIM,
PERSUADE HIM ? THE DARK LORD WILL NOT BE PERSUADED, AND I AM
NOT STUPID ENOUGH TO ATTEMPT IT, SAID SNAPE FLATLY. I CAN'T
PRETEND THAT THE DARK LORD IS NOT ANGRY WITH LUCIUS, LUCIUS WAS
SLIPPED TO BE IN CHARGE. HE GOT HIMSELF CAPTURED, ALONG WITH MANY
OTHERS, AND FAILED TO RETRIEVE THE PROPHECY IN THE BARGAIN.
YES, THE DARK LORD IS ANGRY, NARCISSA, VERY ANGRY INDEED. THEN I
AM RIGHT, HE HAS CHOSEN DRACH IN REVENGE? CHIEF NARCISSA. HE
DOES NOT MEAN HIM TO SUCCEED, HE WANTS HIM TO BE KILLED TRYING!
WHEN SNAPE SAID NOTHING, NARCISSA SEEMED TO LOSE WHAT LITTLE
SELF-RESTRAINT SHE STILL POSSESSED. STANDING UP, SHE STAGGERED TO

SNAPE AND SEIZED THE POINT OF HIS REEKS. HER FACE CLASPED TO HIS, HER
 TEARS FALLING INTO HIS CHEST, SHE GASPED, YOU COULD DO IT, YOU
 COULD DO IT INSTEAD OF DRACHE, SEVERUS, YOU WOULD SUCCEED, HE CHIRPED
 YOU WOULD, AND HE WOULD REWARD YOU BY BEING ALL OF US SNAPE
 CALGHT HOLD OF HER WRISTS AND REMOVED HER CLUTCHING HANDS,
 LEANING DOWN INTO HER TEARSTAINED FACE, HE SAID SILENTLY, HE
 INTENDS ME TO DO IT IN THE END, I THINK, BUT HE IS DETERMINED THAT
 DRACHE SHOULD TRY FIRST, YOU SEE, IN THE UNLIKELY EVENT THAT DRACHE
 SUCCEEDS, I SHALL BE ABLE TO REMAIN AT HOGWARTS A LITTLE LONGER,
 FULFILLING MY LIFE'S DREAM AS YOU. IN EITHER CASE, IT DOESN'T
 MATTER TO HIM IF DRACHE IS KILLED! THE DARK LORD IS VERY ANGRY,
 REPEATED SNAPE QUIETLY, HE FAILED TO HEAR THE PROPHECY, YOU
 KNOW AS WELL AS I DO, NARCISSE, THAT HE DOES NOT FORGIVE EASILY,
 SHE CRUMPLED, FALLING AT HIS FEET, SHAKING AND WHINING IN THE
 PAIN. MY ONLY SON MY ONLY SON YOU SHOULD BE PROUD!
 SAID BELLATRIX RUTHLESSLY, IF I HAD SONS, I WOULD BE GLAD TO GIVE
 THEM UP TO THE SERVICE OF THE DARK LORD! NARCISSE GAVE A LITTLE
 SCREAM OF DESPAIR AND CLUTCHED AT HER LONG BLONDE HAIR, SNAPE
 STEPPED, SEIZED HER BY THE ARMS, LIFTED HER UP, AND STEPPED HER BACK
 INTO THE SEAT, HE THEN FILLED HER MORE WINE AND FORCED THE GLASS
 INTO HER HAND, NARCISSE, THAT'S ENOUGH, DRINK THIS, LISTEN TO
 ME, SHE BLINKED A LITTLE, SWALLOWING WINE DOWN HERSELF, SHE TOOK A
 SHADY SIP, IT MIGHT BE POSSIBLE FOR ME TO HELP DRACHE, SHE SAT
 UP, HER FACE PAPER-WHITE, HER EYES FLICK, SEVERUS HE, SEVERUS
 YOU WOULD HELP HIM? WOULD YOU LEAVE AFTER HIM, SEE HE CHASES THE
 NEW HARK? I CAN TRY, SHE FLUNG AWAY HER GLASS, IT SKIDDED ACROSS
 THE TABLE AS SHE SLID OFF THE SEAT INTO A KNEELING POSITION AT
 SNAPE'S FEET, SEIZED HIS HAND IN BOTH OF HER, AND PRESSED HER LIPS
 TO IT, IF YOU ARE THERE TO PROTECT HIM SEVERUS, WILL YOU SWEAR
 IT? WILL YOU MAKE THE UNREADABLE YOU? THE UNREADABLE
 YOU? SNAPE'S EXPRESSION WAS BLANK, UNREADABLE, BELLATRIX,
 HOWEVER, LET ME HEAR A CRY OF TRIUMPHANT LAUGHTER, AREN'T YOU
 LISTENING, NARCISSE? HE, HE'LL TRY, I'M SURE, THE USUAL EMPTY
 WORDS, THE USUAL SLITHERING HEAT OF ACTION HE, HE, THE DARK
 LORD'S ORDERS, HE CHIRPED? SNAPE DID NOT LOOK AT BELLATRIX, HIS
 BLACK EYES WERE FIXED UPON NARCISSE'S TEAR-FILLED BLUE EYES AS SHE
 CONTINUED TO CLUTCH HIS HAND, CERTAINLY, NARCISSE, I SHALL MAKE
 THE UNREADABLE YOU, HE SAID QUIETLY, PERHAPS YOUR SISTER WILL

CONSENT THE RE HER BENDER. BELLATRIX'S MOUTH FELL OPEN. SNAPE
WHISPERED HIMSELF SHE THAT HE WAS KNEELING OPPOSITE NARCISSA.
BENEATH BELLATRIX'S ASTONISHED GAZE, THEY GRASPED RIGHT HANDS.

WELL WILL NEED YOUR HAND, BELLATRIX, SAID SNAPE CALMLY. SHE DREW
IT, STILL BREATHING ASTONISHED. AND WELL WILL NEED THE MEAT A LITTLE
CLOSER, HE SAID. SHE STEPPED FORWARD SHE THAT SHE STOOD OVER THEM,
AND PLACED THE TIP OF HER HAND BETWEEN THEIR LINKED HANDS. NARCISSA
SMILED. WILL WELL, SEVERUS, WATCH EVER MY SON, DRAGON, AS HE
ATTEMPTS THE FULFILL THE DARK LORD'S WISHES? I WILL, SAID SNAPE.
A THIN THING OF BRILLIANT FLAME ISSUED FROM THE HAND AND WHIRLED
ITS WAY AROUND THEIR HANDS LIKE A RED-HOT WIRE. AND WILL WELL, THE
THE BEST OF YOUR ABILITY, PROTECT HIM FROM HARM? I WILL, SAID
SNAPE. A SECOND THING OF FLAME SHEET FROM THE HAND AND
INTERLINED WITH THE FIRST, MAKING A FINE, GLOWING CHAIN. AND,
SHOULD IT PROVE NECESSARY IF IT SEEMS DRAGON WILL FAIL

WHISPERED NARCISSA (SNAPE'S HAND TWITCHED WITHIN HER, BUT HE DID
NOT DRAW AWAY). WILL WELL CARRY OUT THE DEED THAT THE DARK LORD
HAS ORDERED DRAGON THE PERFORM? THERE WAS A MOMENT'S SILENCE.
BELLATRIX WATCHED, HER HAND UPON THEIR CLASPED HANDS, HER EYES
WIDE. I WILL, SAID SNAPE. BELLATRIX'S ASTONISHED FACE GLOWED RED IN
THE GLAZE OF A THIRD THING OF FLAME, WHICH SHEET FROM THE HAND,
TWISTED WITH THE OTHERS, AND WHIRLED ITSELF THICKLY AROUND THEIR
CLASPED HANDS, LIKE A REEF, LIKE A FIERY SNAKE. WILL AND WHEN T
HARRY POTTER WAS SMILING BROADLY, HE HAD BEEN SITTING IN A CHAIR
BESIDE HIS BEDROOM WINDOW FOR THE BEST PART OF THEIR YEARS, STARING
OUT AT THE DARKENING STREET, AND HAD FINALLY FALLEN ASLEEP WITH ONE
SIDE OF HIS FACE PRESSED AGAINST THE CHILD WINDOWPANE, HIS GLASSES
ASIDE AND HIS MOUTH WIDE OPEN. THE MISTY AIR HIS BREATH HAD LEFT
BETWEEN THE WINDOW SPARKLED IN THE STRANGE GLARE OF THE STREETLAMP
OUTSIDE, AND THE ARTIFICIAL LIGHT DRAINED HIS FACE OF ALL COLOR, SHE
THAT HE BREATHED GENTLY BENEATH HIS SHEED OF LONELY BLACK HAIR.
THE ROOM WAS STREWED WITH VARIOUS POSSESSIONS AND A GOOD
SMATTERING OF RICKETS, FEEL FEATHERS, APPLE CORES, AND SWEET
WRAPPERS LITTERED THE FLOOR, A NUMBER OF SPELLBOOKS LAY HIGGLEDY-
PIGGLEDY AMONG THE TANGLED REELS OF HIS BED, AND A MESS OF
NEWSPAPERS SAT IN A PUDDLE OF LIGHT ON HIS DESK. THE HEADLINE OF
ONE BLARED: OLIVERS CONTINUE TO FLY ABOUT THE MYSTERIOUS RECENT
DISTURBANCE AT THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, DURING WHICH HE-HE-

MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED WAS SIGHTED SINCE THEN. WE'RE NOT ALLOWED THE
TALK ABOUT IT, THEN I ASK ME ANYTHING, SAID ONE AGITATED
EKLIVIAITH, WHO REPLIED THE GIVE HIS NAME AS HE LEFT THE MINISTRY
LAST NIGHT. NEVERTHELESS, HIGHLY PLACED SHERIFFS WITHIN THE
MINISTRY HAVE CONFIRMED THAT THE DISTURBANCE CENTERED ON THE
FABLED FALL OF PROPHECY. THOUGH MINISTRY SPOKESWIZARDS HAVE
HITHERTO REFUSED EVEN THE CONFIRM THE EXISTENCE OF SUCH A PLACE, A
GRIMING NUMBER OF THE WIZARDING COMMUNITY BELIEVE THAT THE
DEATH EATERS NOW SERVING SENTENCES IN AZDARAN FOR TRESPASS AND
ATTEMPTED THEFT WERE ATTEMPTING THE STEAL A PROPHECY. THE NATURE
OF THAT PROPHECY IS UNKNOWN, ALTHOUGH SPECULATION IS RIFE THAT
IT CONCERNS HARRY POTTER, THE ONLY PERSON EVER KNOWN THE HAVE
SURVIVED THE KILLING CURSE, AND WHO IS ALSO KNOWN THE HAVE BEEN
AT THE MINISTRY ON THE NIGHT IN QUESTION. SOME ARE GOING SO FAR
AS THE CALL POTTER THE CHosen ONE, BELIEVING THAT THE PROPHECY
NAMES HIM AS THE ONLY ONE WHO WILL BE ABLE TO RID US OF THE
MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED. THE CURRENT WHEREABOUTS OF THE PROPHECY, IF
IT EXISTS, ARE UNKNOWN, ALTHOUGH (LTD, PAGE 2, COLUMN 1) A SECOND
NEWSPAPER LAY BESIDE THE FIRST. THIS ONE BEAR THE HEADLINE: MEET
OF THIS FRONT PAGE WAS TAKEN UP WITH A LARGE BLACK-AND-WHITE
PICTURE OF A MAN WITH A LIKELIKE MANNER OF THICK HAIR AND A RATHER
RAVAGED FACE. THE PICTURE WAS MOVING THE MAN WAS LAYING AT
THE CEILING. RUFUS SCRIMGEWELL, PREVIOUSLY HEAD OF THE ALBION
OFFICE IN THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT, HAS
SUCCEEDED CERNELIUS FUDGE AS MINISTER OF MAGIC. THE APPOINTMENT
HAS LARGELY BEEN GREETED WITH ENTHUSIASM BY THE WIZARDING
COMMUNITY, THOUGH ALIMERS OF A RIFT BETWEEN THE NEW MINISTER AND
ALBUS DUMBLEDORE, NEWLY REINSTATED CHIEF WARLOCK OF THE
WIZENGAMMOT, SURFACED WITHIN FEELINGS OF SCRIMGEWELL TAKING OFFICE.
SCRIMGEWELL'S REPRESENTATIVES ADMITTED THAT HE HAD MET WITH
DUMBLEDORE AT ONCE UPON TAKING POSSESSION OF THE THROON, BUT
REFUSED THE COMMENT ON THE TOPICS UNDER DISCUSSION. ALBUS
DUMBLEDORE IS KNOWN THE (LTD, PAGE 3, COLUMN 2) THE THE LEFT OF THIS
PAPER SAT ANOTHER, WHICH HAD BEEN FILLED SEE THAT A STORY BEARING
THE TITLE MINISTRY GUARANTEES STUDENTS' SAFETY WAS
VISIBLE. NEWLY APPOINTED MINISTER OF MAGIC, RUFUS SCRIMGEWELL,
SPOKE TODAY OF THE THOUGH NEW MEASURES TAKEN BY HIS MINISTRY TO
ENSURE THE SAFETY OF STUDENTS RETURNING TO HOGWARTS SCHOOL OF

WITCHCRAFT AND WIZARDRY THIS AFTERNOON. FOR EVERYONE'S REASONS, THE MINISTRY WILL NOT BE GOING INTO DETAIL ABOUT ITS STRINGENT NEW SECURITY PLANS, SAID THE MINISTER, ALTHOUGH AN INSIDER CONFIRMED THAT MEASURES INCLUDE DEFENSIVE SPELLS AND CHARMS, A COMPLEX ARRAY OF COUNTERCOUNTERS, AND A SMALL TASK FORCE OF ADVISERS DEDICATED SPECIFICALLY TO THE PROTECTION OF HOGWARTS SCHOOL. MOST SEEM REASSURED BY THE NEW MINISTER'S THOUGH STAND ON STUDENT SAFETY. SAID MRS. AUGUSTA LONGBOTTLE, MY GRANDSON, NEVILLE A GOOD FRIEND OF HARRY POTTER'S, INCIDENTALLY, WE'VE HEARD THE DEATH EATERS ALONGSIDE HIM AT THE MINISTRY IN JULY AND BUT THE REST OF THIS STORY WAS OBTAINED BY THE LARGE KIDNAPER STANDING IN THE OF IT. INSIDE IT WAS A MAGNIFICENT STONY HALL, HER AMBER EYES SURVEYED THE ROOM IMPASSIVELY, HER HEAD SWIVELING OCCASIONALLY THE GAZE AT HER SMILING MASTER. THEN SHE TWICE SHE CLINKED HER BEAK IMPATIENTLY, BUT HARRY WAS THEN DEEPLY ASLEEP THE HEAR HER. A LARGE TRUNK STOOD IN THE VERY MIDDLE OF THE ROOM. ITS LID WAS OPEN; IT LOOKED EXPECTANT; YET IT WAS ALMOST EMPTY BUT FOR A RESIDUE OF OLD UNDERWEAR, SWEETS, EMPTY INK BOTTLES, AND CRUMPLED HILLS THAT CHATED THE VERY BOTTLES. NEARBY, ON THE FLOOR, LAY A PURPLE BASKET EMBLAZONED WITH THE WORDS: THE WIZARDING COMMUNITY IS CURRENTLY UNDER THREAT FROM AN ORGANIZATION CALLING ITSELF THE DEATH EATERS. OBSERVING THE FOLLOWING SIMPLE SECURITY GUIDELINES WILL HELP PROTECT YOU, YOUR FAMILY, AND YOUR HOME FROM ATTACK. 1. YOU ARE ADVISED NOT TO LEAVE THE HOUSE ALONE. 2. PARTICULAR CARE SHOULD BE TAKEN DURING THE HOURS OF DARKNESS. WHEREVER POSSIBLE, ARRANGE THE COMPLETE JOURNEY'S BEFORE NIGHT HAS FALLEN. 3. REVIEW THE SECURITY ARRANGEMENTS AROUND YOUR HOUSE, MAKING SURE THAT ALL FAMILY MEMBERS ARE AWARE OF EMERGENCY MEASURES SUCH AS SHIELD AND DISILLUSIONMENT CHARMS, AND, IN THE CASE OF UNDERAGE FAMILY MEMBERS, SIDE-ALONG-APPARITION. 4. AGREE ON SECURITY QUESTIONS WITH CLOSE FRIENDS AND FAMILY SEE AS THE DETECT DEATH EATERS MASHLEADING AS OTHERS BY USE OF THE POLYLIC POTTER (SEE PAGE 2). 5. SHOULD YOU FEEL THAT A FAMILY MEMBER, COLLEAGUE, FRIEND, OR NEIGHBOR IS ACTING IN A STRANGE MANNER, CONTACT THE MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT BUREAU AT ONCE. THEY MAY HAVE BEEN PUT UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE (SEE PAGE 4). 6. SHOULD THE DARK MARK APPEAR EVER ANY DWELLING PLACE OR OTHER BUILDING, DO NOT ENTER, BUT CONTACT THE ADVISOR OFFICE IMMEDIATELY. 7. UNCONFIRMED SIGHTINGS

SUGGEST THAT THE DEATH PATERS MAY NOW BE LISTING INVERI (SEE PAGE 10). AND SIGHTING OF AN INVERIUS, HER ENCOUNTER WITH SAME, SHOULD BE REPORTED TO THE MINISTRY IMMEDIATELY. HARRY GRUNTED IN HIS SLEEP AND HIS FACE SLID BEHIND THE WINDOW AN INCH OR SO, MAKING HIS GLASSES STILL MORE UPSIDED, BUT HE DID NOT WAKE UP. AN ALARM CLOCK, REPAIRED BY HARRY SEVERAL YEARS AGO, TICKED LOUDLY ON THE SILL, SHOWING ONE MINUTE THE ELEVEN. BESIDE IT, HELD IN PLACE BY HARRY'S RELAXED HAND, WAS A PIECE OF PARCHMENT COVERED IN THIN, SLANTING WRITING. HARRY HAD READ THIS LETTER SEVEN TIMES SINCE ITS ARRIVAL THREE DAYS AGO THAT ALTHOUGH IT HAD BEEN DELIVERED IN A TIGHTLY FOLDED SHEET, IT NOW LAY FLAT. DEAR HARRY, IF IT IS CONVENIENT TO YOU, I SHALL CALL AT NUMBER FOUR, PRIVET DRIVE THIS COMING FRIDAY AT ELEVEN P.M. THE REST OF YOU THE BURNING, WHERE YOU HAVE BEEN INVITED TO SPEND THE REMAINDER OF YOUR SUMMER HOLIDAYS. IF YOU ARE AGREEABLE, I SHOULD ALSO BE GLAD OF YOUR ASSISTANCE IN A MATTER THE WHICH I HOPE TO ATTEND ON THE WAY THE BURNING. I SHALL EXPLAIN THIS MORE FULLY WHEN I SEE YOU. KINDLY SEND YOUR ANSWER BY RETURN OF THIS MAIL. HOPING TO SEE YOU THIS FRIDAY, I AM, YOURS MOST SINCERELY, THOUGH HE ALREADY KNEW IT BY HEART, HARRY HAD BEEN STEALING GLANCES AT THIS MISSIVE EVERY FEW MINUTES SINCE SEVEN O'CLOCK THAT EVENING, WHEN HE HAD FIRST TAKEN UP HIS POSITION BESIDE HIS BEDROOM WINDOW, WHICH HAD A REASONABLE VIEW OF BOTH ENDS OF PRIVET DRIVE. HE KNEW IT WAS POINTLESS TO KEEP REREADING OLIMPEDE'S WORDS; HARRY HAD SENT BACK HIS YES WITH THE DELIVERING MAIL, AS REQUESTED, AND ALL HE COULD DO NOW WAS WAIT: EITHER OLIMPEDE WAS GOING TO COME, OR HE WAS NOT. BUT HARRY HAD NOT PACKED. IT JUST SEEMED TO HIM THAT HE WAS GOING TO BE RESCUED FROM THE BURNING AFTER A MERE THIRTY-NINE OF THEIR COMPANY. HE COULD NOT SHAKE OFF THE FEELING THAT SOMETHING WAS GOING TO GO WRONG HIS REPLY TO OLIMPEDE'S LETTER MIGHT HAVE GONE astray; OLIMPEDE COULD BE PREVENTED FROM COLLECTING HIM; THE LETTER MIGHT TURN OUT NOT TO BE FROM OLIMPEDE AT ALL, BUT A TRICK OR HOAX OR TRAP. HARRY HAD NOT BEEN ABLE TO FACE PACKING AND THEN BEING LET DOWN AND HAVING THE LINPACK AGAIN. THE ONLY GESTURE HE HAD MADE TO THE POSSIBILITY OF A DELIVERY WAS TO SLIT HIS SLEEPING MAIL, EDWIG, SAFELY IN HER CAGE. THE MINUTE HAND ON THE ALARM CLOCK REACHED THE NUMBER TWELVE AND, AT THAT PRECISE MOMENT, THE STREETLAMP OUTSIDE THE WINDOW WENT OUT.

FARRY ALIKE AS THOUGH THE SUDDEN DARKNESS WERE AN ALARM, FASTLY STRAIGHTENING HIS GLASSES AND UNSTICKING HIS CHAIR FROM THE GLASS, HE PRESSED HIS NESE AGAINST THE WINDOW INSTEAD AND SEELINTED DOWN AT THE PAVEMENT. A TALL FIGURE IN A LONG, KILLING CLOAK WAS WALKING UP THE GARDEN PATH. FARRY JUMPED UP AS THOUGH HE HAD RECEIVED AN ELECTRIC SHOCK, KNEELED OVER HIS CHAIR, AND STARTED SNATCHING ANYTHING AND EVERYTHING WITHIN REACH FROM THE SHELF AND THROWING IT INTO THE TRUNK. EVEN AS HE LOOKED A SET OF BOOKS, TWO SPILLERS, AND A PACKET OF CRISPS ACROSS THE ROOM, THE DINNER RANG, DOWNSTAIRS IN THE LIVING ROOM HIS UNCLE VERNON SMILED. WHEN THE BLAZE IS CALLING AT THIS TIME OF NIGHT? FARRY FREEZE WITH A BRASS TELESCOPE IN ONE HAND AND A PAIR OF TRAINERS IN THE OTHER. HE HAD COMPLETELY FORGOTTEN THE WARN THE DURSLEY THAT DUMBLEDORE MIGHT BE COMING. FEELING BOTH PANICKY AND CHESE THE HALFTER, HE CLAMBERED OVER THE TRUNK AND WRENCHED OPEN HIS BEDROOM DOOR IN TIME TO HEAR A DEEP VOICE SAY,

GOOD EVENING, YOU MUST BE MR. DURSLEY, I DARE SAY FARRY HAS TOLD YOU I WOULD BE COMING FOR HIM? FARRY RAN DOWN THE STAIRS TWO AT A TIME, COMING TO AN ABRUPT HALT SEVERAL STEPS FROM THE BOTTOM, AS LONG EXPERIENCE HAD TAUGHT HIM TO REMAIN HILT OF ARM & REACH OF HIS UNCLE WHENEVER POSSIBLE. THERE IN THE HALLWAY STOOD A TALL, THIN MAN WITH WAIST-LENGTH SILVER HAIR AND BEARD. FAL-PHON SPECTACLES WERE PERCHED ON HIS CRINKLED NESE, AND HE WAS WEARING A LONG BLACK TRAVELING CLOAK AND A POINTED HAT. VERNON DURSLEY, WHOSE MUSTACHE WAS WHITE AS LIME AS DUMBLEDORE'S, THOUGH BLACK, AND WHEN WAS WEARING A POLICE DRESSING GOWN, WAS STARING AT THE VISITOR AS THOUGH HE COULD NOT BELIEVE HIS TINY EYES. JUDGING BY YOUR LOOK OF STUNNED DISBELIEF, FARRY DID NOT WORN YOU THAT I WAS COMING, SAID DUMBLEDORE PLEASANTLY. HOWEVER, LET US ASSUME THAT YOU HAVE INVITED ME WARMLY INTO YOUR HOUSE. IT IS UNLISE TO LINGER EVERLONG ON DOWNSTEPS IN THESE TRICKLED TIMES. HE STEPPED SMARTLY OVER THE THRESHOLD AND CLOSED THE FRONT DOOR BEHIND HIM.

IT IS A LONG TIME SINCE MY LAST VISIT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, PEERING DOWN HIS CRINKLED NESE AT UNCLE VERNON. I MUST SAY, YOUR ACAPANTHUS ARE FLOURISHING. VERNON DURSLEY SAID NOTHING AT ALL. FARRY DID NOT BELIEVE THAT SPEECH WOULD RETURN TO HIM, AND WHEN THE VEIN PULSING IN HIS UNCLE'S TEMPLE WAS REACHING DANGER POINT BUT SOMETHING ABOUT DUMBLEDORE SEEMED TO HAVE

BREKED HIM TEMPORARILY OF BREATH. IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN THE BLATANT
 WIZARDISHNESS OF HIS APPEARANCE, BUT IT MIGHT, THEN, HAVE BEEN THAT
 EVEN UNCLE VERNON COULD SENSE THAT THERE WAS A MAN WITH WHOM IT
 WOULD BE VERY DIFFICULT TO TALK. AT, GOOD EVENING HARRY, SAID
 DUMBLEDORE, LEANING UP AT HIM THROUGH HIS HALF-MOON GLASSES
 WITH A MOST SATISFIED EXPRESSION. EXCELLENT, EXCELLENT. THESE
 WORDS SEEMED THE RIGHT UNCLE VERNON. IT WAS CLEAR THAT AS FAR AS
 HE WAS CONCERNED, ANY MAN WITH WHOM HE COULD NEVER SEE EYE TO EYE. I
 DON'T MEAN TO BE RUDE HE BEGAN, IN A TONE THAT THREATENED
 RUDENESS IN EVERY SYLLABLE. YET, SADLY, ACCIDENTAL RUDENESS
 OCCURS ALARMINGLY OFTEN. DUMBLEDORE FINISHED THE SENTENCE
 GRAVELY. BEST TO SAY NOTHING AT ALL, MY DEAR MAN, AT, AND THIS
 MUST BE PETLINA. THE DOOR HAD OPENED, AND THERE STOOD
 HARRY'S AUNT, WEARING RUBBER GLOVES AND A NIGHTGOWN OVER HER
 NIGHTDRESS, CLEARLY HALFWAY THROUGH HER USUAL PRE-BEDTIME WIP-
 DOWN OF ALL THE KITCHEN SURFACES. HER RATHER FIERCE
 REGISTERED NOTHING BUT STICK. ASKED DUMBLEDORE, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
 WHEN UNCLE VERNON FAILED THE EFFECT OF AN INTRODUCTION. WE HAVE
 CORRESPONDED, OF COURSE. HARRY THOUGHT THIS AN odd WAY OF
 REMINDING AUNT PETLINA THAT HE HAD RECENTLY SENT HER AN EXPLORING
 LETTER, BUT AUNT PETLINA DID NOT CHALLENGE THE TERM. AND THIS
 MUST BE PHILIP SHUN, DUDLEY? DUDLEY HAD THAT MOMENT PEERED BEHIND
 THE LIVING ROOM DOOR, HIS LARGE, BLOND HEAD RISING OUT OF THE
 STRIPY CURTAIN OF HIS PALMAMAS. HE LOOKED HOPEFULLY DISCOMFORTED, HIS MOUTH
 GAPPING IN ASTONISHMENT AND FEAR. DUMBLEDORE WAITED A MOMENT HER
 THEN, APPARENTLY TO SEE WHETHER ANY OF THE DURSLEYS WERE GOING TO
 SAY ANYTHING, BUT AS THE SILENCE STRETCHED ON HE SMILED. SHALL WE
 ASSUME THAT YOU HAVE INVITED ME INTO YOUR SITTING ROOM? DUDLEY
 STAMBLERED OUT OF THE WAY AS DUMBLEDORE PASSED HIM. HARRY, STILL
 CLUTCHING THE TELESCOPE AND TRAINERS, LIMPED THE LAST FEW STAIRS
 AND FOLLOWED DUMBLEDORE, WHO HAD SETTLED HIMSELF IN THE ARMCHAIR
 NEAREST THE FIRE AND WAS TAKING IN THE SURROUNDINGS WITH AN
 EXPRESSION OF BENIGN INTEREST. HE LOOKED ELITE EXTRAORDINARILY
 OUT OF PLACE. AREN'T WE LEAVING, SIR? HARRY ASKED
 ANXIOUSLY. YES, INDEED WE ARE, BUT THERE ARE A FEW MATTERS WE NEED
 TO DISCUSS FIRST, SAID DUMBLEDORE. AND I WOULD PREFER NOT TO SEE
 IN THE OPEN. WE SHALL TRESPASS UPON YOUR AUNT AND UNCLE'S

HOSPITALITY ONLY A LITTLE LONGER. 'WELL WILL, WILL YOU?' 'VERNON
BLURLEY HAD ENTERED THE ROOM, PETUNIA AT HIS SIDE, AND DUDLEY
SKIDING BEHIND THEM BOTH. 'YES, SAID DUMKEDDRE SIMPLY, I
SHALL. HE DREW HIS HAND SHE RAPIDLY THAT HARRY RARELY SAW IT; WITH
A CASUAL FLICK, THE SHEA ZIPPED FORWARD AND DUNKED THE DUNKS HEAT
FROM UNDER ALL THREE OF THE BLURLEYS SHE THAT THEY COLLAPSED UPON
IT IN A HEAP. ANOTHER FLICK OF THE HAND AND THE SHEA ZIPPED BACK
TO ITS ORIGINAL POSITION. 'WE MAY AS WELL BE COMFORTABLE, SAID
DUMKEDDRE PLEASANTLY, AS HE REPLACED HIS HAND IN HIS POCKET,
HARRY SAW THAT HIS HAND WAS BLACKENED AND SWOLLEN; IT LOOKED AS
THOUGH HIS FLESH HAD BEEN BURNED AWAY. 'SIR WHAT HAPPENED THE
YEAR ? LATER, HARRY, SAID DUMKEDDRE, PLEASE SIT DOWN,
HARRY TOOK THE REMAINING ARMCHAIR, LEANING NEAR THE WINDOW AT THE
BLURLEYS, WHO SEEMED STUNNED INTO SILENCE. 'I WOULD ASSUME THAT
YOU WERE GIVING THE HOPPER MY REPRESENTMENT, DUMKEDDRE SAID THE LITTLE
VERNON, BUT THE EVIDENCE SHE FAR SUGGESTS THAT THAT WOULD BE
OPTIMISTIC THE THE POINT OF REALITY. A THIRD TWITCH OF THE
HAND, AND A DUSTY BOTTLE AND FIVE GLASSES APPEARED IN MIDAIR. THE
BOTTLE TIPPED AND DELIVERED A GENEROUS MEASURE OF FINEST
LIQUID INTO EACH OF THE GLASSES, WHICH THEN RADIATED THE EACH PERSON
IN THE ROOM. 'MADAM REMBERTA'S FINEST HAND-MATURED MEAD, SAID
DUMKEDDRE, RAISING HIS GLASS TO HARRY, WHO CALICHT FILLD OF HIS
OWN AND SIPPED, HE HAD NEVER TASTED ANYTHING LIKE IT BEFORE, BUT
ENJOYED IT IMMENSELY. THE BLURLEYS, AFTER A WHILE, STARED LOOKS AT
ONE ANOTHER, TRIED TO IGNORE THEIR GLASSES COMPLETELY, A DIFFICULT
FEAT, AS THEY WERE NIBBLING THEM GENTLY ON THE SIDES OF THEIR HEADS.
HARRY COULD NOT SUPPRESS A SUSPICION THAT DUMKEDDRE WAS
RATHER ENJOYING HIMSELF. 'WELL, HARRY, SAID DUMKEDDRE, TURNING
TOWARD HIM, A DIFFICULTY HAS ARISEN WHICH I HOPE YOU WILL BE ABLE
TO SOLVE FOR US. BY US, I MEAN THE HOUSE OF THE PEACOCK, BUT FIRST
OF ALL I MUST TELL YOU THAT SIRILIS'S WILL WAS DISCOVERED A WEEK AGO
AND THAT HE LEFT YOU EVERYTHING HE OWNED. EVER ON THE SHEA,
LITTLE VERNON'S HEAD TURNED, BUT HARRY DID NOT LOOK AT HIM, NOR
COULD HE THINK OF ANYTHING TO SAY EXCEPT, 'EH. RIGHT. THIS IS,
IN THE MAIN, FAIRLY STRAIGHTFORWARD. DUMKEDDRE WENT ON, YOU
ADD A REASONABLE AMOUNT OF GOLD TO THE YEARLY ACCOUNT AT GRINGETTS,
AND YOU INHERIT ALL OF SIRILIS'S PERSONAL POSSESSIONS. THE
SLIGHTLY PROBLEMATIC PART OF THE LEGACY HIS GRANDFATHER'S

DEAD? SAID LUNCLE VERNEEN LUDLOO FROM THE SHIP, DUMKLEBHERE AND
HARRY BOTH TURNED THE HEAD AT HIM. THE GLASS OF MEAD WAS NOW
DUNKLING WHITE INSISTENTLY IN THE SIDE OF VERNEEN'S HEAD; HE
ATTEMPTED THE BEAT IT AWAY. HE'S DEAD? HIS CHILDREN? YES, SAID
DUMKLEBHERE, HE DID NOT ASK HARRY WHY HE HAD NOT CHANGED IN THE
DUNKLES. ELITE PROBLEM, HE CONTINUED THE HARRY, AS IF THERE HAD
BEEN AN INTERRUPTION, IS THAT SIRILIS ALSO LEFT WITH NUMBER TWELVE,
CRIMINAL PLACE. HE'S BEEN LEFT A HOUSE? SAID LUNCLE VERNEEN
CAREFULLY, HIS SMALL EYES NARROWING, BUT QUICKLY ANSWERED HIM. YES
CAN KEEP LISTING IT AS HEADQUARTERS, SAID HARRY. I DON'T CARE, YES
CAN HAVE IT, I DON'T REALLY WANT IT. HARRY NEVER WANTED THE SET
LEFT IN NUMBER TWELVE, CRIMINAL PLACE AGAIN IF HE COULD HELP IT.
HE THOUGHT HE WOULD BE HAUNTED FOREVER BY THE MEMORY OF SIRILIS
PUSHING ITS DARK MILKY REIMS ALONE, IMPRISONED WITHIN THE
PLACE HE HAD WANTED SO DESPERATELY TO LEAVE. THAT IS GENERALLY,
SAID DUMKLEBHERE. WE HAVE, HOWEVER, VACATED THE BUILDING
TEMPORARILY. WHY? WELL, SAID DUMKLEBHERE, IGNORING THE
MUTTERINGS OF LUNCLE VERNEEN, WHO WAS NOW BEING RAPPED SMARTLY
OVER THE HEAD BY THE PERSISTENT GLASS OF MEAD. BLACK FAMILY
TRADITION DECREED THAT THE HOUSE WAS HANDED DOWN THE DIRECT LINE,
THE THE NEXT MALE WITH THE NAME OF BLACK. SIRILIS WAS THE VERY LAST
OF THE LINE AS HIS YOUNGER BROTHER, REGILLIS, PREDECEASED HIM AND
BOTH WERE CHILDLESS. WHILE HIS WILL MAKES IT PERFECTLY PLAIN THAT HE
WANTS YES TO HAVE THE HOUSE, IT IS NEVERTHELESS POSSIBLE THAT
SOME SPELL OR ENCHANTMENT HAS BEEN SET UPON THE PLACE TO ENSURE
THAT IT CANNOT BE OWNED BY ANYONE OTHER THAN A DUMKLEBHERE. A
VIVID IMAGE OF THE SMILING, SPITTING PORTRAIT OF SIRILIS'S MOTHER
THAT HUNG IN THE HALL OF NUMBER TWELVE, CRIMINAL PLACE FLASHED
INTO HARRY'S MIND. I GET THERE HAS, HE SAID. ELITE, SAID
DUMKLEBHERE. AND IF SUCH AN ENCHANTMENT EXISTS, THEN THE
OWNERSHIP OF THE HOUSE IS MOST LIKELY TO PASS TO THE ELDEST OF
SIRILIS'S LIVING RELATIVES, WHICH WOULD MEAN HIS CHLISIN, KELLATRIX
LESTRANGE. WITHOUT REALIZING WHAT HE WAS DOING, HARRY SPRANG
TO HIS FEET; THE TELESCOPE AND TRAINERS IN HIS LAP REELLED ACROSS THE
FLOOR. KELLATRIX LESTRANGE, SIRILIS'S KILLER, INHERIT HIS HOUSE?
NO, HE SAID. WELL, EVIDENTLY WE WOULD PREFER THAT SHE DIDN'T GET
IT EITHER, SAID DUMKLEBHERE CALMLY. THE SITUATION IS FRUGHT WITH
COMPLICATIONS. WE DO NOT KNOW WHETHER THE ENCHANTMENTS WE

THEMSELVES HAVE PLACED UPON IT, FOR EXAMPLE, MAKING IT
 UNPLEASANT, WILL THEY NOW THAT OWNERSHIP HAS PASSED FROM
 SIRIUS'S HANDS. IT MIGHT BE THAT BELLATRIX WILL ARRIVE IN THE
 BARRISTER AT ANY MOMENT. NATURALLY WE HAD THE MEET UNTIL
 SUCH TIME AS WE HAVE CLARIFIED THE POSITION. BUT THEY ARE STILL
 GOING TO FIND OUT IF I'M ALLOWED TO HAVE IT? FORTUNATELY, SAID
 DUMBLEDORE, THERE IS A SIMPLE TEST. HE PLACED HIS EMPTY GLASS ON A
 SMALL TABLE BESIDE HIS CHAIR, BUT BEFORE HE COULD DO ANYTHING ELSE,
 UNCLE VERNON INTERRUPTED. WILL YOU GET THESE RUDY THINGS OFF US?
 HARRY WHISPERED AROUND; ALL THREE OF THE DURSLEYS WERE CHEERING
 WITH THEIR ARMS OVER THEIR HEADS AS THEIR GLASSES ROLLED UP AND
 DOWN ON THEIR SKILLS, THEIR CONTENTS FLYING EVERYWHERE. EH, I'M
 SURE, SAID DUMBLEDORE POLITELY, AND HE RAISED HIS WAND AGAIN.
 ALL THREE GLASSES VANISHED. BUT IT WOULD HAVE BEEN BETTER
 MANNERS TO DRINK IT, YOU KNOW. IT LOOKED AS THOUGH UNCLE
 VERNON WAS BUSTLING WITH ANY NUMBER OF UNPLEASANT RETORTS, BUT
 HE MERELY STRAND BACK INTO THE CUSHIONS WITH ALINT PETLONIA AND
 DUDLEY AND SAID NOTHING, KEEPING HIS SMALL PIGEY EYES ON
 DUMBLEDORE'S WAND. YOU SEE, DUMBLEDORE SAID, TURNING BACK TO
 HARRY AND AGAIN SPEAKING AS THOUGH UNCLE VERNON HAD NOT
 INTERRUPTED. IF YOU HAVE INDEED INHERITED THE HEIR, YOU HAVE ALSO
 INHERITED HE FLICKED HIS WAND FOR A FIFTH TIME. THERE WAS A
 LOUD CRACK, AND A HEIRSELF APPEARED, WITH A SMILE FOR A NOSE,
 GIANT BAT'S EARS, AND ENORMOUS BLEEDING EYES, CREEPING ON THE
 DURSLEYS' SHAG CARPET AND CRAWLED IN GRIMY RACS. ALINT PETLONIA LET
 OUT A HAIR-RAISING SCREECH; NOTHING THIS FILTHY HAD ENTERED HER
 HEIR IN LIVING MEMORY. DUDLEY DREW HIS LARGE, BARE, PINK FEET OFF
 THE FLOOR AND SAT WITH THEM RAISED ALMOST ABOVE HIS HEAD, AS
 THOUGH HE THOUGHT THE CREATURE MIGHT RUN UP HIS PALM
 TREES, AND UNCLE VERNON BELIEVED. WHAT THE HELL IS THAT?
 KREACHER, FINISHED DUMBLEDORE. KREACHER WHEN T, KREACHER
 WHEN T, KREACHER WHEN T? CREATED THE HEIRSELF, WHITE AS LILLY AS
 UNCLE VERNON, STAMPING HIS LEGS, GRARLED FEET AND PULLING HIS
 EARS. KREACHER BELONGS TO MISS BELLATRIX, EH YES, KREACHER
 BELONGS TO THE BLACKS, KREACHER WANTS HIS NEW MISTRESS, KREACHER
 WHEN T GET THE THE BETTER BRAT, KREACHER WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T
 AS YOU CAN SEE, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE LILLY, EVER KREACHER'S
 CONTINUED CREATES HE WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T, KREACHER IS SHOWING

A CERTAIN RELUCTANCE THE PASS INTO YOUR OWNERSHIP. I DON'T
CARE, SAID HARRY AGAIN, WHISKING WITH DISGUST AT THE WRITING,
STAMPING FHELS-ELF. I DON'T WANT HIM. WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T,
WHEN T. YOU WOULD PREFER HIM THE PASS INTO THE OWNERSHIP OF
BELLATRIX LESTRANGE? BEARING IN MIND THAT HE HAS LIVED AT THE
HEADQUARTERS OF THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX FOR THE PAST YEAR?

WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T. HARRY STARED AT DUMBLEDORE. HE
KNEW THAT DREACHER COULD NOT BE PERMITTED TO GO AND LIVE WITH
BELLATRIX LESTRANGE, BUT THE IDEA OF OWNING HIM, OF HAVING
RESPONSIBILITY FOR THE CREATURE THAT HAD BETRAYED SIRILIS, WAS
REPLENANT. GIVE HIM AN ORDER, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IF HE HAS PASSED
INTO YOUR OWNERSHIP, HE WILL HAVE THE CHOICE. IF NOT, THEN WE SHALL
HAVE THE THING OF SOME OTHER MEANS OF KEEPING HIM FROM HIS
RIGHTFUL MISTRESS. WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T, WHEN T? DREACHER'S
VOICE HAD RISEN TO A SCREAM. HARRY COULD THINK OF NOTHING TO SAY,
EXCEPT, DREACHER, SHUT UP! IT LASTED FOR A MOMENT AS THOUGH
DREACHER WAS CHING THE CHAIR, HE GRABBED HIS THROAT, HIS MOUTH
STILL WHISKING FLURIOUSLY, HIS EYES BLINKING. AFTER A FEW SECONDS OF
FRANTIC GLIMPING, HE THREW HIMSELF FACE FORWARD INTO THE CARPET
(ALINT PETLONIA WHIMPERED) AND BEAT THE FLOOR WITH HIS HANDS AND
FEET, GIVING HIMSELF EVER TO A VIOLENT, BUT ENTIRELY SILENT, TANTALUM.

WELL, THAT SIMPLIFIES MATTERS, SAID DUMBLEDORE CHEERFULLY. IT
SEEMS THAT SIRILIS KNEW WHAT HE WAS DOING. YOU ARE THE RIGHTFUL
OWNER OF NUMBER TWELVE, CRIMINALS PLACE AND OF DREACHER. DO I

DO I HAVE TO KEEP HIM WITH ME? HARRY ASKED, AGHAST, AS
DREACHER THRASHED AROUND AT HIS FEET. NOT IF YOU DON'T WANT TO,
SAID DUMBLEDORE. IF I MIGHT MAKE A SUGGESTION, YOU COULD SEND HIM
TO THE HOGWARTS THE WARD IN THE KITCHEN THERE. IN THAT WAY, THE OTHER
FHELS-ELVES COULD KEEP AN EYE ON HIM. YES, SAID HARRY IN
RELIEF, YES, I'LL DO THAT, ER DREACHER I WANT YOU TO GO TO THE
HOGWARTS AND WARD IN THE KITCHENS THERE WITH THE OTHER
FHELS-ELVES. DREACHER, WHO WAS NOW LYING FLAT ON HIS BACK WITH
HIS ARMS AND LEGS IN THE AIR, GAVE HARRY ONE UPSIDE-DOWN LOOK OF
DEEPEST HATHING AND, WITH ANOTHER LUD CRACK, VANISHED. GOOD,
SAID DUMBLEDORE. THERE IS ALSO THE MATTER OF THE HIPPOGRIF,
BLICKHEAD. HAGRID HAS BEEN WHISKING AFTER HIM SINCE SIRILIS DIED, BUT
BLICKHEAD IS YOURS NOW, SO IF YOU WOULD PREFER TO MAKE DIFFERENT
ARRANGEMENTS. NO, SAID HARRY AT ONCE. HE CAN STAY WITH

"HARRY, I THINK BLUNDERBELL WOULD PREFER THAT," HARRY WILL BE
 DELIGHTED, SAID BLUNDERBELL, SMILING. HE WAS THRILLED TO SEE
 BLUNDERBELL AGAIN. INCIDENTALLY, WE HAVE DECIDED, IN THE INTERESTS OF
 BLUNDERBELL'S SAFETY, TO RECHARGE HIM WITH WINGS FOR THE TIME
 BEING, THOUGH I DOUBT THAT THE MINISTRY WOULD EVER GUESS HE IS
 THE HIPPOGRYPH THEY ONCE SENTENCED TO DEATH. WELL, HARRY, IS YOUR
 TRUNK PACKED? "I'M DELIGHTED THAT I WOULD TURN UP,"
 BLUNDERBELL SUGGESTED SMILINGLY. "I'LL JUST GO AND ER FINISH
 OFF," SAID HARRY HASTILY, HURRYING TO PICK UP HIS FALLEN TELESCOPE
 AND TRAINERS. IT TOOK HIM A LITTLE OVER TEN MINUTES TO TRACK DOWN
 EVERYTHING HE NEEDED; AT LAST HE HAD MANAGED TO EXTRACT HIS
 INVISIBILITY CLOAK FROM UNDER THE BED, SQUEEZED THE TOP BACK ON HIS
 LAMP OF CHAIR-CHANGE INTO, AND CHECKED THE LID OF HIS TRUNK SEWED ON
 HIS CALIBRE. THEN, GRABING HIS TRUNK IN ONE HAND AND HOLDING
 HEDWIG'S CAGE IN THE OTHER, HE MADE HIS WAY BACK DOWNSTAIRS. HE
 WAS DISAPPOINTED TO DISCOVER THAT BLUNDERBELL WAS NOT WAITING IN
 THE HALL, WHICH MEANT THAT HE HAD TO RETURN TO THE LIVING ROOM.
 NORMALLY WAS TALKING, BLUNDERBELL WAS HUMMING QUIETLY, APPARENTLY
 ELITE AT HIS CASE, BUT THE ATMOSPHERE WAS THICKER THAN CHOCOLATE
 CUSTARD, AND HARRY DID NOT DARE LOOK AT THE BLUNDERBELLS AS HE SAID,

"PROFESSOR I'M READY NOW," HEARD, SAID BLUNDERBELL. "JUST ONE
 LAST THING, THEN. AND HE TURNED TO SPEAK TO THE BLUNDERBELLS ONCE
 MORE. AS YOU WILL NOT DOUBT BE AWARE, HARRY CRIES UP AGE IN A
 YEAR'S TIME. "YES," SAID ALICE PETLINIA, SPEAKING FOR THE FIRST
 TIME SINCE BLUNDERBELL'S ARRIVAL. "I'M SURE?" SAID BLUNDERBELL
 POLITELY. "YES, HE DOESN'T. HE'S A MONTH YOUNGER THAN DUDLEY, AND
 DUDLEY DOESN'T TURN EIGHTEEN UNTIL THE YEAR AFTER NEXT. "A-,"
 SAID BLUNDERBELL PLEASANTLY, BUT IN THE WIZARDING WORLD, WE CRY
 UP AGE AT SEVENTEEN. "UNCLE VERNON MUTTERED, PREPARETHIS,
 BUT BLUNDERBELL IGNORED HIM. "WELL, AS YOU ALREADY KNOW, THE
 WIZARD CALLED LORD VOLDEMORT HAS RETURNED TO THIS COUNTRY. THE
 WIZARDING COMMUNITY IS CURRENTLY IN A STATE OF OPEN WARFARE.
 HARRY, WHEN LORD VOLDEMORT HAS ALREADY ATTEMPTED TO KILL HIM A
 NUMBER OF TIMES, IS IN EVEN GREATER DANGER NOW THAN THE DAY
 WHEN I LEFT HIM UPON YOUR DOORSTEP FIFTEEN YEARS AGO, WITH A
 LETTER EXPLAINING ABOUT HIS PARENTS' MURDER AND EXPRESSING THE
 HOPE THAT YOU WOULD CARE FOR HIM AS THOUGH HE WERE YOUR OWN.
 BLUNDERBELL PAUSED, AND ALTHOUGH HIS VOICE REMAINED LIGHT AND

CALM, AND HE GAVE NO EVIDENT SIGN OF ANGER. HARRY FELT A KIND OF
 CHILL EMANATING FROM HIM AND NOTICED THAT THE DURSLEYS DREW VERY
 SLIGHTLY CLOSER TOGETHER. YET HE DID NOT DO AS I ASKED. YET I HAVE
 NEVER TREATED HARRY AS A SON. HE HAS KNOWN NOTHING BUT NEGLECT
 AND OPEN CRUELTY AT MY HANDS. THE BEST THAT CAN BE SAID IS THAT
 HE HAS AT LEAST ESCAPED THE APPALLING DAMAGE YET I HAVE INFLICTED
 UPON THE UNFORTUNATE KID SITTING BETWEEN ME. BOTH ALINT
 PETLINIA AND UNCLE VERNON BEHEADED ARHARD INSTINCTIVELY, AS
 THOUGH EXPECTING THE SEE SOMETHING WITHER THAN DUDLEY SHEWEEZED
 BETWEEN THEM. WAS MISTREAT DUDLEYS? WHAT D YET ? BEGAN
 UNCLE VERNON FLURRIEDLY, BUT DUMBLEDORE RAISED HIS FINGER FOR
 SILENCE, A SILENCE WHICH FELL AS THOUGH HE HAD STRUCK UNCLE
 VERNON DUMB. THE MAGIC I WEEDED FIFTEEN YEARS AGO MEANS THAT
 HARRY HAS POWERFUL PROTECTION WHILE HE CAN STILL CALL THIS HOUSE
 HOME. HOWEVER MISERABLE HE HAS BEEN HERE, HOWEVER UNWELCAME,
 HOWEVER BADLY TREATED, YET I HAVE AT LEAST, GRUDGINGLY, ALLOWED HIM
 HOME. THIS MAGIC WILL CEASE THE MOMENT THE MOMENT THAT
 HARRY TURNS SEVENTEEN; IN OTHER WORDS, AT THE MOMENT HE BECOMES
 A MAN. I ASK ONLY THIS: THAT YET ALLOW HARRY THE RETURN, HENCE
 MORE, THE THIS HOUSE, BEFORE HIS SEVENTEENTH BIRTHDAY, WHICH WILL
 ENSURE THAT THE PROTECTION CONTINUES UNTIL THAT TIME. NONE OF
 THE DURSLEYS SAID ANYTHING. DUDLEY WAS FROWNING SLIGHTLY, AS
 THOUGH HE WAS STILL TRYING THE WORDS HE HAD EVER BEEN
 MISTREATED. UNCLE VERNON BEHEADED AS THOUGH HE HAD SOMETHING
 STUCK IN HIS THROAT; ALINT PETLINIA, HOWEVER, WAS EDDY FLURRIED.
 WELL, HARRY TIME FOR US TO GO, SAID DUMBLEDORE AT LAST,
 STANDING UP AND STRAIGHTENING HIS LONG BLACK CLOAK. UNTIL WE
 MEET AGAIN, HE SAID THE THE DURSLEYS, WHO BEHEADED AS THOUGH THAT
 MOMENT CHILD WAIT FOREVER AS FAR AS THEY WERE CONCERNED, AND AFTER
 DIPPING HIS HAT, HE WENT FROM THE ROOM. BYE, SAID HARRY HASTILY
 THE THE DURSLEYS, AND FOLLOWED DUMBLEDORE, WHO PALSED BESIDE
 HARRY'S TRUNK, UPON WHICH FREDWIG'S CASE WAS PERCHED. WE DO
 NOT WANT TO BE ENCLIMBERED BY THESE ILST YET, HE SAID, PULLING HEAT
 HIS WAND AGAIN. I SHALL SEND THEM THE THE BLURRY THE AWAIT US
 THERE. HOWEVER, I WOULD LIKE YET TO BRING MY INVISIBILITY CLOAK
 ILST IN CASE. HARRY EXTRACTED HIS CLOAK FROM HIS TRUNK WITH
 SOME DIFFICULTY, TRYING NOT TO SHOW DUMBLEDORE THE MESS WITHIN.
 WHEN HE HAD STUFFED IT INTO AN INSIDE POCKET OF HIS JACKET,

OLMKEDEHRE WAVED HIS WAND AND THE TRILINX, CAGE, AND HERBIE VANISHED. OLMKEDEHRE THEN WAVED HIS WAND AGAIN, AND THE FRONT DOOR OPENED INTO THE CHEL, MISTY DARKNESS. AND NOW, HARRY, LET HIS STEP HIT INTO THE NIGHT AND PURSUE THAT FLIGHTY TEMPTRESS, ADVENTURE. HERACE SLUGGISHLY DESPITE THE FACT THAT HE HAD SPENT EVERY WAKING MOMENT OF THE PAST FEW DAYS HOPING DESPERATELY THAT OLMKEDEHRE WOULD INDEED COME TO GET HIM, HARRY FELT DISTINCTLY ABOARD AS THEY SET OFF DOWN PRIVET DRIVE TOGETHER. HE HAD NEVER HAD A PROPER CONVERSATION WITH THE HEADMASTER HILTSIDE OF HOGWARTS BEFORE; THERE WAS USUALLY A DICK BETWEEN THEM. THE MEMORY OF THEIR LAST FACE-TO-FACE ENCOUNTER KEPT INTRUDING THEM, AND IT RATHER FRIGHTENED HARRY'S SENSE OF EMBARRASSMENT; HE HAD SHELLED A LIT ON THAT OCCASION, NOT TO MENTION DONE HIS BEST TO SMASH SEVERAL OF OLMKEDEHRE'S MOST PRIZED POSSESSIONS. OLMKEDEHRE, HOWEVER, SEEMED COMPLETELY RELAXED. KEEP YOUR WAND AT THE READY, HARRY. HE SAID BRIGHTLY. BUT I THOUGHT I'M NOT ALLOWED THE LICE MAGIC HILTSIDE SAYS, SIR? IF THERE IS AN ATTACK, SAID OLMKEDEHRE,

I GIVE YOU PERMISSION THE LICE AND CONSIDERING HER CLUSE THAT MIGHT BECOME THE YOU. HOWEVER, I DO NOT THINK YOU NEED WORRY ABOUT BEING ATTACKED TONIGHT. WHY NOT, SIR? YOU ARE WITH ME, SAID OLMKEDEHRE SIMPLY. THIS WILL DO, HARRY. HE CAME TO AN ABRUPT HALT AT THE END OF PRIVET DRIVE. YOU HAVE NOT, OF COURSE, PASSED YOUR APPARITION TEST, HE SAID. NO, SAID HARRY. I THOUGHT YOU HAD THE RE SEVENTEEN? YOU DO, SAID OLMKEDEHRE. SEE YOU WILL NEED TO HOLD ON TO MY ARM VERY TIGHTLY. MY LEFT, IF YOU DON'T MIND AS YOU HAVE NOTICED, MY WAND ARM IS A LITTLE FRAGILE AT THE MOMENT. HARRY GRIPPED OLMKEDEHRE'S PROFFERED FOREARM.

VERY GOOD, SAID OLMKEDEHRE. WELL, HERE WE GO. HARRY FELT OLMKEDEHRE'S ARM TWIST AWAY FROM HIM AND REDUBLED HIS GRIP; THE NEXT THING HE KNEW, EVERYTHING WENT BLACK; HE WAS BEING PRESSED VERY HARD FROM ALL DIRECTIONS; HE COULD NOT BREATHE, THERE WERE THREE HANDS TIGHTENING AROUND HIS CHEST; HIS EYEBALLS WERE BEING PRESSED BACK INTO HIS HEAD; HIS EARDRUMS WERE BEING PUSHED DEEPER INTO HIS SKULL AND THEN HE CLUTCHED GREAT LONGFULS OF COLD NIGHT AIR AND OPENED HIS STREAMING EYES. HE FELT AS THOUGH HE HAD JUST BEEN PRESSED THROUGH A VERY TIGHT RUBBER TUBE. IT WAS A FEW SECONDS BEFORE HE REALIZED THAT PRIVET DRIVE HAD VANISHED. HE AND OLMKEDEHRE WERE NOW STANDING IN WHAT APPEARED TO BE A DESERTED

VILLAGE SQUARE, IN THE CENTER OF WHICH STOOD AN OLD WAR MEMORIAL AND A FEW BENCHES, HIS COMPREHENSION CATCHING UP WITH HIS SENSES, HARRY REALIZED THAT HE HAD JUST APPARATED FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HIS LIFE. ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? ASKED DUMKEDDRE, LEANING DOWN AT HIM SILENTLY. THE SENSATION BEARS SOME GETTING USED TO.

I'M FINE, SAID HARRY, RUBBING HIS EARS, WHICH FELT AS THOUGH THEY HAD LEFT PRIVET DRIVE RATHER RELUCTANTLY. BUT I THINK I MIGHT PREFER KROHNS. DUMKEDDRE SMILED, DREW HIS TRAVELING COAT A

LITTLE MORE TIGHTLY AROUND HIS NECK, AND SAID, THIS WAY. HE SET OFF AT A BRISK PACE, PAST AN EMPTY INN AND A FEW HOUSES. ACCORDING TO A CLOCK ON A NEARBY CHURCH, IT WAS ALMOST MIDNIGHT. SHE TELL ME, HARRY, SAID DUMKEDDRE. YOUR STAR HAS IT BEEN FLUTTERING AT

ALL? HARRY RAISED A HAND UNCONSCIOUSLY TO HIS FOREHEAD AND RUBBED THE LIGHTNING-STRIKE MARK. NO, HE SAID, AND I'VE BEEN WONDERING ABOUT THAT. I THOUGHT IT WOULD BE BURNING ALL THE TIME

WHEN VERMONT'S GETTING SO PHEWFUL AGAIN. HE GLANCED UP AT DUMKEDDRE AND SAW THAT HE WAS WEARING A SATISFIED EXPRESSION. I, ON THE OTHER HAND, THOUGHT OTHERWISE, SAID DUMKEDDRE. LORD

VERMONT HAS FINALLY REALIZED THE DANGEROUS ACCESS TO HIS THOUGHTS AND FEELINGS YOU HAVE BEEN ENJOYING. IT APPEARS THAT HE IS NOW EMPLOYING HILLMANN AGAINST YOU. WELL, I'M NOT

COMPLAINING, SAID HARRY, WHO MISSED NEITHER THE DISTURBING DREAMS NOR THE STARTLING FLASHES OF INSIGHT INTO VERMONT'S MIND. THEY TURNED A CORNER, PASSING A TELEPHONE BOX AND A BUS SHELTER. HARRY LOOKED SIDELONGS AT DUMKEDDRE AGAIN. PROFESSOR?

HARRY? OR WHERE EXACTLY ARE WE? THIS, HARRY, IS THE CHARMING VILLAGE OF RUDOLPH KARKERTON. AND WHAT ARE WE DOING HERE? Ah yes, OF COURSE, I HAVEN'T TOLD YOU, SAID DUMKEDDRE.

WELL, I HAVE LOST COUNT OF THE NUMBER OF TIMES I HAVE SAID THIS IN RECENT YEARS, BUT WE ARE, ONCE AGAIN, ONE MEMBER OF STAFF SHORT. WE ARE HERE TO PERSUADE AN OLD COLLEAGUE OF MINE TO COME OUT OF

RETIREMENT AND RETURN TO THE HOGWARTS. HOW CAN I HELP WITH THAT, SIR? Oh, I THINK WE'LL FIND A USE FOR YOU, SAID DUMKEDDRE

VALENTLY. LEFT HERE, HARRY. THEY PROCEEDED UP A STEEP, NARROW STREET LINED WITH HOUSES. ALL THE WINDOWS WERE DARK. THE OLD CHILL THAT HAD LAIN OVER PRIVET DRIVE FOR TWO WEEKS PERSISTED HERE TOO.

THINKING OF DEMENTORS, HARRY CAST A LOOK OVER HIS SHOULDER AND GRASPED HIS WAND REASSURINGLY IN HIS POCKET. PROFESSOR, WHY

CHILDREN T HE ILST APPARATE DIRECTLY INTO THE HALL AND CHIEFAGLE S
 FELLER? BECAUSE IT WOULD BE ELITE AS RIDE AS DRIVING DOWN THE
 FRONT DOOR, SAID DUMBLEDORE. COURTESY DICTATES THAT WE OFFER
 FELLOW WIZARDS THE HOPPELTLINITY OF DENYING HIS ENTRY, IN ANY CASE,
 MOST WIZARDING DWELLINGS ARE MAGICALLY PROTECTED FROM UNWANTED
 APPARATERS, AT HOGWARTS, FOR INSTANCE. YELL CAN T
 APPARATE ANYWHERE INSIDE THE BUILDINGS OR GARDENS, SAID HARRY
 QUIETLY. HERRMINE CRANGER TOLD ME. AND SHE IS ELITE RIGHT. WE
 TURN LEFT AGAIN. THE CHURCH CLOCK CHIMED MIDNIGHT BEHIND THEM.
 HARRY WONDERED WHY DUMBLEDORE DID NOT CONSIDER IT WISE TO CALL HIM
 HIS OLD CHIEFAGLE SHE LATE, BUT WHEN THAT CONVERSATION HAD BEEN
 ESTABLISHED, HE HAD MORE PRESSING ELIESTHENS TO ASK. SIR, I SAW IN
 THE DAILY PROPHET THAT FLUGE HAS BEEN SACKED. CORRECT, SAID
 DUMBLEDORE, NOW TURNING UP A STEEP SIDE STREET. HE HAS BEEN
 REPLACED, AS I AM SURE YELL ALSO SAW, BY ROLPH SCRIMPHELM, WHO
 LIVED THE RE HEAD OF THE ALIENR OFFICE. IS HE ONE YELL THINK HE S
 GOOD? ASKED HARRY. AN INTERESTING ELIESTHEN, SAID DUMBLEDORE.
 HE IS ABLE, CERTAINLY, A MORE DECISIVE AND FORCEFUL PERSONALITY
 THAN CHERNELIS. YES, BUT I MEANT I KNOW WHAT YELL MEANT.
 ROLPH IS A MAN OF ACTION AND, HAVING FELIGHT DARK WIZARDS FOR
 MOST OF HIS WORKING LIFE, DOES NOT UNDERESTIMATE LORD VEEDMENT.
 HARRY WAITED, BUT DUMBLEDORE DID NOT SAY ANYTHING ABOUT THE
 DISAGREEMENT WITH SCRIMPHELM THAT THE DAILY PROPHET HAD
 REPORTED, AND HE DID NOT HAVE THE NERVE TO PURSUE THE SUBJECT, SO
 HE CHANGED IT. AND SIR I SAW ABOUT MADAM BONES. YES,
 SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY. A TERRIBLE LOSS. SHE WAS A GREAT WITCH.
 LIST UP HERE, I THINK. HE HAD POINTED WITH HIS INJURED
 HAND. PROFESSOR, WHAT HAPPENED TO THE HALL ? I HAVE NO TIME
 TO EXPLAIN NOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IT IS A THRILLING TALE, I WISH TO
 SEE IT LISTED. HE SMILED AT HARRY, WHO UNDERSTOOD THAT HE WAS NOT
 BEING SULKED, AND THAT HE HAD PERMISSION TO KEEP ASKING
 ELIESTHENS. SIR I GOT A MINISTRY OF MAGIC LEAFLET BY MAIL, ABOUT
 SECURITY MEASURES WE SHOULD ALL TAKE AGAINST THE DEATH EATERS.
 YES, I RECEIVED ONE MYSELF, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STILL SMILING. DID YELL
 FIND IT USEFUL? NOT REALLY. NO, I THOUGHT NOT. YELL HAVE NOT
 ASKED ME, FOR INSTANCE, WHAT IS MY FAVORITE PLAYER OF IAM, THE CHICK
 THAT I AM INDEED PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE AND NOT AN IMPOSTER. I
 DIDN T HARRY BEGAN, NOT ENTIRELY SURE WHETHER HE WAS BEING

REPRIMANDED HER NEXT. HER FLITTING REFERENCE, HARRY, IT IS RASPBERRY

ALTHOUGH HE CHIRPED, IF I WERE A DEATH EATER, I WOULD HAVE BEEN
SURE THE RESEARCH MY OWN I AM PREFERENCES BEHIND IMPERSONATING
MYSELF. ER RIGHT, SAID HARRY. WELL, IN THAT LEAFLET, IT SAID
SOMETHING ABOUT INFERI. WHAT EXACTLY ARE THEY? THE LEAFLET
WASN'T VERY CLEAR. THEY ARE CHIMPS, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY.

DEAD BODIES THAT HAVE BEEN REWITCHED THE BY A DARK WIZARD'S KIDDING.
INFERI HAVE NOT BEEN SEEN FOR A LONG TIME, HOWEVER, NOT SINCE
Voldemort WAS LAST MENTIONED. HE KILLED ENOUGH PEOPLE TO MAKE
AN ARMY OF THEM, HE CHIRPED. THIS IS THE PLACE, HARRY, LIST HERE.

THEY WERE NEARING A SMALL, NEAT STONE HOUSE SET IN ITS OWN
GARDEN. HARRY WAS THEN BUSY DIGESTING THE HORRIBLE IDEA OF INFERI
THEY HAVE MUCH ATTENTION LEFT FOR ANYTHING ELSE, BUT AS THEY REACHED
THE FRONT GATE, DUMBLEDORE STOPPED DEAD AND HARRY WALKED INTO
HIM. OH DEAR, OH DEAR, DEAR, DEAR. HARRY FOLLOWED HIS GAZE UP THE
CAREFULLY TENDED FRONT PATH AND FELT HIS HEART SINK. THE FRONT
DOOR WAS HANGING OFF ITS HINGES, DUMBLEDORE GLANCED UP AND DOWN
THE STREET. IT SEEMED BLITZ DESERTED. WAND OUT AND FOLLOW ME,
HARRY. HE SAID QUIETLY. HE OPENED THE GATE AND WALKED SWIFTLY AND
SILENTLY UP THE GARDEN PATH. HARRY AT HIS HEELS, THEN PULSED THE
FRONT DOOR VERY SLOWLY, HIS WAND RAISED AND AT THE READY. FLAMES,
DUMBLEDORE'S WAND TIP IGNITED, CASTING ITS LIGHT UP A NARROW
HALLWAY. THE LEFT, ANOTHER DOOR STOOD OPEN, HOLDING HIS
ILLUMINATED WAND ALIGHT, DUMBLEDORE WALKED INTO THE SITTING ROOM
WITH HARRY RIGHT BEHIND HIM. A SCENE OF TOTAL DESTRUCTION MET
THEIR EYES. A GRANDFATHER CLOCK LAY SPLINTERED AT THEIR FEET, ITS
FACE CRACKED, ITS PENDULUM LYING A LITTLE FARTHER AWAY LIKE A
DROPPED SWORD. A PIANO WAS ON ITS SIDE, ITS KEYS STREWN ACROSS THE
FLOOR. THE WRECKAGE OF A FALLEN CHANDELIER GLITTERED NEARBY.
CUSHIONS LAY DEFLATED, FEATHERS SPRING FROM SLASHES IN THEIR SIDES;
FRAGMENTS OF GLASS AND CHINA LAY LIKE POWDER OVER EVERYTHING.
DUMBLEDORE RAISED HIS WAND EVEN HIGHER, SEE THAT ITS LIGHT WAS
THROWING UPON THE WALLS, WHERE SOMETHING DARKLY RED AND
GLUTINIOUS WAS SPATTERED OVER THE WALLPAPER. HARRY'S SMALL
INTAKE OF BREATH MADE DUMBLEDORE LEEDS AHEAD. NOT PRETTY, IS
IT? HE SAID HEAVILY. YES, SOMETHING HORRIBLE HAS HAPPENED HERE.
DUMBLEDORE MOVED CAREFULLY INTO THE MIDDLE OF THE ROOM,
STUTINIZING THE WRECKAGE AT HIS FEET. HARRY FOLLOWED, GAZING

AROUND, HALF-SCARED OF WHAT HE MIGHT SEE HIDDEN BEHIND THE WRECK
OF THE PLANE AND THE EVERSTURNED SHIP, BUT THERE WAS NO SIGN OF A
BODY. MAYBE THERE WAS A FIGHT AND AND THEY DRAGGED HIM OFF,
PRESSURE? HARRY SUGGESTED, TRYING NOT TO IMAGINE HOW BADLY
WOUNDED A MAN WOULD HAVE TO BE TO LEAVE THESE STAINS SPATTERED
HALFWAY UP THE WALLS. I DON'T THINK SO, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY,
PEERING BEHIND AN EVERSTUPPED ARMCHAIR LYING ON ITS SIDE. YOU
MEAN HE'S ? STILL HERE SOMEWHERE? YES, AND WITHOUT
WARNING, DUMBLEDORE SWEEPED, PULLING THE TIP OF HIS WAND INTO
THE SEAT OF THE EVERSTUPPED ARMCHAIR, WHICH YELLED. HUSH! GOOD
EVENING, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STRAIGHTENING UP AGAIN.
HARRY'S EYES DROPPED. WHERE A SPOT SEEMED BEFORE THERE HAD BEEN
AN ARMCHAIR, THERE NOW CRIBLED AN ENORMOUSLY FAT, OLD MAN
WHO WAS MASSAGING HIS LOWER BELLY AND SMILING UP AT
DUMBLEDORE WITH AN AGGRIEVED AND WATERY EYE. THERE WAS NO NEED
TO STICK THE WAND IN THAT HARD, HE SAID GRUMPY, CLAMPING HIS
FEET. IT HURT. THE WANDLIGHT SPARKLED ON HIS SHINY PATE, HIS
PROMINENT EYES, HIS ENORMOUS, SILVER, WAXY-LIKE MUSTACHE, AND
THE HIGHLY POLISHED BUTTONS ON THE MARSHY VELVET JACKET HE WAS
WEARING OVER A PAIR OF LILAC SILK PANTALONS. THE TOP OF HIS HEAD
BARELY REACHED DUMBLEDORE'S CHIN. WHAT GAVE IT AWAY? HE GRUNTED
AS HE STAGGERED ON HIS FEET, STILL RUBBING HIS LOWER BELLY. HE SEEMED
REMARKABLY UNABASHED FOR A MAN WHO HAD JUST BEEN DISCOVERED
PRETENDING TO BE AN ARMCHAIR. MY DEAR HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
LOOKING APLUST, IF THE DEATH EATERS REALLY HAD HEARD THE CALL, THE
DARK MARK WOULD HAVE BEEN SET OVER THE HOUSE. THE WIZARD
CLAPPED A PLUMPY HAND TO HIS VAST FOREHEAD. THE DARK MARK, HE
MUTTERED. KNOW THERE WAS SOMETHING AS WELL. WOULD YOU LIKE MY
HELP ANYWAY, I'D ONLY JUST PUT THE FINISHING TOUCHES TO MY
LIFE-MYSTERY WHEN YOU ENTERED THE ROOM. HE HEAVED A GREAT SIGH
THAT MADE THE ENDS OF HIS MUSTACHE FLUTTER. WOULD YOU LIKE MY
ASSISTANCE CLEARING UP? ASKED DUMBLEDORE POLITELY. PLEASE, SAID
THE OTHER. THEY STOOD BACK TO BACK, THE TALL THIN WIZARD AND THE
SHORT BEING ONE, AND WAIVED THEIR WANDS IN ONE IDENTICAL SWEEPING
MOTION. THE FURNITURE FLEW BACK TO ITS ORIGINAL PLACES;
ORNAMENTS REFORMED IN MIDAIR, FEATHERS ZIPPED INTO THEIR
CLUSTERS; TEAR BEADS REPAIRED THEMSELVES AS THEY LANDED UPON
THEIR SHELVES; OIL LANTERNS SHEDDENTH SIDE TABLES AND REIGNITED; A

FAST COLLECTION OF SPLINTERED SILVER PICTURE FRAMES FLEW GLITTERING ACROSS THE ROOM AND ALIGHTED, LIKE AND LINTARNISHED, UPON A DESK, RIPS, CRACKS, AND FIBRES HEALED EVERYWHERE, AND THE WALLS WIPED THEMSELVES CLEAN. WHAT KIND OF BLEED WAS THAT, INCIDENTALLY? ASKED DUMBLEDORE HEEDLESSLY OVER THE CHIMING OF THE NEWLY LINTARNISHED GRANDFATHER CLOCK. HEN THE WALLS? DRAGON, SHELTERED THE WIZARD CALLED FERRACE, AS, WITH A DEAPENING GRINDING AND TINKLING, THE CHANDELIER SCREWED ITSELF BACK INTO THE CEILING. THERE WAS A FINAL PULLING FROM THE PLANE, AND SILENCE. YES, DRAGON, REPEATED THE WIZARD CONVERSATIONALLY. MY LAST KETTLE, AND PRICES ARE SOY-HIGH AT THE MOMENT. STILL, IT MIGHT BE RELIABLE. HE STUMPED OVER THE A SMALL CRYSTAL KETTLE STANDING IN THE OF A SIDEBARD AND HELD IT UP THE THE LIGHT, EXAMINING THE THICK LIQUID WITHIN. HMM, BIT BLISTY, HE SET THE KETTLE BACK IN THE SIDEBARD AND SIGHED. IT WAS THEN THAT HIS GAZE FELL UPON HARRY. HE-HE, HE SAID, HIS LARGE ROUNDED EYES FLYING THE HARRY'S THREE-HEAD AND THE LIGHTNING-SHAPED STAR IT BORE. HE-HE! THIS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, MOVING FORWARD THE MADE THE INTRODUCTION, IS HARRY POTTER. HARRY, THIS IS AN OLD FRIEND AND COLLEAGUE OF MINE, FERRACE SLUGGEBORN. SLUGGEBORN TURNED IN DUMBLEDORE, HIS EXPRESSION STREWED. SEE THAT I FEEL YELL THELIGHT YELL D PERSUADE ME, IS IT? WELL, THE ANSWER I SEE, ALKIS. HE POLISHED PAST HARRY, HIS FACE TURNED RESOLUTELY AWAY WITH THE AIR OF A MAN TRYING THE RESIST TEMPTATION. I SUPPOSE WE CAN HAVE A DRINK, AT LEAST? ASKED DUMBLEDORE. FOR OLD TIME'S SAKE? SLUGGEBORN HESITATED. ALL RIGHT THEN, ONE DRINK, HE SAID LINGERACIOUSLY. DUMBLEDORE SMILED AT HARRY AND DIRECTED HIM TOWARD A CHAIR NEET UNLIKE THE ONE THAT SLUGGEBORN HAD SEE RECENTLY IMPERSONATED, WHICH STOOD RIGHT BESIDE THE NEWLY BURNING FIRE AND A BRIGHTLY GLEEWING HIL LAMP. HARRY TOOK THE SEAT WITH THE DISTINCT IMPRESSION THAT DUMBLEDORE, FOR SOME REASON, WANTED THE KEEP HIM AS VISIBLE AS POSSIBLE. CERTAINLY WHEN SLUGGEBORN, WHEN HAD BEEN KISSY WITH DECANTERS AND GLASSES, TURNED THE FACE THE ROOM AGAIN, HIS EYES FELL IMMEDIATELY UPON HARRY. HMM, HE SAID, LEERNG AWAY HEEDLESSLY AS THOUGH FRIGHTENED BY FLURTING HIS EYES. HERE HE GAVE A DRINK THE DUMBLEDORE, WHEN HAD SAT DOWN WITHHEUT INVITATION, THELIST THE TRAY AT HARRY, AND THEN SAND INTO THE CLISHENS OF THE REPAIRED SHIP AND A DISORLINTLED SILENCE. HIS LEGS WERE SEE SHEET THEY DID NEET THEICH THE FLEWER. WELL, FEEL HAVE YELL BEEN KEEPING,

FERRACE? DUMKLEDHIRE ASKED, NOT SHE WELL, SAID SLUGGISHORN AT ONCE.
 LEAD CHEST, WHEEZY, DEFLINATIONISM THEM, CAN T MEVE LIKE I USED THE
 WELL, THAT S THE RE EXPECTED, FELD AGE, FATIGUE, AND YET YELL MUST
 HAVE MEVED FAIRLY QUICKLY THE PREPARE SUCH A WELCOME FOR US AT
 SUCH SHORT NOTICE, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, YELL CAN T HAVE HAD MORE
 THAN THREE MINUTES WARNING? SLUGGISHORN SAID, HALF IRRITABLY, HALF
 PROUDLY, THEN, DIDN T HEAR MY INTERLUDE CHARM CH HFF, I WAS TAKING
 A BATH, STILL, HE ADDED STERNLY, SEEMING THE PULL HIMSELF BACK
 TOGETHER AGAIN, THE FACT REMAINS THAT I M AN OLD MAN, ALEKS, A
 TIRED OLD MAN WHO S EARNED THE RIGHT THE A QUIET LIFE AND A FEW
 CREATURE COMFORTS, HE CERTAINLY HAD THESE, THELIGHT FARRY,
 WHISKING AROUND THE ROOM, IT WAS STUFFY AND CLITTERED, YET NEKKED
 WOULD SAY IT WAS UNCOMFORTABLE; THERE WERE SOFT CHAIRS AND
 FEETSTOOLS, DRINKS AND KIDDS, KIDDS OF CIGARETTES AND PLUMP
 CUSHIONS, IF FARRY HAD NOT KNOWN WHO LIVED THERE, HE WOULD HAVE
 GUESSED AT A RICH, FLISSY OLD LADY, YELL RE NOT YET AS OLD AS I AM,
 FERRACE, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, WELL, MAYBE YELL WOULD THE THINK ABOUT
 RETIREMENT YOURSELF, SAID SLUGGISHORN BLUNTLY, HIS PALE CHEESEBERRY
 EYES HAD FOUND DUMKLEDHIRE S INJURED HAND, REACTIONS NOT WHAT
 THEY WERE, I SEE, YELL RE WHITE RIGHT, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE SERENELY,
 SHAKING BACK HIS SLEEVE THE REVEAL THE TIPS OF THESE BURNED AND
 BLACKENED FINGERS; THE SIGHT OF THEM MADE THE BACK OF FARRY S NECK
 PRICKLE UNPLEASANTLY, I AM UNUSUALLY SLOWER THAN I WAS, BUT
 IN THE OTHER HAND HE SPREAD HIS HANDS WIDE, AS
 THOUGH THE SAY THAT AGE HAD ITS COMPENSATIONS, AND FARRY NOTICED
 A RING ON HIS UNINJURED HAND THAT HE HAD NEVER SEEN DUMKLEDHIRE
 WEAR BEFORE; IT WAS LARGE, RATHER CLUMSILY MADE OF WHAT LOOKED LIKE
 GOLD, AND WAS SET WITH A HEAVY BLACK STONE THAT HAD CRACKED DOWN
 THE MIDDLE, SLUGGISHORN S EYES LINGERED FOR A MOMENT ON THE RING THEN,
 AND FARRY SAW A TINY FROWN MOMENTARILY CREESE HIS WIDE FOREHEAD,
 SEE, ALL THESE PRECAUTIONS AGAINST INTRUDERS, FERRACE ARE THEY
 FOR THE DEATH EATERS BENEFIT, FOR MINE? ASKED DUMKLEDHIRE, WHAT
 WOULD THE DEATH EATERS WANT WITH A POOR BROKEN-DOWN OLD CLIFFER
 LIKE ME? DEMANDED SLUGGISHORN, I IMAGINE THAT THEY WOULD WANT
 YELL THE TURN YOUR CONSIDERABLE TALENTS THE CHEERFUL, THIRTY, AND
 MURDER, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, ARE YELL REALLY TELLING ME THAT THEY
 HAVEN T BEEN RECRUITING YET? SLUGGISHORN EYED DUMKLEDHIRE CAUTELLY
 FOR A MOMENT, THEN MUTTERED, I HAVEN T GIVEN THEM THE CHANCE,

I'VE BEEN IN THE MOVIE FOR A YEAR. NEVER STAY IN ONE PLACE MORE THAN A WEEK. MOVIE FROM MUGGLE FEELS THE MUGGLE FEELS THE OWNERS OF THIS PLACE ARE IN HOLIDAY IN THE CANARY ISLANDS IT'S BEEN VERY PLEASANT, I'LL BE SHIRRY THE LEAVE. IT'S WHITE EASY HENCE YELL DROWN FEEL, ONE SIMPLE FREEZING CLAM IN THESE ARSLAD KLINGLAR ALARMS THEY USE INSTEAD OF SNARKSHEPES AND MAKE SURE THE NEIGHBORS DON'T SPOT YELL BRINGING IN THE PLANE. INGENUITY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. BUT IT SEEMS A RATHER TIRING EXISTENCE FOR A KIDNAP-DEAD END KIDDER IN SEARCH OF A QUIET LIFE. WELL, IF YELL WERE THE RETURN THE FIGHTERS IF YELL'RE GOING TO TELL ME MY LIFE WOULD BE MORE PEACEFUL AT THAT PRESTIGIOUS SCHOOL, YELL CAN SAVE YOUR BREATH. ALAS! I MIGHT HAVE BEEN IN HIDING, BUT SOME FLANNY RUMORS HAVE REACHED ME SINCE DUMMOES LIMERIDGE LEFT? IF THAT'S THE YELL TREAT TEACHERS THESE DAYS PROFESSOR LIMERIDGE RAN AWAY OF HIS CENTALIR HERO, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I THINK YELL, FARRACE, WOULD HAVE DONE BETTER THAN THE STRIDE INTO THE ARREST AND CALL A FLOOD OF ANGRY CENTALIRS FIFTY HALF-BREDS. THAT'S WHAT SHE DID, DID SHE? SAID SLUGGISHORN. IDIOTIC WOMAN, NEVER LIKED HER. FARRY CHUCKLED AND KNEW DUMBLEDORE AND SLUGGISHORN LOOKED BEHIND AT HIM. SHIRRY, FARRY SAID HASTILY. IT'S LIST I DIDN'T LIKE HER EITHER. DUMBLEDORE STOOD UP RATHER SUDDENLY. ARE YELL LEAVING? ASKED SLUGGISHORN AT ONCE, LOOKING HOPPEL. NO, I WAS WONDERING WHETHER I MIGHT USE YOUR KATHREEM, SAID DUMBLEDORE. HE, SAID SLUGGISHORN, CLEARLY DISAPPOINTED. SECOND IN THE LEFT BEHIND THE HALL. DUMBLEDORE STOOD FROM THE ROOM, SINCE THE DOOR HAD CLOSED BEHIND HIM, THERE WAS SILENCE. AFTER A FEW MOMENTS, SLUGGISHORN GOT TO HIS FEET BUT SEEMED UNCERTAIN WHAT TO DO WITH HIMSELF. HE SEEMED A FLIRTIVE LOOK AT FARRY, THEN CROSSED TO THE FIRE AND TURNED HIS BACK ON IT, WARMING HIS WIDE BEHIND. DON'T THINK I DON'T KNOW WHY HE'S BRILLIANT YELL, HE SAID ABRUPTLY. FARRY MERELY LOOKED AT SLUGGISHORN. SLUGGISHORN'S WATERY EYES SLID OVER FARRY'S SCAR, THIS TIME TAKING IN THE REST OF HIS FACE. YELL LOOKS VERY LIKE YOUR FATHER. YEAH, I'VE BEEN TOLD, SAID FARRY. EXCEPT FOR YOUR EYES. YELL'VE GOT MY MOTHER'S EYES, YEAH. FARRY HAD HEARD IT SEVENTEN HE FEELING IT A BIT WEARING. FARRY, YES, WELL, YELL SEEMEDN'T HAVE FAVORITES AS A TEACHER, HE CHIRSED, BUT SHE WAS ONE OF MINE. YOUR MOTHER, SLUGGISHORN ADDED, IN ANSWER TO FARRY'S UNEXPECTEDLY LOOK. Lily Evans. ONE OF THE BRIGHTEST I EVER

TALIGHT, VIVACIOUS, VERY NICE, CHARMING GIRL. I USED TO TELL HER SHE
MIGHT BE HAVE BEEN IN MY HOUSE. VERY CHEERFUL ANSWERS I USED TO
GET BACK THEN. WHICH WAS HER HOUSE? I WAS TOLD BY
SLOTHERIN, SAID SLOTHERIN, HE, WELL, HE WENT ON QUICKLY, SEEING
THE EXPRESSION ON HARRY'S FACE AND WAGGING A STICKY FINGER AT
HIM, DON'T BE HOLDING THAT AGAINST ME? WELL BE GRYFFINDOR LIKE
HER, I SUPPOSE? YES, IT USUALLY COMES IN FAMILIES, NOT ALWAYS,
THOUGH. EVER HEARD OF SIRILIS BLACK? WELL MUST HAVE BEEN BEEN
IN THE PAPERS AFTER THE LAST CRUEL OF YEARS DIED A FEW WEEKS AGO

IT WAS AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE HAND HAD TWISTED HARRY'S
INTESTINES AND HELD THEM TIGHT. WELL, ANYWAY, HE WAS A BIG PAL OF
HER FATHER'S AT SCHOOL. THE WHOLE BLACK FAMILY HAD BEEN IN MY
HOUSE, BUT SIRILIS ENDED UP IN GRYFFINDOR? SAME HE WAS A
TALENTED KID. I MET HIS BROTHER, REGULUS, WHEN HE CAME ALONG, BUT
I'D HAVE LIKED THE SET. HE BEHAVED LIKE AN ENTHUSIASTIC COLLECTOR
WHEN HAD BEEN HELD AT AUNTIES, APPARENTLY LOST IN MEMORIES, HE
GAZED AT THE OPPOSITE WALL, TURNING IDLY ON THE SPOT THE ENSURE AND
EVEN HEAT ON HIS BACKSIDE. HER MOTHER WAS MUGGLE-BORN, OF
COURSE, CHILDREN T BELIEVE IT WHEN I FOUND OUT. MIGHT SHE MUST
HAVE BEEN PURE-BLOOD, SHE WAS SHE GOOD. ONE OF MY BEST FRIENDS IS
MUGGLE-BORN, SAID HARRY, AND SHE'S THE BEST IN HER YEAR.

PLANNY WELL THAT SOMETIMES HAPPENS, ISN'T IT? SAID SLOTHERIN.

NOT REALLY, SAID HARRY COLDLY, SLOTHERIN LOOKED DOWN AT HIM IN
SURPRISE. WELL MUSTN'T THINK I'M PREJUDICED? HE SAID, NEH, NEH,
NEH? HAVEN'T I JUST SAID HER MOTHER WAS ONE OF MY ALL-TIME
FAVORITE STUDENTS? AND THERE WAS DIXIE CRESSWELL IN THE YEAR AFTER
HER THEN WELL TOLD OF THE GURIN LIAISON OFFICE, OF COURSE
ANOTHER MUGGLE-BORN, A VERY GIFTED STUDENT, AND STILL GIVES ME
EXCELLENT INSIDE INFORMATION ON THE GOINGS-ON AT GRINGETTS? HE
BEHAVED UP AND DOWN A LITTLE, SMILING IN A SELF-SATISFIED WAY, AND
POINTED AT THE MANY GLITTERING PHOTOGRAPH FRAMES ON THE DRESSER,
EACH FILLED WITH TINY MOVING PICTURES. ALL EX-STUDENTS, ALL
SIGNED, WELL BE NOTICE BARNABAS CLIFF, EDITOR OF THE DAILY PROPHET,
HE'S ALWAYS INTERESTED TO HEAR MY TAKE ON THE DAY'S NEWS, AND
AMBERLIS FLAME, OF HONEYBLOODS A HAMPER EVERY BIRTHDAY, AND
ALL REALISE I WAS ABLE TO GIVE HIM AN INTRODUCTION TO LUCIFER
HARDISS, WHO GAVE HIM HIS FIRST JOB? AND AT THE END WELL BE SEE
HER IF WELL JUST CRANE HER NECK THAT'S CLARENCE JONES, WHO OF

CHLWSE CAPTAINS THE F-HLY-HEAD F-HARPIES. PEOPLE ARE ALWAYS
ASTHENSIFIED THE HEAR I M HEN FIRST-NAME TERMS WITH THE F-HARPIES, AND
FREE TICKETS WHENEVER I WANT THEM? THIS THHLIGHT SEEMED THE CHRR
HIM LIP ENTHRMHLISLY. AND ALL THESE PEOPLE DNHL WHERE THE FND
YHL, THE SEND YHL STLY? ASKED F-HARRY, W-HH CHLD NHT HLP
WHNDRING W-HY THE DEATH EATERS HAD NHT YET TRACKED DNHLN
SLIG-HRN IF HAMPERS HF SWEETS, FLIDDITCH TICKETS, AND VISITHRS
CRAVING HIS ADVICE AND HP INIHNS CHLD FND HIM. THE SMILE SLID FRHM
SLIG-HRN S FACE AS HLICKLY AS THE BLNHD FRHM HIS WALLS. HF
CHLWSE NHT, HE SAID, LHHKING DNHLN AT F-HARRY, I HAYE BEEN HLT HF
THLCH WITH EVERYBODY FHR A YEAR. F-HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSHN THAT
THE WHRDS ST-HCKED SLIG-HRN HIMSELF; HE LHHKED HLITE LNSSETLED
FHR A MHMENT, THEN HE ST-LLGED. STILL THE PRUDENT WIZARD
KEEPS HIS HEAD DNHLN IN SUCH TIMES. ALL VERY WELL FHR DUMKLEDHRE THE
TALK, BLT TAKING LIP A PHST AT F-HGLWARTS ILST NHLN WHLHD BE
TANTAMHLNT THE DECLARING MY PLBLIC ALLEGIANCE TH THE F-HRDER HF THE
P-HRRNIX? AND W-HILE I M SURE THEY RE VERY ADMIRABLE AND KRAYE AND
ALL THE REST HF IT, I DEN T PERSONALLY FANLY THE MHTALITY RATE

YHL DEN T HAYE TH IHIN THE F-HRDER THE TEACH AT F-HGLWARTS, SAID
F-HARRY, W-HH CHLD NHT HLITE KEEP A NHT HF DERISHN HLT HF HIS
VHIC: IT WAS HARD THE SYMPATHIZE WITH SLIG-HRN S CHSSETED
EXISTENCE WHEN HE REMEMBERED SIRILIS, CRHLK-HING IN A CAYE AND
LIVING HEN RATS. MHST HF THE TEACHERS AREN T IN IT, AND NHHN HF
THEM HAS EVER BEEN KILLED WELL, UNLESS YHL CHLNT FLIRRELL, AND
HE GHT W-HAT HE DESERVED SEEING AS HE WAS WHRRKING WITH
VHLDEMHT. F-HARRY HAD BEEN SLRE SLIG-HRN WHLHD BE HNE HF THESE
WIZARDS W-HH CHLD NHT REAR THE HEAR VHLDEMHT S NAME SPHDEN
AHLHD, AND WAS NHT DISAPPHNTED: SLIG-HRN GAVE A SHLDDER AND A
SHLWLD HF PRHTEST, W-HICH F-HARRY IGNHRED. I RECHN THE STAFF ARE
SAPER THAN MHST PEOPLE W-HILE DUMKLEDHRE S HEADMASTER; HE S
SLPPHSED TH BE THE HNLH HNE VHLDEMHT EVER FEARED, ISN T HE?
F-HARRY WENT HEN. SLIG-HRN GAZED INTN SPACE FHR A MHMENT HEN THH:
HE SEEMED TH BE TH-HDKING EVER F-HARRY S WHRDS. WELL, YES, IT IS TRUE
THAT F-HR-W-HH-MLST-NHT-KE-NAMED HAS NEVER SHLGHIT A FIGHT WITH
DUMKLEDHRE, HE MLTTERED GRUDGINGLY. AND I SLPPHSE HNE CHLD
ARELIE THAT AS I HAYE NHT IHINED THE DEATH EATERS, F-HR-W-HH-MLST-
NHTKE-NAMED CAN HARDLY CHLNT ME A FRIEND IN W-HICH CASE, I
MIGHT WELL BE SAPER A LITTLE CHESER TH ABLIS. I CANNHT PRETEND

THAT AMELIA RHINES'S DEATH DID NOT SHAKE ME. IF SHE, WITH ALL HER
 MINISTRY CONTACTS AND PROTECTION. OLIMPEDEHRE REENTERED THE
 ROOM AND SILVERHORN JUMPED AS THOUGH HE HAD FORGOTTEN HE WAS IN
 THE HOUSE. EH, THERE YOU ARE, ARLIS, HE SAID. YOU'VE BEEN A
 VERY LONG TIME. I'D SET STEWART? NO, I WAS MERELY READING THE
 MUGGLE MAGAZINES, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE. I DO HAVE KNITTING PATTERNS.
 WELL, HARRY, WE HAVE TRESPASSED UPON FERRACE'S HOSPITALITY ENOUGH
 LONG ENOUGH; I THINK IT IS TIME FOR US TO LEAVE. NOT AT ALL
 RELUCTANT THEY, HARRY JUMPED TO HIS FEET. SILVERHORN SEEMED
 TAKEN ABACK. YOU'RE LEAVING? YES, INDEED, I THINK I KNOW A BETTER
 PLACE WHEN I SEE ONE. BETTER? SILVERHORN SEEMED AGITATED. HE
 TWIDDLER HIS FAT THUMBS AND FIDGERTED AS HE WATCHED OLIMPEDEHRE FASTEN
 HIS TRAVELING COAT, AND HARRY ZIP UP HIS JACKET. WELL, I'M SORRY
 YOU DON'T WANT THE ONE, FERRACE, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE, RAISING HIS
 LINENED HAND IN A FAREWELL SALUTE. FERGUSON'S WOULD HAVE BEEN
 GLAD TO SEE YOU BACK AGAIN. HIS GREATLY INCREASED SECURITY
 NOTWITHSTANDING, YOU WILL ALWAYS BE WELCOME TO VISIT, SHOULD YOU
 WISH TO. YES, WELL, VERY GRACIOUS AS I SAY. GOOD-BYE,
 THEN. BYE, SAID HARRY. THEY WERE AT THE FRONT DOOR WHEN THERE
 WAS A SHOUT FROM BEHIND THEM. ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, I'LL DO IT!
 OLIMPEDEHRE TURNED TO SEE SILVERHORN STANDING BREATHLESS IN THE
 HALLWAY WITH THE SITTING ROOM. YOU WILL COME INTO RETIREMENT?
 YES, YES, SAID SILVERHORN IMPATIENTLY. I MUST BE MAD, BUT YES.
 WONDERFUL, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE, BEAMING. THEN, FERRACE, WE SHALL SEE
 YOU IN THE FIRST OF SEPTEMBER. YES, I DARE SAY YOU WILL, GRANTED
 SILVERHORN. AS THEY SET OFF DOWN THE GARDEN PATH, SILVERHORN'S
 VOICE RANGED AFTER THEM. I'LL WANT A PAY RISE, OLIMPEDEHRE!
 OLIMPEDEHRE CHUCKLED. THE GARDEN GATE SWUNG SHUT BEHIND THEM, AND
 THEY SET OFF BACK DOWN THE HILL THROUGH THE DARK AND THE SWIRLING
 MIST. WELL DONE, HARRY, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE. I DIDN'T DO ANYTHING,
 SAID HARRY IN SURPRISE. EH, YES YOU DID, YOU SHOWED FERRACE
 EXACTLY HOW MUCH HE STANDS TO GAIN BY RETURNING TO FERGUSON'S.
 DID YOU LIKE HIM? ER. HARRY WASN'T SURE WHETHER HE LIKED
 SILVERHORN OR NOT. HE SLIPPED HE HAD BEEN PLEASANT IN HIS WAY,
 BUT HE HAD ALSO SEEMED VAIN AND, WHATEVER HE SAID TO THE CONTRARY,
 MUCH TOO SURPRISED THAT A MUGGLE-BORN SHOULD MAKE A GOOD
 WITCH. FERRACE, SAID OLIMPEDEHRE, RELIEVING HARRY OF THE
 RESPONSIBILITY THE DAY AND OF THIS, LIKES HIS COMPANY. HE ALSO LIKES

THE COMPANY OF THE FAMOUS, THE SUCCESSFUL, AND THE POWERFUL. HE ENJOYS THE FEELING THAT HE INFLUENCES THESE PEOPLE. HE HAS NEVER WANTED THE ECLIPSE OF HIMSELF. HE PREFERS THE BACKSEAT WHERE BEHIND THE SPREAD ELEGANT, WELL SET, HE LIKES THE HANDSOME FAVORITES AT THE GARDENS, SOMETIMES FOR THEIR AMBITIOUS AND THEIR BRAINS, SOMETIMES FOR THEIR CHARM AND THEIR TALENT, AND HE HAD AN UNCOMMON DANCE AND CHASING THESE WHEN WOULD BE IN THE ELEGANT ELEGANT IN THEIR VARIOUS FIELDS. HERACE FORMED A KIND OF CLUB OF HIS FAVORITES WITH HIMSELF AT THE CENTER, MAKING INTRODUCTIONS, MAKING USEFUL CONTACTS BETWEEN MEMBERS, AND ALWAYS REAPING SOME KIND OF BENEFIT IN RETURN, WHETHER A FREE RIDE OF HIS FAVORITE CRYSTALIZED PINEAPPLE OR THE CHANCE TO RECOMMEND THE NEXT ILLEGAL MEMBER OF THE GARDEN LIAISON OFFICE. HARRY HAD A SUDDEN AND VIVID MENTAL IMAGE OF A GREAT SPIDERS SPIDER, SPINNING A WEB AROUND IT, TWITCHING A THREAD HERE AND THERE TO BRING ITS LARGE AND LIMP FLIES A LITTLE CLOSER. I TELL YOU ALL THIS, DUMKEDDRE CONTINUED, NOT THE TURN YOU AGAINST HERACE OR, AS WE MUST NOW CALL HIM, PROFESSOR SLEIGHORN BUT THE POINT YOU ARE YOUR OWN. HE WILL UNEXPECTEDLY TRY TO KILL YOU, HARRY, YOU WOULD BE THE JEWEL OF HIS COLLECTION. THE REASON WHY LIVED OR, AS THEY CALL YOU THESE DAYS, THE CHASING ONE. AT THESE WORDS, A CHILL THAT HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH THE SURROUNDING MIST STEAL OVER HARRY, HE WAS REMINDED OF WORDS HE HAD HEARD A FEW WEEKS AGO, WORDS THAT HAD A TERRIBLE AND PARTICULAR MEANING TO HIM. NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE THE OTHER SURVIVES DUMKEDDRE HAD STOPPED WALKING, LEVEL WITH THE CHURCH THEY HAD PASSED EARLIER. THIS WILL BE, HARRY, IF YOU WILL GRASP MY ARM. RACED THIS TIME, HARRY WAS READY FOR THE APPEARANCE, BUT STILL FEELING IT UNPLEASANT. WHEN THE PRESSURE DISAPPEARED AND HE FEELING HIMSELF ABLE TO BREATHE AGAIN, HE WAS STANDING IN A COUNTRY LANE BESIDE DUMKEDDRE AND LOOKING AHEAD TO THE CRIMINAL SILHOUETTE OF HIS SECOND FAVORITE BUILDING IN THE WORLD: THE BARRON. IN SPITE OF THE FEELING OF DREAD THAT HAD JUST SWEEP THROUGH HIM, HIS SPIRITS COULD NOT HELP BUT LIFT AT THE SIGHT OF IT. THEN WAS IN THERE AND SHE WAS MRS. WEALEY, WHEN COULD BE BETTER THAN ANYONE HE KNEW. IF YOU DON'T MIND, HARRY, SAID DUMKEDDRE, AS THEY PASSED THROUGH THE GATE, I'D LIKE A FEW WORDS WITH YOU BEFORE WE PART. IN PRIVATE, PERHAPS IN HERE? DUMKEDDRE POINTED TOWARD A BLIND-DEAF STONE HOUSE

WHERE THE LEASLEYS KEPT THEIR KITCHENSTICKS. A LITTLE FLUSTERED, FARRY FOLLOWED DUMKEDDRE THROUGH THE CREAKING DOOR INTO A SPACE A LITTLE SMALLER THAN THE AVERAGE KITCHEN. DUMKEDDRE ILLUMINATED THE TIP OF HIS HAND, SEE THAT IT GLOWED LIKE A TAPER, AND SMILED DOWN AT FARRY. I HOPE YOU WILL FORGIVE ME FOR MENTIONING IT, FARRY, BUT I AM PLEASED AND A LITTLE PROUD AT HOW WELL YOU SEEM TO BE COPING AFTER EVERYTHING THAT HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY. PERMIT ME TO SAY THAT I THINK SIRILIS WOULD HAVE BEEN PROUD OF YOU. FARRY SWALLOWED; HIS VOICE SEEMED TO HAVE DESERTED HIM. HE DID NOT THINK HE COULD STAND TO DISCUSS SIRILIS; IT HAD BEEN PAINFUL ENOUGH TO HEAR UNCLE VERNON SAY 'HIS GODFATHER'S DEAD' AND EVEN WORSE TO HEAR SIRILIS'S NAME THROWN OUT CASUALLY BY SILVERHORN. IT WAS TRUE, SAID DUMKEDDRE SOFTLY, THAT YOU AND SIRILIS HAD SUCH A SHORT TIME TOGETHER. A BRITISH ENDING TO WHAT SHOULD HAVE BEEN A LONG AND HAPPY RELATIONSHIP. FARRY NEEDED, HIS EYES FIXED RESOLUTELY ON THE SPIDER NOW CLIMBING DUMKEDDRE'S HAIR, HE COULD TELL THAT DUMKEDDRE UNDERSTOOD, THAT HE MIGHT EVEN SUSPECT THAT UNTIL HIS LETTER ARRIVED, FARRY HAD SPENT NEARLY ALL HIS TIME AT THE OLIVESLYS LYING ON HIS BED, REFUSING MEALS, AND STARING AT THE MISTED WINDOWS, FULL OF THE CHILL EMPTINESS THAT HE HAD COME TO ASSOCIATE WITH DEMENTERS. IT'S JUST HARD, FARRY SAID FINALLY, IN A LOW VOICE, TO REALIZE HE WON'T WRITE THEM AGAIN. HIS EYES BURNED SUDDENLY AND HE BLINKED. HE FELT STUPID FOR ADMITTING IT, BUT THE FACT THAT HE HAD HAD SOMETHING HELTSIDE FINGHARTS WHEN LARD WHAT HAPPENED TO HIM, ALMOST LIKE A PARENT, HAD BEEN ONE OF THE BEST THINGS ABOUT DISCOVERING HIS GODFATHER AND NOW THE BEST THING WOULD NEVER BRING HIM THAT COMFORT AGAIN.

SIRILIS REPRESENTED MUCH TO YOU THAT YOU HAD NEVER KNOWN BEFORE, SAID DUMKEDDRE GENTLY. NATURALLY, THE LOSS IS DEVASTATING. BUT WHILE I WAS AT THE OLIVESLYS INTERRUPTED FARRY, HIS VOICE GROWING STRONGER, I REALIZED I CAN'T SHUT MYSELF AWAY FOR FOR CRACK UP, SIRILIS WOULD NOT HAVE WANTED THAT, WOULD HE? AND ANYWAY, LIFE'S THE SHORT. LOOK AT MADAM BONES, LOOK AT EUGENIE VANCE. IT COULD BE ME NEXT, COULDN'T IT? BUT IF IT IS, HE SAID FIRMLY, NOW LEAVING STRAIGHT INTO DUMKEDDRE'S BLUE EYES GLAMING IN THE HANDLIGHT, I'LL MAKE SURE I TAKE AS MANY DEATH EATERS WITH ME AS I CAN, AND VEHMENT THEM IF I CAN MANAGE IT.

SPEAKEN WITH LIKE YOUR MOTHER AND FATHER'S SON AND SIRILIS'S

TRUE CHOSEN? SAID DUMBLEDORE, WITH AN APPROVING PAT ON HARRY'S BACK. I TAKE MY HAT OFF THE YELL. FOR I WOULD, IF I WERE NOT AFRAID OF STIRRING YELL IN SPIDERS. AND NOW, HARRY, IN A CLOSELY RELATED SUBJECT. I GATHER THAT YELL HAVE BEEN TAKING THE DAILY PROPHET EVER THE LAST TWO WEEKS? YES, SAID HARRY, AND HIS HEART BEAT A LITTLE FASTER. THEN YELL WILL HAVE SEEN THAT THERE HAVE BEEN NOT SO MUCH LEADS AS PLEADS CONCERNING YOUR ADVENTURE IN THE FALL OF PROPHET? YES, SAID HARRY AGAIN. AND NOW EVERYONE KNOWS THAT I'M THE ONE. NO, THEY DO NOT, INTERRUPTED DUMBLEDORE. THERE ARE ONLY TWO PEOPLE IN THE WHOLE WORLD WHO KNOW THE FULL CONTENTS OF THE PROPHET: MADE ARKENT YELL AND LORD VOLDEMORT, AND THEY ARE BOTH STANDING IN THIS SMELLY, SPIDERY ROOM. IT IS TRUE, HOWEVER, THAT MANY HAVE GUESSED, CORRECTLY, THAT VOLDEMORT SENT HIS DEATH EATERS TO STEAL A PROPHET, AND THAT THE PROPHET CONCERNED YELL. NOW, I THINK I AM CORRECT IN SAYING THAT YELL HAVE NOT TOLD ANYBODY THAT YELL KNOW WHAT THE PROPHET SAID? NO, SAID HARRY. A WISE DECISION, IN THE WHOLE, SAID DUMBLEDORE. ALTHOUGH I THINK YELL MIGHT THE MORE IT IN FAVOR OF YOUR FRIENDS, MR. RICHARD LEASLEY AND MISS HERMIONE GRANGER. YES, HE CONTINUED, WHEN HARRY LOOKED STARTLED. I THINK THEY MIGHT THE KNOW, YELL DO THEM A DISSERVICE BY NOT CONSIDERING SOMETHING THIS IMPORTANT TO THEM. I DIDN'T WANT THE WHOLE OF THEM FRIGHTEN THEM? SAID DUMBLEDORE, SURVEYING HARRY EVER THE TOP OF HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES. FOR PERHAPS, THE CHIEF THAT YELL YOURSELF ARE WHORLED AND FRIGHTENED? YELL NEED YOUR FRIENDS, HARRY. AS YELL SO RIGHTLY SAID, SIRIUS WOULD NOT HAVE WANTED YELL TO SHUT YOURSELF AWAY. HARRY SAID NOTHING, BUT DUMBLEDORE DID NOT SEEM TO REQUIRE AN ANSWER. HE CONTINUED. IN A DIFFERENT, THOUGH RELATED, SUBJECT, IT IS MY WISH THAT YELL TAKE PRIVATE LESSONS WITH ME THIS YEAR. PRIVATE WITH YELL? SAID HARRY, SURPRISED BY HIS PRECIPITANT SILENCE. YES, I THINK IT IS TIME THAT I TAKE A GREATER HAND IN YOUR EDUCATION. WHAT WILL YELL BE TEACHING ME, SIR? EH, A LITTLE OF THIS, A LITTLE OF THAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE AIRILY. HARRY WAITED IMPROBLY, BUT DUMBLEDORE DID NOT ELABORATE, SO HE ASKED SOMETHING ELSE THAT HAD BEEN BOTHERING HIM SLIGHTLY. IF I'M HAVING LESSONS WITH YELL, I WON'T HAVE TO DO OCCUPANCY LESSONS WITH SNAPE, WILL I? PROFESSOR SNAPE, HARRY. AND NO, YELL WILL NOT. GOOD.

SAID HARRY IN RELIEF, BECAUSE THEY WERE A HE STOPPED, CAREFULLY
NOT THE SAY WHAT HE REALLY THOUGHT. I THINK THE WORD FLASH
WOULD BE A GOOD ONE HERE, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NODDING. HARRY
LAUGHED. WELL, THAT MEANS I WON'T SEE MUCH OF PROFESSOR Snape
FROM NOW ON, HE SAID, BECAUSE HE WON'T LET ME CARRY ON PETITIONS
UNLESS I GET HELD UPSTANDING IN MY HULL, WHICH I KNOW I HAVEN'T.

DON'T WORRY YOUR HEADS BEFORE THEY ARE DELIVERED, SAID DUMBLEDORE
GRAVELLY. WHICH, NOW I THINK OF IT, MIGHT BE SOME TIME LATER
TODAY. NOW, TWO MORE THINGS, HARRY, BEFORE WE PART. FIRSTLY, I
WISH YOU TO KEEP YOUR INVISIBILITY CLOAK WITH YOU AT ALL TIMES
FROM THIS MOMENT ONWARD, EVEN WITHIN HOGWARTS ITSELF. JUST IN
CASE YOU UNDERSTAND ME? HARRY NODDED. AND LASTLY, WHILE YOU
STAY HERE, THE KLUDGE HAS BEEN GIVEN THE HIGHEST SECURITY THE
MINISTRY OF MAGIC CAN PROVIDE. THESE MEASURES HAVE CAUSED A
CERTAIN AMOUNT OF INCONVENIENCE TO ARTHEUR AND MULLY ALL
THEIR POST, FOR INSTANCE, IS BEING SEARCHED AT THE MINISTRY BEFORE
BEING SENT ON. THEY DO NOT MIND IN THE SLIGHTEST, FOR THEIR ONLY
CONCERN IS YOUR SAFETY. HOWEVER, IT WOULD BE YOUR REPAYMENT IF
YOU RISKED YOUR NECK WHILE STAYING WITH THEM. I UNDERSTAND,
SAID HARRY QUICKLY. VERY WELL, THEN, SAID DUMBLEDORE, PUSHING
OPEN THE KITCHEN DOOR AND STEPPING OUT INTO THE YARD. I SEE A
LIGHT IN THE KITCHEN. LET US NOT DEPRIVE MULLY AND HENGE OF THE
CHANCE TO BECOME FRIENDS WITH YOU ARE. AN EXCESS OF PLEASED HARRY
AND DUMBLEDORE APPROACHED THE BACK DOOR OF THE KLUDGE, WHICH
WAS SURROUNDED BY THE FAMILIAR LITTER OF OLD WELLINGTON BENT'S AND
RUSTY CALIBRENS. HARRY COULD HEAR THE SOFT CLUCKING OF SLEEPY
CHICKENS COMING FROM A DISTANT SHED. DUMBLEDORE KNOCKED THREE
TIMES AND HARRY SAW SLIDEN MOVEMENT BEHIND THE KITCHEN WINDOW.

WHO'S THERE? SAID A NERVOUS VOICE HE RECOGNIZED AS MRS.
WEASLEY'S. DECLARE YOURSELF! IT IS I, DUMBLEDORE, BRINGING
HARRY. THE DOOR OPENED AT ONCE. THERE STOOD MRS. WEASLEY,
SHORT, PLUMP, AND WEARING AN OLD GREEN DRESSING GOWN. HARRY,
DEAR! GRACIOUS, ALAS, YOU GAVE ME A FRIGHT, YOU SAID NOT THE
EXPECT YOU BEFORE MEETING! WE WERE LUCKY, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
LISTENING HARRY OVER THE THRESHOLD. SILENCE PREVED MUCH
MORE PERSUADABLE THAN I HAD EXPECTED, HARRY'S BEING, OF COURSE.
Ah, HELLO, Nymphadora! HARRY LOOKED AROUND AND SAW THAT MRS.
WEASLEY WAS NOT ALONE, DESPITE THE LATENESS OF THE HOUR, A YOUNG

WITCH WITH A PALE, HEART-SHAPED FACE AND MELISSY GREEN HAIR WAS SITTING AT THE TABLE CLUTCHING A LARGE MUG BETWEEN HER HANDS.

WELL, PROFESSOR, SHE SAID, WHETHER HARRY, HI, THANKS, HARRY THOUGHT SHE LOOKED DRIVEN, EVEN ILL, AND THERE WAS SOMETHING FORCED IN HER SMILE, CERTAINLY HER APPEARANCE WAS LESS CHEERFUL THAN USUAL WITHOUT HER CLUSTERY SHADE OF CLUCK-CLUMPING HAIR. I'D BETTER BE OFF, SHE SAID BRISKLY, STANDING UP AND PULLING HER CHEAD AROUND HER SHOULDERS. THANKS FOR THE TEA AND SYMPATHY, MIMMY. PLEASE DON'T LEAVE ME MY ACCOUNT, SAID DUMKEDDRE CHEERFULLY, I CANNOT STAY, I HAVE URGENT MATTERS TO DISCUSS WITH ROLPH SCRIMPHEAR. NEH, NEH, I NEED TO GET GOING, SAID THANKS, NOT MEETING DUMKEDDRE'S EYES. NIGHT DEAR, WHY NOT COME TO DINNER AT THE WEEKEND, ROLPH AND MAD-EYE ARE COMING? NEH, REALLY, MIMMY THANKS ANYWAY GOOD NIGHT, EVERYONE. THANKS HURRIED PAST DUMKEDDRE AND HARRY INTO THE YARD; A FEW PACES BEYOND THE DOORSTEP, SHE TURNED ON THE SPOT AND VANISHED INTO THE THIN AIR. HARRY NOTICED THAT MRS. WEASLEY LOOKED TROUBLED. WELL, I SHALL SEE YOU AT HOGWARTS, HARRY, SAID DUMKEDDRE. TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF, MIMMY, YOUR SERVANT. HE MADE MRS. WEASLEY A KISS AND WHISPERED THANKS, VANISHING AT PRECISELY THE SAME SPOT. MRS. WEASLEY CHECKED THE DOOR ON THE EMPTY YARD AND THEN STEERED HARRY BY THE SHOULDERS INTO THE FLICK GLOW OF THE LANTERN ON THE TABLE TO EXAMINE HIS APPEARANCE. YOU'RE LIKE ROBIN, SHE SIGHED, LOOKING HIM UP AND DOWN. BOTH OF YOU LOOK AS THOUGH YOU'VE HAD STRETCHING LIMBS PUT ON YOU. I SWEAR ROBIN'S GREEN HAIR INCHES SINCE I LAST HELD HIM SCHEER RECKES. ARE YOU FLINERY, HARRY? YES, I AM, SAID HARRY, SLIDDERLY REALIZING JUST HOW FLINERY HE WAS. SIT DOWN, DEAR, I'LL KNICK SOMETHING UP. AS HARRY SAT DOWN, A FLIRRY GINGER CAT WITH A SEELASHED FACE LIMPED BENTH HIS KNEES AND SETTLED THERE, PURRING. SEE FERMINE'S HERE? HE ASKED HAPPILY AS HE TICKLED CRIBBESHANDS BEHIND THE EARS. EH, YES, SHE ARRIVED THE DAY BEFORE YESTERDAY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, RAPPING A LARGE IRON PEET WITH HER HAND. IT KEELINKED BENTH THE STEVE WITH A LEHID CLANG AND BEGAN TO CLUCK AT HIM. EVERYONE'S IN BED, OF COURSE, WE DIDN'T EXPECT YOU FOR FEELS. HERE YOU ARE SHE TAPPED THE PEET AGAIN; IT ROSE INTO THE AIR, FLEW TOWARD HARRY, AND TIPPED OVER; MRS. WEASLEY SLID A KISS NEATLY BENEATH IT JUST IN TIME TO CATCH THE STREAM OF THICK, STREAMING URINE. BREAD,

DEAR? THANKS, MRS. WEASLEY. SHE WAVED HER HAND OVER HER
 SHOULDER; A KNIFE CAME AND A KNIFE SHARED GRACEFULLY BETWEEN THE
 TABLE; AS THE KNIFE SLICED ITSELF AND THE SLIPPER DROPPED BACK BETWEEN
 THE STEVE, MRS. WEASLEY SAT DOWN OPPOSITE HIM. SHE WOULD PERSUADE
 HERACE SLIGHTLY THE TAKE THE HER? HARRY NEEDED, HIS MOUTH SHE
 ALL OF THE SLIPPER THAT HE COULD NOT SPEAK. HE TAUGHT ARTHUR AND
 ME, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, HE WAS AT HERMION'S AGE, STARTED
 ARRIVING THE SAME TIME AS DUMBLEDORE, I THINK, DID YOU LIKE HIM?
 HIS MOUTH WHEN ALL OF THE SLIPPER, HARRY STOLICED AND GAVE A
 NUNCHUKMITTAL IRON OF THE HEAD, I KNOW WHAT YOU MEAN, SAID MRS.
 WEASLEY, NODDING WISELY. HE CHURSE HE CAN BE CHARMING WHEN HE
 WANTS THE RE, BUT ARTHUR'S NEVER LIKED HIM MUCH. THE MINISTRY'S
 LITTERED WITH SLIGHTLY'S OLD FAVORITES, HE WAS ALWAYS GOOD AT
 GIVING LEGS, BUT HE NEVER HAD MUCH TIME FOR ARTHUR. DIDN'T
 SEEM THE THING HE WAS ENOUGH OF A HIGH-FLIER. WELL, THAT LIST SEEMS
 YOU, EVEN SLIGHTLY MAKES MISTAKES, I DON'T KNOW WHETHER YOU'RE
 THE YOU IN ANY OF HIS LETTERS. IT'S ONLY JUST HAPPENED. BUT
 ARTHUR'S BEEN PROMOTED? IT COULD NOT HAVE BEEN CLEARER THAT
 MRS. WEASLEY HAD BEEN BLISTERING THE SAY THIS, HARRY SWALLOWED A
 LARGE AMOUNT OF VERY HOT SLIPPER AND THOUGHT HE COULD FEEL HIS
 THERMAL BLISTERING. THAT'S GREAT? HE GASPED, YOU ARE SWEET,
 BEAMED MRS. WEASLEY, POSSIBLY TAKING HIS WATERING EYES FOR
 EVIDENCE AT THE NEWS. YES, RUFUS SCRINGHELL HAS SET UP SEVERAL
 NEW OFFICES IN RESPONSE TO THE PRESENT SITUATION, AND ARTHUR'S
 HEADING THE OFFICE FOR THE DETECTION AND CONFISCATION OF
 UNINTERPRET DEFENSIVE SPELLS AND PROTECTIVE OBJECTS. IT'S A BIG JOB,
 HE'S GET TEN PEOPLE REPORTING TO HIM NOW? WHAT EXACTLY?

WELL, YOU SEE, IN ALL THE PANIC ABOUT YOU-KNOW-WHAT, A LOT OF THINGS
 HAVE BEEN CREEPING UP FOR SALE EVERYWHERE, THINGS THAT ARE
 SUPPOSED TO GUARD AGAINST YOU-KNOW-WHAT AND THE DEATH EATERS.
 YOU CAN IMAGINE THE KIND OF THING. SHE-CALLED PROTECTIVE
 OBJECTS THAT ARE REALLY GRAY WITH A BIT OF ELDERLY POLIS ADDED,
 HER INSTRUCTIONS FOR DEFENSIVE INDEXES THAT ACTUALLY MAKE YOUR EARS
 FALL OFF. WELL, IN THE MAIN THE PERPETRATORS ARE JUST PEOPLE LIKE
 MURDERING FLETCHER, WHO'VE NEVER DONE AN HONEST DAY'S WORK IN
 THEIR LIVES AND ARE TAKING ADVANTAGE OF THE FRIGHTENED EVERYBODY
 IS, BUT EVERY NOW AND THEN SOMETHING REALLY NASTY TURNS UP. THE
 OTHER DAY ARTHUR CONFISCATED A BOX OF CURSED SNEAKSCAPES THAT

WERE ALMOST CERTAINLY PLANTED BY A DEATH-LATER. SHE WOULD SEE, IT WAS A VERY IMPORTANT ONE, AND I TELL HIM IT WAS JUST SILLY THE MISS DEALING WITH SPARK PLUGS AND THASTERS AND ALL THE REST OF THAT MUCKLE RUCKISH. MRS. WEASLEY ENDED HER SPEECH WITH A STERN LOOK, AS IF IT HAD BEEN HARRY SUGGESTING THAT IT WAS NATURAL THE MISS SPARK PLUGS. IS MR. WEASLEY STILL AT WORK? HARRY ASKED. YES, HE IS, AS A MATTER OF FACT, HE IS A TINY BIT LATE. HE SAID HE'D BE BACK AROUND MIDNIGHT. SHE TURNED THE LOOK AT A LARGE CLOCK THAT WAS PERCHED ALONGWARDLY ON THE OF A PILE OF SHEETS IN THE WASHING BASKET AT THE END OF THE TABLE. HARRY RECOGNIZED IT AT ONCE: IT HAD NINE HANDS, EACH INSCRIBED WITH THE NAME OF A FAMILY MEMBER, AND USUALLY FINE ON THE WEASLEYS SITTING ROOM WALL, THOUGH ITS CURRENT POSITION SUGGESTED THAT MRS. WEASLEY HAD TAKEN THE CARRYING IT AROUND THE HOUSE WITH HER. EVERY SINGLE ONE OF ITS NINE HANDS WAS NOW POINTING AT MORTAL PERIL. IT WAS KEEN LIKE THAT FOR A WHILE NOW, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, IN AN UNCONVINCINGLY CASUAL VOICE. EVER SINCE YOUNG MISS WEASLEY CAME BACK INTO THE HOUSE, I SUPPOSE EVERYBODY IS IN MORTAL DANGER NOW. I DON'T THINK IT CAN BE JUST HER FAMILY BUT I DON'T KNOW ANYONE ELSE WHO'S GOT A CLOCK LIKE THIS, SHE I CAN'T CHECK, HEY? WITH A SUDDEN EXCLAMATION SHE POINTED AT THE CLOCK'S FACE. MR. WEASLEY'S HAND HAD SWITCHED THE TRAVELING. HE'S CHIRPING! AND SURE ENOUGH, A MOMENT LATER THERE WAS A BANG ON THE BACK DOOR. MRS. WEASLEY JUMPED UP AND FLURRIED THE IT; WITH ONE HAND ON THE DOORHANDLE AND HER FACE PRESSED AGAINST THE WOOD SHE CALLED SHOUTS. ARTHUR, IS THAT YOU? YES, CAME MR. WEASLEY'S WEARY VOICE. BUT I WOULD SAY THAT EVEN IF I WERE A DEATH-LATER, DEAR, ASK THE ELDEST! HE, HONESTLY MUM? ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT. WHAT IS YOUR DEAREST AMBITION? THE FIND OUT HOW AIRPLANES STAY UP. MRS. WEASLEY NEEDED AND TURNED THE DOORHANDLE, BUT APPARENTLY MR. WEASLEY WAS HOLDING TIGHT TO IT ON THE OTHER SIDE, BECAUSE THE DOOR REMAINED FIRMLY SHUT. MUM? I'VE GOT THE ASK YOU YOUR ELDEST FIRST? ARTHUR, REALLY, THIS IS JUST SILLY. WHAT DO YOU LIKE ME TO CALL YOU WHEN WE'RE ALONE TOGETHER? EVEN BY THE DIM LIGHT OF THE LANTERN HARRY COULD TELL THAT MRS. WEASLEY HAD TURNED BRIGHT RED; HE HIMSELF FELT SUDDENLY WARM AROUND THE EARS AND NECK, AND HASTILY GLIPPED SHUT, CLATTERING HIS SPEECH AS LOUDLY AS HE COULD AGAINST THE WOOD. MUM! HE WHISPERED A MORTIFIED MRS. WEASLEY INTO

THE CRACK AT THE EDGE OF THE DOOR. CORRECT, SAID MR. WEASLEY,

WHEN YOU CAN LET ME IN. MRS. WEASLEY OPENED THE DOOR AND REVEALED HER HUSBAND, A THIN, BALDING, RED-FAIRED WIZARD WEARING THINN-RIMMED SPECTACLES AND A LONG AND BUSY TRAVELLING CLOAK. I STILL DIDN'T SEE WHY WE HAVE TO GO THROUGH THAT EVERY TIME YOU COME HOME, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, STILL FIND IN THE FACE AS SHE HELPED HER HUSBAND PUT ON HIS CLOAK. I MEAN, A DEATH EATER MIGHT HAVE FORCED THE ANSWER OUT OF YOU BEFORE IMPERSONATING YOU! I KNOW, DEAR, BUT IT'S MINISTRY PROCEDURE, AND I HAVE TO SET AN EXAMPLE.

SOMETHING SMELLS GOOD WHEN YOU SLEEP? MR. WEASLEY TURNED SUDDENLY IN THE DIRECTION OF THE TABLE. HARRY? WE DIDN'T EXPECT YOU UNTIL MORNING! THEY SMELL HANDS, AND MR. WEASLEY DROPPED INTO THE CHAIR BESIDE HARRY AS MRS. WEASLEY SET A CUP OF SLEEP IN FRONT OF HIM THEM. THANKS, MUM, IT'S BEEN A TIGHT NIGHT. SOMEbody'S STARTED SELLING METAMORPH-MEDALS, JUST SELLING THEM AROUND YOUR NECK AND YOU'LL BE ABLE TO CHANGE YOUR APPEARANCE AT WILL, A HUNDRED THOUSAND DISGUISES, ALL FOR TEN GALLEONS! AND WHAT REALLY HAPPENS WHEN YOU PUT THEM ON? MOSTLY YOU JUST TURN A FAIRLY UNPLEASANT STRANGE COLOR, BUT A COUPLE OF PEOPLE HAVE ALREADY SPRUNG TENTACLE-LIKE WARTS ALL OVER THEIR BODIES, AS IF ST. MUNGUS DIDN'T HAVE ENOUGH OF THEM ALREADY! IT SEEMS LIKE THE SORT OF THING FRED AND GEORGE WOULD FIND FUNNY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY HESITANTLY, ARE YOU SURE? OF COURSE I AM! SAID MR. WEASLEY. THE KIDS WOULDN'T DO ANYTHING LIKE THAT NOW, NOT WHEN PEOPLE ARE DESPERATE FOR PROTECTION! SEE IS THAT WHY YOU'RE LATE, METAMORPH-MEDALS? NO, WE GOT WIND OF A NASTY BACKFIREING LINE DOWN IN ELEPHANT AND CASTLE, BUT LUCKILY THE MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT SHIELD HAD STOPPED IT BEFORE BY THE TIME WE GOT THERE. HARRY STOLE A GLANCE BEHIND HIS HAND, YES, SAID AN UNDECEIVED MRS. WEASLEY AT ONCE. I'VE GOT FRED AND GEORGE'S ROOMS ALL READY FOR YOU, YOU'LL HAVE IT THEMSELVES. WHY, WHERE ARE THEY? OH, THEY'RE IN DIAGON ALLEY, SLEEPING IN THE LITTLE FLAT OVER THEIR HOME SHOP AS THEY'RE SELLING, SAID MRS. WEASLEY. I MUST SAY, I DIDN'T APPROVE AT FIRST, BUT THEY DO SEEM TO HAVE A BIT OF A FLAIR FOR BUSINESS! COME ON, DEAR, YOUR TRUNK'S ALREADY UP THERE. NIGHT, MR. WEASLEY, SAID HARRY, PUSHING BACK HIS CHAIR. CRENSHAW'S LEAPT LIGHTLY FROM HIS LAP AND SLID OUT OF THE ROOM. GOOD NIGHT, HARRY, SAID MR. WEASLEY. HARRY SAW MRS.

WEASLEY GLANCE AT THE CLOTH IN THE WASHING BASKET AS THEY LEFT THE KITCHEN. ALL THE HANDS WERE HERE AGAIN AT MORTAL PERIL. FRED AND GEORGE'S REBELLION WAS IN THE SECOND FLIGHT. MRS. WEASLEY POINTED HER HAND AT A LAMP ON THE BEDSIDE TABLE AND IT IGNITED AT ONCE, BATHING THE ROOM IN A PLEASANT GILDEN GLOW. THROUGH A LARGE VASE OF FLOWERS HAD BEEN PLACED ON A DESK IN FRONT OF THE SMALL WINDOW, THEIR PERMANENT CHILD NEET DISCLOSE THE LINGERING SMELL OF WHAT FARRY THROUGH IT WAS CLIMBERING. A CONSIDERABLE AMOUNT OF FLIGHT SPACE WAS DEVOTED TO A VAST NUMBER OF UNMARKED, SEALED CARDBOARD BOXES, AMONGST WHICH STOOD FARRY'S SECRET TRUNK. THE ROOM BREATHED AS THOUGH IT WAS BEING USED AS A TEMPORARY WAREHOUSE. FREDIE SMILED HAPPILY AT FARRY FROM HER PERCH ON TOP OF A LARGE WARDROBE, THEN THREW HER THROUGH THE WINDOW. FARRY KNEW SHE HAD BEEN WAITING TO SEE HIM BEFORE GOING FLIGHTING. FARRY KNEW MRS. WEASLEY COULD NOT, PUT ON PALMERS, AND GET INTO ONE OF THE BEDS. THERE WAS SOMETHING HARD INSIDE THE PILLOWCASE. HE CRAWLED INSIDE IT AND PULLED OUT A STICKY PURPLE-AND-ORANGE SWEET, WHICH HE RECOGNIZED AS A PLOTTING PASTILLE. SMILING TO HIMSELF, HE ROLLED OVER AND WAS INSTANTLY ASLEEP. SECONDS LATER, HE SAW IT SEEMED TO FARRY, HE WAS AWAKENED BY WHAT SEEMED LIKE CANNON FIRE AS THE DOOR FIRST OPEN. SITTING UP UPRIGHT, HE HEARD THE RASP OF THE CURTAINS BEING PULLED BACK. THE DAZZLING SUNLIGHT SEEMED TO POKE HIM HARD IN BOTH EYES. SHIELDING THEM WITH ONE HAND, HE CRAWLED FORTHLESSLY FOR HIS GLASSES WITH THE OTHER. 'WIZZING!' HE DIDN'T KNOW WHY WERE HERE ALREADY? SAID A LOW AND EXCITED VOICE, AND HE RECEIVED A SHARP BLOW TO THE TOP OF THE HEAD. THEN, DIDN'T HIT HIM? SAID A GIRL'S VOICE REPROACHFULLY. FARRY'S HAND FELT HIS GLASSES AND HE SEIZED THEM ON, THOUGH THE LIGHT WAS SO BRIGHT HE COULD HARDLY SEE ANYWAY. A LONG, WHISTLING SHADES DELIVERED IN FRONT OF HIM FOR A MOMENT. HE BLINKED AND THEN WEASLEY CAME INTO VIEW, GRINNING DOWN AT HIM. ALL RIGHT? NEVER BEEN BETTER, SAID FARRY, RUBBING THE TOP OF HIS HEAD AND SLUMPING BACK INTO HIS PILLOWS. WHY NOT BAD, SAID THEN, PULLING OVER A CARDBOARD BOX AND SITTING ON IT. WHEN DID YOU GET HERE? MUM'S ONLY JUST TOLD US. ABOUT ONE O'CLOCK THIS MORNING. WERE THE MUGGLES ALL RIGHT? DID THEY TREAT YOU BAD? SAME AS USUAL, SAID FARRY, AS HERMIONE PERCHED HERSELF ON THE EDGE OF HIS BED. THEY DIDN'T TALK TO ME MUCH, BUT I LIKE IT BETTER THAT WAY. THEN ARE YOU,

BERMINE? EH, I'M FINE, SAID BERMINE, WHO WAS SCRUTINIZING HARRY AS THOUGH HE WAS SICKENING HER SOMETHING. HE THOUGHT HE KNEW WHAT WAS BEHIND THIS, AND AS HE HAD NO WISH TO DISCUSS SIRIL'S DEATH OR ANY OTHER MISERABLE SUBJECT AT THE MOMENT, HE SAID, WHAT'S THE TIME? HAVE I MISSED BREAKFAST? THEN WHERRY ASHLY THAT, MUM'S BRINGING YOU UP A TRAY, SHE RECOGNIZED YOU WERE LINGERED, SAID RENN, ROLLING HIS EYES. SEE, WHAT'S BEEN GOING ON?

NOTHING MUCH, I'VE JUST BEEN STUCK AT MY AUNT AND UNCLE'S, HAVEN'T I? COME OFF IT! SAID RENN, YOU'VE BEEN OFF WITH DUMKEDDER? IT WASN'T THAT EXCITING, HE JUST WANTED ME TO HELP HIM PERSUADE THIS OLD TEACHER TO COME OUT OF RETIREMENT. HIS NAME'S HERACE SLUGGISHORN. EH, SAID RENN, LOOKING DISAPPOINTED.

HE THOUGHT BERMINE FLASHED A WARNING LOOK AT RENN, AND RENN CHANGED TACK AT THE SPEED. HE THOUGHT IT TO BE SOMETHING LIKE THAT. YOU DID? SAID HARRY, AMUSED. YEAH YEAH, WELL LIMERIDGE HAS LEFT, HEVILLY WE NEED A NEW DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER, DON'T WE? SEE, ER, WHAT'S HE LIKE? HE LOOKS A BIT LIKE A WALRUS, AND HE USED TO BE HEAD OF SLYTHERIN, SAID HARRY.

SOMETHING WORTHY, BERMINE? SHE WAS WATCHING HIM AS THOUGH EXPECTING STRANGE SYMPTOMS TO MANIFEST THEMSELVES AT ANY MOMENT. SHE REARRANGED HER FEATURES FASTLY IN AN UNCONVINCING SMILE. OH, HOW CHLORSE NOT? SEE, MUM, DID SLUGGISHORN SEEM LIKE HE MIGHT BE A GOOD TEACHER? BLINNY, SAID HARRY, HE CAN'T BE WORSER THAN LIMERIDGE, CAN HE? I KNOW SOMEBODY WHO'S WORSER THAN LIMERIDGE, SAID A VOICE FROM THE DRIVEWAY, RENN'S YOUNGER SISTER SNEEZED INTO THE RHEM, LOOKING IRRITABLE. HI, HARRY, WHAT'S UP WITH YOU? RENN ASKED. IT'S HER, SAID GINNY, PLEADING HERSELF DOWN ON HARRY'S BED. SHE'S DRIVING ME MAD. WHAT'S SHE DONE NOW? ASKED BERMINE SYMPATHETICALLY. IT'S THE WAY SHE TALKS TO ME YOU'D THINK I WAS ASHLY THERE! I KNOW, SAID BERMINE, DROPPING HER VEIL. SHE'S SHE'LL OFF HERSELF. HARRY WAS ASTONISHED TO HEAR BERMINE TALKING ASHLY MRS. WEASLEY LIKE THIS AND CHILD NOT BLAME RENN FOR SAYING ANGRILY, CAN'T YOU TWO LAUGH OFF HER FOR FIVE SECONDS? EH, THAT'S RIGHT, DEFEND HER, SNAPPED GINNY. WE ALL KNOW YOU CAN'T GET ENOUGH OF HER. THIS SEEMED AN EDD COMMENT TO MAKE ASHLY RENN'S MOTHER, STARTING TO FEEL THAT HE WAS MISSING SOMETHING. HARRY SAID, WHO ARE YOU? BUT HIS QUESTIONS WERE ANSWERED BEFORE HE COULD FINISH IT. THE REDDISH DRESS FLEW UPON

AGAIN, AND HARRY INSTINCTIVELY PANDERED THE REDCOVERS UP THE HIS
CHIN SHE HAD THAT HERMIONE AND GINNY SLID OFF THE BED BENTH THE
FLOOR. A YOUNG WOMAN WAS STANDING IN THE DOORWAY, A WOMAN IN
SUCH GREAT-TAKING REALITY THAT THE ROOM SEEMED THE HAVE BECOME
STRANGELY AIRLESS. SHE WAS TALL AND WILLINGLY WITH LONG BLONDE HAIR
AND APPEARED THE EMANATE A FAINT, SILVERY GLOW. THE COMPLETE THIS
VISION OF PERFECTION, SHE WAS CARRYING A HEAVILY LADEN BREAKFAST
TRAY. ARRY, SHE SAID IN A THREATY VOICE. LET AS BEEN THE
LONG. AS SHE SLEPT OVER THE THRESHOLD TOWARD HIM, MRS. WEASLEY
WAS REVEALED, BEKKING ALONG IN HER WARD, BEKKING RATHER CRESS.

THERE WAS NO NEED THE BRING UP THE TRAY, I WAS JUST ABOUT THE DO IT
MYSELF. LET WAS NO TRICKLE, SAID FLEUR DELACOUR, SETTING THE TRAY
ACROSS HARRY'S KNEES AND THEN SWEEPING THE KISS HIM IN EACH
CHEEK. HE FELT THE PLACES WHERE HER MOUTH HAD TOUCHED HIM BURN.

I HAVE BEEN BEGGING THE SEE ME. YOU REMEMBER MY SISTER,
GABRIELLE? SHE NEVER STOPS TALKING ABOUT ARRY PETER. SHE WILL
BE DELIGHTED THE SEE YOU AGAIN. EH? IS SHE HERE THEN? HARRY
CREAKED. NO, NO, SILLY KID, SAID FLEUR WITH A TINKLING LAUGH. I
MEAN NEXT SUMMER, WHEN WE GO OUT YOU MEET DRAGON? HER GREAT
BLUE EYES WIDENED AND SHE BEAMED REPROACHFULLY AT MRS. WEASLEY,
WHO SAID, WE HADN'T GET AROUND THE TELLING HIM YET. FLEUR TURNED
BACK THE HARRY, SWINGING HER SILVERY SHEET OF HAIR SHE THAT IT
WHIPPED MRS. WEASLEY ACROSS THE FACE. KILL AND I ARE GOING TO BE
MARRIED. EH, SAID HARRY BLANDLY, HE COULD NOT HELP NOTICING
HOW MRS. WEASLEY, HERMIONE, AND GINNY WERE ALL DETERMINEDLY
AVOIDING ONE ANOTHER'S GAZE. WELL, ER CONGRATULATIONS! SHE
SWEEPED DOWN UPON HIM AND KISSED HIM AGAIN. KILL IS VERY BUSY AT
THE MOMENT, WORKING VERY HARD, AND I ONLY WORK PARTTIME AT
GRINGOTTS FOR MY PENGLISH, SHE HE BRIGHT ME FOR FOR A FEW DAYS THE
GET THE DRAGON IS FAMILY PROPERLY. I WAS SHE PLEASED THE EAR YOU
WOULD BE COMING. THERE ISN'T MUCH THE DO FOR, UNLESS YOU LIKE
CHICKENS AND CHICKENS. WELL. ENJOY YOUR BREAKFAST, ARRY.
WITH THESE WORDS SHE TURNED GRACEFULLY AND SEEMED THE FLEAT HLT OF
THE ROOM, CLOSING THE DOOR QUIETLY BEHIND HER. MRS. WEASLEY MADE A
NOISE THAT SOUNDED LIKE T-HAT. MOM HATES HER, SAID GINNY
QUIETLY. I DO NOT HATE HER. SAID MRS. WEASLEY IN A CRESS WHISPER.
I JUST THINK THEY VE HURRIED INTO THE THIS ENGAGEMENT, THAT'S ALL.
THEY VE KNOWN EACH OTHER A YEAR, SAID BEN, WHO BEAMED BOLDLY

GREGORY AND WAS STARING AT THE CLOSED DOOR. WELL, THAT S NOT VERY
 LONG; I KNOW WHY IT S HAPPENED, HE CHURSE. IT S ALL THIS
 UNCERTAINTY WITH YELL-DONNEN WHEN COMING BACK, PEOPLE THINK THEY
 MIGHT BE DEAD THEMSELVES, SEE THEY RE ALISHING ALL SORTS OF DECISIONS
 THEY D NORMALLY TAKE TIME EVER. IT WAS THE SAME LAST TIME HE WAS
 PRESENT, PEOPLE PEEPING LEFT, RIGHT, AND CENTER INCLUDING
 YELL AND DAD, SAID GINNY SLYLY. YES, WELL, YELLER FATHER AND I WERE
 MADE FOR EACH OTHER, WHAT WAS THE POINT IN WAITING? SAID MRS.
 LEASLEY, WHEREAS BILL AND FLEW. WELL WHAT HAVE THEY REALLY
 GET IN COMMON? HE S A HARDWORKING, DOWN-TH-EARTH SORT OF
 PERSON, WHEREAS SHE S A LADY, SAID GINNY, NODDING, BUT
 BILL S NOT THAT DOWN-TH-EARTH, HE S A CLERE-BREAKER, ISN T HE, HE
 LIKES A BIT OF ADVENTURE, A BIT OF GLAMOUR. I EXPECT THAT S WHY
 HE S GOING FOR PLEEM. STOP CALLING HER THAT, GINNY, SAID MRS.
 LEASLEY SHARPLY, AS HARRY AND HERMIONE LAUGHED. WELL, I D BETTER
 GET ON. PUT YELLER EGGS WHILE THEY RE WARM, HARRY, SMILING
 CARELESSLY, SHE LEFT THE ROOM. REN STILL SEEMED SLIGHTLY
 PLUCKED; HE WAS SHAKING HIS HEAD EXPERIMENTALLY LIKE A DUE
 TRYING THE RID ITS EARS OF WATER. DONT YELL GET USED TO HER IF SHE S
 STAYING IN THE SAME HOUSE? HARRY ASKED. WELL, YELL DUE, SAID
 REN, BUT IF SHE LIPS OUT AT YELL UNEXPECTEDLY, LIKE THEN
 IT S PATHETIC, SAID HERMIONE FLIRTELISLY, STRIDING AWAY FROM REN
 AS FAR AS SHE COULD GO AND TURNING THE FACE HIM WITH HER ARMS
 FLEW SINCE SHE HAD REACHED THE WALL. YELL DONT REALLY WANT HER
 ANYMORE? GINNY ASKED REN INCREDULOUSLY, WHEN HE
 MERELY SMILED, SHE SAID. WELL, MYM S GOING TO PUT A STOP TO IT
 IF SHE CAN, I GET YELL ANYTHING. HEH S SHE GOING TO MANAGE
 THAT? ASKED HARRY. SHE KEEPS TRYING TO GET THINGS DONE FOR
 DINNER, I THINK SHE S HELPING BILL WILL FALL FOR THINGS INSTEAD. I
 HOPE HE DOES, I D MUCH RATHER HAVE HER IN THE FAMILY. YES,
 THAT LL WORK, SAID REN SARCASTICALLY. LISTEN, REN KNEW IN HIS
 RIGHT MIND S GOING TO FANCY THINGS WHEN FLEW S ANYMORE. I MEAN,
 THINGS IS HAPPENING WHEN SHE ISN T DOING STUPID THINGS TO HER
 HAIR AND HER NECK, BUT SHE S A DAMN SIGHT NICER THAN
 PLEEM, SAID GINNY AND SHE S MORE INTELLIGENT, SHE S AN
 ALRIGHT, SAID HERMIONE FROM THE CORNER. FLEW S NOT STUPID, SHE
 WAS GOOD ENOUGH TO ENTER THE TRIWIZARD TOURNAMENT, SAID
 HARRY. NOT YELL AS WELL? SAID HERMIONE BITTERLY. I SUPPOSE YELL

LIKE THE WAY PRILEM SAYS. "ARRY, DEE VELL?" ASKED CINDY SCORNFULLY. "DEE," SAID HARRY, WISHING HE HADN'T SPOKEN. "I WAS JUST SAYING, PRILEM. I MEAN, FLEUR. I'D MUCH RATHER HAVE THEM IN THE FAMILY," SAID CINDY. "AT LEAST SHE'S A LADY. SHE HADN'T BEEN MUCH OF A LADY LATELY," SAID RENN. "EVERY TIME I'VE SEEN HER SHE'S BEEN THERE LIKE MEANING MORTLE. THAT'S NOT FAIR," SNAPPED HERMINE. "SHE STILL HADN'T GOTTEN OVER WHAT HAPPENED. VELL KNEW. I MEAN, HE WAS HER CHILDSIN? HARRY'S HEART SANK. THEY HAD ARRIVED AT SIRILIS. HE PICKED UP A PEEK AND BEGAN SHEVELING SCRAMBLED EGGS INTO HIS MOUTH, MISSING THE DELECT AND INVITATION THE IMIN IN THIS PART OF THE CONVERSATION. "THEM AND SIRILIS BARELY KNEW EACH OTHER?" SAID RENN. "SIRILIS WAS IN AZERKAN HALF HER LIFE AND BEFORE THAT THEIR FAMILIES NEVER MET."

"THAT'S NOT THE POINT," SAID HERMINE. "SHE THINKS IT WAS HER FAULT HE DIED? THEN DOES SHE KNOW THAT ONE VELL?" ASKED HARRY, IN SPITE OF HIMSELF. "WELL, SHE WAS FIGHTING BELLATRIX LESTRANGE, WASN'T SHE? I THINK SHE FEELS THAT IF ONLY SHE HAD FINISHED HER OFF, BELLATRIX WOULDN'T HAVE KILLED SIRILIS. THAT'S STUPID," SAID RENN.

"IT'S SURVIVOR'S GUILT," SAID HERMINE. "I KNOW LUPIN'S TRIED TO TALK HER AROUND, BUT SHE'S STILL REALLY DOWN. SHE'S ACTUALLY HAVING TROUBLE WITH HER METAMORPHOSING. WITH HER ? SHE CAN'T CHANGE HER APPEARANCE LIKE SHE USED TO," EXPLAINED HERMINE. "I THINK HER POWERS MUST HAVE BEEN AFFECTED BY SOMETHING, OR SOMETHING."

"I DIDN'T KNOW THAT COULD HAPPEN," SAID HARRY. "NEED I?" SAID HERMINE. "BUT I SUPPOSE IF VELL IS REALLY DEPRESSED." THE DOOR OPENED AGAIN AND MRS. WEASLEY PLOPPED HER HEAD IN. "CINDY, SHE WHISPERED. "COME DOWNSTAIRS AND HELP ME WITH THE LINEN. I'M TALKING THE THING LEFT?" SAID CINDY, ELTRAGED. "NEED?" SAID MRS. WEASLEY, AND WITHDREW. "SHE ONLY WANTS ME THERE SEE SHE DOESN'T HAVE THE BE ALONE WITH PRILEM?" SAID CINDY CREEPLY. "SHE SWING HER LONG RED HAIR AROUND IN A VERY GOOD IMITATION OF FLEUR AND PRANCED ACROSS THE ROOM WITH HER ARMS HELD AHEAD LIKE A BALLETRINA."

"VELL LEFT HAD BETTER COME DOWN QUICKLY THEN," SHE SAID AS SHE LEFT. HARRY TOOK ADVANTAGE OF THE TEMPORARY SILENCE TO EAT MORE BREAKFAST. HERMINE WAS PEERING INTO FRED AND GEORGE'S ROOMS, THROUGH EVERY DOOR AND THEN SHE CAST SIDELONG GLANCES AT HARRY. RENN, WHO WAS NOW HELPING HIMSELF TO HARRY'S TEAST, WAS STILL GAZING DREAMILY AT THE DOOR. "WHAT'S THIS?" HERMINE ASKED

EVENTUALLY, HOLDING UP WHAT LOOKED LIKE A SMALL TELESCOPE.

DOWNHE, SAID REIN, BUT IF FRED AND GEORGE WERE LEFT IT HERE, IT'S PROBABLY NOT READY FOR THE HIDE SHEEP YET, SEE BE CAREFUL. YELIA MUM SAID THE SHEEP'S GOING WELL, SAID HARRY. SAID FRED AND GEORGE HAVE GOTTEN A REAL FLAIR FOR BUSINESS. THAT'S AN UNDERSTATEMENT, SAID REIN. THEY'RE MAKING IN THE GALLEONS! I CAN'T WAIT TO SEE THE PLACE, WE HAVEN'T BEEN TO DIAGEN ALLEY YET, BECAUSE MUM SAYS DAD'S GOTTEN THEM THERE FOR EXTRA SECURITY AND HE'S BEEN REALLY BUSY AT WORK, BUT IT SOUNDS EXCELLENT. AND WHAT ABOUT PERCY? ASKED HARRY. THE THIRD-ELDEST WEALEY BROTHER HAD FALLEN OUT WITH THE REST OF THE FAMILY. IS HE TALKING TO YELIA MUM AND DAD AGAIN? NEHE, SAID REIN, BUT HE KNOWS YELIA DAD WAS RIGHT ALL ALONG WHEN ABOUT VERDMEERT BEING BACK. DUMKEDHRE SAYS PEOPLE FIND IT FAR EASIER TO FORGIVE OTHERS FOR BEING WRONG THAN BEING RIGHT, SAID HERMINE. I HEARD HIM TELLING YELIA MUM, REIN. SOUNDS LIKE THE SORT OF MENTAL THING DUMKEDHRE WOULD SAY, SAID REIN. HE'S GOING TO BE GIVING ME PRIVATE LESSONS THIS YEAR, SAID HARRY CONVERSATIONALLY. REIN CHECKED HIS KIT IN THEAST, AND HERMINE GASPED. YELI KEPT THAT QUIET? SAID REIN. I ONLY JUST REMEMBERED, SAID HARRY HONESTLY. HE TOLD ME LAST NIGHT IN YELIA BROTHER'S BED. BUSY PRIVATE LESSONS WITH DUMKEDHRE? SAID REIN, LOOKING IMPRESSED. I WONDER WHY HE'S ? HIS VEHICLE TAILED AWAY, HARRY SAW HIM AND HERMINE EXCHANGE LOOKS. HARRY LAID DOWN HIS KNIFE AND FEEL, HIS HEART BEATING RATHER FAST CONSIDERING THAT ALL HE WAS DOING WAS SITTING IN BED. DUMKEDHRE HAD SAID THE DEE IT. WHY NOT NEHE? HE FIXED HIS EYES ON HIS FEEL, WHICH WAS GLEAMING IN THE SLIGHT STREAMING INTO HIS LAP, AND SAID, I DIDN'T KNOW EXACTLY WHY HE'S GOING TO BE GIVING ME LESSONS, BUT I THINK IT MUST BE BECAUSE OF THE PROPHECY. NEITHER REIN NOR HERMINE SPOKE. HARRY HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT BOTH HAD FROZEN. HE CONTINUED, STILL SPEAKING TO HIS FEEL. YELI KNOW, THE MORE THEY WERE TRYING TO STEAL AT THE MINISTRY. NEHE KNOWS WHAT IT SAID, TELL ME, SAID HERMINE QUICKLY. IT GOT SMASHED.

ALTHOUGH THE PROPHECY SAYS REGAN REIN, BUT HERMINE SAID, SEE! THE PROPHECY'S GOT IT RIGHT, SAID HARRY, LOOKING UP AT THEM BOTH WITH A GREAT EFFORT! HERMINE SEEMED FRIGHTENED AND REIN AMAZED. THAT GLASS BALL THAT SMASHED WASN'T THE ONLY RECIPE OF THE PROPHECY, I HEARD THE WHOLE THING IN DUMKEDHRE'S OFFICE, HE

WAS THE HUR THE PROPHECY WAS MADE THE, SEE HE CHILD TELL ME, FROM
WHAT IT SAID, HARRY THREW A DEEP BREATH, IT SEEMS LIKE I'M THE HUR
WHEN I GET THE FINISH OF VERDICT, AT LEAST, IT SAID NEITHER OF
US CHILD LIVE WHILE THE OTHER SURVIVES, THE THREE OF THEM GAZED
AT ONE ANOTHER IN SILENCE FOR A MOMENT, THEN THERE WAS A HEAVY
BANG AND FERMINE VANISHED BEHIND A PUFF OF BLACK SMOKE.

FERMINE? SHOUTED HARRY AND BEN, THE BREAKFAST TRAY SLID THE
THE FLOOR WITH A CRASH, FERMINE EMERGED, CRYING, HEAT OF THE
SMOKE, CLUTCHING THE TELESCOPE AND SPURTING A BRILLIANTLY PURPLE
BLACK EYE, I FREEZED IT AND IT IT PLINCHED ME? SHE GASPED, AND
SURE ENOUGH, THEY NOW SAW A TINY FIST AND A LONG SPRING
PROTRUDING FROM THE END OF THE TELESCOPE, BEN T HARRY, SAID BEN,
WHEN WAS PLAINLY TRYING NOT TO LAUGH, MOM LL FIX THAT, SHE'S
GOOD AT HEALING MINOR INJURIES HEH WELL, NEVER MIND THAT

NOW? SAID FERMINE HASTILY, HARRY, HEH, HARRY SHE SAT DOWN
ON THE EDGE OF HIS BED AGAIN, WE WANDERED, AFTER WE GOT BACK FROM
THE MINISTRY HEAVILY, WE DIDN'T WANT TO SAY ANYTHING THE
YELL, BUT FROM WHAT LUCILIS MALFOY SAID ABOUT THE PROPHECY, WELL
IT WAS ABOUT YELL AND VERDICT, WELL, WE THOUGHT IT MIGHT BE
SOMETHING LIKE THIS, HEH, HARRY SHE STARED AT HIM, THEN
WHISPERED, ARE YELL SCARED? NOT AS MUCH AS I WAS, SAID HARRY,

WHEN I FIRST HEARD IT, I WAS BUT NOW, IT SEEMS AS THOUGH I
ALWAYS KNEW I'D HAVE TO FACE HIM IN THE END, WHEN WE HEARD
DUMBLEDORE WAS CHECKING YELL IN PERSON, WE THOUGHT HE MIGHT BE
TELLING YELL SOMETHING OR SHOWING YELL SOMETHING THE DEE WITH THE
PROPHECY, SAID BEN EAGERLY, AND WE WERE KIND OF RIGHT, WEREN'T
WE? HE WOULDN'T BE GIVING YELL LESSONS IF HE THOUGHT YELL WERE A
GENIUS, WOULDN'T WASTE HIS TIME HE MUST THINK YELL'VE GOT A
CHANCE? THAT'S TRUE, SAID FERMINE, I WONDER WHAT HE'LL TEACH
YELL, HARRY? REALLY ADVANCED DEFENSIVE MAGIC, PREHABLY

POWERFUL COUNTERCLOUSES ANTI-INDICES HARRY DID NOT REALLY
LISTEN, A WARMTH WAS SPREADING THROUGH HIM THAT HAD NOTHING
THE DEE WITH THE SLIGHT; A TIGHT RESTRAINT IN HIS CHEST SEEMED
TO BE DISSOLVING, HE KNEW THAT BEN AND FERMINE WERE MORE
SHOCKED THAN THEY WERE LETTING ON, BUT THE MORE FACT THAT THEY
WERE STILL THERE ON EITHER SIDE OF HIM, SPREADING BRACING WORDS OF
COMFORT, NOT SHRINKING FROM HIM AS THOUGH HE WERE CONTAMINATED
OR DANGEROUS, WAS WORTH MORE THAN HE COULD EVER TELL THEM.

AND EVASIVE ENCHANTMENTS GENERALLY, CONCLUDED FERMINE. WELL, AT LEAST YOU KNOW ONE LESSON YOU LL BE LEARNING THIS YEAR, THAT S ONE MORE THAN BEN AND ME. I WONDER WHEN YOUR H.W.S. RESULTS WILL COME? CAN T BE LONG NOW, IT S BEEN A MONTH, SAID BEN. FANG BEN, SAID FARRY, AS ANOTHER PART OF LAST NIGHT S CONVERSATION CAME BACK TO HIM. I THINK DUMKEDORE SAID YOUR H.W.S. RESULTS WOULD BE ARRIVING TODAY? TODAY? STIRRED FERMINE. TODAY? BUT WHY DIDN T YOU HEY MY GOD YOU SHOULD HAVE SAID SHE LEAPT TO HER FEET. I M GOING TO SEE WHETHER ANY HELLS HAVE COME.

BUT WHEN FARRY ARRIVED DOWNSTAIRS TEN MINUTES LATER, FULLY DRESSED AND CARRYING HIS EMPTY BREAKFAST TRAY, IT WAS THE FIND FERMINE SITTING AT THE KITCHEN TABLE IN GREAT AGITATION, WHILE MRS. WEASLEY TRIED TO LESSEN HER RESEMBLANCE TO HALF A PANDA. IT ILST WHEN T KIDGE, MRS. WEASLEY WAS SAYING ANXIOUSLY, STANDING OVER FERMINE WITH HER HAND IN HER HAIR AND A COPY OF THE HEALER S HELP-MATE OPEN AT BRUISES, CUTS, AND ABRASIONS. THIS HAS ALWAYS WORKED BEFORE, I ILST CAN T UNDERSTAND IT. IT LL BE FRED AND GEORGE S IDEA OF A FLINDY INDEX, MAKING SURE IT CAN T COME OFF, SAID CINDY. BUT IT S GHT TO COME OFF? SHOOKED FERMINE. I CAN T BE AROUND LOOKING LIKE THIS FOREVER? YOU WHEN T, DEAR, WE LL FIND AN ANTIDOTE, BEN T WORRY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY SHEETHEINGLY. KILL THEM ME HOW FRED AND GEORGE ARE VERY AMUSING? SAID FLEUR, SMILING SERENELY. YES, I CAN HARDLY BREATHE FOR LAUGHING, SNAPPED FERMINE. SHE ILMPED UP AND STARTED WALKING AROUND AND AROUND THE KITCHEN, TWISTING HER FINGERS TOGETHER. MRS. WEASLEY, YOU RE WHITE, WHITE LIKE NEW HELLS HAVE ARRIVED THIS MORNING? YES, DEAR, I D HAVE NOTICED, SAID MRS. WEASLEY PATIENTLY. BUT IT S BARELY NINE, THERE S STILL PLENTY OF TIME. I KNOW I MESSED UP ANCIENT RINES, MUTTERED FERMINE FEVERISHLY. I DEFINITELY MADE AT LEAST ONE SERIOUS MISTRANSLATION, AND THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS PRACTICAL WAS NEH GOOD AT ALL. I THOUGHT TRANSFIGURATION WENT ALL RIGHT AT THE TIME, BUT LOOKING BACK FERMINE, WILL YOU SHUT UP, YOU RE NOT THE ONLY ONE WHO S NERVOUS? BARKED BEN. AND WHEN YOU VE GHT YOUR ELEVEN ELTSTANDING H.W.S. BEN T, BEN T, BEN T? SAID FERMINE, FLAPPING HER HANDS HYSTERICALLY. I KNOW I VE FAILED EVERYTHING? WHAT HAPPENS IF WE FAIL? FARRY ASKED THE THREE AT LARGE, BUT IT WAS AGAIN FERMINE WHO ANSWERED. WE DISCUSS OUR HOPEFULNESS WITH OUR HEAD

HE FELT, I ASKED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AT THE END OF LAST TERM.
HARRY'S STOMACH SHRILLED, HE WISHED HE HAD EATEN LESS BREAKFAST.

AT BREAKFAST, SAID FLEUR COMPLACENTLY, WE AD A DIFFERENT WAY
OF DOING THINGS, I THINK IT WAS BETTER. WE SAT OUR EXAMINATIONS
AFTER SIX YEARS OF STUDY, NOT FIVE, AND THEN FLEUR'S EARS WERE
DRENCHED IN A SCREAM. FERMINE WAS POINTING THROUGH THE KITCHEN
WINDOWS. THREE BLACK SPOTS WERE CLEARLY VISIBLE IN THE SKY,
GROWING LARGER ALL THE TIME. THEY'RE DEFINITELY HOGS, SAID REIN
HARSHLY, JUMPING UP THE HILL FERMINE AT THE WINDOWS. AND
THERE ARE THREE OF THEM, SAID HARRY, HASTENING THE HER EITHER SIDE.

ONE FOR EACH OF US, SAID FERMINE IN A TERRIFIED WHISPER. HE
NEE HE NEE HE NEE SHE GRIPPED BOTH HARRY AND REIN
TIGHTLY AROUND THE ELBOWS. THE HOGS WERE FLYING DIRECTLY AT THE
BLINDS, THREE HANDSOME TANNIES, EACH OF WHICH, IT BECAME CLEAR AS
THEY FLEW NEARER OVER THE PATH LEADING UP THE THE HILL, WAS
CARRYING A LARGE SQUARE ENVELOPE. HE NEE! SHRIEKED FERMINE.
MRS. WEASLEY SHRILLED PAST THEM AND OPENED THE KITCHEN WINDOWS.
ONE, TWO, THREE, THE HOGS SHARED THROUGH IT AND LANDED ON THE
TABLE IN A NEAT LINE. ALL THREE OF THEM LIFTED THEIR RIGHT LEGS.
HARRY MOVED FORWARD. THE LETTER ADDRESSED TO HIM WAS TIED TO THE
LEG OF THE HOG IN THE MIDDLE. HE LIFTED IT WITH FLIMBING FINGERS. TO
HIS LEFT, REIN WAS TRYING TO DETACH HIS OWN RESULTS; TO HIS RIGHT,
FERMINE'S HANDS WERE SHAKING SO MUCH SHE WAS MAKING HER
WHITE HOG TREMBLE. ANYBODY IN THE KITCHEN SPACE. AT LAST, HARRY
MANAGED TO DETACH THE ENVELOPE. HE SLIT IT OPEN QUICKLY AND
UNFOLDED THE PARCHMENT INSIDE. HARRY JAMES POTTER HAS ACHIEVED:
HARRY READ THE PARCHMENT THROUGH SEVERAL TIMES, HIS BREATHING
BECOMING EASIER WITH EACH READING. IT WAS ALL RIGHT: HE HAD ALWAYS
KNOWN THAT HE WOULD FAIL DIVINATION, AND HE HAD HAD NO CHANCE OF
PASSING HISTORY OF MAGIC, GIVEN THAT HE HAD COLLAPSED HALFWAY
THROUGH THE EXAMINATION, BUT HE HAD PASSED EVERYTHING ELSE: HE
RAN HIS FINGER DOWN THE GRADES HE HAD PASSED WELL IN
TRANSFIGURATION AND HERMELBY, HE HAD EVEN EXCEEDED
EXPECTATIONS AT POTIONS: AND BEST OF ALL, HE HAD ACHIEVED

STANDING AT DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS: HE LED
AROUND, FERMINE HAD HER BACK TO HIM AND HER HEAD BENT, BUT REIN
WAS BEING DELIGHTED. ONLY FAILED DIVINATION AND HISTORY OF
MAGIC, AND WHO CARES ABOUT THEM? HE SAID HAPPILY TO HARRY.

HERE SWAP HARRY GLANCED DOWN REIN'S GRADES: THERE WERE
 NO EIGHT STANDINGS THERE. DOWN SHE'D BE THEN AT DEFENSE
 AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, SAID REIN, PLUNGING HARRY IN THE
 SHOULDER. WE'RE DONE ALL RIGHT, HAVEN'T WE? WELL DONE! SAID
 MRS. WEASLEY FREELLY, RIPPING REIN'S HAIR. SEVEN EIGHTS, THAT'S
 MORE THAN FRED AND GEORGE GET TOGETHER! HERMION? SAID
 GINNY TENTATIVELY, FOR HERMION STILL HADN'T TURNED AROUND.
 SHE'D DO WELL HER? I HET BAD, SAID HERMION IN A SMALL VOICE.
 EH, CHEER UP IT, SAID REIN, STRIDING OVER THE HER AND WHIPPING
 HER RESULTS OUT OF HER HAND. YEP NINE EIGHT STANDINGS AND HERE
 EXCEEDS EXPECTATIONS AT DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS. HE
 LOOKED DOWN AT HER, HALF-AMUSED, HALF-EXASPERATED. SHE'S
 ACTUALLY DISAPPOINTED, AREN'T SHE? HERMION SHOOK HER HEAD, BUT
 HARRY LAUGHED. WELL, WE'RE DONE, STUDENT'S DONE! GRINNED REIN.
 MUM, ARE THERE ANY MORE SALISAGES? HARRY LOOKED BACK DOWN AT
 HIS RESULTS. THEY WERE AS GOOD AS HE COULD HAVE HOPED FOR, HE FELT
 JUST ONE TINY TWINGE OF REGRET. THIS WAS THE END OF HIS
 AMBITION THE BECOME AN ALUMNUS, HE HAD NOT SECURED THE REQUIRED
 FIFTH GRADE. HE HAD KNOWN ALL ALONG THAT HE WOULDN'T, BUT HE
 STILL FELT A SINKING IN HIS STOMACH AS HE LOOKED AGAIN AT THAT
 SMALL BLACK 2. IT WAS BAD, REALLY, SEEING THAT IT HAD BEEN A DRAKE
 LATER IN DISGUISE WHEN HAD FIRST THOUGHT HARRY HE WOULD MAKE A GOOD
 ALUMNUS, BUT SOMEHOW THE IDEA HAD TAKEN HOLD OF HIM, AND HE
 WOULDN'T REALLY THINK OF ANYTHING ELSE HE WOULD LIKE TO BE.
 NEVERTHELESS, IT HAD SEEMED THE RIGHT DESTINY FOR HIM SINCE HE HAD
 HEARD THE PROPHECY A FEW WEEKS AGO. NEITHER CAN LIVE WHILE THE
 OTHER SURVIVES. WOULDN'T HE BE LIVING UP TO THE PROPHECY, AND
 GIVING HIMSELF THE BEST CHANCE OF SURVIVAL, IF HE JOINED THESE
 HIGHLY TRAINED WIZARDS WHERE HE IT WAS TO FIND AND KILL
 VILDEBERT? DRACH & DETHUR HARRY REMAINED WITHIN THE CHAINS OF
 THE KILN'S GARDEN OVER THE NEXT FEW WEEKS. HE SPENT MOST OF
 HIS DAYS PLAYING TWEE-A-SIDE HILLOUTCH IN THE WEASLEY'S HERDARD (HE
 AND HERMION AGAINST REIN AND GINNY; HERMION WAS DREADFUL AND
 GINNY GOOD, SHE THEY WERE REASONABLY WELL MATCHED) AND HIS
 EVENINGS EATING TRIPLE HELPINGS OF EVERYTHING MRS. WEASLEY PUT
 IN FRONT OF HIM. IT WOULD HAVE BEEN A HAPPY, PEACEFUL HOLIDAY HAD
 IT NOT BEEN FOR THE STORIES OF DISAPPEARANCES, BAD ACCIDENTS, EVEN OF
 DEATHS NOW APPEARING ALMOST DAILY IN THE PROPHECY. SOMETIMES KILL

AND MR. WEASLEY BRING HOME NEWS BEFORE IT EVEN REACHED THE
PAPER. THE MRS. WEASLEY'S DISPLEASURE, HARRY'S SIXTEENTH BIRTHDAY
CELEBRATIONS WERE MARRED BY GRISLY TIDINGS BRING THE PARTY BY
REMUS LUPIN, WHO WAS LOOKING CALM AND GRIM, HIS REDDISH HAIR
STREAKED LIBERALLY WITH GRAY, HIS CLOTHES WERE RAGGED AND PATCHED
THAN EVER. THERE HAVE BEEN ANOTHER PEOPLE OF DEMENTOR
ATTACKS. HE ANNOUNCED, AS MRS. WEASLEY PASSED HIM A LARGE SLICE OF
BIRTHDAY CAKE. AND THEY WERE FEELING THEIR DEMENTORS' SKEIN IN A
SHADE OF WHITE. THE DARK MARK HAD BEEN SET EVER IT WELL,
FRANKLY, I'M SURPRISED HE STAYED ALIVE FOR EVEN A YEAR AFTER
DESERVING THE DEATH PENALTY. SIRIUS'S BROTHER, REGULUS, ONLY
MANAGED A FEW DAYS AS FAR AS I CAN REMEMBER. YES, WELL, SAID MRS.
WEASLEY, FRETTERING. PERHAPS WE SHOULD TALK ABOUT SOMETHING DIFF

DID YOU HEAR ABOUT HERMAN GRIMSHAW, REMUS? ASKED BILL,
WHO WAS BEING FLIED WITH WINE BY FLEUR. THE MAN WHO RAN
THE ICE-CREAM PLACE IN DIAGON ALLEY? HARRY INTERRUPTED,
WITH AN UNPLEASANT, BUBBLING SENSATION IN THE PIT OF HIS STOMACH.
HE USED TO GIVE ME FREE ICE CREAMS, WHAT'S HAPPENED TO HIM?
DROGGED OFF, BY THE LOOK OF HIS FACE. WHY? ASKED RENN, WHILE
MRS. WEASLEY PHINTEDLY GLARED AT BILL. WHO KNOWS? HE MUST BE
LAPSET THEM SOMEHOW. HE WAS A GOOD MAN, HERMAN. TALKING OF
DIAGON ALLEY, SAID MR. WEASLEY, LOOKS LIKE HELLIVANDER'S GONE
THEN. THE HANDMAKER? SAID GINNY, LOOKING STARTLED. THAT'S THE
ONE, SHEEP'S EMPTY, NO SIGN OF A STRUGGLE, NO ONE KNOWS WHETHER
HE LEFT VOLUNTARILY OR WAS KIDNAPPED. BUT WANDS WHAT DO
PEOPLE DO FOR WANDS? THEY DO MAKE DO WITH OTHER MAKERS, SAID
LUPIN. BUT HELLIVANDER WAS THE BEST, AND IF THE OTHER SIDE HAVE
GOT HIM IT'S NOT THE GOOD FOR US. THE DAY AFTER THIS RATHER
GLEAMY BIRTHDAY TEA, THEIR LETTERS AND BIRTHLISTS ARRIVED FROM
HOGWARTS. HARRY'S INCLUDED A SURPRISE: HE HAD BEEN MADE
SLUDGITCH CAPTAIN. THAT GIVES YOU FULL STATUS WITH PROFESSORS
CRIES HERMIONE HAPPILY. YOU CAN USE YOUR SPECIAL BATHROOM NOW
AND EVERYTHING! WELL, I REMEMBER WHEN CHARLIE WORE ONE OF
THESE, SAID RENN, EXAMINING THE BADGE WITH GLEE. HARRY, THIS IS THE
ONE, YOU'RE MY CAPTAIN IF YOU LET ME BACK IN THE TEAM, I
SWOON, HA HA. WELL, I DON'T SWOON WE CAN PUT OFF A TRIP
TO DIAGON ALLEY MUCH LONGER NOW YOU'VE GOT THESE, SIGHED MRS.
WEASLEY, LOOKING DOWN RENN'S BIRTHLIST. WE'LL GO ON SATURDAY AS

BEING AS YOUR FATHER DOESN'T HAVE THE CAR ANYMORE AGAIN, I'M NOT
GOING THERE WITHOUT HIM. MUM, DO YOU HONESTLY THINK YOU
DON'T WANT TO BE HIDING BEHIND A KITCHEN SINK IN FLORISS-
AND-KRISTY'S SNIGGERED THEN. FORTESCUE AND HOLLIVANDER WENT FOR
HOLIDAY, DID THEY? SAID MRS. LEASLEY, FIRING UP AT HER. IF YOU
THINK SECURITY'S A LAUGHING MATTER YOU CAN STAY BEHIND AND I'LL
GET YOUR THINGS MYSELF. NO, I WANT THEM, I WANT THE SEE-FRED
AND GEORGE'S SHIP! SAID BEN HASTILY. THEN YOU JUST KICK UP
YOUR IDEAS, YOUNG MAN, BECAUSE I DECIDE YOU'RE TOO IMPATIENT TO COME
WITH US! SAID MRS. LEASLEY ANGRILY, SNATCHING UP HER CLOAK, ALL
NINE HANDS OF WHICH WERE STILL POINTING AT MENTAL PERIL, AND
BALANCING IT ON THE OF A PILE OF JUST-LANDERED TOWELS. AND THAT
Goes FOR RETURNING THE FIVEWARTS AS WELL! BEN TURNED THE STARE
INCREDULOUSLY AT HARRY AS HIS MOTHER HUSTLED THE LAUNDRY BASKET
AND THE TEETERING CLOAK INTO HER ARMS AND STORMED OUT THE
DOOR. CLIMBY YOU CAN'T EVEN MAKE A HOLE HERE ANYMORE.

BUT BEN WAS CAREFUL NOT TO BE FLIPPANT ABOUT VENDORMENT EVER
THE NEXT FEW DAYS, SATURDAY DAWNED WITHOUT ANY MORE HOSTILITIES
FROM MRS. LEASLEY, THOUGH SHE SEEMED VERY TENSE AT BREAKFAST. KILL,
WHO WOULD BE STAYING AT HOME WITH YOUR MUM THE FERMINE AND
GINNY'S PLEASURE, PASSED A FULL MONEY BAG ACROSS THE TABLE TO
HARRY. WHERE'S MINE? DEMANDED BEN AT ONCE, HIS EYES WIDE.

THAT'S ALREADY HARRY'S, IDIOT, SAID KILL. I GOT IT FROM YOUR
VALIANT FOR YOU, HARRY, BECAUSE IT'S TAKING ABOUT FIVE HOURS FOR THE
PUBLIC TO GET THE THEIR CAR AT THE MOMENT, THE GELINS HAVE
TIGHTENED SECURITY SEE MUM. TWO DAYS AGO ARDIE PHILPOTT HAD A
PROBITY PROBE STICK UP HIS. WELL, TRUST ME, THIS WAS EASIER.

THANKS, KILL, SAID HARRY, PICKETING HIS CAR. IT IS ALWAYS SEE
THOUGHTFUL, PLANNED YOUR ADHERINGLY, STRENGTH KILL'S NEAR. GINNY
MIMED VOMITTING INTO HER CEREAL BEHIND YOUR, HARRY CHECKED OVER
HIS CHEEKLINES, AND BEN THUMPED HIM ON THE BACK. IT WAS AN
EVERCAST, MURDER DAY, HERE OF THE SPECIAL MINISTRY OF MAGIC CARS, IN
WHICH HARRY HAD RIDDEN ONCE BEFORE, WAS AWAITING THEM IN THE
FRONT YARD WHEN THEY EMERGED FROM THE HOUSE, PULLING ON THEIR
COATS. IT'S GOOD DAD CAN GET US THESE AGAIN, SAID BEN
APPRECIATIVELY, STRETCHING LUKERILLY AS THE CAR MOVED SILENTLY
AWAY FROM THE CURTAIN, KILL AND YOUR WAVING FROM THE KITCHEN
WINDOW. HE, HARRY, FERMINE, AND GINNY WERE ALL SITTING IN

REEMER CHIMPANT IN THE WIDE BACKSEAT. BEEN T GET USED TH IT, IT S ONLY
BECAUSE OF HARRY. SAID MR. LEASLEY OVER HIS SHOULDER. HE AND
MRS. LEASLEY WERE IN FRONT WITH THE MINISTRY DRIVER. THE FRONT
PASSENGER SEAT HAD BEINGLY STRETCHED INTO WHAT RESEMBLED A TWO-
SEATER SEAT. HE S BEEN GIVEN THE-GRADE SECURITY STATUS. AND WE LL
BE BEHIND UP WITH ADDITIONAL SECURITY AT THE LEADY CALIBREIN
THE. HARRY SAID NOTHING. HE DID NOT MUCH FANCY BEING HIS
SHIPPING WHILE SURROUNDED BY A BATTALION OF SOLDIERS. HE HAD
STEALING HIS INVISIBILITY CHARM IN HIS BACKPACK AND FELT THAT, IF THAT
WAS GOOD ENOUGH FOR DUMBLEDORE, IT MIGHT BE GOOD ENOUGH FOR
THE MINISTRY, THOUGH WHEN HE CAME TO THINK OF IT, HE WAS NOT SURE
THE MINISTRY WOULD ACCEPT HIS CHARM. THERE YET ARE, THEN, SAID THE
DRIVER, A SURPRISINGLY SHORT WHILE LATER, SPEAKING FOR THE FIRST
TIME AS HE STEPPED IN LEAVING CROSS ROAD AND STOPPED BESIDE THE
LEADY CALIBREIN. I M THE LAST FOR YET, ANY IDEA HOW LONG YET LL
BE? A COUPLE OF HOURS, I EXPECT, SAID MR. LEASLEY. OH, GOOD,
HE S HERE. HARRY IMITATED MR. LEASLEY AND PEERED THROUGH THE
WINDOW. HIS HEART LEAPT. THERE WERE NO SOLDIERS WAITING BESIDE
THE INN, BUT INSTEAD THE GIGANTIC, BLACK-BEARDED FORM OF RUKKUS
HAGRID, THE HOGWARTS GAMEKEEPER, WEARING A LONG BEAVERSKIN
COAT, BEARING AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY S FACE AND BELIEVING THE
STARTLED STARES OF PASSING MUGGLES. HARRY. HE WHIMPERED, SLEEPING
HARRY INTO A BONE-CRUSHING HUG THE MOMENT HARRY HAD STOPPED
BESIDE THE CAR. BUCKLE UP WITHERWINGS, I MEAN YET SHOULD
SEE HIM, HARRY, HE S SH HAPPY TO BE BACK IN THE OPEN AIR

GLAD HE S PLEASED, SAID HARRY, GRINNING AS HE MASSAGED HIS RIBS.
WE DIDN T KNOW SECURITY MEANT YET. I KNOW, ITS LIKE OLD
TIMES, INNT? SEE, THE MINISTRY WANTED TO SEND A CLUNCH OF SOLDIERS,
BUT DUMBLEDORE SAID I D BE. SAID HAGRID PROBABLY, TRIPPING BESIDE HIS
CHEST AND TAPPING HIS THUMBS INTO HIS POCKETS. LET S GET GOIN
THEN AFTER YET, MERRY, ARTHUR THE LEADY CALIBREIN WAS,
FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HARRY S MEMORY, COMPLETELY EMPTY. ONLY THEM
THE LANDLORD, WIZENED AND TEETHLESS, REMAINED OF THE OLD CREW. HE
BEHEADED UP HOPPEFULLY AS THEY ENTERED, BUT BEFORE HE COULD SPEAK,
HAGRID SAID IMPERTINENTLY, ITS PASSIN THROUGH TODAY, THEM, SURE
YET UNDERSTAND, HOGWARTS BUSINESS, YET KNOW. THEM NEEDED
GENTLY AND RETURNED THE WIPING GLASSES. HARRY, FERMINE,
HAGRID, AND THE LEASLEYS WALKED THROUGH THE BAR AND INTO THE

THE CHILLY LITTLE COURTYARD AT THE BACK WHERE THE BUSTS STOOD, HARRY RAISED HIS PINK UMBRELLA AND TAPPED A CERTAIN BRICK IN THE WALL, WHICH OPENED AT ONCE THE FIRM AN ARCHWAY INTO A WINDING CROOKED STREET. THEY STEPPED THROUGH THE ENTRANCE AND PAUSED, BREATHING AROUND. DIAGONAL ALLEY HAD CHANGED. THE CROOKED, GLITTERING WINDOW DISPLAYS OF SPELLBOOKS, POTIONS INGREDIENTS, AND CALIBRENS WERE LOST THE VIEW, HIDDEN BEHIND THE LARGE MINISTRY OF MAGIC POSTERS THAT HAD BEEN PASTED OVER THEM. MOST OF THESE SUMMER PINK POSTERS CARRIED BROWN-LIP VERSIONS OF THE SECURITY ADVICE ON THE MINISTRY PAMPHLETS THAT HAD BEEN SENT OUT OVER THE SUMMER, BUT OTHERS WERE MOVING BLACK-AND-WHITE PHOTOGRAPHS OF DEATH EATERS DOWN THE REAR THE HOUSE. BELLATRIX LESTRANGE WAS SNEERING FROM THE FRONT OF THE NEAREST APOTHECARY. A FEW WINDOWS WERE SHUT UP, INCLUDING THOSE OF FLEURBAUM FORTESCUE'S ICE CREAM PARLOR. ON THE OTHER HAND, A NUMBER OF STARKY-BREATHING STALLS HAD SPRUNG UP ALONG THE STREET. THE NEAREST ONE, WHICH HAD BEEN ERECTED HALF-SIDE FLEURISH AND BLETTS, UNDER A STRIPED, STAINED AWNING, HAD A CARDBOARD SIGN PINNED TO ITS FRONT: A SPOOKY-BREATHING LITTLE WIZARD WAS RATTLING ARMFULS OF SILVER SYMBOLS ON CHAINS AT PASSERSBY. ONE HER YELLOW LITTLE GIRL, MADAM? HE CALLED AT MRS. WEASLEY AS THEY PASSED, LOOKING AT GINNY. PROTECT HER PRETTY NECK? IF I WERE ON DUTY SAID MR. WEASLEY, GLARING ANGRILY AT THE AMULET SELLER. YES, BUT THEN I'VE ARRESTING ANYONE NEW, DEAR, WE'RE IN A HURRY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, NERVOUSLY CONSULTING A LIST. I THINK WE'D BETTER GO MADAM MALDIN'S FIRST, HERMIONE WANTS NEW DRESS MAKES, AND RON'S SHOWING MUCH MORE MUCH ANKLE IN HIS SCHOOL MAKES, AND YELL MUST NEED NEW SHOES THEM, HARRY, YELL'VE GROWN SO MUCH CHEER UP, EVERYONE MERRY, IT DOESN'T MAKE SENSE FOR ALL OF US TO GO TO MADAM MALDIN'S, SAID MR. WEASLEY. WHY THEN I THOSE THREE GO WITH HARRY, AND WE CAN GO TO FLEURISH AND BLETTS AND GET EVERYONE'S SCHOOLBOOKS? I DON'T KNOW, SAID MRS. WEASLEY ANXIOUSLY, CLEARLY TORN BETWEEN A DESIRE TO FINISH THE SHOPPING QUICKLY AND THE WISH TO STICK TOGETHER IN A PACK. HARRY, DO YOU THINK? THEN FRET, THEY'LL BE FINE WITH ME, MERRY, SAID HARRY SEETHINGLY, WAVING AN AIRY HAND THE SIZE OF A BUSTIN LIP. MRS. WEASLEY DID NOT SEEM ENTIRELY CONVINCED, BUT ALLOWED THE SEPARATION, SLURPING OFF TOWARD FLEURISH AND BLETTS WITH HER HUSBAND AND GINNY WHILE HARRY,

RENN, FERMINE, AND HAGRID SET OFF FOR MADAM MALDIN'S. HARRY
NOTICED THAT MANY OF THE PEOPLE WHO PASSED THEM HAD THE SAME
HARRIED, ANXIOUS LOOK AS MRS. WEASLEY, AND THAT NEKKO WAS
STAPPING THE TALK ANOTHER. THE SHOPPERS STAYED TOGETHER IN THEIR
ELN TIGHTLY KNIT CLOTHES, MOVING INTENTLY ABOUT THEIR BUSINESS.
NEKKO SEEMED THE BE SHOPPING ALONE. MIGHT BE A KIT OF A SHEPHERD
IN THERE WITH ALL OF US. SAID HAGRID, STAPPING ELTIDE MADAM
MALDIN'S AND BENDING DOWN THE PEER THROUGH THE WINDOW. I LL
STAND GUARD ELTIDE, ALL RIGHT? SHE HARRY, RENN, AND FERMINE
ENTERED THE LITTLE SHOP TOGETHER. IT APPEARED, AT FIRST GLANCE, THE BE
EMPTY, BUT SHE SEEMER HAD THE DOOR SLING SLIT BEHIND THEM THAN
THEY HEARD A FAMILIAR VOICE ISSUING FROM BEHIND A RACK OF DRESS
BOOKS IN SPANGLED GREEN AND BLUE. NOT A CHILD, IN CASE YOU
HAVEN'T NOTICED, MOTHER, I AM PERFECTLY CAPABLE OF DOING MY
SHOPPING ALONE. THERE WAS A CLICKING NOISE AND A VOICE HARRY
RECOGNIZED AS THAT OF MADAM MALDIN, THE ELDER, SAID, WELL, DEAR,
YOUR MOTHER'S ELITE RIGHT, NONE OF US IS SUPPOSED TO BE
WANDERING AROUND IN OUR OWN ANOTHER, IT'S NOTHING THE BE WITH
BEING A CHILD. WATCH WHERE YOU'RE STICKING THAT PIN, WILL
YOU? A TEENAGE BOY WITH A PALE, PAINTED FACE AND WHITE-BLOND HAIR
APPEARED FROM BEHIND THE RACK, WEARING A HANDSOME SET OF DARK
GREEN BOOKS THAT GLITTERED WITH PINS AROUND THE HEM AND THE EDGES
OF THE SLEEVES. HE STRODE TO THE MIRROR AND EXAMINED HIMSELF. IT
WAS A FEW MOMENTS BEFORE HE NOTICED HARRY, RENN, AND FERMINE
REFLECTED OVER HIS SHOULDER. HIS LIGHT GRAY EYES NARROWED. IF
YOU'RE WANDERING WHAT THE SMELL IS, MOTHER, A MILDLY ILT
WALKED IN. SAID DRACE MALPHY. I DON'T THINK THERE'S ANY NEED FOR
LADENLACK LIKE THAT. SAID MADAM MALDIN, SLIPPING ELT FROM
BEHIND THE CLOTHES RACK HOLDING A TAPE MEASURE AND A LARD. AND I
DON'T WANT HANDS DRAGN IN MY SHOP EITHER. SHE ADDED HASTILY, FOR
A GLANCE TOWARD THE DOOR HAD SEEN HER HARRY AND RENN BOTH
STANDING THERE WITH THEIR HANDS ELT AND POINTING AT MALPHY.
FERMINE, WHO WAS STANDING SLIGHTLY BEHIND THEM, WHISPERED, SHE
DON'T, HONESTLY, IT'S NOT WORTH IT. YES, LIKE YOU'D DARE BE
MAGIC ELT OF SHELL, SNEERED MALPHY. WHO BLANDED YOUR EYE,
GRANGER? I WANT TO SEND THEM FLOWERS. THAT'S ELITE ENOUGH.
SAID MADAM MALDIN SHARPLY, LOOKING OVER HER SHOULDER FOR
SLIPPER. MADAM PLEASE NARCISSA MALPHY STROLLED ELT

FROM BEHIND THE CLOTHES RACK. PLUT THESE AWAY, SHE SAID CHILDLY THE
 HARRY AND REIN. IF YOU ATTACK MY SHIP AGAIN, I SHALL ENSURE THAT
 IT IS THE LAST THING YOU EVER DO. REALLY? SAID HARRY, TAKING A
 STEP FORWARD AND GAZING INTO THE SMUGGLEDLY ARROGANT FACE THAT,
 FOR ALL ITS PALLOR, STILL RESEMBLED HER SISTER S. HE WAS AS TALL AS SHE
 WAS NEEL. GOING TO GET A FEW DEATH LATER PALS THE DEE LIS IN, ARE
 YOU? MADAM MALDIN SMILED AND CLUTCHED AT HER HEART. REALLY,
 YOU SHOULDNT ACCUSE DANGEROUSLY THING THE SAY HANDS AWAY,
 PLEASE? BUT HARRY DID NOT LOWER HIS HAND. NARCISSA MALDIN SMILED
 UNPLEASANTLY. I SEE THAT KING DUMKEDDRE S FAVORITE HAS GIVEN
 YOU A FALSE SENSE OF SECURITY. HARRY PITTER, BUT DUMKEDDRE WENT
 ALWAYS BE THERE TO PROTECT YOU. HARRY SMILED MEERKINGLY ALL
 AROUND THE SHIP. WHEN LOOK AT THAT HE S NOT HERE NEEL? SHE
 WHY NOT HAVE A GO? THEY MIGHT BE ABLE TO FIND YOU A DOUBLE CELL IN
 AZERKAN WITH YOUR LIESER OF A HUSBAND? MALDIN MADE AN ANGRY
 MOVEMENT TOWARD HARRY, BUT STUMBLER OVER HIS EVERLIVING REEK.
 REIN LAUGHED LOUDLY. DONT YOU DARE TALK TO MY MOTHER LIKE THAT,
 PITTER? MALDIN SNARLED. IT S ALL RIGHT, GRACE, SAID NARCISSA,
 RESTRAINING HIM WITH HER THIN WHITE FINGERS UPON HIS SHOULDER.

I EXPECT PITTER WILL BE REUNITED WITH DEAR SIRILIS BEFORE I AM
 REUNITED WITH ELILIS. HARRY RAISED HIS HAND HIGHER. HARRY,
 NEEL MEANED HERMINE, GRABBING HIS ARM AND ATTEMPTING TO PULL
 IT DOWN BY HIS SIDE. THINK. YOU LISTEN T. YOU LL BE IN SUCH
 TROUBLE. MADAM MALDIN DITHERED FOR A MOMENT IN THE SPLIT,
 THEN SEEMED TO DECIDE TO ACT AS THOUGH NOTHING WAS HAPPENING IN
 THE HOPE THAT IT WOULDNT. SHE WENT TOWARD MALDIN, WHO WAS STILL
 GLARING AT HARRY. I THINK THIS LEFT SLEEVE COULD COME UP A LITTLE
 BIT MORE, DEAR, LET ME JUST HELIX? KILLED MALDIN, SLAPPING
 HER HAND AWAY. WATCH WHERE YOU ARE PUTTING YOUR PINS, WERDAN?
 MOTHER I DONT THINK I WANT THESE ANYMORE HE PULLED THE
 REEKS OVER HIS HEAD AND THREW THEM INTO THE FLOOR AT MADAM
 MALDIN S FEET. YOU ARE RIGHT, GRACE, SAID NARCISSA, WITH A
 CONTEMPTUOUS GLANCE AT HERMINE. NEEL I KNOW THE KIND OF SLIM
 THAT SHEEPS HERE. WE LL BE BETTER AT TWILFITT AND TATTING S.
 AND WITH THAT, THE PAIR OF THEM STRODE OUT OF THE SHIP, MALDIN
 TAKING CARE TO BANG AS HARD AS HE COULD INTO REIN WHEN THE WAY WENT.

WELL, REALLY? SAID MADAM MALDIN, SNATCHING UP THE FALLEN REEKS
 AND MOVING THE TIP OF HER HAND OVER THEM LIKE A VACUUM CLEANER,

SEE THAT IT REMOVED ALL THE BLIST. SHE WAS DISTRACTED ALL THROUGHOUT THE
FITTING OF RHEIN S AND FARRY S NEW SHOES, TRIED THE SELL FERMINE
WIZARD S DRESS SHOES INSTEAD OF WITCH S, AND WHEN SHE FINALLY KNEWED
THEM WELL OF THE SHOE IT WAS WITH AN AIR OF BEING GLAD TO SEE THE
BACK OF THEM. GET BY ANYTHING? ASKED FARRID KNIGHTLY WHEN THEY
REAPPEARED AT HIS SIDE. JUST ABOUT, SAID FARRY. DID YOU SEE THE
MAGNETS? YES, SAID FARRID, UNCONSCIOUSLY. BUT THEY WOULD
DARK MAKE TRICKLE IN THE MIDDLE OF DIAGONAL ALLEY, FARRY, THEN
WHY ABOUT THEM. FARRY, RHEIN, AND FERMINE EXCHANGED LOOKS,
BUT BEFORE THEY COULD DISABUSE FARRID OF THIS COMFORTABLE NOTION,
MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY AND GINNY APPEARED, ALL CLUTCHING HEAVY
PACKAGES OF SHOES. EVERYTHING ALL RIGHT? SAID MRS. WEASLEY. GET
YOUR SHOES? RIGHT THEN, WE CAN STOP IN AT THE APOTHECARY AND
REPAIRS ON THE WAY TO FRED AND GEORGE S. STICK CLOSE, NOW.
NEITHER FARRY NOR RHEIN RECOGNIZED ANY INGREDIENTS AT THE
APOTHECARY, SEEING THAT THEY WERE NO LONGER STUDYING POTIONS,
BUT RATHER RECOGNIZED LARGE BOXES OF NEW SLITS FOR FRED AND
PICKERING AT REPAIRS FOR EMERILY. THEN, WITH MRS. WEASLEY
CHECKING HER WATCH EVERY MINUTE FOR HER, THEY HEADED FARTHER ALONG
THE STREET IN SEARCH OF WEASLEY S WIZARD SHOES, THE THREE SHOE
OWN BY FRED AND GEORGE. WE REALLY HAVEN T GET THE LINE, MRS.
WEASLEY SAID. SEE WE LL JUST HAVE A QUICK LOOK AROUND AND THEN
BACK TO THE CAR, WE MUST BE CLOSE, THAT S NUMBER NINETY-TWO
NINETY-FOUR. WEHA, SAID RHEIN, STOPPING IN HIS TRACKS. SET
AGAINST THE BLIND, PASTER-MOUNTED SHOE PRINTS AROUND THEM, FRED
AND GEORGE S WHEELS HIT THE EYE LIKE A FIREWORK DISPLAY. CASUAL
PASSERSBY WERE LOOKING BACK OVER THEIR SHOULDERS AT THE WHEELS,
AND A FEW RATHER STUNNED-LOOKING PEOPLE HAD ACTUALLY COME TO A
HALT, TRANSFIXED. THE LEFT-HAND WHEEL WAS DAZZLINGLY FLAMING AN
ASSORTMENT OF COLORS THAT REVOLVED, PULSED, FLASHED, REBOLLED, AND
SPARKED; FARRY S EYES BEGAN TO WATER JUST LOOKING AT IT. THE
RIGHT-HAND WHEEL WAS COVERED WITH A GIANTIC PASTER, PURPLE
LIKE THOSE OF THE MINISTRY, BUT EMBELLISHED WITH FLASHING YELLOW
LETTERS: FARRY STARTED TO LAUGH, HE HEARD A WEAK SORT OF MEAN
RESIDE HIM AND LOOKED AROUND TO SEE MRS. WEASLEY GAZING,
BLINKING, AT THE PASTER. HER LIPS MOVED SILENTLY, MELTING THE
NAME LINDY-PEE. THEY LL BE MURDERED IN THEIR BEDS! SHE
WHISPERED. NO THEY WENT TO! SAID RHEIN, WHO, LIKE FARRY, WAS

LAUGHING. THIS IS BRILLIANT! AND HE AND HARRY LED THE WAY INTO THE SHOP. IT WAS PACKED WITH CUSTOMERS; HARRY COULD NOT GET NEAR THE SHELVES. HE STARED AROUND, LEERING UP AT THE BOOKS POILED THE CEILING; THERE WERE THE SOUVENIR SNACKBOOKS THAT THE TWINS HAD PERFECTED DURING THEIR LAST, UNFINISHED YEAR AT HOGWARTS; HARRY NOTICED THAT THE OVERSIZED WHEAT WAS MOST POPULAR, WITH ONLY ONE BATTERED ONE LEFT ON THE SHELF. THERE WERE KIDS ALL OF TRICK WANDS, THE CHEAPEST MERELY TURNING INTO BLACKER CHICKENS OR PAIRS OF BRIEFS WHEN WAVED, THE MOST EXPENSIVE BEATING THE LUNAR LENS AROUND THE HEAD AND NECK, AND BOOKS OF SPELLS, WHICH CAME IN SELF-INDULGENCE, SPELL-CHUCKING, AND SMARTANSWER VARIETIES. A SPACE CLEARED IN THE CROWD, AND HARRY PUSHED HIS WAY TOWARD THE COUNTER, WHERE A CACGLE OF DELIGHTED TEN-YEAR-OLDS WAS WATCHING A TINY LITTLE WOODEN MAN SLOWLY ASCENDING THE STEPS TO A REAL SET OF CALLIGRAPHY, KEITH PERCHED ON A BOOK THAT READ: RELIABLE

HANGMAN SPELL IT FOR ME AS SWINE! PATENTED DAYDREAM CHARMS HERMIONE HAD MANAGED TO SNEEZE THROUGH THE A LARGE DISPLAY NEAR THE COUNTER AND WAS READING THE INFORMATION ON THE BACK OF A BOOK BEARING A HIGHLY CHARMED PICTURE OF A HANDSOME YOUTH AND A SMILING GIRL WHO WERE STANDING ON THE DECK OF A PIRATE SHIP. ONE SIMPLE INCANTATION AND YOU WILL ENTER A TEMPORALITY, HIGHLY REALISTIC, THIRTY-MINUTE DAYDREAM, EASY TO FIT INTO THE AVERAGE SCHOOL LESSON AND VIRTUALLY UNDETECTABLE (SIDE EFFECTS INCLUDE VACANT EXPRESSION AND MINOR DREAMING). NOT FOR SALE THE UNDER-SIXTEENS. YOU KNOW, SAID HERMIONE, LEERING UP AT HARRY, THAT REALLY IS EXTRAORDINARY MAGIC! FOR THAT, HERMIONE, SAID A VOICE BEHIND THEM, YOU CAN HAVE ONE FOR FREE. A BEAMING FRED STOOD BEFORE THEM, WEARING A SET OF MAGENTA BOOKS THAT CLASHED MAGNIFICENTLY WITH HIS FLAMING HAIR. HOW ARE YOU, HARRY? THEY SHOOK HANDS. AND WHAT IS HAPPENING TO YOUR EYE, HERMIONE? YOUR POKING TELESCOPE, SHE SAID BLISSFULLY. OH KIDNEY, I FORGOT ABOUT THESE, SAID FRED. THERE HE PULLED A TINY BOLT OF HIS POCKET AND HANDED IT TO HER; SHE UNSCREWED IT GINGERLY TO REVEAL A THICK YELLOW PASTE. JUST DO IT NOW, THAT BRUISE IS BE GONE WITHIN THE HOUR, SAID FRED. WE HAD TO FIND A DECENT BRUISE REMOVER. WE'RE TESTING MOST OF OUR PRODUCTS ON OURSELVES. HERMIONE LOOKED NERVOUS. IT IS SAFE, ISN'T IT? SHE ASKED.

COURSE IT IS, SAID FRED GRACIOUSLY. COME ON, HARRY, I'LL GIVE YOU A

THEIR. HARRY LEFT FERMINE DARNING HER BLACK EYE WITH PASTE AND
FOLLOWED FRED TOWARD THE BACK OF THE SHOP, WHERE HE SAW A STAND OF
CARD AND RUBE TRICKS. MISCLE MAGIC TRICKS! SAID FRED HAPPILY,
PHINTING THEM OUT. HER FEELS LIKE DAD, YELL DNEH, WEH LEEV
MISCLE STUFF. IT S NEET A BIG EARNER, BUT WE DE FAIRLY STEADY
BUSINESS, THEY RE GREAT NEVELTIES. EH, HERE S GEORGE. FRED S
TWIN STHEH HARRY S HAND ENERGETICALLY. GIVING HIM THE THEIR?
LEH THROUGH THE BACK, HARRY, THAT S WHERE WE RE MAKING THE
REAL MONEY. PICKET ANYTHING, YELL, AND YELL LL PAY IN MORE THAN
CALLERS! HE ADDED WARNINGLY THE A SMALL KEY WEH HASTILY WHIPPED
HIS HAND OUT OF THE TIE LABELED DIBBLE DARD MARKS
THEY LL MAKE ANYONE SICK! GEORGE PULSED BACK A CURTAIN
RESIDE THE MISCLE TRICKS AND HARRY SAW A DARKER, LESS CROWDED
RHEH. THE PACKAGING ON THE PRODUCTS LINING THESE SHELVES WAS
MORE SLEEKED. WE VE IUST DEVELOPED THIS MORE SERIOUS LINE, SAID
FRED. FLINDY EH IT HAPPENED. YELL WHELDN T BELIEVE EH
MANY PEOPLE, EVEN PEOPLE WEH WORK AT THE MINISTRY, CAN T DE A
DECENT SHIELD CHARM, SAID GEORGE. CHELISE, THEY DIDN T HAVE YELL
TEACHING THEM, HARRY. THAT S RIGHT. WELL, WE THUGHT SHIELD
HATS WERE A BIT OF A LAUGH, YELL DNEH, CHALLENGE YELLR MATE THE IIND
YELL WHILE WEARING IT AND WATCH HIS FACE WHEN THE IIND IUST
RELINES OFF, BUT THE MINISTRY RELIGHT FIVE HUNDRED PER ALL ITS
SLIPPERT STAFF! AND WE RE STILL GETTING MASSIVE ORDERS! SEE WE VE
EXPANDED INTO A RANGE OF SHIELD CHARM, SHIELD CLOVES. I
MEAN, THEY WHELDN T HELP MUCH AGAINST THE UNTHREIVABLE CURSES,
BUT PER MINER THE MODERATE FEELS PER IINDS. AND THEN WE
THOUGHT WE D GET INTO THE WEHLE AREA OF DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK
ARTS, BECAUSE IT S SUCH A MONEY SPINNER, CONTINUED GEORGE
ENTHUSIASTICALLY. THIS IS CHEH, LHEH, INSTANT DARKNESS PHELDER,
WE RE IMPERTING IT FROM PERL, HARRY IF YELL WANT THE MAKE A HELIX
ESCAPE. AND ELIR DEEH DETHNATERS ARE IUST WALKING OFF THE
SHELVES, LHEH, SAID FRED, PHINTING AT A NUMBER OF WEIRD-LEHNG
BLACK FERN-TYPE ERIETS THAT WERE INDEED ATTEMPTING THE SLURRY OUT
OF SIGHT. YELL IUST DROP ONE SLURPTITHILLY AND IT LL RUN OFF AND
MAKE A NICE LEHD NEISE OUT OF SIGHT, GIVING YELL A DIVERSION IF YELL
NEED ONE. HARRY, SAID HARRY, IMPRESSED. HERE, SAID GEORGE,
CATCHING A CHIPLE AND THREWING THEM THE HARRY, A YELING WICH
WITH SHORT BLONDE HAIR PEEKED HER HEAD AROUND THE CURTAIN!

FARRY SAW THAT SHE THEN WAS WEARING MAGENTA STAFF SHORTS.

THERE'S A CUSTOMER OUT HERE WHEEDLING FOR A BODE CALIBREIN, MR. WEASLEY AND MR. WEASLEY, SHE SAID, FARRY FEELING IT VERY HOT THE HEAR FRED AND GEORGE CALLED MR. WEASLEY, BUT THEY THREW IT IN THEIR STRIDE. RIGHT WELL ARE, VERITY, I'M HEARING, SAID GEORGE PROMPTLY. FARRY, WELL HELP YOURSELF THE ANYTHING WELL WANT, ALL RIGHT? NO CHARGE. I CAN'T SEE THAT! SAID FARRY, WHO HAD ALREADY PULLED OUT HIS MONEY BAG THE DAY FOR THE DEEDY DETERMINATIONS. WELL BEEN T PAY HERE, SAID FRED FIRMLY, WAVING AWAY FARRY'S COIN, BUT

WELL GAVE US OUR START-UP LEAD, WE HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN, SAID GEORGE STERNLY. TAKE WHATEVER WELL LIKE, AND JUST REMEMBER THE TELL PEOPLE WHERE WELL GET IT, IF THEY ASK. GEORGE SWEEP OFF THROUGH THE CURTAIN THE HELP WITH THE CUSTOMERS, AND FRED LED FARRY BACK INTO THE MAIN PART OF THE SHOP THE FIND HERMINE AND GINNY STILL PHIRING OVER THE PATENTED DADDREAM CHAIRS. HAVEN'T WELL GIRLS FEELING OUR SPECIAL WUNDERWITCH PRODUCTIONS YET? ASKED FRED. FELLOW ME, LADIES. NEAR THE WINDOW WAS AN ARRAY OF VIBRANTLY PINK PRODUCTIONS AROUND WHICH A CLUSTER OF EXCITED GIRLS WAS GIGGLING ENTHUSIASTICALLY. HERMINE AND GINNY KEPT FILING BACK, WHEEDLING AWAY. THERE WELL GO, SAID FRED PROMPTLY. BEST RANGE OF LOVE PRODUCTIONS WELL BE FIND ANYWHERE. GINNY RAISED AN EYEBROW SKEPTICALLY. DO THEY WORK? SHE ASKED. CERTAINLY THEY WORK, FOR UP THE TWENTY-FOUR FEELS AT A TIME DEPENDING ON THE WEIGHT OF THE KEY IN HOLSTEIN

AND THE ATTRACTIVENESS OF THE GIRL, SAID GEORGE, REAPPEARING SUDDENLY AT THEIR SIDE. BUT WE'RE NOT SELLING THEM THE OUR SISTER. HE ADDED, BECOMING SUDDENLY STERN. NOT WHEN SHE'S ALREADY GOT ABOUT FIVE KEYS ON THE GO FROM WHAT WE'RE

WHATEVER WELL WE HEARD FROM REIN IS A BIG FAT LIE, SAID GINNY CALMLY, LEANING FORWARD THE TAKE A SMALL PINK PEEK OFF THE SHELF.

WHAT'S THIS? GUARANTEED TEN-SECOND PIMPLE VANISHER, SAID FRED. EXCELLENT FOR EVERYTHING FROM BEARS THE BLACKHEADS, BUT BEEN T CHANGE THE SUBJECT. ARE WELL HERE ARE WELL NOT CURRENTLY GOING OUT WITH A KEY CALLED DEAN THOMAS? YES, I AM, SAID GINNY. AND LAST TIME I WHEEDED, HE WAS DEFINITELY MORE KEYS, NOT FIVE. WHAT ARE THESE? SHE WAS POINTING AT A NUMBER OF ROLLING BALLS OF PLUFF IN SHADES OF PINK AND PURPLE, ALL ROLLING AROUND THE KEETTER OF A CAGE AND EMITTING HIGH-PITCHED SQUEALS. PYGMY PLUFFS, SAID GEORGE.

MINIATURE PLUFFSQUINS, WE CAN'T BREED THEM FAST ENOUGH. SEE WHAT

AKELT MICHAEL CHENER? I DUMPED HIM, HE WAS A BAD LIESER, SAID GINNY, PLUTTING A FINGER THROUGH THE BARS OF THE CAGE AND WATCHING THE PYGMY PLUFFS CRAWL AROUND IT. THEY ARE REALLY CUTE?

THEY ARE FAIRLY CUDDY, YES, CHUCKLED FRED, BUT THEY ARE MOVING THROUGH KEEFRIENDS A BIT FAST, AREN'T THEY? GINNY TURNED THE HEAD AT HIM, HER HANDS ON HER HIPS. THERE WAS SUCH A MRS. WEASLEY-ISH GLARE ON HER FACE THAT HARRY WAS SURPRISED FRED DIDN'T RECKIL. IT'S NONE OF YOUR BUSINESS, AND I'LL THANK YOU, SHE ADDER ANGRILY THE THEN, WHEN HAD ILST APPEARED AT GEORGE'S ELKEL, LADEN WITH MERCHANDISE, NHT THE TELL TALKS AKELT ME THE THESE THEN? THAT'S THREE GALLEONS, NINE SICKLES, AND A KNUT, SAID FRED, EXAMINING THE MANY KEEKS IN REIN'S ARMS. CHUCK LIP, I'M YOUR KRETTHER?

AND THAT'S YOUR STUFF YOU'RE NICKING, THREE GALLEONS, NINE SICKLES, I'LL KNICK OFF THE KNUT, BUT I HAVEN'T GOT THREE GALLEONS, NINE SICKLES? YOU'D BETTER PUT IT BACK THEN, AND MIND YOU PUT IT ON THE RIGHT SHELVES, REIN DROPPED SEVERAL KEEKS, SWHRE, AND MADE A RUDE HAND GESTURE AT FRED THAT WAS UNFORTUNATELY SPEETED BY MRS. WEASLEY, WHEN HAD CHSEN THAT MEMENT THE APPER. IF I SEE YOU DO THAT AGAIN I'LL TINK YOUR FINGERS TOGETHER, SHE SAID SHARPLY, MUM, CAN I HAVE A PYGMY PLUFF? SAID GINNY AT ENCE. A WHAT? SAID MRS. WEASLEY WARILY.

LEHED, THEY'RE SO SWEET. MRS. WEASLEY MOVED ASIDE THE LEHED AT THE PYGMY PLUFFS, AND HARRY, REIN, AND HERMIONE MEMENTARILY HAD AN UNIMPEDED VIEW HLT OF THE WINDHIL, DRACH MALFOY WAS FLIRRYING LIP THE STREET ALONE, AS HE PASSED WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEKEZES, HE GLANCED OVER HIS SHULDER, SECONDS LATER, HE MOVED BEYOND THE SCOPE OF THE WINDHIL AND THEY LOST SIGHT OF HIM. WUNDER WHERE HIS MILMID IS? SAID HARRY, FREELING, GIVEN HER THE SLIP BY THE LEHEDS OF IT, SAID REIN, WHY, TELLGHT? SAID HERMIONE, HARRY SAID NOTHING; HE WAS THINKING THEM HARD, NARCISSE MALFOY WOULD NHT HAVE LET HER PRECIELIS SEEN HLT OF HER SIGHT WILLINGLY; MALFOY MUST HAVE MADE A REAL EFFORT THE FREE HIMSELF FROM HER CLUTCHES, HARRY, KNEELING AND LEATHING MALFOY, WAS SURE THE REASON WOULD NHT BE INNOCENT, HE GLANCED AROUND, MRS. WEASLEY AND GINNY WERE BENDING OVER THE PYGMY PLUFFS, MR. WEASLEY WAS DELIGHTEDLY EXAMINING A PACK OF MUGGLE MARKED PLAYING CARDS, FRED AND GEORGE WERE BOTH HELPING CUSTOMERS, ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE GLASS, HAGRID WAS STANDING WITH HIS BACK TO THEM, LEHIXING LIP AND

DOWN THE STREET. GET UNDER HERE, ELIOT, SAID HARRY, PULLING HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK AROUND HIS EARS. HEI I DON'T KNOW, HARRY, SAID FERMINE, LOOKING UNCERTAINLY TOWARD MRS. WEALEY. COME ON, SAID RENE. SHE HESITATED FOR A SECOND LONGER, THEN DROPPED UNDER THE CLOAK WITH HARRY AND RENE. NOBODY NOTICED THEM VANISH. THEY WERE ALL THEN INTERESTED IN FRED AND GEORGE'S PRODUCTS. HARRY, RENE, AND FERMINE SELECTED THEIR WAY AROUND THE SHOP AS QUICKLY AS THEY COULD, BUT BY THE TIME THEY GAINED THE STREET, MALPHY HAD DISAPPEARED JUST AS SUCCESSFULLY AS THEY HAD.

HE WAS GOING IN THAT DIRECTION, MURMURED HARRY AS QUICKLY AS POSSIBLE, SO THAT THE FLIPPING HAGRID WOULD NOT HEAR THEM.

MEAN. THEY SLURRIED AHEAD, PEERING LEFT AND RIGHT, THROUGH SHEEP WINDOWS AND DOORS, UNTIL FERMINE POINTED AHEAD. THAT'S HIM, ISN'T IT? SHE WHISPERED. TURNING LEFT? BIG SURPRISE, WHISPERED RENE, FOR MALPHY HAD GLANCED AROUND, THEN SLID INTO DOCKTOWN ALLEY AND OUT OF SIGHT. ELIOT, HE'LL BE WITH HIM, SAID HARRY, SPEEDING UP. ELIOT FEET WERE SEEN, SAID FERMINE ANXIOUSLY, AS THE CLOAK FLAPPED A LITTLE AROUND THEIR ANKLES. IT WAS MUCH MORE DIFFICULT HIDING ALL THREE OF THEM UNDER THE CLOAK NOWADAYS. IT DOESN'T MATTER, SAID HARRY IMPATIENTLY. JUST FLURY! BUT DOCKTOWN ALLEY, THE SIDE STREET DEVOTED TO THE DARK ARTS, LOOKED COMPLETELY DESERTED. THEY PEERED INTO WINDOWS AS THEY PASSED, BUT NONE OF THE SHOPS SEEMED TO HAVE ANY CUSTOMERS AT ALL. HARRY SUSPECTED IT WAS A BIT OF A GIVEAWAY IN THESE DANGEROUS AND SUSPICIOUS TIMES TO BUY DARK ARTIFACTS. HE AT LEAST, THEY'RE SEEN BUYING THEM. FERMINE GAVE HIS ARM A HARD PINCH.

ELIOT? SHE? WHO? HE'S IN THERE? SHE BREATHED IN HARRY'S EAR. THEY HAD DRIVEN LEVEL WITH THE ONLY SHOP IN DOCKTOWN ALLEY THAT HARRY HAD EVER VISITED, BEERIN AND BLOOMER, WHICH SOLD A WIDE VARIETY OF SINISTER OBJECTS. THERE IN THE MIDDLE OF THE CASES FULL OF SKULLS AND OLD KETTLES STOOD BRACE MALPHY WITH HIS BACK TO THEM, JUST VISIBLE BEHIND THE VERY SAME LARGE BLACK CABINET IN WHICH HARRY HAD ONCE HIDDEN THE YOUNG MALPHY AND HIS FATHER. JUDGING BY THE MOVEMENTS OF MALPHY'S HANDS, HE WAS TALKING ANIMATEDLY. THE PROPRIETOR OF THE SHOP, MR. BEERIN, AN EILY-FAIRED, STEEPING MAN, STOOD FACING MALPHY. HE WAS WEARING A CLIMBING EXPRESSION OF MINGLED RESENTMENT AND FEAR. IF ONLY WE COULD HEAR WHAT THEY'RE SAYING, SAID FERMINE. WE CAN, SAID RENE EXCITEDLY. FANG HE

DAMN HE DROPPED A CHILDLIKE MERE OF THE KIDNEY HE WAS STILL CLUTCHING AS HE FLUMPELLED WITH THE LARGEST. EXTENDABLE EARS, HEARD? FANTASTIC! SAID FERMINE, AS RHN UNRAVELLED THE LONG, FLESH-COLOURED STRINGS AND BEGAN TO FEED THEM TOWARD THE RHYTHM OF THE DEER. EH, I HOPE THE DEER ISN'T IMPERTURABLE. NEH! SAID RHN CLEVERLY. LISTEN! THEY PUT THEIR HEADS TOGETHER AND LISTENED INTENTLY TO THE ENDS OF THE STRINGS, THROUGH WHICH MALPHY'S VOICE COULD BE HEARD LOUD AND CLEAR, AS THOUGH A RADIO HAD BEEN TURNED ON. YELI KNOWN WHEN TO FIX IT? POSSIBLY, SAID RHEGIN, IN A TONE THAT SUGGESTED HE WAS UNDERMINING THE COMMIT HIMSELF. I'LL NEED TO SEE IT, THOUGH. WHY THEN NOT YELI BRING IT INTO THE SHOP? I CAN'T, SAID MALPHY. IT'S GOTTEN STAY PUT. I MUST NEED YELI TO TELL ME WHEN TO DO IT. HARRY SAW RHEGIN LICK HIS LIPS NERVOUSLY. WELL, WITHOUT SEEING IT, I MUST SAY IT WILL BE A VERY DIFFICULT JOB, PERHAPS IMPOSSIBLE. I COULDN'T GUARANTEE ANYTHING.

NEH! SAID MALPHY, AND HARRY KNEW, INSTANTLY, THAT MALPHY WAS SNEERING. PERHAPS THIS WILL MAKE YELI MORE CONFIDENT. HE MOVED TOWARD RHEGIN AND WAS BLOCKED FROM VIEW BY THE CABINET. HARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE SLIPPED SIDELWAYS TO TRY AND KEEP HIM IN SIGHT, BUT ALL THEY COULD SEE WAS RHEGIN, BEHAVING VERY FRIGHTENED. TELL ANYONE, SAID MALPHY, AND THERE WILL BE RETALIATION. YELI KNOWN FERRIS GREYBACK? HE'S A FAMILY FRIEND. HE'LL BE DROPPING IN FROM TIME TO TIME TO MAKE SURE YELI IS GIVING THE PROBLEM YOUR FULL ATTENTION. THERE WILL BE NO NEED FOR

I'LL DECIDE THAT, SAID MALPHY. WELL, I'D BETTER BE OFF, AND THEN I FORGET TO KEEP THAT ONE SAFE, I'LL NEED IT. PERHAPS YELI'D LIKE TO TAKE IT NOW? NEH, OF COURSE I WOULDN'T, YELI STUPID LITTLE MAN, WHEN WOULD I BEHOLD CARRYING THAT DOWN THE STREET? I JUST DON'T WANT IT. OF COURSE NOT. SIR, RHEGIN MADE A KNEE AS DEEP AS THE ONE HARRY HAD ONCE SEEN HIM GIVE LUCILIS MALPHY. NOT A WORD TO ANYONE, RHEGIN, AND THAT INCLUDES MY MOTHER, UNDERSTAND?

NATURALLY, NATURALLY, MURMURED RHEGIN, KNEELING AGAIN. NEXT MOMENT, THE BELL OVER THE DEER TINKLED LOUDLY AS MALPHY STALKED AWAY. HE WAS BEHAVING VERY PLEASED WITH HIMSELF. HE PASSED SO CLOSE TO HARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE THAT THEY FELT THE CLOAK FLUTTER AROUND THEIR KNEES AGAIN. INSIDE THE SHOP, RHEGIN REMAINED FROZEN; HIS UNCTUOUS SMILE HAD VANISHED; HE BEHEADED WHIRLED. WHAT WAS THAT ABILITY? WHISPERED RHN, REELING IN THE

EXTENDABLE EARS, BLINDED, SAID HARRY, THINKING HARD, HE WANTS
SOMETHING MORE AND HE WANTS THE RESERVE SOMETHING IN THERE.

CHILD YOU SEE WHAT HE POINTED AT WHEN HE SAID THAT HEN?

NEE, HE WAS BEHIND THAT CLOSET YOU TWO STAY HERE,
WHISPERED HERMIONE. WHAT ARE YOU? BUT HERMIONE HAD
ALREADY BLINKED HIM FROM UNDER THE CHAIR. SHE CHECKED HER HAIR IN
THE REFLECTION IN THE GLASS, THEN MARCHED INTO THE SHOP, SETTING
THE BELL TINKLING AGAIN. THEN HASTILY SHE TOOK THE EXTENDABLE EARS BACK
UNDER THE CHAIR AND PASSED HER THE STRINGS THE HARRY, FELLER,
HORRIBLE MEANING, ISN'T IT? HERMIONE SAID BRIGHTLY THE BERING,
WHEN DID NOT ANSWER, BUT LEFT HER A SUSPICIOUS LOOK, FLIPPING
CHEERILY, HERMIONE STRENGTHENED THROUGH THE LITTLE OF HERETS IN
DISPLAY, IS THIS NECKLACE FOR SALE? SHE ASKED, PALMING BESIDE A
GLASS-FRONTED CASE. IF YOU'VE GOT ONE AND A HALF THOUSAND
GALLEONS, SAID MR. BERING CHILDLY, HEH ER NEE, I HAVEN'T GOT
WHITE THAT MUCH, SAID HERMIONE, WALKING ON, AND WHAT
ABOUT THIS BEAUTIFUL LITTLE SKULL? SIXTEEN GALLEONS, SHE IT'S
FOR SALE, THEN? IT ISN'T BEING KEPT FOR ANYONE? MR. BERING
POINTED AT HER, HARRY HAD THE NASTY FEELING HE KNEW EXACTLY
WHAT HERMIONE WAS UP TO, APPARENTLY HERMIONE FELT SHE HAD BEEN
RUMPLED THEN BECAUSE SHE SUDDENLY THREW CALTHERN THE WINDS. THE
THING IS, THAT ER SHE WHEN WAS IN HERE JUST NOW, DRAGON
MAYBE, WELL, HE'S A FRIEND OF MINE, AND I WANT TO GET HIM A BIRTHDAY
PRESENT, BUT IF HE'S ALREADY RESERVED ANYTHING, I HEAVILY DON'T
WANT TO GET HIM THE SAME THING, SHE LITTLE IT WAS A PRETTY LARGE
STORY IN HARRY'S MIND, AND APPARENTLY BERING THOUGHT SHE
THAT. BUT, HE SAID SHARPLY, GET HIM? HERMIONE DID NOT WAIT TO
BE ASKED TWICE, BUT HURRIED TO THE CHAIR WITH BERING AT HER HEELS.
AS THE BELL TINKLED AGAIN, BERING SLAMMED THE CHAIR BEHIND HER AND
PLUT UP THE CLOSED SIGN. AH WELL, SAID THEN, TURNING THE CHAIR
BACK OVER HERMIONE. WORTH A TRY, BUT YOU WERE A BIT HEAVILY

WELL, NEXT TIME YOU CAN SHOW ME HOW IT'S DONE, MASTER OF
MYSTERY! SHE SNAPPED, THEN AND HERMIONE KICKED ALL THE WAY
BACK TO WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEASELES, WHERE THEY WERE FORCED TO STOP
SEE THAT THEY COULD BECOME UNDETECTED ABOUT A VERY ANXIOUS-
LOOKING MRS. WEASLEY AND HAGRID, WHEN HAD CLEARLY NOTICED THEIR
ABSENCE. THEN IN THE SHOP, HARRY WHIPPED OFF THE INVISIBILITY
CHAIR, HID IT IN HIS BAG, AND JOINED IN WITH THE OTHER TWO WHEN

THEY INSISTED, IN ANSWER THE MRS. WEASLEY'S ACCUSATIONS, THAT THEY HAD BEEN IN THE BACK ROOM ALL ALONG, AND THAT SHE COULD NOT HAVE LIKED PROPERLY. THE SLUG LIKE HARRY SPENT A LOT OF THE LAST WEEK OF THE HOLIDAYS Pondering THE MEANING OF MALPHY'S RELATIVES IN DOWNSTOWN ALLEY. WHAT DISTURBED HIM MOST WAS THE SATISFIED LOOK ON MALPHY'S FACE AS HE HAD LEFT THE SHOP. NOTHING THAT MADE MALPHY LOOK THAT HAPPY COULD BE GOOD NEWS. THE HIS SLIGHT ANNOYANCE, HOWEVER, NEITHER RENN NOR FERMINE SEEMED BLIND AS CLIMBING ABOUT MALPHY'S ACTIVITIES AS HE WAS; HER AT LEAST, THEY SEEMED TO GET BORED OF DISCUSSING IT AFTER A FEW DAYS. YES, I'VE ALREADY AGREED IT WAS FISHY, HARRY, SAID FERMINE A LITTLE IMPATIENTLY. SHE WAS SITTING ON THE WINDOW SILL IN FRED AND GEORGE'S ROOM WITH HER FEET UP ON ONE OF THE CARPETS AND HAD ONLY GRABBERINGLY LOOKED UP FROM HER NEW COPY OF ADVANCED RUSSIAN TRANSLATIONS. BUT HAVEN'T WE AGREED THERE COULD BE A LOT OF EXPLANATIONS? MAYBE HE'S BROKEN HIS HAND OF CLIMBING, SAID RENN VAGUELY, AS HE ATTEMPTED TO STRAIGHTEN HIS KNEEMASTERS' KENT TAIL TWIGS. REMEMBER THAT STRIVELY-UP ARM MALPHY HAD? BUT WHAT ABOUT WHEN HE SAID, DON'T FORGET THE DEED THAT HE'S SAFE? ASKED HARRY FOR THE THIRTEENTH TIME. THAT SOUNDED TO ME LIKE BURGINS'S GET ANOTHER ONE OF THE BROKEN BRICKS, AND MALPHY WANTS BOTH.

WELL RECKON? SAID RENN, NEW TRYING THE SCRAPE SOME DIRT OFF HIS KNEEM HANDLE. Yeah, I DO, SAID HARRY, WHEN NEITHER RENN NOR FERMINE ANSWERED, HE SAID, MALPHY'S FATHER'S IN AZDABAN. DON'T YOU THINK MALPHY'D LIKE REVENGE? RENN LOOKED UP, BLINKING.

MALPHY, REVENGE? WHAT CAN HE DO ABOUT IT? THAT'S MY POINT, I DON'T KNOW! SAID HARRY, FRUSTRATED. BUT HE'S UP THE SOMETHING AND I THINK WE SHOULD TAKE IT SERIOUSLY. HIS FATHER'S A DEATH EATER AND HARRY KNEW HER, HIS EYES FIXED ON THE WINDOW BEHIND FERMINE, HIS MOUTH OPEN. A STARTLING THOUGHT HAD JUST ILLUMINATED THE HIM. HARRY? SAID FERMINE IN AN ANXIOUS VOICE.

WHAT'S WRONG? WELL, SCAR'S NOT FLIRTING AGAIN, IS IT? ASKED RENN NERVOUSLY. HE'S A DEATH EATER, SAID HARRY SLEELY. HE'S REPLACED HIS FATHER AS A DEATH EATER? THERE WAS A SILENCE; THEN RENN ERUPTED IN LAUGHTER. MALPHY? HE'S SIXTEEN, HARRY? WELL, THINK WELL-KNEW-WELL WOULD LET MALPHY THINK IT SEEMS VERY UNLIKELY, HARRY, SAID FERMINE IN A REPRESSIVE SORT OF VOICE. WHAT MAKES YOU THINK? IN MADAM MALBIN'S, SHE DIDN'T

THLICK HIM, BUT HE YELLED AND PULLED HIS ARM AWAY FROM HER WHEN SHE WENT THE WHOLE WAY UP HIS SLEEVE. IT WAS HIS LEFT ARM, THE ONE KEEN BRANDED WITH THE DARK MARK. RHEIN AND FERMINE LOOKED AT EACH OTHER. WELL SAID RHEIN, SOUNDING TERRIBLY UNCONVINCED. I THINK HE JUST WANTED TO GET HIT UP THERE, HARRY. SAID FERMINE. HE SHOWED RHEIN SOMETHING HE COULDN'T SEE. HARRY PRESSED HIS STUBBORNLY. SOMETHING THAT SERIOUSLY SCARED RHEIN. IT WAS THE MARK, I KNOW IT HE WAS SHOWING RHEIN WHAT HE WAS DEALING WITH, WHY WAS HE SERIOUSLY RHEIN THEN HIM? RHEIN AND FERMINE EXCHANGED ANOTHER LOOK. I'M NOT SURE, HARRY.

YES, I STILL DON'T REMEMBER WHY-KNOW-WHAT WOULD LET MARY IN. ANSWERED, BUT ABSOLUTELY CONVINCED HE WAS RIGHT, HARRY SNATCHED UP A PILE OF FILTHY ELIDITCH RIBS AND LEFT THE ROOM. MRS. WEASLEY HAD BEEN LINGERING THEM FOR DAYS NOT TO LEAVE THEIR WASHING AND PACKING UNTIL THE LAST MOMENT. IN THE LANDING HE CLIMBED INTO CINDY, WHO WAS RETURNING TO HER ROOM CARRYING A PILE OF FRESHLY LAUNDERED CLOTHES. I COULDN'T GO IN THE KITCHEN JUST NOW, SHE WARNED HIM. THERE'S A LOT OF PEOPLE ARRIVING.

I'LL BE CAREFUL NOT TO SLIP IN IT. HARRY SMILED. SURE ENOUGH, WHEN HE ENTERED THE KITCHEN IT WAS THE FINE FLEUR SITTING AT THE KITCHEN TABLE, IN FULL FLOW ABOUT PLANS FOR HER WEDDING THE BILL, WHILE MRS. WEASLEY KEPT WATCH OVER A PILE OF SELF-PEELING SPAGHETTI, LOOKING BADTEMPERED. BILL AND I HAVE ALMOST DECIDED ON ONLY TWO BRIDESMAIDS, CINDY AND GABRIELLE WILL BE VERY SWEET THEZZER, I AM THINKING OF DRESSING THEM IN PINK AND PINK WOULD BE CHOICE BE HORRIBLE WITH CINDY'S AIR AH, HARRY? SAID MRS. WEASLEY LOUDLY, CUTTING ACROSS FLEUR'S MINDLESSLY. GOOD, I WANTED TO EXPLAIN ABOUT THE SECURITY ARRANGEMENTS FOR THE HILARY THE FLEWARTS THEMSELVES. WE'VE GOT MINISTRY CARS AGAIN, AND THERE WILL BE ALWAYS WAITING AT THE STATION. IS THERE ANYTHING TO BE THERE? ASKED HARRY, HANDING OVER HIS ELIDITCH THINGS. NO, I DON'T THINK SHE'S BEEN STATISTED SOMEWHERE ELSE FROM WHAT ARTHUR SAID. SHE HAS LET HERSELF GO, ZAT THINGS, FLEUR MOVED, EXAMINING HER OWN STUNNING REFLECTION IN THE BACK OF A TRAPDOOR. A BIG MISTAKE IF YOU ASK YES, THANK YOU, SAID MRS. WEASLEY TARTLY, CUTTING ACROSS FLEUR AGAIN. YOU'D BETTER GET ON, HARRY, I WANT THE TRUNKS READY TONIGHT, IF POSSIBLE, SHE WE DON'T HAVE THE USUAL LAST-MINUTE SCRAMBLE. AND IN FACT, THEIR

DEPARTURE THE FOLLOWING MORNING WAS SWIFTER THAN USUAL. THE
MINISTRY CARS GLIDED UP THE FRONT OF THE STATION THE FIND THEM
WAITING, TRUNKS PACKED; HERMINE & CAT, CRIBSTANDS, SAFELY
ENCLOSED IN HIS TRAVELING BASKET; AND EDWIG; RHN & HEAL,
PICKWICKEN; AND GINNY & NEW PURPLE PONY PONY, ARNOLD, IN
CAGES. ALL REVIEW, ARRY, SAID FLUR THREATENING, MISSING HIM GOOD-
BYE. RHN HURRIED FORWARD, LEAVING HERSELF, BUT GINNY STUCK HEAT
HER FEET AND RHN FELL, SPRAWLING IN THE DUST AT FLUR'S FEET.
FLURRIS, RED-FACED, AND DIRT-SPATTERED, HE HURRIED INTO THE CAR
WITHOUT SAYING GOOD-BYE. THERE WAS NO OTHER FLURRIS WAITING
FOR THEM AT KING & CROSS STATION. INSTEAD, TWO GRIM-FACED, BEARDED
GUARDS IN DARK MUGGLE SLITS MOVED FORWARD THE MOMENT THE CARS
STOPPED AND, FLANKING THE PARTY, MARCHED THEM INTO THE STATION
WITHOUT SPEAKING. FLICK, FLICK, THROUGH THE BARRIER, SAID MRS.
WEASLEY, WHO SEEMED A LITTLE FLUSTERED BY THIS ALIEN EFFICIENCY.

HARRY HAD BETTER GO FIRST, WITH SHE LOOKED INQUIRINGLY AT
ONE OF THE GUARDS, WHO NODDED BRIEFLY, SEIZED HARRY'S UPPER ARM,
AND ATTEMPTED TO STEER HIM TOWARD THE BARRIER BETWEEN PLATFORMS
NINE AND TEN. I CAN WALK, THANKS, SAID HARRY IRRITABLY, PULLING
HIS ARM OUT OF THE GUARD'S GRIP. HE PUSHED HIS TRUNKS DIRECTLY AT
THE SOLID BARRIER, IGNORING HIS SILENT COMPANION, AND FINDING
HIMSELF, A SECOND LATER, STANDING ON PLATFORM NINE AND THREE-
QUARTERS, WHERE THE SCARLET HOGWARTS EXPRESS STOOD BELCHING
STEAM OVER THE CREW. HERMINE AND THE WEASLEYS JOINED HIM
WITHIN SECONDS. WITHOUT WAITING TO CONSULT HIS GRIM-FACED GUARD,
HARRY MENTIONED THE RHN AND HERMINE TO HERSELF HIM UP THE
PLATFORM, LEAVING FOR AN EMPTY COMPARTMENT. WE CAN'T, HARRY,
SAID HERMINE, LEAVING APOLOGETIC. RHN AND I'VE GOT TO GET THE
THE PERFECTS CARRIAGE FIRST AND THEN PATROL THE CORRIDORS FOR A
KIT. HEY YEAH, I FORGET, SAID HARRY. YOU'D BETTER GET STRAIGHT
ON THE TRAIN, ALL OF YOU, YOU'VE ONLY GOT A FEW MINUTES TO GO,
SAID MRS. WEASLEY, CONSULTING HER WATCH. WELL, HAVE A NICE
TRIP, RHN. MR. WEASLEY, CAN I HAVE A FLICK WHIP? SAID
HARRY, MAKING UP HIS MIND ON THE SPUR OF THE MOMENT. HE
HEARS, SAID MR. WEASLEY, WHO LOOKED SLIGHTLY SURPRISED, BUT
FOLLOWED HARRY OUT OF EARSHOT OF THE OTHERS NEVERTHELESS. HARRY
HAD THOUGHT IT THROUGH CAREFULLY AND CAME TO THE CONCLUSION
THAT, IF HE WAS TO TELL ANYONE, MR. WEASLEY WAS THE RIGHT PERSON;

FIRSTLY, BECAUSE HE WORKED AT THE MINISTRY AND WAS THEREFORE IN THE BEST POSITION TO MAKE FURTHER INVESTIGATIONS, AND SECONDLY, BECAUSE HE THOUGHT THAT THERE WAS NOT THE MUCH RISK OF MR. WEASLEY EXPLODING WITH ANGER, HE COULD SEE MRS. WEASLEY AND THE GRIM-FACED ALIBIA LASTING THE PAIR OF THEM SUSPICIOUS LOOKS AS THEY MOVED AWAY. WHEN HE WAS IN DIAGEN ALLEY, HARRY BEGAN, BUT MR. WEASLEY ARRESTED HIM WITH A GRIMACE. AM I ABOUT THE DISCOVERY WHERE YOU, RON, AND HERMION DISAPPEARED THE WHILE YOU WERE SLIPPED THE IN THE BACK ROOM OF FRED AND GEORGE'S SHOP?

YOU DID YOU? HARRY, PLEASE, YOU'RE TALKING TO THE MAN WHO RAISED FRED AND GEORGE. ER, YES, ALL RIGHT, WE WERE IN THE BACK ROOM. VERY WELL, THEN, LET'S HEAR THE WORST. WELL, WE FOLLOWED DRAGON MALFOY, WE USED MY INVISIBILITY CLOAK. DID YOU HAVE ANY PARTICULAR REASONS FOR BEING THERE, OR WAS IT A PURE WHIM?

BECAUSE I THOUGHT MALFOY WAS UP TO SOMETHING, SAID HARRY, DISREGARDING MR. WEASLEY'S LOOK OF MINGLED EXASPERATION AND AMUSEMENT. HE'D GIVEN HIS MOTHER THE SLIP AND I WANTED TO KNOW WHY. HE HIMSELF YOU DID, SAID MR. WEASLEY, SOUNDING RESIGNED.

WELL? DID YOU FIND OUT WHY? HE WENT INTO BURGON AND BURGON, SAID HARRY, AND STARTED KILLING THE BLOOD IN THERE, BURGON, THE HELP HIM FIX SOMETHING, AND HE SAID HE WANTED BURGON TO KEEP SOMETHING ELSE FOR HIM, HE MADE IT SOUND LIKE IT WAS THE SAME KIND OF THING THAT NEEDED FIXING, LIKE THEY WERE A PAIR, AND HARRY TOOK A DEEP BREATH. THERE'S SOMETHING ELSE, WE SAW MALFOY IMPLORE A MILE WHEN MADAM MALFOY TRIED TO TWIST HIS LEFT ARM, I THINK HE'S BEEN BRANDED WITH THE DARK MARK, I THINK HE'S REPLACED HIS FATHER AS A DEATH EATER. MR. WEASLEY LOOKED TAKEN ABACK.

AFTER A MOMENT HE SAID, HARRY, I DOUBT WHETHER YOU-KNOW-WHO WOULD ALLOW A SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLD DOES ANYONE REALLY KNOW

WHAT YOU-KNOW-WHO WOULD HE WOULDN'T HE? ASKED HARRY ANGERILY. MR. WEASLEY, I'M SURE, BUT ISN'T IT WORTH INVESTIGATING? IF MALFOY WANTS SOMETHING FIXING, AND HE NEEDS THE THREATEN BURGON TO GET IT DONE, IT'S PROBABLY SOMETHING DARK AND DANGEROUS, ISN'T IT? I DOUBT IT, THE BE HONEST, HARRY, SAID MR. WEASLEY SILENTLY. YOU SEE, WHEN LUCIUS MALFOY WAS ARRESTED, WE RAIDED HIS HOUSE, WE TOOK AWAY EVERYTHING THAT MIGHT HAVE BEEN DANGEROUS. I THINK YOU MISSED SOMETHING, SAID HARRY STUBBORNLY. WELL, MAYBE, SAID MR. WEASLEY, BUT HARRY COULD TELL

THAT MR. WEASLEY WAS FLIPPING HIM. THERE WAS A WHISTLE BEHIND THEM; NEARLY EVERYONE HAD BOARDED THE TRAIN AND THE DOORS WERE CLOSING. 'WELL I BETTER HURRY,' SAID MR. WEASLEY, AS MRS. WEASLEY CRIED, 'HARRY, HURRIKLY!' HE HURRIED FORWARD AND MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY HELPED HIM LEAD HIS TRUNK BENTH THE TRAIN. 'WELL, DEAR, WELL BE CHEERING THE LIS FOR CHRISTMAS, IT'S ALL FIXED WITH DUMKLEDBERE, SEE WE LL SEE WELL WHITE SHEEN,' SAID MRS. WEASLEY THROUGH THE WINDOW, AS HARRY SLAMMED THE DOOR SHUT BEHIND HIM AND THE TRAIN BEGAN THE MOVE. 'WELL MAKE SURE WELL LEED AFTER WELLRSELF AND THE TRAIN WAS GATHERING SPEED. ER CHEED AND SHE WAS HEGGING THE DEEP LIP NEEL. STAY SAFE! HARRY WAVED UNTIL THE TRAIN HAD TURNED A CORNER AND MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY WERE LOST THE VIEW, THEN TURNED THE SEE WHERE THE OTHERS HAD GET THE, HE SLIPPED RHEEN AND HERMININE WERE CHESTERED IN THE PERFECTS CARRIAGE, BUT GINNY WAS A LITTLE WAY ALONG THE CORRIDOR, CHATTING THE SOME FRIENDS. HE MADE HIS WAY TOWARD HER, DRAGGING HIS TRUNK. PEOPLE STARED SHAMELESSLY AS HE APPROACHED. THEY EVEN PRESSED THEIR FACES AGAINST THE WINDOWS OF THEIR COMPARTMENTS TO GET A LEED AT HIM. HE HAD EXPECTED AN UPSWING IN THE AMPLINT OF GASPING AND GASPING HE WOULD HAVE THE ENDURE THIS TERM AFTER ALL THE CHESSEN FINE RUMMERS IN THE DAILY PROPHET, BUT HE DID NOT ENJOY THE SENSATION OF STANDING IN A VERY BRIGHT SPOTLIGHT. HE TAPPED GINNY ON THE SHOULDER. 'FANCY TRYING TO FIND A COMPARTMENT? I CAN'T, HARRY, I SAID I'D MEET DEAN,' SAID GINNY BRIGHTLY. 'SEE WELL LATER. RIGHT,' SAID HARRY. HE FELT A STRANGE TWINGE OF ANNOYANCE AS SHE WALKED AWAY, HER LONG RED HAIR DANCING BEHIND HER; HE HAD BECOME SHE USED TO HER PRESENCE EVER THE SLIMMER THAT HE HAD ALMOST FORGOTTEN THAT GINNY DID NOT HANG AROUND WITH HIM, RHEEN, AND HERMININE WHILE AT SCHOOL. THEN HE BLINKED AND LEEDED AROUND: HE WAS SURPRISED BY MESMERIZED GIRLS. 'HI, HARRY!' SAID A FAMILIAR VOICE FROM BEHIND HIM. 'NEVILLE!' SAID HARRY IN RELIEF, TURNING THE SEE A REDD-FACED BOY STRUGGLING TOWARD HIM. 'HELLO, HARRY,' SAID A GIRL WITH LONG HAIR AND LARGE MISTY EYES, WHO WAS JUST BEHIND NEVILLE. 'LUNA, HI, WELL ARE WELL?' 'VERY WELL, THANKS WELL,' SAID LUNA. SHE WAS CLUTCHING A MAGAZINE TO HER CHEST; LARGE LETTERS ON THE FRONT ANNOUNCED THAT THERE WAS A PAIR OF FREE SPECTRESPELS INSIDE. 'HURRIKLY STILL GOING STRONG, THEN?' ASKED HARRY, WHO FELT A CERTAIN FRIENDNESS FOR THE MAGAZINE,

HAVING GIVEN IT AN EXCLUSIVE INTERVIEW THE PREVIOUS YEAR, HE
YES, CIRCULATION IS WELL UP, SAID LUNA HAPPILY. LET US FIND SEATS,
SAID HARRY, AND THE THREE OF THEM SET OFF ALONG THE TRAIN THROUGH
HERDS OF SILENTLY STARING STUDENTS. AT LAST THEY FOUND AN EMPTY
COMPARTMENT, AND HARRY BURIED INSIDE GRATEFULLY. THEY ARE EVEN
STARING AT US! SAID NEVILLE, INDICATING HIMSELF AND LUNA. BECAUSE
WE ARE WITH THEM! THEY ARE STARING AT THEM BECAUSE THEY WERE AT THE
MINISTRY THEN, SAID HARRY, AS HE REELLED HIS TRUNK INTO THE
LUGGAGE RACK. HIS LITTLE ADVENTURE THERE WAS ALL OVER THE DAILY
PROPHET, THEY MUST HAVE SEEN IT. YES, I THOUGHT GRAN WOULD BE
ANGRY ABOUT ALL THE PUBLICITY, SAID NEVILLE, BUT SHE WAS REALLY
PLEASED, SAYS I'M STARTING THE LIVE UP THE MY DAD AT LONG LAST. SHE
RECEIVED ME A NEW WAND, DIDN'T SHE? HE PULLED IT OUT AND SHOWED IT TO
HARRY. CHERRY AND LILAC-HAIR, HE SAID PROUDLY. WE THINK IT
WAS ONE OF THE LAST HILLYARD EVER SEEN, HE VANISHED NEXT DAY
HE, CAME BACK HERE, TREVOR! AND HE DIVED UNDER THE SEAT TO
RETRIEVE HIS THING AS IT MADE ONE OF ITS FREQUENT RIDS FOR FREEDOM.

ARE WE STILL DOING D.A. MEETINGS THIS YEAR, HARRY? ASKED LUNA,
WHILE WAS DETACHING A PAIR OF PSYCHEDELIC SPECTACLES FROM THE MIDDLE
OF THE FLICKER. SHE POINTED OUT WE HAVE GOT RID OF LUMBER, IS
THERE? SAID HARRY, SITTING DOWN. NEVILLE CLIMBED HIS HEAD AGAINST
THE SEAT AS HE EMERGED FROM UNDER IT. HE LOOKED MOST DISAPPOINTED.

I LIKED THE D.A. I LEARNED LOADS WITH THEM! I ENJOYED THE MEETINGS
THEN, SAID LUNA SERENELY. IT WAS LIKE HAVING FRIENDS. THIS WAS
ONE OF THOSE UNCOMFORTABLE THINGS LUNA OFTEN SAID AND WHICH
MADE HARRY FEEL A SWIRLING MIXTURE OF PITY AND EMBARRASSMENT.
BEFORE HE COULD RESPOND, HOWEVER, THERE WAS A DISTURBANCE OUTSIDE
THEIR COMPARTMENT DOOR: A GROUP OF FOURTEEN-YEAR GIRLS WAS
WHISPERING AND GIGGLING TOGETHER ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE GLASS.

THEY ASK HIM! SHE, THEY! I'LL DO IT! AND ONE OF THEM, A RED-
LOOKING GIRL WITH LARGE DARK EYES, A PROMINENT CHIN, AND LONG
BLACK HAIR PULSED HER WAY THROUGH THE DOOR. HI, HARRY, I'M
REMILDA, REMILDA VANE, SHE SAID LOUDLY AND CONFIDENTLY. WHY
DIDN'T YOU JOIN US IN OUR COMPARTMENT? YOU DIDN'T HAVE TO SIT
WITH THEM, SHE ADDED IN A STAGE WHISPER, INDICATING NEVILLE'S
BETTER, WHICH WAS STICKING OUT FROM UNDER THE SEAT AGAIN AS HE
CRAWLED AROUND FOR TREVOR, AND LUNA, WHO WAS NOW WEARING HER
FREE SPECTACLES, WHICH GAVE HER THE LOOK OF A DEMENTED,

MULTICHECKED HELL. THEY'RE FRIENDS OF MINE, SAID HARRY CHELBY.

HEH, SAID THE GIRL, SMILING VERY SURPRISED. HEH, HEY, AND SHE WITHDREW, SLIDING THE OTHER CHECKS BEHIND HER. PEOPLE EXPECT YOU TO HAVE CHECKER FRIENDS THAN US, SAID LUNA, HENCE AGAIN DISPLAYING HER OWNAGE FOR EMBARRASSING HONESTY. YOU ARE CHECK, SAID HARRY SHORTLY. WHEN HE THEM WAS AT THE MINISTRY, THEY DIDN'T FIGHT WITH ME. THAT'S A VERY NICE THING TO SAY, BEAMED LUNA. THEN SHE PULSED HER SPECTACLES FARTHER UP HER NOSE AND SETTLED DOWN TO READ THE FLICKER. WE DIDN'T FACE HIM, THOUGH, SAID NEVILLE, EMERGING FROM UNDER THE SEAT WITH ALOOF AND BLISS IN HIS HAIR AND A RESIGNED-SMILING TROPHY IN HIS HAND. YOU DID, YOU SHOULD HEAR MY GRANDFATHER ABOUT YOU. THAT HARRY PETER'S GET MORE BACKSTREET THAN THE WHOLE MINISTRY OF MAGIC PUT TOGETHER? SHE'D GIVE ANYTHING TO HAVE YOU AS A GRANDSON. HARRY LAUGHED

UNCONSCIOUSLY AND CHANGED THE SUBJECT TO THE H.L.L. RESULTS AS SEEN AS HE CHELBY. WHILE NEVILLE RECITED HIS GRADES AND WONDERED ALREADY WHETHER HE WOULD BE ALLOWED TO TAKE A TRANSFIGURATION D.E.L.T. WITH ONLY AN ACCEPTABLE, HARRY WATCHED HIM WITHOUT REALLY LISTENING. NEVILLE'S CHILDHOOD HAD BEEN BRIGHTENED BY VERDERMENT JUST AS MUCH AS HARRY'S HAD, BUT NEVILLE HAD NO IDEA HOW CLOSE HE HAD COME TO HAVING HARRY'S DESTINY. THE PROPHECY WOULD HAVE REFERRED TO EITHER OF THEM, YET, FOR HIS OWN UNSCRUTABLE REASONS, VERDERMENT HAD CHOSEN TO BELIEVE THAT HARRY WAS THE ONE MEANT. HAD VERDERMENT CHOSEN NEVILLE, IT WOULD BE NEVILLE SITTING OPPOSITE HARRY BEARING THE LIGHTNING-SHAPED STAR AND THE WEIGHT OF THE PROPHECY. HER WOULD IT? WOULD NEVILLE'S MOTHER HAVE DIED TO SAVE HIM, AS LILY HAD DIED FOR HARRY? SURELY SHE WOULD, BUT WHAT IF SHE HAD BEEN UNABLE TO STAND BETWEEN HER SON AND VERDERMENT? WOULD THERE THEN HAVE BEEN NO CHOICE FOR HER AT ALL? AN EMPTY SEAT WHERE NEVILLE NOW SAT AND A SCARLESS HARRY WHO WOULD HAVE BEEN KISSED GOOD-BYE BY HIS OWN MOTHER, NOT RICHARD?

YOU'RE ALL RIGHT, HARRY? YOU'RE FLIRTY, SAID NEVILLE. HARRY STARTED. SURELY I WRACKSPLINT GET YOU? ASKED LUNA SYMPATHETICALLY, PEERING AT HARRY THROUGH HER PNEUMATIC CHECKED SPECTACLES. I WHAT? A WRACKSPLINT THEY'RE INVISIBLE. THEY SPEAK IN THROTTLE YOUR EARS AND MAKE YOUR BRAIN GO FLIZZY, SHE SAID. I THOUGHT I FELT ONE ZIPPING AROUND IN HERE. SHE FLAPPED HER HANDS AT THE AIR, AS THOUGH BEATING OFF

YOU'RE ALL RIGHT, HARRY? YOU'RE FLIRTY, SAID NEVILLE. HARRY STARTED. SURELY I WRACKSPLINT GET YOU? ASKED LUNA SYMPATHETICALLY, PEERING AT HARRY THROUGH HER PNEUMATIC CHECKED SPECTACLES. I WHAT? A WRACKSPLINT THEY'RE INVISIBLE. THEY SPEAK IN THROTTLE YOUR EARS AND MAKE YOUR BRAIN GO FLIZZY, SHE SAID. I THOUGHT I FELT ONE ZIPPING AROUND IN HERE. SHE FLAPPED HER HANDS AT THE AIR, AS THOUGH BEATING OFF

LARGE INVISIBLE MOUNTAINS. HARRY AND NEVILLE CALIGET EACH OTHER'S EYES AND HASTILY REGAIN THE TALK OF HEDDITCH. THE WEATHER BEYOND THE TRAIN WINDOWS WAS AS PATCHY AS IT HAD BEEN ALL SUMMER; THEY PASSED THROUGH STRETCHES OF THE CHILLING MIST, THEN HURT INTO WARM, CLEAR SUNLIGHT. IT WAS DURING ONE OF THE CLEAR SPELLS, WHEN THE SUN WAS VISIBLE ALMOST DIRECTLY OVERHEAD, THAT RON AND HERMION ENTERED THE COMPARTMENT AT LAST. WITH THE LUNCH TRUCKS WOULD HARRY UP, I'M STARVING, SAID RON LONGINGLY, SLUMPING INTO THE SEAT BESIDE HARRY AND RUBBING HIS STOMACH. HI, NEVILLE, HI, LUNA, GUESS WHAT? HE ADDED, TURNING TO HARRY.

MALFOY'S NEET BEING PERFECT DUTY, HE'S JUST SITTING IN HIS COMPARTMENT WITH THE OTHER SLYTHERINS, WE SAW HIM WHEN WE PASSED. HARRY SAT UP STRAIGHT, INTERESTED. IT WAS NEET LIKE MALFOY THE PASS UP THE CHANCE TO DEMONSTRATE HIS POWER AS PERFECT, WHICH HE HAD HAPPILY ABUSED ALL THE PREVIOUS YEAR. WHAT DID HE DO WHEN HE SAW YOU? THE USUAL, SAID RON INDIFFERENTLY, DEMONSTRATING A RUDE HAND GESTURE. NEET LIKE HIM, THOUGH, IS IT? WELL THAT IS

HE DID THE HAND GESTURE AGAIN BUT WHY ISN'T HE HURT THERE KILLING FIRST YEARS? BLINDLY, SAID HARRY, BUT HIS MIND WAS RACING. DIDN'T THIS SEEM AS THOUGH MALFOY HAD MORE IMPORTANT THINGS ON HIS MIND THAN KILLING YOUNGER STUDENTS? MAYBE HE PREFERRED THE INHUMANITARIAN SHELAD, SAID HERMION. MAYBE BEING A PERFECT SEEMS A BIT TAME AFTER THAT. I DON'T THINK SO, SAID HARRY.

I THINK HE'S BUT BEFORE HE COULD EXPLAIN ON HIS THEORY, THE COMPARTMENT DOOR SLID OPEN AGAIN AND A BREATHLESS THIRD-YEAR GIRL STEPPED INSIDE. I'M SUPPOSED TO DELIVER THESE TO NEVILLE LONGBOTT AND HARRY POTTER, SHE PALTERED, AS HER EYES MET HARRY'S AND SHE TURNED SCARLET. SHE WAS HOLDING OUT TWO SHEETS OF PARCHMENT TIED WITH VIOLET RIBBON. PERPLEXED, HARRY AND NEVILLE THEN THE SHEET ADDRESSED TO EACH OF THEM AND THE GIRL STUMBLER BACK OUT OF THE COMPARTMENT. WHAT IS IT? RON DEMANDED, AS HARRY UNRAVELLED HIS. AN INVITATION, SAID HARRY. HARRY, I WOULD BE DELIGHTED IF YOU WOULD JOIN ME FOR A RITE OF LUNCH IN COMPARTMENT C. SINCERELY, PROFESSOR H. E. F. SLUGGISH. WHEN'S PROFESSOR SLUGGISH? ASKED NEVILLE, LOOKING PERPLEXED AT HIS OWN INVITATION. NEW TEACHER, SAID HARRY. WELL, I SUPPOSE WE'LL HAVE TO GO, WON'T WE? BUT WHAT DOES HE WANT ME FOR? ASKED NEVILLE NERVOUSLY, AS THOUGH HE WAS EXPECTING DETENTION. NEET

idea, said Harry, which was not entirely true, though he had not
proof yet that his hunch was correct. Listen, he added, seized by
a sudden brain wave, let's go under the invisibility cloak, then
we might get a good look at Malfoy on the way, see what he's up
to. This idea, however, came to nothing: the corridors, which
were packed with people on the way to the lunch trolley,
were impossible to negotiate while wearing the cloak. Harry
steered it regretfully back in his bag, reflecting that it would have
been nice to wear it just to avoid all the staring, which seemed to
have increased in intensity even since he had last walked down the
train. Every now and then, students would furtively hint at their
compartments to get a better look at him. The exception was Cree
Chang, who darted into her compartment when she saw Harry
coming. As Harry passed the window, he saw her deep in
determined conversation with her friend Marietta, who was
wearing a very thick layer of makeup that did not entirely
obscure the odd formation of pimples still etched across her face.
Smirking slightly, Harry plucked her. When they reached
compartment C, they saw at once that they were not altogether so
uninvited, although judging by the enthusiasm of Slughorn's
welcome, Harry was the most warmly anticipated. Harry, mhm?
said Slughorn, limping up at the sight of him to see that his great
velvet-covered belly seemed to fill all the remaining space in the
compartment. His shiny bald head and great silver mustache
gleamed as brightly in the sunlight as the golden buttons on his
waistcoat. Good to see you, good to see you! And you must be Mr.
Longbottom? Neville nodded, looking scared. At a gesture from
Slughorn, they sat down opposite each other in the only two
empty seats, which were nearest the door. Harry glanced around
at their fellow guests. He recognized a Slytherin from their year,
a tall black boy with high cheekbones and long, slanting eyes;
there were also two seventh-year boys Harry did not know and,
seated in the corner beside Slughorn and looking as though
she was not entirely sure how she had got there, Ginny. Now, do
you know everyone? Slughorn asked Harry and Neville. Blaise
Zabini is in your year, he chirped. Zabini did not make any sign
of recognition or greeting, nor did Harry or Neville. Gryffindor
and Slytherin students leathed each other in principle. This is

CHERMIE MCKAGGEN, PERHAPS YOU'VE MET EACH OTHER ?
 NEH? MCKAGGEN, A LARGE, WINDY-FAIRED YOUNG MAN, RAISED A HAND, AND
 HARRY AND NEVILLE NODDED BACK AT HIM. AND THIS IS MARCUS
 KELLY, I DON'T KNOW WHETHER ? KELLY, WHO WAS THIN AND
 NERVOUSLY-LOOKING, GAVE A STRAINED SMILE. AND THIS CHARMING
 YOUNG LADY TELLS ME SHE KNOWS YOU? SILVERHORN FINISHED, GINNY
 GRIMACED AT HARRY AND NEVILLE FROM BEHIND SILVERHORN'S BACK. WELL
 NOW, THIS IS MOST PLEASANT, SAID SILVERHORN CHEERILY. A CHANCE TO
 GET THE KNOW YOU ALL A LITTLE BETTER, HERE, TAKE A NAPKIN, I'VE
 PACKED MY OWN LUNCH; THE TRUTH, AS I REMEMBER IT, IS HEAVY ON
 LICHEN WINGS, AND A POOR OLD MAN'S DIGESTIVE SYSTEM ISN'T WHITE
 UP THE SUCH THINGS. PLEASANT, KELLY? KELLY STARTED AND ACCEPTED
 WHAT LOOKED LIKE HALF A CHICK PLEASANT. I WAS JUST TELLING YOUNG
 MARCUS HERE THAT I HAD THE PLEASURE OF TEACHING HIS LITTLE
 DAMELICKS. SILVERHORN TOLD HARRY AND NEVILLE, NOW PASSING AROUND
 A BASKET OF EGGS. ELITESTANDING WIZARD, ELITESTANDING, AND HIS
 FATHER OF MERLIN MUST BE WELL-DERIVED, DO YOU SEE MUCH OF YOUR
 LITTLE, MARCUS? UNFORTUNATELY, KELLY HAD JUST TAKEN A LARGE
 MOUTHFUL OF PLEASANT; IN HIS HASTE THE ANSWER SILVERHORN HE
 SWALLOWED TOO FAST, TURNED PURPLE, AND BEGAN TO CHOKE.

ANAPNEH, SAID SILVERHORN CALMLY, POINTING HIS WAND AT KELLY,
 WHOSE AIRWAY SEEMED TOO CLEAR AT ONCE. NEH? NEH MUCH OF HIM,
 NEH, GASPED KELLY, HIS EYES STREAMING. WELL, OF COURSE, I DARE SAY
 HE'S BLISSY, SAID SILVERHORN, LOOKING ELDESTIMININGLY AT KELLY. I
 BELIEVE HE INVENTED THE WHOLESCOME POTION WITHOUT CONSIDERABLE
 HARD WORK? I SUPPOSE SAID KELLY, WHO SEEMED AFRAID TO TAKE
 ANOTHER BITE OF PLEASANT UNTIL HE WAS SURE THAT SILVERHORN HAD
 FINISHED WITH HIM. ER HE AND MY DAD DON'T GET ON VERY WELL, YOU
 SEE, SEE I DON'T REALLY KNOW MUCH ABOUT HIS VOICE TAILED AWAY
 AS SILVERHORN GAVE HIM A CHIMP SMILE AND TURNED TO MCKAGGEN
 INSTEAD. NOW, YOU, CHERMIE, SAID SILVERHORN, I HAPPEN TO KNOW
 YOU SEE A LOT OF YOUR LITTLE TIGERLIS, BECAUSE HE HAS A RATHER
 SPLENDID PICTURE OF THE TWO OF YOU HUNTING NIGHTS IN, I THINK,
 NEHEHEHE? EH, YES, THAT WAS FUN, THAT WAS, SAID MCKAGGEN.

WE WENT WITH BERTIE BIGGS AND ROLAND SCRIMPHEAR THIS WAS
 BEFORE HE BECAME MINISTER, HEYHEHEHE? AH, YOU KNOW BERTIE
 AND ROLAND THEN? BEAMED SILVERHORN, NOW OFFERING AROUND A SMALL
 TRAY OF PIES; SOMEHOW, KELLY WAS MISSED OUT. NOW TELL ME IT

WAS AS HARRY HAD SUSPECTED. EVERYONE HERE SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN
 INVITED BECAUSE THEY WERE CONNECTED TO THE SHIPKIND WELL-KNOWN AND
 INFLUENTIAL. EVERYONE EXCEPT GINNY, ZAKINI, WHO WAS
 INTERVIEWED AFTER MCLAGGEN, TURNED OUT TO HAVE A FAMOUSLY
 BEAUTIFUL WIFE AND A MOTHER (FROM WHAT HARRY COULD MAKE OUT,
 SHE HAD BEEN MARRIED SEVEN TIMES, EACH OF HER HUSBANDS DYING
 MYSTERIOUSLY AND LEAVING HER PREGNANT OR CHILD. IT WAS NEVILLE'S
 TURN NEXT. THIS WAS A VERY UNCOMFORTABLE TEN MINUTES, AND
 NEVILLE'S PARENTS, WELL-KNOWN ALIENS, HAD BEEN THROWN INTO
 INSANITY BY BELLATRIX LESTRANGE AND A COUPLE OF DEATH EATER
 CREWIES. AT THE END OF NEVILLE'S INTERVIEW, HARRY HAD THE
 IMPRESSION THAT SILVERHORN WAS RESERVING JUDGMENT ON NEVILLE,
 YET HE DID NOT KNOW IF HE HAD ANY OF HIS PARENTS' FAIR. AND THEN,
 SAID SILVERHORN, SHIFTING MASSIVELY IN HIS SEAT WITH THE AIR OF A
 CHAMPION INTRODUCING HIS STAR ACT. HARRY SMILED. WHERE THE HELL
 I FEEL I HARDLY SCRATCHED THE SURFACE WHEN WE MET OVER THE
 SUMMER? HE CONTEMPLATED HARRY FOR A MOMENT AS THOUGH HE WAS
 A PARTICULARLY LARGE AND SKILFUL PIECE OF MEAT, THEN SAID,
 THE CHIEF HERE, THEY'RE CALLING YOU NOW. HARRY SAID NOTHING.
 KELLY, MCLAGGEN, AND ZAKINI WERE ALL STARING AT HIM. HE CHUCKLED,
 SAID SILVERHORN, WATCHING HARRY CLOSELY. THERE HAVE BEEN RUMORS
 FOR YEARS. I REMEMBER WHEN WELL AFTER THAT TERRIBLE NIGHT
 LILY, JAMES, AND PETER SURVIVED AND THE WORD WAS THAT
 PETER MUST HAVE BEEN BEYOND THE ORDINARY. ZAKINI GAVE A TINY
 LITTLE CHUCKLE THAT WAS CLEARLY SUPPRESSED TO INDICATE AMUSED
 SKEPTICISM. AN ANGRY VOICE BLASTED OUT FROM BEHIND SILVERHORN.
 Yeah, ZAKINI, BECAUSE YOU'RE SO TALENTED AT PESSIMISM. HE
 DEAR? CHUCKLED SILVERHORN COMFORTABLY, LEANING AHEAD AT GINNY,
 WHO WAS GLARING AT ZAKINI AHEAD SILVERHORN'S GREAT KELLY. YOU
 WANT TO BE CAREFUL, BLAISE? I SAW THIS YOUNG LADY PERFORM THE MOST
 MARVELOUS BACKFLIP EVER AS I WAS PASSING HER CARRIAGE. I
 WOULDNT CROSS HER? ZAKINI MERELY SMILED CONTEMPTUOUSLY.
 ANYWAY, SAID SILVERHORN, TURNING BACK TO HARRY. SUCH RUMORS
 THIS SUMMER. HE CHUCKLED, HE DOESN'T KNOW WHAT TO BELIEVE, THE
 PROPHECY HAS BEEN KNOWN THE FIRST INACCURACIES, MADE MISTAKES
 BUT THERE SEEMS LITTLE DOUBT, GIVEN THE NUMBER OF WITNESSES, THAT
 THERE WAS SOME DISTURBANCE AT THE MINISTRY AND THAT YOU WERE
 THERE IN THE THICK OF IT ALL. HARRY, WHO COULD NOT SEE ANY WAY

HELT UP THIS WITHOUT FLATLY LYING, NEEDED BUT STILL SAID NOTHING. SLEIGHORN BEAMED AT HIM. SHE MUSED, SHE MUSED, SHE WONDER DUMKLEBHERE IS SHE FIND THEM WERE THERE, THEN? BUT THE REST OF THE STORIES SHE SENSATIONAL, OF COURSE, HEN DEESEN T DENYEN WHITE WHAT THE BELIEVE THIS FABLED PROPHECY, FOR INSTANCE WE NEVER HEARD A PROPHECY, SAID NEVILLE, TURNING GERANILIM PINK AS HE SAID IT. THAT'S RIGHT, SAID GINNY STALINELY, NEVILLE AND I WERE BOTH THERE THEN, AND ALL THIS CHESSE HEN BLISSISH IS JUST THE PROPHECY MAKING THINGS UP AS USUAL. THEM WERE BOTH THERE THEN, WERE THEY? SAID SLEIGHORN WITH GREAT INTEREST, LEERING FROM GINNY THE NEVILLE, BUT BOTH OF THEM SAT CLAMOR BEHIND HIS ENCOURAGING SMILE. YES WELL IT IS TRUE THAT THE PROPHECY OFTEN EXAGGERATES, OF COURSE. SLEIGHORN SAID, SOUNDING A LITTLE DISAPPOINTED. I REMEMBER DEAR CLEWING TELLING ME (CLEWING JONES, I MEAN, OF COURSE, CAPTAIN OF THE FIGHT-HEAD FIGHTERS! HE MEANDERED OFF INTO A LONG-WINDED REMINISCENCE, BUT HARRY HAD THE DISTINCT IMPRESSION THAT SLEIGHORN HAD NOT FINISHED WITH HIM, AND THAT HE HAD NOT BEEN CONVINCED BY NEVILLE AND GINNY. THE AFTERNOON WHEN HE WITH MORE ANECDOTES ABOUT ILLUSTRIOUS WIZARDS SLEIGHORN HAD TALKED, ALL OF WHOM HAD BEEN DELIGHTED THE MORE WHAT HE CALLED THE SLUG CLUB AT FLEWARTS, HARRY COULD NOT WAIT THE LEAVE, BUT COULD NOT SEE THEM THE DEE SHE POLITELY, FINALLY THE TRAIN EMERGED FROM YET ANOTHER LONG MISTY STRETCH INTO A RED SUNSET, AND SLEIGHORN BEAMED AROUND, BLINKING IN THE TWILIGHT. GOOD GRACIOUS, IT'S GETTING DARK ALREADY? I DIDN'T NOTICE THAT THEY'D LIT THE LAMPS? THEY'D BETTER GO AND CHANGE INTO THEIR ROBES, ALL OF THEM. MCLAGGEN, THEY MUST DROP BY AND SHOWER THAT KISS ON NEGTAILS. HARRY, BLISS AND TIME THEY'RE PASSING, SAME GUESSES THEY, MISS, HE TWINKLED AT GINNY. WELL, OFF THEY GO, OFF THEY GO? AS HE PULSED PAST HARRY INTO THE DARKENING CORRIDOR, ZAKINI SEETH HIM A FILTHY LEED THAT HARRY RETURNED WITH INTEREST. HE, GINNY, AND NEVILLE FOLLOWED ZAKINI BACK ALONG THE TRAIN. I'M GLAD THAT'S OVER, MUTTERED NEVILLE. STRANGE MAN, ISN'T HE? YEAH, HE IS A BIT, SAID HARRY, HIS EYES ON ZAKINI. WHEN THEY WERE END UP IN THERE, GINNY? HE SAW ME HERE ZACHARIAS SMITH, SAID GINNY.

THEY REMEMBER THAT IDIOT FROM FLEWARTS WHO WAS IN THE DAY HE KEPT HIM AND HIM ASKING ABOUT WHAT HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY AND IN THE END HE ANSWERED ME SHE MUCH I HEARD HIM WHEN SLEIGHORN

CAME IN I THOUGHT I WAS GOING TO GET DETENTION, BUT HE JUST
THOUGHT IT WAS A REALLY GOOD Joke AND INVITED ME TO LUNCH! MAD,
EH? BETTER REASON FOR INVITING SOMEONE THAN BECAUSE THEIR
MOTHER'S FRIENDS, SAID HARRY, SMILING AT THE BACK OF ZAKINI'S
HEAD, HE BECAUSE THEIR LUCK. BUT HE KNEW HER, AN IDEA HAD
JUST OCCURRED TO HIM, A RECKLESS BUT POTENTIALLY WONDERFUL IDEA.
IN A MINUTE'S TIME, ZAKINI WAS GOING TO REENTER THE SIXTY-THIRD
SIXTH-FLIGHT COMPARTMENT AND MALCOLM WOULD BE SITTING THERE,
THINKING HIMSELF UNHARMED BY ANYBODY EXCEPT FELLOW SIXTY-THIRDS.
IF HARRY COULD ONLY ENTER, LISTEN, BEHIND HIM, WHAT MIGHT HE NOT
SEE OR HEAR? TRUE, THERE WAS LITTLE OF THE JOURNEY LEFT
BUT THE STATION HAD TO BE LESS THAN HALF AN HOUR AWAY,
JUDGING BY THE WILDERNESS OF THE SCENERY FLASHING BY THE WINDOWS
BUT NOBODY ELSE SEEMED PREPARED TO TAKE HARRY'S SUSPICIONS
SERIOUSLY, SO IT WAS UP TO HIM TO PROVE THEM. I'LL SEE YOU THEN
LATER, SAID HARRY UNDER HIS BREATH, PULLING OUT HIS INVISIBILITY
CLASP AND SLINGING IT OVER HIMSELF, BUT WHAT RE YOU? ASKED
NEVILLE. LATER, HE WHISPERED HARRY, DARTING AFTER ZAKINI AS QUIETLY
AS POSSIBLE, THOUGH THE RATTLING OF THE TRAIN MADE SUCH CALLS
ALMOST HEARDIBLE. THE CORRIDORS WERE ALMOST COMPLETELY EMPTY
NOW, NEARLY EVERYONE HAD RETURNED TO THEIR CARRIAGES TO CHANGE
INTO THEIR SCHOOL ROBES AND PACK UP THEIR POSSESSIONS, THOUGH
HE WAS AS CLOSE AS HE COULD GET TO ZAKINI WITHOUT TOUCHING HIM,
HARRY WAS NOT BRICK ENOUGH TO SLIP INTO THE COMPARTMENT WHEN
ZAKINI OPENED THE DOOR. ZAKINI WAS ALREADY SLIDING IT SHUT WHEN
HARRY HASTILY STUCK OUT HIS ARM TO PREVENT IT CLOSING. WHAT'S
WRONG WITH THIS THING? SAID ZAKINI ANGRILY AS HE SMASHED THE
SLIDING DOOR REPEATEDLY INTO HARRY'S ARM. HARRY SEIZED THE DOOR
AND PUSHED IT OPEN, HARD. ZAKINI, STILL CLINGING TO THE HANDLE,
TUMBLING OVER SIDEWAYS INTO GREGORY GOYLE'S LAP, AND IN THE
ENSLING CLICKS, HARRY DARTED INTO THE COMPARTMENT, LEAPT TOWARD
ZAKINI'S TEMPORARILY EMPTY SEAT, AND HUNG HIMSELF UP INTO THE
LUGGAGE RACK. IT WAS FORTUNATE THAT GOYLE AND ZAKINI WERE
SNARLING AT EACH OTHER, DRAWING ALL EYES TOWARD THEM, FOR HARRY
WAS WHITE SURE HIS FEET AND ANKLES HAD BEEN REVEALED AS THE CLASP
HAD FLAPPED AROUND THEM. INDEED, FOR ONE TERRIBLE MOMENT HE
THOUGHT HE SAW MALCOLM'S EYES FOLLOW HIS TRAINER AS IT WHIPPED
UPWARD OUT OF SIGHT, BUT THEN GOYLE SLAMMED THE DOOR SHUT AND

ALLING ZAKINI OFF HIM! ZAKINI COLLAPSED INTO HIS OWN SEAT LAUGHING
RUEFULLY, VINCENT CRACKER RETURNED TO HIS CHAIR, AND MALFOY,
SNIGGERING, LAY BACK BEHIND ACROSS TWO SEATS WITH HIS HEAD IN PANSY
PARKINSON'S LAP. HARRY LAY CLIMBED UNCOMFORTABLY UNDER THE CHAIR
THE ENSURE THAT EVERY INCH OF HIM REMAINED HIDDEN, AND WATCHED
PANSY STROKE THE SLEEK BLOND HAIR OFF MALFOY'S FOREHEAD, SMIRKING
AS SHE DID SO, AS THOUGH ANYONE WOULD HAVE BELIEVED THEY WOULD BE IN
HER PLACE. THE LANTERNS SWINGING FROM THE CARRIAGE CEILING CAST A
BRIGHT LIGHT OVER THE SCENE! HARRY COULD READ EVERY WORD OF
CRACKER'S CHAIR DIRECTLY BEFORE HIM. SEE, ZAKINI, SAID MALFOY, WHAT
DID SILVERHORN WANT? JUST TRYING TO MAKE UP THE WELL-CONNECTED
PEOPLE, SAID ZAKINI, WHO WAS STILL GAWKING AT HER. NOT THAT
HE MANAGED TO FIND MANY. THIS INFORMATION DID NOT SEEM TO PLEASE
MALFOY. WHO ELSE HAD HE INVITED? HE DEMANDED. MCLAGGEN FROM
GROSSINGHAM, SAID ZAKINI. EH? YES, HIS UNCLE'S KID IN THE
MINISTRY, SAID MALFOY. SOMEONE ELSE CALLED BELLY, FROM
RAVENCLAW. NOT HIM, HE'S A PRAT! SAID PANSY, AND
LUNGEHEATH, PITTER, AND THAT WEASLEY GIRL, FINISHED ZAKINI.
MALFOY SAT UP VERY SUDDENLY, DENYING PANSY'S HAND ASIDE. HE
INVITED LUNGEHEATH? WELL, I ASSUME SHE, AS LUNGEHEATH WAS
THERE, SAID ZAKINI INDIFFERENTLY. WHAT'S LUNGEHEATH GET THE
INTEREST SILVERHORN? ZAKINI SMUGGLED, PITTER, PRECISELY PITTER,
HEAVILY HE WANTED A LOOK AT THE CHIEF ONE, SNEERED MALFOY,
BUT THAT WEASLEY GIRL! WHAT'S SHE SPECIAL ABOUT HER? A LOT OF
KIDS LIKE HER, SAID PANSY, WATCHING MALFOY GLUT IN THE CORNER OF
HER EYES FOR HIS REACTION. EVEN WHEN THINK SHE'S GOOD-LOOKING,
BUT NOT WHEN, BLAISE, AND WE ALL KNOW HOW HARD WHEN ARE THE PLEASE! I
WOULDN'T THINK A FILTHY LITTLE BLEED TRAITOR LIKE HER WOULD EVER SHE
LOOKED LIKE, SAID ZAKINI COLDLY, AND PANSY LOOKED PLEASED. MALFOY
SANK BACK ACROSS HER LAP AND ALLOWED HER TO RESUME THE STROKING
OF HIS HAIR. WELL, I PITY SILVERHORN'S TASTE, MAYBE HE'S GOING A BIT
SENILE. SHAME, MY FATHER ALWAYS SAID HE WAS A GOOD WIZARD IN HIS
DAY, MY FATHER USED TO BE A BIT OF A FAVORITE OF HIS. SILVERHORN
PREVIOUSLY HADN'T HEARD I'M ON THE TRAIN, HE I WOULDN'T HAVE
HAD AN INVITATION, SAID ZAKINI. HE ASKED ME ABOUT NUTT'S FATHER
WHEN I FIRST ARRIVED. THEY USED TO BE OLD FRIENDS, APPARENTLY, BUT
WHEN HE HEARD HE'D BEEN CALLED AT THE MINISTRY HE DIDN'T LOOK
HAPPY, AND NUTT DIDN'T GET AN INVITATION, DID HE? I DON'T THINK

SILVERHORN IS INTERESTED IN DEATH PATERS. MALPHY LAUGHED ANGRY, BUT
THROWED HIM A SINGULARLY HUMORLESS LAUGH. WELL, WHO CARES WHAT
HE IS INTERESTED IN? WHAT IS HE, WHEN YOU COME DOWN THE IT? JUST
SOME STUPID TEACHER. MALPHY PALMED HESTITATELY. I MEAN, I
MIGHT MEET EVEN BE AT FLEGLARTS NEXT YEAR, WHAT IS IT MATTER TO ME
IF SOME FAT OLD HAS BEEN LIKES ME HER MEET? WHAT DO YOU MEAN, YOU
MIGHT MEET BE AT FLEGLARTS NEXT YEAR? SAID PANSY INDIGNANTLY,
CEASING GROOMING MALPHY AT ONCE. WELL, YOU NEVER KNOW, SAID
MALPHY WITH THE GHOST OF A SMILE. I MIGHT HAVE OR MEET
HIM THE BIGGER AND BETTER THINGS. CRACKLED IN THE LUGGAGE RACK
UNDER HIS CHAIR, HARRY'S HEART BEGAN THE RACE. WHAT WOULD BE
AND FERMINE SAY ABOUT THIS? CRACK AND CRACK WERE COMING AT
MALPHY; APPARENTLY THEY HAD HAD NO IDEAS OF ANY PLANS THE
MAY BE THE BIGGER AND BETTER THINGS. EVEN ZAKINI HAD ALREADY A
LOOK OF CURIOUSITY THE MAN HIS FALGHTY FEATURES. PANSY RESUMED THE
SHEEN STROKING OF MALPHY'S HAIR, LOOKING DUMPELLED. DO YOU
MEAN HIM? MALPHY SHRUGGED. WHETHER WANTS ME THE COMPLETE
MY EDUCATION, BUT PERSONALLY, I DON'T SEE IT AS THAT IMPORTANT
THESE DAYS, I MEAN, THINK ABOUT IT. WHEN THE DARK LEAD TAKES
OVER, IS HE GETTING THE CARE FROM MANY HILLS AND RILTS ANYONE IS
GET? OF COURSE HE ISN'T. IT WILL BE ALL ABOUT THE KIND OF SERVICE HE
RECEIVED, THE LEVEL OF DEVOTION HE WAS GIVEN. AND YOU THINK
YOU WILL BE ABLE TO DO SOMETHING FOR HIM? ASKED ZAKINI STATIONING.

SIXTEEN YEARS OLD AND NOT EVEN FULLY ELIGIBLE YET? I'VE JUST
SAID, HAVEN'T I? MAYBE HE DOESN'T CARE IF I'M ELIGIBLE, MAYBE THE
HIM HE WANTS ME TO DO ISN'T SOMETHING THAT YOU NEED TO BE
ELIGIBLE FOR. SAID MALPHY QUIETLY. CRACK AND CRACK WERE BOTH
SITTING WITH THEIR MOUTHS OPEN LIKE GARGOYLES. PANSY WAS GAZING
DOWN AT MALPHY AS THOUGH SHE HAD NEVER SEEN ANYTHING SHE ALW-
INSPIRING. I CAN SEE FLEGLARTS, SAID MALPHY, CLEARLY RELISHING THE
EFFECT HE HAD CREATED AS HE POINTED HIM OF THE BLACKENED WINDMILL.

WE'D BETTER GET HIM BACKS ON. HARRY WAS SHEELING STARING AT
MALPHY, HE DID NOT NOTICE CRACK REACHING UP FOR HIS TRUNK; AS HE
SWUNG IT DOWN, IT HIT HARRY HARD ON THE SIDE OF THE HEAD. HE LET
HIM AN INVOLUNTARY GASP OF PAIN, AND MALPHY LAUGHED UP AT THE
LUGGAGE RACK, FREELING. HARRY WAS NOT AFRAID OF MALPHY, BUT HE
STILL DID NOT MUCH LIKE THE IDEA OF BEING DISCOVERED HIDING UNDER HIS
INVISIBILITY CLOAK BY A GRIP OF UNFRIENDLY SLOTHFULNESS. EYES STILL

WATERING AND HEAD STILL THROBBING, HE DREW HIS HAND, CAREFULLY NOT THE
DISARRANGE THE CLOTH, AND WAITED, BREATH HELD. THEN HIS RELIEF, MALPHY
SEEMED TO DECIDE THAT HE HAD IMAGINED THE NOISE; HE PULLED UP HIS
REEKS LIKE THE OTHERS, LOCKED HIS TROLLEY, AND AS THE TRAIN SLOWED TO
A LERDY CRAWL, FASTENED A THICK NEW TRAVELING CLOTH AROUND HIS
NECK. HARRY COULD SEE THE CORRIDORS FILLING UP AGAIN AND HOPED
THAT HIRSHINE AND BEN WOULD TAKE HIS THINGS AWAY BEFORE THE
PLATFORM AWOKE HIM; HE WAS STUCK WHERE HE WAS UNTIL THE
COMPARTMENT HAD ALMOST EMPTIED. AT LAST, WITH A FINAL CLUCK, THE
TRAIN CAME TO A COMPLETE HALT. GEORGE THREW THE DOOR OPEN AND
MISSED HIS WAY OUT INTO A CROWD OF SECOND YEARS, PLUNGING THEM
ASIDE; CRACK AND ZAKINI FOLLOWED. THEN HE HEARD MALPHY TELL PANSY,
WHICH WAS WAITING FOR HIM WITH HER HAND HELD OUT AS THOUGH
HOPING HE WOULD HOLD IT. I JUST WANT TO CHECK SOMETHING. PANSY
LEFT. THEN HARRY AND MALPHY WERE ALONE IN THE COMPARTMENT.
PEOPLE WERE FILING PAST, DESCENDING INTO THE DARK PLATFORM.
MALPHY MOVED OVER TO THE COMPARTMENT DOOR AND LET DOWN THE
BLINDS, SEE THAT PEOPLE IN THE CORRIDOR BEYOND COULD NOT PEER IN. HE
THEN RENT DOWN OVER HIS TROLLEY AND OPENED IT AGAIN. HARRY PEERED
DOWN OVER THE EDGE OF THE LUGGAGE RACK, HIS HEART PUMPING A
LITTLE FASTER. WHAT HAD MALPHY WANTED TO HIDE FROM PANSY? WAS HE
ABOUT TO SEE THE MYSTERIOUS KIDNAPER HE HAD SO IMPORTANT TO
MENTION? PETRIFIED TERROR! WITHOUT WARNING, MALPHY POINTED
HIS HAND AT HARRY, WHO WAS INSTANTLY PARALYZED, AS THOUGH IN
SOME MISTAKE, HE THROUPEL OUT OF THE LUGGAGE RACK AND FELL, WITH AN
AGONYING, FLICKER-FLICKERING CRASH, AT MALPHY'S FEET, THE INVISIBILITY
CLOTH TRAPPED BENEATH HIM, HIS WHOLE BODY REVEALED WITH HIS LEGS
STILL CLUTTERED AWKWARDLY INTO THE CRAMPED KNEELING POSITION. HE
COULD NOT MOVE A MUSCLE; HE COULD ONLY GAZE UP AT MALPHY, WHO
SMILED BROADLY. I THOUGHT SO, HE SAID ILLEGIBLY. I HEARD GEORGE'S
TROLLEY HIT YOU, AND I THOUGHT I SAW SOMETHING WHITE FLASH
THROUGH THE AIR AFTER ZAKINI CAME BACK. HIS EYES LINGERED FOR
A MOMENT UPON HARRY'S TRAINERS. THEN DIDN'T HEAR ANYTHING I
CARE ABOUT, BETTER. BUT WHILE I WAS OUT THERE AND HE
STAMPED HARD ON HARRY'S FACE, HARRY FELT HIS NOSE BREAK; BLEED
SPLOTTED EVERYWHERE. THAT'S FROM MY FATHER. THEN, LET'S SEE.
MALPHY DRAGGED THE CLOTH AWAY FROM UNDER HARRY'S IMMobilIZED BODY
AND THREW IT OVER HIM. I DON'T RECKON THEY'LL FIND YOU TILL THE

TRAIN S RACK IN LONDON, HE SAID QUIETLY, SEE WHY ARTHUR, PETER
HIS MIND. AND TAKING CARE THE TREAD OF HARRY S FINGERS, MALPHY
LEFT THE COMPARTMENT, SNARE VICTORIOUS HARRY CHILD NOT MOVE A
MUSCLE, HE WAS THERE BENEATH THE INVISIBILITY CHARM FEELING THE
BLEED FROM HIS NOSE FLOW, HOT AND WET, OVER HIS FACE, LISTENING THE
THE VEHICLES AND FEETSTEPS IN THE CORRIDOR BEYOND, HIS IMMEDIATE
THOUGHT WAS THAT SOMEONE, SURELY, WOULD CHECK THE COMPARTMENTS
BEFORE THE TRAIN DEPARTED AGAIN, BUT AT THAT MOMENT THE DISPIRING
REALIZATION THAT EVEN IF SOMEONE WENT INTO THE COMPARTMENT,
HE WOULD BE NEITHER SEEN NOR HEARD, HIS BEST HOPE WAS THAT
SOMEONE ELSE WOULD WALK IN AND STEP ON HIM, HARRY HAD NEVER
HATED MALPHY MORE THAN AS HE WAS THERE, LIKE AN ASLUG TURTLE ON
ITS BACK, BLEED DRIPPING SICKENINGLY INTO HIS OPEN MOUTH, WHAT A
STUPID SITUATION HE HAD LANDED HIMSELF IN AND NOW THE LAST FEW
FEETSTEPS WERE DYING AWAY, EVERYONE WAS SHUFFLING ALONG THE DARK
PLATFORM OUTSIDE, HE COULD HEAR THE SCRAPING OF TRUNKS AND THE
LOUD RATTLE OF TALK, BEN AND HERMIONE WOULD THINK THAT HE HAD
LEFT THE TRAIN WITHOUT THEM, THEN THEY ARRIVED AT HOGWARTS AND
TOOK THEIR PLACES IN THE GREAT HALL, WENT UP AND DOWN THE
GROFFINDBUR TABLE A FEW TIMES, AND FINALLY REALIZED THAT HE WAS NOT
THERE, HE, NOT ONLY, WOULD BE HALFWAY BACK TO LONDON, HE TRIED TO
MAKE A SHIELD, EVEN A GILTY, BUT IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE, THEN HE
REMEMBERED THAT SOME WIZARDS, LIKE DUMBLEDORE, COULD PERFORM
SPELLS WITHOUT SPEAKING, SO HE TRIED TO SUMMON HIS WAND, WHICH
HAD FALLEN OUT OF HIS HAND, BY SAYING THE WORDS ACCIO WAND!
OVER AND OVER AGAIN IN HIS HEAD, BUT NOTHING HAPPENED, HE
THOUGHT HE COULD HEAR THE WHISTLING OF THE TREES THAT SURROUNDED
THE LAKE, AND THE FAR-OFF HUM OF AN HORN, BUT NOT A SINGLE
RING MADE FOR EVEN HE DESPISED HIMSELF SLIGHTLY FOR MISSING IT!
PANICKED VEHICLES WHIZZING WHERE HARRY PETER HAD GONE, A
FEELING OF HELPLESSNESS SPREAD THROUGH HIM AS HE IMAGINED THE
CHUGGING OF STEAM-DRIVEN CARRIAGES TRUNDLING UP THE STEEP
AND THE MUFFLED YELLS OF LAUGHTER ISSUING FROM WHICHEVER CARRIAGE
MALPHY WAS RIDING IN, WHERE HE COULD BE RECKONING HIS ATTACK ON
HARRY THE CRACK, CRASH, CRASH, AND PANSY PARKINSON, THE TRAIN
LURCHED, CAUSING HARRY TO REEL OVER HIS SIDE, NOW HE WAS
STARING AT THE DUSTY UNDERSIDE OF THE SEATS INSTEAD OF THE CEILING,
THE FLOOR BEGAN TO VIBRATE AS THE ENGINE BEARED INTO LIFE, THE

EXPRESS WAS LEAVING AND NEITHER KNEW HE WAS STILL IN IT. THEN HE FELT HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK FLY OFF HIM AND A VOICE OVERHEAD SAID, WHETHER HARRY, THERE WAS A FLASH OF RED LIGHT AND HARRY'S BODY UNFROZE; HE WAS ABLE TO PUSH HIMSELF INTO A MORE DIGNIFIED SITTING POSITION, HASTILY WIPE THE BLOOD OFF HIS REDLINED FACE WITH THE BACK OF HIS HAND, AND RAISE HIS HEAD TO LOOK UP AT THEM, WHO WAS HOLDING THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK SHE HAD JUST PULLED AWAY. WE'D BETTER GET OUT OF HERE, QUICKLY, SHE SAID, AS THE TRAIN WHISTLES BECAME ENCLOSED WITH STEAM AND THEY BEGAN TO MOVE OUT OF THE STATION. COME ON, WE'LL GO. HARRY FLURRIED AFTER HER INTO THE CORRIDOR. SHE PULLED OPEN THE TRAIN DOOR AND LEAPT ONTO THE PLATFORM, WHICH SEEMED TO BE SLIDING UNDERNEATH THEM AS THE TRAIN GATHERED MOMENTUM. HE FOLLOWED HER, STAGGERED A LITTLE ON LANDING, THEN STRAIGHTENED UP IN TIME TO SEE THE GLEAMING SCARLET STEAM ENGINE PICK UP SPEED, ROLLING THE CORNER, AND DISAPPEAR FROM VIEW. THE COLD NIGHT AIR WAS SHOOTING IN HIS TREKING NOSE. THEM WAS LOOKING AT HIM; HE FELT ANGRY AND EMBARRASSED THAT HE HAD BEEN DISCOVERED IN SUCH A RIDICULOUS POSITION. SILENTLY SHE HANDED HIM BACK THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK. WHO DID IT? DRACH MALPHE, SAID HARRY BITTERLY. THANKS FOR WELL. OH PROBLEM, SAID THEM, WITHOUT SMILING, FROM WHAT HARRY COULD SEE IN THE DARKNESS, SHE WAS AS MELLY-FAIRED AND MISERABLE-LOOKING AS SHE HAD BEEN WHEN HE HAD MET HER AT THE CLIFFS. I CAN FIX YOUR NOSE IF YOU STAND STILL. HARRY DID NOT THINK MUCH OF THIS IDEA; HE HAD BEEN INTENDING TO VISIT MADAM POMPREE, THE MATRON, IN WHOM HE HAD A LITTLE MORE CONFIDENCE WHEN IT CAME TO HEALING SPELLS, BUT IT SEEMED WISE TO SAY THIS, SO HE STAYED STOCK-STILL AND CLOSED HIS EYES. POISKEY, SAID THEM, HARRY'S NOSE FELT VERY HOT, AND THEN VERY COLD. HE RAISED A HAND AND FELT IT GINGERLY. IT SEEMED TO BE MENDED. THANKS A LOT! YOU'D BETTER PUT THAT CLOAK BACK ON, AND WE CAN WALK UP TO THE SCHOOL, SAID THEM, STILL UNSMILING. AS HARRY SWUNG THE CLOAK BACK OVER HIMSELF, SHE WAVED HER HAND; AN IMMENSE SILVERY PHIL-LEGGED CREATURE ERIPTED FROM IT AND STREADED OFF INTO THE DARKNESS. WAS THAT A PATRONUS? ASKED HARRY, WHO HAD SEEN OLIMPELRE SEND MESSAGES LIKE THIS. YES, I'M SENDING WORD TO THE CASTLE THAT I'VE GOTTEN YOU FOR THEY'LL BEHOLD. COME ON, WE'D BETTER NOT DANGLE. THEY SET OFF TOWARD THE LAKE THAT LED TO THE SCHOOL. HOW DID YOU FIND ME? I NOTICED YOU HADN'T LEFT THE TRAIN

AND I KNEW YELL HAD THAT CLHAK, I THHUGHT YELL MIGHT BE HIDING HER
SOME REASON. WHEN I SAW THE BLINDS WERE DRAWN DOWN HEN THAT
CHMPARTMENT I THHUGHT I D CHECK. BUT WHAT ARE YELL DOING HERE,
ANYWAY? HARRY ASKED. I M STATINED IN HEGSMRDE NELL, TH GIVE
THE SCHEEL EXTRA PROTECTION, SAID THENDS. IS IT ILST YELL WHE S
STATINED LIP HERE, ER ? NEH, PRELIDHEHT, SAVAGE, AND DALISH
ARE HERE THEE. DALISH, THAT ALIRER DUMKEDHRE ATTACKED LAST
YEAR? THAT S RIGHT. THEY TRIDGED LIP THE DARK, DESERTED LANE,
FOLLOWING THE FRESHLY MADE CARRIAGE TRACKS. HARRY LHHKED SIDWAYS
AT THENDS LINDER HIS CLHAK. LAST YEAR SHE HAD BEEN INHESITIVE (THE
THE PHINT OF BEING A LITTLE ANNOYING AT TIMES), SHE HAD LAUGHED
EASILY, SHE HAD MADE IHES. NELL SHE SEEMED HIDER AND MUCH MORE
SERIOUS AND PURPOSEFUL. WAS THIS ALL THE EFFECT OF WHAT HAD
HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY? HE REFLECTED LINCHEMPTARTLY THAT
HERMIONE WOULD HAVE SUGGESTED HE SAY SOMETHING CONCERNING
ARHET SIRILIS TO HER, THAT IT HADN T BEEN HER FAULT AT ALL, BUT HE
CHLDN T BRING HIMSELF TO DO IT. HE WAS FAR FROM BLAMING HER FOR
SIRILIS S DEATH; IT WAS NEH MORE HER FAULT THAN ANYONE ELSE S (AND
MUCH LESS THAN HIS), BUT HE DID NOT LIKE TALKING ARHET SIRILIS IF HE
CHLD AVOID IT. AND SHE THEY TRAPPED HEN THROUGH THE CHD NIGHT IN
SILENCE. THENDS S LING CLHAK WHISPERING HEN THE CARLIND BEHIND
THEM. HAVING ALWAYS TRAVELED THERE BY CARRIAGE, HARRY HAD NEVER
BEFORE APPRECIATED ILST HEN FAR HEGWARTS WAS FROM HEGSMRDE
STATION. WITH GREAT RELIEF HE FINALLY SAW THE TALL PILLARS HEN
EITHER SIDE OF THE GATES, EACH TOPPED WITH A WINGED KHAR. HE WAS
CHD, HE WAS HUNGRY, AND HE WAS WHITE BEEN TO LEAVE THIS NELL,
GLENNY THENDS BEHIND. BUT WHEN HE PUT HLT A HAND TO PUSH OPEN
THE GATES, HE FELIND THEM CHAINED SHLT. ALHEHHEHRA? HE SAID
CONFIDENTLY, PHINTING HIS HAND AT THE PADLOCK, BUT NOTHING
HAPPENED. THAT WHEN T WHRD HEN THESE, SAID THENDS. DUMKEDHRE
REWITCHED THEM HIMSELF. HARRY LHHKED ARHLIND. I CHLD CLIMB A
WALL, HE SUGGESTED. NEH, YELL CHLDN T, SAID THENDS FLATLY. ANTI-
INTRUDER IINES HEN ALL OF THEM. SECURITY S BEEN TIGHTENED A
HUNDREDFOLD THIS SUMMER. WELL THEN, SAID HARRY, STARTING TO
FEEL ANNOYED AT HER LACK OF HELPFULNESS. I SUPPOSE I LL ILST HAVE
TO SLEEP HLT HERE AND WAIT FOR MORNING. SOMEBODY S CHMING DOWN
FOR YELL, SAID THENDS. LHHK. A LANTERN WAS BEERING AT THE
DISTANT PHET OF THE CASTLE. HARRY WAS SHE PLEASED TO SEE IT HE FELT HE

could even endure Filch's weekly criticisms of his tardiness and Runt's abhorrent smell. His timekeeping would improve with the regular application of thumbstrews. It was not until the glowing yellow light was ten feet away from them, and Harry had pulled off his invisibility cloak, that he could be seen, that he recognized, with a rush of pure loathing, the split-haired nose and long, black, greasy hair of Severus Snape. Well, well, well, sneered Snape, taking out his wand and tapping the marble floor, that the chains snapped backward and the gates creaked open. Nice of you to turn up, Pottter, although you have evidently decided that the wearing of school robes would detract from your appearance. I couldn't change, I didn't have my wand. Harry began, but Snape cut across him. There is no need to wait, Nymphadora, Pottter is elite and safe in my hands. I meant Harry to get the message, said Tonks, frowning. Harry was late for the start-of-term feast, just like Pottter here, so I think it instead, and incidentally, said Snape, standing back to allow Harry to pass him. I was interested to see your new patronus. He split the gates in her face with a loud clang and tapped the chains with his wand again, so that they slithered, clinking, back into place. I think you were better off with the old one, said Snape, the malice in his voice unmistakable. The new one looks weak. As Snape swung the lantern about, Harry saw, fleetingly, a look of shock and anger on Tonks's face. Then she was covered in darkness once more. Good night, Harry called to her over his shoulder, as he began the walk up the stairs with Snape. Thanks for everything, see you, Harry. Snape did not speak for a minute or so. Harry felt as though his body was generating waves of hatred so powerful that it seemed incredible that Snape could not feel them burning him. He had loathed Snape from their first encounter, but Snape had placed himself forever and irrevocably beyond the possibility of Harry's forgiveness by his attitude toward Sirius. Whatever Dumbledore said, Harry had had time to think over the summer, and had concluded that Snape's snide remarks to Sirius about remaining safely hidden while the rest of the Order of the Phoenix were off fighting Voldemort had probably been a powerful factor in Sirius rushing off to the Ministry the night that he had died. Harry

CLINGING TO THIS NOTION, REALISE IT ENABLED HIM THE BLAME SNAPE, WHICH
FELT SATISFYING, AND ALSO REALISE HE KNEW THAT IF ANYONE WAS NOT
SHERRY THAT SIRILIS WAS DEAD, IT WAS THE MAN NOW STRIDING NEXT TO
HIM IN THE DARKNESS. FIFTY POINTS FROM CROPPINGHER FOR LATENESS, I
THINK, SAID SNAPE. AND, LET ME SEE, ANOTHER TWENTY FOR WEIRD
MISCELLANEOUS ATTIRE. WELL DONE, I DON'T BELIEVE ANY FELLOW HAS EVER BEEN
IN NEGATIVE FIGURES THIS EARLY IN THE TERM! WE HAVEN'T EVEN
STARTED PLIDDING, WELL MIGHT HAVE SET A RECORD, PENTTER. THE FLURY
AND HATED KLICKING INSIDE FARRY SEEMED THE BLAZE WHITE-LIGHT, BUT HE
WOULD RATHER HAVE BEEN IMMOBILIZED ALL THE WAY BACK THE LINDEN
THAN TELL SNAPE WHY HE WAS LATE. I SUPPOSE WELL WANTED THE MAKE
AN ENTRANCE, DID WELL? SNAPE CONTINUED, AND WITH NO FLYING CAR
AVAILABLE WELL DECIDED THAT CLIMBING INTO THE GREAT HALL HALLWAY
THROUGH THE PLAST LIGHT TO CREATE A DRAMATIC EFFECT. STILL FARRY
REMAINED SILENT, THOUGH HE THOUGHT HIS CHEST MIGHT EXPLODE. HE
KNEW THAT SNAPE HAD COME TO FETCH HIM FOR THIS, FOR THE FEW
MINUTES WHEN HE COULD NEEDLE AND THREATEN FARRY WITHOUT ANYONE
ELSE LISTENING. THEY REACHED THE CASTLE STEPS AT LAST AND AS THE
GREAT HADEN FRONT DOORS SWUNG OPEN INTO THE VAST FLAGGED
ENTRANCE HALL, A BURST OF LIGHT AND BRIGHTER AND OF TINKLING PLATES
AND GLASSES GREETED THEM THROUGH THE DOORS STANDING OPEN INTO
THE GREAT HALL. FARRY WONDERED WHETHER HE COULD SLIP HIS
INVISIBILITY CLOAK BACK ON, THEREBY GAINING HIS SEAT AT THE LONG
CROPPINGHER TABLE WHICH, INCONVENIENTLY, WAS THE FARTHEST FROM
THE ENTRANCE HALL WITHOUT BEING NOTICED. AS THOUGH HE HAD READ
FARRY'S MIND, HOWEVER, SNAPE SAID, NO CLOAK. WELL CAN WALK IN SEE
THAT EVERYONE SEES WELL, WHICH IS WHAT WELL WANTED, I'M SURE.
FARRY TURNED HIM THE SPOT AND MARCHED STRAIGHT THROUGH THE
OPEN DOORS: ANYTHING TO GET AWAY FROM SNAPE. THE GREAT HALL,
WITH ITS WEIRD LONG FELLOW TABLES AND ITS STAFF TABLE SET AT THE TOP
OF THE ROOM, WAS DECORATED AS USUAL WITH FLASHING CANDLES THAT
MADE THE PLATES KEEN GLITTER AND GLEW. IT WAS ALL A SHIMMERING
ILLUMINATION FOR FARRY, HOWEVER, WHEN WALKED SO FAST THAT HE WAS PASSING
THE FLIPFLOPP TABLE BEFORE PEOPLE REALLY STARTED TO STARE, AND BY
THE TIME THEY WERE STANDING UP TO GET A GOOD LOOK AT HIM, HE HAD
SPOTTED BEN AND BERMIE, SPED ALONG THE BENCHES TOWARD THEM,
AND FORCED HIS WAY IN BETWEEN THEM. WHERE ARE YOU CLIMBING,
WHAT ARE YOU DOING THE WEIRD FACE? SAID BEN, GOGGLING AT HIM ALONG

WITH EVERYONE ELSE IN THE VICINITY, WHY, WHAT'S WRONG WITH IT? SAID HARRY, GRABING A SPEER AND SHLINTING AT HIS DISTORTED REFLECTION. WHY RE COVERED IN BLEED? SAID HERMIONE. COME HERE

SHE RAISED HER HAND, SAID TERREN? AND SIPHERED OFF THE DRIED BLEED. THANKS, SAID HARRY, FEELING HIS NEEL CLEAN FACE. FEEL'S MY NEEL BLEEDING? NORMAL, SAID HERMIONE ANXIOUSLY. WHY SEHLIDN T IT? HARRY, WHAT HAPPENED? WE VE BEEN TERRIFIED! I LL TELL WHY LATER, SAID HARRY CLUTLY. HE WAS VERY CHENSCHLIS THAT GINNY, NEVILLE, DEAN, AND SEAMUS WERE LISTENING IN; EVEN DEARLY HEADLESS NICK, THE GRYFFINDOR GHOST, HAD COME FLEMATING ALONG THE BENCH THE RAYSDRIMP. BUT SAID HERMIONE. NEXT NEEL, HERMIONE, SAID HARRY, IN A DARKLY SIGNIFICANT VEICE, HE FEELD VERY MUCH THAT THEY WOULD ALL ASSUME HE HAD BEEN INVOLVED IN SOMETHING FERRIC, PREFERABLY INVOLVING A CHILPIL OF DEATH EATERS AND A DEMENTOR. HE CHLIRSE, MALFOY WOULD SPREAD THE STORY AS FAR AND WIDE AS HE CHULD, BUT THERE WAS ALWAYS A CHANCE IT WOULDNT T REACH THE MANY GRYFFINDOR EARS, HE REACHED ACROSS REHN FOR A CHILPIL OF CHICKEN LEGS AND A HANDFUL OF CHIPS, BUT BEFHE HE CHULD TAKE THEM THEY VANISHED, THE RE REPLACED WITH PLIDDINGS. WHY MISSED THE SHIRTING, ANYWAY, SAID HERMIONE, AS REHN DIVED FOR A LARGE CHICHILATE GATEALL. THAT SAY ANYTHING INTERESTING? ASKED HARRY, TAKING A PIECE OF TREACLE TART. MORE OF THE SAME, REALLY ADVISING LIS ALL THE LINTIE IN THE FACE OF HLIR ENEMIES, WHY KNEL.

BLIMPLEBHE MENTIONED VELDMENT AT ALL? NEXT YET, BUT HE ALWAYS SAVES HIS PROPER SPEECH FOR AFTER THE FEAST, DEESN T HE? IT CAN T BE LING NEEL. SNAPE SAID HAGRID WAS LATE FOR THE FEAST WHY VE SEEN SNAPE? FEEL COME? SAID REHN BETWEEN FRENZIED MEHLTYFULS OF GATEALL. BLIMPD INTH HIM, SAID HARRY EVASIVELY. HAGRID WAS ONLY A FEW MINLITES LATE, SAID HERMIONE. BLEED, HE S WAVING AT WHY, HARRY. HARRY BLEEDD LIP AT THE STAFF TABLE AND GRINDD AT HAGRID, WHO WAS INDEED WAVING AT HIM. HAGRID HAD NEVER ELITE MANAGED THE CHMPERT HIMSELF WITH THE DIGNITY OF PROFESSOR MCHENACALL, HEAD OF GRYFFINDOR FEHLISE, THE THP OF WHOSE HEAD CAME LIP THE SEMPLEHERE BETWEEN HAGRID S BLEED AND SEHLIDN AS THEY WERE SITTING SIDE BY SIDE, AND WHO WAS BLEEDING DISAPPROVINGLY AT THIS ENTHUSIASTIC GREETING. HARRY WAS SURPRISED THE SEE THE DIVINATION TEACHER, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, SITTING BEN HAGRID S EITHER SIDE; SHE RARELY LEFT HER TOWER ROOM, AND HE HAD NEVER SEEN

HER AT THE START-OF-TERM FEAST BEHIND. SHE SMILED AS BOLD AS EVER, GLITTERING WITH BEADS AND TRAILING STALKS, HER EYES MAGNIFIED THE ENORMOUS SIZE BY HER SPECTACLES. HAVING ALWAYS CONSIDERED HER A BIT OF A FOOL, HARRY HAD BEEN SHOCKED THE DISCOVERY AT THE END OF THE PREVIOUS TERM THAT IT HAD BEEN SHE WHO HAD MADE THE PREDICTION THAT CAUSED LORD VOLDEMORT THE KILL HARRY'S PARENTS AND ATTACK HARRY HIMSELF. THE KNOWLEDGE HAD MADE HIM EVEN LESS EAGER TO FIND HIMSELF IN HER COMPANY, BUT THANKFULLY, THIS YEAR HE WOULD BE DROPPING DIVINATION. HER GREAT BEACHSIDE EYES SWIVELLED IN HIS DIRECTION; HE HASTILY SMILED AWAY TOWARD THE SLYTHERIN TABLE. DRAGON MALFOY WAS MIMING THE SPATTERING OF A KISS THE RAUCOUS LAUGHTER AND APPLAUSE. HARRY DROPPED HIS GAZE TO HIS TREADLE TART, HIS INSIDES BURNING AGAIN. WHAT HE WOULD NOT GIVE THE FIGHT MALFOY HONORING. SHE WHAT DID PROFESSOR SLUGGERTON WANT? HERMION ASKED. THE KNOW WHAT REALLY HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY, SAID HARRY. HIM AND EVERYONE ELSE HERE, SMILED HERMION. PEOPLE WERE INTERFERING WITH WHAT IT WAS THE TRAIN, WEREN'T THEY, RIGHT? YES, SAID SHE, ALL WANTING THE KNOW IF YOU REALLY ARE THE CHOSEN ONE. THERE HAS BEEN MUCH TALK HERE THAT VERY SUBJECT EVEN AMONGST THE GHOSTS, INTERRUPTED NEARLY HEADLESS NICK, INCLINING HIS BARELY CONNECTED HEAD TOWARD HARRY SHE THAT IT WINKLED DANGEROUSLY IN ITS RUFF. I AM CONSIDERED SOMETHING OF A BETTER AUTHORITY; IT IS WIDELY KNOWN THAT WE ARE FRIENDLY. I HAVE ASSURED THE SPIRIT COMMUNITY THAT I WILL NOT PESTER YOU FOR INFORMATION, HOWEVER. HARRY BETTER KNOWS THAT HE CAN CONFIDE IN ME WITH COMPLETE CONFIDENCE. I TOLD THEM. I WOULD RATHER DIE THAN BETRAY HIS TRUST. THAT'S NOT SAYING MUCH, SEEING AS YOU'RE ALREADY DEAD. SHE SMILED. THEN HERVED. THEN AGAIN, YOU SHOW ALL THE SENSITIVITY OF A BLIND AXE, SAID NEARLY HEADLESS NICK IN APPARENTED THANKS, AND HE ROSE INTO THE AIR AND GLIDED BACK TOWARD THE FAR END OF THE CRYSTAL TABLE JUST AS DIMPLEDHEE GET THE HIS FEET AT THE STAFF TABLE. THE TALK AND LAUGHTER CEASING AROUND THE HALL DIED AWAY ALMOST INSTANTLY. THE VERY BEST OF EVENINGS THE YOU! HE SAID, SMILING BROADLY, HIS ARMS SPREAD WIDE AS THOUGH THE EMBRACE THE WHILE THEM. WHAT HAPPENED TO HIS HAND? GASPED HERMION. SHE WAS NOT THE ONLY ONE WHO HAD NOTICED. DIMPLEDHEE'S RIGHT HAND WAS AS BLACKENED AND DEAD-LOOKING AS IT HAD BEEN IN THE NIGHT HE HAD COME TO FETCH HARRY FROM THE

DUMBLEDORE, WHISPERS SWEEP THE ROOM; DUMBLEDORE, INTERPRETING THEM
 CORRECTLY, MERELY SMILED AND STOOD HIS PURPLE-AND-GOLD SLEEVE OVER
 HIS INJURY. NOTHING THE WHIRRY ABOUT, HE SAID AIRILY, WHEN THE
 NEW STUDENTS, WELCOME, THE NEW OLD STUDENTS, WELCOME BACK;
 ANOTHER YEAR FULL OF MAGICAL EDUCATION AWAITS YOU HIS HAND
 WAS LIKE THAT WHEN I SAW HIM OVER THE SUMMER, HARRY WHISPERED
 THE FERMINE. I THOUGHT HE D HAVE CLARED IT BY NOW, THOUGH HER
 MADAM POMFREY WOULD VE DONE. IT LOOKS AS IF IT S DIED, SAID
 FERMINE, WITH A NAUSEATED EXPRESSION. BUT THERE ARE SOME
 INJURIES YOU CAN T CLARE OLD CLARES AND THERE ARE PHISONS
 WITHOUT ANTIDOTES. AND MR. FILCH, HER CARETAKER, HAS ASKED
 ME THE DAY THAT THERE IS A BLANKET BANNED ANY MORE ITEMS KNIGHT AT
 THE SHOP CALLED WEASLEYS WIZARD WEASELES. THESE WISHING THE PLAY
 FOR THEIR HOUSE CHIDDITCH TEAMS SHOULD GIVE THEIR NAMES THE THEIR
 HEADS OF HOUSE AS USUAL. WE ARE ALSO WISHING FOR NEW CHIDDITCH
 COMMENTATORS, WHO SHOULD BE LIKEWISE. WE ARE PLEASED TO WELCOME
 A NEW MEMBER OF STAFF THIS YEAR, PROFESSOR SLUGGISHORN
 SLUGGISHORN STOOD UP, HIS BALD HEAD GLEAMING IN THE CANDLELIGHT, HIS
 BIG WAISTCLOATHED BELLY CASTING THE TABLE BEHIND INTO SHADOW IS A
 FORMER CHIEF OF MINE WHO HAS AGREED TO RESUME HIS OLD POST OF
 PHISONS MASTER. PHISONS? PHISONS? THE WORD ECHOED ALL
 OVER THE HALL AS PEOPLE WONDERED WHETHER THEY HAD HEARD RIGHT.
 PHISONS? SAID RON AND FERMINE TOGETHER, TURNING THE STARE AT
 HARRY. BUT YOU SAID PROFESSOR SNAPE, MEANWHILE, SAID
 DUMBLEDORE, RAISING HIS VOICE SO THAT IT CARRIED OVER ALL THE
 MUTTERING. WILL BE TAKING OVER THE PHISONS OF DEFENSE AGAINST
 THE DARK ARTS TEACHER. NO? SAID HARRY, SEEING THAT MANY
 HEADS TURNED IN HIS DIRECTION, HE DID NOT CARE; HE WAS STARING UP
 AT THE STAFF TABLE, INCENSED, HOW COULD SNAPE BE GIVEN THE DEFENSE
 AGAINST THE DARK ARTS NOW AFTER ALL THIS TIME? HADN T IT BEEN
 WIDELY KNOWN FOR YEARS THAT DUMBLEDORE DID NOT TRUST HIM THE DAY IT?
 BUT HARRY, YOU SAID THAT SLUGGISHORN WAS GOING TO BE TEACHING
 DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS? SAID FERMINE. I THOUGHT HE
 WAS? SAID HARRY, RACKING HIS BRAINS TO REMEMBER WHEN DUMBLEDORE
 HAD TOLD HIM THIS, BUT WHEN THAT HE CAME TO THINK OF IT, HE WAS
 UNABLE TO RECALL DUMBLEDORE EVER TELLING HIM WHAT SLUGGISHORN
 WOULD BE TEACHING. SNAPE, WHO WAS SITTING NEXT DUMBLEDORE S RIGHT,
 DID NOT STAND UP AT THE MENTION OF HIS NAME; HE MERELY RAISED A

HAND IN LAZY ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF THE APPLAUSE FROM THE SOUTHERN TABLE, YET HARRY WAS SURE HE COULD DETECT A FLICK OF TRIUMPH IN THE FEATURES HE HATED SO MUCH. WELL, THERE'S ONE GOOD THING, HE SAID SAVAGELY. SNAPE IS BE GONE BY THE END OF THE YEAR. WHAT DID YELL MEAN? ASKED RHN. THAT HE'S LIVED. SHE HAD LASTED MORE THAN A YEAR. HARRY ACTUALLY DIED BEING IT. PERSONALLY, I'M GIVING THE DEEP MY FINGERS CROSSED FOR ANOTHER DEATH. HARRY:

SAID DETERMINED, STICKED AND REPROACHFUL. HE MIGHT JUST GO BACK THE TEACHING POSITIONS AT THE END OF THE YEAR, SAID RHN REASSURINGLY.

THAT SILENTLY RHN MIGHT NOT WANT THE STAY LONG-TERM, MERRY DIDN'T. DUMBLEDORE CLEARED HIS THROAT, HARRY, RHN, AND DETERMINED WERE NOT THE ONLY ONES WHO HAD BEEN TALKING; THE WHILE HALL HAD ERUPTED IN A BLIZZ OF CONVERSATION AT THE NEWS THAT SNAPE HAD FINALLY ACHIEVED HIS HEART'S DESIRE. SEEMINGLY BELIVIOUS THE THE SENSATIONAL NATURE OF THE NEWS HE HAD JUST IMPARTED, DUMBLEDORE SAID NOTHING MORE ABOUT STAFF APPOINTMENTS, BUT WAITED A FEW SECONDS THE ENSURE THAT THE SILENCE WAS ABSOLUTE BEFORE CONTINUING.

WELL, AS EVERYBODY IN THIS HALL KNOWS, LORD VOLDEMORT AND HIS FOLLOWERS ARE BACK HERE AT LARGE AND GAINING IN STRENGTH. THE SILENCE SEEMED THE TALITEN AND STRAIN AS DUMBLEDORE SPoke, HARRY GLANCED AT MERRY, MERRY WAS NOT LOOKING AT DUMBLEDORE, BUT MAKING HIS THIRD FINGER IN MIDAIR WITH HIS HAND, AS THOUGH HE FELT THE HEADMASTER'S WORDS UNWORTHY OF HIS ATTENTION. I CANNOT EMPHASIZE STRONGLY ENOUGH HOW DANGEROUS THE PRESENT SITUATION IS, AND HOW MUCH CARE EACH OF US AT HOGWARTS MUST TAKE THE ENSURE THAT WE REMAIN SAFE. THE CASTLE'S MAGICAL DEFENSATIONS HAVE BEEN STRENGTHENED EVER THE SUMMER, WE ARE PROTECTED IN NEW AND MORE POWERFUL WAYS, BUT WE MUST STILL GUARD SCRUPULOUSLY AGAINST CARELESSNESS ON THE PART OF ANY STUDENT OR MEMBER OF STAFF. I URGE YOU, THEREFORE, TO ABIDE BY ANY SECURITY RESTRICTIONS THAT YOUR TEACHERS MIGHT IMPOSE UPON YOU, HOWEVER IRKSOME YOU MIGHT FIND THEM. IN PARTICULAR, THE RULE THAT YOU ARE NOT TO BE OUT OF BED AFTER HOURS. I IMPLOR YOU, SHOULD YOU NOTICE ANYTHING STRANGE OR SUSPICIOUS WITHIN OR OUTSIDE THE CASTLE, TO REPORT IT TO A MEMBER OF STAFF IMMEDIATELY. I TRUST YOU WILL CONDUCT YOURSELVES, ALWAYS, WITH THE UTMOST REGARD FOR YOUR OWN AND OTHERS' SAFETY. DUMBLEDORE'S BLUE EYES SLEPT OVER THE STUDENTS BEFORE HE SMILED BACK MORE. BUT WELL, YOUR BEDS AWAIT, AS WARM AND

COMFORTABLE AS YOU WOULD POSSIBLY WISH, AND I KNOW THAT YOUR TOP
PRIORITY IS THE BE WELL-RESTED FOR YOUR LESSONS TOMORROW. LET US
THEREFORE SAY GOOD NIGHT. PIP PIP! WITH THE USUAL DRAPENING
SCRAPING NOISE, THE BENCHES WERE MOVED BACK AND THE HUNDREDS OF
STUDENTS BEGAN THE FILE WENT OF THE GREAT HALL TOWARD THEIR
DORMITORIES. HARRY, WHO WAS IN THE HALL AT ALL THE LEAVE WITH THE
CAMPING CREW, WHEN THEY GOT NEAR ENOUGH THE MALPHEUS THEN ASKED HIM
THE RETELL THE STORY OF THE NOISE-STAMPING, LAGGED BEHIND, PRETENDING
THE RETIE THE BACK OF HIS TRAINER, ALLOWING MEET OF THE CROPPINGERS
THE DRAW AHEAD OF HIM. HERMIONE HAD DARTED AHEAD THE PLUMM HER
PERFECT DUTY OF SHEPHERDING THE FIRST YEARS, BUT REMAINED
WITH HARRY. WHAT REALLY HAPPENED THE YOUR NOISE? HE ASKED, SINCE
THEY WERE AT THE VERY BACK OF THE TRAINING PRESSING WENT OF THE
HALL, AND WENT OF EARLIEST OF ANYONE ELSE. HARRY TOLD HIM. IT WAS A
MARK OF THE STRENGTH OF THEIR FRIENDSHIP THAT RON DID NOT LAUGH.

I SAW MALPHEUS MIMING SOMETHING TO ME WITH A NOISE. HE SAID
DARBY. Yeah, well, NEVER MIND THAT, SAID HARRY BITTERLY. LISTEN
THE WHAT HE WAS SAYING BEFORE HE FOUND OUT I WAS THERE. HARRY
HAD EXPECTED RON THEN BE STUNNED BY MALPHEUS'S RHAPS. WITH WHAT
HARRY CONSIDERED PURE PIG-HEADEDNESS, HOWEVER, RON WAS
UNIMRESSED. THERE HE, HARRY, HE WAS JUST SPEAKING OFF FOR
PARKINSON. WHAT KIND OF MISTAKE WOULD YOU KNOW WHAT I HAVE
GIVEN HIM? THEN YOU KNOW VERMONT DOESN'T NEED SOMETHING AT
BRIGHTWATTS? IT WOULDNT BE THE FIRST I WISH YOU'D STOP SAYIN
THE NAME, HARRY, SAID A REPROACHFUL VOICE BEHIND THEM. HARRY
SHOOKED OVER HIS SHOULDER THEN SAW HAGRID SHAKING HIS HEAD.

BLIMBLEBEE USES THAT NAME, SAID HARRY STUBBORNLY. Yeah, well,
THAT'S BLIMBLEBEE, INNY? SAID HAGRID MYSTERIOUSLY. SEE HOW CLOSE
YOU WERE, HARRY? I WAS WHIPPED. GET FELD UP ON THE TRAIN,
SAID HARRY. WE'RE VERY LATE? I WAS WITH GRAMP, SAID
HAGRID HAPPILY. LESS TRACKS IN THE TIME, HE'S GET A NEW FHEM UP
IN THE MOUNTAINS NOW, BLIMBLEBEE FIXED IT. NICE BIG CAVE, HE'S
MUCH HAPPIER THAN HE WAS IN THE FOREST. WE WERE HAVING A GOOD
CHAT. Really? SAID HARRY, TAKING CARE NOT TO CATCH RON'S EYE;
THE LAST TIME HE HAD MET HAGRID'S HALF-BROTHER, A VICIOUS GIANT
WITH A TALENT FOR RIPPING UP TREES BY THE ROOTS, HIS VOCABULARY
HAD COMPRISED FIVE WORDS, TWO OF WHICH HE WAS UNABLE TO
PRONOUNCE PROPERLY. THEN Yeah, HE'S REALLY CLOSE HE, SAID HAGRID

PROBABLY. YOU'LL BE AMAZED, I'M THINKING HE TRAINING HIM UP AS MY ASSISTANT. REIN SNORTED LOUDLY, BUT MANAGED TO PASS IT OFF AS A VIOLENT SNEEZE. THEY WERE NOW STANDING BESIDE THE BACK FRONT DOORS. ANYWAY, I'LL SEE YOU TOMORROW, FIRST LESSON'S STRAIGHT AFTER LUNCH. COME EARLY AND YOU CAN SAY HELLO TO RICK. I MEAN, WITHEWINGS? RAISING AN ARM IN CHEERY FAREWELL, HE HEADED OFF TO THE FRONT DOORS INTO THE DARKNESS. HARRY AND REIN LOOKED AT EACH OTHER. HARRY COULD TELL THAT REIN WAS EXPERIENCING THE SAME STUNNING FEELING AS HIMSELF. YOU'RE NOT TAKING CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES, ARE YOU? REIN SHOOK HIS HEAD. AND YOU'RE NOT EITHER, ARE YOU? HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD TOO. AND HERMIONE, SAID REIN, SHE'S NOT, IS SHE? HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD AGAIN. EXACTLY WHAT HAGRID WOULD SAY WHEN HE REALIZED HIS THREE FAVORITE STUDENTS HAD GIVEN UP HIS SUBJECT, HE DID NOT LIKE THE THING. THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE HARRY AND REIN MET HERMIONE IN THE COMMON ROOM BEFORE BREAKFAST NEXT MORNING. HOPING FOR SOME SUPPORT FOR HIS THEORY, HARRY LEFT NO TIME IN TELLING HERMIONE WHAT HE HAD EVER-HEARD MALPHY SAYING ON THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS. BUT HE WAS HEAVILY SLEEPING OFF HIS PARKINSON, WASN'T HE? INTERRUPTED REIN QUICKLY, BEFORE HERMIONE COULD SAY ANYTHING. WELL, SHE SAID UNCERTAINLY, I DON'T KNOW. IT WOULD BE LIKE MALPHY TO MAKE HIMSELF SEEM MORE IMPORTANT THAN HE IS. BUT THAT'S A BIG LIE TO TELL. EXACTLY, SAID HARRY, BUT HE COULD NOT PRESS THE POINT, BECAUSE SO MANY PEOPLE WERE TRYING TO LISTEN IN TO HIS CONVERSATION, NOT TO MENTION STARING AT HIM AND WHISPERING BEHIND THEIR HANDS. IT'S ALIVE THE POINT, REIN SNAPPED AT A PARTICULARLY MINUSCULE FIRST-YEAR BOY AS THEY IMINED THE HOLE IN THE CLIMB OFF THE PORTRAIT HOLE. THE BOY, WHO HAD BEEN MUTTERING SOMETHING ABOUT HARRY BEHIND HIS HAND TO HIS FRIEND, PROMPTLY TURNED SCARLET AND TIPPLED OFF THE HOLE IN ALARM. REIN SNIGGERED. I LOVE BEING A SIXTH YEAR, AND WE'RE GOING TO BE GETTING FREE TIME THIS YEAR. WEEKLY PERIODS WHEN WE CAN JUST SIT UP HERE AND RELAX. WE'RE GOING TO NEED THAT TIME FOR STUDYING, REIN? SAID HERMIONE, AS THEY SET OFF DOWN THE CORRIDOR. Yeah, BUT NOT TODAY, SAID REIN. TODAY'S GOING TO BE A REAL DESS, I RECKON. HOLD IT? SAID HERMIONE, THROWING OFF AN ARM AND HALTING A PASSING FOURTH YEAR, WHO WAS ATTEMPTING TO PUSH PAST HER WITH A LIME-GREEN DISC CLUTCHED TIGHTLY IN HIS HAND. FANGED FRISBEE'S ARE

EARNED, HAND IT OVER. SHE TOLD HIM STERNLY, THE SCHEMING KID
HANDS OVER THE SPARKING FRISKEE, SLICKED UNDER HER ARM, AND THEN
OFF AFTER HIS FRIENDS. REIN WAITED FOR HIM TO VANISH, THEN TUGGED
THE FRISKEE FROM HERMIONE'S GRIP. EXCELLENT, I'VE ALWAYS WANTED
ONE OF THESE. HERMIONE'S REMONSTRATION WAS DROPPED BY A LILLY
GIGGLE. LAVENDER BROWN HAD APPARENTLY HEARD REIN'S REMARK
HIGHLY AMUSING. SHE CONTINUED THE LAUGH AS SHE PASSED THEM,
GLANCING BACK AT REIN OVER HER SHOULDER. REIN SMILED RATHER
PLEASED WITH HIMSELF. THE CEILING OF THE GREAT HALL WAS SERENELY
BLUE AND STREADED WITH FAIR, WISPY CLOUDS, JUST LIKE THE SKY
VISIBLE THROUGH THE HIGH MILLINED WINDOWS. WHILE THEY
TALKED INTO PHURLOCK AND EGGS AND BACON, HARRY AND REIN TOLD
HERMIONE ABOUT THEIR EMBARRASSING CONVERSATION WITH LACRIB
THE PREVIOUS EVENING. BUT HE CAN'T REALLY THINK WE'D CONTINUE
CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES? SHE SAID, LOOKING DISTRESSED. I MEAN,
WHEN HAS ANY OF US EXPRESSED SUCH AN INTEREST?

THAT'S IT, THOUGH, INNIT? SAID REIN, SWALLOWING AN ENTIRE FRIED
EGG WHILE. WE WERE THE ONLYS WHO MADE THE MOST EFFORT IN CLASSES
BECAUSE WE LIKE LACRIB, BUT HE THINKS WE LIKE THE STUPID SUBJECT.
D'YOU REMEMBER ANYONE'S GIVING THE CHIN THE D.R.L.T.? NEITHER
HARRY NOR HERMIONE ANSWERED; THERE WAS NO NEED. THEY KNEW
PERFECTLY WELL THAT NOBODY IN THEIR YEAR WOULD WANT TO CONTINUE
CARE OF MAGICAL CREATURES. THEY AVOIDED LACRIB'S EYE AND RETURNED
HIS CHEERY WAVE ONLY HALF-HEARTEDLY WHEN HE LEFT THE STAFF TABLE TEN
MINUTES LATER. AFTER THEY HAD EATEN, THEY REMAINED IN THEIR PLACES,
AWAITING PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S DESCENT FROM THE STAFF TABLE.
THE DISTRIBUTION OF CLASS SCHEDULES WAS MORE COMPLICATED THAN
USUAL THIS YEAR, FOR PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL NEEDED FIRST THE CONFIRM
THAT EVERYBODY HAD ACHIEVED THE NECESSARY H.L.L. GRADES TO
CONTINUE WITH THEIR CHOSEN D.R.L.T.'S. HERMIONE WAS IMMEDIATELY
CLEARED TO CONTINUE WITH CHARM, DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS,
TRANSFIGURATION, HERBOL, ARITHMAGIC, ANCIENT RUNES, AND
POTIONS, AND SHEET OFF TO A FIRST-PERIOD ANCIENT RUNES CLASS
WITHOUT FURTHER ADIE. NEVILLE THEN A LITTLE LONGER THE SHORT HILT; HIS
RED-FACE WAS ANXIOUS AS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL LOOKED DOWN
HIS APPLICATION AND THEN CONSULTED HIS H.L.L. RESULTS.

HERBOL, FINE, SHE SAID. PROFESSOR SPRETT WILL BE DELIGHTED TO
SEE YOU BACK WITH AN OUTSTANDING H.L.L. AND YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS WITH EXCEEDS EXPECTATIONS, BUT THE PROBLEM IS TRANSFIGURATION. I'M SORRY, LONGSIGHTED, BUT AN ACCEPTABLE REALLY ISN'T GOOD ENOUGH THE CONTINUAL THE D.R.L.T. LEVEL. I JUST DON'T THINK YOU'D BE ABLE TO Cope WITH THE CHALLENGE. NEVILLE HUNG HIS HEAD. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL PEERED AT HIM THROUGH HER SQUARE SPECTACLES. WHY DO YOU WANT THE CONTINUAL WITH TRANSFIGURATION, ANYWAY? I'VE NEVER HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT YOU PARTICULARLY ENJOYED IT. NEVILLE SMILED MISERABLY AND MUTTERED SOMETHING ABOUT MY GRANDMOTHER WANTS.

EMPH, SMIRLED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. IT'S HIGH TIME YOUR GRANDMOTHER LEARNED THE REAL PROBLEM OF THE GRANDSON SHE'S GET, RATHER THAN THE ONE SHE THINKS SHE MIGHT THE HAVE PARTICULARLY AFTER WHAT HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY. NEVILLE TURNED VERY PINK AND BLINKED CONFUSEDLY. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HAD NEVER PAID HIM A COMPLIMENT BEFORE. I'M SORRY, LONGSIGHTED, BUT I CANNOT LET YOU INTO MY D.R.L.T. CLASS, I SEE THAT YOU HAVE AN EXCEEDS EXPECTATIONS IN CHARM, HOWEVER. WHY NOT TRY FOR A D.R.L.T. IN CHARM? MY GRANDMOTHER THINKS CHARM IS A SHORT CUT, MUMBLED NEVILLE. TAKE CHARM, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND I SHALL DROP ALICIA A LINE REMINDING HER THAT JUST BECAUSE SHE FAILED HER CHARM EXAM, THE SUBJECT IS NOT NECESSARILY WORTHLESS. SMILING SLIGHTLY AT THE LOOK OF DELIGHTED INCREDULITY ON NEVILLE'S FACE, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TAPPED A BLANK SCHEDULE WITH THE TIP OF HER WAND AND HANDED IT, THEN CARRYING DETAILS OF HIS NEW CLASSES, TO NEVILLE. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TURNED NEXT TO PARVATI PATIL, WHOSE FIRST MISTRESS WAS WHETHER FIRE, THE HANDSOME CENTAUR, WAS STILL TEACHING DIVINATION. HE AND PROFESSOR TRILAKSHY ARE DIVIDING CLASSES BETWEEN THEM THIS YEAR, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, A HINT OF DISAPPROVAL IN HER VOICE. IT WAS COMMON KNOWLEDGE THAT SHE DESPISED THE SUBJECT OF DIVINATION. THE SIXTH YEAR IS BEING TAKEN BY PROFESSOR TRILAKSHY. PARVATI SET OFF FOR DIVINATION FIVE MINUTES LATER SMILING SLIGHTLY CRESTFALLON. SEE, BETTER, BETTER

SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, CONSULTING HER NOTES AS SHE TURNED THE HARRY. CHARM, DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, HERMELING, TRANSFIGURATION. ALL FINE. I MUST SAY, I WAS PLEASED WITH YOUR TRANSFIGURATION MARK, BETTER, VERY PLEASED, NOW, WHY HAVEN'T YOU APPLIED THE CONTINUAL WITH PETITIONS? I THOUGHT IT WAS

YOUR AMBITIOUS THE RECTOR AN ALIEN? IT WAS, BUT YOU TOLD ME I
 HAD THE GET AN ELITESTANDING IN MY H.L.L. PROFESSOR. AND SHE
 YOU DID WHEN PROFESSOR SNARE WAS TEACHING THE SUBJECT. PROFESSOR
 SLUGGISH, HOWEVER, IS PERFECTLY HAPPY TO ACCEPT D.R.W.T STUDENTS
 WITH EXCEEDS EXPECTATIONS AT H.L.L. DO YOU WISH TO PROCEED WITH
 PHTHENS? YES, SAID HARRY, BUT I DIDN'T BUY THE REEDS OR ANY
 INGREDIENTS OR ANYTHING. I'M SURE PROFESSOR SLUGGISH WILL
 BE ABLE TO LEND YOU SOME, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. VERY WELL,
 PHTTER, HERE IS YOUR SCHEDULE. EH, BY THE WAY TWENTY HUNDREDS
 HAVE ALREADY PUT DOWN THEIR NAMES FOR THE GRYFFINDOR ELIJDITCH
 TEAM. I SHALL PASS THE LIST TO YOU IN ONE MOMENT AND YOU CAN FIX UP
 TRIALS AT YOUR LEISURE. A FEW MINUTES LATER, RON WAS CLEARED TO DO
 THE SAME SUBJECTS AS HARRY, AND THE TWO OF THEM LEFT THE TABLE
 TOGETHER. LUNA, SAID RON DELIGHTEDLY, GLAZING AT HIS SCHEDULE.
 WE'VE GOT A FREE PERIOD NOW AND A FREE PERIOD AFTER BREAK
 AND AFTER LUNCH. EXCELLENT! THEY RETURNED TO THE CHAMBER
 ROOM, WHICH WAS EMPTY APART FROM A HALF DOZEN SEVENTH YEARS,
 INCLUDING KATIE BELL, THE ONLY REMAINING MEMBER OF THE ORIGINAL
 GRYFFINDOR ELIJDITCH TEAM THAT HARRY HAD JOINED IN HIS FIRST
 YEAR. I THOUGHT YOU'D GET THAT, WELL DONE, SHE CALLED OVER,
 POINTING AT THE CAPTAIN'S BADGE ON HARRY'S CHEST. TELL ME WHEN
 YOU CALL TRIALS? DON'T BE STUPID, SAID HARRY, YOU DON'T NEED TO
 TRY OUT, I'VE WATCHED YOU PLAY FOR FIVE YEARS. YOU MUSTN'T
 START OFF LIKE THAT, SHE SAID WARNINGLY, FOR ALL YOU KNOW,
 THERE'S SOMEONE MUCH BETTER THAN ME OUT THERE. GOOD TEAMS HAVE
 BEEN RUINED BEFORE NOW BECAUSE CAPTAINS JUST KEPT PLAYING THE OLD
 GAMES, OR LETTING IN THEIR FRIENDS. RON LAUGHED A LITTLE
 UNCOMFORTABLE AND BEGAN PLAYING WITH THE FANGED FRISBEE
 HERMIONE HAD TAKEN FROM THE FIFTH-YEAR STUDENT. IT SEEMED
 AROUND THE CHAMBER ROOM, SPARKING AND ATTEMPTING TO TAKE KITES
 OF THE TAPESTRY. CRUCIO-HANDS'S YELLOW EYES FOLLOWED IT AND HE
 HISSED WHEN IT CAME TOO CLOSE. AN HOUR LATER THEY RELUCTANTLY LEFT
 THE SUNNY CHAMBER ROOM FOR THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS
 CLASSROOM FOR FLETCHER'S REASON. HERMIONE WAS ALREADY HURLING
 ELITIDE, CARRYING AN ARMY OF HEAVY REEDS AND LEAVING PUT-
 LIPEN. WE GET SO MUCH HUNDREDS FOR RINES, SHE SAID ANXIOUSLY,
 WHEN HARRY AND RON JOINED HER. A FIFTEEN-INCH ESSAY, TWO
 TRANSLATIONS, AND I'VE GOT TO READ THESE BY WEDNESDAY! SHE SAID,

VALINED BEEN. YELL WAIT, SHE SAID RESENTFULLY. I LET SNAPE GIVES
 US HEADS. THE CLASSROOM DOOR OPENED AS SHE SPoke, AND SNAPE
 STEPPED INTO THE CORRIDOR, HIS SALLER FACE FRAMED AS EVER BY THE
 CURTAINS OF GREASY BLACK HAIR. SILENCE FELL OVER THE HALLS
 IMMEDIATELY. INSIDE, HE SAID, HARRY WHINED AROUND AS THEY ENTERED.
 SNAPE HAD IMPOSED HIS PERSONALITY UPON THE ROOM ALREADY; IT WAS
 CLOSER THAN USUAL, AS CURTAINS HAD BEEN DRAWN OVER THE
 WINDOWS, AND WAS LIT BY CANDLELIGHT. NEW PICTURES ADORNED THE
 WALLS, MANY OF THEM SHOWING PEOPLE WHO APPEARED TO BE IN PAIN,
 SUFFERING CRUEL INJURIES OR STRANGELY DISTORTED BODY PARTS.
 NERVOUS SPEECH AS THEY SETTLED DOWN, WHISPERING AROUND AT THE
 SHADY, GLOOMY PICTURES. I HAVE NOT ASKED YET THE TAKE HEAT
 YOUR BOOKS, SAID SNAPE, CLOSING THE DOOR AND MOVING THE FACE THE
 CLASS FROM BEHIND HIS DESK. HARRY HASTILY DROPPED HER COPY OF
 CONFRONTING THE FACELESS BACK INTO HER BAG AND STEWED IT UNDER
 HER HAIR. I WISH TO SPEAK TO YOU, AND I WANT YOUR FULLST
 ATTENTION. HIS BLACK EYES MET OVER THEIR LIGHTENED FACES,
 LINGERING FOR A FRACTION OF A SECOND LONGER THAN HARRY'S THAN
 ANYONE ELSE'S. YET HAVE HAD FIVE TEACHERS IN THIS SUBJECT SHE FAR, I
 BELIEVE. YET BELIEVE LIKE YET HAVEN'T WATCHED THEM ALL COME
 AND GO, SNAPE, FINDING YET TO BE NEXT, TELLING HARRY STAFFINGLY.

NATURALLY, THESE TEACHERS WILL ALL HAVE HAD THEIR OWN METHODS
 AND PRIORITIES. GIVEN THIS CONVICTION I AM SURPRISED SEE MANY OF
 YET SCRAPED AN ELL, IN THIS SUBJECT. I SHALL BE EVEN MORE
 SURPRISED IF ALL OF YET MANAGE TO KEEP UP WITH THE DDLT, WHICH
 WHICH WILL BE MUCH MORE ADVANCED. SNAPE SET OFF AROUND THE EDGE
 OF THE ROOM, SPREADING THEM IN A WIDER VICE; THE CLASS CRANED THEIR
 NECKS TO KEEP HIM IN VIEW. THE DARK ARTS, SAID SNAPE, ARE
 MANY, VARIED, EVER-CHANGING, AND ETERNAL. FIGHTING THEM IS LIKE
 FIGHTING A MANY-HEADED MONSTER, WHICH, EACH TIME A NECK IS SEVERED,
 SPREEDS A HEAD EVEN FIERCE AND CLEVERER THAN BEFORE. YET ARE
 FIGHTING THAT WHICH IS UNKIND, MUTATING, INDESTRUCTIBLE. HARRY
 STARED AT SNAPE. IT WAS SURELY ONE THING TO RESPECT THE DARK ARTS
 AS A DANGEROUS ENEMY, ANOTHER TO SPREAD OF THEM, AS SNAPE WAS
 BEING, WITH A LEVING CARESS IN HIS VOICE? YET DEFENSES, SAID
 SNAPE, A LITTLE WIDER, MUST THEREFORE BE AS FLEXIBLE AND INVENTIVE
 AS THE ARTS YET SEEK TO UNDO. THESE PICTURES HE INDICATED A
 FEW OF THEM AS HE SWEEP PAST GIVE A FAIR REPRESENTATION OF

WHAT HAPPENS THE THREE WITH SLIPPER, FOR INSTANCE, THE CRUCIATUS
CURSE HE WAVED A HAND TOWARD A WITCH WHO WAS CLEARLY
SHRIEKING IN AGONY FEEL THE DEMENTED'S KISS A WIZARD
LYING FLIBBLED AND BLANK-EYED, SLUMPED AGAINST A WALL HER
PREVIOUS THE AGGRESSION OF THE IMPERILS A BLEEDY MASS LIPEN
THE GRIELING. HAS AN IMPERILS BEEN SEEN, THEN? SAID PARVATI PATIL
IN A HIGH-PITCHED WHISK. IS IT DEFINITE, IS HE LIVING THEN? THE
DARK LORD HAS LIVED IMPERI IN THE PAST, SAID SNAPE, WHICH MEANS
WELL WOULD BE WELL-ADVISED TO ASSUME HE MIGHT LIVE THEM AGAIN, WHEN

HE SET OFF AGAIN AROUND THE EITHER SIDE OF THE CLASSROOM
TOWARD HIS DESK, AND AGAIN, THEY WATCHED HIM AS HE WALKED, HIS DARK
RIBBONS KILLING BEHIND HIM. WELL ARE, I BELIEVE, COMPLETE SERVICES
IN THE USE OF NUMEROUS SPELLS, WHAT IS THE ADVANTAGE OF A
NUMEROUS SPELL? DETERMINE'S HAND SEET INTO THE AIR, SNAPE THREW
HIS TIME WHEELING AROUND AT EVERYBODY ELSE, MAKING SURE HE HAD BEEN
CHECK, BEFORE SAYING CLITELY, VERY WELL MISS GRANGER? THEIR
ADVERSARY HAS BEEN WARNING ABOUT WHAT KIND OF MAGIC THEY'RE ABOUT
THE PERFORM, SAID DETERMINE, WHICH GIVES THEM A SPLIT-SECOND
ADVANTAGE. AN ANSWER CHIRPED ALMOST WARD HER WARD FROM THE
STANDARD BOOK OF SPELLS, GRADE SIX, SAID SNAPE DISMISSIVELY NEVER
IN THE CORNER, MALFOY SNIGGERED, BUT CORRECT IN ESSENTIALS, YES,
THREE WITH PROGRESS THE LIVING MAGIC WITHOUT SILENTING
INCANTATIONS GAIN AN ELEMENT OF SURPRISE IN THEIR SPELL-CASTING,
NOT ALL WIZARDS CAN DO THIS, OF COURSE; IT IS A QUESTIONS OF
CONCENTRATION AND MIND POWER WHICH SOME HIS GAZE LINGERED
MALICIOUSLY UPON HARRY WHEN MORE LACK, HARRY KNEW SNAPE
WAS THINKING OF THEIR DISASTROUS ILLUMINERY LESSONS OF THE
PREVIOUS YEAR, HE REJECTED THE DRIFT HIS GAZE, BUT GLEWERED AT SNAPE
UNTIL SNAPE WHEEDED AWAY, THEY WILL NOW DIVIDE, SNAPE WENT ON,

IN THE PAIRS, ONE PARTNER WILL ATTEMPT THE LINK THE EITHER WITHOUT
SPREADING, THE EITHER WILL ATTEMPT THE REPEL THE LINK IN SILENT
SILENCE, CARRY ON, ALTHOUGH SNAPE DID NOT KNOW IT, HARRY HAD
TAUGHT AT LEAST HALF THE CLASS (EVERYONE WHO HAD BEEN A MEMBER OF
THE D.A.) THE PERFORM A SHIELD CHARM THE PREVIOUS YEAR, NONE
OF THEM HAD EVER CAST THE CHARM WITHOUT SPREADING, HOWEVER, A
REASONABLE AMOUNT OF CHEATING ENSUED; MANY PEOPLE WERE MERELY
WHISPERING THE INCANTATION INSTEAD OF SAYING IT ALOUD, TYPICALLY,
TEN MINUTES INTO THE LESSON DETERMINE MANAGED THE REPEL NEVILLE'S

MUTILATED IRON-LEGS JINK WITHOUT LITTERING A SINGLE WORD, A FEAT
 THAT WOULD SURELY HAVE EARNED HER TWENTY POINTS FOR GRACIOUSNESS
 FROM ANY REASONABLE TEACHER, THOUGH HARRY KITTERLY, BUT WHICH
 SNAPE IGNORED. HE SLEPT BETWEEN THEM AS THEY PRACTICED, BEHAVING
 JUST AS MUCH LIKE AN EVERGREEN CAT AS EVER, LINGERING THE WATCH
 HARRY AND RON STRUGGLING WITH THE TASK. RON, WHO WAS SUPPOSED
 TO BE HINDING HARRY, WAS PURPLE IN THE FACE, HIS LIPS TIGHTLY
 COMPRESSED TO SAVE HIMSELF FROM THE TEMPTATION OF MUTILATING THE
 INCANTATION. HARRY HAD HIS HAND RAISED, WAITING FOR TENDERNESS
 THE REPEL A JINK THAT SEEMED UNLIKELY EVER TO COME. PATHETIC,
 WEASLEY, SAID SNAPE, AFTER A WHILE. HERE LET ME SHOW YOU
 HE TURNED HIS HAND AND HARRY SAW FAST THAT HARRY REACTED
 INSTINCTIVELY; ALL THOUGH HE NEVER KNEW SPELLS FORGETTEN, HE
 YELLED, PROTECT! HIS SHIELD CHARM WAS BE STRONG SNAPE WAS
 KNOCKED OFF-BALANCE AND HIT A DESK. THE WHOLE CLASS HAD BEEN
 ARILING AND NOW WATCHED AS SNAPE RIGHTED HIMSELF, SNEERING. DO
 YOU REMEMBER ME TELLING YOU WE ARE PRACTICING NEVER KNEW SPELLS,
 PROTECT? YES, SAID HARRY STIFFLY. YES, SIR. THERE'S NO NEED TO
 CALL ME SIR, PROFESSOR. THE WORDS HAD ESCAPED HIM BEFORE HE KNEW
 WHAT HE WAS SAYING. SEVERAL PEOPLE GASPED, INCLUDING HERMION.
 BEHIND SNAPE, HOWEVER, RON, DEAN, AND SEamus GRINNED
 APPRECIATIVELY. DETENTION, SATURDAY NIGHT, MY OFFICE, SAID SNAPE.
 I DO NOT TAKE CHARGE FROM ANYONE, PROTECT NOT EVEN THE CHIEF
 ONE. THAT WAS BRILLIANT, HARRY? CHORTLED RON, SINCE THEY WERE
 SAFELY AND THEIR WAY TO READ A SHORT WHILE LATER. YOU REALLY
 SHOULDN'T HAVE SAID IT, SAID HERMION, FROWNING AT RON. WHAT
 MADE YOU? HE TRIED TO HIDE ME, IN CASE YOU DIDN'T NOTICE? FLIPPED
 HARRY. I HAD ENOUGH OF THAT DURING THESE HILLMONEY LESSONS.
 WHY DOESN'T HE USE ANOTHER GLINKA PIG FOR A CHARGE? WHAT'S
 GOING ON PLAYING AT, ANYWAY, LETTING HIM TEACH DEFENSE? DID YOU
 HEAR HIM TALKING ABOUT THE DARK ARTS? HE LEAVES THEM! ALL THAT
 UNFIXED, INDESTRUCTIBLE STUFF. WELL, SAID HERMION, I
 THOUGHT HE SEEMED A BIT LIKE YOU. LIKE ME? YES, WHEN YOU
 WERE TELLING US WHAT IT'S LIKE THE FACE OF DEATH. YOU SAID IT
 WASN'T JUST MEMORIZING A LIST OF SPELLS, YOU SAID IT WAS JUST YOU
 AND YOUR BRAINS AND YOUR GLITS. WELL, WASN'T THAT WHAT SNAPE
 WAS SAYING? THAT IT REALLY COMES DOWN TO BEING BRAVE AND QUICK-
 THINKING? HARRY WAS BE DISARMED THAT SHE HAD THOUGHT HIS

WORDS AS WELL WORTH MEMORIZING AS THE STANDARD BUNCH OF SPELLS
THAT HE DID NOT ARGUE. HARRY? YES, HARRY? HARRY NEEDED
ARHLD; JACK SLEEPER, ONE OF THE BEATERS FROM LAST YEAR'S CROFFINGER
ELIOTT'S TEAM, WAS HURRYING TOWARD HIM HOLDING A ROLL OF
PARCHMENT. PER YEL, PANTED SLEEPER. LISTEN, I HEARD YEL RE THE
NEW CAPTAIN. WHEN RE YEL HOLDING TRIALS? I'M NOT SURE YET,
SAID HARRY, THINKING PRIVATELY THAT SLEEPER WOULD BE VERY LIKELY
TO GET BACK IN THE TEAM. I'LL LET YEL KNOW. EH, RIGHT, I WAS
HOPING IT'D BE THIS WEEKEND. BUT HARRY WAS NOT LISTENING; HE
HAD JUST RECOGNIZED THE THIN, SLANTING WRITING ON THE PARCHMENT.
LEAVING SLEEPER IN MID-SENTENCE, HE HURRIED AWAY WITH RON AND
HERMION, UNROLLING THE PARCHMENT AS HE WENT. DEAR HARRY, I
WOULD LIKE TO START OUR PRIVATE LESSONS THIS SATURDAY. KINDLY
COME ALONG TO MY OFFICE AT 8 P.M. I HOPE YEL ARE ENJOYING YEL
FIRST DAY BACK AT SCHOOL. YEL'S SINCERELY, P.S. I ENJOY ACID PEEPS.
HE ENJOYS ACID PEEPS? SAID RON, WHO HAD READ THE MESSAGE OVER
HARRY'S SHOULDER AND WAS LOOKING PERPLEXED. IT'S THE PASSWORD
TO GET PAST THE GARGOYLE OUTSIDE HIS STUDY. SAID HARRY IN A LOW
VOICE. HA! SNAPE'S NOT GIVING THEM BE PLEASED. I WON'T BE ABLE TO
SEE HIS DETENTION? NO, RON, AND HERMION SPENT THE WHILE OF
BREAK SPECULATING ON WHAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD TEACH HARRY. RON
THOUGHT IT MOST LIKELY TO BE SPECTACULAR INJEXES AND HEXES OF THE
TYPE THE DEATH EATERS WOULD NOT KNOW. HERMION SAID SUCH THINGS
WERE ILLEGAL, AND THOUGHT IT MUCH MORE LIKELY THAT DUMBLEDORE
WANTED TO TEACH HARRY ADVANCED DEFENSIVE MAGIC. AFTER BREAK, SHE
WENT OFF TO ARTHEMANS WHILE HARRY AND RON RETURNED TO THE
COMMON ROOM, WHERE THEY GRADUALLY STARTED SNAPE'S CHALLENGE.
THIS TURNED OUT TO BE A COMPLEX TASK THAT THEY STILL HAD NOT FINISHED
WHEN HERMION JOINED THEM FOR THEIR AFTER-LUNCH FREE PERIOD
(THOUGH SHE CONSIDERABLY SPEEDED UP THE PROCESS). THEY HAD ONLY
JUST FINISHED WHEN THE BELL RANG FOR THE AFTERNOON'S DOUBLE
POTIONS AND THEY TOOK THE FAMILIAR PATH DOWN THE DUNGEON
CLASSROOM THAT HAD, FOR HER LONG, BEEN SNAPE'S. WHEN THEY ARRIVED
IN THE CORRIDOR THEY SAW THAT THERE WERE ONLY A DOZEN PEOPLE
PROGRESSING THE N.E.W.T. LEVEL. CRABBE AND GOYLE HAD EVIDENTLY FAILED
TO ACHIEVE THE REQUIRED E.L.L. GRADE, BUT YEL'S SLYTHERINS HAD MADE
IT THROUGH, INCLUDING MALFOY. YEL'S RAVENCLAWS WERE THERE, AND
ONE FLUFFLEPP, ERNIE MACMILLAN, WHO HARRY LIKED DESPITE HIS

RATHER POMPILUS MANNER. HARRY, ERNIE SAID PERTINENTLY, HOLDING UP HIS HAND AS HARRY APPROACHED, DIDN'T GET A CHANCE THE SPREAD IN DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS THIS MORNIN'. GOOD LUCK, I THINK, BUT STIELD CHARM'S ARE NO FAT, NO CHURSE, NO LIS NO D.A. LACS AND NOO ARE YELL, REIN FERMINE? BEFORE THEY COULD SAY MORE THAN FINE, THE DUNGEON DOOR OPENED AND SLUGHERN'S KELLY PRECEDED HIM UP THE DOOR. AS THEY FILED INTO THE ROOM, HIS GREAT WALRUS MUSTACHE CLAYED ABOVE HIS BEAMING MOUTH, AND HE GREETED HARRY AND ZAKINI WITH PARTICULAR ENTHUSIASM. THE DUNGEON WAS, MOST UNUSUALLY, ALREADY FULL OF VAPORS AND BAD SMELLS. HARRY, REIN, AND FERMINE SNIFFED INTERESTEDLY AS THEY PASSED LARGE, BUBBLING CALIBRENS. THE OTHER SLOTHERINS TOOK A TABLE TOGETHER, AS DID THE OTHER RAVENCLAWS. THIS LEFT HARRY, REIN, AND FERMINE THE SHARE A TABLE WITH ERNIE. THEY CHOSE THE ONE NEAREST A CHILD-CHIEFED CALIBREN THAT WAS EMITTING ONE OF THE MOST SEDUCTIVE SCENTS HARRY HAD EVER INHALED: SWEETLY IT REMINDED HIM SIMULTANEOUSLY OF TREATY TART, THE WHIPPY SMELL OF A BREWSTICK HANDLE, AND SOMETHING FLEETLY HE THOUGHT HE MIGHT HAVE SMELLED AT THE CURRUL. HE FOUND THAT HE WAS BREATHING VERY SLOWLY AND DEEPLY AND THAT THE POTION'S FLAVES SEEMED TO BE FILLING HIM UP LIKE DRINK. A GREAT CONTENTMENT STEAL OVER HIM; HE GRINNED ACROSS AT REIN, WHO GRINNED BACK LAZILY.

NOO THEN, NOO THEN, NOO THEN, SAID SLUGHERN, WHOSE MASSIVE BELTLINE WAS BELIVERING THROUGH THE MANY SHIMMERING VAPORS.

SCALES UP, EVERYONE, AND POTION RITS, AND DON'T FORGET YOUR CHIPS OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING. SIR? SAID HARRY, RAISING HIS HAND. HARRY, MAY? I HAVEN'T GET A CHANCE FOR SCALES FOR ANYTHING. NOO REIN WE DIDN'T REALIZE WE'D BE ASKED THE DEE THE D.L.W.T., YELL SEE. AH, YES, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DID MENTION. MEET THE WHERRY, MY DEAR KID, MEET THE WHERRY AT ALL. YELL CAN USE INGREDIENTS FROM THE STONE CLIPBOARD TODAY, AND I'M SURE WE CAN LEND YOU SOME SCALES, AND WE'VE GOT A SMALL STOCK OF OLD RINGS HERE, THEY'LL BE UNTIL YOU CAN WRITE THE FLEURISH AND KLETT. SLUGHERN STRODE OVER THE A CHURCH CLIPBOARD AND, AFTER A MOMENT'S PERAGING, EMERGED WITH TWO VERY BATTERED-LOOKING CHIPS OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING BY LIRATILIS BEERAGE, WHICH HE GAVE THE HARRY AND REIN ALONG WITH TWO SETS OF TARNISHED SCALES. NOO THEN, SAID SLUGHERN, RETURNING TO THE FRONT OF THE CLASS AND

INFLATING HIS ALREADY BULGING CHEST SEE THAT THE CLITTERS ON HIS
 WAISTCLOTH THREATENED THE CLUST OFF, I VE PREPARED A FEW PETITIONS
 FOR YOU THE HAVE A LOOK AT, LISTEN TO MY INTEREST, YOU KNOW, THESE
 ARE THE KIND OF THING YOU MIGHT BE ABLE TO MAKE AFTER
 COMPLETING YOUR D.D.L.T.S, YOU MIGHT BE HAVE HEARD OF EM, EVEN
 IF YOU HAVEN T MADE EM YET, ANYONE TELL ME WHAT THIS ONE IS? HE
 INDICATED THE CALIBRE NEAREST THE SLOTHERIN TABLE, FERRY RAISED
 HIMSELF SLIGHTLY IN HIS SEAT AND SAW WHAT LOOKED LIKE PLAIN WATER
 BUBBLING AWAY INSIDE IT, FERMINE S WELL-PRACTICED HAND HIT THE AIR
 BEFORE ANYBODY ELSE S, SLEIGHORN POINTED AT HER, IT S VERITASERUM,
 A CHERLESS, HONORLESS PETITION THAT FORCES THE DRINKER TO TELL THE
 TRUTH, SAID FERMINE, VERY GOOD, VERY GOOD! SAID SLEIGHORN
 HAPPILY, NOW, HE CONTINUED, POINTING AT THE CALIBRE NEAREST
 THE RAVENCLAW TABLE, THIS ONE HERE IS PRETTY WELL KNOWN,
 FEATURED IN A FEW MINISTRY LEAFLETS LATELY THEN WHEN CAN ?
 FERMINE S HAND WAS FASTEST SINCE MINE, IT S PHELYLICE PETITION,
 SIR, SHE SAID, FERRY THEN HAD RECOGNIZED THE SLEW-BLEBLING, MILDLY
 SUBSTANCE IN THE SECOND CALIBRE, BUT DID NOT RESIST FERMINE
 GETTING THE CREDIT FOR ANSWERING THE QUESTION; SHE, AFTER ALL, WAS
 THE ONE WHO HAD SUCCEEDED IN MAKING IT, BACK IN THEIR SECOND YEAR,
 EXCELLENT, EXCELLENT! NOW, THIS ONE HERE YES, MY DEAR? SAID
 SLEIGHORN, NOW LOOKING SLIGHTLY REMLISED, AS FERMINE S HAND
 PUNCHED THE AIR AGAIN, IT S AMPERTENTIA! IT IS INDEED, IT SEEMS
 ALMOST PHELISH TO ASK, SAID SLEIGHORN, WHO WAS LOOKING MIGHTILY
 IMPRESSED, BUT I ASSUME YOU KNOW WHAT IT DOES? IT S THE MOST
 PHELYLICE PETITION IN THE WORLD! SAID FERMINE, ELITE RIGHT?
 YOU RECOGNIZED IT, I SUPPOSE, BY ITS DISTINCTIVE MOTHER-HAPPY
 SHERN? AND THE STEAM RISING IN CHARACTERISTIC SPIRALS, SAID
 FERMINE ENTHUSIASTICALLY, AND IT S SUPPOSED TO SMELL DIFFERENTLY
 TO EACH OF US, ACCORDING TO WHAT ATTRACTS US, AND I CAN SMELL
 FRESHLY MOWN GRASS AND NEW PARCHMENT AND BUT SHE TURNED
 SLIGHTLY PINK AND DID NOT COMPLETE THE SENTENCE, MAY I ASK YOUR
 NAME, MY DEAR? SAID SLEIGHORN, IGNORING FERMINE S
 EMBARRASSMENT, FERMINE GRANGER, SIR, GRANGER? GRANGER?
 CAN YOU POSSIBLY BE RELATED TO THE LATER DAGWEHT-GRANGER, WHO
 FOUNDED THE MOST EXTRAORDINARY SOCIETY OF PETITIONERS? NO, I
 HAVEN T THOUGHT OF, SIR, I M MUGGLE-KORN, YOU SEE, FERRY SAW MALPHE
 LEAN CLOSE TO THE DOOR AND WHISPER SOMETHING; BOTH OF THEM

SNIGGERED, BUT SLUGGISHLY SHOWED NO DISMAY; ON THE CONTRARY, HE
 BEAMED AND WHISKED FROM DETERMINING THE FARRY, WHO WAS SITTING NEXT
 TO HER. HE-HE! HERE MY BEST FRIENDS IS MUGGLE-THORN, AND SHE'S
 THE BEST IN HER YEAR! I'M ASSUMING THIS IS THE VERY FRIEND OF
 WHO YOU SPEAK, FARRY? YES, SIR, SAID FARRY, WELL, WELL, TAKE
 TWENTY WELL-EARNED POINTS FOR GRYFFINDOR, MISS GRANGER, SAID
 SLUGGISHLY GENIALLY, MALPHE WHISKED RATHER AS HE HAD DONE THE TIME
 DETERMINING HAD PUNCHED HIM IN THE FACE, DETERMINING TURNED THE FARRY
 WITH A RADIANT EXPRESSION AND WHISPERED, DID YOU REALLY TELL HIM
 I'M THE BEST IN THE YEAR? HE-HE, FARRY! WELL, WHAT'S SHE IMPRESSIVE
 ABOUT THAT? WHISPERED THEN, WHO FOR SOME REASON WHISKED
 ANSWERED, YOU ARE THE BEST IN THE YEAR I'D YET TOLD HIM SHE IF HE'D
 ASKED ME! DETERMINING SMILED BUT MADE A STRANGE GESTURE, SHE THAT
 THEY COULD HEAR WHAT SLUGGISHLY WAS SAYING, THEN WHISKED SLIGHTLY
 DISORIENTED, AMERTENTIA DOESN'T REALLY CREATE LOVE, OF COURSE, IT
 IS IMPOSSIBLE TO MANUFACTURE OR IMITATE LOVE, NO, THIS WILL SIMPLY
 CAUSE A PERPETUAL INFLAMMATION OR EXCESSIVE LOVE, IT IS PROBABLY THE
 MOST DANGEROUS AND PERPETUAL POTION IN THIS ROOM HE-HE YES, HE
 SAID, NODDING GRAVELY AT MALPHE AND NUTT, BOTH OF WHOM WERE
 SMIRKING SKEPTICALLY, WHEN YOU HAVE SEEN AS MUCH OF LIFE AS I
 HAVE, YOU WILL NOT UNDERESTIMATE THE POWER OF EXCESSIVE LOVE.

AND THEN, SAID SLUGGISHLY, IT IS TIME FOR US TO START WORK, SIR,
 YOU HAVEN'T TOLD US WHAT'S IN THIS ONE, SAID ERNIE MACMILLAN,
 POINTING AT A SMALL BLACK CALIBREON STANDING BY SLUGGISHLY'S DESK,
 THE POTION WITHIN WAS SPLASHING ABOUT MERRILY; IT WAS THE COLOR
 OF MOLTEN GOLD, AND LARGE BUBBLES WERE LEAPING LIKE GIGGLISH ABOUT
 THE SURFACE, THOUGH NOT A PARTICLE HAD SPILLED, HE-HE, SAID
 SLUGGISHLY AGAIN, FARRY WAS SURE THAT SLUGGISHLY HAD NOT
 FORGOTTEN THE POTION AT ALL, BUT HAD WAITED THEN HE ASKED FOR
 DRAMATIC EFFECT, YES, THAT, WELL, THAT ONE, LADIES AND GENTLEMEN, IS
 A MOST CURIOUS LITTLE POTION CALLED FELIX FELIXIS, I TAKE IT, HE
 TURNED, SMILING, THEN WHISKED AT DETERMINING, WHO HAD LET OUT AN AUDIBLE
 GASP, THAT YOU KNOW WHAT FELIX FELIXIS DOES, MISS GRANGER?

IT'S LIKELY LOVE, SAID DETERMINING EXCITEDLY, IT MAKES YOU LIKELY!
 THE WHOLE CLASS SEEMED TO SIT UP A LITTLE STRAIGHTEN WHEN ALL
 FARRY COULD SEE HE MALPHE WAS THE BACK OF HIS SPEED BLEND HEAD,
 BECAUSE HE WAS AT LAST GIVING SLUGGISHLY HIS FULL AND UNDIVIDED
 ATTENTION, ELITE RIGHT, TAKE ANOTHER TEN POINTS FOR GRYFFINDOR.

YES, IT IS A FLINDY LITTLE PHTHEN, FELIX FELIX, SAID SLUGGISHRN.

DESPERATELY TRICKY THE MAKE, AND DISASTROUS THE GET WORKING.
HOWEVER, IF BREWED CORRECTLY, AS THIS HAS BEEN, YOU WILL FIND THAT
ALL YOUR ENDEAVORS TEND THE SICKER AT LEAST UNTIL THE EFFECTS
WEAR OFF. WHY DON'T PEOPLE DRINK IT ALL THE TIME, SIR? SAID
TERRY KEET RAGERLY. BECAUSE IF TAKEN IN EXCESS, IT CAUSES GIDDINESS,
RECKLESSNESS, AND DANGEROUS HYPERCONFIDENCE, SAID SLUGGISHRN. THAT
MUCH OF A GOOD THING, YOU KNOW. HIGHLY TOXIC IN LARGE
QUANTITIES, BUT TAKEN SPARINGLY, AND VERY OCCASIONALLY HAVE
YOU EVER TAKEN IT, SIR? ASKED MICHAEL KERNER WITH GREAT INTEREST.

TWICE IN MY LIFE, SAID SLUGGISHRN. ONCE WHEN I WAS TWENTY-FOUR,
ONCE WHEN I WAS FIFTY-SEVEN. THEN TABLESPHOONS TAKEN WITH
BREAKFAST, THEN PERFECT DAYS. HE GAZED DREAMILY INTO THE DISTANCE.
WHETHER HE WAS PLAYACTING HIS NEET, THELIGHT HARRY, THE EFFECT WAS
GOOD, AND THAT, SAID SLUGGISHRN, APPARENTLY CHIMING BACK THE
EARTH, IS WHAT I SHALL BE OFFERING AS A PRIZE IN THIS LESSON.
THERE WAS SILENCE IN WHICH EVERY KICKLE AND CLURGLE OF THE
SURROUNDING PHTHENS SEEMED MAGNIFIED TENFOLD. THEN TINY KEETLE OF
FELIX FELIX, SAID SLUGGISHRN, TAKING A MINUSCULE GLASS BOTTLE WITH
A CORK IN IT HILT UP HIS PEECKET AND SHOWING IT TO THEM ALL.

ENOUGH FOR TWELVE FEELERS LIKE, FROM DAWN TILL DUSK, YOU WILL BE
LIKE IN EVERYTHING YOU ATTEMPT. NOW, I MUST GIVE YOU WARNING
THAT FELIX FELIX IS A BANNED SUBSTANCE IN ORGANIZED COMPETITIONS

SPORTING EVENTS, FOR INSTANCE, EXAMINATIONS, FOR ELECTIONS. SEE
THE WINNER IS THE LIKE IT ON AN ORDINARY DAY ONLY AND WATCH HOW
THAT ORDINARY DAY BECOMES EXTRAORDINARY? SEE, SAID SLUGGISHRN,
SUDDENLY BRISK. HOW ARE YOU TO WIN MY FABLED PRIZE? WELL, BY
TURNING THE PAGE TEN OF ADVANCED PHTHEN-MAKING. WE HAVE A
LITTLE MORE AN FEELER LEFT THE LIS, WHICH SHOULD BE TIME FOR YOU THE
MAKE A DECENT ATTEMPT AT THE DRALIGHT OF LIVING DEATH. I KNOW IT
IS MORE COMPLEX THAN ANYTHING YOU HAVE ATTEMPTED BEFORE, AND I
DO NOT EXPECT A PERFECT PHTHEN FROM ANYBODY. THE PERSON WHO
DOES BEST, HOWEVER, WILL WIN LITTLE FELIX HERE. OFF YOU GO! THERE
WAS A SCRAPING AS EVERYONE DREW THEIR CALIBRENS TOWARD THEM AND
SOME LEDD CLINDS AS PEOPLE BEGAN ADDING WEIGHTS TO THEIR SCALES,
BUT NEARLY SPOKE. THE CONCENTRATION WITHIN THE RHEM WAS ALMOST
TANGIBLE. HARRY SAW MALPHE RIPPING FEVERISHLY THROUGH HIS COPY
OF ADVANCED PHTHEN-MAKING. IT COULD NOT HAVE BEEN CLEARER THAT

MALPHEY REALLY WANTED THAT LICKY DAY, F-HARRY RENT SWIFTLY OVER THE TATTERED REDD SLUG-HERN HAD LENT HIM. THE HIS ANNOYANCE HE SAW THAT THE PREVIOUS HUNTER HAD SCRIBBLED ALL OVER THE PAGES, SEE THAT THE MARGINS WERE AS BLACK AS THE PRINTED PERTINENS. KENDING WHEN THE DECIPHER THE INGREDIENTS (EVEN HERE, THE PREVIOUS HUNTER HAD MADE ANNOTATIONS AND CROSSED THINGS OUT!) F-HARRY HURRIED OFF TOWARD THE STORE CLIPBOARD THE FIND WHAT HE NEEDED. AS HE DASHED BACK THE HIS CALIBREIN, HE SAW MALPHEY CUTTING UP VALERIAN ROOTS AS FAST AS HE COULD. EVERYONE KEPT GLANCING AROUND AT WHAT THE REST OF THE CLASS WAS DOING; THIS WAS BOTH AN ADVANTAGE AND A DISADVANTAGE OF PERTINENS, THAT IT WAS HARD TO KEEP YOUR WORK PRIVATE. WITHIN TEN MINUTES, THE WHOLE PLACE WAS FULL OF BLISSY STEAM. F-HERMINE, OF COURSE, SEEMED TO HAVE PROGRESSED FURTHER. F-HER PERTINENS ALREADY RESEMBLED THE SPICED, BLACK CURRANT-FLAVORED LIQUID MENTIONED AS THE IDEAL HALFWAY STAGE. F-HAVING FINISHED CHOPPING HIS ROOTS, F-HARRY RENT WHEN OVER HIS REDD AGAIN. IT WAS REALLY VERY IRRITATING, HAVING TO TRY AND DECIPHER THE DIRECTIONS UNDER ALL THE STUPID SCRIBBLES OF THE PREVIOUS HUNTER, WHEN FOR SOME REASON HAD TAKEN ISSUE WITH THE ORDER HE CUT UP THE SHEPHERD-SHEPHERD'S REAN AND HAD WRITTEN IN THE ALTERNATIVE INSTRUCTIONS: CRUSH WITH FLAT SIDE OF SILVER DAGGER, RELEASES LIKE BETTER THAN CUTTING. SIR, I THINK YOU KNOW MY GRANDFATHER, AERAXAS MALPHEY? F-HARRY WHISKED UP; SLUG-HERN WAS JUST PASSING THE SLOTHERIN TABLE. YES, SAID SLUG-HERN, WITH-OUT WHISKING AT MALPHEY. I WAS SORRY TO HEAR HE HAD DIED, ALTHOUGH OF COURSE IT WASN'T UNEXPECTED, DRAGON PINK AT HIS AGE. AND HE WALKED AWAY, F-HARRY RENT BACK OVER HIS CALIBREIN, SMIRKING. F-HE COULD TELL THAT MALPHEY HAD EXPECTED TO BE TREATED LIKE F-HARRY OR ZARINI; PERHAPS EVEN HELPED FOR SOME PREFERENTIAL TREATMENT OF THE TYPE HE HAD LEARNED TO EXPECT FROM SNAPE. IT SEEMED AS THOUGH MALPHEY WOULD HAVE THE REPLY OF NOTHING BUT TALENT TO WIN THE KETTLE OF FELIX FELIXIS. THE SHEPHERD-SHEPHERD'S REAN WAS PROVING VERY DIFFICULT TO CUT UP. F-HARRY TURNED TO F-HERMINE. CAN I BORROW YOUR SILVER KNIFE? SHE NEEDED IMPATIENTLY, NOT TAKING HER EYES OFF HER PERTINENS, WHICH WAS STILL DEEP PURPLE, THOUGH ACCORDING TO THE REDD HIGHLIGHT TO BE TURNING A LIGHT SHADE OF LILAC BY NOW. F-HARRY CRUSHED HIS REAN WITH THE FLAT SIDE OF THE DAGGER. THE HIS ASTONISHMENT, IT IMMEDIATELY EXLUDED SEE MUCH LIKE HE WAS AMAZED THE SHRIVELED REAN COULD HAVE HELD IT ALL.

FASTLY SCHEPPING IT ALL INTO THE CALIBRENS HE SAW, THE HIS SURPRISE, THAT THE POTION IMMEDIATELY TURNED EXACTLY THE SHADE OF LILAC DESCRIBED BY THE TEXTBOOK. HIS APPREHENSION WITH THE PREVIOUS BLUNDER VANISHING IN THE SPOT, HARRY NOW SKINNED AT THE NEXT LINE OF INSTRUCTIONS. ACCORDING TO THE BOOK, HE HAD THE STIR COUNTERCLOCKWISE UNTIL THE POTION TURNED CLEAR AS WATER.

ACCORDING TO THE ADDITION THE PREVIOUS BLUNDER HAD MADE, HOWEVER, HE HAD BETTER ADD A CLOCKWISE STIR AFTER EVERY SEVENTH COUNTERCLOCKWISE STIR. COULD THE OLD BLUNDER BE RIGHT TWICE? HARRY STIRRED COUNTERCLOCKWISE, HELD HIS BREATH, AND STIRRED HENCE CLOCKWISE. THE EFFECT WAS IMMEDIATE. THE POTION TURNED PALEST PINK. 'THEY ARE WELL BEING THAT?' DEMANDED HERMIONE, WHO WAS RED-FACED AND WHOSE HAIR WAS GROWING BLONDER AND BLONDER IN THE FLAMES FROM HER CALIBRENS; HER POTION WAS STILL RESOLUTELY PURPLE.

ADD A CLOCKWISE STIR 'NEH, NEH, THE BOOK SAYS COUNTERCLOCKWISE?' SHE SNAPPED. HARRY STIRRED AND CONTINUED WHAT HE WAS DOING. SEVEN STIRS COUNTERCLOCKWISE, HENCE CLOCKWISE, PAUSE SEVEN STIRS COUNTERCLOCKWISE, HENCE STIR CLOCKWISE ACROSS THE TABLE, RON WAS CURSING ALIQUOTLY UNDER HIS BREATH; HIS POTION LOOKED LIKE LIQUID LICHEN. HARRY GLANCED AROUND, AS FAR AS HE COULD SEE, NEH HENCE ELSE'S POTION HAD TURNED AS PALE AS HIS. HE FELT FLAT, SOMETHING THAT HAD CERTAINLY NEVER HAPPENED BEFORE IN THIS DUNGEON. AND TIME'S UP! CALLED SILVERHORN. STOP STIRRING, PLEASE! SILVERHORN MOVED SILENTLY AMONG THE TABLES, PEEKING INTO CALIBRENS. HE MADE NO COMMENT, BUT OCCASIONALLY GAVE THE POTIONS A STIR OR A SNIFF. AT LAST HE REACHED THE TABLE WHERE HARRY, RON, HERMIONE, AND ERNIE WERE SITTING. HE SMILED RELIEFEDLY AT THE TARTAR SUBSTANCE IN RON'S CALIBRENS. HE PASSED OVER ERNIE'S NAVY CHOCOLATE. HERMIONE'S POTION HE GAVE AN APPREHENSIVE NOOD. THEN HE SAW HARRY'S, AND A LOOK OF INCREDIBLE DELIGHT SPREAD OVER HIS FACE. 'THE CLEAR WINNER!' HE CRIED TO THE DUNGEON. EXCELLENT, EXCELLENT, HARRY! GOOD LORD, IT'S CLEAR THEY'VE INHERITED THEIR MOTHER'S TALENT. SHE WAS A DAB HAND AT POTIONS, LILY WAS! THERE THEY ARE, THEN, HERE THEY ARE HENCE KETTLE OF FELIX FELIX, AS PROMISED, AND USE IT WELL! HARRY SLIPPED THE TINY KETTLE OF GOLDEN LIQUID INTO HIS INNER POCKET, FEELING AN OLD COMINATION OF DELIGHT AT THE FLIRTY LOOKS FROM THE SLYTHERINS' FACES AND GUILT AT THE DISAPPOINTED EXPRESSION IN HERMIONE'S. RON LOOKED SIMPLY

BLINKINGLY. HOW DID YOU DO THAT? HE WHISPERED TO HARRY AS THEY LEFT THE DINING. GEE, LUCKY, I SLEPPED, SAID HARRY, BECAUSE MALPHE WAS WITHIN EARSIGHT. SINCE THEY WERE SECURELY ENGAGED AT THE CROQUINCHER TABLE FOR DINNER, HOWEVER, HE FELT SAFE ENOUGH TO TELL THEM. FERMINE'S FACE BECAME STERNER WITH EVERY WORD HE UTTERED. IS THERE ANYTHING I CREATED? HE FINISHED, AGGRAVATED BY HER EXPRESSION. WELL, IT WASN'T EXACTLY YOUR OWN WORK, WAS IT? SHE SAID STIFFLY. HE ONLY FOLLOWED DIFFERENT INSTRUCTIONS THE ELKS, SAID RENE. COULD WE BEEN A CATASTROPHIC, COULDN'T IT? BUT HE TOOK A RISK AND IT PAID OFF. HE HEAVED A SIGH. SOMETIMES COULD WE HANDED ME THAT BOOK, BUT NO, I GET THE ONE NO ONE'S EVER WRITTEN IN. PLODGED IN, BY THE WAY OF PAGE FIFTY-TWO, BUT HANG ON, SAID A VOICE CLOSE BY HARRY'S LEFT EAR AND HE CALGHT A SUDDEN WAVE OF THAT FLEETERY SMELL HE HAD PICKED UP IN SOMETIMES'S DINING. HE LOOKED AROUND AND SAW THAT GINNY HAD JOINED THEM. DID I HEAR RIGHT? YOU'VE BEEN TAKING ORDERS FROM SOMEONE SOMEWHERE WRITE IN A BOOK, HARRY? SHE LOOKED ALARMED AND ANGRY. HARRY KNEW WHAT WAS IN HER MIND AT ONCE. IT'S NOTHING, HE SAID REASSURINGLY, LOWERING HIS VOICE. IT'S NOT LIKE YOU KNOW, RIDDLE'S DIARY. IT'S JUST AN OLD TEXTBOOK SOMEONE'S SCRIBBLED IN. BUT YOU'RE DOING WHAT IT SAYS? I JUST TRIED A FEW OF THE TIPS WRITTEN IN THE MARGINS, HONESTLY, GINNY, THERE'S NOTHING FUNNY GINNY'S GET A POINT, SAID FERMINE, PERKING UP AT ONCE. WE MIGHT THINK THAT THERE'S NOTHING TOO ABOUT IT. I MEAN, ALL THESE FUNNY INSTRUCTIONS, WHY KNOWS? HEY? SAID HARRY INDIGNANTLY, AS SHE PULLED HIS COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING OUT OF HIS BAG AND RAISED HER HAND. SPECIALS REVELIE? SHE SAID, RAPPING IT SMARTLY ON THE FRONT COVER. NOTHING WHATSOEVER HAPPENED. THE BOOK SIMPLY LAY THERE, LOOKING OLD AND DIRTY AND BEG-PAVED. FINISHED? SAID HARRY IRRITABLY. HE'D YOU WANT TO WAIT AND SEE IF IT DOES A FEW BACKFLIPS? IT SEEMS ALL RIGHT, SAID FERMINE, STILL STARING AT THE BOOK SUSPICIOUSLY. I MEAN, IT REALLY DOES SEEM TO BE JUST A TEXTBOOK. GEE, THEN I'LL HAVE IT BACK, SAID HARRY, SNATCHING IT OFF THE TABLE, BUT IT SLIPPED FROM HIS HAND AND LANDED OPEN ON THE FLOOR. NOBODY ELSE WAS LOOKING. HARRY KENT DOWN TO RETRIEVE THE BOOK, AND AS HE DID SO, HE SAW SOMETHING SCRIBBLED ALONG THE BOTTOM OF THE BACK COVER IN THE SAME SMALL, CRAMPED HANDWRITING AS THE INSTRUCTIONS THAT HAD BEEN HIM HIS BATTLE OF FELIX FELIX.

NEED SAFELY HIDDEN INSIDE A PAIR OF SHOES IN HIS TRUNK UPSTAIRS. THE BELIEF OF CALIST FOR THE REST OF THE WEEK'S PENTHUS LESSONS JARRY CONTINUED TO FOLLOW THE HALF-BLIND PRINCE'S INSTRUCTIONS WHEREVER THEY DEVIATED FROM LIKATIL'S REARAGE'S, WITH THE RESULT THAT BY THEIR FOURTH LESSON SLIGHTLY WAS SAYING ABOUT JARRY'S ABILITIES, SAYING THAT HE HAD RARELY TAUGHT ANYONE SO TALENTED. NEITHER REIN NOR JERMINE WAS DELIGHTED BY THIS, ALTHOUGH JARRY HAD OFFERED THE SHARE HIS KNOW WITH BOTH OF THEM, REIN HAD MORE DIFFICULTY DECRYPTING THE HANDWRITING THAN JARRY DID, AND COULD NOT KEEP ASKING JARRY TO READ ALoud FOR IT MIGHT BECOME SUSPICIOUS. JERMINE, MEANWHILE, WAS RESOLUTELY FOLLOWING HIM WITH WHAT SHE CALLED THE OFFICIAL INSTRUCTIONS, BUT BECOMING INCREASINGLY BAD-TEMPERED AS THEY YIELDED FEWER RESULTS THAN THE PRINCE'S. JARRY WONDERED VAGUELY WHEN THE HALF-BLIND PRINCE HAD BEEN. ALTHOUGH THE AMOUNT OF INFORMATION THEY HAD BEEN GIVEN PREVENTED HIM FROM READING THE WHOLE OF HIS COPY OF ADVANCED PENTHUS-MAKING, HE HAD SKIPPED THROUGH IT SUFFICIENTLY TO SEE THAT THERE WAS RARELY A PAGE IN WHICH THE PRINCE HAD NOT MADE ADDITIONAL NOTES, NOT ALL OF THEM CONCERNED WITH PENTHUS-MAKING. HERE AND THERE WERE DIRECTIONS FOR WHAT LOOKED LIKE SPELLS THAT THE PRINCE HAD MADE UP HIMSELF. FOR HERSELF, SAID JERMINE IRRITABLY, OVERHEARING JARRY PHINTING SOME OF THESE HINTS TO REIN IN THE CHURCH ROOM ON SATURDAY EVENING. IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN A GIRL, I THINK THE HANDWRITING LOOKS MORE LIKE A GIRL'S THAN A BOY'S. THE HALF-BLIND PRINCE, HE WAS CALLED, JARRY SAID. HOW MANY GIRLS HAVE BEEN PRINCES? JERMINE SEEMED TO HAVE NO ANSWER TO THIS. SHE MERELY SMILED AND TWITCHED HER EYES ON THE PRINCIPLES OF REMATERIALIZATION ALAS FROM REIN, WHEN WAS TRYING TO READ IT UPSIDE DOWN. JARRY LOOKED AT HIS WATCH AND FLURRIEDLY PUT THE OLD COPY OF ADVANCED PENTHUS-MAKING BACK INTO HIS BAG. IT'S FIVE THE RIGHT, I'D BETTER GO, I'LL BE LATE FOR DINNER.

HEHEHE! GASPED JERMINE, LOOKING UP AT HER. GOOD LUCK! WE'LL WAIT UP, WE WANT TO HEAR WHAT HE TEACHES YOU! SHEEP IT GOES AWAY, SAID REIN, AND THE PAIR OF THEM WATCHED JARRY LEAVE THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE. JARRY PROCEEDED THROUGH DESERTED CORRIDORS, THOUGH HE HAD THE STEP HASTILY BEHIND A STATUE WHEN PROFESSOR TRELANKEY APPEARED AROUND A CORNER, MUTTERING TO HIMSELF AS SHE SHUFFLED A PACK OF DIRTY-LOOKING PLAYING CARDS.

READING THEM AS SHE WALKED. TWO OF SPADES: CONFLICT, SHE
MURMURED, AS SHE PASSED THE PLACE WHERE HARRY CROUCHED, HIDDEN.

SEVEN OF SPADES: AN ILL MEN, TEN OF SPADES: VIOLENCE, DRAVE OF
SPADES: A DARK YOUNG MAN, POSSIBLY TRICKED, HERE WE-H DISLIKES THE
ELDESTHENER

SHE STOPPED DEAD, RIGHT IN THE MIDDLE SIDE OF
HARRY'S STATUE. WELL, THAT CAN'T BE RIGHT, SHE SAID, ANNOYED, AND
HARRY HEARD HER RESPIRING VIOLENTLY AS SHE SET OFF AGAIN,
LEAVING NOTHING BUT A WHIFF OF CHEERING SHERRY BEHIND HER. HARRY
WAITED UNTIL HE WAS WHITE SURE SHE HAD GONE, THEN FLURRIED OFF
AGAIN UNTIL HE REACHED THE SPOT IN THE SEVENTEENTH CORRIDOR
WHERE A SINGLE GARGOYLE STOOD AGAINST THE WALL. AID POPS, SAID
HARRY, AND THE GARGOYLE LEAPT ASIDE; THE WALL BEHIND IT SLID APART,
AND A MOVING SPIRAL STONE STAIRCASE WAS REVEALED, INTO WHICH
HARRY STEPPED, SEE THAT HE WAS CARRIED IN SWIFT CIRCLES UP THE
DOWN WITH THE BRASS KNICKER THAT LED THE DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE. HARRY
KNICKER, COME IN, SAID DUMBLEDORE'S VOICE. GOOD EVENING, SIR,
SAID HARRY, WALKING INTO THE HEADMASTER'S OFFICE. Ah, GOOD
EVENING, HARRY, SIT DOWN, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING. I HOPE
YOU'VE HAD AN ENJOYABLE FIRST WEEK BACK AT SCHOOL? YES, THANKS,
SIR, SAID HARRY. YOU MUST HAVE BEEN BUSY, A DETENTION UNDER
YOUR BELT ALREADY? ER, BEGAN HARRY ALGEBRAICALLY, BUT DUMBLEDORE
DID NOT LOOK THE STERN. I HAVE ARRANGED WITH PROFESSOR Snape
THAT YOU WILL BE YOUR DETENTION NEXT SATURDAY INSTEAD. RIGHT,
SAID HARRY, WHO HAD MORE PRESSING MATTERS IN HIS MIND THAN
Snape'S DETENTION, AND NOW LOOKED AROUND SLURP-TITIVELY FOR
SOME INDICATION OF WHAT DUMBLEDORE WAS PLANNING TO DO WITH HIM
THIS EVENING. THE CIRCULAR OFFICE LOOKED JUST AS IT ALWAYS DID; THE
DELICATE SILVER INSTRUMENTS STOOD ON SPINDLE-LEGGED TABLES, PLUFFING
SMOKE AND WHIRRING; PORTRAITS OF PREVIOUS HEADMASTERS AND
HEADMISTRESSES BEZEL IN THEIR FRAMES, AND DUMBLEDORE'S MAGNIFICENT
PHEENIX, FALCON, STOOD ON HIS PERCH BEHIND THE DOWN, WATCHING
HARRY WITH EIGHT INTEREST. IT DID NOT EVEN LOOK AS THOUGH
DUMBLEDORE HAD CLEARED A SPACE FOR DUELING PRACTICE. SEE, HARRY,
SAID DUMBLEDORE, IN A BUSINESSLIKE VOICE. YOU HAVE BEEN
WONDERING, I AM SURE, WHAT I HAVE PLANNED FOR YOU DURING THESE

FOR WANT OF A BETTER WORD LESSONS? YES, SIR. WELL, I HAVE
DECIDED THAT IT IS TIME, NOW THAT YOU KNOW WHAT PROMPTED LORD
VOLDEMORT TO TRY AND KILL YOU FIFTEEN YEARS AGO, FOR YOU TO BE

GIVEN CERTAIN INFORMATION. THERE WAS A PALISE. YELL SAID, AT THE END OF LAST TERM, YELL WERE GOING TO TELL ME EVERYTHING, SAID F-JARRY. IT WAS HARD TO KEEP A NIGHT OF ACCUSATION FROM HIS VOICE.

SIR, HE ADDED. AND THEN I DID, SAID DUMKLEDDERE PLACIDLY. I TOLD YELL EVERYTHING I KNEW, FROM THIS POINT FORTH, WE SHALL BE LEAVING THE FIRM FOUNDATION OF FACT AND INTERWEAVING TOGETHER THROUGH THE MIND'S MARCHES OF MEMORY INTO THE THICKETS OF WILDEST GUESSES. FROM HERE ON IN, F-JARRY, I MAY BE AS WHEELWY WRENG AS F-JUMPIER. BELIEVE ME, WHEN BELIEVED THE TIME WAS RIFE FOR A CHEESE CALIBRE.

BUT YELL THOUGHT YELL BE RIGHT? SAID F-JARRY. NATURALLY I DO, BUT AS I HAVE ALREADY PROVEN TO YELL, I MAKE MISTAKES LIKE THE NEXT MAN. IN FACT, BEING AWARE OF ME RATHER CLEVERER THAN MOST MEN, MY MISTAKES TEND TO BE CORRESPONDINGLY BIGGER. SIR, SAID F-JARRY TENTATIVELY. DOES WHAT YELL BE GOING TO TELL ME HAVE ANYTHING TO DO WITH THE PROPHECY? WILL IT HELP ME SURVIVE? IT HAS A VERY GREAT DEAL TO DO WITH THE PROPHECY, SAID DUMKLEDDERE, AS CASUALLY AS IF F-JARRY HAD ASKED HIM ABOUT THE NEXT DAY'S WEATHER, AND I CERTAINLY HOPE THAT IT WILL HELP YELL TO SURVIVE. DUMKLEDDERE GOT TO HIS FEET AND WALKED AROUND THE DESK, PAST F-JARRY, WHEN TURNED EAGERLY IN HIS SEAT TO WATCH DUMKLEDDERE BENDING OVER THE CABINET BESIDE THE DOOR. WHEN DUMKLEDDERE STRAIGHTENED UP, HE WAS HOLDING A FAMILIAR SHALLOW STONE BASIN ETCHED WITH HED MARKINGS AROUND ITS RIM. HE PLACED THE PENSIVE ON THE DESK IN FRONT OF F-JARRY.

YELL WENT WHIRLED. F-JARRY HAD INDEED BEEN EYING THE PENSIVE WITH SOME APPREHENSION. HIS PREVIOUS EXPERIENCES WITH THE HED DEVICE THAT STORED AND REVEALED THOUGHTS AND MEMORIES, THOUGH HIGHLY INSTRUCTIVE, HAD ALSO BEEN UNCOMFORTABLE. THE LAST TIME HE HAD DISTURBED ITS CONTENTS, HE HAD SEEN MUCH MORE THAN HE WOULD HAVE WISHED. BUT DUMKLEDDERE WAS SMILING. THIS TIME, YELL ENTERED THE PENSIVE WITH ME AND, EVEN MORE UNUSUALLY, WITH PERMISSION.

WHERE ARE WE GOING, SIR? FOR A TRIP DOWN THE HEDEN'S MEMORY LAKE, SAID DUMKLEDDERE, PULLING FROM HIS POCKET A CRYSTAL BOTTLE CONTAINING A SWIRLING SILVERY-WHITE SUBSTANCE. WHEN WAS THE HEDEN? HE WAS EMPLOYED BY THE DEPARTMENT OF MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT, SAID DUMKLEDDERE. HE DIED SOME TIME AGO, BUT NOT BEFORE I HAD TRACKED HIM DOWN AND PERSUADED HIM TO CHASE THESE RECOLLECTIONS TO ME. WE ARE ABOUT TO ACCOMPANY HIM ON A VISIT HE MADE IN THE COURSE OF HIS DUTIES. IF YELL WILL STAND, F-JARRY BUT

OLMLEDHRE WAS HAVING DIFFICULTY PULLING HLIT THE STOPPER OF THE CRYSTAL BOTTLE: HIS INJURED HAND SEEMED STIFF AND PAINFUL. SHALL I, SIR? NO MATTER, HARRY. OLMLEDHRE POINTED HIS HAND AT THE BOTTLE AND THE CORK FLEW HLIT. SIR HOW DID YOU INJURE YOUR HAND? HARRY ASKED AGAIN, LEERING AT THE BLACKENED FINGERS WITH A MIXTURE OF REVULSION AND PITY. WHEN IS NEXT THE MEETING FOR THAT STUFF, HARRY, NOT YET. WE HAVE AN APPOINTMENT WITH THE HEDEN. OLMLEDHRE TIPPED THE SILVERY CONTENTS OF THE BOTTLE INTO THE PENSIVE, WHERE THEY SWIRLED AND SHIMMERED, NEITHER LIKED NOR GAS. AFTER THAT, SAID OLMLEDHRE, GESTURING TOWARD THE BOWL, HARRY KENT FORWARD, TOOK A DEEP BREATH, AND PLUNGED HIS FACE INTO THE SILVERY SUBSTANCE. HE FELT HIS FEET LEAVE THE OFFICE FLOOR; HE WAS FALLING, FALLING THROUGH WHIRLING DARKNESS AND THEN, BLITZ SLIDENLY, HE WAS BLINKING IN DAZZLING SLIGHT, BEFORE HIS EYES HAD ADJUSTED, OLMLEDHRE LANDED BESIDE HIM. THEY WERE STANDING IN A COUNTRY LANE BORDERED BY HIGH, TANGLED HEDGEROWS, BENEATH A SUMMER SKY AS BRIGHT AND BLUE AS A FORGET-ME-NOT. SOME TEN FEET IN FRONT OF THEM STOOD A SHORT, PLUMP MAN WEARING ENORMOUSLY THICK GLASSES THAT OBSCURED HIS EYES THE MERE LIKE SPOTS. HE WAS READING A WHEDEN SIGNPOST THAT WAS STICKING HLIT OF THE BRAMBLES ON THE LEFT-HAND SIDE OF THE ROAD. HARRY KNEW THIS MUST BE HEDEN; HE WAS THE ONLY PERSON IN SIGHT, AND HE WAS ALSO WEARING THE STRANGE ASSORTMENT OF CLOTHES SO OFTEN CHOSEN BY INEXPERIENCED WIZARDS TRYING THE WHEDEN LIKE MUGGLES: IN THIS CASE, A FINE COAT AND SPATS OVER A STRIPED HORN-PIECE BATHING CHESTLINE. BEFORE HARRY HAD TIME TO BE MORE THAN REGISTER HIS BIZARRE APPEARANCE, HOWEVER, HEDEN HAD SET OFF AT A BRISK WALK DOWN THE LANE. OLMLEDHRE AND HARRY FOLLOWED. AS THEY PASSED THE WHEDEN SIGN, HARRY WHEDEN LIP AT ITS TWO ARMS. THE ONE POINTING BACK THE WAY THEY HAD COME READ: GREAT HANGLEDEN, 5 MILES. THE ARM POINTING AFTER HEDEN SAID LITTLE HANGLEDEN, 1 MILE. THEY WALKED A SHORT WAY WITH NOTHING TO SEE BUT THE HEDGEROWS, THE WIDE BLUE SKY OVERHEAD AND THE SWISHING, FINE-COATED FIGURE AHEAD. THEN THE LANE CURVED TO THE LEFT AND FELL AWAY, SLEEPING STEEPLY DOWN A HILLSIDE, SO THAT THEY HAD A SLIDEN, UNEXPECTED VIEW OF A WHOLE VALLEY Laid HLIT IN FRONT OF THEM. HARRY COULD SEE A VILLAGE, UNDELETEDLY LITTLE HANGLEDEN, NESTLED BETWEEN TWO STEEP HILLS, ITS CHURCH AND GRAVEYARD CLEARLY VISIBLE. ACROSS THE VALLEY, SET ON THE

OPPOSITE HILLSIDE, WAS A HANDSOME MANHER HOUSE SURROUNDED BY A WIDE EXPANSE OF VELVETY GREEN LAWN. EGDEN HAD CRASHED INTO A RELUCTANT TREE DUE TO THE STEEP DOWNWARD SLOPE. DUMKEDDRE LENGTHENED HIS STRIDE, AND HARRY FLURRIED THE DEEP LIP. HE THOUGHT LITTLE HANGLETEN MUST BE THEIR FINAL DESTINATION AND WANDERED, AS HE HAD DONE IN THE NIGHT THEY HAD FEELING SLUGGISHLY, WHY THEY HAD THE APPROACH IT FROM SUCH A DISTANCE. HE THEN DISCOVERED THAT HE WAS MISTAKEN IN THINKING THAT THEY WERE GOING TO THE VILLAGE, HOWEVER. THE LAKE CURVED TO THE RIGHT AND WHEN THEY REACHED THE CORNER, IT WAS TO SEE THE VERY EDGE OF EGDEN'S FRECKLED VANISHING THROUGH A GAP IN THE HEDGE. DUMKEDDRE AND HARRY FOLLOWED HIM INTO A NARROW DIRT TRACK BORDERED BY HIGHER AND WILDER HEDGEROWS THAN THESE THEY HAD LEFT BEHIND. THE PATH WAS CRUMBLED, ROCKY, AND POTTLED, SLEEPING DOWNHILL LIKE THE LAST ONE, AND IT SEEMED TO BE HEADING FOR A PATCH OF DARK TREES A LITTLE BEHIND THEM. SOON ENOUGH, THE TRACK THEN OPENED UP AT THE CORNER, AND DUMKEDDRE AND HARRY CAME TO A HALT BEHIND EGDEN, WHO HAD STOPPED AND DRAGN HIS HAND. DESPITE THE CLOUDLESS SKY, THE OLD TREES AHEAD CAST DEEP, DARK, COOL SHADOWS, AND IT WAS A FEW SECONDS BEFORE HARRY'S EYES DISCOVERED THE BUILDING HALF-HIDDEN AMONGST THE TANGLE OF TRUNKS. IT SEEMED TO HIM A VERY STRANGE LOCATION THE CORNER FOR A HOUSE, HE ELSE AN HAD DECIDED TO LEAVE THE TREES GROWING NEARBY, BLOCKING ALL LIGHT AND THE VIEW OF THE VALLEY BEHIND. HE WANDERED WHETHER IT WAS INHABITED; ITS WALLS WERE MESSY AND SO MANY TILES HAD FALLEN OFF THE ROOF THAT THE RAFTERS WERE VISIBLE IN PLACES. NETTLES GREW ALL AROUND IT, THEIR TIPS REACHING THE WINDOWS, WHICH WERE TINY AND THICK WITH GRIME. JUST AS HE HAD CONCLUDED THAT NOBODY COULD POSSIBLY LIVE THERE, HOWEVER, ONE OF THE WINDOWS WAS THROWN OPEN WITH A CLATTER, AND A THIN TRICKLE OF STEAM OR SMOKE ISSUED FROM IT, AS THOUGH SOMEBODY WAS COOKING. EGDEN MOVED FORWARD QUIETLY AND, IT SEEMED TO HARRY, RATHER CALMLY. AS THE DARK SHADOWS OF THE TREES SLID OVER HIM, HE STOPPED AGAIN, STARING AT THE FRONT DOOR, THE WHICH SOMEBODY HAD NAILED A DEAD SNAKE. THEN THERE WAS A RUSTLE AND A CRACK, AND A MAN IN RAGS DROPPED FROM THE NEAREST TREE, LANDING ON HIS FEET RIGHT IN FRONT OF EGDEN, WHO LEAPT BACKWARD SO FAST HE STOOD ON THE TAILS OF HIS FRECKLED CAT AND STUMBLER. 'WELL BE NEET WELCOME. THE MAN STANDING BEFORE THEM HAD THICK HAIR SO MATTED WITH DIRT

IT COULD HAVE BEEN ANY OTHER. SEVERAL OF HIS TEETH WERE MISSING. HIS EYES WERE SMALL AND DARK AND STARED IN OPPOSITE DIRECTIONS. HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN CHEMICAL, BUT HE DID NOT. THE EFFECT WAS FRIGHTENING, AND HARRY COULD NOT BLAME HEDEN FOR BACKING AWAY SEVERAL FEET PACE BEFORE HE SPEKE. ER GOOD MORNING. I AM FROM THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC. YOU ARE NOT WELCOME. ER I AM SURE I DON'T UNDERSTAND YOU, SAID HEDEN NERVOUSLY. HARRY THOUGHT HEDEN WAS BEING EXTREMELY DUMB. THE STRANGER WAS MAKING HIMSELF VERY CLEAR IN HARRY'S OPINION, PARTICULARLY AS HE WAS BRANDISHING A WAND IN ONE HAND AND A SHORT AND RATHER BLOODY KNIFE IN THE OTHER. YOU UNDERSTAND HIM, I AM SURE, HARRY? SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY. YES, HE CLEARLY, SAID HARRY, SLIGHTLY NEERVOUSED. WHY CAN'T HEDEN? BUT AS HIS EYES MET THE DEAD SNACKER IN THE DEER AGAIN, HE SUDDENLY UNDERSTOOD. HE'S SPEAKING PARSELMOUTH? VERY GOOD, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NODDING AND SMILING. THE MAN IN RAGS WAS NOW ADVANCING ON HEDEN, KNIFE IN ONE HAND, WAND IN THE OTHER. NOW, THEN, HEDEN BEGAN, BUT TOO LATE. THERE WAS A BANG, AND HEDEN WAS ON THE GRIDLING, CLUTCHING HIS NOSE, WHILE A NASTY YELLOWISH GELI SPLOTTED FROM BETWEEN HIS FINGERS. MURKIN? SAID A MILD VOICE. AN ELDERLY MAN HAD COME FLOWERING OUT OF THE CHITAGE, RANGING THE DEER BEHIND HIM SEE THAT THE DEAD SNACKER SWUNG PATHETICALLY. THIS MAN WAS SHORTER THAN THE FIRST, AND HOOLY PROPORTIONED. HIS SHOULDERS WERE VERY BROAD AND HIS ARMS EVERLONG, WHICH, WITH HIS BRIGHT GREEN EYES, SHORT SCRIBBY HAIR, AND WRINKLED FACE, GAVE HIM THE LOOK OF A PLEASANT, AGED MURDERER. HE CAME TO A HOLT BESIDE THE MAN WITH THE KNIFE, WHO WAS NOW LAUGHING WITH LAUGHTER AT THE SIGHT OF HEDEN ON THE GRIDLING. MINISTRY, IS IT? SAID THE ELDER MAN, LEANING DOWN AT HEDEN. CORRECT? SAID HEDEN ANGRILY, DABBLING HIS FACE. AND YOU, I TAKE IT, ARE MR. GALINT? I RIGHT, SAID GALINT. GEE YOU IN THE FACE, DID HE? YES, HE DID? SNAPPED HEDEN. SHOULD WE MAKE YOUR PRESENCE KNOWN, SHOULDN'T WE? SAID GALINT AGGRESSIVELY. THIS IS PRIVATE PROPERTY. CAN'T I JUST WALK IN HERE AND NOT EXPECT MYSELF TO DEFEND HIMSELF. DEFEND HIMSELF AGAINST WHAT, MAM? SAID HEDEN, CLAMPERING BACK TO HIS FEET. KISSKISSIES, INTRUDERS, MUGGLES AND FILTH. HEDEN POINTED HIS WAND AT HIS OWN NOSE, WHICH WAS STILL ISSUING LARGE AMPLANTS OF WHAT LOOKED LIKE YELLOW POLIS, AND THE FLEW STOPPED AT ONCE. MR. GALINT SPEKE OUT OF THE CORNER OF

HIS MOUTH THE MERLIN. GET IN THE HILLSE, DEN T ARGUE. THIS TIME, READY FOR IT, HARRY RECOGNIZED PARSELTHENGLE; EVEN WHILE HE COULD UNDERSTAND WHAT WAS BEING SAID, HE DISTINGUISHED THE WEIRD HISsing noise THAT WAS ALL EGDEN COULD HEAR. MERLIN SEEMED TO BE IN THE PHASE OF DISAGREEING, BUT WHEN HIS FATHER CAST HIM A THREATENING LOOK HE CHANGED HIS MIND, LINGERING AWAY THE THE CHITTAGE WITH AN EDD REELING GAIT AND SLAPPING THE FRONT DOOR BEHIND HIM, SEE THAT THE SNAKE SWILING SADLY AGAIN. IT S YELLER THEN I M HERE THE SEE, MR. GALINT, SAID EGDEN, AS HE MIPPED THE LAST OF THE PLS FROM THE FRONT OF HIS CHAT. THAT WAS MERLIN, WASN T IT? AR, THAT WAS MERLIN, SAID THE OLD MAN INDIFFERENTLY. ARE YELL PLURKLEHED? HE ASKED, SUDDENLY AGGRESSIVE. THAT S NEITHER HERE NOR THERE, SAID EGDEN COLDLY, AND HARRY FELT HIS RESPECT FOR EGDEN RISE. APPARENTLY GALINT FELT RATHER DIFFERENTLY. HE SHELINTED INTH EGDEN S FACE AND MUTTERED, IN WHAT WAS CLEARLY SUPPRESSED THE BE AN OFFENSIVE TONE. WHEN I COME THE THIND ARHET IT, I VE SEEN NOSES LIKE YELLERS DOWN IN THE VILLAGE. I DEN T BELIEVE IT, IF YELLER THEN S BEEN LET WHISE IN THEM, SAID EGDEN. PERHAPS WE COULD CONTINUE THIS DISCUSSION INSIDE? INSIDE? YES, MR. GALINT, I VE ALREADY THED YELL, I M HERE ARHET MERLIN. WE SENT AN EDD I VE NEE LICE FOR EDDS, SAID GALINT. I DEN T OPEN LETTERS. THEN YELL CAN HARDLY COMPLAIN THAT YELL GET NEE WARNING OF VISITERS, SAID EGDEN TARTLY. I AM HERE FOLLOWING A SERIOUS BREACH OF WIZARDING LAW, WHICH OCCURRED HERE IN THE EARLY HOURS OF THIS MORNING. ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT, ALL RIGHT? BELIEVED GALINT. COME IN THE BLEEDING HILLSE, THEN, AND MUCH GOOD IT LL BE YELL. THE HILLSE SEEMED TO CONTAIN THREE TINY ROOMS, TWO DOORS LED OFF THE MAIN ROOM, WHICH SERVED AS KITCHEN AND LIVING ROOM COMBINED. MERLIN WAS SITTING IN A FILTHY ARMCHAIR BESIDE THE SMOKING FIRE, TWISTING A LIVE ADDER BETWEEN HIS THICK FINGERS AND CRENNING SHFTLY AT IT IN PARSELTHENGLE: HISSY, HISSY, LITTLE SNAKEY, SLITHER IN THE FLEHR, YELL BE GOOD TH MERLIN FOR HE LL NAIL YELL THE THE DOOR. THERE WAS A SLUPLING NOISE IN THE CORNER BESIDE THE OPEN WINDOW, AND HARRY REALIZED THAT THERE WAS SOMEBODY ELSE IN THE ROOM, A GIRL WHOSE RAGGED GRAY DRESS WAS THE EXACT COLOR OF THE DIRTY STONE WALL BEHIND HER. SHE WAS STANDING BESIDE A STEAMING POTT IN A GRIMY BLACK STEVE, AND WAS FIDDLING AROUND WITH THE SHELF OF SHALID-LEEDING POTS AND PANS ABOVE IT. HER HAIR WAS LONG AND BLISS AND

SHE HAD A PLAIN, PALE, RATHER HEAVY FACE. HER EYES, LIKE HER BROTHER'S, STARED IN OPPOSITE DIRECTIONS. SHE SMILED A LITTLE CLEANER THAN THE TWO MEN, BUT HARRY THOUGHT HE HAD NEVER SEEN A MORE DEFEATED-LOOKING PERSON. HIS DAUGHTER, MERPHE, SAID CALINT GRABINGLY, AS HEDEN SMILED INHUMANELY TOWARD HER. SHE MURMURED, SAID HEDEN. SHE DID NOT ANSWER, BUT WITH A FRIGHTENED GLANCE AT HER FATHER TURNED HER BACK ON THE ROOM AND CONTINUED SHIFTING THE POTS ON THE SHELF BEHIND HER. WELL, MR. CALINT, SAID HEDEN, THEN GET STRAIGHT TO THE POINT, WE HAVE REASON TO BELIEVE THAT YOUR SON, MERFIN, PERFORMED MAGIC IN FRONT OF A MUGGLE LATE LAST NIGHT. THERE WAS A DRAVENING CLANG, MERPHE HAD DROPPED ONE OF THE POTS. PICK IT UP! CALINT BELIEVED AT HER. THAT'S IT, GRAB THE FLAME LIKE SOME FILTHY MUGGLE, WHAT'S YOUR WAND FOR, YOU USELESS SACK OF MILK? MR. CALINT, PLEASE! SAID HEDEN IN A SHAKEN VOICE, AS MERPHE, WHO HAD ALREADY PICKED UP THE POT, FLUSHED BLITCHILY SCARLET, LOST HER GRIP ON THE POT AGAIN, DREW HER WAND SHAKILY FROM HER POCKET, POINTED IT AT THE POT, AND MUTTERED A FAST, UNDECIPHERABLE SPELL THAT CAUSED THE POT TO SHOOT ACROSS THE ROOM AWAY FROM HER, HIT THE OPPOSITE WALL, AND CRACK IN TWO. MERFIN LET OUT A MAD CACKLE OF LAUGHTER, CALINT SCREAMED, MEND IT, YOU POINTLESS LUMP, MEND IT! MERPHE STUMBLER ACROSS THE ROOM, BUT BEFORE SHE HAD TIME TO RAISE HER WAND, HEDEN HAD LIFTED HIS HAND AND SAID FIRMLY, REPAIR. THE POT MENDED ITSELF INSTANTLY. CALINT SMILED FOR A MOMENT AS THOUGH HE WAS CHING THE SHULT AT HEDEN, BUT SEEMED TO THINK BETTER OF IT: INSTEAD, HE LEERED AT HIS DAUGHTER, LIKE THE NICE MAN FROM THE MINISTRY'S HERE, ISN'T IT? PERHAPS HE'LL TAKE YOU OFF MY HANDS, PERHAPS HE DOESN'T MIND DIRTY SPELLS.

WITHOUT LOOKING AT ANYBODY BUT TOWARD HEDEN, MERPHE PICKED UP THE POT AND RETURNED IT, HANDS TREMBLING, TO ITS SHELF. SHE THEN STOOD BLITELY STILL, HER BACK AGAINST THE WALL BETWEEN THE FILTHY WINDOWS AND THE STOVE, AS THOUGH SHE WISHED FOR NOTHING MORE THAN TO SINK INTO THE STONE AND VANISH. MR. CALINT, HEDEN BEGAN AGAIN, AS I'VE SAID: THE REASON FOR MY VISIT I HEARD YOU THE FIRST TIME! SNAPPED CALINT. AND SEE WHAT? MERFIN GAVE A MUGGLE A HIT OF WHAT WAS COMING TO HIM WHAT ABOUT IT, THEN? MERFIN HAS BROKEN WIZARDING LAW, SAID HEDEN STERNLY. MERFIN HAS BROKEN WIZARDING LAW. CALINT IMITATED HEDEN'S VOICE, MAKING IT PEEVISH AND SINGING. MERFIN CACKLED AGAIN.

HE THOUGHT A FILTHY MUGGLE A LESSON, THAT S ILLEGAL NEEL, IS IT?

YES, SAID HEDEN. I M AFRAID IT IS. HE PULLED FROM AN INSIDE POCKET A SMALL SCROLL OF PARCHMENT AND UNROLLED IT. WHAT S THAT, THEN, HIS SENTENCE? SAID CALINT, HIS VOICE RISING ANGERILY. IT IS A SUMMONS TO THE MINISTRY FOR A HEARING. SUMMONS?

SUMMONS? WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU ARE, SUMMONING MY SON ANYWHERE? I M FEAR OF THE MAGICAL LAW ENFORCEMENT SHIELD, SAID HEDEN. AND YOU THINK WE RE SCUM, DO YOU? SCREAMED CALINT, ADVANCING TOWARD HEDEN NEEL, WITH A DIRTY YELLOW-NAILED FINGER POINTING AT HIS CHEST. SCUM WE M BE RUNNING WHEN THE MINISTRY TELLS EM THEY DO YOU KNOW WHAT YOU RE TALKING THE, YOU FILTHY LITTLE MUGGLEHEAD, DO YOU? I WAS UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT I WAS SPEAKING TO MR. CALINT, SAID HEDEN, LOOKING WARY, BUT STANDING HIS GROUND. THAT S RIGHT? REARED CALINT, FOR A MOMENT, HARRY THOUGHT CALINT WAS MAKING AN EXCITED HAND GESTURE, BUT THEN REALIZED THAT HE WAS SHOWING HEDEN THE LEGAL, BLACK-STAINED RING HE WAS WEARING ON HIS MIDDLE FINGER, HAVING IT BEFORE HEDEN S EYES. SEE THIS? SEE THIS? KNOW WHAT IT IS? KNOW WHERE IT CAME FROM? CENTURIES IT S BEEN IN OUR FAMILY, THAT S BEEN FAR BACK WE GO, AND LONGER ALL THE WAY? KNOW HOW MUCH I VE BEEN OFFERED FOR THIS, WITH THE PEVERELL COAT OF ARMS ENGRAVED ON THE STONE? I VE REALLY NO IDEA, SAID HEDEN, GLANCING AT THE RING SAILED WITHIN AN INCH OF HIS NOSE, AND IT S WHITE BESIDE THE POINT, MR. CALINT, YOUR SON HAS COMMITTED. WITH A FLASH OF RAGE, CALINT RAN TOWARD HIS DAUGHTER, FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HARRY THOUGHT HE WAS GOING TO THREATEN HER AS HIS HAND FLEW TOWARD HER THREAT; NEXT MOMENT, HE WAS DRAGGING HER TOWARD HEDEN BY A CHAIN AROUND HER NECK. SEE THIS? HE BELLEVED AT HEDEN, SHAKING A HEAVY CHAIN LOCKET AT HIM, WHILE MERPHE SPOLLTERED AND GASPED FOR BREATH. I SEE IT, I SEE IT! SAID HEDEN HASTILY. SLYTHERIN S? YELLED CALINT. SALAZAR SLYTHERIN S? WE RE HIS LAST LIVING DESCENDANTS, WHAT DO YOU SAY TO THAT, EH? MR. CALINT, YOUR DAUGHTER? SAID HEDEN IN ALARM, BUT CALINT HAD ALREADY RELEASED MERPHE; SHE STAGGERED AWAY FROM HIM, BACK TO HER CORNER, MASSAGING HER NECK AND GLIMPING HER AIR. SHE! SAID CALINT TRIUMPHANTLY, AS THOUGH HE HAD JUST PROVED A COMPLICATED POINT BEYOND ALL POSSIBLE DISPUTE. DON T YOU GO TALKING TO US AS IF WE RE DIRT AND YOUR SHEES? GENERATIONS OF PURPLEHEADS, WIZARDS ALL

MORE THAN YOU CAN SAY, I DON'T BELIEVE! AND HE SPAT HIM THE FLAME AT EGDEN'S FEET. MERFIN LAUGHED AGAIN. MERFEE, HIDDEN BESIDE THE WINDMILL, HER HEAD BOWED AND HER FACE HIDDEN BY HER LONG HAIR, SAID NOTHING. MR. GALINT, SAID EGDEN DEEPLY, I AM AFRAID THAT NEITHER YOUR ANCESTERS NOR MINE HAVE ANYTHING TO DO WITH THE MATTER IN HAND. I AM HERE BECAUSE OF MERFIN, MERFIN AND THE MUGGLE HE ACCUSED LAST LAST NIGHT. YOUR INFORMATION HE GLANCED DOWN AT HIS SCROLL OF PARCHMENT IS THAT MERFIN PERFORMED A Jinx ON ME IN THE SAID MUGGLE, CAUSING HIM THE PAIN IN HIS PAINFUL HIVES. MERFIN GIGGLED. BE BELIEVE, SHE, SNARLED GALINT IN PARSEMENT, AND MERFIN FELL SILENT AGAIN. AND SHE WHAT IF HE DID, THEN? GALINT SAID DEFIANTLY TO EGDEN, I EXPECT YOU WILL WIPED THE MUGGLE'S FILTHY FACE CLEAN FOR HIM, AND HIS MEMORY THE SHEET THAT'S HARDLY THE POINT, IS IT, MR. GALINT? SAID EGDEN. THIS WAS AN UNPREPARED ATTACK IN A DEFENSELESS

AH, I HAD YOU MARKED HIM AS A MUGGLE-LIEN THE MOMENT I SAW YOU, SNARLED GALINT, AND HE SPAT HIM THE FLAME AGAIN. THIS DISCUSSION IS GETTING US NOWHERE, SAID EGDEN FIRMLY. IT IS CLEAR FROM YOUR OWN ATTITUDE THAT HE FEELS NO REMORSE FOR HIS ACTIONS. HE GLANCED DOWN AT HIS SCROLL OF PARCHMENT AGAIN.

MERFIN WILL ATTEND A HEARING IN THE FORTIETH OF SEPTEMBER TO ANSWER THE CHARGES OF USING MAGIC IN FRONT OF A MUGGLE AND CAUSING HARM AND DISTRESS TO THAT SAME MUGGLE. EGDEN KROOKED OFF. THE RINGING, CLIPPING SOUNDS OF WHEELS AND WHEELS, LAUGHING VEHICLES WERE DRIFTING IN THROUGH THE OPEN WINDMILL. APPARENTLY THE WINDING LANE TO THE VILLAGE PASSED VERY CLOSE TO THE CHURCH WHERE THE HOUSE STOOD. GALINT FREEZE, LISTENING, HIS EYES WIDE. MERFIN HISSED AND TURNED HIS FACE TOWARD THE SOUNDS, HIS EXPRESSION FLINCHING. MERFEE RAISED HER HEAD, HER FACE, BARRY SAW, WAS STARKLY WHITE. MY GOD, WHAT AN EYESHORE! RANG HIM A GIRL'S VOICE, AS CLEARLY AUDIBLE THROUGH THE OPEN WINDMILL AS IF SHE HAD STOOD IN THE ROOM BESIDE THEM. COULDN'T YOUR FATHER HAVE THAT HIVEY CLEARED AWAY, THEN? IT'S NOT HIS, SAID A YOUNG MAN'S VOICE. EVERYTHING IN THE EITHER SIDE OF THE VALLEY BELONGS TO US, BUT THAT CHURCH BELONGS TO AN OLD TRAMP CALLED GALINT, AND HIS CHILDREN. THE SHE'S WHITE MAD, YOU SHOULD HEAR SOME OF THE STORIES THEY TELL IN THE VILLAGE. THE GIRL LAUGHED. THE RINGING, CLIPPING WHEELS WERE GROWING LOUDER AND LOUDER. MERFIN

MADE THE GET UP HT OF HIS ARMCHAIR, DEEP YELLO SEAT, SAID HIS FATHER
 WARNINGLY, IN PARSELTENGLIE. THEN, SAID THE GIRL S VOICE AGAIN,
 WHEN SHE CLESE THEY WERE CLEARLY RIGHT BESIDE THE HOUSE, I MIGHT BE
 WRITING BUT HAS SHE KNEWLY NAILED A SNAKE THE THAT DEER? GOOD
 LORD, YELL RE RIGHT? SAID THE MAN S VOICE. THAT LL BE THE SEEN, I
 TELL YELL HE S NOT RIGHT IN THE HEAD, DEEN T LEEK AT IT, CECILIA,
 DARLING. THE INGELING AND CLEPPING SEELDS WERE WHEN GRUWING
 FAINTER AGAIN. DARLING, WHISPERED MERFIN IN PARSELTENGLIE,
 LEEKING AT HIS SISTER. DARLING, HE CALLED HER, SEE HE WELLDEN T
 HAVE YELL ANDWAY. MERHEP WAS SHE WHITE FARRY FELT SURE SHE WAS
 GOING THE FAINT. WHAT S THAT? SAID CALINT SHARPLY, ALSO IN
 PARSELTENGLIE, LEEKING FROM HIS SEEN THE HIS DAUGHTER. WHAT DID
 YELL SAY, MERFIN? SHE LIKES LEEKING AT THAT MUGGLE, SAID
 MERFIN, A VICIOUS EXPRESSION IN HIS FACE AS HE STARED AT HIS SISTER,
 WHEN WHEN LEEKED TERRIFIED. ALWAYS IN THE GARDEN WHEN HE PASSES,
 PEERING THROUGH THE HEDGE AT HIM, ISN T SHE? AND LAST NIGHT
 MERHEP SEEN HER HEAD IRKILY, IMPLORINGLY, BUT MERFIN WENT ON
 RUTHLESSLY. HANGING HT OF THE WINDEN WAITING FOR HIM THE RIDE
 HOME, WASN T SHE? HANGING HT OF THE WINDEN THE LEEK AT A
 MUGGLE? SAID CALINT QUIETLY. ALL THREE OF THE CALINTS SEEMED TO
 HAVE FORGOTTEN HEDEN, WHEN WAS LEEKING BOTH KILDERED AND
 IRRITATED AT THIS REVELED HLTEREAD OF INCOMPREHENSIBLE HISsing
 AND RASping. IS IT TRUE? SAID CALINT IN A DEADLY VOICE, ADVANCING
 A STEP FOR THEN TOWARD THE TERRIFIED GIRL. MY DAUGHTER PURE-
 BLEHED DESCENDANT OF SALAZAR SLYTHERIN HANDERING AFTER A
 FILTHY, DIRT-VEINED MUGGLE? MERHEP SEEN HER HEAD FRANTICALLY,
 PRESSING HERSELF INTO THE WALL, APPARENTLY UNABLE TO SPEAK. BUT I
 GET HIM, FATHER? CACKLED MERFIN. I GET HIM AS HE WENT BY AND HE
 DIDN T LEEK SEE PRETTY WITH HIVES ALL OVER HIM, DID HE, MERHEP?

YELL DISGLISTING LITTLE SEELIE, YELL FILTHY LITTLE BLEED TRAITER!
 REARED CALINT, LESTING CENTRELL, AND HIS HANDS CLESED AROUND HIS
 DAUGHTER S THREAT. BOTH FARRY AND HEDEN YELLED NO! AT THE
 SAME TIME; HEDEN RAISED HIS WAND AND CRIED, RELASH-HE! CALINT WAS
 THROWN BACKWARD, AWAY FROM HIS DAUGHTER; HE TRIPPED OVER A
 CHAIR AND FELL FLAT ON HIS BACK. WITH A REAR OF RAGE, MERFIN LEAPT
 HT OF HIS CHAIR AND RAN AT HEDEN, BRANDISHING HIS BLEEDY KNIFE
 AND FIRING HEXES INDISCRIMINATELY FROM HIS WAND. HEDEN RAN FOR
 HIS LIFE, DUMKLEDORE INDICATED THAT THEY HUGHT THE FELLEW AND FARRY

HEARD, MERPHE'S SCREAMS ECHOING IN HIS EARS. EGEDEN FLIRTLED UP THE PATH AND ROLLOTTED BENTH THE MAIN LANE, HIS ARMS OVER HIS HEAD, WHERE HE COLLIDED WITH THE GLOSSY CHESTNUT HORSE RIDDEN BY A VERY HANDSOME, DARK-HAIRED YOUNG MAN, BENTH HE AND THE PRETTY GIRL RIDING BESIDE HIM IN A GRAY HORSE REARED WITH ALACRITY AT THE SIGHT OF EGEDEN, WHO REELINED OFF THE HORSE'S FLANK AND SET OFF AGAIN, HIS FEELER CHAT FLYING, CHIVERED FROM HEAD TO HEEL IN BLIST, ROLLING PELL-MELL UP THE LANE. I THINK THAT WILL DO, FARRY, SAID DUMKLEDHRE, HE THREW FARRY BY THE ELBOW AND TUGGED. NEXT MOMENT, THEY WERE BOTH SHARING WEIGHTLESSLY THROUGH DARKNESS, UNTIL THEY LANDED SULLARLY IN THEIR FEET, BACK IN DUMKLEDHRE'S NEAR TWILIT OFFICE. WHAT HAPPENED TO THE GIRL IN THE CHITAGE? SAID FARRY AT ONCE, AS DUMKLEDHRE LIT EXTRA LAMPS WITH A FLICK OF HIS WAND.

MERPHE, HER WHATEVER HER NAME WAS? EH, SHE SURVIVED, SAID DUMKLEDHRE, RESEATING HIMSELF BEHIND HIS DESK AND INDICATING THAT FARRY SHOULD SIT DOWN TOO. EGEDEN APPARATED BACK TO THE MINISTRY AND RETURNED WITH REINFORCEMENTS WITHIN FIFTEEN MINUTES. MERFIN AND HIS FATHER ATTEMPTED THE FIGHT, BUT BOTH WERE OVERPOWERED, REMOVED FROM THE CHITAGE, AND SUBSEQUENTLY CONVICED BY THE WIZENGAMET. MERFIN, WHO ALREADY HAD A RECORD OF MULEE ATTACKS, WAS SENTENCED TO THREE YEARS IN AZKABAN. MARVELL, WHO HAD INJURED SEVERAL MINISTRY EMPLOYEES IN ADDITION TO EGEDEN, RECEIVED SIX MONTHS. MARVELL? FARRY REPEATED WHINDERINGLY. THAT'S RIGHT, SAID DUMKLEDHRE, SMILING IN APPROVAL. I AM GLAD TO SEE YOU'RE KEEPING UP. THAT OLD MAN WAS ? VERBEMERT'S GRANDFATHER, YES, SAID DUMKLEDHRE.

MARVELL, HIS SON, MERFIN, AND HIS DAUGHTER, MERPHE, WERE THE LAST OF THE CALINTS, A VERY ANCIENT WIZARDING FAMILY NOTED FOR A VEIN OF INSTABILITY AND VIOLENCE THAT FLOURISHED THROUGH THE GENERATIONS DUE TO THEIR HABIT OF MARRYING THEIR OWN COUNSINS. LACK OF SENSE COMBLED WITH A GREAT LIXING FOR GRANDLIR MEANT THAT THE FAMILY CHILD WAS SHANDERED SEVERAL GENERATIONS BEFORE MARVELL WAS BORN. HE, AS YOU SAW, WAS LEFT IN SHALAH AND POVERTY, WITH A VERY NASTY TEMPER, A FANTASTIC AMELINT OF ARRIGANCE AND PRIDE, AND A COMPLE OF FAMILY FEELINGS THAT HE TREASURED ILIT AS MUCH AS HIS SON, AND RATHER MORE THAN HIS DAUGHTER. SEE MERPHE, SAID FARRY, LEANING FORWARD IN HIS CHAIR AND STARING AT DUMKLEDHRE. SEE MERPHE WAS SIR, DOES THAT MEAN

SHE WAS VERDEMERT'S MOTHER? IT DOES, SAID DUMKLEBERRY, AND IT SHE HAPPENS THAT WE ALSO HAD A GLIMPSE OF VERDEMERT'S FATHER, I WONDER WHETHER YOU NOTICED? THE MUGGLE MURKIN ATTACKED? THE MAN ON THE HORSE? VERY GOOD INDEED, SAID DUMKLEBERRY, BEARING, YES, THAT WAS THEM RIDDLER SENIOR, THE HANDSOME MUGGLE WHEN USED THE GEE RIDING PAST THE CALINT COTTAGE AND HER WITH MERKLE CALINT CHERISHED A SECRET, KLARNING PASSION, AND THEY ENDED UP MARRIED? HARRY SAID IN DISBELIEF, UNABLE TO IMAGINE TWO PEOPLE LESS LIKELY TO FALL IN LOVE, I THINK YOU ARE FORGETTING, SAID DUMKLEBERRY, THAT MERKLE WAS A WITCH, I DO NOT BELIEVE THAT HER MAGICAL POWERS APPEARED TO THEIR BEST ADVANTAGE WHEN SHE WAS BEING TERRIFIED BY HER FATHER, SINCE MARVELL AND MERKIN WERE SAFELY IN AZKABAN, SINCE SHE WAS ALONE AND FREE FOR THE FIRST TIME IN HER LIFE, THEN, I AM SURE, SHE WAS ABLE TO GIVE FULL REIN TO HER ABILITIES AND TO PLOT HER ESCAPE FROM THE DESPERATE LIFE SHE HAD LED FOR EIGHTEEN YEARS, CAN YOU NOT THINK OF ANY MEASURE MERKLE COULD HAVE TAKEN TO MAKE THEM RIDDLER FORGET HIS MUGGLE COMPANION, AND FALL IN LOVE WITH HER INSTEAD? THE IMPERIALS CURSE? HARRY SUGGESTED, HER A LOVE POTION? VERY GOOD, PERSONALLY, I AM INCLINED TO THINK THAT SHE USED A LOVE POTION, I AM SURE IT WOULD HAVE SEEMED MORE ROMANTIC TO HER, AND I DO NOT THINK IT WOULD HAVE BEEN VERY DIFFICULT, SOME FINE DAY, WHEN RIDDLER WAS RIDING ALONE, TO PERSUADE HIM TO TAKE A DRINK OF WATER, IN ANY CASE, WITHIN A FEW MONTHS OF THE SCENE WE HAVE JUST WITNESSED, THE VILLAGE OF LITTLE HANGLETON ENJOYED A TREMENDOUS SCANDAL, YOU CAN IMAGINE THE Gossip IT CAUSED WHEN THE SHLIRE'S SON RAN OFF WITH THE TRAMP'S DAUGHTER, MERKLE, BUT THE VILLAGERS SHOULD HAVE NOTICED THE MARVELL'S, HE RETURNED FROM AZKABAN, EXPECTING TO FIND HIS DAUGHTER BLISSFULLY AWAITING HIS RETURN WITH A FINE MEAL READY ON HIS TABLE, INSTEAD, HE FOUND A CLEAR ICE-BOX AND HER NOTE OF FAREWELL, EXPLAINING WHAT SHE HAD DONE, FROM ALL THAT I HAVE BEEN ABLE TO DISCOVER, HE NEVER MENTIONED HER NAME OR EXISTENCE FROM THAT TIME FORTH, THE SILENCE OF HER DESERTION MAY HAVE CONTRIBUTED TO HIS EARLY DEATH, OR PERHAPS HE HAD SIMPLY NEVER LEARNED TO FEEL HIMSELF, AZKABAN HAD GREATLY WEAKENED MARVELL, AND HE DID NOT LIVE TO SEE MERKIN RETURN TO THE COTTAGE, AND MERKLE? SHE SHE DIED, DIDN'T SHE? WASN'T VERDEMERT BRIGHT UP IN AN EMPHATIC? YES, INDEED, SAID

OLMPEDEHRE. WE MUST BE A CERTAIN AMOUNT OF GUESSING HERE, ALTHOUGH I DO NOT THINK IT IS DIFFICULT TO BELIEVE WHAT HAPPENED. YELL SEE, WITHIN A FEW MONTHS OF THEIR ORIGINAL MARRIAGE, THEM RIDDLE REAPPEARED AT THE MANOR HOUSE IN LITTLE HANGLETON WITHOUT HIS WIFE. THE RUMOR FLEW AROUND THE NEIGHBORHOOD THAT HE WAS TALKING OF BEING FORTHWENT AND TAKEN IN. WHAT HE MEANT, I AM SURE, IS THAT HE HAD BEEN UNDER AN ENCHANTMENT THAT HAD BEEN LIFTED, THOUGH I DARE SAY HE DID NOT DARE USE THESE PRECISE WORDS FOR FEAR OF BEING THOUGHT INSANE. WHEN THEY HEARD WHAT HE WAS SAYING, HOWEVER, THE VILLAGERS GUESSED THAT MERPHE HAD LIED TO THEM RIDDLE, PRETENDING THAT SHE WAS GOING TO HAVE HIS BABY, AND THAT HE HAD MARRIED HER FOR THIS REASON. BUT SHE DID HAVE HIS BABY. BUT NOT UNTIL A YEAR AFTER THEY WERE MARRIED, THEM RIDDLE LEFT HER WHILE SHE WAS STILL PREGNANT. WHAT WENT WRONG? ASKED HARRY. WHY DID THE LEVE FORTHEN STOP WORKING? AGAIN, THIS IS GUESSWORK, SAID OLMPEDEHRE, BUT I BELIEVE THAT MERPHE, WHEN WAS DEEPLY IN LOVE WITH HER HUSBAND, COULD NOT BEAR THE CONTINUING ENSLAVING HIM BY MAGICAL MEANS. I BELIEVE THAT SHE MADE THE CHOICE TO STOP GIVING HIM THE POTION. PERHAPS, RESETTLED AS SHE WAS, SHE HAD CONVINCED HERSELF THAT HE WOULD BY NOW HAVE FALLEN IN LOVE WITH HER IN RETURN. PERHAPS SHE THOUGHT HE WOULD STAY FOR THE BABY'S SAKE. IF SHE, SHE WAS WORKING ON BOTH COUNTS, SHE LEFT HER, NEVER SAW HER AGAIN, AND NEVER TRIEBLED THE DISCOVERY WHAT BECAME OF HIS SON. THE SKY OUTSIDE WAS INDEED BLACK AND THE LAMPS IN OLMPEDEHRE'S OFFICE SEEMED TO GLOW MORE BRIGHTLY THAN BEFORE. I THINK THAT WILL BE FOR TONIGHT, HARRY, SAID OLMPEDEHRE AFTER A MOMENT OF TALK. YES, SIR, SAID HARRY, HE GET TO HIS FEET, BUT DID NOT LEAVE. SIR IS IT IMPORTANT TO KNOW ALL THIS ABOUT VERBEMERT'S PAST? VERY IMPORTANT, I THINK, SAID OLMPEDEHRE. AND IT IT'S GET SOMETHING TO DO WITH THE PROPHECY? IT HAS EVERYTHING TO DO WITH THE PROPHECY. RIGHT, SAID HARRY, A LITTLE CONFUSED, BUT REASSURED ALL THE SAME. HE TURNED TO GO, THEN ANOTHER ELDESTERN ECCLARED TO HIM, AND HE TURNED BACK AGAIN. SIR, AM I ALLOWED TO TELL BEN AND HERMIONE EVERYTHING YELL'VE TOLD ME? OLMPEDEHRE CONSIDERED HIM FOR A MOMENT, THEN SAID, YES, I THINK MR. WEASLEY AND MISS GRANGER HAVE PROVED THEMSELVES TRUSTWORTHY. BUT HARRY, I AM GOING TO ASK YELL TO ASK THEM NOT TO REPEAT ANY OF THIS TO ANYBODY ELSE. IT WOULD NOT BE A GOOD IDEA IF

WHO'D GET AROUND HOW MUCH I KNOW, HER SUSPECT, ABOUT LORD
VANDERHART'S SECRETS. NO, SIR, I'LL MAKE SURE IT'S JUST ROBIN AND
BERMINE, GOOD NIGHT. HE TURNED AWAY AGAIN, AND WAS ALMOST AT
THE DOOR WHEN HE SAW IT, SITTING ON ONE OF THE LITTLE SPINDLE-
LEGGED TABLES THAT SUPPORTED SHE MANY FRILLING SILVER
INSTRUMENTS, WAS AN OLD GOLD RING SET WITH A LARGE, CRACKED, BLACK
STONE. SIR, SAID HARRY, STARING AT IT. THAT RING YES? SAID
DUMBLEDORE. YOU WERE WEARING IT WHEN WE VISITED PROFESSOR
SLUGHORN THAT NIGHT. SEE I WAS, DUMBLEDORE AGREED, BUT ISN'T IT

SIR, ISN'T IT THE SAME RING MARVELL CALINT STOLE FROM ME?
DUMBLEDORE NODDED HIS HEAD. THE VERY SAME. BUT HOW COME?
HAVE YOU ALWAYS HAD IT? NO, I ACQUIRED IT VERY RECENTLY, SAID
DUMBLEDORE. A FEW DAYS BEFORE I CAME TO FETCH YOU FROM YOUR AUNT
AND UNCLE'S, IN FACT. THAT WOULD BE AROUND THE TIME YOU INJURED
YOUR HAND, THEN, SIR? AROUND THAT TIME, YES, HARRY. HARRY
HESITATED, DUMBLEDORE WAS SMILING. SIR, HOW EXACTLY? THE
LATE, HARRY? YOU SHALL HEAR THE STORY ANOTHER TIME, GOOD NIGHT.

GOOD NIGHT, SIR. BERMINE'S HELPING HAND AS BERMINE HAD
PREDICTED, THE SIXTH YEARS FREE PERIODS WERE NOT THE EASY
BLISSFUL RELAXATION ROBIN HAD ANTICIPATED, BUT TIMES IN WHICH THE
ATTEMPT TO KEEP UP WITH THE VAST AMOUNT OF HOMEWORK THEY WERE
BEING SET, NOT ONLY WERE THEY STUDYING AS THOUGH THEY HAD EXAMS
EVERY DAY, BUT THE LESSONS THEMSELVES HAD BECOME MORE DEMANDING
THAN EVER BEFORE. HARRY RARELY UNDERSTOOD HALF OF WHAT PROFESSOR
MCGRAGALL SAID THEM THESE DAYS; EVEN BERMINE HAD HAD TO
ASK HER THE REPEAT INSTRUCTIONS SINCE HER TWICE. INCREDIBLY, AND THE
BERMINE'S INCREASING RESENTMENT, HARRY'S BEST SECRET HAD
SUDDENLY BECOME PERILS, THANKS TO THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE.

NUMEROUS SPELLS WERE NOW EXPECTED, NOT ONLY IN DEFENSE AGAINST
THE DARK ARTS, BUT IN CHARM AND TRANSFIGURATION TOO. HARRY
FREQUENTLY LOOKED OVER AT HIS CLASSMATES IN THE CHAIRS WHEN HE
AT MEALTIMES TO SEE THEM PURPLE IN THE FACE AND STRAINING AS
THOUGH THEY HAD OVERDOSE ON L-J-N-P-EE; BUT HE KNEW THAT THEY
WERE REALLY STRUGGLING TO MAKE SPELLS WORK WITHOUT SAYING
INCANTATIONS ALOUD. IT WAS A RELIEF TO GET OUTSIDE INTO THE
GREENHOUSE; THEY WERE DEALING WITH MORE DANGEROUS PLANTS THAN
EVER IN HERBOLGY, BUT AT LEAST THEY WERE STILL ALLOWED TO SWEAR
LOUDLY IF THE VENOMOUS TENTACLES SEIZED THEM UNEXPECTEDLY FROM

BEHIND. THE RESULT OF THEIR ENORMOUS WERKHEAD AND THE FRANTIC EFFORTS OF PRACTISING NUMEROUS SPELLS WAS THAT HARRY, RON, AND HERMION HAD SO FAR BEEN LUCKY THE FIND TIME THE GO AND VISIT HAGRID. HE HAD STOPPED COOKING THE MEALS AT THE STAFF TABLE, AN OBVIOUS SIGN, AND WHEN THE FEW OCCASIONS WHEN THEY HAD PASSED HIM IN THE HALLWAYS HE HELT IN THE CORRIDORS, HE HAD MYSTERIOUSLY FAILED THE NOTICE THEM OR HEAR THEIR GREETINGS. WE VE GOT THE GO AND EXPLAIN, SAID HERMION, LEAVING UP AT HAGRID'S FLICKER EMPTY CHAIR AT THE STAFF TABLE THE FOLLOWING SATURDAY AT BREAKFAST.

WE VE GOT HEDDITCH-TROUBLE THIS MORNING? SAID RON. AND WE RE SUPPOSED TO BE PRACTISING THAT AGGLEMENTI CHARM FROM FLITWICK? ANYWAY, EXPLAIN WHAT? THEY ARE WE GOING TO TELL HIM WE HATED HIS STUPID SUBJECT? WE DIDN'T HATE IT? SAID HERMION.

SPREAD HER WINGS, I HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN THE SUBJECTS, SAID RON DABBLING. AND I'M TELLING YOU NOW, WE VE HAD A NARROW ESCAPE. YOU DIDN'T HEAR HIM GOING ON ABOUT HIS CHARMLESS KITCHEN. WE'D HAVE BEEN TEACHING GRABP HOW TO TIE HIS SHOELACES IF WE'D STAYED. I HATE NOT TALKING TO HAGRID, SAID HERMION, LEAVING UPSET.

WE'LL GO DOWN AFTER HEDDITCH, HARRY ASSURED HER. HE THEN WAS MISSING HAGRID, ALTHOUGH LIKE RON HE THOUGHT THAT THEY WERE BETTER OFF WITHOUT GRABP IN THEIR LIVES. BUT TRIALS MIGHT TAKE ALL MORNING, THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO HAVE APPLIED. HE FELT SLIGHTLY NERVOUS AT CONFRONTING THE FIRST HURDLE OF HIS CAPTAINCY. I WONDER WHY THE TEAM'S THIS POPULAR ALL OF A SUDDEN.

HEY, COME ON, HARRY, SAID HERMION, SLIDENLY IMPATIENT. IT'S NOT HEDDITCH THAT'S POPULAR, IT'S YOU! YOU'VE NEVER BEEN MORE INTERESTING, AND FRANKLY, YOU'VE NEVER BEEN MORE FASCINATING. RON GAGGED ON A LARGE PIECE OF BIPPY. HERMION SPARED HIM ONE LOOK OF DISDAIN BEFORE TURNING BACK TO HARRY. EVERYONE KNOWS YOU'VE BEEN TELLING THE TRUTH NOW, DON'T THEY? THE WHOLE WIZARDING WORLD HAS HAD TO ADMIT THAT YOU WERE RIGHT ABOUT VOLDEMORT BEING BACK AND THAT YOU REALLY HAVE HELPT HIM TWICE IN THE LAST TWO YEARS AND ESCAPED SEVERAL TIMES. AND NOW THEY'RE CALLING YOU

THE CHOSEN ONE. WELL, COME ON, CAN'T YOU SEE WHY PEOPLE ARE FASCINATED BY YOU? HARRY WAS FINDING THE GREAT HALL VERY HOT ALL OF A SUDDEN, EVEN THOUGH THE CEILING STILL LOOKED OLD AND RAINY. AND YOU'VE BEEN THROUGH ALL THAT PERSECUTION FROM THE MINISTRY WHEN THEY WERE TRYING TO MAKE YOU UNSTABLE

AND A LIAR, YHEL CAN STILL SEE THE MARKS ON THE BACK OF YHELIR HAND WHERE THAT EVIL WHEMAN MADE YHEL WRITE WITH YHELIR OWN BLOOD, BUT YHEL SLICK THE YHELIR STEROY AWAY. YHEL CAN STILL SEE WHERE THESE BRAINS GET HELD UP IN THE MINISTRY, LHEED, SAID REEN, SHADING BACK HIS SLEEVES. AND IT DOESN'T HURT THAT YHEL VE GREEN ABELT A FEET EVER THE SUMMER EITHER. FERMINE FINISHED, IGNORING REEN. I'M TALL, SAID REEN INCHENSELIENTIALLY, THE FEET HELLS ARRIVED, SLEDDING DOWN THROUGH RAIN-FLECKED WINDMILLS, SCATTERING EVERYTHING WITH DRIPLETS OF WATER. MOST PEOPLE WERE RECEIVING MORE FEET THAN USUAL; ANDHEL'S PARENTS WERE BEEN THE HEAR FROM THEIR CHILDREN AND THE REASSURE THEM, IN TURN, THAT ALL WAS WELL AT HOME. HARRY HAD RECEIVED NEW MAIL SINCE THE START OF TERM; HIS ONLY REGULAR CORRESPONDENT WAS NEW DEAD AND ALTHOUGH HE HAD HEARD THAT LUPIN MIGHT WRITE OCCASIONALLY, HE HAD BEEN DISAPPOINTED. HE WAS VERY SURPRISED, THEREFORE, TO SEE THE SNOWY WHITE FREDWIG CIRCLING AMONGST ALL THE GREEN AND GRAY HELLS. SHE LANDED IN FRONT OF HIM CARRYING A LARGE, SQUARE PACKAGE. A MOMENT LATER, AN IDENTICAL PACKAGE LANDED IN FRONT OF REEN, CRUSHING BENEATH IT HIS MINUSCULE AND EXHAUSTED HELL, PIGWIDGERN. HAY SAID HARRY, UNWRAPPING THE PARCEL TO REVEAL A NEW COPY OF ADVANCED PETITION-MAKING, FRESH FROM FLEURISH AND BLETTS. EH GHEED, SAID FERMINE, DELIGHTED. NEW YHEL CAN GIVE THAT GRAFFITIED COPY BACK. ARE YHEL MAD? SAID HARRY. I'M KEEPING IT! LHEED, I'VE THOUGHT IT OUT. HE PULLED THE OLD COPY OF ADVANCED PETITION-MAKING OUT OF HIS BAG AND TAPPED THE COVER WITH HIS HAND, MUTTERING, DIFFINDEE! THE COVER FELL OFF, HE DID THE SAME THING WITH THE BRAND-NEW BHEED (FERMINE BHEED SCANDALIZED). HE THEN SWAPPED THE COVERS, TAPPED EACH, AND SAID, REPAIR! THERE SAT THE PRINCE'S COPY, DISGUISED AS A NEW BHEED, AND THERE SAT THE FRESH COPY FROM FLEURISH AND BLETTS, LHEEDING THROUGHLY SECOND-HAND. I'LL GIVE SLLIGHORN BACK THE NEW ONE, HE CAN'T COMPLAIN, IT COST NINE GALLEONS. FERMINE PRESSED HER LIPS TOGETHER, LHEEDING ANGRY AND DISAPPROVING, BUT WAS DISTRACTED BY A THIRD HELL LANDING IN FRONT OF HER CARRYING THAT DAY'S COPY OF THE DAILY PROPHECY. SHE UNWHEDED IT HASTILY AND SCANNED THE FRONT PAGE. ANYONE WE KNOW DEAD? ASKED REEN IN A DETERMINEDLY CASUAL VOICE; HE PRESSED THE SAME QUESTIONS EVERY TIME FERMINE OPENED HER PAPER. NEW, BUT THERE HAVE BEEN MORE DEMENTHE ATTACKS, SAID FERMINE. AND

AN ARREST. EXCELLENT, WHEN? SAID F-HARRY, THINKING OF BELLATRIX LESTRANGE. STAN SKLIMPICK, SAID F-HERMIONNE. WHAT? SAID F-HARRY, STARTLED. STANLEY SKLIMPICK, CHOCOLATE IN THE POPULAR WIZARDING CHOCOLATE THE KNIGHT BUS, HAS BEEN ARRESTED ON SUSPICION OF DEATH EATER ACTIVITY. MR. SKLIMPICK, 21, WAS TAKEN INTO CUSTODY LATE LAST NIGHT AFTER A RAID ON HIS CLAPNET HOME.

STAN SKLIMPICK, A DEATH EATER? SAID F-HARRY, REMEMBERING THE SPOTTY VELVET HE HAD FIRST MET THREE YEARS BEFORE. NO WAY? HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN PUT UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE, SAID RHEN REASONABLY. WELL NEVER CAN TELL. IT DOESN'T LOOK LIKE IT, SAID F-HERMIONNE, WHEN WAS STILL READING. IT SAYS HERE HE WAS ARRESTED AFTER HE WAS OVERHEARD TALKING ABOUT THE DEATH EATERS' SECRET PLANS IN A PUB. SHE LOOKED UP WITH A TWINKLED EXPRESSION ON HER FACE. IF HE WAS UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE, HE'D HARDLY STAND AROUND Gossiping ABOUT THEIR PLANS, WOULD HE? IT SEEMS LIKE HE WAS TRYING TO MAKE OUT HE KNEW MORE THAN HE DID, SAID RHEN.

ISN'T HE THE ONE WHEN CLAIMED HE WAS CHIEF THE RECENT MINISTER OF MAGIC WHEN HE WAS TRYING TO GET UP THERE YET? Yeah, THAT'S HIM, SAID F-HARRY. I DON'T KNOW WHAT THEY'RE PLAYING AT, TAKING STAN SERIOUSLY. THEY PROBABLY WANT THE LOOK AS THOUGH THEY'RE DOING SOMETHING, SAID F-HERMIONNE, FROWNING. PEOPLE ARE TERRIFIED. WELL KNOW THE PATIL TWINS' PARENTS WANT THEM TO GO HOME? AND ELISE MIDGEN HAS ALREADY BEEN WITHDRAWN. HER FATHER PICKED HER UP LAST NIGHT. WHAT? SAID RHEN, GIGGLING AT F-HERMIONNE. BUT F-HERMIONNE IS SAFER THAN THEIR HOMES, BEHIND THE RE? WE'VE GOT ALIBIS, AND ALL THESE EXTRA PROTECTIVE SPELLS, AND WE'VE GOT OMBLEBERRY? I DON'T THINK WE'VE GOT HIM ALL THE TIME, SAID F-HERMIONNE VERY QUIETLY, GLANCING TOWARD THE STAFF TABLE OVER THE TOP OF THE PREFECT.

HAVEN'T YOU NOTICED HIS SEAT'S BEEN EMPTY AS OFTEN AS F-ACRID'S THIS PAST WEEK. F-HARRY AND RHEN LOOKED UP AT THE STAFF TABLE. THE HEADMASTER'S CHAIR WAS INDEED EMPTY. WHEN F-HARRY CAME TO THINK OF IT, HE HAD NOT SEEN OMBLEBERRY SINCE THEIR PRIVATE LESSON A WEEK AGO. I THINK HE'S LEFT THE SCHOOL TO DO SOMETHING WITH THE ORDER, SAID F-HERMIONNE IN A LOW VOICE. I MEAN IT'S ALL LOOKING SERIOUS, ISN'T IT? F-HARRY AND RHEN DID NOT ANSWER, BUT F-HARRY KNEW THAT THEY WERE ALL THINKING THE SAME THING. THERE HAD BEEN A HORRIBLE INCIDENT THE DAY BEFORE, WHEN F-ANDREW ARKETT HAD BEEN TAKEN OUT OF F-RECKLESSLY THE RE TOLD HER MOTHER HAD BEEN FEELING DEAD.

THEY HAD NOT SEEN HANNAH SINCE. WHEN THEY LEFT THE GRYPFINDER TABLE FIVE MINUTES LATER THE HEAD BEHIND THE THE FLIBBITCH PITCH, THEY PASSED LAVENDER BROWN AND PARVATI PATIL. REMEMBERING WHAT HERMIONE HAD SAID ABOUT THE PATIL TWINS' PARENTS WANTING THEM TO LEAVE HOGWARTS, HARRY WAS UNSURPRISED TO SEE THAT THE THREE BEST FRIENDS WERE WHISPERING TOGETHER, LOOKING DISTRESSED. WHAT DID SURPRISE HIM WAS THAT WHEN ROON DREW LEVEL WITH THEM, PARVATI SUDDENLY NUDGED LAVENDER, WHO LOOKED AROUND AND GAVE ROON A WIDE SMILE. ROON BLINKED AT HER, THEN RETURNED THE SMILE UNCERTAINLY. HIS HAIR INSTANTLY BECAME SOMETHING MORE LIKE A STRUT. HARRY RESISTED THE TEMPTATION TO LAUGH, REMEMBERING THAT ROON HAD REFRAINED FROM DOING SO AFTER MALFOY HAD CRICKENED HARRY'S NECK; HERMIONE, HOWEVER, LOOKED COLD AND DISTANT ALL THE WAY DOWN THE STADIUM THROUGH THE CLOUD, MISTY DRIZZLE, AND DEPARTED TO FIND A PLACE IN THE STANDS WITHOUT WISHING ROON GOOD LUCK. AS HARRY HAD EXPECTED, THE TRIALS THEMSELVES MET IN THE MORNING. HALF OF GRYPFINDER HOUSE SEEMED TO HAVE TURNED UP, FROM FIRST YEARS WHO WERE NERVOUSLY CLUTCHING A SELECTION OF THE DREADFUL OLD SCREAMING SNAKES, THE SEVENTH YEARS WHO THUNDERED OVER THE REST, LOOKING COLDLY INTIMIDATING. THE LATTER INCLUDED A LARGE, WIND-FAIRED BOY HARRY RECOGNIZED IMMEDIATELY FROM THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS. HE MET HIM IN THE TRAIN, IN OLD SILVER'S COMPARTMENT. HE SAID CONFIDENTLY, STEPPING OUT OF THE CLOUD THE SHADE HARRY'S HAND.

CHARMA McLAGGEN, KEEPER. YOU DIDN'T TRY OUT LAST YEAR, DID YOU? ASKED HARRY, TAKING NOTE OF THE BREADTH OF McLAGGEN AND THINKING THAT HE WOULD PROBABLY BLOCK ALL THREE CHAMBERS WITHOUT EVEN TRYING. I WAS IN THE HOSPITAL WING WHEN THEY HELD THE TRIALS, SAID McLAGGEN, WITH SOMETHING OF A SWAGGER. ATE A POUND OF DICKY EGGS FOR A KIT. RIGHT, SAID HARRY. WELL, IF YOU WAIT OVER THERE

HE POINTED OVER THE EDGE OF THE PITCH, CLOSE TO WHERE HERMIONE WAS SITTING. HE THOUGHT HE SAW A GLIMPSE OF ANTHONY PARSIVALL PASS OVER McLAGGEN'S FACE AND WONDERED WHETHER McLAGGEN EXPECTED PREFERENTIAL TREATMENT BECAUSE THEY WERE BOTH OLD SILVER'S FAVORITES. HARRY DECIDED TO START WITH A BASIC TEST, ASKING ALL APPLICANTS FOR THE TEAM TO DIVIDE INTO GROUPS OF TEN AND FLY OVER AROUND THE PITCH. THIS WAS A GOOD DECISION! THE FIRST TEN WAS MADE UP OF FIRST YEARS AND IT COULD NOT HAVE BEEN PLAINER THAT THEY HAD HARDLY EVER BEEN THERE. ONLY ONE WHO MANAGED THE

REMAIN AIRBORNE FOR MORE THAN A FEW SECONDS, AND HE WAS SO SURPRISED HE PROMPTLY CRASHED INTO ONE OF THE CHAL POSTS. THE SECOND CRASH WAS COMPRISED OF TEN OF THE SILLIEST GIRLS HARRY HAD EVER ENCOUNTERED, WHO, WHEN HE BLEW HIS WHISTLE, MERELY FELL ABOUT GIGGLING AND CLUTCHING ONE ANOTHER. RHEMILDA VANE WAS AMONGST THEM. WHEN HE TOLD THEM TO LEAVE THE PITCH, THEY DID SO BLITHELY AND WENT TO SIT IN THE STANDS THE FIDDLE EVERYONE ELSE. THE THIRD CRASH HAD A PILEUP HALFWAY AROUND THE PITCH. MOST OF THE FOURTH CRASH HAD COME WITHBLIT KRIKSTICKS. THE FIFTH CRASH WERE FLUFFPOPPS. IF THERE'S ANYONE ELSE HERE WHO'S NOT FROM GRYFFINDOR, REARED HARRY, WHO WAS STARTING TO GET SERIOUSLY ANNOYED. LEAVE NOW, PLEASE! THERE WAS A PAUSE, THEN A CLOUD OF LITTLE RAVENCLAWS WENT SPRINTING OFF THE PITCH, SNEERTING WITH LAUGHTER. AFTER TWO HOURS, MANY COMPLAINTS, AND SEVERAL TANTRUMS, ONE INVOLVING A CRASHED CHMET TWO SIXTY AND SEVERAL BROKEN TEETH, HARRY HAD FOUND HIMSELF THREE CHASERS: KATIE BELL, RETURNED TO THE TEAM AFTER AN EXCELLENT TRIAL; A NEW FIND CALLED DEMELZA REKINS, WHO WAS PARTICULARLY GOOD AT DODGING BLUDGERS; AND GINNY WEASLEY, WHO HAD OUTPERFORMED ALL THE COMPETITION AND SCORED SEVENTEEN CHALS THE WHOLE. PLEASED THOUGH HE WAS WITH HIS CHOICES, HARRY HAD ALSO SEEMED HIMSELF FEARFUL AT THE MANY COMPLAINERS AND WAS NOW ENDURING A SIMILAR BATTLE WITH THE REJECTED BEATERS. THAT'S MY FINAL DECISION AND IF YOU DON'T GET HIT BY THE WAY FOR THE KEEPERS I'LL FORGIVE YOU, HE BELLEVED. NEITHER OF HIS CHOSEN BEATERS HAD THE OLD BRILLIANCE OF FRED AND GEORGE, BUT HE WAS STILL REASONABLY PLEASED WITH THEM: JIMMY PEABLES, A SHORT BUT BROAD-CHESTED THIRD-YEAR BOY WHO HAD MANAGED TO RAISE A LUMP THE SIZE OF AN EGG ON THE BACK OF HARRY'S HEAD WITH A PERFECTIONALLY HIT BLUDGER, AND RITCHIE COOTE, WHO WHISKED WEEDY BUT AIMED WELL. THEY NOW JOINED KATIE, DEMELZA, AND GINNY IN THE STANDS TO WATCH THE SELECTION OF THEIR LAST TEAM MEMBER. HARRY HAD DELIBERATELY LEFT THE TRIAL OF THE KEEPERS UNTIL LAST, HOPING FOR AN EMPTY STADIUM AND LESS PRESSURE FROM ALL CONCERNED. UNFORTUNATELY, HOWEVER, ALL THE REJECTED PLAYERS AND A NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO HAD COME DOWN TO WATCH AFTER A LENGTHY BREAKFAST HAD JOINED THE CROWD BY NOW, SO THAT IT WAS LARGER THAN EVER. AS EACH KEEPER FLEW UP TO THE CHAL FLOCKS, THE CROWD REARED AND KEERED IN EQUAL MEASURE. HARRY GLANCED OVER AT BEN, WHO HAD ALWAYS HAD A PROBLEM WITH NERVES;

Harry had hoped that winning their final match last term might have cleared it, but apparently not! Ron was a delicate shade of green. None of the first five applicants saved more than two goals apiece. The Harry's great disappointment, Chermal McLaggen saved their penalties but of five. In the last one, however, he sent it in completely the wrong direction; the crowd laughed and Ron and McLaggen returned to the crowd grinding his teeth. Ron looked ready to pass out as he belated his cleansweep eleven. Good luck! cried a voice from the stands. Harry looked around, expecting to see Hermione, but it was Lavender Brown. He would have quite liked to have hidden his face in his hands, as she did a moment later, but thought that as the captain he ought to show slightly more grit, and he turned to watch Ron on his trial. Yet he need not have worried; Ron saved one, two, three, four, five penalties in a row, delighted, and resisting nothing in the cheers of the crowd with difficulty. Harry turned to McLaggen to tell him that, most unfortunately, Ron had beaten him, only to find McLaggen's red face inches from his own. He stepped back hastily.

His sister didn't really try, said McLaggen menacingly. There was a vein pulsing in his temple like the one Harry had often admired in Uncle Vernon's. She gave him an easy save.

Alright, said Harry calmly. That was the one he nearly missed. McLaggen took a step nearer Harry, who stood his ground this time. Give me another go. No, said Harry. Well you had your go. Well saved four, Ron saved five, Ron's keeper, he won it fair and square. Get out of my way. He thought for a moment that McLaggen might punch him, but he contented himself with an ugly grimace and stormed away, growling what sounded like threats to thin air. Harry turned around to find his new team staring at him. Well done, he cheered. Well played really well.

Well did brilliantly, Ron! This time it really was Hermione running toward them from the stands! Harry saw Lavender walking off the pitch, arm in arm with Parvati, a rather grimy expression on her face. Ron looked extremely pleased with himself and even taller than usual as he grinned at the team and at Hermione. After fixing the time for their first full practice for the following Thursday, Harry, Ron, and Hermione said good-bye to the rest of the team and headed off toward Hagrid's. A watery

SLIN WAS TRYING THE BREAD THROUGH THE CHILDS NEEL AND IT HAD STOPPED DRIZZLING AT LAST. F-JARRY FELT EXTREMELY HINGERY; HE HOPED THERE WOULD BE SOMETHING THE CAT AT F-JAGRID S. I THOUGHT I WAS EATING THE MISS THAT FORTH PENALTY, REIN WAS SAYING HAPPILY.

TRICKY SHEET FROM DEMELZA, DID YOU SEE, HAD A KIT HE SPIN IN IT YES, YES, YOU WERE MAGNIFICENT, SAID F-ERMINE, LEEKING AMUSED. I WAS BETTER THAN THAT MCLAGGEN ANWAY, SAID REIN IN A HIGHLY SATISFIED VOICE. DID YOU SEE HIM LINGERING OFF IN THE WINDING DIRECTIONS IN HIS FIFTY? LEEKED LIKE HE D BEEN CHENLINED. THE F-JARRY S SURPRISE, F-ERMINE TURNED A VERY DEEP SHADE OF PINK AT THESE WORDS, REIN NOTICED NOTHING; HE WAS THEN BUSY DESCRIBING EACH OF HIS OTHER PENALTIES IN LIVING DETAIL. THE GREAT GRAY HIPPOGRIF, CLICKHEAD, WAS TETHERED IN FRONT OF F-JAGRID S CARKIN. HE CLICKED HIS RAZOR-SHARP BARK AT THEIR APPROACH AND TURNED HIS BLUE HEAD TOWARD THEM. HEY DEAR, SAID F-ERMINE NERVOUSLY.

HE S STILL A KIT SCARY, ISN T HE? COME OFF IT, YOU VE RIDDEN HIM, HAVEN T YOU? SAID REIN, F-JARRY STEPPED FORWARD AND KEHLED WITH THE HIPPOGRIF WITHOUT BREAKING EYE CONTACT OR BLINKING. AFTER A FEW SECONDS, CLICKHEAD SANK INTO A KEEL THEM. F-EL ARE YOU? F-JARRY ASKED HIM IN A LOW VOICE, MOVING FORWARD THE STRIDE THE FEATHERY HEAD. MISSING HIM? BUT YOU RE HERE HERE WITH F-JAGRID, AREN T YOU? HEY SAID A LOW VOICE, F-JAGRID HAD COME STRIDING AROUND THE CORNER OF HIS CARKIN WEARING A LARGE FLEEKY APRON AND CARRYING A SACK OF PENTATHES. HIS ENORMOUS SHARK-TEETH, FANG, WAS AT HIS FEET; FANG GAVE A KEHNING BARK AND KEHLED FORWARD, GET AWAY FROM HIM! HE LL HAVE YER FINGERS HEY, IT S YER LEFT. FANG WAS LIMPING UP AT F-ERMINE AND REIN, ATTEMPTING THE LICK THEIR EARS. F-JAGRID STOOD AND LEEKED AT THEM ALL FOR A SPLIT SECOND, THEN TURNED AND STRODE INTO HIS CARKIN, SLAMMING THE DOOR BEHIND HIM.

HEY DEAR! SAID F-ERMINE, LEEKING STRICKEN. DEN T WHIRRY ABELT IT, SAID F-JARRY GRIMLY, HE WALKED OVER THE THE DOOR AND KNOCKED LOUDLY. F-JAGRID! OPEN UP, WE WANT THE TALK THE YOU! THERE WAS NO SOUND FROM WITHIN. IF YOU DEN T OPEN THE DOOR, WE LL BLAST IT OPEN! F-JARRY SAID, PULLING OUT HIS HAND. F-JARRY! SAID F-ERMINE, SHEDDING SKEED. YOU CAN T POSSIBLY YEAH, I CAN! SAID F-JARRY. STAND BACK BUT BEFORE HE COULD SAY ANYTHING ELSE, THE DOOR FLEW OPEN AGAIN AS F-JARRY HAD KNOWN IT WOULD, AND THERE STOOD F-JAGRID, GLEEKING DOWN AT HIM AND LEEKING, DESPITE THE

ALWAYS APPEARED POSITIVELY ALARMING. I'M A TEACHER! HE REARED AT
FARRY. A TEACHER, PITTER? HOW DARE YOU THREATEN THE BREAD BEEN
MY DEER? I'M SURE, SIR, SAID FARRY, EMPHASIZING THE LAST WORD
AS HE STEWED HIS HAND INSIDE HIS REEKS. FARRID WHISKED STUNNED.

SINCE WHEN HAVE YOU CALLED ME SIR? SINCE WHEN HAVE YOU
CALLED ME PITTER? EH, VERY CLEVER, GRIELED FARRID. VERY
AMUSING, THAT'S MY ELTSMARTED, INNIT? ALL RIGHT, COME IN THEN, YOU
LINGERATEFUL LITTLE MUMBLING DABBLER, HE STOOD BACK THEN LET THEM

PASS, FERMINE SCURRIED IN AFTER FARRY, WHISKING RATHER
FRIGHTENED. WELL? SAID FARRID GRIMPLY, AS FARRY, REEN, AND
FERMINE SAT BEEN AROUND HIS ENORMOUS WHEDEN TABLE, FANG
LAYING HIS HEAD IMMEDIATELY UPON FARRY'S KNEE AND DREHLING ALL
OVER HIS REEKS. WHAT'S THIS? FEELIN SURE FOR ME? RECKEN I'M
HEAVILY HIS SLIMMAY? NO, SAID FARRY AT ONCE. WE WANTED THE SEE
YOU. WE'VE MISSED YOU! SAID FERMINE TREMBLINGLY. MISSED ME,
HAVE YOU? SMERGED FARRID. YEAH, RIGHT. HE STOMPED AROUND,
BREWING LIP TEA IN HIS ENORMOUS CHOPPER KETTLE, MUTTERING ALL THE
WHILE. FINALLY HE SLAMMED DOWN THREE CLACKET-SIZED MUGS OF
MAHOGANY-BREWED TEA IN FRONT OF THEM AND A PLATE OF HIS REEK
CACKES. FARRY WAS FLINERY ENOUGH EVEN FOR FARRID'S WHISKING, AND
THESE HEN AT ONCE. FARRID, SAID FERMINE TIMIDLY, WHEN HE THINED
THEM AT THE TABLE AND STARTED PEELING HIS POTATOES WITH A
BRUTALITY THAT SUGGESTED THAT EACH TUCKER HAD DONE HIM A GREAT
PERSONAL WRONG. WE REALLY WANTED THE CARRY MEN WITH CARE OF
MAGICAL CREATURES, YOU KNOW. FARRID GAVE ANOTHER GREAT SMERT.
FARRY RATHER TELLIGHT SOME KECKYS LANDED ON THE POTATOES, AND
WAS INWARDLY THANKFUL THAT THEY WERE NOT STAYING FOR DINNER.

WE DID! SAID FERMINE. BUT NONE OF US COULD FIT IT INTO OUR
SCHEDULES! YEAH, RIGHT, SAID FARRID AGAIN. THERE WAS A FLINDY
SEWELCHING SEED AND THEY ALL WHISKED AROUND! FERMINE LET OUT A
TINY SHRIEK, AND REEN LEAPT OUT OF HIS SEAT AND FLURRIED AROUND THE
TABLE AWAY FROM THE LARGE BARREL STANDING IN THE CORNER THAT THEY
HAD ONLY JUST NOTICED. IT WAS FULL OF WHAT WHISKED LIKE FEET-LENG
MAGGETS, SLIMY, WHITE, AND WRITHING. WHAT ARE THEY, FARRID?
ASKED FARRY, TRYING THE SEEDING INTERESTED RATHER THAN REVELED, BUT
PLUTTING BEEN HIS REEK CACKES ALL THE SAME. IT'S GIANT GRUBS, SAID
FARRID. AND THEY CRAW INTO ? SAID REEN, WHISKING
APPREHENSIVE. THEY'VE CRAW INTO NOTHING, SAID FARRID. I

GET EM TER FEED TER ARACHIC, AND WITH-OUT WARNING, HE BURST INTO
TEARS, F-JAGRID: CRIED F-JERMINE, LEAPING UP, FLURRYING AROUND THE
TABLE THE BEING WAY THE AVOID THE BARREL OF MAGGOTS, AND PLUTTING AN
ARM AROUND HIS SHAKING SHOULDERS, WHAT IS IT? IT S HIM
GLIMPED F-JAGRID, HIS KEETLE-BLACK EYES STREAMING AS HE MEEPTED HIS
FACE WITH HIS APRON, IT S ARACHIC, I THINK HE S DYIN, F-J
GETTILL EVER THE SLUMPER AN HE S MEET GETTIN BETTER, I DEEN
KNOW WHAT I LL DO IF HE IF HE WE VE KIN TOGETHER SEE BEING,

F-JERMINE PATTED F-JAGRID S SHOULDERS, LEEKING AT A COMPLETE
LOSS FOR ANYTHING THE SAY, F-JARRY KNEW WELL SHE FELT, F-J HAD KNOWN
F-JAGRID THE PRESENT A VICIOUS BABY DRAGON WITH A TEDDY BEAR, SEEN
HIM CREEP EVER GIANT SCORPIONS WITH SLICKERS AND STINGERS,
ATTEMPT THE REASON WITH HIS BRUTAL GIANT OF A HALF-BROTHER, BUT
THIS WAS PERHAPS THE MEET INCOMPREHENSIBLE OF ALL HIS MINISTER
FANCIES: THE GIGANTIC TALKING SPIDER, ARACHIC, WHO DWELLED DEEP IN
THE FORBIDDEN FOREST AND WHICH HE AND RHN HAD ONLY NARROWLY
ESCAPED FEW YEARS PREVIOUSLY, IS THERE IS THERE ANYTHING WE
CAN DO? F-JERMINE ASKED, IGNORING RHN S FRANTIC GRIMACES AND
HEAD-SHAKINGS, I DEEN THINK THERE IS, F-JERMINE, CHUCKED F-JAGRID,
ATTEMPTING THE STEW THE BLEED OF HIS TEARS, SEE, THE REST OF THE
TRIBE ARACHIC S FAMILY THEY RE GETTIN A BIT FLINDY WELL HE S
ILL KIT RESTIVE YEAH, I THINK WE SAW A BIT OF THAT SIDE OF
THEM, SAID RHN IN AN UNDERTONE, I DEEN RECKON IT D BE SAFE FOR
ANYONE BUT ME TO GO NEAR THE COUNTRY AT THE ME, F-JAGRID FINISHED,
BLEEWING HIS NOSE HARD IN HIS APRON AND LEEKING UP, BUT THANKS
FOR OFFERIN, F-JERMINE, IT MEANS A LOT, AFTER THAT, THE
ATMOSPHERE LIGHTENED CONSIDERABLY, FOR ALTHOUGH NEITHER F-JARRY
NOR RHN HAD FELTEN ANY INCLINATION TO GO AND FEED GIANT GILKS THE
A MURDEROUS, GARGANTUAN SPIDER, F-JAGRID SEEMED TO TAKE IT FOR
GRANTED THAT THEY WOULD HAVE LIKED TO HAVE BEEN AND BECAME HIS
USUAL SELF SINCE MORE, AR, I ALWAYS KNEW YEH D FIND IT HARD TO
SLEEPER ME INTO YER TIMETABLES, HE SAID GRUFFLY, PHILRING THEM
MORE TEA, EVEN IF YEH APPLIED FOR TIME-TURNERS WE CHILDEN T
HAVE BEEN, SAID F-JERMINE, WE SMASHED THE ENTIRE STOCK OF
MINISTRY TIME-TURNERS WHEN WE WERE THERE LAST SUMMER, IT WAS
IN THE DAILY PROPHECY, AR, WELL THEN, SAID F-JAGRID, THERE S NO
WAY YEH CHILD VE BEEN IT, I M SORRY I VE KIN YEH KNOW
I VE ILIS KIN WHORIED AROUND ARACHIC AN I DID WONDER WHETHER, IF

PROFESSOR GILKELY-PLANK HAD BEEN TEACHING THEM AT WHICH ALL THREE OF THEM STATED CATEGORICALLY AND UNHESITANTLY THAT PROFESSOR GILKELY-PLANK, WHO HAD SUBSTITUTED FOR LAGRID A FEW TIMES, WAS A DREADFUL TEACHER, WITH THE RESULT THAT BY THE TIME LAGRID WAVED THEM OFF THE PREMISES AT DUSK, HE HEEDED ELITE CHEROKEE. I'M STARVING, SAID LARRY, SINCE THE DINER HAD CLOSED BEHIND THEM AND THEY WERE HURRYING THROUGH THE DARK AND DESERTED GREENLANDS; HE HAD ABANDONED THE RED CAR AFTER AN EMINENT CRACKING NOISE FROM ONE OF HIS BACK TEETH. AND I'VE GOTTEN THAT DETENTION WITH SNARE TONIGHT, I HAVEN'T GOTTEN MUCH TIME FOR DINNER. AS THEY CAME INTO THE CASTLE THEY SPOTTED HERMAN McLAGGEN ENTERING THE GREAT HALL. IT THREW HIM TWO ATTEMPTS TO GET THROUGH THE DINERS; HE RICHETED OFF THE FRAME ON THE FIRST ATTEMPT, THEN MERELY CLAPPED CLANGINGLY AND STRODE OFF INTO THE HALL AFTER HIM, BUT LARRY CALLED LERMINNE'S ARM AND HELD HER BACK. WHAT? SAID LERMINNE DEFENSIVELY. IF YOU ASK ME, SAID LARRY QUIETLY, McLAGGEN LOOKS LIKE HE WAS CHOKED THIS MORNING. AND HE WAS STANDING RIGHT IN FRONT OF WHERE YOU WERE SITTING. LERMINNE BLISHED. HEI, ALL RIGHT THEN, I DID IT, SHE WHISPERED. BUT YOU SHOULD HAVE HEARD THE WAY HE WAS TALKING ABOUT RHN AND GINNY! ANYWAY, HE'S GOT A NASTY TEMPER, YOU SAW HOW HE REACTED WHEN HE DIDN'T GET IN. YOU WOULDN'T HAVE WANTED SOMEONE LIKE THAT ON THE TEAM. NO, SAID LARRY, NO, I SUPPOSE THAT'S TRUE, BUT WASN'T THAT DISHONEST, LERMINNE? I MEAN, YOU'RE A PERFECT, AREN'T YOU? HEI, BE QUIET, SHE SNAPPED, AS HE SMIRKED. WHAT ARE YOU TWO DOING? DEMANDED RHN, REAPPEARING IN THE DINERWAY TO THE GREAT HALL AND LOOKING SUSPICIOUS. NOTHING, SAID LARRY AND LERMINNE TOGETHER, AND THEY HURRIED AFTER RHN. THE SMELL OF ROAST BEEF MADE LARRY'S STOMACH ACHIE WITH HUNGER, BUT THEY HAD BARELY TAKEN THREE STEPS TOWARD THE GYFFINDOR TABLE WHEN PROFESSOR SLUGGISHORN APPEARED IN FRONT OF THEM, BLOCKING THEIR PATH. LARRY, LARRY, LIST THE MAN I WAS TELLING YOU SEE? HE SMILED GENIALLY, TWIDDLING THE ENDS OF HIS WAXEN MUSTACHE AND PLUFFING OUT HIS PNEUMATIC BELLY. I WAS TELLING YOU CATCH YOU BEFORE DINNER? WHAT DO YOU SAY TO A SPOT OF SLIPPER TONIGHT IN MY ROOMS INSTEAD? WE'RE HAVING A LITTLE PARTY, JUST A FEW RISING STARS, I'VE GOT McLAGGEN COMING AND ZARINI, THE CHARMING MELINDA BERRIN. I DON'T KNOW WHETHER YOU KNOW HER? LER

FAMILY HELDS A LARGE CHAIN OF APOTHECARIES AND, OF COURSE, I
 HOPED VERY MUCH THAT MISS GRANGER WILL FAVOUR ME BY CHEERING THEM.
 SLYTHE-HORN MADE FERMINE A LITTLE REEL AS HE FINISHED SPREADING. IT
 WAS AS THOUGH RON WAS NOT PRESENT; SLYTHE-HORN DID NOT SEE MUCH
 AS LOOK AT HIM. I CAN'T CHEER, PROFESSOR, SAID HARRY AT ONCE. I'VE
 GOT A DETENTION WITH PROFESSOR SNAPE. EH DEAR? SAID
 SLYTHE-HORN, HIS FACE FALLING CHEMICALLY. DEAR, DEAR, I WAS CHELINTING
 HIM YELL, HARRY? WELL, NOW, I'LL JUST HAVE TO HAVE A WORD WITH
 SEVERUS AND EXPLAIN THE SITUATION. I'M SURE I'LL BE ABLE TO
 PERSUADE HIM TO PESTERME YOUR DETENTION. YES, I'LL SEE YOU BOTH
 LATER. HE KLISHED AWAY HLT OF THE FALL. HE'S GOT NO CHANCE OF
 PERSUADING SNAPE, SAID HARRY, THE MOMENT SLYTHE-HORN WAS HLT OF
 EARSHEET. THIS DETENTION'S ALREADY BEEN PESTERME HENCE; SNAPE DID
 IT FOR DUMBLEDORE, BUT HE WHEN'T DO IT FOR ANYONE ELSE. EH, I WISH
 YOU COULD CHEER, I DON'T WANT TO GET HIM MY HAND. SAID FERMINE
 ANXIOUSLY; HARRY KNEW THAT SHE WAS THINKING ABOUT MCLAGGEN.
 I DON'T THINK I'LL BE ALONE, GINNY'LL PROBABLY BE INVITED. SNAPE'D
 RON, WHO DID NOT SEEM TO HAVE TAKEN KINDLY TO BEING IGNORED BY
 SLYTHE-HORN. AFTER DINNER THEY MADE THEIR WAY BACK TO CROFFINDOR
 TOWER. THE COMMON ROOM WAS VERY CROWDED, AS MOST PEOPLE HAD
 FINISHED DINNER BY NOW, BUT THEY MANAGED TO FIND A FREE TABLE AND
 SAT DOWN; RON, WHO HAD BEEN IN A BAD MOOD EVER SINCE THE
 ENCOUNTER WITH SLYTHE-HORN, FOLDED HIS ARMS AND FROWNED AT THE
 CEILING. FERMINE REACHED HLT FOR A COPY OF THE EVENING PROPHET,
 WHICH SOMEONE HAD LEFT ABANDONED ON A CHAIR. ANYTHING NEW?
 SAID HARRY. NOT REALLY. FERMINE HAD OPENED THE NEWSPAPER
 AND WAS SCANNING THE INSIDE PAGES. EH, LOOK, YOUR DAD'S IN HERE,
 RON. HE'S ALL RIGHT? SHE ADDED QUICKLY, FOR RON HAD LOOKED
 ABOUT IN ALARM. IT JUST SAYS HE'S BEEN TO VISIT THE MALFOYS
 HOUSE. THIS SECOND SEARCH OF THE DEATH EATER'S RESIDENCE DOES NOT
 SEEM TO HAVE YIELDED ANY RESULTS. ARTHUR WEASLEY OF THE OFFICE FOR
 THE DETECTION AND INVESTIGATION OF UNWANTED DEFENSIVE SPELLS AND
 PROTECTIVE CHARMES SAID THAT HIS TEAM HAD BEEN ACTING UPON A
 CONFIDENTIAL TIP-OFF. YEAH, MINE? SAID HARRY. I TOLD HIM AT
 KING'S CROSS ABOUT MALFOY AND THAT THING HE WAS TRYING TO GET
 REINGIN THE FIX? WELL, IF IT'S NOT AT THEIR HOUSE, HE MUST HAVE
 BROUGHT WHATEVER IT IS TO HOGWARTS WITH HIM. BUT HOW CAN
 HE HAVE DONE, HARRY? SAID FERMINE, PLUTTING DOWN THE

NEWSPAPER WITH A SURPRISED LOOK. WE WERE ALL SEARCHED WHEN WE ARRIVED, WEREN'T WE? WERE YOU? SAID HARRY, TAKEN ABACK. I WASN'T. THEN WHY DID CHLOE SAY WE WEREN'T, I THOUGHT YOU WERE LATE.

WELL, FILCH RAN EVERYWHERE WITH SECRET SENSORS WHEN WE GOT INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL, AND DARK HURST WOULDN'T HAVE BEEN ASLEEP. I KNOW FOR A FACT CRABBE HAD A STYLISHED HEAD COMPICATED. SHE YOU SEE, MALPHY CAN'T HAVE KNOWN IN ANYTHING DANGEROUS. MENTALLY STORMED, HARRY WATCHED GINNY WEASLEY PLAYING WITH ARNOLD THE PYROMANIAC FOR A WHILE BEFORE SEEING A WAY AROUND THIS SITUATION. SOMEONE SENT IT TO HIM BY MAIL, THEN, HE SAID,

HIS MOTHER HAD SOMEONE. ALL THE HILLS ARE BEING CHECKED THEN, SAID HERMION. FILCH TOLD US SHE WHEN HE WAS TAKING THESE SECRET SENSORS EVERYWHERE HE COULD REACH. REALLY STUMPED THIS TIME, HARRY FEELING NOTHING ELSE TO SAY. THERE DIDN'T SEEM TO BE ANY WAY MALPHY COULD HAVE KNOWN A DANGEROUS HURST HURST INTO THE SCHOOL. HE LOOKED HOPEFULLY AT RON, WHO WAS SITTING WITH HIS ARMS FOLDED, STARING OVER AT LAVENDER BROWN. CAN YOU THINK OF ANY WAY MALPHY? HE, DRUM IT, HARRY, SAID RON, LISTEN, IT'S NOT MY FAULT SILENTLY INVITED HERMION AND ME TO HIS STUPID PARTY, NEITHER OF US WANTED TO GO, YOU KNOW? SAID HARRY, FIRING UP. WELL, AS I'M NOT INVITED TO ANY PARTIES, SAID RON, GETTING ON HIS FEET AGAIN. I THINK I'LL GO TO BED. HE STOMPED OFF TOWARD THE DOOR TO THE BOYS' DORMITORIES, LEAVING HARRY AND HERMION STARING AFTER HIM. HARRY? SAID THE NEW CHASER, DEMELZA POKINS, APPEARING SUDDENLY AT HIS SHOULDERS. I'VE GOT A MESSAGE FOR YOU.

FROM PROFESSOR SLUGGISH? ASKED HARRY, SITTING UP HOPEFULLY. NO FROM PROFESSOR SNAPE, SAID DEMELZA. HARRY'S HEART SANK. HE SAYS YOU'RE THE CHIEF OF HIS OFFICE AT HALF PAST EIGHT TONIGHT TO SEE YOUR DETENTION OR NOT. MATTER HOW MANY PARTY INVITATIONS YOU'VE RECEIVED, AND HE WANTED YOU TO KNOW YOU'LL BE STARTING WITH SEVEN FLEETWORKS FROM GOOD HOURS, THE LIST IN PITCHES AND AND HE SAYS THERE'S NO NEED TO BRING PROTECTIVE GLOVES. RIGHT, SAID HARRY GRIMLY. THANKS A LOT, DEMELZA. SILVER AND HOPALS WHERE WAS DUMBLEDORE, AND WHAT WAS HE DOING? HARRY CALLED SIGHT OF THE HEADMASTER ONLY TWICE OVER THE NEXT FEW WEEKS. HE RARELY APPEARED AT MEALS ANYMORE, AND HARRY WAS SURE HERMION WAS RIGHT IN THINKING THAT HE WAS LEAVING THE SCHOOL FOR DAYS AT A TIME. HAD DUMBLEDORE FORGOTTEN THE LESSONS HE

WAS SLIPPED THE RE GIVING F-JARRY? DUMPLEDOORE HAD SAID THAT THE LESSONS WERE LEADING THE SOMETHING THE DEE WITH THE PROPHETCY; F-JARRY HAD FELT KILSTERED, CHEMTERED, AND NEEN HE FELT SLIGHTLY ABANDONED. F-JALWAY THREELIGH EETHEER CAME THEIR FIRST TRIP OF THE TERM THE F-HEGSMRAGE. F-JARRY HAD WONDERED WHETHER THESE TRIPS WOULD STILL BE ALLOWED, GIVEN THE INCREASINGLY TIGHT SECURITY MEASURES AROUND THE SCHOOL, BUT WAS PLEASED TO KNOW THAT THEY WERE GOING AHEAD; IT WAS ALWAYS GOOD TO GET OUT OF THE CASTLE GROUNDS FOR A FEW HOURS. F-JARRY WROTE EARLY IN THE MORNING OF THE TRIP, WHICH WAS PROVEING STORMY, AND WROTE AWAY THE TIME UNTIL BREAKFAST BY READING HIS COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING. HE DID NOT USUALLY LIKE READING HIS TEXTBOOKS; THAT SORT OF RE-JAYING, AS REEN RIGHTLY SAID, WAS INDICENT IN ANYBODY EXCEPT F-JERMINE, WHO WAS SIMPLY WEIRD THAT WAY. F-JARRY FELT, HOWEVER, THAT THE F-JALF-BLIND PRINCE'S COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING HARDLY QUALIFIED AS A TEXTBOOK. THE MORE F-JARRY PORED OVER THE BOOK, THE MORE HE REALIZED HOW MUCH WAS IN THERE, NOT ONLY THE HANDY HINTS AND SHORTCUTS AND POTIONES THAT WERE EARNING HIM SUCH A GLORIOUS REPUTATION WITH SLUGGISH, BUT ALSO THE IMAGINATIVE LITTLE INDEXES AND NOTES SCRIBBLED IN THE MARGINS, WHICH F-JARRY WAS SURE, JUDGE BY THE CROSSINGS-OUT AND REVISIONS, THAT THE PRINCE HAD INVENTED HIMSELF. F-JARRY HAD ALREADY ATTEMPTED A FEW OF THE PRINCE'S SELF-INVENTED SPELLS. THERE HAD BEEN A HEX THAT CALLED THORNAILS TO GROW ALARMINGLY FAST (HE HAD TRIED THIS AND CRACKED IN THE CORRIDOR, WITH VERY ENTERTAINING RESULTS); A INDEX THAT CALLED THE THUNDER TO THE REEF OF THE MOUTH (WHICH HE HAD TWICE USED, THE GENERAL APPLAUSE, AND AN UNSUSPECTING AUNT'S FILLS); AND, PERHAPS MOST USEFUL OF ALL, MUFFLIATH, A SPELL THAT FILLED THE EARS OF ANYONE NEARBY WITH AN UNIDENTIFIABLE BUZZING, SO THAT LENGTHY CONVERSATIONS COULD BE HELD IN CLASS WITHOUT BEING HEARD. THE ONLY PERSON WHO DID NOT FIND THESE CHARMS AMUSING WAS F-JERMINE, WHO MAINTAINED A RIGIDLY DISAPPROVING EXPRESSION THROUGHOUT AND REFUSED TO TALK AT ALL IF F-JARRY HAD USED THE MUFFLIATH SPELL AND ANYONE IN THE VICINITY. SITTING UP IN BED, F-JARRY TURNED THE BOOK SIDEWAYS SO AS TO EXAMINE MORE CLOSELY THE SCRIBBLED INSTRUCTIONS FOR A SPELL THAT SEEMED TO HAVE CALLED THE PRINCE SOME TRICKLE. THERE WERE MANY CROSSINGS-OUT AND ALTERATIONS, BUT FINALLY, CRAMPED INTO A CORNER OF THE PAGE, THE

STRIKES! LEVITCHOLDS INK! WHILE THE WIND AND SLEET PHUNDED
RELENTLESSLY ON THE WINDHELS, AND NEVILLE SNORED BLINDLY, HARRY
STARED AT THE LETTERS IN BRACKETS, INK THAT HAD THE MEAN
NEEDYFEEL. HARRY RATHER BELIEVED HE WOULD BE ABLE TO BRING OFF
THIS PARTICULAR SPELL; HE WAS STILL HAVING DIFFICULTY WITH
NEEDYFEEL SPELLS, SOMETHING SNAPE HAD BEEN BELIEVED THE COMMENT ON
IN EVERY DADA CLASS. ON THE OTHER HAND, THE PRINCE HAD PROVED
A MUCH MORE EFFECTIVE TEACHER THAN SNAPE SE FAR, POINTING HIS
WAND AT NOTHING IN PARTICULAR, HE GAVE IT AN UPWARD FLICK AND
SAID LEVITCHOLDS! INSIDE HIS HEAD, AAAAAAARGH! THERE WAS A
FLASH OF LIGHT AND THE ROOM WAS FULL OF WHIRS! EVERYONE HAD
WOKEN UP AS RON HAD LET OUT A YELL, HARRY SENT ADVANCED POINTING-
MAGIC FLYING IN PANIC; RON WAS DANGLING UPSIDE DOWN IN MIDAIR
AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE HAND HAD TWISTED HIM UP BY THE ANKLE.

SHRILL! YELLED HARRY, AS DEAN AND SEamus REARED WITH LAUGHTER,
AND NEVILLE PICKED HIMSELF UP FROM THE FLOOR, HAVING FALLEN OUT OF
BED. HANG ON I'LL LET YOU DOWN HE CRIED FOR THE POINTING
MAGIC AND RIPPED THROUGH IT IN A PANIC, TRYING TO FIND THE RIGHT
PAGE; AT LAST HE LOCATED IT AND DECRYPTED ONE CRAMPED WORD
UNDERNEATH THE SPELL: PRAYING THAT THIS WAS THE CORRECT-ONE,
HARRY THROUGHT LICKERISHOLDS! WITH ALL HIS MIGHT. THERE WAS
ANOTHER FLASH OF LIGHT, AND RON FELL IN A HEAP ONTO HIS MATTRESS.

SHRILL, REPEATED HARRY WEARILY, WHILE DEAN AND SEamus CONTINUED
THE REAR WITH LAUGHTER. THUNDERING, SAID RON IN A MUFFLED VOICE,

I'D RATHER YOU SET THE ALARM CLOCK. BY THE TIME THEY HAD GET
DRESSED, PADDING THEMSELVES OUT WITH SEVERAL OF MRS. WEASLEY'S
HAND-KNITTED SWEATERS AND CARRYING COATS, SCARVES, AND GLOVES,
RON'S SHOCK HAD SLIDED AND HE HAD DECIDED THAT HARRY'S NEW SPELL
WAS HIGHLY AMUSING; SHE AMUSING, IN FACT, THAT HE HAD TIME IN
RECALLING HERMIONE WITH THE STORY AS THEY SAT DOWN FOR BREAKFAST.

AND THEN THERE WAS ANOTHER FLASH OF LIGHT AND I LANDED ON THE
BED AGAIN! RON GRINNED, HELPING HIMSELF TO SALISAGES. HERMIONE
HAD NOT CRACKED A SMILE DURING THIS ANECDOTE, AND NOW TURNED AN
EXPRESSION OF WINTRY DISAPPROVAL UPON HARRY. WAS THIS SPELL,
BY ANY CHANCE, ANOTHER ONE FROM THAT POINTING MAGIC OF YOURS? SHE
ASKED, HARRY FREELINED AT HER. ALWAYS I'M THE THE WERST
CHUCKLEHEAD, DON'T YOU? WAS IT? WELL, YES, IT WAS, BUT SHE
WHAT? SHE YOU JUST DECIDED TO TRY OUT AN UNDERHAND, HANDWRITTEN

INCANTATION AND SEE WHAT WOULD HAPPEN? WHY DOES IT MATTER IF IT'S HANDWRITTEN? SAID HARRY, PREFERRING NOT THE ANSWER THE REST OF THE ELDESTEN. BECAUSE IT'S PROBABLY NOT MINISTRY OF MAGIC APPROVED, SAID HERMION. AND ALSO, SHE ADDED, AS HARRY AND RON WELLED THEIR EYES, BECAUSE I'M STARTING TO THINK THIS PRINCE CHARACTER WAS A KIT DEDDY. BOTH HARRY AND RON SHOUTED HER DOWN AT ONCE. IT WAS A LAUGH! SAID RON, WIPING A DITCHED SMILE FROM HIS SALISAGES. JUST A LAUGH, HERMION, THAT'S ALL! DANGLING PEOPLE UPSIDE DOWN BY THE ANKLE? SAID HERMION. WITH PLITS THEIR TIME AND ENERGY INTO MAKING UP SPELLS LIKE THAT? FRED AND GEORGE, SAID RON, SHRUGGING, IT'S THEIR KIND OF THING. AND, ER

MY DAD, SAID HARRY, HE HAD ONLY JUST REMEMBERED. WHAT? SAID RON AND HERMION TOGETHER. MY DAD USED THIS SPELL, SAID HARRY.

I LUPIN TOLD ME. THIS LAST PART WAS NOT TRUE; IN FACT, HARRY HAD SEEN HIS FATHER USE THE SPELL ON SNAPE, BUT HE HAD NEVER TOLD RON AND HERMION ABOUT THAT PARTICULAR EXCLUSION INTO THE PENSIVE. NOW, HOWEVER, A WONDERFUL POSSIBILITY OCCURRED TO HIM. COULD THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE POSSIBLY BE ? MAYBE YOUNG DAD DID USE IT, HARRY, SAID HERMION, BUT HE'S NOT THE ONLY ONE. WE'VE SEEN A WHOLE BUNCH OF PEOPLE USE IT, IN CASE YOU'VE FORGOTTEN, DANGLING PEOPLE IN THE AIR, MAKING THEM FLOAT AWAY, ASLEEP, HELPLESS. HARRY STARED AT HER, WITH A SINKING FEELING, HE THEN REMEMBERED THE BEHAVIOUR OF THE DEATH EATERS AT THE BLODDY WORLD CUP, RON CAME TO HIS AID. THAT WAS DIFFERENT, HE SAID RECKLESSLY. THEY WERE ABUSING IT. HARRY AND HIS DAD WERE JUST HAVING A LAUGH. YOU DON'T LIKE THE PRINCE, HERMION. HE ADDED, POINTING A SALISAGE AT HER STERNLY. BECAUSE HE'S BETTER THAN YOU AT POTTIONS. IT'S GET NOTHING TO DO WITH THAT! SAID

HERMION, HER CHEEKS REDDENING. I JUST THINK IT'S VERY IRRESPONSIBLE TO START PERFORMING SPELLS WHEN YOU DON'T EVEN KNOW WHAT THEY'RE FOR, AND STOP TALKING ABOUT THE PRINCE AS IF IT'S HIS TITLE. I BET IT'S JUST A STUPID NICKNAME, AND IT DOESN'T SEEM AS THOUGH HE WAS A VERY NICE PERSON TO ME. I DON'T SEE WHERE YOU GET THAT FROM, SAID HARRY HEATEDLY. IF HE'D BEEN A BLODDY DEATH EATER HE WOULDN'T HAVE BEEN REASTING ABOUT BEING

HALF-BLOOD, WOULD HE? EVEN AS HE SAID IT, HARRY REMEMBERED THAT HIS FATHER HAD BEEN PURSUED, BUT HE PULSED THE THOUGHT OUT OF HIS MIND; HE WOULD NEVER ABOUT THAT LATER. THE DEATH EATERS

CAN'T ALL BE POLICE-KNIGHTS, THERE AREN'T ENOUGH POLICE-KNIGHTS WIZARDS LEFT, SAID FERMINE STARKLY, I EXPECT MOST OF THEM ARE HALF-KNIGHTS PRETENDING THEY'RE POLICE. IT'S ONLY MUGGLE-KNIGHTS THEY HATE, THEY'D BE WHITE HAPPY THEY LET YOU AND RHN JOIN UP. THERE IS NO WAY THEY'D LET ME BE A DEATH EATER! SAID RHN INDIGNANTLY, A KIT OF SALSAGE FLYING OFF THEIR MEAT HE WAS NOW BRANDISHING AT FERMINE AND HITTING ERNIE MACMILLAN ON THE HEAD. MY WHOLE FAMILY ARE KNIGHT TRAITORS! THAT'S AS BAD AS MUGGLE-KNIGHTS THE DEATH EATERS!

AND THEY'D LOVE TO HAVE ME, SAID HARRY SARCASTICALLY, WE'D BE BEST PAID IF THEY DIDN'T KEEP TRYING TO GET ME IN. THIS MADE RHN LAUGH; EVEN FERMINE GAVE A GRUBBING SMILE, AND A DISTRACTION ARRIVED IN THE SHAPE OF CINNY. HEY, HARRY, I'M SUPPOSED TO GIVE YOU THIS. IT WAS A SHEET OF PARCHMENT WITH HARRY'S NAME WRITTEN UPON IT IN FAMILIAR THIN, SLANTING WRITING. THANKS, CINNY. IT'S DUMBLEDORE'S NEXT LESSON! HARRY TOLD RHN AND FERMINE, PULLING OPEN THE PARCHMENT AND QUICKLY READING ITS CONTENTS. MONDAY EVENING! HE FELT SUDDENLY LIGHT AND HAPPY.

WANT TO JOIN US IN HOGSMEAD, CINNY? HE ASKED. I'M GOING WITH DEAN MIGHT SEE YOU THERE, SHE REPLIED, GLANCING AT THEM AS SHE LEFT. FILCH WAS STANDING AT THE BACK FRONT DOORS AS USUAL, CHECKING OFF THE NAMES OF PEOPLE WHO HAD PERMISSION TO GO INTO HOGSMEAD. THE PROCESS THERE EVEN LONGER THAN NORMAL AS FILCH WAS TRIPLE-CHECKING EVERYBODY WITH HIS SECRET SENSE. WHAT DOES IT MATTER IF WE'RE SMUGGLING DARK STUFF INTO? DEMANDED RHN, TRYING THE LONG THIN SECRET SENSE WITH APPREHENSION. SURELY YOU'LL NOTICE WE'RE CHECKING WHAT WE'RE BRINGING BACK INTO! HIS CHECK EARNED HIM A FEW EXTRA LARS WITH THE SENSE, AND HE WAS STILL WINCING AS THEY STEPPED OUT INTO THE WIND AND SLEET. THE WALK INTO HOGSMEAD WAS NOT ENJOYABLE. HARRY WRAPPED HIS SCARF OVER HIS LOWER FACE; THE EXPOSED PART SEEMED TO BITE RAW AND NUMB. THE REAR OF THE VILLAGE WAS FULL OF STUDENTS SENT DRIFTING AGAINST THE BITTER WIND. MORE THAN ONCE HARRY WONDERED WHETHER THEY MIGHT NOT HAVE HAD A BETTER TIME IN THE WARM COMMON ROOM, AND WHEN THEY FINALLY REACHED HOGSMEAD AND SAW THAT ZENKES'S INDEX SHEEP HAD BEEN REARDED UP, HARRY TOOK IT AS CONFIRMATION THAT THIS TRIP WAS NOT DESTINED TO BE FLIN. RHN PINCHED, WITH A THICKLY GLEEVED HAND, TOWARD FINEYDOR, WHICH WAS MERCIFULLY OPEN, AND HARRY AND FERMINE STAGGERED IN HIS WAKE INTO THE CROWDED SHEP.

THANK GOD, SHIVERED REEN AS THEY WERE ENVELOPED BY WARM, REPRESENTED AIR. LET S STAY HERE ALL AFTERNOON. FARRY, M KID? SAID A RUMMING WHIRL FROM BEHIND THEM. EH-NH, MUTTERED FARRY. THE THREE OF THEM TURNED THE SEE PROFESSOR SLUGGISH, WHO WAS WEARING AN ENORMOUS FLIRY HAT AND AN EVERWEAT WITH MATCHING FLIR CELLAR, CLUTCHING A LARGE BAG OF CRYSTALIZED PINEAPPLE, AND HURRYING AT LEAST A HUNTER OF THE SEEP. FARRY, THAT S THREE OF MY LITTLE SLIPPERS YOU VE MISSED WHEN? SAID SLUGGISH, PEEKING HIM GENIALLY IN THE CHEST. IT WHEN T BE, M KID, I M DETERMINED THE HAVE YOU? MISS GRANGER LEAVES THEM, WHEN T YOU? YES, SAID FERMINE HELPLESSLY. THEY ARE REALLY. SHE WHY WHEN T YOU COME ALONG, FARRY? DEMANDED SLUGGISH. WELL, I VE HAD ELIDITCH PRACTICE, PROFESSOR, SAID FARRY, WHO HAD INDEED BEEN SCHEDULED PRACTICES EVERY TIME SLUGGISH HAD SENT HIM A LITTLE, VIOLET RICKEN-ADORNED INVITATION. THIS STRATEGY MEANT THAT REEN WAS NOT LEFT OUT, AND THEY USUALLY HAD A LAUGH WITH GINNY, IMAGINING FERMINE SHUT UP WITH MLAGGEN AND ZARINI. WELL, I CERTAINLY EXPECT YOU THE WIN YOUR FIRST MATCH AFTER ALL THIS HARD WORK? SAID SLUGGISH.

BUT A LITTLE RECREATION NEVER HURT ANYBODY, WHEN, WHEN ABOUT MONDAY NIGHT, YOU CAN T POSSIBLY WANT THE PRACTICE IN THIS WEATHER. I CAN T, PROFESSOR, I VE GOT ER AN APPOINTMENT WITH PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE THAT EVENING. UNLIKELY AGAIN? CRIED SLUGGISH DRAMATICALLY. AH, WELL. YOU CAN T EVADE ME ANYMORE, FARRY? AND WITH A REGAL WAFF, HE WADDLED OUT OF THE SEEP, TAKING AS LITTLE NOTICE OF REEN AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN A DISPLAY OF CHICKENHEAD CLUSTERS. I CAN T BELIEVE YOU VE WIGGLED OUT OF ANOTHER ONE, SAID FERMINE, SHAKING HER HEAD. THEY ARE NOT THAT BAD, YOU KNOW. THEY ARE EVEN WHITE FOR SOMETIMES. BUT THEN SHE CAUGHT SIGHT OF REEN S EXPRESSION. EH, WELL. THEY VE GOT DELICIOUS SUGAR HILLS. THESE WOULD LAST FORHOURS? GLAD THAT FERMINE HAD CHANGED THE SUBJECT, FARRY SMILED MUCH MORE INTEREST IN THE NEW EXTRA-LARGE SUGAR HILLS THAN HE WOULD NORMALLY HAVE DONE, BUT REEN CONTINUED THE LONG MIND AND MERELY STUTTERED WHEN FERMINE ASKED HIM WHERE HE WANTED THE GO NEXT.

LET S GO TO THE THREE KNEESTICKS, SAID FARRY. IT LL BE WARM. THEY RUMBLERED THEIR SLAVES BACK OVER THEIR FACES AND LEFT THE SWEETSEEP. THE BITTER WIND WAS LIKE KNIVES IN THEIR FACES AFTER THE SUGARY WARMTH OF FERNETBLORES. THE STREET WAS NOT VERY BUSY;

NOBODY WAS LINGERING THE CHAT, JUST HURRYING TOWARD THEIR DESTINATIONS. THE EXCEPTIONS WERE THE MEN A LITTLE AHEAD OF THEM, STANDING JUST BESIDE THE THREE BROOMSTICKS. ONE WAS VERY TALL AND THIN, SHEDDING THROUGH HIS RAIN-WASHED GLASSES HARRY RECOGNIZED THE BARMAN WHO WHISKED IN THE OTHER BUSHY-HEADED PLK, THE BEE'S HEAD. AS HARRY, BEN, AND HERMIONE DREW CLOSER, THE BARMAN DREW HIS CLOAK MORE TIGHTLY AROUND HIS NECK AND WALKED AWAY, LEAVING THE SHORTER MAN THE PLK WITH SOMETHING IN HIS ARMS. THEY WERE BARELY FEET FROM HIM WHEN HARRY REALIZED WHO THE MAN WAS. MUNDLINGIS! THE SHORT, BONY-LEGGED MAN WITH LONG, STRAGGLY, GINGER HAIR LIMPED AND DROPPED AN ANCIENT SPLITCASE, WHICH FIRST OPEN, RELEASING WHAT LOOKED LIKE THE ENTIRE CONTENTS OF A LIND SHIP WINDING. EH, WELL, HARRY, SAID MUNDLINGIS FLETCHER, WITH A MEET LINCINGING STAB AT AIRINESS. WELL, BEN T LET ME KEEP YA. AND HE BEGAN SCRAMBLING IN THE GRINDING THE RETRIEVE THE CONTENTS OF HIS SPLITCASE WITH EVERY APPEARANCE OF A MAN EAGER TO BE DONE. ARE YOU SELLING THIS STUFF? ASKED HARRY, WATCHING MUNDLINGIS GRAB AN ASSORTMENT OF GILDED-LOOKING OBJECTS FROM THE GRINDING. EH, WELL, GOTTA SCRAPE A LIVING, SAID MUNDLINGIS. GIMME THAT! BEN HAD STEPPED DOWN AND PICKED UP SOMETHING SILVER. HANG ON, BEN SAID SILENTLY. THIS LOOKS FAMILIAR. THANK YOU! SAID MUNDLINGIS, SNATCHING THE GILDED OBJECT FROM BEN'S HAND AND STUFFING IT BACK INTO THE CASE. WELL, I'LL SEE YOU ALL. EH, HARRY HAD PINNED MUNDLINGIS AGAINST THE WALL OF THE PLK BY THE THROAT. HOLDING HIM FAST WITH ONE HAND, HE PULLED OUT HIS WAND. HARRY? SHOUTED HERMIONE. YOU THINK THAT FROM SIRILIS'S FEELING, SAID HARRY, WHO WAS ALMOST NEAR THE NEAR WITH MUNDLINGIS AND WAS BREATHING IN AN UNPLEASANT SMELL OF OLD TREASURE AND SPIRITS. THAT HAD THE BLACK FAMILY CREST ON IT. I SEE WHAT? SPLUTTERED MUNDLINGIS, WHO WAS SILENTLY TURNING PURPLE. WHAT DID YOU DO, GO BACK THE NIGHT HE DIED AND STRIP THE PLACE? SNARLED HARRY. I SEE. GIVE IT TO ME! HARRY, YOU LISTEN! SHRIEKED HERMIONE, AS MUNDLINGIS STARTED TO TURN BLUE. THERE WAS A RANG, AND HARRY FELT HIS HANDS FLY OFF MUNDLINGIS'S THROAT. GASPING AND SPLUTTERING, MUNDLINGIS SEIZED HIS FALLEN CASE, THEN CRASH HE DISAPPEARED. HARRY STOOD AT THE TOP OF HIS VEHICLE, SPINNING IN THE SPOT TO SEE WHERE MUNDLINGIS HAD GONE. THERE WAS, YOU KNOWING :

THERE'S NO POINT, HARRY. THINGS HAD APPEARED BLITZ BY NOWHERE, HER MESSY HAIR WET WITH SWEAT. MINDLINGIS WILL PROBABLY BE IN BLINDEN BY NOW. THERE'S NO POINT YELLING. HE'S NICKED SIRILIS'S STUFF? NICKED IT? YES, BUT STILL, SAID THINGS, WE'VE SEEMED PERFECTLY UNTRICKLED BY THIS PIECE OF INFORMATION. WHY SHOULD GET BLITZ BY THE CHILD. SHE WATCHED THEM GO THROUGH THE DOOR OF THE THREE BRIMSTICKS. THE MOMENT HE WAS INSIDE, HARRY KNEW BLITZ, HE WAS NICKING SIRILIS'S STUFF? I KNOW, HARRY, BUT PLEASE DON'T SCREAM, PEOPLE ARE STARING, WHISPERED FERMINE. GO AND SIT DOWN, I'LL GET YOU A DRINK. HARRY WAS STILL FLINCHING WHEN FERMINE RETURNED TO THEIR TABLE A FEW MINUTES LATER HOLDING THREE BOTTLES OF CLITTERER. CAN'T THE OTHER CENTRAL MINDLINGIS? HARRY DEMANDED OF THE OTHER TWO IN A FLURRIED WHISPER. CAN'T THEY AT LEAST STOP HIM STEALING EVERYTHING THAT'S NOT FIXED DOWN WHEN HE'S AT HEADQUARTERS? SHE? SAID FERMINE DESPERATELY, LEANING AROUND THE BACK SORE NOBODY WAS LISTENING; THERE WERE A COUPLE OF GUARDS SITTING CLOSE BY WHO WERE STARING AT HARRY WITH GREAT INTEREST, AND ZARINI WAS LEANING AGAINST A PILLAR NOT FAR AWAY.

HARRY, I'D BE ANNOYED TOO, I KNOW IT'S YOUR THINGS HE'S STEALING. HARRY GAGGED ON HIS CLITTERER; HE HAD MOMENTARILY FORGOTTEN THAT HE HUNG NUMBER TWELVE, CRIMINALS PLACE. Yeah, IT'S MY STUFF? HE SAID. NO WONDER HE WASN'T PLEASED TO SEE ME? WELL, I'M GOING TO TELL DUMBLEDORE WHAT'S GOING ON, HE'S THE ONLY ONE WHO KNOWS MINDLINGIS. GOOD IDEA, WHISPERED FERMINE, CLEARLY PLEASED THAT HARRY WAS CALMING DOWN. THEN, WHAT ARE YOU STARING AT? NOTHING, SAID REIN, HASTILY LEAVING AWAY FROM THE BAR, BUT HARRY KNEW HE WAS TRYING TO CATCH THE EYE OF THE CLIMBY AND ATTRACTIVE BARMAID, MADAM REEMERTA, FOR WHOM HE HAD LONG NERSED A SOFT SPOT. I EXPECT NOTHING'S IN THE BACK GETTING MORE FIREWORKS, SAID FERMINE WASPISLY. REIN IGNORED THIS LIKE, SIPPING HIS DRINK IN WHAT HE EVIDENTLY CONSIDERED TO BE A DIGNIFIED SILENCE. HARRY WAS THINKING ABOUT SIRILIS, AND HOW HE HAD HATED THOSE SILVER CHAINS ANYWAY. FERMINE DRUMMED HER FINGERS ON THE TABLE, HER EYES FLICKERING BETWEEN REIN AND THE BAR. THE MOMENT HARRY DRAINED THE LAST DROPS IN HIS BOTTLE SHE SAID, SHALL WE CALL IT A DAY AND GO BACK TO SCHOOL, THEN? THE OTHER TWO NEEDED; IT HAD NOT BEEN A FLIN TRIP AND THE WEATHER WAS GETTING WORSER THE LONGER THEY STAYED, SOON AGAIN THEY DREW THEIR CHAIRS TIGHTLY

ARRIVING THEM, REARRANGED THEIR SLAVES, PULLED UP THEIR GLOVES, THEN FOLLOWED KATIE BELL AND A FRIEND OUT OF THE POLICE AND RACE UP THE HIGH STREET, HARRY'S TEHLIGHTS STRAYED THE GROUND AS THEY TRUDGED UP THE ROAD THE HIGHTWAYS THROUGH THE FROZEN SLUSH. THEY HAD NOT MET UP WITH HER, UNEXPECTEDLY, TEHLIGHT HARRY, BECAUSE SHE AND DEAN WERE CHEZILY CHESTED IN MADAM PLUMMER'S TEA SHOP, THAT HADN'T OF HAPPY CHILDREN, SLOWLY, HE BOWED HIS HEAD AGAINST THE SWIRLING SLEET AND TRUDGED ON. IT WAS A LITTLE WHILE BEFORE HARRY BECAME AWARE THAT THE VEHICLES OF KATIE BELL AND HER FRIEND, WHICH WERE BEING CARRIED BACK THE HIM BY THE WIND, HAD BECOME SHRIILLER AND LULLDER, HARRY SHUTINATED AT THEIR INDISTINCT FIGURES. THE TWO GIRLS WERE HAVING AN ARGUMENT ABOUT SOMETHING KATIE WAS HOLDING IN HER HAND. IT'S SOMETHING THE SHE WITH YOU, LEANNE? HARRY HEARD KATIE SAY. THEY REWINDED A CORNER IN THE LANE, SLEET CHEMING THICK AND FAST, BLURRING HARRY'S GLASSES. JUST AS HE RAISED A GLOVED HAND TO WIPER THEM, LEANNE MADE THE GRAB HOLD OF THE PACKAGE KATIE WAS HOLDING; KATIE TUGGED IT BACK AND THE PACKAGE FELL THE THE GROUND. AT ONCE, KATIE RESE INTO THE AIR, NOT AS WHEN HAD BEEN, SUSPENDED CHEMICALLY BY THE ANGLE, BUT GRACEFULLY, HER ARMS OUTSTRETCHED, AS TEHLICH SHE WAS ABOUT THE FLY. YET THERE WAS SOMETHING WRONG, SOMETHING ERRIC. HER HAIR WAS WHIPPED AROUND HER BY THE FIERCE WIND, BUT HER EYES WERE CLOSED AND HER FACE WAS WHITE EMPTY OF EXPRESSION. HARRY, DEAN, HERMINE, AND LEANNE HAD ALL HALTED IN THEIR TRACKS, WATCHING. THEN, SIX FEET ABOVE THE GROUND, KATIE LET OUT A TERRIBLE SCREAM. HER EYES FLEW OPEN BUT WHATEVER SHE COULD SEE, OR WHATEVER SHE WAS FEELING, WAS CLEARLY CAUSING HER TERRIBLE ANGUISH. SHE SCREAMED AND SCREAMED; LEANNE STARTED THE SCREAM THEN AND SEIZED KATIE'S ANKLES, TRYING TO TUG HER BACK THE THE GROUND. HARRY, DEAN, AND HERMINE RUSHED FORWARD THE HELP, BUT EVEN AS THEY GRABBED KATIE'S LEGS, SHE FELL INTO THEM OF THEM; HARRY AND DEAN MANAGED TO CATCH HER BUT SHE WAS WRITHING SO MUCH THEY COULD HARDLY HOLD HER. INSTEAD THEY WHEWER HER THE THE GROUND WHERE SHE THRASHED AND SCREAMED, APPARENTLY UNABLE TO RECOGNIZE ANY OF THEM. HARRY WHEWER AROUND; THE LANDSCAPE SEEMED DESERTED. STAY THERE! HE SHOUTED AT THE OTHERS EVERY THE HOWLING WIND. I'M GOING FOR HELP! HE BEGAN THE SPRINT TOWARD THE SCREAM; HE HAD NEVER SEEN ANYONE BEFORE AS KATIE HAD JUST BEFORE AND COULD NOT THINK WHAT HAD CAUSED IT; HE FLUTTERED

ARIELING A KEND IN THE LANE AND COLLIDED WITH LEIAT SEEMED THE RE AN
ENHARMELIS REAR HEN ITS HIND LEGS. F-JAGRIB? HE PANTED,
DISENTANGLING HIMSELF FROM THE HEDGEROW INTH WHICH HE HAD FALLEN.

F-JARRY? SAID F-JAGRIB, WE-H HAD SLEET TRAPPED IN HIS EYERHOLS AND
BEARD, AND WAS WEARING HIS GREAT, SHAGGY LEATHERSKIN COAT. ILIS KIN
VISITIN GRAMP, HE S CHMIN HEN SHE WELL YEH WHELDEN F-JAGRIB,
SHEPHENE S FLIRT BACK THERE, HER CLORSED, HER SHEPETHING WE-HAT?
SAID F-JAGRIB, BENDING LOWER THE HEAR WE-HAT F-JARRY WAS SAYING EVER
THE RAGING WIND. SHEPHENE S BEEN CLORSED? KELLHELD F-JARRY,

CLORSED? WE-H S KIN CLORSED NEET REEN? F-JERMINE? NEH, IT S NEET
THEM, IT S KATIE BELL THIS WAY TOGETHER THEY RAN BACK
ALONG THE LANE. IT THEED THEM NEH TIME THE FIND THE LITTLE GREENLIP HEP
PEOPLE ARIELING KATIE, WE-H WAS STILL WRITING AND SCREAMING HEN
THE GREENLIP? REEN, F-JERMINE, AND LEANNE WERE ALL TRYING THE BELIET
HER. GET BACK? SHELTED F-JAGRIB. LETME SEE HER? SHEPETHING S
HAPPENED THE HER? SHEKED LEANNE. I DHEN T KNOW WE-HAT F-JAGRIB
STARED AT KATIE FOR A SECHEND, THEN WITHEHLT A WHIRD, KENT DEHLIN,
SHEPHEDE HER INTH HIS ARMS, AND RAN HEP THEWARD THE CASTLE WITH HER.
WITHIN SECHENDS, KATIE S PIERCING SCREAMS HAD DIED AWAY AND THE
ONLY SHLIND WAS THE REAR HEP THE WIND. F-JERMINE FLURIED EVER THE
KATIE S WAILING FRIEND AND PLIT AN ARM ARIELING HER. IT S LEANNE,
ISN T IT? THE GIRL NEEDED. DID IT ILST HAPPEN ALL HEP A SLIDDEN, HER

? IT WAS WE-HEN THAT PACKAGE THERE, SHEKED LEANNE, PEINTING AT
THE NEW SHEDDEN GREENLIP-PAPER PACKAGE HEN THE GREENLIP, WE-HICH HAD
SPLIT HEPEN THE REVEAL A GREENISH GLITTER. REEN KENT DEHLIN, HIS HAND
HLTSTRETCHED, BLT F-JARRY SEIZED HIS ARM AND PULLED HIM BACK. DHEN T
THELICH IT? HE CRELICHED DEHLIN. AN ERNATE HPAL NECKLACE WAS VISIBLE,
PEEKING HLT HEP THE PAPER. I VE SEEN THAT BEFORE, SAID F-JARRY,
STARING AT THE THING. IT WAS HEN DISPLAY IN KIRGIN AND KIRKES
AGES AGH. THE LABEL SAID IT WAS CLORSED, KATIE MUST HAVE THELICHED IT.
HE WHEKED LIP AT LEANNE, WE-H HAD STARTED THE SHADDE
LINCHENTRELLABLY. F-JEH DID KATIE GET HHELD HEP THIS? WELL, THAT S
WE-H WE WERE ARGLING. SHE CAME BACK FROM THE KATHREHM IN THE
THREE KREHMSTICKS HHELDING IT, SAID IT WAS A SURPRISE FOR SHEPHEHED
AT F-JEGLARTS AND SHE HAD THE DELIVER IT. SHE WHEKED ALL FLURDY WHEN
SHE SAID IT. HEH NEH, HEH NEH, I GET SHE D BEEN IMPERILISED AND I DIDN T
REALIZE? LEANNE SHEHED WITH RENEWED SEHS. F-JERMINE PATTED HER
SHEHLDER GENTLY. SHE DIDN T SAY WE-H D GIVEN IT THE HER, LEANNE?

"NEH SHE WOULDN'T TELL ME AND I SAID SHE WAS BEING STUPID AND
 NOT TAKE IT UP THE SCHEM, BUT SHE JUST WOULDN'T LISTEN AND
 AND THEN I TRIED TO GRAB IT FROM HER AND LEANNE LET
 HER A WAIL OF DESPAIR. WE'D BETTER GET UP THE SCHEM, SAID
 FERMINE, HER ARM STILL AROUND LEANNE. WE'LL BE ABLE TO FIND HER
 WHEN SHE IS, THEN. HARRY HESITATED FOR A MOMENT, THEN
 PULLED HIS SCARF FROM AROUND HIS FACE AND, IGNORING REEN'S GASP,
 CAREFULLY COVERED THE NECKLACE IN IT AND PICKED IT UP. WE'LL NEED THE
 SCHEM THIS THE MADAM PHEMPEY, HE SAID, AS THEY FOLLOWED FERMINE
 AND LEANNE UP THE HILL, HARRY WAS THINKING FLURRIEDLY. THEY HAD
 JUST ENTERED THE GREENS WHEN HE STOPPED, UNABLE TO KEEP HIS
 THOUGHTS TO HIMSELF ANY LONGER. MALCOLM KNEW ABOUT THIS
 NECKLACE. IT WAS IN A CASE AT BIRGIN AND BIRDS FOUR YEARS AGO, I
 SAW HIM HAVING A GOOD LOOK AT IT WHILE I WAS HIDING FROM HIM AND
 HIS DAD. THIS IS WHAT HE WAS SAYING THAT DAY WHEN WE FOLLOWED HIM?
 HE REMEMBERED IT AND HE WENT BACK FOR IT? I I BLINNY, HARRY,
 SAID REEN HESITANTLY. LEADS OF PEOPLE GET THE BIRGIN AND BIRDS
 AND DIDN'T THAT GIRL SAY KATIE GOT IT IN THE GIRLS KATH-HEM? SHE
 SAID SHE CAME BACK FROM THE KATH-HEM WITH IT, SHE DIDN'T
 NECESSARILY GET IT IN THE KATH-HEM ITSELF. MCGINAGALL? SAID
 REEN WARNINGLY, HARRY LOOKED UP, SURE ENOUGH, PROFESSOR
 MCGINAGALL WAS HURRYING DOWN THE STONE STEPS THROUGH
 SWIRLING SLEET TO MEET THEM. HAGRID SAYS YELL WHEN YOU SAW WHAT
 HAPPENED THE KATIE BELL UPSTAIRS THE MY OFFICE AT HENCE, PLEASE?
 WHAT'S THAT YELL BE HOLDING, PETER? IT'S THE THING SHE
 HELD, SAID HARRY. GOOD LORD, SAID PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL,
 LOOKING ALARMED AS SHE TOOK THE NECKLACE FROM HARRY. NEH, NEH,
 FILCH, THEY'RE WITH ME? SHE ADDED HASTILY, AS FILCH CAME SHUFFLING
 EAGERLY ACROSS THE ENTRANCE HALL HOLDING HIS SECRET SENSEER AHEAD.
 TAKE THIS NECKLACE THE PROFESSOR SNAP AT HENCE, BUT BE SURE NOT
 TO TELL IT, KEEP IT WRAPPED IN THE SCARF? HARRY AND THE OTHERS
 FOLLOWED PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL UPSTAIRS AND INTO HER OFFICE. THE
 SLEET-SPATTERED WINDS WERE RATTLING IN THEIR FRAMES, AND THE
 ROOM WAS CHILLY DESPITE THE FIRE CRACKLING IN THE GRATE. PROFESSOR
 MCGINAGALL CLOSED THE DOOR AND SWEEP AROUND HER DESK THE FACE
 HARRY, REEN, FERMINE, AND THE STILL SEEKING LEANNE. WELL? SHE
 SAID SHARPLY. WHAT HAPPENED? HALTINGLY, AND WITH MANY PAUSES
 WHILE SHE ATTEMPTED TO CONTROL HER CRYING, LEANNE TOLD PROFESSOR

MCGONAGALL FELT KATIE HAD GIVEN THE THREE BROOMSTICKS AND RETURNED HOLDING THE UNMARKED PACKAGE, FELT KATIE HAD SEEMED A LITTLE HED, AND FELT THEY HAD ARGUED ABOUT THE ADVISABILITY OF AGREEING TO DELIVER UNKNOWN OBJECTS, THE ARGUMENT CLIMINATING IN THE TISSUE OVER THE PARCEL, WHICH THERE WERE, AT THIS POINT, LEANNE WAS SHE EVERHERE, THERE WAS SHE GETTING ANOTHER WORD OUT OF HER. ALL RIGHT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, NOT UNKINDLY, GO UP TO THE HOSPITAL WING, PLEASE, LEANNE, AND GET MADAM POMFREY TO GIVE YOU SOMETHING FOR SICK. WHEN SHE HAD LEFT THE ROOM, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TURNED BACK TO HARRY, RON, AND HERMIONE. WHAT HAPPENED WHEN KATIE THREW THE NECKLACE? SHE ROSE UP IN THE AIR, SAID HARRY, KEPT EITHER RON OR HERMIONE CHILD STUCK, AND THEN BEGAN THE SCREAM, AND COLLAPSED, PROFESSOR, CAN I SEE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, PLEASE?

THE HEADMASTER IS AWAY UNTIL MONDAY, BETTER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, LOOKING SURPRISED, AWAY? HARRY REPEATED ANGRILY.

YES, BETTER, AWAY? SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL TARTLY, BUT ANYTHING YOU HAVE TO SAY ABOUT THIS HORRIBLE BUSINESS CAN BE SAID TO ME, I'M SURE. FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HARRY HESITATED, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DID NOT INVITE CONFIDENCES; DUMBLEDORE, THOUGH IN MANY WAYS MORE INTIMIDATING, STILL SEEMED LESS LIKELY TO SCORN A TALKER, HOWEVER WILD. THIS WAS A LIFE-AND-DEATH MATTER, THOUGH, AND SHE MIGHT BE LAUGHED AT. I THINK DRACO MALFOY GAVE KATIE THAT NECKLACE, PROFESSOR. ON ONE SIDE OF HIM, RON BLINKED HIS EYES IN APPARENT EMBARRASSMENT; ON THE OTHER, HERMIONE STAMPEDED HER FEET AS THOUGH SHE'D BEEN THE PART OF DISTANCE BETWEEN HERSELF AND HARRY. THAT IS A VERY SERIOUS ACCUSATION, BETTER, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AFTER A SHORT PAUSE. DO YOU HAVE ANY PROOF? NO, SAID HARRY, BUT AND HE TOLD HER ABOUT FOLLOWING MALFOY TO KILGORE AND KILGORE AND THE CONVERSATION THEY HAD OVERHEARD BETWEEN HIM AND MR. KILGORE. WHEN HE HAD FINISHED SPEAKING, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL LOOKED SLIGHTLY CONFUSED. MALFOY THREW SOMETHING TO KILGORE AND KILGORE FOR REPAIR? NO, PROFESSOR, HE JUST WANTED KILGORE TO TELL HIM HOW TO MEND SOMETHING, HE DIDN'T HAVE IT WITH HIM, BUT THAT'S NOT THE POINT, THE POINT IS THAT HE KNEW SOMETHING AT THE SAME TIME, AND I THINK IT WAS THAT NECKLACE YOU SAW MALFOY LEAVING THE SHOP WITH A SIMILAR PACKAGE? NO, PROFESSOR, HE TOLD

KEIRGIN THE DEEP IT IN THE SHEEP FOR HIM BUT FARRY, FERMINE
INTERLUPTED, KEIRGIN ASKED HIM IF HE WANTED THE TAKE IT WITH HIM,
AND MALPHY SAID NEH

BECAUSE HE DIDN T WANT THE THICK IT,
HEVILLY? SAID FARRY ANGRILY, WHAT HE ACTUALLY SAID WAS, FHEW
WHLID I LHEEX CARRYING THAT DEHN THE STREET? SAID FERMINE,

WELL, HE WHLID LHEEX A KIT OF A PRAT CARRYING A NECKLACE,
INTERLUPTED REHN, EH, REHN, SAID FERMINE DESPAIRINGLY, IT WHLID
BE ALL WRAPPED UP, SHE HE WHLIDN T HAVE THE THICK IT, AND ELITE EASY
THE HIDE INSIDE A CHEAD, SHE NEKHIDY WHLID SEE IT? I THINK WEATEVER HE
RESERVED AT KEIRGIN AND KIRKES WAS NEHLY HER KIDY, SOMETHING HE
DNEW WHLID DRAW ATTENTION THE HIM IF HE CARRIED IT DEHN THE STREET

AND IN ANY CASE, SHE PRESSED HN LELIDY, BEFORE FARRY WHLID
INTERLUPT, I ASKED KEIRGIN ABHUT THE NECKLACE, DEHN T YHL
REMEMBER? WHEN I WENT IN THE TRY AND FIND ELIT WEAT MALPHY HAD
ASKED HIM THE DEEP, I SAW IT THERE, AND KEIRGIN ILST THLD ME THE
PRICE, HE DIDN T SAY IT WAS ALREADY SEHD HER ANYTHING WELL, YHL
WERE BEING REALLY HEVILLY, HE REALIZED WEAT YHL WERE UP THE WITHIN
ABHUT FIVE SECONDS, OF CHLUSE HE WASN T CHING THE TELL YHL
ANYWAY, MALPHY WHLID YE SENT HFF FOR IT SINCE THAT S

ENHLEH? SAID PROFESSOR MCHENAGALL, AS FERMINE HPENED HER
MHLTH THE RETERT, LHEEXING FLRILLY, BETTER, I APPRECIATE YHL
TELLING ME THIS, BUT WE CANNET PHINT THE FINGER OF BLAME AT MR,
MALPHY PLIRELY BECAUSE HE VISITED THE SHEEP WHERE THIS NECKLACE
MIGHT HAVE BEEN PURCHASED, THE SAME IS PROBABLY TRUE OF HUNDREDS
OF PEOPLE

THAT S WHAT I SAID MUITTERED REHN, AND IN
ANY CASE, WE HAVE PUT STRINGENT SECURITY MEASURES IN PLACE THIS
YEAR, I DO NOT BELIEVE THAT NECKLACE CAN POSSIBLY HAVE ENTERED THIS
SCHEM WITHHUT HLIR DNEHLEDER BUT AND WHAT IS

MORE, SAID PROFESSOR MCHENAGALL, WITH AN AIR OF APLIL FINALITY,

MR, MALPHY WAS NOT IN FEEGSMRDE TODAY, FARRY Gaped AT HER,
DEFLATING, FHEW DE YHL DNEH, PROFESSOR? BECAUSE HE WAS BEING
DETENTION WITH ME, HE HAS NEH FAILED THE COMPLETE HIS

TRANSFIGURATION HEMELHARD TWICE IN A REHN, SHE, THAND YHL FOR
TELLING ME YHLR SUSPICIONS, BETTER, SHE SAID AS SHE MARCHED PAST
THEM, BUT I NEED THE GH UP THE THE HOSPITAL WING NEH THE CH-CK HN
DATIVE BELL, CHHD DAY THE YHL ALL, SHE HLD HPEN HER OFFICE DEHN,
THEY HAD NEH CH-CKE BUT THE FILE PAST HER WITHHUT ANEITHER WHRD,
FARRY WAS ANGRY WITH THE EITHER TWO FOR SIDING WITH

MCGINNAGALL; NEVERTHELESS, HE FELT COMPELLED TO JOIN IN SINCE THEY STARTED DISCUSSING WHAT HAD HAPPENED. SHE WHEN SHE WOULD RECOGNISE KATIE WAS SURPRISED TO GIVE THE NECKLACE THEN ASKED REHN, AS THEY CLIMBED THE STAIRS TO THE CHAMBER ROOM. COMEDONNESS ONLY KNOWS, SAID FERMINE. BUT WHATEVER IT WAS HAS HAD A NARROW ESCAPE. SHE HAD CHILD HAVE OPENED THAT PACKAGE WITHOUT THINKING THE NECKLACE. IT COULD BE BEEN MEANT FOR HEADS OF PEOPLE, SAID HARRY.

OLIVERMORE THE DEATH EATERS WOULD LOVE TO GET RID OF HIM, HE MUST BE ONE OF THEIR TOP TARGETS, HE SUGGESTED. OLIVERMORE RECOGNISED VERMORENT REALLY WANTED HIM AND THEY CAN'T BE PLEASED THAT HE'S SIDED WITH OLIVERMORE. HE HEY SHE, SAID FERMINE, THINKING TRIKLED. CHILDREN HAVE BEEN, SAID HARRY, HE KATIE WOULD BE JUST TURNED AROUND IN THE LANE AND GIVEN IT TO ME, CHILDREN T-SHIRT I WAS BEHIND HER ALL THE WAY BUT OF THE THREE BRIMSTICKS, IT WOULD HAVE MADE MUCH MORE SENSE TO DELIVER THE PARCEL ELTIDE FISHGARTS, WHAT WITH FISH SEARCHING EVERYONE WHEN GIES IN AND OUT, I WONDER WHY MALPHY TOLD HER TO TAKE IT INTO THE CASTLE? HARRY, MALPHY WASN'T IN FISHMEAD? SAID FERMINE, ACTUALLY STAMPING HER FEET IN FRUSTRATION. HE MUST HAVE USED AN ACCOMPLICE, THEN, SAID HARRY, CRABBE AND GOYLE NEW HE'S JOINED UP. REHN AND FERMINE EXCHANGED GLANCES THAT PLAINLY SAID THERE'S NO POINT ARGUING WITH HIM. DILLIGENT, SAID FERMINE FIRMLY AS THEY REACHED THE FAT LADY, THE PORTRAIT SEEMING TO ADMIT THEM TO THE CHAMBER ROOM. IT WAS WHITE FLUFF AND SMELLED OF DAMP CLOTHING; MANY PEOPLE SEEMED TO HAVE RETURNED FROM FISHMEAD EARLY BECAUSE OF THE BAD WEATHER. THERE WAS NO CLUE OF FEAR OR SPECULATION, HOWEVER; CLEARLY, THE NEWS OF KATIE'S FATE HAD NOT YET SPREAD. IT WASN'T A VERY SLICK ATTACK, REALLY, WHEN SHE STOPPED AND THOUGHT ABOUT IT, SAID REHN, CASUALLY TIPPING A FIRST YEAR OUT OF ONE OF THE CHAIRS BY THE FIRE SHE THAT HE COULD SIT DOWN. THE CURSE DIDN'T EVEN MAKE IT INTO THE CASTLE. NOT WHAT SHE'D CALL PERFECT.

HEY BE RIGHT, SAID FERMINE, PREDICTING REHN OUT OF THE CHAIR WITH HER FEET AND OFFERING IT TO THE FIRST YEAR AGAIN. IT WASN'T VERY WELL THOUGHT-OUT AT ALL. BUT SINCE WHEN HAS MALPHY BEEN ONE OF THE WORLD'S GREAT THINKERS? ASKED HARRY. NEITHER REHN NOR FERMINE ANSWERED HIM. THE SECRET RIDDLE KATIE WAS REMOVED

THE ST. MUNGUS HOSPITAL FOR MAGICAL MALADIES AND INJURIES THE FOLLOWING DAY, BY WHICH TIME THE NEWS THAT SHE HAD BEEN CURSED HAD SPREAD ALL OVER THE SCHOOL, THOUGH THE DETAILS WERE CHANGING AND NEARLY EITHER THAN HARRY, RON, HERMION, AND LUCAS SEEMED TO KNOW THAT KATIE HERSELF HAD NOT BEEN THE INTENDED TARGET. HE, AND MALCOLM KNOWLES, OF COURSE, SAID HARRY THE RON AND HERMION, WHO CONTINUED THEIR NEW POLICY OF FEIGNING DRAINNESS WHENEVER HARRY MENTIONED HIS MALCOLM-IS-A-DEATH-LATER THEORY, HARRY HAD WONDERED WHETHER DUMBLEDORE WOULD RETURN FROM WHEREVER HE HAD BEEN IN TIME FOR MONDAY NIGHT'S LESSON, BUT HAVING HAD NO WORD THE OTHER CONTRARY, HE PRESENTED HIMSELF OUTSIDE DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE AT EIGHT ON CLOCK, KNOCKED, AND WAS TOLD TO ENTER. THERE SAT DUMBLEDORE LOOKING UNUSUALLY TIRED; HIS HAND WAS AS BLACK AND BURNED AS EVER, BUT HE SMILED WHEN HE GREETED THE HARRY THE SIT DOWN. THE PROFESSOR WAS SITTING IN THE DEER AGAIN, CASTING SILVERY SPECKS OF LIGHT OVER THE CEILING. YOU HAVE HAD A BUSY TIME WHILE I HAVE BEEN AWAY, DUMBLEDORE SAID. I BELIEVE YOU WITNESSED KATIE'S ACCIDENT. YES, SIR, SHE IS SHE? STILL VERY LINGERS, ALTHOUGH SHE WAS RELATIVELY LUCKY. SHE APPEARS TO HAVE BROKEN THE NECKLACE WITH THE SMALLEST POSSIBLE AMOUNT OF SKIN! THERE WAS A TINY FLESH IN HER CLAW, HAD SHE PUT IT ON, HAD SHE EVEN HELD IT IN HER LINGERED HAND, SHE WOULD HAVE DIED, PERHAPS INSTANTLY. LUCKILY PROFESSOR SNAPE WAS ABLE TO DO ENOUGH TO PREVENT A RAPID SPREAD OF THE CURSE. WHY HIM? ASKED HARRY QUICKLY. WHY NOT MADAM POMFREY? IMPERTINENT, SAID A SHOT VOICE FROM ONE OF THE PORTRAITS ON THE WALL, AND PHINEAS NIGELLUS BLACK, SIRIUS'S GREAT-GREAT-GRANDFATHER, RAISED HIS HEAD FROM HIS ARMS WHERE HE HAD APPEARED TO BE SLEEPING. I WOULD NOT HAVE PERMITTED A STUDENT TO INTERFERE THE WAY HOGWARTS OPERATED IN MY DAY. YES, THANK YOU, PHINEAS, SAID DUMBLEDORE HELPLESSLY. PROFESSOR SNAPE KNOWS MUCH MORE ABOUT THE DARK ARTS THAN MADAM POMFREY, HARRY. ANYWAY, THE ST. MUNGUS STAFF ARE SENDING ME REGULAR REPORTS, AND I AM HOPEFUL THAT KATIE WILL MAKE A FULL RECOVERY IN TIME.

WHERE WERE YOU THIS WEEKEND, SIR? HARRY ASKED, DISREGARDING A STRENGTH FEELING THAT HE MIGHT BE PUSHING HIS LUCK, A FEELING APPARENTLY SHARED BY PHINEAS NIGELLUS, WHO HISSED SHARPLY. I WOULD RATHER NOT SAY JUST NOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE. HOWEVER, I SHALL TELL YOU IN DUE COURSE. YOU WILL? SAID HARRY, STARTLED.

Yes, I expect she said Dimpledhere, withdrawing a fresh kettle of silver memories from inside his rears and unhooking it with a pinch of his hand. Sir, said Harry tentatively, I met Mumblyngs in Fhesmeade. Ah yes, I am already aware that Mumblyngs has been treating your inheritance with light-fingered contempt, said Dimpledhere, frowning a little. He has gone the wrong way since you accused him outside the three brasssticks; I rather think he breeds facing me. However, rest assured that he will not be making away with any more of Sirilis's old possessions. That Mandy old half-breed has been stealing black heirlooms? said Phineas Nickalls, incensed; and he stalked out of his frame, undoubtedly the visit his portrait in Number Twelve Grimald Place. Professor, said Harry, after a short pause, did Professor McEnagall tell you what I told her after Katie got hurt? About Drach Malfoy? She told me of your suspicions, yes, said Dimpledhere, and oh you? I shall take all appropriate measures to investigate anyone who might have had a hand in Katie's accident, said Dimpledhere. But what concerns me now, Harry, is your lesson. Harry felt slightly resentful at this; if their lessons were so very important, why had there been such a long gap between the first and second? However, he said no more about Drach Malfoy, but watched as Dimpledhere poured the fresh memories into the Pensieve and began swirling the stone basin once more between his long-fingered hands. You will remember, I am sure, that we left the tale of Lord Voldemort's beginnings at the point where the handsome Muggle, Tom Riddle, had abandoned his witch wife, Merope, and returned to his family home in Little Hangleton. Merope was left alone in London, expecting the baby when would one day become Lord Voldemort. How did you know she was in London, sir? Recall of the evidence of one Caractacus Podge, said Dimpledhere, who, by an odd coincidence, helped find the very shop where came the necklace we have just been discussing. He swilled the contents of the Pensieve as Harry had seen him swirl them before, much as a child prospecter sifts for gold. Up out of the swirling, silver mass rose a little old man revolving slowly in the Pensieve, silver as a ghost but much more solid, with a thatch of hair that completely covered his eyes. Yes, we acquired it in Clithells

CIRCUMSTANCES, IT WAS BRILLIANT IN BY A YOUNG WITCH JUST BEFORE CHRISTMAS, HEI, MANY YEARS AGO NOW. SHE SAID SHE NEEDED THE CHILD BADLY, WELL, THAT MUCH WAS EVIDENT, COVERED IN RAGS AND PRETTY FAR ALONE. GIVING THE HAVE A BABY, SEE. SHE SAID THE WICKET HAD BEEN SLOTHFUL, WELL, WE HEAR THAT SHEET OF STUFF ALL THE TIME, HEI, THIS WAS MERLIN, THIS WAS, HIS FAVORITE TRAP, BUT WHEN I LOOKED AT IT, IT HAD HIS MARK ALL RIGHT, AND A FEW SIMPLE SPELLS WERE ENOUGH TO TELL ME THE TRUTH, HE CHUCKLE, THAT MADE IT NEAR ENOUGH PRICELESS, SHE DIDN'T SEEM TO HAVE ANY IDEA HOW MUCH IT WAS WORTH, HAPPY TO GET TEN GALLEONS FOR IT, BEST BARGAIN WE EVER MADE! DUMBLEDORE GAVE THE PENSIVE AN EXTRA-VIVID SHADE AND CARACTACUS BLURR DESCENDED BACK INTO THE SWIRLING MASS OF MEMORY FROM WHENCE HE HAD COME. HE ONLY GAVE HER TEN GALLEONS? SAID HARRY INDIGNANTLY, CARACTACUS BLURR WAS NOT FAMED FOR HIS GENEROSITY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. SHE WE KNOW THAT, NEAR THE END OF HER PREGNANCY, MERPHE WAS ALONE IN LONDON AND IN DESPERATE NEED OF CHILD, DESPERATE ENOUGH TO SELL HER HONOR AND ONLY VALUABLE POSSESSION, THE WICKET THAT WAS ONE OF MARVELL'S TREASURED FAMILY HEIRLOOMS. BUT SHE COULD DO MAGIC? SAID HARRY IMPATIENTLY. SHE COULD HAVE GOT FOOD AND EVERYTHING FOR HERSELF BY MAGIC, COULDN'T SHE? AH, SAID DUMBLEDORE, PERHAPS SHE COULD, BUT IT IS MY BELIEF I AM GUESSING AGAIN, BUT I AM SURE I AM RIGHT

THAT WHEN HER HUSBAND ABANDONED HER, MERPHE STOPPED USING MAGIC, I DO NOT THINK THAT SHE WANTED TO BE A WITCH ANY LONGER, HE CHUCKLE, IT IS ALSO POSSIBLE THAT HER UNREQUITED LOVE AND THE ATTENDANT DESPAIR SAPPED HER OF HER POWERS; THAT CAN HAPPEN, IN ANY CASE, AS YOU ARE ABOUT TO SEE, MERPHE REFUSED TO RAISE HER WAND EVEN TO SAVE HER OWN LIFE. SHE WOULDN'T EVEN STAY ALIVE FOR HER SON? DUMBLEDORE RAISED HIS EYEBROWS, COULD YOU POSSIBLY BE FEELING SURE FOR LEAD VEDMENT? NO, SAID HARRY HURLING,

BUT SHE HAD A CHOICE, DIDN'T SHE, NOT LIKE MY MOTHER. YOUR MOTHER HAD A CHOICE THEN, SAID DUMBLEDORE GENTLY. YES, MERPHE RIDDLE CHOSE DEATH IN SPITE OF A SON WHO NEEDED HER, BUT DO NOT JUDGE HER THEN HARSHLY, HARRY. SHE WAS GREATLY WEAKENED BY LONG SUFFERING AND SHE NEVER HAD YOUR MOTHER'S COURAGE, AND NOW, IF YOU WILL STAND

WHERE ARE WE GOING? HARRY ASKED, AS DUMBLEDORE THREW HIM AT THE FRONT OF THE DESK. THIS TIME, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WE ARE GOING TO ENTER MY MEMORY, I THINK YOU WILL

FIND IT BOTH RICH IN DETAIL AND SATISFYINGLY ACCURATE. AFTER PHIL,
FARRY FARRY SENT OVER THE PENSIVE; HIS FACE RANDE THE CHILL
SURFACE OF THE MEMORY AND THEN HE WAS FALLING THROUGH DARKNESS
AGAIN. SECONDS LATER, HIS FEET HIT FIRM GROUND; HE OPENED HIS
EYES AND FOUND THAT HE AND DUMKEDDRE WERE STANDING IN A KISTINE,
HOLD-FAST-THICKED LINDEN STREET. THERE I AM, SAID DUMKEDDRE
BRIGHTLY, POINTING AHEAD OF THEM THE A TALL FIGURE CRESSING THE
ROAD IN FRONT OF A HORSE-DRAWN MILK CART. THIS YELLINGER ALKIS
DUMKEDDRE S LONG HAIR AND BEARD WERE ALKIRN. HAVING REACHED
THEIR SIDE OF THE STREET, HE STRIDE OFF ALONG THE PAVEMENT, DRAWING
MANY CURIOUS GLANCES BUT THE FLAMBOYANTLY CUT SUIT OF PLUM
VELVET THAT HE WAS WEARING. NICE SUIT, SIR, SAID FARRY, BEHOLD HE
COULD STOP HIMSELF, BUT DUMKEDDRE MERELY CHUCKLED AS THEY FOLLOWED
HIS YELLINGER SELF A SHORT DISTANCE, FINALLY PASSING THROUGH A SET
OF IRON GATES INTO A DARK CHURTYARD THAT PRESENTED A RATHER GRIM,
SEMI-AR KLINDING SURROUNDED BY HIGH RAILINGS. HE FOLLOWED THE FEW
STEPS LEADING TO THE FRONT DOOR AND DENIED HENCE. AFTER A MOMENT
HE TOOK THE DOOR WAS OPENED BY A SCRUFFY GIRL WEARING AN APRON.

GOOD AFTERNOON, I HAVE AN APPOINTMENT WITH A MRS. CHUR, WE-EE, I
BELIEVE, IS THE MATHEN HERE? HE, SAID THE BEMILDERED-LOOKING
GIRL, TAKING IN DUMKEDDRE S ECCENTRIC APPEARANCE. I'M ILST A
MRS. CHUR? SHE BELIEVED EVER HER SHOULD, FARRY HEARD
A DISTANT WHIRL WHISTLING SOMETHING IN RESPONSE. THE GIRL TURNED
BACK TO DUMKEDDRE. COME IN, SHE S HEH ER WAY. DUMKEDDRE STEPPED
INTO A HALLWAY TILED IN BLACK AND WHITE; THE WHITE PLACE WAS
SHARPLY BUT SPEETLESSLY CLEAN. FARRY AND THE ELDER DUMKEDDRE
FOLLOWED. BEFORE THE FRONT DOOR HAD CLOSED BEHIND THEM, A SKINNY,
HARASS-LOOKING WOMAN CAME SCURRYING TOWARD THEM. SHE HAD A
SHARP-FEATURED FACE THAT APPEARED MORE ANXIOUS THAN LONELY,
AND SHE WAS TALKING EVER HER SHOULD THE ANOTHER APRONED
HELPER AS SHE WALKED TOWARD DUMKEDDRE. AND TAKE THE INDINE
UPSTAIRS THE MARTHA, KILLY STILKES HAS BEEN PICKING HIS SCARS AND
ERIC WHALLEY S HEEZING ALL EVER HIS SHEETS CHICKEN PHO EN THE
OF EVERYTHING ELSE. SHE SAID THE NEEDY IN PARTICULAR, AND THEN HER
EYES FELL UPON DUMKEDDRE AND SHE STOPPED DEAD IN HER TRACKS,
LOOKING AS ASTONISHED AS IF A GIRAFFE HAD ILST CRESSED HER
THRESHOLD. GOOD AFTERNOON, SAID DUMKEDDRE, HOLDING OUT HIS
HAND. MRS. CHUR SIMPLY GAZED. MY NAME IS ALKIS DUMKEDDRE. I SENT

YELL A LETTER REQUESTING AN APPOINTMENT AND YELL VERY KINDLY INVITED ME HERE TODAY. MRS. LEHL BLINKED, APPARENTLY DECIDING THAT DUMKLEDHRE WAS NOT A HALLUCINATION, SHE SAID PEERLY, EH? YES, WELL

WELL THEN YELL D BETTER COME INTO MY ROOM, YES. SHE LED DUMKLEDHRE INTO A SMALL ROOM THAT SEEMED PART SITTING ROOM, PART OFFICE. IT WAS AS STARKY AS THE HALLWAY AND THE FURNITURE WAS OLD AND MISMATCHED. SHE INVITED DUMKLEDHRE TO SIT IN A RICKETY CHAIR AND SEATED HERSELF BEHIND A CLUTTERED DESK, EYING HIM NERVIOUSLY. I AM HERE, AS I TOLD YELL IN MY LETTER, TO DISCUSS THE RIDDLE AND ARRANGEMENTS FOR HIS FUTURE, SAID DUMKLEDHRE. ARE YELL FAMILY? ASKED MRS. LEHL. NO, I AM A TEACHER, SAID DUMKLEDHRE. I HAVE COME TO OFFER THEM A PLACE AT MY SCHOOL. WHAT SCHOOL IS THIS, THEN?

IT IS CALLED FINGHARTS, SAID DUMKLEDHRE. AND HOW COME YELL RE INTERESTED IN THEM? WE BELIEVE HE HAS ABILITIES WE ARE LOOKING FOR. YELL MEAN HE IS WHEN A SCHOLARSHIP? FELL CAN HE HAVE DONE? HE IS NEVER BEEN ENTERED FOR ONE. WELL, HIS NAME HAS BEEN DOWN FOR OUR SCHOOL SINCE BIRTH. WHEN REGISTERED HIM? HIS PARENTS? THERE WAS NO DOUBT THAT MRS. LEHL WAS AN INCONVENIENTLY SHARP WOMAN, APPARENTLY DUMKLEDHRE THOUGHT SHE THOUGHT FOR FARRY WHEN SHE SAW HIM SLIP HIS HAND INTO OF THE POCKET OF HIS VELVET SLIT, AT THE SAME TIME PICKING UP A PIECE OF PERFECTLY BLANK PAPER FROM MRS. LEHL'S DESKTOP. HERE, SAID DUMKLEDHRE, WAVING HIS HAND ONCE AS HE PASSED HER THE PIECE OF PAPER. I THINK THIS WILL MAKE EVERYTHING CLEAR. MRS. LEHL'S EYES SLID INTO HIS ARMS AND BACK AGAIN AS SHE GAZED INTENTLY AT THE BLANK PAPER FOR A MOMENT. THAT SEEMS PERFECTLY IN ORDER, SHE SAID PLACIDLY, HANDING IT BACK. THEN HER EYES FELL UPON A KETTLE OF GIN AND TWO GLASSES THAT HAD CERTAINLY NOT BEEN PRESENT A FEW SECONDS BEFORE.

OR MAY I OFFER YELL A GLASS OF GIN? SHE SAID IN AN EXTRA-REFINED VOICE. THANK YELL VERY MUCH, SAID DUMKLEDHRE, BEAMING. IT SEEMED BECAME CLEAR THAT MRS. LEHL WAS NO NEVILL WHEN IT CAME TO GIN DRINKING. FEELING BOTH OF THEM A GENERALIS MEASURE, SHE DRAINED HER OWN GLASS IN ONE GLIP. SMACKING HER LIPS FRANKLY, SHE SMILED AT DUMKLEDHRE FOR THE FIRST TIME, AND HE DIDN'T HESITATE TO PRESS HIS ADVANTAGE. I WAS WONDERING WHETHER YELL COULD TELL ME ANYTHING OF THE RIDDLE'S HISTORY? I THINK HE WAS BORN HERE IN THE ORPHANAGE? THAT IS RIGHT, SAID MRS. LEHL, HELPING HERSELF THE MORE GIN. I REMEMBER IT CLEAR AS ANYTHING, BECAUSE I DID JUST

STARTED HERE MYSELF, NEW YEAR'S EVE AND BITTER COLD, SNOWING, WELL
 KNOWN, NASTY NIGHT, AND THIS GIRL, NOT MUCH OLDER THAN I WAS
 MYSELF AT THE TIME, CAME STAGGERING UP THE FRONT STEPS, WELL, SHE
 WASN'T THE FIRST, WE THREW HER IN, AND SHE HAD THE BABY WITHIN THE
 HOUR, AND SHE WAS DEAD IN ANOTHER HOUR. MRS. LEE NEEDED
 IMPRESSIVELY AND THREW ANOTHER GENERALIS CLIP OF GIN. DID SHE SAY
 ANYTHING BEFORE SHE DIED? ASKED DUMKLEHIRE, ANYTHING ABOUT THE
 BABY'S FATHER, FOR INSTANCE? WELL, AS IT HAPPENS, SHE DID, SAID
 MRS. LEE, WHEN SEEMED TO BE RATHER ENJOYING HERSELF WITH THE
 GIN IN HER HAND AND AN EAGER AUDIENCE FOR HER STORY. I REMEMBER
 SHE SAID TO ME, I HOPE HE LOOKS LIKE HIS DADA, AND I WHEN T LIE, SHE
 WAS RIGHT TO HOPE IT, BECAUSE SHE WAS NOT REALITY AND THEN SHE
 TOLD ME HE WAS THE ONE NAMED THEM, FOR HIS FATHER, AND MARVELLUS, FOR
 HER FATHER YES, I KNOW, FLINDY NAME, ISN'T IT? WE WONDERED
 WHETHER SHE CAME FROM A CIRCLE AND SHE SAID THE BABY'S SURNAME
 WAS THE ONE RIDDLE, AND SHE DIED SOON AFTER THAT WITHOUT ANOTHER
 WORD. WELL, WE NAMED HIM JUST AS SHE'D SAID, IT SEEMED SO IMPORTANT
 THE THE OTHER GIRL, BUT NOT THEM NOR MARVELLUS NOR ANY KIND OF RIDDLE
 EVER CAME LOOKING FOR HIM, NOR ANY FAMILY AT ALL, SEE HE STAYED IN
 THE ORPHANAGE AND HE'S BEEN HERE EVER SINCE. MRS. LEE HELPED
 HERSELF, ALMOST AKENTIMEDLY, THE ANOTHER HEALTHY MEASURE OF GIN.
 TWO PINK SPOTS HAD APPEARED HIGH ON HER CHEEKBONES, THEN SHE
 SAID, HE'S A FLINDY BABY, YES, SAID DUMKLEHIRE, I THOUGHT HE
 MIGHT BE. HE WAS A FLINDY BABY THEN, HE HARDLY EVER CRIED, WELL
 KNOWN, AND THEN, WHEN HE GOT A LITTLE OLDER, HE WAS HED, HED IN
 WHAT WAY? ASKED DUMKLEHIRE GENTLY, WELL, HE BUT MRS. LEE
 PULLED UP SHORT, AND THERE WAS NOTHING BLIND FOR VAGUE ABOUT
 THE INHIBITORIAL GLANCE SHE SENT DUMKLEHIRE OVER HER GIN GLASS.
 HE'S DEFINITELY GOT A PLACE AT YOUNG SCHEM, WELL SAY? DEFINITELY,
 SAID DUMKLEHIRE, AND NOTHING I SAY CAN CHANGE THAT?
 NOTHING, SAID DUMKLEHIRE, WELL LL BE TAKING HIM AWAY,
 WHATEVER? WHATEVER, REPEATED DUMKLEHIRE GRAVELY, SHE
 SEEMED AT HIM AS THOUGH DECIDING WHETHER HER NOT THE TRUST HIM,
 APPARENTLY SHE DECIDED SHE COULD, BECAUSE SHE SAID IN A SUDDEN FLUSH,
 HE SCARES THE OTHER CHILDREN, WELL MEAN HE IS A KID? ASKED
 DUMKLEHIRE, I THINK HE MUST BE, SAID MRS. LEE, FREELING SLIGHTLY,
 BUT IT'S VERY HARD TO CATCH HIM AT IT, THERE HAVE BEEN INCIDENTS,
 NASTY THINGS DUMKLEHIRE DID NOT PRESS HER, THOUGH HARDY

CHILD TELL THAT HE WAS INTERESTED, SHE THUD YET ANOTHER CLIP OF
GIN AND HER REDDY CHEEKS GAVE RESISTANCE STILL. KILLY STUCKS & RABBIT
WELL, THEN SAID HE DIDN'T DO IT AND I DIDN'T SEE HOW HE COULD HAVE
DONE, BUT EVEN SHE, IT DIDN'T HANG ITSELF FROM THE RASTERS, DID IT? I
SHOULDN'T THINK SHE, NEH, SAID DUMKLEBHERE QUIETLY. BUT I'M HESITANT
IF I KNOW HOW HE GOT UP THERE TO DO IT, ALL I KNOW IS HE AND KILLY
HAD ARGUED THE DAY BEFORE, AND THEN MRS. CLEW THUD ANOTHER
SWIG OF GIN, SLEEPING A LITTLE DEEPER HER CHIN THIS TIME WHEN THE
SLUMBER HUNG. WE TAKE THEM OUT, SHE KNOWS, SINCE A YEAR, THE
THE COUNTRY-SIDE OR THE SEASIDE WELL, AND BENJAMIN AND DENNIS
KIDNAP WERE NEVER WHITE RIGHT AFTERWARDS, AND ALL WE EVER GOT OUT
OF THEM WAS THAT THEY'D GONE INTO A LAKE WITH THEM RIDDLER, & HE
SAID THEY'D JUST GONE EXPLORING, BUT SOMETHING HAPPENED IN
THERE, I'M SURE OF IT, AND, WELL, THERE HAVE BEEN A LOT OF THINGS,
ALARMING THINGS. SHE LOOKED AROUND AT DUMKLEBHERE AGAIN, AND
THOUGH HER CHEEKS WERE FLUSHED, HER GAZE WAS STEADY. I DIDN'T
THINK MANY PEOPLE WILL BE SHY TO SEE THE BACK OF HIM. SHE
UNDERSTAND, I'M SURE, THAT WE WILL NOT BE KEEPING HIM
PERMANENTLY? SAID DUMKLEBHERE. HE WILL HAVE TO RETURN HERE, AT
THE VERY LEAST, EVERY SUMMER. EH, WELL, THAT'S BETTER THAN A
WACK WHEN THE NISS WITH A RUSTY POKER, SAID MRS. CLEW WITH A
SLIGHT HICUP. SHE GOT TO HER FEET, AND HARRY WAS IMPRESSED TO SEE
THAT SHE WAS WHITE STEADY, EVEN THOUGH TWO-THIRDS OF THE GIN WAS
NOW GONE. I SUPPOSE YOU'D LIKE TO SEE HIM? VERY MUCH, SAID
DUMKLEBHERE, RISING THEN. SHE LED HIM OUT OF HER OFFICE AND UP THE
STONE STAIRS, CALLING OUT INSTRUCTIONS AND ADMONITIONS TO THE HELPERS
AND CHILDREN AS SHE PASSED. THE HIRPANS, HARRY SAW, WERE ALL
WEARING THE SAME KIND OF GRAYISH TUNIC. THEY LOOKED REASONABLY
WELL-CARED FOR, BUT THERE WAS NO DENYING THAT THIS WAS A GRIM
PLACE IN WHICH TO GROW UP. HERE WE ARE, SAID MRS. CLEW, AS THEY
TURNED OFF THE SECOND LANDING AND STOPPED OUTSIDE THE FIRST DOOR
IN A LONG HALLWAY. SHE KNOCKED TWICE AND ENTERED. THEN YOU'VE
GOT A VISITOR. THIS IS MR. DUMKERTON SHY, DUMKERTON, HE'S
COME TO TELL YOU WELL, I'LL LET HIM DO IT. HARRY AND THE TWO
DUMKLEBHERES ENTERED THE ROOM, AND MRS. CLEW CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND
THEM. IT WAS A SMALL BARE ROOM WITH NOTHING IN IT EXCEPT AN OLD
WARDROBE, A WOODEN CHAIR, AND AN IRON BEDSTEAD. A BOY WAS SITTING
END OF THE GRAY BLANKETS, HIS LEGS STRETCHED OUT IN FRONT OF

HIM, HOLDING A KID. THERE WAS NO TRACE OF THE CALINTS IN THE
RIDDLE'S FACE. MERRIE HAD GOTTEN HER DYING WISH: HE WAS HIS HANDSOME
FATHER IN MINIATURE, TALL AND ELEVEN YEARS OLD, DARK-HAIRED, AND
PALE. HIS EYES NARROWED SLIGHTLY AS HE THOUGHT OF DUMKLEDDERE'S
ECCENTRIC APPEARANCE. THERE WAS A MOMENT'S SILENCE. "WELL, THEN?"
SAID DUMKLEDDERE, WALKING FORWARD AND HOLDING UP HIS
HAND. THE KID HESITATED, THEN THREW IT, AND THEY SHOOK HANDS.
DUMKLEDDERE DREW UP THE HARD WOODEN CHAIR BESIDE RIDDLE, SO THAT
THE PAIR OF THEM LOOKED RATHER LIKE A HOSPITAL PATIENT AND
VISITOR. "I AM PROFESSOR DUMKLEDDERE." PROFESSOR? REPEATED
RIDDLE. HE LOOKED WARY. IS THAT LIKE DOCTOR? WHAT ARE YOU HERE
FOR? DID SHE GET YOU IN THE HALL A MOMENT AGO? HE WAS POINTING AT
THE DOOR THROUGH WHICH MRS. CHURCH HAD JUST LEFT. NO, NO, SAID
DUMKLEDDERE, SMILING. I DON'T BELIEVE YOU, SAID RIDDLE. SHE WANTS
ME TO LOOK AT, DOESN'T SHE? TELL THE TRUTH! HE SPoke THE LAST
THREE WORDS WITH A RINGING FORCE THAT WAS ALMOST SHOCKING. IT
WAS A COMMAND, AND IT SOUNDED AS THOUGH HE HAD GIVEN IT MANY
TIMES BEFORE. HIS EYES HAD WIDENED AND HE WAS GLARING AT
DUMKLEDDERE, WHO MADE NO RESPONSE EXCEPT THE CONTINUING SMILING
PLEASANTLY. AFTER A FEW SECONDS RIDDLE STOPPED GLARING, THOUGH HE
LOOKED, IF ANYTHING, WARIER STILL. WHO ARE YOU? I HAVE TOLD YOU.
MY NAME IS PROFESSOR DUMKLEDDERE AND I WORK AT A SCHOOL CALLED
FEEGLARTS. I HAVE COME TO OFFER YOU A PLACE AT MY SCHOOL. YOUR
NEW SCHOOL, IF YOU WOULD LIKE THE COME. RIDDLE'S REACTION TO THIS
WAS MOST SURPRISING. HE LEAPT FROM THE BED AND BACKED AWAY FROM
DUMKLEDDERE, LOOKING FLURRIED. YOU CAN'T DO ME? THE ASYLUM,
THAT'S WHERE YOU'RE FROM, ISN'T IT? PROFESSOR, YES, OF COURSE
WELL, I'M NOT GOING, SEE? THAT WOULD PUT ME IN THE END WHERE I SHOULD BE IN
THE ASYLUM. I NEVER DID ANYTHING THE LITTLE AMY BENSON OR DENNIS
KISHIP, AND YOU CAN ASK THEM, THEY'LL TELL YOU! I AM NOT FROM
THE ASYLUM, SAID DUMKLEDDERE PATIENTLY. I AM A TEACHER AND, IF YOU
WILL SIT DOWN CALMLY, I SHALL TELL YOU ABOUT FEEGLARTS. OF COURSE, IF
YOU WOULD RATHER NOT COME TO THE SCHOOL, NOBODY WILL FORCE YOU.
I'D LIKE TO SEE THEM TRY, SNEERED RIDDLE. FEEGLARTS,
DUMKLEDDERE WENT ON, AS THOUGH HE HAD NOT HEARD RIDDLE'S LAST
WORDS. IS A SCHOOL FOR PEOPLE WITH SPECIAL ABILITIES. I'M NOT
MAD! I KNOW THAT YOU ARE NOT MAD, FEEGLARTS IS NOT A SCHOOL
FOR MAD PEOPLE. IT IS A SCHOOL OF MAGIC. THERE WAS SILENCE. RIDDLE

HAD FREEZEN, HIS FACE EXPRESSIONLESS, BUT HIS EYES WERE FLICKERING BACK AND FORTH BETWEEN EACH OF DUMBLEDORE'S, AS THOUGH TRYING TO CATCH ONE OF THEM LYING. 'MAGIC?' HE REPEATED IN A WHISPER.

THAT'S RIGHT, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IT'S IT'S MAGIC, WHAT I CAN DO? WHAT IS IT THAT YOU CAN DO? ALL SORTS, REPLIED RIDDLE. A FLUSH OF EXCITEMENT WAS RISING UP HIS NECK INTO HIS REDDISH CHEEKS; HE BREATHED FEVERED. I CAN MAKE THINGS MOVE WITHOUT TOUCHING THEM, I CAN MAKE ANIMALS DO WHAT I WANT THEM TO DO, WITHOUT TRAINING THEM, I CAN MAKE BAD THINGS HAPPEN TO PEOPLE WHEN ANNOYED ME, I CAN MAKE THEM FURT IF I WANT THEM. HIS LEGS WERE TREMBLING. HE STUMBLERED FORWARD AND SAT DOWN ON THE BED AGAIN, STARING AT HIS HANDS, HIS HEAD BOWED AS THOUGH IN PRAYER. I KNOW I WAS DIFFERENT, HE WHISPERED TO HIS OWN TWINKLING FINGERS. I KNOW I WAS SPECIAL. ALWAYS, I KNOW THERE WAS SOMETHING. WELL, YOU WERE ALIVE RIGHT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WHO WAS NOW LONGER SMILING, BUT WATCHING RIDDLE INTENTLY. YOU ARE A WIZARD. RIDDLE LIFTED HIS HEAD. HIS FACE WAS TRANSFIGURED: THERE WAS A WILD HAPPINESS UPON IT, YET FOR SOME REASON IT DID NOT MAKE HIM BETTER LOOKING; ON THE CONTRARY, HIS FINELY CARVED FEATURES SEEMED SOMEHOW RELEGHER, HIS EXPRESSION ALMOST BESTIAL. ARE YOU A WIZARD THEN? YES, I AM. PROVE IT, SAID RIDDLE AT ONCE, IN THE SAME COMMANDING TONE HE HAD USED WHEN HE HAD SAID, 'TELL THE TRUTH.' DUMBLEDORE RAISED HIS EYEBROWS. IF, AS I TAKE IT, YOU ARE ACCEPTING YOUR PLACE AT HOGWARTS? OF COURSE I AM! THEN YOU WILL ADDRESS ME AS PROFESSOR OR SIR. RIDDLE'S EXPRESSION HARDENED FOR THE MOST FLEETING MOMENT BEFORE HE SAID, IN AN UNRECOGNIZABLY POLITE VOICE, I'M SORRY, SIR, I MEANT PLEASE, PROFESSOR, COULD YOU SHOW ME? HARRY WAS SURE THAT DUMBLEDORE WAS GIVING THE REPLY, THAT HE WOULD TELL RIDDLE THERE WOULD BE PLENTY OF TIME FOR PRACTICAL DEMONSTRATIONS AT HOGWARTS, THAT THEY WERE CURRENTLY IN A BUILDING FULL OF MUGGLES AND MUST THEREFORE BE CALTHERS. TO HIS GREAT SURPRISE, HOWEVER, DUMBLEDORE DREW HIS HAND FROM AN INSIDE POCKET OF HIS SLIT JACKET, POINTED IT AT THE SHAKY WARDROBE IN THE CORNER, AND GAVE THE WARD A CASUAL FLICK. THE WARDROBE BURST INTO FLAMES. RIDDLE LIMPED TO HIS FEET; HARRY COULD HARDLY BLAME HIM FOR FEELING IN SHOCK AND RAGE; ALL HIS WORLDLY POSSESSIONS MUST BE IN THERE, BUT EVEN AS RIDDLE REINED IN DUMBLEDORE, THE FLAMES VANISHED, LEAVING THE WARDROBE

COMPLETELY UNBAMAGED, RIDDLE STARED FROM THE WARDROBE THE DUMBLEDORE; THEN, HIS EXPRESSION GRABBED, HE POINTED AT THE WARD, WHERE CAN I GET ONE OF THEM? ALL IN GOOD TIME, SAID DUMBLEDORE, I THINK THERE IS SOMETHING TRYING TO GET OUT OF YOUR WARDROBE, AND SURE ENOUGH, A FAINT RATTLING SOUND BE HEARD FROM INSIDE IT, FOR THE FIRST TIME, RIDDLE LOOKED FRIGHTENED, OPEN THE DOOR, SAID DUMBLEDORE, RIDDLE HESITATED, THEN CROSSED THE ROOM AND THREW OPEN THE WARDROBE DOOR, IN THE THOROUGHST SELF, ABOVE A RAIL OF THREADBARE CLOTHES, A SMALL CARDBOARD BOX WAS SHAKING AND RATTLING AS THOUGH THERE WERE SEVERAL FRANTIC MICE TRAPPED INSIDE IT, TAKE IT OUT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, RIDDLE THEN OPENED THE SHAKING BOX, HE LOOKED UNNERVED, IS THERE ANYTHING IN THAT BOX THAT YOU WOULD NOT WANT TO HAVE? ASKED DUMBLEDORE, RIDDLE THREW DUMBLEDORE A LONG, CLEAR, CALCULATING LOOK, YES, I SUPPOSE YES, SIR, HE SAID FINALLY, IN AN EXPRESSIVELESS VOICE, OPEN IT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, RIDDLE THEN LIFTED THE LID AND TIPPED THE CONTENTS INTO HIS BED WITHOUT LOOKING AT THEM, HARRY, WHO HAD EXPECTED SOMETHING MUCH MORE EXCITING, SAW A MASS OF SMALL, EVERYDAY OBJECTS: A PEN-PEN, A SILVER TRINKET, AND A TARNISHED METAL HORN AMONG THEM, ENJOY FREE OF THE BOX, THEY STOPPED DELIVERING AND LAY WHITE STILL UPON THE THIN BLANKETS, YOU WILL RETURN THEM TO THEIR OWNERS WITH YOUR APPLAUSES, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY, PLACING HIS HAND BACK INTO HIS JACKET, I SHALL KNOW WHETHER IT HAS BEEN DONE, AND BE WARNED: THEFT IS NOT TOLERATED AT HOGWARTS, RIDDLE DID NOT LOOK REMOTELY ABASHED; HE WAS STILL STARING DULLY AND APPRAISINGLY AT DUMBLEDORE, AT LAST HE SAID IN A CHEERLESS VOICE, YES, SIR, AT HOGWARTS, DUMBLEDORE WENT ON, WE TEACH YOU NOT ONLY THE USE OF MAGIC, BUT THE CONTROL OF IT, YOU HAVE INADVERTENTLY, I AM SURE BEEN USING YOUR POWERS IN A WAY THAT IS NEITHER TALENT NOR TOLERATED AT OUR SCHOOL, YOU ARE NOT THE FIRST, NOR WILL YOU BE THE LAST, TO ALLOW YOUR MAGIC TO RUN AWAY WITH YOU, BUT YOU SHOULD KNOW THAT HOGWARTS CAN EXPEL STUDENTS, AND THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC YES, THERE IS A MINISTRY WILL PUNISH LAWBREAKERS STILL MORE SEVERELY, ALL NEW WIZARDS MUST ACCEPT THAT, IN ENTERING OUR WORLD, THEY ABIDE BY OUR LAWS, YES, SIR, SAID RIDDLE AGAIN, IT WAS IMPOSSIBLE TO TELL WHAT HE WAS THINKING; HIS FACE REMAINED WHITE BLANK AS HE PUT THE LITTLE CACHE OF STOLEN OBJECTS BACK INTO THE CARDBOARD BOX, WHEN HE HAD FINISHED, HE

TURNED THE DUMKLEDBERE AND SAID CALDLY, I HAVEN'T GOT ANY MONEY.

THAT IS EASILY REMEDIED, SAID DUMKLEDBERE, DRAWING A LEATHER MONEYPOUCH FROM HIS POCKET. THERE IS A FUND AT FINGWARTS FOR THOSE WHO REQUIRE ASSISTANCE THE WAY KINGS AND QUEENS. YOU MIGHT HAVE THE WAY SOME OF YOUR SPELLBOOKS AND SEE HOW SECOND-HAND, BUT

WHERE DO YOU BUY SPELLBOOKS? INTERRUPTED RIDDLE, WHO HAD TAKEN THE HEAVY MONEY BAG WITHOUT THANKING DUMKLEDBERE, AND WAS NOW EXAMINING A FAT CHILD CALLED. IN DIAGON ALLEY, SAID DUMKLEDBERE, I HAVE YOUR LIST OF BOOKS AND SOME OTHER EQUIPMENT WITH ME, I CAN HELP YOU FIND EVERYTHING. YOU'RE COMING WITH ME?

ASKED RIDDLE, LICKING LIP. CERTAINLY, IF YOU. I DON'T NEED YOU, SAID RIDDLE. I'M USED TO DOING THINGS FOR MYSELF, I CAN FIND MY OWN WAY. HE ADDED, CATCHING DUMKLEDBERE'S EYE, HARRY REMEMBERED THAT DUMKLEDBERE WOULD INSIST UPON ACCOMPANYING RIDDLE, BUT ONCE AGAIN HE WAS SURPRISED. DUMKLEDBERE HANDED RIDDLE THE ENVELOPE CONTAINING HIS LIST OF EQUIPMENT, AND AFTER TELLING RIDDLE EXACTLY HOW TO GET THE THE LEADY CALLED FROM THE HOPKINAGE, HE SAID,

YOU WILL BE ABLE TO SEE IT, ALTHOUGH MUGGLES AREN'T YOU. NON-MAGICAL PEOPLE, THAT IS. WILL NOT, ASK FOR THEM THE KARMAN EASY ENOUGH TO REMEMBER, AS HE SHARES YOUR NAME. RIDDLE GAVE AN IRRITABLE TWITCH, AS THOUGH TRYING TO DISPLACE AN UNDESIRABLE FLY.

YOU DISLIKE THE NAME THEM? THERE ARE A LOT OF THEM, MUTTERED RIDDLE. THEN, AS THOUGH HE COULD NOT SUPPRESS THE FEELING, AS THOUGH IT BURST FROM HIM IN SPITE OF HIMSELF, HE ASKED, WAS MY FATHER A WIZARD? HE WAS CALLED THEM RIDDLE THEN, THEY'VE TOLD ME. I'M AFRAID I DON'T KNOW, SAID DUMKLEDBERE, HIS VOICE GENTLE. MY MOTHER CAN'T HAVE BEEN MAGIC, HER SISTER WOULDNT HAVE DIED, SAID RIDDLE, MORE TO HIMSELF THAN DUMKLEDBERE. IT MUST'VE BEEN HIM, SHE. WHEN I'VE GOT ALL MY STUFF. WHEN DO I COME TO THE FINGWARTS? ALL THE DETAILS ARE IN THE SECOND PIECE OF PARCHMENT IN YOUR ENVELOPE, SAID DUMKLEDBERE. YOU WILL LEAVE FROM KING'S CROSS STATION ON THE FIRST OF SEPTEMBER. THERE IS A TRAIN TICKET IN THERE THEN. RIDDLE NODDED, DUMKLEDBERE GOT TO HIS FEET AND HELD OUT HIS HAND AGAIN. TAKING IT, RIDDLE SAID, I CAN SPREAD THE SNARKS, I FEELING OUT WHEN WE'VE BEEN TO THE COUNTRY AND TRIPS THEY FIND ME, THEY WHISPER TO ME. IS THAT NORMAL FOR A WIZARD? HARRY COULD TELL THAT HE HAD WITHHELD MENTION OF THIS STRANGEST

PHENIX UNTIL THAT MOMENT, DETERMINED THE IMPRESSION. IT IS UNUSUAL, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AFTER A MOMENT'S HESITATION, BUT NOT UNHEARD OF. HIS THEN WAS CASUAL BUT HIS EYES MOVED CURIOUSLY OVER RIDDLE'S FACE. THEY STOOD FOR A MOMENT, MAN AND BOY, STARING AT EACH OTHER. THEN THE HANDSHAKE WAS BROKEN; DUMBLEDORE WAS AT THE DOOR. GOOD-BYE, THEN, I SHALL SEE YOU AT HOGWARTS. I THINK THAT WILL BE, SAID THE WHITE-HAIRED DUMBLEDORE AT HARRY'S SIDE, AND SECONDS LATER, THEY WERE SHARING WEIGHTLESSLY THROUGH DARKNESS BEYOND THERE, BEFORE LANDING SEPARATELY IN THE PRESENT-DAY OFFICE. SIT DOWN, SAID DUMBLEDORE, LANDING BESIDE HARRY. HARRY HEAVED, HIS MIND STILL FULL OF WHAT HE HAD JUST SEEN. HE BELIEVED IT MUCH EASIER THAN I DID. I MEAN, WHEN YOU TOLD HIM HE WAS A WIZARD, SAID HARRY, I DIDN'T BELIEVE IT AT FIRST, WHEN HE TOLD ME. YES, RIDDLE WAS PERFECTLY READY TO BELIEVE THAT HE WAS THE LIKE HIS WHOLE SPECIAL, SAID DUMBLEDORE. DID YOU KNOW THEN? ASKED HARRY. DID I KNOW THAT I HAD JUST MET THE MOST DANGEROUS DARK WIZARD OF ALL TIME? SAID DUMBLEDORE. NO, I HAD NO IDEA THAT HE WAS THE GREEN WIP THE HE WHAT HE IS. HOWEVER, I WAS CERTAINLY INTRIGUED BY HIM. I RETURNED TO HOGWARTS INTENDING TO KEEP AN EYE UPON HIM, SOMETHING I SHOULD HAVE DONE IN ANY CASE, GIVEN THAT HE WAS ALONE AND FRIENDLESS, BUT WHICH, ALREADY, I FELT I MIGHT THE DO FOR OTHERS' SAKE AS MUCH AS HIS. HIS POWERS, AS YOU HEARD, WERE SURPRISINGLY WELL-DEVELOPED FOR SUCH A YOUNG WIZARD AND MOST INTERESTINGLY AND EMINENTLY OF ALL HE HAD ALREADY DISCOVERED THAT HE HAD SOME MEASURE OF CONTROL OVER THEM, AND BEGIN THE LIKE THEM CONSCIOUSLY, AND AS YOU SAW, THEY WERE NOT THE RANDOM EXPERIMENTS TYPICAL OF YOUNG WIZARDS! HE WAS ALREADY USING MAGIC AGAINST OTHER PEOPLE, TO FRIGHTEN, TO PUNISH, TO CONTROL. THE LITTLE STORIES OF THE STRANGLED RABBIT AND THE YOUNG BOY AND GIRL HE LURED INTO A CAVE WERE MOST SUGGESTIVE. I CAN MAKE THEM FLIRT IF I WANT THEM. AND HE WAS A PARSELMOUTH, INTERJECTED HARRY. YES, INDEED; A RARE ABILITY, AND ONE SUPPOSEDLY CONNECTED WITH THE DARK ARTS, ALTHOUGH AS WE KNOW, THERE ARE PARSELMOUTHS AMONG THE GREAT AND THE GOOD TOO. IN FACT, HIS ABILITY TO SPEAK THE SERPENTS DID NOT MAKE ME NEARLY AS UNEASY AS HIS EVIL INSTINCTS FOR CRUELTY, SECRECY, AND DOMINATION. TIME IS MAKING FEELS OF US AGAIN, SAID DUMBLEDORE, INDICATING THE DARK SKY BEYOND THE WINDOWS. BUT BEFORE WE PART, I WANT TO DRAW YOUR ATTENTION

THE CERTAIN FEATURES OF THE SCENE WE HAVE JUST WITNESSED, AND THEY HAVE A GREAT BEARING ON THE MATTERS WE SHALL BE DISCUSSING IN FUTURE MEETINGS. FIRSTLY, I HOPE YOU NOTICED RIDDLER'S REACTION WHEN I MENTIONED THAT ANOTHER SHARED HIS FIRST NAME. THEN? HARRY NEEDED. THERE HE SHOWED HIS CONTEMPT FOR ANYTHING THAT TIED HIM TO EITHER PEOPLE, ANYTHING THAT MADE HIM ORDINARY. EVEN THEN, HE WISHED TO BE DIFFERENT, SEPARATE, NOTWITHSTANDING, HE SHED HIS NAME, AS YOU KNOW, WITHIN A FEW SHORT YEARS OF THAT CONVERSATION AND CREATED THE MASK OF LORD VERDERBERT BEHIND WHICH HE HAS BEEN HIDDEN FOR SO LONG. I TRUST THAT YOU ALSO NOTICED THAT THE RIDDLER WAS ALREADY HIGHLY SELF-SUFFICIENT, SECRETIVE, AND, APPARENTLY, FRIENDLESS? HE DID NOT WANT HELP OR COMPANIONSHIP ON HIS TRIP TO DIAGEN ALLEY, HE PREFERRED TO OPERATE ALONE. THE ADULT VERDERBERT IS THE SAME, YOU WILL HEAR MANY OF HIS DEATH EATERS CLAIMING THAT THEY ARE IN HIS CONFIDENCE, THAT THEY ALONE ARE CLOSE TO HIM, EVEN UNDERSTAND HIM. THEY ARE DELUDED. LORD VERDERBERT HAS NEVER HAD A FRIEND, NEAR DO I BELIEVE THAT HE HAS EVER WANTED ONE. AND LASTLY I HOPE YOU ARE NOT TOO SLEEPY TO PAY ATTENTION TO THIS, HARRY THE THINKING THE RIDDLER LIKED TO COLLECT TREASURES, YOU SAW THE BOX OF STEEL ARTICLES HE HAD HIDDEN IN HIS ROOM. THESE WERE TAKEN FROM VICTIMS OF HIS KILLING BEHAVIOUR, SOUVENIRS, IF YOU WILL, OF PARTICULARLY UNPLEASANT BITS OF MAGIC. BEAR IN MIND THIS MAGIC-LIKE TENDENCY, AND THIS, PARTICULARLY, WILL BE IMPORTANT LATER. AND NOW, IT REALLY IS TIME FOR BED. HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET, AS HE WALKED ACROSS THE ROOM, HIS EYES FELL UPON THE LITTLE TABLE ON WHICH MARYELLE CALINT'S RING HAD RESTED LAST TIME, BUT THE RING WAS NO LONGER THERE. YES, HARRY? SAID OLMLEDER, AND HARRY HAD COME TO A HALT. THE RING'S GONE, SAID HARRY, WHISKING AROUND. BUT I THOUGHT YOU MIGHT HAVE THE MIGHTY EYE FOR SOMETHING. OLMLEDER BEAMED AT HIM, PEERING OVER THE TOP OF HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES. VERY ASTUTE, HARRY, BUT THE MIGHTY EYE WAS ONLY EVER A MIGHTY EYE. AND ON THAT ENIGMATIC NOTE HE WAVED THE HARRY, WHO UNDERSTOOD HIMSELF TO BE DISMISSED. FELIX FELIX HARRY HAD HEREBY FIRST THING THE FOLLOWING MORNING, HE HAD BEEN UNABLE TO TELL BEN AND HERMIONE ABOUT HIS LESSON WITH OLMLEDER EVER BREAKFAST FOR FEAR OF BEING OVERHEARD, BUT HE FILLED THEM IN AS THEY WALKED ACROSS THE VEGETABLE PATCH TOWARD THE

GREEN-HILSES. THE WEEKEND'S ERIAL WIND HAD DIED BLT AT LAST; THE
WIND MIST HAD RETURNED AND IT THHX THEM A LITTLE HNGER THAN
USUAL TH FIND THE CORRECT GREEN-HILSE. WHEN, SCAR T-ELIGHT, THE
KEY YEL-KNEL-WITH, SAID REN BLTLY, AS THEY THHX THEIR PLACES
ARHLND HNE HF THE GNARLED SNAREALLY STUMPS THAT FORMED THIS
TERM'S PRHKT, AND BEGAN PULLING HEN THEIR PRHKTIVE GLVES. BLT
I STILL HEN T GET WHY BLKEDHRE S SHHNG YEL ALL THIS. I MEAN,
IT S REALLY INTERESTING AND EVERYTHING, BLT WHAT S THE PHINT?

BLNNEH, SAID HARRY, INSERTING A CLM SHLD. BLT HE SAYS IT S ALL
IMPHTANT AND IT LL HELP ME SURVIVE. I THINK IT S FASCINATING,
SAID H-ERMINEH EARNESTLY. IT MAKES ABSHLLTE SENSE TH KNEL AS
MUCH ABHLT VELDERT AS POSSIBLE, HEN ELSE WILL YEL FIND BLT HIS
WEAKNESSES? SHE HEN WAS SLUG-HRN S LATEST PARTY? HARRY
ASKED HER THHLY THHGH THE CLM SHLD. HEN, IT WAS BLTE FLN,
REALLY, SAID H-ERMINEH, HEN PLTTING HEN PRHKTIVE GEGLES. I
MEAN, HE DRINKS HEN ABHLT FAPHLIS EX-PLIPIS A KIT, AND HE
ABSHLLTELY FALNS HEN MLAGGEN BECAUSE HE S SH WELL-CONNECTED, BLT
HE GAVE US SHME REALLY NICE PHND AND HE INTRODUCED US TH GWENHE
HNES. GWENHE HNES? SAID REN, HIS EYES WIDENING UNDER HIS
HWN GEGLES. THE GWENHE HNES? CAPTAIN HF THE H-HY-HEAD
HARRIES? THAT S RIGHT, SAID H-ERMINEH. PERSONALLY, I THHGH
SHE WAS A KIT FLN HF HERSELF, BLT BLTE ENHGH THAT HYER
HERE? SAID PROFESSER SPRLT KRISLY, BLSTING HYER AND LHHNG
STERN. YEL RE LAGGING BEHIND, EVERYBODY ELSE HAS STARTED, AND
NEVILLE S ALREADY GET HIS FIRST PHD. THEY LHHED ARHLND; SLRE
ENHGH, THERE SAT NEVILLE WITH A BLEEDY LIP AND SEVERAL NASTY
SCRATCHES ALONG THE SIDE HF HIS FACE, BLT CLTCHING AN
UNPLEASANTLY PLASATING GREEN HIKT ABHLT THE SIZE HF A
GRAPFRUIT. HDAY, PROFESSER, WE RE STARTING NEN? SAID REN,
ADDING BLTLY, WHEN SHE HAD TURNED AWAY AGAIN, SHHLD VE USED
MULPLATEH, HARRY. NEE, WE SHHLDN T? SAID H-ERMINEH AT HNE,
LHHNG, AS SHE ALWAYS DID, INTENSELY CROSS AT THE THHGH HF THE
HAL-BLEED PRINCE AND HIS SPELLS. WELL, HME HEN WE D BETTER GET
GHNG. SHE GAVE THE HTHR TWO AN APPREHENSIVE LHH; THEY
ALL THHX DEEP BREATHS AND THEN DVED AT THE GNARLED STUMP BETWEEN
THEM. IT SPRANG TH LIFE AT HNE; HNG, PRICKLY, BRAMBLELIKE VINES
FLEW BLT HF THE THP AND WHIPPED THHGH THE AIR. HNE TANGLED
ITSELF IN H-ERMINEH S HAIR, AND REN BEAT IT BACK WITH A PAIR HF

SEATED. HARRY SUCCEEDED IN TRAPPING A CLUMPLE OF VINES AND
 KNOTTING THEM TOGETHER. A HOLE OPENED IN THE MIDDLE OF ALL THE
 TENTACLELIKE BRANCHES. HERMIONE PLUNGED HER ARM BRAVELY INTO
 THIS HOLE, WHICH CLOSED LIKE A TRAP AROUND HER ELBOW. HARRY AND
 RON TUGGED AND WRENCHED AT THE VINES, PULLING THE HOLE THE OPEN
 AGAIN, AND HERMIONE SNATCHED HER ARM FREE, CLUTCHING IN HER
 FINGERS A PINK ILIUM LIKE NEVILLE'S. AT ONCE, THE PRICKLY VINES SHED
 BACK INSIDE, AND THE ENRAGED SLIMP SAT THERE BEHEADING LIKE AN
 INNOCENTLY DEAD LUMP OF WHITE. 'WELL DONE, I DON'T THINK I'LL BE
 HAVING ANY OF THESE IN MY GARDEN WHEN I'VE GOT MY OWN PLACE,'
 SAID RON, PUSHING HIS GOGGLES UP BETWEEN HIS FOREHEAD AND WIPING
 SWEAT FROM HIS FACE. 'PASS ME A KILL,' SAID HERMIONE, HOLDING THE
 PULSATING PINK AT ARM'S LENGTH. HARRY HANDED HER OVER AND SHE
 DROPPED THE PINK INTO IT WITH A BANG OF DISGUST ON HER FACE. 'DON'T
 BE SHREWDISH, SHELLS. IT HURT, THEY'RE BEST WHEN THEY'RE FRESH.'
 CALLED PROFESSOR SPURR. ANYWAY, SAID HERMIONE, CONTINUING
 THEIR INTERRUPTED CONVERSATION AS THOUGH A LUMP OF WHITE HAD
 NOT ILIUM ATTACKED THEM. 'SILVERHORN'S GOING TO HAVE A CHRISTMAS
 PARTY, HARRY, AND THERE'S NO WAY YOU'LL BE ABLE TO WRIGGLE OUT OF
 THIS ONE BECAUSE HE ACTUALLY ASKED ME TO CHECK YOUR FREE EVENINGS,
 SO HE'LL BE SURE TO HAVE IT ON A NIGHT YOU CAN COME. HARRY
 GRINNED. MEANWHILE, RON, WHO WAS ATTEMPTING TO KISS THE PINK IN
 THE KILL BY PUTTING BOTH HANDS ON IT, STANDING UP, AND SHOUTING
 IT AS HARD AS HE COULD, SAID ANGRILY, 'AND THIS IS ANOTHER PARTY
 ILIUM FOR SILVERHORN'S FAVORITES, IS IT? ILIUM FOR THE SILVER LILY,
 YES,' SAID HERMIONE. THE PINK FLEW OUT FROM UNDER RON'S FINGERS
 AND HIT THE GREENHOUSE GLASS, REBOUNDING BOUNDED THE BACK OF
 PROFESSOR SPURR'S HEAD AND KNOCKING OFF HER HAIR, PATCHED HAT.
 HARRY WENT TO RETRIEVE THE PINK; WHEN HE GOT BACK, HERMIONE WAS
 SAYING, 'WELL, I DIDN'T MAKE UP THE NAME SILVER LILY SILVER
 LILY,' REPEATED RON WITH A SNEER WORTHY OF MALFOY. 'IT'S
 PATHETIC. WELL, I HOPE YOU ENJOY YOUR PARTY, WHY DON'T YOU TRY
 FIGHTING UP WITH MCKAGG, THEN SILVERHORN CAN MAKE YOU KING
 AND QUEEN SILVER. WE'RE ALLOWED TO BRING GUESTS,' SAID
 HERMIONE, WHO FOR SOME REASON HAD TURNED A BRIGHT, SMILING
 SCARLET. 'AND I WAS GOING TO ASK YOU TO COME, BUT IF YOU THINK IT'S
 THAT STUPID THEN I WON'T EITHER.' HARRY SUDDENLY WISHED THE PINK
 HAD FLEW A LITTLE FARTHER, SO THAT HE NEED NOT HAVE BEEN SITTING

HERE WITH THE PAIR OF THEM, UNNOTICED BY EITHER, HE SEIZED THE WHEEL THAT CONTAINED THE PNEU AND BEGAN THE TRY AND OPEN IT BY THE NEAREST AND MOST ENERGETIC MEANS HE COULD THINK OF; UNFORTUNATELY, HE COULD STILL HEAR EVERY WORD OF THEIR CONVERSATION. "WELL WERE GOING THE SAME WAY?" ASKED RENN, IN A COMPLETELY DIFFERENT VOICE. "YES," SAID FERMINE ANGERILY, BUT HEAVENLY IF WELL'D RATHER I HUNG UP WITH MCLAGGEN. THERE WAS A PAUSE WHILE HARRY CONTINUED THE POUNDING THE RESILIENT PNEU WITH A TRUNK. "WELL, I WOULDN'T," SAID RENN, IN A VERY QUIET VOICE. HARRY MISSED THE PNEU, HIT THE WHEEL, AND SHATTERED IT. REPAIRS, HE SAID HASTILY, POUNDING THE PIECES WITH HIS HAND, AND THE WHEEL SPRANG BACK TOGETHER AGAIN. THE CRASH, HOWEVER, APPEARED TO HAVE AWAKENED RENN AND FERMINE TO HARRY'S PRESENCE. FERMINE WHINED ALISTERS AND IMMEDIATELY STARTED FLISSING AROUND FOR HER COPY OF FLESH-EATING TREES OF THE WORLD THE FIND OUT THE CORRECT WAY THE ILIKE SNAGGALLY PNEUS; RENN, ON THE OTHER HAND, WHINED SHEEPISHLY BUT ALSO RATHER PLEASED WITH HIMSELF. "AND THAT EVER," HARRY, SAID FERMINE FLURRIEDLY. IT SAYS WE'RE SLIPPED THE PLINKLE THEM WITH SOMETHING SHARP. HARRY PASSED HER THE PNEU IN THE WHEEL; HE AND RENN BOTH SNAPPED THEIR GOGGLES BACK OVER THEIR EYES AND DIVED, HENCE MORE, FOR THE STUMP. IT WAS NOT AS THOUGH HE WAS REALLY SURPRISED, THOUGH HARRY, AS HE WRESTLED WITH A THIRTY-ONE INTENT UPON THREATENING HIM; HE HAD HAD AN INCLINE THAT THIS MIGHT HAPPEN SOONER OR LATER, BUT HE WAS NOT SURE WHEN HE FELT ABOUT IT. HE AND SHE WERE NOW THEN EMBARRASSED THE MORE AT EACH OTHER, LET ALONE TALK TO EACH OTHER; WHAT IF RENN AND FERMINE STARTED GOING OUT TOGETHER, THEN SPLIT UP? COULD THEIR FRIENDSHIP SURVIVE IT? HARRY REMEMBERED THE FEW WEEKS WHEN THEY HAD NOT BEEN TALKING TO EACH OTHER IN THE THIRD YEAR; HE HAD NOT ENJOYED TRYING THE BRIDGE THE DISTANCE BETWEEN THEM. AND THEN, WHAT IF THEY DIDN'T SPLIT UP? WHAT IF THEY BECAME LIKE BILL AND FELIX, AND IT BECAME EXCRUCIATINGLY EMBARRASSING TO BE IN THEIR PRESENCE, SEE THAT HE WAS SHUT OUT FOR GOOD? "GET-UP!" YELLED RENN, PULLING A SECOND PNEU FROM THE STUMP JUST AS FERMINE MANAGED THE FIRST THE FIRST ONE OPEN, SEE THAT THE WHEEL WAS FULL OF TWIGS WRIGGLING LIKE PALE GREEN WORMS. THE REST OF THE LESSON PASSED WITHOUT FURTHER MENTION OF SLUGGISH'S PARTY. ALTHOUGH HARRY WATCHED HIS TWO FRIENDS MORE CLOSELY OVER THE NEXT FEW DAYS, RENN AND FERMINE DID

NEET SEEM ANY DIFFERENT EXCEPT THAT THEY WERE A LITTLE PEELTER THE EACH OTHER THAN USUAL. HARRY SUPPOSED HE WOULD ILST HAVE THE WAIT THE SEE WHAT HAPPENED UNDER THE INFLUENCE OF KLITTERBER IN SILVERHORN S DIMLY LIT ROOMS ON THE NIGHT OF THE PARTY. IN THE MEANTIME, HOWEVER, HE HAD MORE PRESSING WHIRRIES. KATIE BELL WAS STILL IN ST. MUNGUS S HOSPITAL WITH THE PROSPECT OF LEAVING, WHICH MEANT THAT THE PROMISING GRYFFINDOR TEAM HARRY HAD BEEN TRAINING SEE CAREFULLY SINCE SEPTEMBER WAS HERE CHASER SEHRT. HE KEPT PLUTTING OFF REPLACING KATIE IN THE HOPE THAT SHE WOULD RETURN, BUT THEIR OPENING MATCH AGAINST SLYTHERIN WAS NEEHING, AND HE FINALLY HAD TO ACCEPT THAT SHE WOULD NEET BE BACK IN TIME TO PLAY. HARRY DID NEET THINK HE COULD STAND ANOTHER FULL-BELLY TROHLIT. WITH A SINKING FEELING THAT HAD LITTLE TO DO WITH ELUDDITCH, HE CHARGED DEAN THOMAS AFTER TRANSFIGURATION ONE DAY. MOST OF THE CLASS HAD ALREADY LEFT, ALTHOUGH SEVERAL TWITTERING YELLOW BIRDS WERE STILL ZEEHING AROUND THE ROOM, ALL OF HERRMINE S CREATIONS; NEHNDY ELSE HAD SUCCEEDED IN CHURLING SEE MUCH AS A FEATHER FROM THEIR AIR. ARE YOU STILL INTERESTED IN PLAYING CHASER? WEA ? YEAH, HE CHIRPED. SAID DEAN EXCITEDLY. EVER DEAN S SCHILDER, HARRY SAW SEAMUS FINNIGAN SLAMMING HIS KNEES INTO HIS KAG, LEEHNG SEEH. ONE OF THE REASONS WHY HARRY WOULD HAVE PREFERRED NEET TO HAVE THE ASK DEAN THE PLAY WAS THAT HE KNEW SEAMUS WOULD NEET LIKE IT. ON THE OTHER HAND, HE HAD TO DO WHAT WAS BEST FOR THE TEAM, AND DEAN HAD HILTFELLEN SEAMUS AT THE TROHLITS. WELL THEN, YOU RE IN, SAID HARRY. THERE S A PRACTICE TONIGHT, SEVEN O CLK. RIGHT, SAID DEAN. CHEERS, HARRY! KIMMY, I CAN T WAIT TO TELL GINNY! HE SPRINTED OUT OF THE ROOM, LEAVING HARRY AND SEAMUS ALONE TOGETHER, AN UNCOMFORTABLE MOMENT MADE NEE EASIER WHEN A BIRD DROPPING LANDED ON SEAMUS S HEAD AS ONE OF HERRMINE S CANARIES WHIZZED OVER THEM. SEAMUS WAS NEET THE ONLY PERSON DISORIENTED BY THE CHIEK OF KATIE S SLICKTILTE. THERE WAS MUCH MUTTERING IN THE CHAMBER ROOM ABOUT THE FACT THAT HARRY HAD NEEN CHESN TWO OF HIS CLASSMATES FOR THE TEAM. AS HARRY HAD ENDURED MUCH WHESE MUTTERINGS THAN THIS IN HIS SCHOOL CAREER, HE WAS NEET PARTICULARLY BOTHERED, BUT ALL THE SAME, THE PRESSURE WAS INCREASING TO PROVIDE A WIN IN THE UPCOMING MATCH AGAINST SLYTHERIN. IF GRYFFINDOR WEN, HARRY KNEW THAT THE WHOLE SCHOOL WOULD FORGET THAT THEY HAD CRITICIZED HIM AND SWEAR THAT THEY HAD

ALWAYS KNOWN IT WAS A GREAT TEAM. IF THEY LOST WELL, HARRY
THOUGHT WORSE, HE HAD STILL ENJOINED WHOSE MUTTERINGS. HARRY
HAD NOT REACHED THE REGRET HIS CHOICE SINCE HE SAW DEAN FLY THAT
EVENING. HE WORKED WELL WITH GINNY AND DERMIDA. THE BEATERS,
PEAKES AND CHUTE, WERE GETTING BETTER ALL THE TIME. THE ONLY
PROBLEM WAS REIN. HARRY HAD KNOWN ALL ALONG THAT REIN WAS AN
INCONSISTENT PLAYER WHO SUFFERED FROM NERVES AND A LACK OF
CONFIDENCE, AND UNFORTUNATELY, THE SHINING PROSPECT OF THE
UPCOMING GAME OF THE SEASON SEEMED TO HAVE BRIGHTENED ALL HIS
OLD INSECURITIES. AFTER LETTING IN HALF A DOZEN GOALS, MOST OF THEM
SCORED BY GINNY, HIS TECHNICAL BECAME WILDER AND WILDER, UNTIL HE
FINALLY PLUNGED AN ENORMOUS DERMIDA REIKINS IN THE MOUTH. IT
WAS AN ACCIDENT, I'M SURE, DERMIDA, REALLY SURE. REIN STUMBLED
AFTER HER AS SHE ZIGZAGGED BACK TO THE GOAL, DRIPPING BLOOD
EVERYWHERE. I MUST PANICKED, GINNY SAID ANGERILY, LANDING
NEXT TO DERMIDA AND EXAMINING HER FAT LIP. WELL PRAT, REIN, LOOK
AT THE STATE OF HER. I CAN FIX THAT, SAID HARRY, LANDING BESIDE
THE TWO GIRLS, POINTING HIS HAND AT DERMIDA'S MOUTH, AND SAYING
POISER. AND GINNY, DON'T CALL REIN A PRAT, WELL BE NOT THE
CAPTAIN OF THIS TEAM WELL, WELL SEEMED THE LAST THE CALL HIM A
PRAT AND I THOUGHT SOMETHING SHOULD HARRY FORCED HIMSELF NOT
TO LAUGH. IN THE AIR, EVERYONE, LET'S GO. OVERALL IT WAS ONE OF
THE WORST PRACTICES THEY HAD HAD ALL TERM, THOUGH HARRY DID NOT
FEEL THAT HONESTY WAS THE BEST POLICY WHEN THEY WERE THIS CLOSE TO
THE MATCH. GOOD WORK, EVERYONE, I THINK WE'LL FLATTEN
SLITHERIN. HE SAID BRACINGLY AND THE CHASERS AND BEATERS LEFT THE
CHANGING ROOMS LEAVING REASONABLY HAPPY WITH THEMSELVES. I
PLAYED LIKE A SACK OF DRAGON BONE, SAID REIN IN A WHISPER WHILE
WHEN THE DOOR HAD SLUNG SHUT BEHIND GINNY. NO, WELL DIDN'T,
SAID HARRY FIRMLY. WELL BE THE BEST KEEPER I TRIED NOT, REIN, YOUR
ONLY PROBLEM IS NERVES. HE KEPT UP A RELENTLESS FLOW OF
ENCOURAGEMENT ALL THE WAY BACK TO THE CASTLE, AND BY THE TIME THEY
REACHED THE SECOND FLOOR, REIN WAS BECOMING marginally MORE
CHEERFUL. WHEN HARRY PULSED OPEN THE TAPESTRY TO TAKE THEIR
USUAL SHORTCUT UP THE GRYFFINDOR TOWER, HOWEVER, THEY FOUND
THEMSELVES LOOKING AT DEAN AND GINNY, WHO WERE LOCKED IN A CLOSE
EMBRACE AND KISSING FIRMLY AS THOUGH GLUED TOGETHER. IT WAS AS
THOUGH SOMETHING LARGE AND SCALY ERUPTED INTO LIFE IN HARRY'S

STOMACH, CLAWING AT HIS INSIDES! HEIT KLEHED SEEMED THE FLEHED HIS BRAIN, SEE THAT ALL THELIGHT WAS EXTINGLISHED, REPLACED BY A SAVAGE LARGE THE INK DEAN INTEH A JELLY, WRESTLING WITH THIS SLUDGEN MADNESS, HE HEARD REHN S VEHKE AS TEHLIGH FREEM A GREAT DISTANCE AWAY. HEIT DEAN AND GINNY KRHEK APART AND LHEHED ARHELD. WHAT? SAID GINNY. I DENN T WANT THE FIND MY ELHN SISTER SNEGGING PEEPLE IN PLEKIK! THIS WAS A DESERTED CHORRIDER TILL YELJ CAME KLITTING IN! SAID GINNY, DEAN WAS LHEHED EMBARRASSED, HE GAVE HARRY A SHIFTY GRIN THAT HARRY DID NEET RETLURN, AS THE NELKEHN MINISTER INSIDE HIM WAS REHARING AER DEAN S INSTANT DISMISSAL FREEM THE TEAM. ER I MHHN, GINNY, SAID DEAN, LET S GEE KACK THE THE CHEMPHN REHHEM.

YELJ GEE? SAID GINNY. I WANT A WHRD WITH MY DEAR KREHTHER! DEAN LEFT, LHEHED AS TEHLIGH HE WAS NEET SHERRY THE DEPART THE SCENE. RIGHT, SAID GINNY, THESSING HER LEHNG RED HAIR ELJT HF HER FACE AND CLARING AT REHN, LET S GET THIS STRAIGHT HENCE AND AER ALL. IT IS NHHN HF YELJR KLISINESS WHEH I GEE ELJT WITH HER WHAT I DEE WITH THEM, REHN YEAH, IT IS! SAID REHN, ILIST AS ANGERILY. O YELJ THHND I WANT PEEPLE SAYING MY SISTER S A A WHAT? SHHELTED GINNY, DRAWING HER HAND. A WHAT, EXACTLY? HE DHEEN T MEAN ANYTHING, GINNY SAID HARRY ALTHEMATICALLY, TEHLIGH THE MINISTER WAS REHARING ITS APPREHVAL HF REHN S WHRDS. HEH YES HE DHEES! SHE SAID, FLARING LIP AT HARRY. ILIST RECALISE HE S NEVER SNEGGED ANYONE IN HIS LIFE, ILIST RECALISE THE BEST DISS HE S EVER HAD IS FREEM ELJR ALINTIE MLRIEL SHLT YELJR MEHLTH! KELLEHED REHN, BYPASSING RED AND TURNING MARHEHN. NEH, I WILL NEET! YELLED GINNY, RESIDE HERSELF. I VE SEEN YELJ WITH PHELEM, HHEPING SHE LL DISS YELJ HEN THE CHEEK EVERY TIME YELJ SEE HER, IT S PATHETIK! IF YELJ WENT ELJT AND GEE A KIT HF SNEGGING DEHN YELJRSELF, YELJ WHELDON T MIND SEE MLKH THAT EVERYONE ELSE DHEES IT! REHN HAD PULLED ELJT HIS HAND THEH, HARRY STEPPED SLIFTLY BETWEEN THEM. YELJ DENN T DNEHL WHAT YELJ RE TALKING AHEHJT! REHN REHARED, TRYING THE GET A CLEAR SEHHT AT GINNY ARHELD HARRY, WHEH WAS NEHL STANDING IN FREHNT HF HER WITH HIS ARMS ELJTSTRETCHED. ILIST RECALISE I DENN T DEE IT IN PLEKIK ! GINNY SCREAMED WITH DERISIVE LALIGHTER, TRYING THE PUSHE HARRY ELJT HF THE WAY. KEEN DISSING PIGWIDGEHN, HAVE YELJ HER HAVE YELJ GEE A PICTURE HF ALINTIE MLRIEL STASHED LINDER YELJR PILLHEH? YELJ A STREK HF HIRANGE LIGHT FLEW LINDER HARRY S LEFT ARM AND MISSED GINNY BY INCHES! HARRY PUSHEH REHN UP

AGAINST THE WALL. THEN T HE STUPID HARRY S SNEGGED LHE
CHANGE! SHUTTED CINDY, LHE SHLNDOD CHESE TH TEARS NEHL. AND
HERMINE SNEGGED VIXTER DRLIM, IT S ENLY VHL LHE ACTS LIKE IT S
SHEMETHING DISGLISTING, REHN, AND THAT S BECALISE VHL VE GET ABELT AS
MLCH EXPERIENCE AS A TWELVE-YEAR-ELD! AND WITH TEAT, SHE STHRRD
ALAY, HARRY ELICKLY LET GE HE REHN, THE LHHX EN HIS FACE WAS
MLRDERHLS, THEY KHTH STHH THERE, KRATHING HEAVILY, UNTIL MRS.
NHRIS, FILCH S CAT, APPEARED ARHLND THE CHRRNR, LHEH KRRKE THE
TENSINN, L MEN, SAID HARRY, AS THE SHLND HE FILCH S SHLPLING FEET
REACHED THEIR EARS, THEY HLRRIED LIP THE STAIRS AND ALENG A
SEVENTH-FLHH CHRRIDHR, HI, HLT HE TE WAY? REHN KARRD AT A
SMALL GIRL LHE ILMPD IN FRIGHT AND DRHPED A BHTLE HE
THADSPALN, HARRY HARDLY NHTICKED THE SHLND HE SHATTERING GLASS,
HE FELT DISHRIENTED, DIZZY, BEING STRICK BY A LIGH-TNING BHT MLST BE
SHEMETHING LIKE THIS, IT S ILST BECALISE SHE S REHN S SISTER, HE THLD
HIMSELF, VHL ILST DIDN T LIKE SRING HER KISSING DEAN BECALISE SHE S
REHN S SISTER. BLT LNKIDEN INTH HIS MIND CAME AN IMAGE HE TEAT
SAME DESERTED CHRRIDHR WITH HIMSELF KISSING CINDY INSTEAD. THE
MHNSTER IN HIS CHEST PLRRD BLT THEN HE SAW REHN RIPPING
HOPEN THE TAPESTRY CLRTAIN AND DRALING HIS HAND EN HARRY,
SHHLTING THINGS LIKE BETRAYAL HE TRLIST SLPPHSED THE BE MY
FRIEND D VHL THIND HERMINE DID SNHG DRLIM? REHN ASKED
ABRLPTLY, AS THEY APPREHACHED THE FAT LADY, HARRY GAVE A GLITTY
START AND WRENCHED HIS IMAGINATION ALAY FREEM A CHRRIDHR IN
WHICH NH REHN INTRLDED, IN WHICH HE AND CINDY WERE HLITE ALENG
WHAT? HE SAID CHNLISEDLY, EN ER THE HNNEST ANSWER
WAS YES, BLT HE DID NHT WANT TE GIVE IT, HHEWER, REHN SEEMD TE
GATHER THE WHRRST FREEM THE LHHX EN HARRY S FACE, DILLIGREHLT, HE
SAID DARKLY TE THE FAT LADY, AND THEY CLIMED TEHRLGH THE PHRTAIT
HHLR INTH THE CHMTHN RHHM, NEITHER HE THEM MENTIONED CINDY HE
HERMINE AGAIN; INDEED, THEY KARELY SPEEDE TE EACH EETHER TEAT
EVENING AND GET INTH BED IN SILENCE, EACH ARSHRED IN HIS HLIN
TEHLGHTS, HARRY LAY ALAKE FER A LENG TIME, LHHXING LIP AT THE
CANDPY HE HIS PHLRPESTER AND TRYING TE CHNVINCE HIMSELF TEAT HIS
FEELINGS FER CINDY WERE ENTIRELY ELDER-KRETHERLY, THEY HAD LIVED,
HAD THEY NHT, LIKE KRETHEER AND SISTER ALL SLMPER, PLAYING
HLIDITCH, TEASING REHN, AND HAVING A LALGH ABELT BILL AND
PHLEGH HE HAD KNHWN CINDY FER YEARS NEHL. IT WAS NATURAL

THAT HE SHOULD FEEL PROTECTIVE NATURAL THAT HE SHOULD WANT THE
BLOOD HUNT FOR HER WANT THE RIP DEAN LIKE FROM LIKE FOR KISSING
HER NO HE WOULD HAVE THE CENTRAL THAT PARTICULAR
BROTHERLY FEELING. REEN GAVE A GREAT GRUNTING SOUND. SHE S
REEN S SISTER, HARRY TOLD HIMSELF FIRMLY, REEN S SISTER, SHE S HUNT-
HOUNDS, HE WOULD NOT RISK HIS FRIENDSHIP WITH REEN FOR
ANYTHING. HE PUNCHED HIS PILLER INTO A MORE COMFORTABLE SHAPE
AND WAITED FOR SLEEP TO COME, TRYING HIS UTMOST NOT TO ALLOW HIS
THOUGHTS TO STRAY ANYWHERE NEAR GINDY. HARRY ALONE NEXT
MORNING FEELING SLIGHTLY DAZED AND CONFUSED BY A SERIES OF DREAMS
IN WHICH REEN HAD CHASED HIM WITH A BEATER S KAT, BUT BY MIDDAY HE
WOULD HAVE HAPPILY EXCHANGED THE DREAM REEN FOR THE REAL ONE,
WHICH WAS NOT ONLY CHILD-STUNNING GINDY AND DEAN, BUT ALSO
TREATING A FLIRT AND REVERBERATED HERMINE WITH AN ICY, SNEERING
INDIFFERENCE. WHAT WAS MORE, REEN SEEMED TO HAVE RETURNED,
EVERY NIGHT, AS THICKY AND READY TO LAST HUNT AS THE AVERAGE BLAST-
ENDED SKELET, HARRY SPENT THE DAY ATTEMPTING TO KEEP THE PEACE
BETWEEN REEN AND HERMINE WITH NO SUCCESS; FINALLY, HERMINE
DEPARTED FOR BED IN HIGH DUDGEON, AND REEN STALKED OFF THE THE KIDS
BIRMINGHAM AFTER SWEARING ANGRILY AT SEVERAL FRIGHTENED FIRST YEARS
FOR LOOKING AT HIM. THE HARRY S DISMAY, REEN S NEW AGGRESSIVENESS DID
NOT WEAR OFF EVER THE NEXT FEW DAYS. WHERE STILL, IT COINCIDED WITH
AN EVEN DEEPER DIP IN HIS KEEPING SKILLS, WHICH MADE HIM STILL MORE
AGGRESSIVE, SO THAT DURING THE FINAL BLINDFOLD PRACTICE BEFORE
SATURDAY S MATCH, HE FAILED TO SAVE EVERY SINGLE CHASEE THE CHASERS
AIMED AT HIM, BUT BELIEVED AT EVERYBODY SO MUCH THAT HE REDUCED
DEWEZIA REKINS TO TEARS. WHY SHUT UP AND LEAVE HER ALONE?
SHUTTED PEAKS, WHICH WAS ABOUT TWENTY-FIFTH REEN S HEIGHT, THOUGH
ADMITTEDLY CARRYING A HEAVY KAT. DUELLING? BELIEVED HARRY, WHICH
HAD SEEN GINDY GLENNING IN REEN S DIRECTION AND, REMEMBERING
HER REPUTATION AS AN ACCOMPLISHED MASTER OF THE KAT-KEEPER HER,
SHARED EVERY INTERVIEW BEFORE THINGS GOT OUT OF HAND. PEAKS,
GEE AND PAID UP THE DUDGERS, DEWEZIA, PULL YOURSELF TOGETHER, WHY
PLAYED REALLY WELL TODAY. REEN HE WAITED UNTIL THE REST OF THE
TEAM WERE OUT OF EARSHOT BEFORE SAYING IT, WHY AM MY BEST MATE,
BUT CARRY ON TREATING THE REST OF THEM LIKE THIS AND I M GOING TO
KICK YOU OFF THE TEAM. HE REALLY THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT THAT REEN
MIGHT HIT HIM, BUT THEN SOMETHING MUCH WORSE HAPPENED: REEN

SEEMED THE SAC IN HIS KNEE; ALL THE FIGHT WENT BLIT BY HIM AND HE SAID, I RESIGN, I M PATHETIC. YEL RE NOT PATHETIC AND YEL RE NOT RESIGNING; SAID FARRY FIRCELY, SEIZING REN BY THE FRONT OF HIS REEKS. YEL CAN SAY ANYTHING WHEN YEL RE IN FIRM, IT S A MENTAL PROBLEM YEL YR GHT? YEL CALLING ME MENTAL? YEAH, MAYBE I AM? THEY GLARED AT EACH OTHER FOR A MOMENT, THEN REN SHOOK HIS HEAD WEARILY. I KNOW YEL HAVEN T GHT ANY TIME THE FIND ANOTHER DEEPER, SH I LL PLAY THEMSELVES, BUT IF WE LSE, AND WE WILL, I M TAKING MYSELF OFF THE TEAM. NOTHING FARRY SAID MADE ANY DIFFERENCE. HE TRIED EXHUSTING REN S CONFIDENCE ALL THROUGH DINNER, BUT REN WAS TOO BUSY BEING GRUMPY AND SLURRY WITH FERMINE THE NUTTER. FARRY PERSISTED IN THE CHIMPIN REHEM THAT EVENING, BUT HIS ASSERTION THAT THE WHOLE TEAM WOULD BE DEVASTATED IF REN LEFT WAS SOMEWHAT UNDERMINED BY THE FACT THAT THE REST OF THE TEAM WAS SITTING IN A Huddle IN A DISTANT CHURCH, CLEARLY MUTTERING ABOUT REN AND CASTING HIM NASTY LOOKS. FINALLY FARRY TRIED GETTING ANGRY AGAIN IN THE HOPE OF PROVOKING REN INTO A DEFIANT, AND EMPERALLY CHAL-SAVING, ATTITUDE, BUT THIS STRATEGY DID NOT APPEAR THE WHOLE ANY BETTER THAN ENCOURAGEMENT; REN WENT THE RED AS DEJECTED AND HELPLESS AS EVER. FARRY LAY AWAKE FOR A VERY LONG TIME IN THE DARKNESS. HE DID NOT WANT THE LSE THE UPCOMING MATCH; NOT ONLY WAS IT HIS FIRST AS CAPTAIN, BUT HE WAS DETERMINED THE BEAT BRACH MALPHY AT ELIDITCH EVEN IF HE COULD NOT YET PROVE HIS SUSPICIONS ABOUT HIM. YET IF REN PLAYED AS HE HAD DONE IN THE LAST FEW PRACTICES, THEIR CHANCES OF WINNING WERE VERY SLIM. IF ONLY THERE WAS SOMETHING HE COULD DO TO MAKE REN PULL HIMSELF TOGETHER MAKE HIM PLAY AT THE TOP OF HIS FORM SOMETHING THAT WOULD ENSURE THAT REN HAD A REALLY GOOD DAY. AND THE ANSWER CAME TO FARRY IN ONE, SLIDEN, CLERICALS STRIDE OF INSPIRATION. BREAKFAST WAS THE USUAL EXCITABLE AFFAIR NEXT MORNING; THE SLYTHERINS HISSED AND SNEERED LOUDLY AS EVERY MEMBER OF THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM ENTERED THE GREAT HALL. FARRY GLANCED AT THE CEILING AND SAW A CLEAR, PALE BLUE SKY; A GOOD OMEN. THE GRYFFINDOR TABLE, A SHED MASS OF RED AND GOLD, CHIRPED AS FARRY AND REN APPROACHED. FARRY GRINNED AND WAVED; REN GRIMACED WEARILY AND SHOOK HIS HEAD. CHEER UP, REN; CALLED LAVENDER. I KNOW YEL LL BE BRILLIANT; REN IGNORED HER. TEA? FARRY ASKED HIM. CHEER? PLIMPTON ILIKE? ANYTHING, SAID REN GRUMPY, TAKING A

NINE O'CLOCK TIME OF THEAST, A FEW MINUTES LATER HERMIONE, WHO HAD BECOME
SHE TIED HER HAIR IN RECENT UNPLEASANT REASONING THAT SHE HAD NOT
COME DOWN THE BREAKFAST WITH THEM, PALSED HER WAY UP THE TABLE.

HOW ARE YOU BOTH FEELING? SHE ASKED TENTATIVELY, HER EYES ON
THE BACK OF HER'S HEAD. FINE, SAID HARRY, WHO WAS CONCENTRATING
ON HANDING HER A GLASS OF PUMPKIN JUICE. THERE YOU GO, HER.
DRINK UP. HER HAD JUST RAISED THE GLASS TO HIS LIPS WHEN
HERMIONE SPEAKED SHARPLY. DON'T DRINK THAT, HER! BOTH HARRY
AND HER LOOKED UP AT HER. WHY NOT? SAID HER. HERMIONE WAS
NOW STARING AT HARRY AS THOUGH SHE COULD NOT BELIEVE HER EYES.

YOU JUST PUT SOMETHING IN THAT DRINK. EXCUSE ME? SAID HARRY.

YOU HEARD ME, I SAW YOU, YOU JUST TIPPED SOMETHING INTO HER'S
DRINK. YOU'VE GOT THE KETTLE IN YOUR HAND RIGHT NOW! I DON'T
KNOW WHAT YOU'RE TALKING ABOUT, SAID HARRY, STEALING THE LITTLE
KETTLE HASTILY IN HIS POCKET. HER, I WARN YOU, DON'T DRINK IT!
HERMIONE SAID AGAIN, ALARMED, BUT HER PICKED UP THE GLASS, DRAINED
IT IN ONE GLIMP, AND SAID, STOP BISSING ME ABOUT, HERMIONE. SHE
LOOKED SCANDALIZED, REMINDING HER THAT ONLY HARRY COULD HEAR
HER, SHE HISSED, YOU SHOULD BE EXPELLED FOR THAT. I'D NEVER HAVE
BELIEVED IT OF YOU, HARRY! HARRY WHO WAS TALKING, HE WHISPERED
BACK, UNBLINDED ANYONE LATELY? SHE STORMED UP THE TABLE AWAY
FROM THEM, HARRY WATCHED HER GO WITH LITTLE REGRET, HERMIONE HAD
NEVER REALLY UNDERSTOOD WHAT A SERIOUS BUSINESS HOGWITCH WAS.
HE THEN LOOKED ABOUT AT HER, WHO WAS SMACKING HIS LIPS.

NINE O'CLOCK TIME, SAID HARRY BLITHELY, THE FRESH GRASS CRINKLED
UNDERNEATH AS THEY STRODE DOWN THE THE STADIUM. PRETTY NICE THE
WEATHER IS THIS EVENING, ISN'T IT? HARRY ASKED HER. YES, SAID HER, WHO
WAS PALE AND SICK-LOOKING. GINNY AND DEMLA WERE ALREADY
WEARING THEIR HOGWITCH ROBES AND WAITING IN THE CHANGING ROOM.

CONDITIONS WERE IDEAL, SAID GINNY, IGNORING HER. AND GUESS
WHAT? THAT SLYTHERIN CHASER VASEY HE THREW A BLUDGEON IN THE
HEAD YESTERDAY DURING THEIR PRACTICE, AND HE'S THEN SHOT THE PLAY!
AND EVEN BETTER THAN THAT MALFOY'S GONE OFF SICK THEM!

WHAT? SAID HARRY, WHISKING ABOUT THE STARE AT HER. HE'S ILL?
WHAT'S WRONG WITH HIM? NO IDEA, BUT IT'S GREAT FOR US, SAID
GINNY BRIGHTLY. THEY'RE PLAYING HARPER INSTEAD! HE'S IN MY YEAR
AND HE'S AN IDIOT. HARRY SMILED BACK VAGUELY, BUT AS HE PULLED ON
HIS SCARLET ROBES HIS MIND WAS FAR FROM HOGWITCH, MALFOY HAD SINCE

KEPPEER CLAIMED HE COULD NOT PLAY DUE THE INJURY, BUT HEN THAT
ECCASION HE HAD MADE SURE THE WHOLE MATCH WAS RESCHEDULED FOR A
TIME THAT SUITED THE SLYTHERINS BETTER. WHY WAS HE BEEN HAPPY THE
LET A SUBSTITUE GO HEN? WAS HE REALLY ILL, OR WAS HE FAKING? FIRST,
ISN'T IT? HE SAID IN AN UNDERSTONE THE REIN. MALPHE NOT PLAYING?

LARRY, I CALL IT, SAID REIN, LOOKING SLIGHTLY MORE ANIMATED. AND
VAISEY HFF THEM, HE'S THEIR BEST CHAL SCHERER, I DIDN'T FANCY HFF?
HE SAID SLIDENLY, FREEZING HALFWAY THROUGH PULLING HEN HIS
DEEPER'S CLOVES AND STARING AT LARRY. WHAT? I YELL
REIN HAD DROPPED HIS VEIL, HE LOOKED BOTH SCARED AND EXCITED. MY
DRINK MY PLIMPTON ILICE YELL DIDN'T? LARRY RAISED HIS
EYEBROWS, BUT SAID NOTHING EXCEPT, WE'LL BE STARTING IN ABOUT FIVE
MINUTES, YELL'D BETTER GET YOUR KICKS HEN. THEY WALKED OUT INTO
THE PITCH THE TUMBLINGHILLS RHARS AND KICKS, HEN END OF THE STADIUM
WAS SHED RED AND GOLD; THE OTHER, A SEA OF GREEN AND SILVER. MANY
FLIPFLOPS AND RAVENCLAWS HAD TAKEN SIDES THEM; AMIDST ALL THE
YELLING AND CLAPPING LARRY COULD DISTINCTLY HEAR THE RHAR OF
LINA LEEVECHND'S FAMILIS LIND-THROPPED HAT. LARRY STEPPED UP THE
MADAM LEECH, THE REFEREE, WHO WAS STANDING READY TO RELEASE THE
BALLS FROM THE CRATE. CAPTAINS SHAKE HANDS, SHE SAID, AND LARRY
HAD HIS HAND CRUSHED BY THE NEW SLYTHERIN CAPTAIN, LIRELHART.

MELINT YOUR KICKS, HEN THE WHISTLE THREE TWO HEN
THE WHISTLE SHOUNED, LARRY AND THE OTHERS KICKED HFF HARD FROM
THE FROZEN GRHLIND, AND THEY WERE AWAY. LARRY SHARED AROUND THE
PERIMETER OF THE GRHLINDS, LOOKING AROUND FOR THE SNITCH AND
KEEPING HEN EYE HEN LARPER, WHO WAS ZIGZAGGING FAR BEHIND HIM.
THEN A VEHICLE THAT WAS LARRINGLY DIFFERENT THE THE USUAL
COMMENTATOR'S STARTED UP. WELL, THERE THEY GO, AND I THINK WE'RE
ALL SURPRISED TO SEE THE TEAM THAT PUTTER'S PUT TOGETHER THIS
YEAR. MANY THELIGHT, GIVEN REINALD LEASLEY'S PATCHY PERFORMANCE
AS DEEPER LAST YEAR, THAT HE MIGHT BE HFF THE TEAM, BUT OF COURSE, A
CLOSE PERSONAL FRIENDSHIP WITH THE CAPTAIN DOES HELP. THESE
WORDS WERE GREETED WITH YELLS AND APPLAUSE FROM THE SLYTHERIN END
OF THE PITCH. LARRY CRANED AROUND HEN HIS KICKS THE LOOK TOWARD
THE COMMENTATOR'S PODIUM. A TALL, SKINNY KLEND KID WITH AN
UPTURNED NOSE WAS STANDING THERE, TALKING INTO THE MAGICAL
MEGAPHONE THAT HAD HENCE BEEN LEE JORDAN'S; LARRY RECOGNIZED
ZACHARIAS SMITH, A FLIPFLOP PLAYER WITH WHOM HE HEARTILY DISLIKED.

HEH, AND HERE COMES SLYTHERIN'S FIRST ATTEMPT HEN CHAL, IT'S
 UNWELIHEART STREAKING DOWN THE PITCH AND HARRY'S STOMACH
 TURNED OVER. WEASLEY SAYS IT, WELL, HE'S BEHIND THE GET BUCKY
 SOMETIMES, I SUPPOSE. THAT'S RIGHT, SMITH, HE IS, MUTTERED
 HARRY, GRINNING TO HIMSELF, AS HE DIVED AMONGST THE CHASERS WITH
 HIS EYES SEARCHING ALL AROUND FOR SOME HINT OF THE ELLIOTIVE SNITCH.
 WITH HALF AN HOUR OF THE GAME GONE, GRYFFINDOR WERE LEADING
 SIXTY POINTS TO ZERO, THEN HAVING MADE SOME TRULY SPECTACULAR
 SAVES, SOME BY THE VERY TIPS OF HIS GLOVES, AND GINNY HAVING
 SCORED FOUR OF GRYFFINDOR'S SIX GOALS. THIS EFFECTIVELY STOPPED
 ZACHARIAS WONDERING HEAVILY WHETHER THE TWO WEASLEYS WERE ONLY
 THERE BECAUSE HARRY LIKED THEM, AND HE STARTED HIS PRADDS AND
 CHUTE INSTEAD. HE CHUCKED, CHUTE ISN'T REALLY THE USUAL BUILD FOR A
 BEATER, SAID ZACHARIAS HEFTILY, THEY'RE GENERALLY GET A BIT MORE
 MUSCLE. HIT A BLUDGER AT HIM? HARRY CALLED THE CHUTE AS HE
 ZOOMED PAST, BUT CHUTE, GRINNING BROADLY, CHASE THE AIM THE NEXT
 BLUDGER AT HARPER INSTEAD, WHEN WAS JUST PASSING HARRY IN THE
 OPPOSITE DIRECTION, HARRY WAS PLEASED TO HEAR THE DULL THUNDER
 THAT MEANT THE BLUDGER HAD FOUND ITS MARK. IT SEEMED AS THOUGH
 GRYFFINDOR COULD BE SEE WINNING, AGAIN AND AGAIN THEY SCORED, AND
 AGAIN AND AGAIN, AT THE OTHER END OF THE PITCH, THEN SAVED GOALS
 WITH APPARENT EASE. HE WAS ACTUALLY SMILING NOW, AND WHEN THE
 CROWD GREETED A PARTICULARLY GOOD SAVE WITH A RUSHING CHORUS OF
 THE OLD FAVORITE WEASLEY IS OUR KING, HE PRETENDED TO CONDUCT
 THEM FROM HIS HIGH. THINKS HE'S SOMETHING SPECIAL TODAY, DOESN'T
 HE? SAID A SNIDE VOICE, AND HARRY WAS NEARLY DROPPED OFF HIS
 KNEES AS HARPER COLLIDED WITH HIM HARD AND DELIBERATELY. FOUR
 BLEND-TRAITOR PAH MADAM HUNCH'S BACK WAS TURNED, AND
 THOUGH GRYFFINDORS KEELER SMILED IN ANGER, BY THE TIME SHE
 LOOKED AROUND, HARPER HAD ALREADY SPED OFF, HIS SMILING ACTING,
 HARRY RACED AFTER HIM, DETERMINED TO RAM HIM BACK. AND I
 THINK HARPER OF SLYTHERIN'S SEEN THE SNITCH? SAID ZACHARIAS
 SMITH THROUGH HIS MEGAPHONE. YES, HE'S CERTAINLY SEEN
 SOMETHING BETTER HASN'T? SMITH REALLY WAS AN IDIOT, THOUGH
 HARRY, HADN'T HE NOTICED THEM COLLIDE? BUT NEXT MOMENT, HIS
 STOMACH SEEMED TO DREPP OUT OF THE SKY. SMITH WAS RIGHT AND
 HARRY WAS WINNING! HARPER HAD NOT SPED UPWARD AT RANDOM; HE HAD
 SPOTTED WHAT HARRY HAD NOT! THE SNITCH WAS SPEEDING ALONG HIGH

AROUND THEM, GLINTING BRIGHTLY AGAINST THE CLEAR BLUE SKY, HARRY
ACCELERATED; THE WIND WAS WHISTLING IN HIS EARS AND THAT IT DRIVEN
ALL BEHIND HIM SMITH'S COMMENTARY FOR THE CRICKET, BUT HARRY WAS
STILL AHEAD OF HIM, AND GRYFFINDOR WAS ONLY A HUNDRED FEET'S UP;
IF HARRY GOT THERE FIRST GRYFFINDOR HAD WIST AND WHEN HARRY
WAS FREE FROM IT, HIS HAND WAS STRETCHED. HI, HARRY! YELLED
HARRY IN DESPERATION. HOW MUCH DID MALFOY PAY YOU TO CHEAT HIM
INSTEAD OF HIM? HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT MADE HIM SAY IT, BUT
HARRY DID A DOUBLE-TAKE; HE FUMBLERED THE SNITCH, LET IT SLIP
THROUGH HIS FINGERS, AND SENT IT RIGHT PAST IT, HARRY MADE A GREAT
SWIPE FOR THE TINY, FLUTTERING BALL AND CAUGHT IT. YES! HARRY
YELLED, WHIRLING AROUND, HE WHIRLED BACK TOWARD THE CRICKET, THE
SNITCH HELD HIGH IN HIS HAND, AS THE CRICKET REALIZED WHAT HAD
HAPPENED, A GREAT SHOUT WENT UP THAT ALMOST DROVE THE SOUND
OF THE WHISTLE THAT SIGNALLED THE END OF THE GAME. GINNY, WHERE ARE
YOU GOING? YELLED HARRY, WHO HAD FOUND HIMSELF TRAPPED IN THE
MIDST OF A MASS MIDAIR FLY WITH THE REST OF THE TEAM, BUT GINNY
SPED RIGHT ON PAST THEM UNTIL, WITH AN ALMIGHTY CRASH, SHE
COLLIDED WITH THE COMMENTATOR'S PODIUM. AS THE CRICKET STRUCKED AND
LAUGHED, THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM LANDED BESIDE THE WRECKAGE OF WHICH
UNDER WHICH ZACHARIAS WAS FREELY STIRRING; HARRY HEARD GINNY
SAYING BLITHELY TO AN IRATE PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, FRIGHTENED THE
BRACK, PROFESSOR, SHIRAZ. LAUGHING, HARRY BROKE FREE OF THE REST
OF THE TEAM AND HUGGED GINNY, BUT LET GO VERY QUICKLY, AVOIDING
HER GAZE, HE CLAPPED A CHEERING RHYTHM ON THE BACK INSTEAD AS, ALL
ENMITY FORGOTTEN, THE GRYFFINDOR TEAM LEFT THE PITCH ARM IN ARM,
PUNCHING THE AIR AND WAVING THEIR SLIPPERS. THE
ATMOSPHERE IN THE CHANGING ROOM WAS ILLEGANT. PARTY UP IN THE
CHANGING ROOM, SEARIS SAID! YELLED DEAN EXUBERANTLY. I MEAN,
GINNY, DEMELZA! RHYTHM AND HARRY WERE THE LAST TWO IN THE
CHANGING ROOM. THEY WERE JUST ABOUT TO LEAVE WHEN HERMIONE
ENTERED. SHE WAS TWISTING HER GRYFFINDOR SCARF IN HER HANDS AND
LOOKED UPSET BUT DETERMINED. I WANT A WORD WITH YOU, HARRY. SHE
TOOK A DEEP BREATH. YOU SHOULDN'T HAVE DONE IT, YOU HEARD
SLIGHTLY, IT'S ILLEGAL. WHAT ARE YOU GOING TO DO, TURN US IN?
DEMANDED RHYTHM. WHAT ARE YOU TWO TALKING ABOUT? ASKED HARRY,
TURNING AWAY THE HAND UP HIS NECKS AND THAT NEITHER OF THEM WOULD
SEE HIM GRINNING. YOU KNOW PERFECTLY WELL WHAT WE'RE TALKING

AKELT? SAID FERMINE SHRILLY. YEL SPIDED REIN S ILICE WITH LICKY
PHTIEN AT BREAKFAST? FELIX FELIX? NOH I DIDN T, SAID HARRY,
TURNING BACK THE FACE THEM KEETH. YES YEL DID, HARRY, AND THAT S
WHY EVERYTHING WENT RIGHT, THERE WERE SLYTERIN PLAYERS MISSING
AND REIN SAVED EVERYTHING? I DIDN T PUT IT IN? SAID HARRY,
GRINNING BROADLY, HE SLIPPED HIS HAND INSIDE HIS JACKET POCKET AND
DREW OUT THE TINY KETTLE THAT FERMINE HAD SEEN IN HIS HAND THAT
MORNING. IT WAS FULL OF CHILDEN PHTIEN AND THE CHRD WAS STILL
TIGHTLY SEALED WITH WAX. I WANTED REIN THE THING I D DONE IT, SEE I
PACKED IT WHEN I DREW YEL WERE WHEDDING. HE WHEDD AT REIN. YEL
SAVED EVERYTHING BECAUSE YEL FELT LICKY, YEL DID IT ALL YELRSELF,
HE POCKETED THE PHTIEN AGAIN. THERE REALLY WASN T ANYTHING IN
MY PLUMPOIN ILICE? REIN SAID, ASTHENDED. BUT THE WEATHER S GOOD

AND FAISY CHILDEN T PLAY. I HONESTLY HAVEN T BEEN GIVEN
LICKY PHTIEN? HARRY SHOOK HIS HEAD, REIN GAZED AT HIM FOR A
MOMENT, THEN WHEDD HIM FERMINE, IMITATING HER VOICE. YEL
ADDED FELIX FELIX THE REIN S ILICE THIS MORNING, THAT S WHY HE SAVED
EVERYTHING? SEE? I CAN SAVE CHALS WITH-OUT HELP, FERMINE? I
NEVER SAID YEL CHILDEN T REIN, YEL TELLIGHT YEL D BEEN GIVEN IT
THEH? BUT REIN HAD ALREADY STRODE PAST HER OUT OF THE DOOR WITH
HIS GRIMASTICK OVER HIS SHOLDER. ER, SAID HARRY INTO THE
SUDDEN SILENCE, HE HAD NOT EXPECTED HIS PLAN THE BACKFIRE LIKE THIS,

SHALL SHALL WE GO UP THE THE PARTY, THEN? YEL GO? SAID
FERMINE, BLINKING BACK TEARS. I M SICK OF REIN AT THE MOMENT, I
DIDN T KNOW WHAT I M SUPPOSED TO HAVE DONE. AND SHE STORMED
OUT OF THE CHANGING ROOMS THEN, HARRY WALKED SLEELY BACK UP THE
GRANDS TOWARD THE CASTLE THROUGH THE CORRID, MANY OF WHICH
SHOUTED CONGRATULATIONS AT HIM, BUT HE FELT A GREAT SENSE OF
LETDOWN, HE HAD BEEN SURE THAT IF REIN WON THE MATCH, HE AND
FERMINE WOULD BE FRIENDS AGAIN IMMEDIATELY. HE DID NOT SEE HOW
HE COULD POSSIBLY EXPLAIN THE FERMINE THAT WHAT SHE HAD DONE THE
EVENING REIN WAS MISS VICTOR KILIM, NOT WHEN THE OFFENSE HAD
DECLINED SHE HUNG AHEAD, HARRY COULD NOT SEE FERMINE AT THE
GRYFFINDOR CELEBRATION PARTY, WHICH WAS IN FULL SWING WHEN HE
ARRIVED, RENEWED CHEERS AND CLAPPING GREETED HIS APPEARANCE, AND
HE WAS SOON SURROUNDED BY A MOB OF PEOPLE CONGRATULATING HIM,
WHAT WITH TRYING THE SHADE OF THE CREEPY KITCHENS, WHICH WANTED
A KEEY-KEEY MATCH ANALYSIS, AND THE LARGE GROUP OF GIRLS THAT

ENCIRLED HIM, LAUGHING AT HIS LEAST AMUSING COMMENTS AND BATTING THEIR EYELIDS, IT WAS SOME TIME BEFORE HE COULD TRY AND FIND REIN. AT LAST, HE EXTRICATED HIMSELF FROM REMILDA VANE, WHO WAS HINTING HEAVILY THAT SHE WOULD LIKE TO GO TO THE SLUGGISH CHRISTMAS PARTY WITH HIM. AS HE WAS GLANCING TOWARD THE DRINKS TABLE, HE WALKED STRAIGHT INTO GINNY, ARNOLD THE PYROMANIC RACING MAN HER SHOULDERS AND CRIBBAGE-MAIDS MELTING HOPEFULLY AT HER FEET.

LOOKING FOR REIN? SHE ASKED, SMIRKING. HE'S OVER THERE, THE FILTHY HYPOCRITE. HARRY LOOKED INTO THE CORNER SHE WAS INDICATING. THERE, IN FULL VIEW OF THE WHOLE ROOM, STOOD REIN WRAPPED SHE CLOSELY AROUND LAVENDER GREEN. IT WAS HARD TO TELL WHOSE HANDS WERE WHOSE. IT LOOKS LIKE HE'S EATING HER FACE, DOESN'T IT? SAID GINNY DISPASSIONATELY. BUT I SUPPOSE HE'S GOT THE REFINED TECHNICAL SKILLS. GOOD GAVE, HARRY. SHE PATTED HIM ON THE ARM. HARRY FELT A SWEEPING SENSATION IN HIS STOMACH, BUT THEN SHE WALKED OFF AND HELPED HERSELF THE MORE CLATTERING. CRIBBAGE-MAIDS TRETTED AFTER HER, HIS YELLOW EYES FIXED UPON ARNOLD. HARRY TURNED AWAY FROM REIN, WHO DID NOT LOOK LIKE HE WOULD BE SURFACING SOON, JUST AS THE PORTRAIT FRAME WAS CLOSING. WITH A STINKING FEELING, HE REALIZED HE SAW A MANE OF BLISTERY GREEN HAIR WHIPPING OUT OF SIGHT. HE DARTED FORWARD, SIDESTEPED REMILDA VANE AGAIN, AND PULSED OPEN THE PORTRAIT OF THE FAT LADY. THE HALLWAY HILLSIDE SEEMED TO BE DESERTED. HERMIONE? HE ASKED HER IN THE FIRST LINGERING CLASSROOM HE TRIED. SHE WAS SITTING ON THE TEACHER'S DESK, ALONE EXCEPT FOR A SMALL RING OF TWITTERING YELLOW BIRDS CIRCLING HER HEAD, WHICH SHE HAD CLEARLY JUST CONJURED OUT OF MIDAIR. HARRY COULD NOT HELP ADMIRING HER SPELL-WEAVE AT A TIME LIKE THIS. EH, HELLO, HARRY, SHE SAID IN A BRITTLE VOICE. I WAS JUST PRACTICING. Yeah, they are so really good. SAID HARRY. HE HAD NO IDEA WHAT TO SAY TO HER. HE WAS JUST WONDERING WHETHER THERE WAS ANY CHANCE THAT SHE HAD NOT NOTICED REIN, THAT SHE HAD MERELY LEFT THE ROOM BECAUSE THE PARTY WAS A LITTLE TOO RELENTLESS, WHEN SHE SAID, IN AN UNNATURALLY HIGH-PITCHED VOICE, REIN SEEMS TO BE ENJOYING THE CELEBRATIONS. ER, DOES HE? SAID HARRY. DOESN'T PRETEND YOU DIDN'T SEE HIM, SAID HERMIONE. HE WASN'T EXACTLY HIDING IT, WAS HE? THE OTHER BEHIND THEM BURST OPEN. THE HARRY'S FURROW, REIN CAME IN, LAUGHING, PULLING LAVENDER BY THE HAND. EH, HE SAID, DRAWING LIP SLIGHT AT THE

SIGHT OF HARRY AND HERMIONE. SHEETS SAID LAVENDER, AND SHE
BACKED OUT OF THE ROOM, GIGGLING. THE OTHER SWING SLIT BEHIND HER.
THERE WAS A TERRIBLE, SWELLING, KILLING SILENCE. HERMIONE WAS
STARING AT RON, WHO REPLIED THE LOOK AT HER, BUT SAID WITH AN EDD
MIXTURE OF RAVAGE AND APOLOGY. HI, HARRY? WONDERED WHERE
YOU'D GET THE HERMIONE SLID OFF THE DESK. THE LITTLE FLOCK OF
CHILDEN KIDS CONTINUED THE TWITTER IN CIRCLES AROUND HER HEAD SHE
THAT SHE LOOKED LIKE A STRANGE, FEATHERY MODEL OF THE SOLAR SYSTEM.
YOU SHOULDNT LEAVE LAVENDER WAITING OUTSIDE. SHE SAID QUIETLY.
SHE LL WONDER WHERE YOU'VE GONE. SHE WALKED VERY SILENTLY AND
DIRECTLY TOWARD THE OTHER. HARRY GLANCED AT RON, WHO WAS LOOKING
RELIEVED THAT NOTHING WORSE HAD HAPPENED. HAPPENED? CAME A
SHRIEK FROM THE OTHERWAY. HARRY SPUN AROUND TO SEE HERMIONE
POINTING HER FINGER AT RON, HER EXPRESSION WILD. THE LITTLE FLOCK
OF KIDS WAS SPEEDING LIKE A FAL OF FAT CHILDEN BULLETS TOWARD RON,
WHO YELLED AND COVERED HIS FACE WITH HIS HANDS, BUT THE KIDS
ATTACKED, PICKING AND CLAWING AT EVERY BIT OF FLESH THEY COULD
REACH. GRRRRRRRR! HE YELLED, BUT WITH ONE LAST LOOK OF
VINDICTIVE FLARE, HERMIONE WRENCHED OPEN THE OTHER AND DISAPPEARED
THROUGH IT. HARRY THOUGHT HE HEARD A SHE BEHIND IT SLAMMED. THE
UNBREAKABLE VELL SHELL WAS SWIRLING AGAINST THE ICE WINDMILLS
HENCE MORE. CHRISTMAS WAS APPROACHING FAST. HAGRID HAD ALREADY
SINGLE-HANDEDLY DELIVERED THE USUAL TWELVE CHRISTMAS TREES FOR THE
GREAT HALL; GARLANDS OF HELL AND TINSEL HAD BEEN TWISTED AROUND
THE BANISTERS OF THE STAIRS; EVERLASTING CANDLES GLOWED FROM INSIDE
THE HELMETS OF SLITS OF ARMOR AND GREAT CLINCHERS OF MISTLETOE HAD
BEEN FLUNG AT INTERVALS ALONG THE CORRIDORS. LARGE GROUPS OF
GIRLS TENDED THE CONVEYER UNDERNEATH THE MISTLETOE CLINCHERS EVERY
TIME HARRY WENT PAST, WHICH CAUSED BLOODAGES IN THE CORRIDORS;
FORTUNATELY, HOWEVER, HARRY'S FREQUENT NIGHTTIME WANDERINGS
HAD GIVEN HIM AN UNUSUALLY GOOD KNOWLEDGE OF THE CASTLE'S SECRET
PASSAGEWAYS, SO THAT HE WAS ABLE, WITHOUT THE MUCH DIFFICULTY, TO
NAVIGATE MISTLETOE-FREE ROUTES BETWEEN CLASSES. RON, WHO MIGHT
HENCE HAVE FELT THE NECESSITY OF THESE DETOURS A CALSE FOR
REALITY RATHER THAN HILARITY, SIMPLY BEAMED WITH LAUGHTER ABOUT
IT ALL. ALTHOUGH HARRY MUCH PREFERRED THIS NEW LAUGHING, HEARD
RON THE THE MERRY, AGGRESSIVE MODEL HE HAD BEEN ENDURING FOR THE
LAST FEW WEEKS, THE IMPROVED RON CAME AT A HEAVY PRICE. FIRSTLY,

FARRY HAD THE PLIT LIP WITH THE FREQUENT PRESENCE OF LAVENDER
BRIEN, WHO SEEMED THE REGARD AND MOMENT THAT SHE WAS NOT MISSING
REIN AS A MOMENT WASTED; AND SECONDLY, FARRY FELT HIMSELF SINCE
MORE THE BEST FRIEND OF TWO PEOPLE WHO SEEMED UNLIKELY EVER TO
SPREAD THE EACH OTHER AGAIN. REIN, WHOSE HANDS AND ARMS STILL
BORE SCRATCHES AND CUTS FROM FERMINE'S KID ATTACK, WAS TAKING A
DEFENSIVE AND RESSENTFUL TONE. SHE CAN'T COMPLAIN, HE TOLD FARRY.

SHE SMUGGED DRUM. SHE SHE'S FEELING BUT SOMEBODY WANTS TO SEE
ME THEN. WELL, IT'S A FREE COUNTRY, I HAVEN'T DONE ANYTHING WRONG.
FARRY DID NOT ANSWER, BUT PRETENDED TO BE ASKED IN THE ROOM
THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO HAVE READ KEITH CLARK'S NEXT MEETING
(HINTSSENCE: A HURST). DETERMINED AS HE WAS TO REMAIN FRIENDS
WITH BOTH REIN AND FERMINE, HE WAS SPENDING A LOT OF TIME WITH
HIS MOUTH SHUT TIGHT. I NEVER PROMISED FERMINE ANYTHING,
REIN MIMLED. I MEAN, ALL RIGHT, I WAS GOING TO GO TO SLUGGISH'S
CHRISTMAS PARTY WITH HER, BUT SHE NEVER SAID I WAS AS FRIENDS
I'M A FREE AGENT. FARRY TURNED A PAGE OF HINTSSENCE, AWARE
THAT REIN WAS WATCHING HIM. REIN'S WHEEL TAILED AWAY IN MUTTERS,
BARELY AUDIBLE OVER THE LOW CRACKLING OF THE FIRE, THOUGH FARRY
THOUGHT HE CAUGHT THE WORDS DRUM AND CAN'T COMPLAIN
AGAIN. FERMINE'S SCHEDULE WAS SET FULL THAT FARRY COULD ONLY
TALK TO HER PROPERLY IN THE EVENINGS, WHEN REIN WAS, IN ANY CASE,
SEE TIGHTLY WRAPPED AROUND LAVENDER THAT HE DID NOT NOTICE WHAT
FARRY WAS DOING. FERMINE REFUSED TO SIT IN THE COMMON ROOM
WHILE REIN WAS THERE, SO FARRY GENERALLY JOINED HER IN THE
LIBRARY, WHICH MEANT THAT THEIR CONVERSATIONS WERE HELD IN
WHISPERS. HE'S AT PERFECT LIBERTY TO KISS WHOMEVER HE LIKES, SAID
FERMINE, WHILE THE LIBRARIAN, MADAM PINCE, FROWLED THE SHELVES
BEHIND THEM. I REALLY COULDN'T CARE LESS. SHE RAISED HER EYEBROW AND
DIPPED AN I SHE PERCEIVEDLY THAT SHE PUNCTURED A HOLE IN HER
PARCHMENT. FARRY SAID NOTHING. HE THOUGHT HIS WHEEL MIGHT SEEM
VANISH FROM LACK OF USE. HE KENT A LITTLE LOWER EVER ADVANCED
PITCHING MAKING AND CONTINUED TO MAKE NOTES AND EVERLASTING
GLIMPS, OCCASIONALLY PAUSING TO DECIPHER THE PRINCE'S USEFUL
ADDITIONS TO LIBRARIAN'S TEXT. AND INCIDENTALLY, SAID
FERMINE, AFTER A FEW MOMENTS, YOU NEED TO BE CAREFUL. AFTER THE
LAST TIME, SAID FARRY, SPEAKING IN A SLIGHTLY HARSH WHISPER
AFTER THREE-QUARTERS OF AN HOUR OF SILENCE. I AM NOT GIVING BACK

THIS KID, I'VE LEARNED MORE FROM THE HALF-BLIND PRINCE THAN
SNAPPE HER SLUGGISHNESS HAVE TAUGHT ME IN I'M NOT TALKING
ABOUT YOUR STUPID SHE-CALLED PRINCE, SAID HERMIONE, GIVING HIS
KID A NASTY LOOK AS THOUGH IT HAD BEEN RUDE TO HER. I'M TALKING
ABOUT EARLIER. I WENT INTO THE GIRLS' BATHROOMS JUST BEFORE I CAME
IN HERE AND THERE WERE ABOUT A DOZEN GIRLS IN THERE, INCLUDING
THAT REMILDA VANE, TRYING TO DECIDE HOW THE SLIP THEY'VE
PUT ON. THEY'RE ALL THINKING THEY'RE GOING TO GET WHEN THEY TAKE THEM
THE SLUGGISHNESS PARTY, AND THEY ALL SEEM TO HAVE REJECTED FRED AND
GEORGE'S LOVE LETTERS, WHICH I'M AFRAID THEY SAY PROBABLY WOULD

WHY DIDN'T THEY CONSIDER THEM THEN? DEMANDED HARRY. IT SEEMED
EXTRAORDINARY THAT HERMIONE'S MANIA FOR LIFE-THREATENING RULES SHOULD
HAVE ABANDONED HER AT THIS CRUCIAL MOMENT. THEY DIDN'T HAVE
THE LETTERS WITH THEM IN THE BATHROOMS, SAID HERMIONE
SCORNFULLY. THEY WERE JUST DISCUSSING TACTICS. AS I DON'T KNOW WHETHER
EVEN THE HALF-BLIND PRINCE SHE GAVE THE KID ANOTHER NASTY
LOOK. CHILD DREAM UP AN ALIBI FOR A DOZEN DIFFERENT LOVE
LETTERS AT ONCE. I'D JUST INVITE SOMEONE TO GO WITH YOU, THAT IS
STOP ALL THE OTHERS THINKING THEY'VE STILL GOT A CHANCE. IT'S
THEIR LAST NIGHT, THEY'RE GETTING DESPERATE. THERE ISN'T ANYONE
I WANT TO INVITE, MURMURED HARRY, WHO WAS STILL TRYING NOT TO
THINK ABOUT GINNY AND MORE THAN HE COULD HELP, DESPITE THE FACT
THAT SHE KEPT CREEPING UP IN HIS DREAMS IN WAYS THAT MADE HIM
DEVILISHLY THANDFUL THAT SHE COULD NOT PERFORM LEGITIMATELY.

WELL, JUST BE CAREFUL WHAT YOU DRINK, BECAUSE REMILDA VANE
LOOKED LIKE SHE MEANT BUSINESS, SAID HERMIONE GRIMLY. SHE PITCHED
UP THE LONG ROLL OF PARCHMENT ON WHICH SHE WAS WRITING HER
ARTIFICIALITY ESSAY AND CONTINUED TO SCRATCH AWAY WITH HER QUILL.
HARRY WATCHED HER WITH HIS MIND A LONG WAY AWAY. HANGING A
MOMENT, HE SAID SLEAZE. I THOUGHT FILCH HAD EARNED ANYTHING
RECEIPT AT WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEAPONS? AND WHEN HAS ANYONE
EVER PAID ATTENTION TO WHAT FILCH HAS EARNED? ASKED HERMIONE,
STILL CONCENTRATING ON HER ESSAY. BUT I THOUGHT ALL THE BOOKS
WERE BEING SEARCHED. SHE FEEL LIKE THESE GIRLS ARE ABLE TO BRING LOVE
LETTERS INTO SCHOOL? FRED AND GEORGE SEND THEM DISGUISED AS
PERFUMES AND CHILDREN'S LETTERS, SAID HERMIONE. IT'S PART OF THEIR
HOLY ORDER SERVICE. YOU KNOW A LOT ABOUT IT. HERMIONE GAVE
HIM THE KIND OF NASTY LOOK SHE HAD JUST GIVEN HIS COPY OF

ADVANCED PERTHIN-MADING. IT WAS ALL WHEN THE BACK OF THE KETTLES THEY SEEMED GINNY AND ME IN THE SLUMPER, SHE SAID CHEERLY, I BEEN T CH ARIELND PLITTING PERTHINS IN PEOPLE S DRINKS HER PRETENDING THE EITHER, WHICH IS ILST AS BAD. YEAH, WELL, NEVER MIND THAT, SAID HARRY HELICELY. THE POINT IS, FILCH IS BEING FISHED, ISN T HE? THESE GIRLS ARE GETTING STUFF INTO THE SCHEMEL DISGUISED AS SOMETHING ELSE? SHE WED CHILDEN T MALTED HAVE KNIGHT THE NECKLACE INTO THE SCHEMEL ? EH, HARRY NEET THAT AGAIN. COME ON, WED NEET? DEMANDED HARRY, LEMME, SIGHED HERMIONE, SECRETLY SENSORS DETECT LINES, CLUSES, AND CONCEALMENT CHARMS, BEEN T THEY? THEY RE LIKED THE FIND DARK MAGIC AND DARK HEIKETS, THEY D HAVE PICKED UP A FEWERAL CLUSE, LIKE THE ONE IN THAT NECKLACE, WITHIN SECONDS, BUT SOMETHING THAT S ILST BEEN PUT IN THE WRING KETTLE WELLDN T REGISTER AND ANYWAY, LEVE PERTHINS AREN T DARK ER DANGEROUS. EASY FOR YELL TH SAY, MUTTERED HARRY, THINKING OF REMILDA VANE, SHE IT WELLD BE DEEN TH FILCH THE REALIZE IT WASN T A CHELCH PERTHIN, AND HE S NEET A VERY GOOD WIZARD, I BELLET HE CAN TELL HNE PERTHIN FROM HERMIONE STOPPED DEAD; HARRY HAD HEARD IT THEE, SOMEHOW HAD MOVED CHESE BEHIND THEM AMONG THE DARK KHEKSELVES, THEY WAITED, AND A MOMENT LATER THE VULTURELIKE CHELTERNANCE OF MADAM PINK APPEARED ARIELND THE CHORER, HER SLINDEN CHEEKS, HER SKIN LIKE PARCHMENT, AND HER LONG FISHED NESE ILLIMINATED LIMPATTERINGLY BY THE LAMP SHE WAS CARRYING. THE LIBRARY IS NEH CHESED, SHE SAID, MIND YELL RETURN ANYTHING YELL HAVE KHRARNED THE THE CHORRET WHAT HAVE YELL BEEN DHING TH THAT KHEK, YELL DEPRAYED KHY? IT ISN T THE LIBRARY S, IT S MINE! SAID HARRY HASTILY, SNATCHING HIS COPY OF ADVANCED PERTHIN-MADING OFF THE TABLE AS SHE LINGED AT IT WITH A CLALIKE HAND, DESPEILED? SHE HISSED, DESPERATED? REPELLED? IT S ILST A KHEK THAT S BEEN WRITTEN HNE? SAID HARRY, TUGGING IT ELT OF HER GRIP, SHE LEMED AS THOUGH SHE MIGHT HAVE A SEIZURE; HERMIONE, WHEH HAD HASTILY PACKED HER THINGS, GRABBED HARRY BY THE ARM AND FREEMARCHED HIM AWAY, SHE LL BAN YELL FROM THE LIBRARY IF YELL RE NEET CAREFUL, WED DID YELL HAVE TH BRING THAT STUPID KHEK? IT S NEET MY FAULT SHE S KARDING MAD, HERMIONE, HEH D YELL THINK SHE EVER-HEARD YELL BEING RLDE ARIELT FILCH? I VE ALWAYS THUGHT THERE MIGHT BE SOMETHING GHING HNE BETWEEN THEM.

EH, HA HA KNOWING THE FACT THAT THEY CHLD SPRAK NORMALLY

AGAIN, THEY MADE THEIR WAY ALONG THE DESERTED, LAMP-LIT CORRIDORS BACK TO THE CHEMISTS ROOM, ARGUING ABOUT WHETHER MR NEET FILCH AND MADAM PINK were secretly in love with each other. RABBIT, SAID HARRY THE FAT LADY, THIS BEING THE NEW, FESTIVE PASSWORD.

SAME THE YELL, SAID THE FAT LADY WITH A REGLISH GRIN, AND SHE SWUNG FORWARD TO ADMIT THEM. HI, HARRY? SAID RHEMILDA VANE, THE MOMENT HE HAD CLIMBED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE. FANCY A GILLYWATER? HERMIONE GAVE HIM A WHAT-DID-I-TELL-YOU? LOOK EVER HER SHOULDER. NO THANKS, SAID HARRY BLICKLY, I DONT LIKE IT MUCH. WELL, TAKE THESE ANYWAY, SAID RHEMILDA, THIRLISTING A BEEK INTO HIS HANDS. CHOCOLATE CALIBRENS, THEY VE GOT FIREWORKS IN THEM. MY GRAN SENT THEM TO ME, BUT I DONT LIKE THEM. HI RIGHT THANKS A LOT, SAID HARRY, WHO CHLD NOT THINK WHAT ELSE TO SAY. ER I M JUST GOING OVER HERE WITH THE FLORIED HOP BEHIND HERMIONE, HIS VEHICLE TAILING AWAY PEELY. THEO YELL, SAID HERMIONE SLICKINLY. SHEENER YELL ASK SHEMONE, SHEENER THEY LL ALL LEAVE YELL ALONE AND YELL CAN BUT HER FACE SLIDENLY TURNED BLANK; SHE HAD JUST SPOTTED ROSE AND LAVENDER, WHO WERE ENTWINED IN THE SAME ARMCHAIR. WELL, GOOD NIGHT, HARRY, SAID HERMIONE, THOUGH IT WAS ONLY SEVEN O CLOCKS IN THE EVENING, AND SHE LEFT HER THE GIRLS DORMITORY WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD. HARRY WENT TO BED CHASTISING HIMSELF THAT THERE WAS ONLY ONE MORE DAY OF LESSONS THE STRUGGLE THOUGH, ALLS SLEIGHORN S PARTY, AFTER WHICH HE AND ROSE WOULD DEPART TOGETHER FOR THE KLIRREL. IT NOW SEEMED IMPOSSIBLE THAT ROSE AND HERMIONE WOULD MAKE UP WITH EACH OTHER BEFORE THE HOLIDAYS BEGAN, BUT PERHAPS, SOMEHOW, THE BREAK WOULD GIVE THEM TIME TO CALM DOWN, THINK BETTER OF THEIR BEHAVIOR.

BUT HIS FEELINGS WERE NOT HIGH, AND THEY SANK STILL LOWER AFTER ENDURING A TRANSFIGURATION LESSON WITH THEM BOTH NEXT DAY. THEY HAD JUST EMBARKED UPON THE IMPENSELY DIFFICULT THING OF FLUMAN TRANSFIGURATION; WORKING IN FRONT OF MIRRORS, THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO BE CHANGING THE COLOR OF THEIR OWN EYEBROWS. HERMIONE LAUGHED LINDLY AT ROSE S DISASTROUS FIRST ATTEMPT, DURING WHICH HE SOMEHOW MANAGED TO GIVE HIMSELF A SPECTACULAR HANDBLEAK MUSTACHE; ROSE RETALIATED BY BEING A CRUEL BUT ACCURATE IMPRESSION OF HERMIONE LIMPING UP AND DOWN IN HER SEAT EVERY TIME PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ASKED A QUESTION, WHICH LAVENDER AND PARVATI FELT DEEPLY AMUSING AND WHICH REDUCED HERMIONE TO THE

WIPED HER TEARS AGAIN. SHE RACED OUT OF THE CLASSROOM AND THE BELL, LEAVING HALF HER THINGS BEHIND. HARRY, DECIDING THAT HER NEED WAS GREATER THAN HIS, SLID THEM, SCRAMLED UP HER REMAINING POSSESSIONS AND FOLLOWED HER. HE FINALLY TRACKED HER DOWN AS SHE EMERGED FROM A GIRLS BATHROOM AND THE FLOOR BELL. SHE WAS ACCOMPANIED BY LINA LEECHER, WHO WAS PATTING HER VAGUELY ON THE BACK. EH, HELLO HARRY, SAID LINA. DID YOU KNOW ONE OF YOUR EVERETTS IS RIGHT YET? HI, LINA, JEROME, YOU LEFT YOUR STUFF. HE HELD OUT HER BOOKS. EH YES, SAID JEROME IN A CHEERFUL VOICE, TAKING HER THINGS AND TURNING AWAY QUICKLY TO HIDE THE FACT THAT SHE WAS WIPING HER EYES WITH HER PENCIL CASE.

THANK YOU, HARRY, WELL, I'D BETTER GET GOING. AND SHE FLURRIED OFF, WITHOUT GIVING HARRY ANY TIME TO OFFER WORDS OF COMFORT, THOUGH ADMITTEDLY HE COULD NOT THINK OF ANY. SHE'S A KIT LIPSET, SAID LINA. I THOUGHT AT FIRST IT WAS MARIANNE MYRTLE IN THERE, BUT IT TURNED OUT TO BE JEROME. SHE SAID SOMETHING ABOUT THAT JOHN LEASLEY. Yeah, they've had a run, SAID HARRY. HE SAYS VERY FLINDY THINGS SOMETIMES, DOESN'T HE? SAID LINA, AS THEY SET OFF DOWN THE CORRIDOR TOGETHER. BUT HE CAN BE A KIT WINKING. I NOTICED THAT LAST YEAR. I SURE, SAID HARRY. LINA WAS DEMONSTRATING HER USUAL knack OF SPREADING UNCOMFORTABLE TRUTHS; HE HAD NEVER MET ANYONE ELITE LIKE HER. SHE HAVE YOU HAD A GOOD TERM? EH, IT'S BEEN ALL RIGHT, SAID LINA. A KIT LONELY WITHOUT THE D.A. GINNY'S BEEN NICE, THOUGH. SHE STOPPED TWO KIDS IN HER TRANSFIGURATION CLASS CALLING ME LONELY THE OTHER DAY.

THEN WOULD YOU LIKE TO COME TO SILVERHORN'S PARTY WITH ME TONIGHT? THE WORDS WERE OUT OF HARRY'S MOUTH BEFORE HE COULD STOP THEM; HE HEARD HIMSELF SAY THEM AS THOUGH IT WERE A STRANGER SPEAKING. LINA TURNED HER PRETENTLY EYES UPON HIM IN SURPRISE. SILVERHORN'S PARTY? WITH YOU? Yeah, SAID HARRY. WE'RE SUPPOSED TO BRING GUESTS, SEE I THOUGHT YOU MIGHT LIKE I MEAN. HE WAS BEEN TOO MADDEN HIS INTENTIONS PERFECTLY CLEAR. I MEAN, JUST AS FRIENDS, YOU KNOW, BUT IF YOU DON'T WANT TO. HE WAS ALREADY HALF HOPING THAT SHE DIDN'T WANT TO. EH, NO, I'D LOVE TO GO WITH YOU AS FRIENDS? SAID LINA, BEAMING AS HE HAD NEVER SEEN HER BEAM BEFORE. NEVER'S EVER ASKED ME TO A PARTY BEFORE, AS A FRIEND? IS THAT WHY YOU DROVE YOUR EVERETT, FOR THE PARTY? SHOULD I BE MINDING THEM? NO, SAID HARRY FIRMLY, THAT WAS A

MISTAKE, I'LL GET HERMIONE TO PUT IT RIGHT FOR ME. SHE'LL MEET YELL
IN THE ENTRANCE HALL AT EIGHT AND CHECK THEM. ~~AAA~~ SCREAMED A
VOICE FROM OVERHEAD AND BOTH OF THEM JUMPED. UNNOTICED BY EITHER
OF THEM, THEY HAD JUST PASSED RIGHT UNDERNEATH PERVES, WHO WAS
HANGING UPSIDE DOWN FROM A CHANDELIER AND GRINNING MALICIOUSLY
AT THEM. PATTY ASKED LINDA THE ONE THE THE PARTY? PATTY LIVES
LINDA? PATTY LULULULIVES LINDA? AND HE ZOOMED AWAY,
CACKLING AND STRIKING. PATTY LIVES LINDA? NICE TO KEEP THESE
THINGS PRIVATE, SAID HARRY, AND SURE ENOUGH, IN NO TIME AT ALL
THE WHOLE SCENE SEEMED TO DENY THAT HARRY PATTY WAS TAKING
LINDA LIVES THE SLUGGISH S PARTY. YELL COULD WE TALKEN
ANYONE? SAID REEN IN DISBELIEF EVER DINNER. ANYONE? AND YELL
THOSE LINDA LIVES? DIDN'T CALL HER THAT, REEN, SNAPPED
GINNY, PALMING BEHIND HARRY IN HER WAY THE OTHER FRIENDS. I'M
REALLY GLAD YELL ARE TAKING HER, HARRY, SHE'S SHE EXCITED. AND SHE
MOVED HIM DOWN THE TABLE TO SIT WITH DEAN. HARRY TRIED TO FEEL
PLEASED THAT GINNY WAS GLAD HE WAS TAKING LINDA THE THE PARTY, BUT
COULD NOT ELITE MANAGE IT. A LONG WAY ALONG THE TABLE, HERMIONE
WAS SITTING ALONE, PLAYING WITH HER STEEL. HARRY NOTICED REEN
LOOKING AT HER FLIRTIVELY. YELL COULD SAY SHIRAZ, SUGGESTED HARRY
BLINDLY. WHAT, AND GET ATTACKED BY ANOTHER FLOCK OF CANARIES?
MUTTERED REEN. WHAT DID YELL HAVE TO IMITATE HER FOR? SHE
LAUGHED AT MY MISTAKE? SHE DID I, IT WAS THE STUPIDEST THING I'VE
EVER SEEN. BUT REEN DID NOT SEEM TO HAVE HEARD. LAVENDER HAD JUST
ARRIVED WITH PARVATI, SLEEPING HERSELF IN BETWEEN HARRY AND
REEN, LAVENDER FLING HER ARMS AROUND REEN'S NECK. HI, HARRY,
SAID PARVATI WHO, LIKE HIM, LOOKED FAINTLY EMBARRASSED AND SHY BY
THE RE-AYING OF THEIR TWO FRIENDS. HI, SAID HARRY, HOW ARE YELL?
YELL ARE STAYING AT HOGWARTS, THEN? I HEARD YELL'S PARENTS WANTED
YELL TO LEAVE. I MANAGED TO TALK THEM OUT OF IT FOR THE TIME
BEING, SAID PARVATI. THAT KATIE THING REALLY FREAKED THEM OUT,
BUT AS THERE HADN'T BEEN ANYTHING SINCE. EH, HI, HERMIONE?
PARVATI POSITIVELY BEAMED. HARRY COULD TELL THAT SHE WAS FEELING
GUILTY FOR HAVING LAUGHED AT HERMIONE IN TRANSFIGURATION. HE
LOOKED AROUND AND SAW THAT HERMIONE WAS BEAMING BACK, IF
POSSIBLE EVEN MORE BRIGHTLY. GIRLS WERE VERY STRANGE SOMETIMES.
HI, PARVATI! SAID HERMIONE, IGNORING REEN AND LAVENDER
COMPLETELY. ARE YELL GOING TO THE SLUGGISH S PARTY TONIGHT? NO

INVITE, SAID PARVATI CHEERFULLY, I'D LOVE TO GO, THOUGH, IT SOUNDS LIKE IT'S GOING TO BE REALLY GOOD. YOU'RE GOING, AREN'T YOU?

YES, I'M MEETING HERMIE AT EIGHT, AND WE'RE THERE WAS A WHISTLE LIKE A PULLER BEING WITHDRAWN FROM A KICKED SIDE AND THEN SURFACED. HERMIE ACTED AS THOUGH SHE HAD NOT SEEN OR HEARD ANYTHING. WE'RE GOING UP TO THE PARTY TOGETHER. HERMIE SAID PARVATI. HERMIE MCKAGGON, YOU MEAN? THAT'S RIGHT, SAID HERMIE SWEETLY. THE ONE WHO ALMOST SHE PUT A GREAT DEAL OF EMPHASIS ON THE WORD BECAUSE GARYFINDER KEEPER, ARE YOU GOING OUT WITH HIM, THEN? ASKED PARVATI, WIDE-EYED. EH? YES

DIDN'T YOU KNOW? SAID HERMIE, WITH A MOST UNHERMIE-ISH GIGGLE. NO? SAID PARVATI, LOOKING POSITIVELY AGED AT THIS POINT OF Gossip. WELL, YOU LIKE YOUR FLUIDITY PLAYERS, DON'T YOU? FIRST DORUM, THEN MCKAGGON I LIKE REALLY GOOD FLUIDITY PLAYERS. HERMIE CORRECTED HER, STILL SMILING. WELL, SEE YOU GO TO THE GO AND GET READY FOR THE PARTY. SHE LEFT. AT ONCE LAVENDER AND PARVATI PUT THEIR HEADS TOGETHER AND DISCUSSED THIS NEW DEVELOPMENT, WITH EVERYTHING THEY HAD EVER HEARD ABOUT MCKAGGON, AND ALL THEY HAD EVER GUESSED ABOUT HERMIE. THEN SHE'D STRANGELY BLANK AND SAID NOTHING. HARRY WAS LEFT THE POWER IN SILENCE THE DEPTHS THE WHICH GIRLS WOULD SIDE TO GET REVENGE. WHEN HE ARRIVED IN THE ENTRANCE HALL AT EIGHT HE CHECKED THAT NIGHT, HE FOUND AN UNUSUALLY LARGE NUMBER OF GIRLS WALKING THERE, ALL OF WHOM SEEMED TO BE STARING AT HIM RESENTFULLY AS HE APPROACHED LINA. SHE WAS WEARING A SET OF SPANGLED SILVER RINGS THAT WERE ATTRACTING A CERTAIN AMOUNT OF GIGGLES FROM THE ENLIGHTENED, BUT OTHERWISE SHE LOOKED WHITE NICER. HARRY WAS GLAD, IN ANY CASE, THAT SHE HAD LEFT OFF HER RADISH EARRINGS, HER KLUTTERED CHAIN NECKLACE, AND HER SPECTACLES. HI, HE SAID.

SHALL WE GET GOING THEN? EH? YES, SHE SAID HAPPILY. WHERE IS THE PARTY? SUGGESTION OFFICE, SAID HARRY, LEADING HER UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE AWAY FROM ALL THE STARING AND MUTTERING. DID YOU HEAR, THERE'S SUPPOSED TO BE A VAMPIRE COMING? RUPERT SCRIMGEWORTH ASKED LINA. I WHAT? SAID HARRY, DISHEARTENED.

YOU MEAN THE MINISTER OF MAGIC? YES, HE'S A VAMPIRE, SAID LINA MATTER-OF-FACTLY. FATHER WROTE A VERY LONG ARTICLE ABOUT IT WHEN SCRIMGEWORTH FIRST THREW HER FROM CROOKED FUDGE, BUT HE WAS FORCED NOT TO PUBLISH BY SOMEONE FROM THE MINISTRY.

HEAVILY, THEY DIDN'T WANT THE TRUTH TO GET OUT! HARRY, WHO THOUGHT IT MOST LIKELY THAT ROLAND STRIMMER WAS A VAMPIRE, BUT WHO WAS USED THE LINA REPEATING HER FATHER'S BIZARRE VIEWS AS THOUGH THEY WERE FACT, DID NOT REPLY; THEY WERE ALREADY APPROACHING SLIGHTER'S OFFICE AND THE SOUNDS OF LAUGHTER, MUSIC, AND LUDIC CONVERSATION WERE GROWING LOUDER WITH EVERY STEP THEY TOOK. WHETHER IT HAD BEEN JUST THAT DAY, OR BECAUSE HE HAD USED MAGICAL TRICKERY TO MAKE IT SO, SLIGHTER'S OFFICE WAS MUCH LARGER THAN THE USUAL TEACHER'S STUDY. THE CEILING AND WALLS HAD BEEN DRAPED WITH EMERALD, CRIMSON, AND GOLD HANGINGS, SO THAT IT LOOKED AS THOUGH THEY WERE ALL INSIDE A VAST TENT. THE ROOM WAS CRIMBED AND STUFFY AND BATHED IN THE RED LIGHT CAST BY AN ORNATE GILDED LAMP DANGLING FROM THE CENTER OF THE CEILING IN WHICH REAL FAIRIES WERE FLUTTERING, EACH A BRILLIANT SPARK OF LIGHT, LOUD SINGING ACCOMPANIED BY WHAT SOUNDED LIKE MANDOLINS ISSUED FROM A DISTANT CORNER; A HAZE OF PIPE SMOKE FLOVE OVER SEVERAL ELDERLY WARLOCKS DEEP IN CONVERSATION, AND A NUMBER OF FLEET-FOOTED WERE NEGOTIATING THEIR WAY SILENTLY THROUGH THE THROTTLE OF DOORS, HESITANT BY THE HEAVY SILVER PLATTERS OF FOOD THEY WERE BEARING, SO THAT THEY LOOKED LIKE LITTLE MOVING TABLES. HARRY, MOTHER? KNEW SLIGHTER, ALMOST AS WELL AS HARRY AND LINA HAD KNOWN IN THROUGH THE DOOR. COME IN, COME IN, SO MANY PEOPLE I'D LIKE YOU TO MEET! SLIGHTER WAS WEARING A TASSELED VELVET HAT TO MATCH HIS SMOKING JACKET, GRIPPING HARRY'S ARM SO TIGHTLY HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN TRYING TO DISAPPEAR WITH HIM. SLIGHTER LED HIM PURPOSEFULLY INTO THE PARTY; HARRY SEIZED LINA'S HAND AND DRAGGED HER ALONG WITH HIM. HARRY, I'D LIKE YOU TO MEET LORD WORMWORM, AN OLD STUDENT OF MINE, ALTHOUGH HE'S BEEN BROTHERS! MY LIFE AMONGST THE VAMPIRES AND, OF COURSE, HIS FRIEND SANGUINI. WORMWORM, WHO WAS A SMALL, STEALTHY, RESPECTABLE MAN, GRABBED HARRY'S HAND AND SHOOK IT ENTHUSIASTICALLY; THE VAMPIRE SANGUINI, WHO WAS TALL AND EMACIATED WITH DARK SHADOWS UNDER HIS EYES, MERELY NODDED. HE LOOKED RATHER BORED. A CIRCLE OF GIRLS WAS STANDING CLOSE TO HIM, LOOKING CURIOUS AND EXCITED. HARRY BETTER, I AM SIMPLY DELIGHTED! SAID WORMWORM, PEERING SHORTSIGHTEDLY UP INTO HARRY'S FACE. I WAS SAYING THE PROFESSOR SLIGHTER ONLY THE OTHER DAY, WHERE IS THE KINGDOM OF HARRY BETTER AND WHICH WE HAVE ALL BEEN WAITING? ER, SAID HARRY, WHERE YOU? JUST AS

MODEST AS FERRACE DESCRIBED? SAID WHEERLE, BUT SERIOUSLY HIS MANNER CHANGED; IT BECAME SLIDDERLY BUSINESSLIKE I WOULD BE DELIGHTED TO WRITE IT MYSELF PEOPLE ARE CRAVING TO KNOW MORE ABOUT YOU, DEAR KID, CRAVING; IF YOU WERE PREPARED TO GRANT ME A FEW INTERVIEWS, SAY IN YOUR- OR FIVE- HOUR SESSIONS, WHY, WE COULD HAVE THE BOOK FINISHED WITHIN MONTHS, AND ALL WITH VERY LITTLE EFFORT ON YOUR PART, I ASSURE YOU ASK SANGUINI HERE IF IT ISN'T ELITE SANGUINI, STAY HERE? ADDED WHEERLE, SLIDDERLY STERN, FOR THE VAMPIRE HAD BEEN EDGING TOWARD THE NEARBY GROUP OF GIRLS, A RATHER FLINERY LOOK IN HIS EYE. HERE, HAVE A PASTY, SAID WHEERLE, SEIZING ONE FROM A PASSING ELF AND STUFFING IT INTO SANGUINI'S HAND BEFORE TURNING HIS ATTENTION BACK TO HARRY. MY DEAR KID, THE CHILD YOU COULD MAKE, YOU HAVE NO IDEA I'M DEFINITELY NOT INTERESTED, SAID HARRY FIRMLY, AND I'VE JUST SEEN A FRIEND OF MINE, SHERRY, HE PULLED LUNA AFTER HIM INTO THE CROWD; HE HAD INDEED JUST SEEN A LONG MANE OF BROWN HAIR DISAPPEAR BETWEEN WHAT LOOKED LIKE TWO MEMBERS OF THE WEIRD SISTERS. DETERMINED? DETERMINED? HARRY? THERE YOU ARE, THANK GOODNESS? HI, LUNA? WHAT'S HAPPENED TO YOU? ASKED HARRY, FOR DETERMINED LOOKED DISTINCTLY DISHEVELED, RATHER AS THOUGH SHE HAD JUST ACHIEVED HER WAY OUT OF A THICKET OF DEVIL'S SNARE. EH, I'VE JUST ESCAPED I MEAN, I'VE JUST LEFT CHARMAC, SHE SAID, UNDER THE MISTLETOE, SHE ADDED IN EXPLANATION, AS HARRY CONTINUED TO LOOK ELDESTERNINGLY AT HER. SERVES YOU RIGHT FOR COMING WITH HIM, HE TOLD HER SEVERELY. I THOUGHT HE'D ANNOY JOHN MOST, SAID DETERMINED DISPASSIONATELY. I DEBATED FOR A WHILE ABOUT ZACHARIAS SMITH, BUT I THOUGHT, ON THE WHOLE YOU CONSIDERED SMITH? SAID HARRY, REVEALED. YES, I DID, AND I'M STARTING TO WISH I'D CHOSEN HIM, McLAGGEN MAKES GRASP LOOK A GENTLEMAN, LET'S GO THIS WAY, WE'LL BE ABLE TO SEE HIM COMING, HE'S SEEN TALL. THE THREE OF THEM MADE THEIR WAY OVER THE OTHER SIDE OF THE ROOM, SCHEMPING UP CHECKS OF MEAD ON THE WAY, REALIZING THEN LATE THAT PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WAS STANDING THERE ALONE. HELLO, SAID LUNA POLITELY TO PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY. GOOD EVENING, MY DEAR, SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, FOCUSING UPON LUNA WITH SOME DIFFICULTY. HARRY COULD SMELL CHEERING SHERRY AGAIN. I HAVEN'T SEEN YOU IN MY CLASSES LATELY. NO, I'VE GOTTEN FIRENZE THIS YEAR, SAID LUNA. EH, HE CHEASE, SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WITH AN ANGRY, DRUNKEN TITTER.

MR DEKKIN, AS I PREFER TO THINK OF HIM, WHO WOULD HAVE THOUGHT, WHO WOULD NOT, THAT WHEN I AM RETURNED TO THE SCHOOL PROFESSOR DUMKLEBERRY MIGHT HAVE GOT RID OF THE HORSE? BUT WE SHARE CLASSES. IT'S AN INSULT, FRANKLY, AN INSULT. SHE WHO KNOWS PROFESSOR TRELANNEY SEEMS THEM TIPSY THEY HAVE RECOGNIZED FARRY, UNDER COVER OF HER FLIRTIOUS CRITICISMS OF FIRENZE, FARRY DREW CLOSER TO FERMINE AND SAID, LET'S GET SOMETHING STRAIGHT, ARE YOU PLANNING TO TELL BEN THAT YOU INTERFERED AT DEEPER TROUBLES? FERMINE RAISED HER EYEBROWS, SHE YOU REALLY THINK I'D STAND THAT LIES? FARRY LOOKED AT HER STAREDBLY, FERMINE, IF YOU CAN ASK HOLT MCLAGGEN THERE'S A DIFFERENCE, SAID FERMINE WITH DIGNITY, I'VE GOT NEW PLANS TO TELL BEN ANYTHING ABOUT WHAT MIGHT, OR MIGHT NOT, HAVE HAPPENED AT DEEPER TROUBLES. GOOD, SAID FARRY FERVENTLY, BECAUSE HE'LL JUST FALL APART AGAIN, AND WE'LL LOSE THE NEXT MATCH. ELJIDITCH? SAID FERMINE ANGRILY, IS THAT ALL KEYS CARE ABOUT? CHARMAC HADN'T ASKED ME ONE SINGLE QUESTION ABOUT MYSELF, NO, I'VE JUST BEEN TREATED TO A HUNDRED GREAT SAYS MADE BY CHARMAC MCLAGGEN SINCE THEN EVER SINCE. HEY NO, HERE HE COMES! SHE MOVED SO FAST IT WAS AS THOUGH SHE HAD DISAPPEARED; ONE MOMENT SHE WAS THERE, THE NEXT, SHE HAD SLEEPED BETWEEN TWO GUFFAWING WITCHES AND VANISHED. SEEN FERMINE? ASKED MCLAGGEN, FEELING HIS WAY THROUGH THE THICK A MINUTE LATER. NO, SORRY, SAID FARRY, AND HE TURNED BRISKLY THE OTHER IN LINA'S CONVERSATION, FORGETTING HER A SPLIT SECOND THE MOMENT SHE WAS TALKING. FARRY BETTER? SAID PROFESSOR TRELANNEY IN DEEP, VIBRANT TONES, NOTICING HIM FOR THE FIRST TIME. HEY, HELLO, SAID FARRY ENTHUSIASTICALLY, MY DEAR KEY! SHE SAID IN A VERY CARRYING WHISPER, THE ALIENS! THE STRIKES! THE CHIEFS! HEY! HEY! I HAVE KNOWN HER A VERY LONG TIME. THE MEN WERE NEVER GOOD, FARRY. BUT WHY HAVE YOU NOT RETURNED THE DIVINATION? FOR YOU, OF ALL PEOPLE, THE SUBJECT IS OF THE UTMOST IMPORTANCE! AH, SYBIL, WE ALL THINK YOUR SUBJECT'S MOST IMPORTANT! SAID A LOUD VOICE, AND SILVERHORN APPEARED AT PROFESSOR TRELANNEY'S OTHER SIDE, HIS FACE VERY RED, HIS VELVET HAT A LITTLE ASKEW, A GLASS OF MEAD IN ONE HAND AND AN ENORMOUS Mince Pie IN THE OTHER. BUT I DON'T THINK I'VE EVER KNOWN SUCH A NATURAL AT PARTIES! SAID SILVERHORN, REGARDING FARRY WITH A HARD, IF BLENDING, EYE. INSTINCTIVE, YOU KNOW

LIKE HIS FATHER! I'VE ONLY EVER TALKED A FEW WITH THIS KIND OF ABILITY, I CAN TELL YOU THAT, SYRILL WE'D EVEN SEVERUS AND THE HARRY'S FATHER, SLUGGISH TROWED HIM AN ARM AND SEEMED THE SNEED SNAPE HIM IN THE AIR TOWARD THEM. STEADY SLOWLY AND CHEER AND THEN WAS, SEVERUS! HICKEYED SLUGGISH HAPPILY, I WAS JUST TALKING ABOUT HARRY'S EXCEPTIONAL POTION-MAKING! SOME CREDIT MUST GO TO YOU, OF COURSE, YOU TALKED HIM FOR FIVE YEARS! TRAPPED, WITH SLUGGISH'S ARM AROUND HIS SHOULDERS, SNAPE LOOKED DOWN HIS THICK NOSE AT HARRY, HIS BLACK EYES NARROWED.

FLINDY, I NEVER HAD THE IMPRESSION THAT I MANAGED THE TEACH POTTER ANYTHING AT ALL. WELL, THEN, IT'S NATURAL ABILITY! SMILED SLUGGISH. YOU SHOULD HAVE SEEN WHAT HE GAVE ME, FIRST LESSON, DRAGONHORN OF LIVING DEATH! NEVER HAD A STUDENT PRODUCE FINER THAN A FIRST ATTEMPT, I DON'T THINK EVEN YOU, SEVERUS

Really? SAID SNAPE QUIETLY, HIS EYES STILL BEARING INTO HARRY, WHEN HE FELT A CERTAIN DISHONOR. THE LAST THING HE WANTED WAS FOR SNAPE TO START INVESTIGATING THE SOURCE OF HIS NEWFOUND BRILLIANCE AT POTIONS. REMIND ME WHAT OTHER SUBJECTS YOU'RE TAKING, HARRY? ASKED SLUGGISH. DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, CHARMS, TRANSFIGURATION, HERBOLGY ALL THE SUBJECTS REQUIRED, IN SHORT, FOR AN ALIEN, SAID SNAPE, WITH THE FAINTEST SNEER. Yeah, well, THAT'S WHAT I'D LIKE TO DO, SAID HARRY DEFIANTLY,

AND A GREAT ONE YOU'LL MAKE THAT! SMILED SLUGGISH. I DON'T THINK YOU SHOULD BE AN ALIEN, HARRY, SAID LUNA UNEXPECTEDLY. EVERYBODY LOOKED AT HER. THE ALIENS ARE PART OF THE RIFTING CONSPIRACY, I THINK EVERYONE KNEW THAT. THEY'RE WORKING TO BRING DOWN THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC FROM WITHIN USING A COMBINATION OF DARK MAGIC AND CLIMATIC DISEASE. HARRY INHALED HALF HIS MOUTH UP HIS NOSE AS HE STARTED TO LAUGH. REALLY, IT HAD BEEN WORTH BRINGING LUNA JUST FOR THIS. EMERGING FROM HIS COAT, CHUCKLING, SHEDDING WET BUT STILL GRINNING, HE SAW SOMETHING CALCULATED TO RAISE HIS SPIRITS EVEN HIGHER: DRAGON MOUTH BEING DRAGGED BY THE EAR TOWARD THEM BY ANGUS FILCH. PROFESSOR SLUGGISH, WHIPPED FILCH, HIS EYES ANGLIER AND THE MANIACAL LIGHT OF MISCHIEF-DETECTION IN HIS BLUE EYES. I DISCOVERED THIS KEY HIDE IN AN UPSTAIRS HALLWAY. HE CLAIMS THEY HAVE BEEN INVITED TO THE PARTY AND THEY HAVE BEEN DELAYED IN SETTING HIM. DID YOU ISSUE HIM WITH AN INVITATION? MALFOY PULLED HIMSELF FREE OF

FILCH'S GRIP, WHISKING FLIRTLIS. ALL RIGHT, I WASN'T INVITED! HE SAID ANGERILY. I WAS TRYING THE GATECRASH, HAPPY? NO, I'M NOT! SAID FILCH, A STATEMENT AT COMPLETE ENDS WITH THE CLIP IN HIS FACE.

THEY'RE IN TROUBLE, THEY ARE! DIDN'T THE HEADMASTER SAY THAT NIGHTTIME PRANKING'S ILIT, UNLESS THEY'VE GHT PERMISSION, DIDN'T HE, EE? THAT'S ALL RIGHT, ARGUS, THAT'S ALL RIGHT, SAID SLUGGISHORN, WAVING A HAND. IT'S CHRISTMAS, AND IT'S NOT A CRIME THE WANT THE CHEER THE A PARTY, ILST THIS ENCE, WE LL FORGET ANY PUNISHMENT; THEY MAY STAY, DRACHE. FILCH'S EXPRESSION OF ILITRAGED DISAPPOINTMENT WAS PERFECTLY PREDICTABLE; BUT WHY, HARRY WHIMDERED, WATCHING HIM, DID MALPHY LOOK ALMOST RELIALLY UNHAPPY? AND WHY WAS SNAPE WHISKING AT MALPHY AS THOUGH BOTH ANGRY AND WAS IT POSSIBLE?

A LITTLE AFRAID? BUT ALMOST BEFORE HARRY HAD REGISTERED WHAT HE HAD SEEN, FILCH HAD TURNED AND SLIPPED AWAY, MUTTERING UNDER HIS BREATH; MALPHY HAD COMPOSED HIS FACE INTO A SMILE AND WAS THANKING SLUGGISHORN FOR HIS GENEROSITY, AND SNAPE'S FACE WAS SMUGGLY INSCRUTABLE AGAIN. IT'S NOTHING, NOTHING, SAID SLUGGISHORN, WAVING AWAY MALPHY'S THANKS. I DID KNOW YOUR GRANDFATHER, AFTER ALL. HE ALWAYS SPoke VERY HIGHLY OF YOU, SIR, SAID MALPHY BLICKLY. SAID YOU WERE THE BEST PARTHEN-MAKER HE D EVER KNOWN. HARRY STARED AT MALPHY. IT WAS NOT THE SLICKING-LIP THAT INTRIGUED HIM; HE HAD WATCHED MALPHY DO THAT THE SNAPE FOR A LONG TIME. IT WAS THE FACT THAT MALPHY DID, AFTER ALL, LOOK A LITTLE ILL. THIS WAS THE FIRST TIME HE HAD SEEN MALPHY CLUSE LIP FOR AGES; HE NEW SAW THAT MALPHY HAD DARK SHADELS UNDER HIS EYES AND A DISTINCTLY GRAYISH TINGE TO HIS SKIN. I D LIKE A WHOD WITH YOU, DRACHE, SAID SNAPE SLIDENLY. EH, NEW, SEVERLIS, SAID SLUGGISHORN, HICCLIPING AGAIN. IT'S CHRISTMAS, DEN'T EE THEE HARD

I'M HIS HEAD OF FHEUSE, AND I SHALL DECIDE HOW HARD, FOR OTHERWISE, THE EE, SAID SNAPE CLITLY. FHEHEW ME, DRACHE. THEY LEFT, SNAPE LEADING THE WAY, MALPHY WHISKING RESENTFUL, HARRY STOOD THERE FOR A MOMENT, IRRESHLLITE, THEN SAID, I LL BE BACK IN A KIT, LLINA ER KATHREHM. ALL RIGHT, SHE SAID CHEERFULLY, AND HE THOUGHT HE HEARD HER, AS HE HURRIED OFF INTO THE CREED, RESUME THE SUBJECT OF THE RETURNING CONSPIRACY WITH PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, WHO SEEMED SINCERELY INTERESTED. IT WAS EASY, ENCE ILIT OF THE PARTY, THE PLUM HIS INVISIBILITY CHAD ILIT OF HIS POCKET AND THREW IT OVER HIMSELF, FOR THE CHORIDOR WAS ALITE DESERTED. WHAT WAS MORE DIFFICULT WAS

FINDING SNAPE AND MALFOY, HARRY RAN DOWN THE CORRIDOR, THE NOISE OF HIS FEET MASKED BY THE MUSIC AND LIVED TALK STILL ISSUING FROM SLUGGERTON'S OFFICE BEHIND HIM. PERHAPS SNAPE HAD TAKEN MALFOY TO HIS OFFICE IN THE DUNGEONS. OR PERHAPS HE WAS EXCHANGING HIM BACK TO THE SLYTHERIN COMMON ROOMS. HARRY PRESSED HIS EAR AGAINST THE DOOR AFTER THE DOOR AS HE DASHED DOWN THE CORRIDOR UNTIL, WITH A GREAT JOLT OF EXCITEMENT, HE CRASHED DOWN THE THE KEY-HOLE OF THE LAST CLASSROOM IN THE CORRIDOR AND HEARD VOICES. CANNOT AFFORD MISTAKES, DRAGON, BECAUSE IF YOU ARE EXPELLED I DIDN'T HAVE ANYTHING TO DO WITH IT, ALL RIGHT? I HOPE YOU ARE TELLING THE TRUTH, BECAUSE IT WAS BOTH CLIMBY AND FOOLISH. ALREADY YOU ARE SUSPECTED OF HAVING A HAND IN IT. WHO SUSPECTS ME? SAID MALFOY ANGERILY. FOR THE LAST TIME, I DIDN'T DO IT, HARRY? THAT BELL GIRL MUST BE HAD AN ENEMY WHO KNOWS ABOUT

DIDN'T LOOK AT ME LIKE THAT? I KNOW WHAT YOU'RE DOING, I'M NOT STUPID, BUT IT WON'T WORK. I CAN STOP YOU! THERE WAS A PAUSE AND THEN SNAPE SAID QUIETLY, AS ALMOST BELLATRIX HAS BEEN TEACHING YOU HELLMONEY, I SEE, WHAT THOUGHTS ARE YOU TRYING TO CONCEAL FROM YOUR MASTER, DRAGON? I'M NOT TRYING TO CONCEAL ANYTHING FROM HIM, I JUST DIDN'T WANT YOU LISTENING IN! HARRY PRESSED HIS EAR STILL MORE CLOSELY AGAINST THE KEY-HOLE. WHAT HAD HAPPENED TO MAKE MALFOY SPEAK TO SNAPE LIKE THIS. SNAPE, THOUGH WHEN HE HAD ALWAYS SHOWN RESPECT, EVEN LISTENING? SEE THAT IS WHY YOU HAVE BEEN AVOIDING ME THIS TERM? YOU HAVE FEARED MY INTERFERENCE? YOU REALIZE THAT, HAD ANYBODY ELSE FAILED TO CHASE THE MY OFFICE WHEN I HAD TOLD THEM REPEATEDLY TO BE THERE, DRAGON

SEE PUT ME IN DETENTION? REPORT ME TO DUMBLEDORE? I KNEW MALFOY, THERE WAS ANOTHER PAUSE. THEN SNAPE SAID, YOU KNOW PERFECTLY WELL THAT I DO NOT WISH TO DO EITHER OF THESE THINGS. YOU'D BETTER STOP TELLING ME TO CHASE THE YOUR OFFICE THEN! LISTEN TO ME, SAID SNAPE, HIS VOICE SHE KNEW NOW THAT HARRY HAD THE PLUG HIS EAR VERY HARD AGAINST THE KEY-HOLE TO HEAR. I AM TRYING TO HELP YOU, I SWORE THE YOUR MOTHER I WOULD PROTECT YOU, I MADE THE UNREADABLE YOU, DRAGON. KNOWS LIKE YOU ALL HAVE TO READ IT, THEN, BECAUSE I DIDN'T NEED YOUR PROTECTION? IT'S MY JOB, HE GAVE IT TO ME AND I'M DOING IT, I'VE GOT A PLAN AND IT'S GOING TO WORK, IT'S JUST TAKING A BIT LONGER THAN I THOUGHT IT WOULD! WHAT IS YOUR PLAN? IT'S NONE OF YOUR BUSINESS! IF YOU TELL ME WHAT YOU ARE

TRYING THE DEE, I CAN ASSIST YELL I VE GHT ALL THE ASSISTANCE I
NEED, THANKS, I M NOT ALONE? YELL WERE CERTAINLY ALONE TONIGHT,
WHICH WAS FHEELISH IN THE EXTREME, WANDERING THE HALLWAYS
WITHHELT LEEHEHLTS HR BACKUP, THESE ARE ELEMENTARY MISTAKES

I WOULD VE HAD CRABBE AND GRAYLE WITH ME IF YELL HADN T PLT THEM
IN DETENTION? DEEP YELLR VICE DEHN? SPAT SNAPE, HR MALPBY S
VICE HAD RISEN EXCITEDLY. IF YELLR FRIENDS CRABBE AND GRAYLE INTEND
THE PASS THEIR DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS HELL, THIS TIME
AROUND, THEY WILL NEED THE WORD A LITTLE HARDER THAN THEY ARE BEING
AT PRES WHAT DOES IT MATTER? SAID MALPBY, DEFENSE AGAINST

THE DARK ARTS IT S ALL ILST A HIDE, ISN T IT, AN ACT? LIKE ANY HP
LIS NEED PROTECTING AGAINST THE DARK ARTS IT IS AN ACT THAT IS
CRUCIAL THE SUCCESS, DRACHE? SAID SNAPE. WHERE DE YELL THINK I
WOULD HAVE BEEN ALL THESE YEARS, IF I HAD NOT KNOWN THE ACT?
DEHN LISTEN THE ME? YELL ARE BEING INCALITHELS, WANDERING AROUND AT
NIGHT, GETTING YELLRSELF CALGT, AND IF YELL ARE PLACING YELLR
RELIANCE IN ASSISTANTS LIKE CRABBE AND GRAYLE THEY RE NOT THE

ONLY HNS, I VE GHT BETTER PEOPLE HN MY SIDE, BETTER PEOPLE? THEN
WHY NOT CHNDR IN ME, AND I CAN I KNOW WHAT YELL RE UP TO?
YELL WANT THE STEAL MY GLORY? THERE WAS ANOTHER PALSE, THEN
SNAPE SAID COLDLY, YELL ARE SPEAKING LIKE A CHILD, I ELLITE
UNDERSTAND THAT YELLR FATHER S CAPTURE AND IMPRISONMENT HAS
UPSET YELL, BLT

HARRY HAD BARELY A SECOND S WARNING; HE HEARD
MALPBY S FEETSTEPS HN THE EITHER SIDE OF THE DEHR AND ALLING HIMSELF
ELT HE THE WAY ILST AS IT BLST HPEN; MALPBY WAS STRIDING AWAY
DEHN THE HALLWAY, PAST THE OPEN DEHR OF SLUGHORN S OFFICE,
AROUND THE DISTANT CORNER, AND ELT HE SIGHT, HARDLY DARING THE
BREATH, HARRY REMAINED CRUELLED DEHN AS SNAPE EMERGED SLEWLY
FROM THE CLASSROOM, HIS EXPRESSION UNPATEHEMABLE, HE RETURNED THE
THE PARTY, HARRY REMAINED HN THE FLHR, HIDDEN BENEATH THE CHAIR,
HIS MIND RACING, A VERY FREESTY CHRISTMAS SEE SNAPE WAS OFFERING
THE HELP HIM? HE WAS DEFINITELY OFFERING THE HELP HIM? IF YELL ASK
THAT HNCR MORE, SAID HARRY, I M GIVING THE STICK THIS SPRLT

I M ONLY CHECKING? SAID REIN, THEY WERE STANDING ALONE AT THE
BLURHELS KITCHEN SINK, PEELING A MELINTAIN OF SPRLTS HR MRS.
WEASLEY, SNEW WAS DRIFTING PAST THE WINDOW IN FRONT OF THEM,

YES, SNAPE WAS OFFERING THE HELP HIM? SAID HARRY, HE SAID HE D
PROMISED MALPBY S MOTHER THE PROTECT HIM, THAT HE D MADE AN

UNREPEATABLY HATH HER SOMETHING AN UNREPEATABLY VELL

SAID RICH, WHIMPERING STUNNED. NAH, HE CAN'T HAVE. ARE VELL
SURE? YES, I'M SURE, SAID FARRY. WHY, WHAT DOES IT MEAN?

WELL, VELL CAN'T READ AN UNREPEATABLY VELL. I'D WISHED THAT
MUCH HLT FOR MYSELF, FLUNNILY ENLIGHTEN. WHAT HAPPENS IF VELL READ
IT, THEN? VELL DIE, SAID RICH SIMPLY. FRED AND GEORGE TRIED TO GET
ME TO MAKE ONE WHEN I WAS ABOUT FIVE, I NEARLY DID THEN, I WAS
HOLDING HANDS WITH FRED AND EVERYTHING WHEN DAD FEELING LIS. HE
WENT MENTAL, SAID RICH, WITH A REMINISCENT GLEAM IN HIS EYES.

ONLY TIME I'VE EVER SEEN DAD AS ANGRY AS MOM. FRED REMEMBERS HIS
LEFT KLITTECK HAS NEVER BEEN THE SAME SINCE. Yeah, WELL, PASSING
EVER FRED'S LEFT KLITTECK I SEE VELL'S PARDON? SAID FRED'S VOICE

AS THE TWINS ENTERED THE KITCHEN. AHH, GEORGE, LOOK AT THIS.
THEY'RE USING KNIVES AND EVERYTHING. BLESS THEM. I'M BE
SEVENTEEN IN TWO AND A BIT MONTHS TIME, SAID RICH GRUMPILY, AND
THEN I'M BE ABLE TO DO IT BY MAGIC? BUT MEANWHILE, SAID GEORGE,
SITTING DOWN AT THE KITCHEN TABLE AND PUTTING HIS FEET UP ON IT,

WE CAN ENJOY WATCHING VELL DEMONSTRATE THE CORRECT USE OF A
WEEDS-A-DAISY? VELL MADE ME DO THAT? SAID RICH ANGERILY,
SLICKING HIS CLIT THUMB. VELL WAIT, WHEN I'M SEVENTEEN I'M
SURE VELL'LL DAZZLE US ALL WITH FIFTEENTH UNSUSPECTED MAGICAL
SKILLS, PALMED FRED, AND SPEAKING OF FIFTEENTH UNSUSPECTED
SKILLS, RICHARD, SAID GEORGE, WHAT IS THIS WE HEAR FROM GINNY
ABOUT VELL AND A VELLING LADY CALLED UNLESS HER INFORMATION IS
FALSY LAVENDER BROWN? RICH TURNED A LITTLE PINK, BUT DID NOT
LOOK DISPLEASED AS HE TURNED BACK TO THE SPINETS. MIND VELL'S OWN
BUSINESS. WHAT A SNAPPY RETORT, SAID FRED. I REALLY DON'T KNOW
HOW VELL THINKS OF THEM. NEH, WHAT WE WANTED TO KNOW WAS HOW
DID IT HAPPEN? WHAT'D VELL MEAN? DID SHE HAVE AN ACCIDENT OR
SOMETHING? WHAT? WELL, HOW DID SHE SUSTAIN SUCH EXTENSIVE
BRAIN DAMAGE? CAREFUL, NEH? MRS. WEASLEY ENTERED THE ROOM JUST
IN TIME TO SEE RICH THROW THE SPINET KNIFE AT FRED, WHO HAD
TURNED IT INTO A PAPER AIRPLANE WITH ONE LAZY FLICK OF HIS HAND.

NEH? SHE SAID FLURRIEDLY. DON'T VELL EVER LET ME SEE VELL
THROWING KNIVES AGAIN? I WON'T, SAID RICH, LET VELL SEE. HE
ADDED UNDER HIS BREATH, AS HE TURNED BACK TO THE SPINET MOUNTAIN.

FRED, GEORGE, I'M SORRY, DEARS, BUT REMUS IS ARRIVING TONIGHT, SO
BILL WILL HAVE TO SLEEP IN WITH VELL TWO. NEH PROBLEM, SAID

GEORGE. THEN, AS CHARLIE ISN'T COMING HOME, THAT JUST LEAVES
HARRY AND RHN IN THE ATTIC, AND IF FLEWER SHARES WITH GINNY

THAT LL MAKE GINNY'S CHRISTMAS MUTILTERED FRED,
EVERYTHING SHOULD BE COMFORTABLE. WELL, THEY LL HAVE A RED, ANYWAY,
SAID MRS. WEASLEY, SOUNDING SLIGHTLY HARASSED. PERCY DEFINITELY
WHT SHEDDING HIS LGLY FACE, THEN? ASKED FRED. MRS. WEASLEY TURNED
AWAY BEFORE SHE ANSWERED. NEE, HE'S BUSY, I EXPECT, AT THE
MINISTRY. ER HE'S THE WORLD'S BIGGEST PRAT, SAID FRED, AS MRS.
WEASLEY LEFT THE KITCHEN. HNE OF THE TWO, WELL, LET'S GET GOING,
THEN, GEORGE. WHAT ARE YOU TWO UP TO? ASKED RHN. CAN'T YOU
HELP US WITH THESE SPOOKS? YOU COULD JUST USE YOUR WAND AND
THEN WE LL BE FREE THEM? NEE, I DONT THINK WE CAN DO THAT, SAID
FRED SERIOUSLY. IT'S VERY CHARACTER-BUILDING STUFF, LEARNING THE
FEEL SPOOKS WITHOUT MAGIC, MAKES YOU APPRECIATE THEM DIFFICULT IT
IS FOR MUGGLES AND SUCH LIKE AND IF YOU WANT PEOPLE TO HELP

YOU, RHN, ADDED GEORGE, THROWING THE PAPER AIRPLANE AT HIM. I
WOULDN'T CHUCK KNIVES AT THEM. JUST A LITTLE HINT, WE'RE OFF TO THE
VILLAGE, THERE'S A VERY PRETTY GIRL WORKING IN THE PAPER SHOP
WHICH THINKS MY CARD TRICKS ARE SOMETHING MARVELLOUS ALMOST
LIKE REAL MAGIC. EITS, SAID RHN DARKLY, WATCHING FRED AND
GEORGE SETTING OFF ACROSS THE SNOWY YARD. WOULD YOU ONLY TAKEN
THEM TEN SECONDS AND THEN WE COULD GO HOME THEM. I WOULDN'T, SAID
HARRY. I PROMISED DUMBLEDORE I WOULDN'T WANDER OFF WHILE I'M
STAYING HERE. EH YEAH, SAID RHN, HE PEEKED A FEW MORE SPOOKS
AND THEN SAID, ARE YOU GOING TO TELL DUMBLEDORE WHAT YOU HEARD
SNAPE AND MALFOY SAYING TO EACH OTHER? YEP, SAID HARRY. I'M
GOING TO TELL ANYONE WHO CAN PUT A STOP TO IT, AND DUMBLEDORE'S
THEY OF THE LIST. I MIGHT HAVE ANOTHER WORD WITH YOUR DAD THEN.

PITY YOU DIDN'T HEAR WHAT MALFOY'S ACTUALLY DOING, THOUGH. I
WOULDN'T HAVE DONE, COULD I? THAT WAS THE WHOLE POINT, HE WAS
REFUSING TO TELL SNAPE. THERE WAS SILENCE FOR A MOMENT FOR TWO,
THEN RHN SAID, CHURCH, YOU KNOW WHAT THEY LL ALL SAY? DAD AND
DUMBLEDORE AND ALL OF THEM? THEY LL SAY SNAPE ISN'T REALLY TRYING
TO HELP MALFOY, HE WAS JUST TRYING TO FIND OUT WHAT MALFOY'S UP
TO. THEY DIDN'T HEAR HIM, SAID HARRY FLATLY. NEE HNE'S THAT
GOOD AN ACTOR, NOT EVEN SNAPE. YEAH I'M JUST SAYING,
THOUGH, SAID RHN, HARRY TURNED THE FACE HIM, FREELING. YOU
THINK I'M RIGHT, THOUGH? YEAH, I DO! SAID RHN HASTILY.

SECRETLY, I DON'T BUT THEY'RE ALL CONVINCED SNAPE'S IN THE HURD,
AREN'T THEY? HARRY SAID NOTHING. IT HAD ALREADY OCCURRED TO HIM
THAT THIS WOULD BE THE MOST LIKELY REACTION TO HIS NEW EVIDENCE;
HE COULD HEAR HERMIONE WELL: HOWEVER, HARRY, HE WAS
PRETENDING THE HURD HELP SEE HE COULD TRICK MALFOY INTO TELLING
HIM WHAT HE'S DOING. THIS WAS PURE IMAGINATION, HOWEVER, AS
HE HAD HAD NO OPPORTUNITY TO TELL HERMIONE WHAT HE HAD
EVER HEARD. SHE HAD DISAPPEARED FROM SLUGGERTON'S PARTY BEFORE HE
RETURNED THE IT, AND SHE HAD BEEN INFORMED BY AN IRATE MCGRAGGER,
AND SHE HAD ALREADY GONE THE BED BY THE TIME HE RETURNED THE THE
CHAMBER ROOM. AS HE AND RON HAD LEFT FOR THE BURNING EARLY THE
NEXT DAY, HE HAD EARLY HAD TIME TO WISH HER A HAPPY CHRISTMAS
AND TO TELL HER THAT HE HAD SOME VERY IMPORTANT NEWS WHEN THEY
CAME BACK FROM THE HOLIDAYS. HE WAS NOT ENTIRELY SURE THAT SHE HAD
HEARD HIM, THOUGH; RON AND LAVENDER HAD BEEN SAYING A
TERRIBLY NEARBY CHOCOLATE ILIT BEHIND HIM AT THE TIME. STILL,
EVEN HERMIONE WOULD NOT BE ABLE TO DENY HIS THING; MALFOY WAS
DEFINITELY UP THE SOMETHING, AND SNAPE KNEW IT, SO HARRY FELT FULLY
JUSTIFIED IN SAYING I TOLD YOU SHE, WHICH HE HAD DONE SEVERAL TIMES
THE RON ALREADY. HARRY DID NOT GET THE CHANCE TO SPEAK TO MR.
WEASLEY, WHO WAS WORKING VERY LONG HOURS AT THE MINISTRY,
UNTIL CHRISTMAS EVE NIGHT. THE WEASLEYS AND THEIR GUESTS WERE
SITTING IN THE LIVING ROOM, WHICH GINNY HAD DECORATED SO LAVISHLY
THAT IT WAS RATHER LIKE SITTING IN A PAPER-CHAIN EXPLOSION. FRED,
GEORGE, HARRY, AND RON WERE THE ONLY ONES WHO KNEW THAT THE
ANGEL ON TOP OF THE TREE WAS ACTUALLY A GARDEN Gnome THAT HAD
BITTEN FRED ON THE ANKLE AS HE PULLED UP CARRETS FOR CHRISTMAS
DINNER. STUPID, PAINTED Gnome, STUFFED INTO A MINIATURE TURTLE AND
WITH SMALL WINGS GLUED TO ITS BACK, IT GLOWED DOWN AT THEM ALL,
THE LIGHTEST ANGEL HARRY HAD EVER SEEN, WITH A LARGE BALD HEAD LIKE
A POTATE AND RATHER HAIRY FEET. THEY WERE ALL SLIPPED TO BE
LISTENING TO A CHRISTMAS BROADCAST BY MRS. WEASLEY'S FAVORITE
SINGER, CECILIA WARECK, WHOSE VOICE WAS WARBLING OUT OF THE
LARGE WOODEN WIRELESS SET. FLEW, WHO SEEMED TO FIND CECILIA VERY
DULL, WAS TALKING SO LOUDLY IN THE CORNER THAT A SCREAMING MRS.
WEASLEY KEPT POINTING HER HAND AT THE VOLUME CONTROL, SO THAT
CECILIA CAME LOUDER AND LOUDER. UNDER COVER OF A PARTICULARLY
LAZY NUMBER CALLED A CALDERON FLY OF FEET, STRENGTH LEVE, FRED

AND GEORGE STARTED A GAME OF EXPLORING SNAP WITH GINNY, WHO
KEPT SHOOTING BILL AND FLEET CHEVY LIGHTS, AS THOUGH HOPING THE
PICK UP TIPS. MEANWHILE, REMUS BLIPIN, WHO WAS THINNER AND MORE
RAGGED-LOOKING THAN EVER, WAS SITTING BESIDE THE FIRE, STARING INTO
ITS DEPTHS AS THOUGH HE COULD NOT HEAR CELESTINA'S VOICE. HE, CHEVY
AND STIR MY CALIBRE, AND IF YOU DO IT RIGHT, I'LL BEIL YOU UP SOME
LIGHT STINGING LOVE THE DEEP YOU WARM TONIGHT. WE DANCED THE THIS
WHEN WE WERE EIGHTEEN? SAID MRS. WEASLEY, WIPING HER EYES ON HER
KNITTING. DO YOU REMEMBER, ARTHUR? MOTHER? SAID MR. WEASLEY,
WHOSE HEAD HAD BEEN NODDING OVER THE SATISMA HE WAS FEELING.

HE YES MARVELOUS TIME WITH AN EFFORT, HE SAT UP A LITTLE
STRAIGHTER AND LOOKED AROUND AT HARRY, WHO WAS SITTING NEXT THE
HIM. SHIRY ABOUT THIS, HE SAID, TUCKING HIS HEAD TOWARD THE
WIRELESS AS CELESTINA KROOK INTO THE CHAIRS. BE EVER SEEN. NO
PROBLEM, SAID HARRY, GRINNING. HAS IT BEEN BUSY AT THE
MINISTRY? VERY, SAID MR. WEASLEY. I WOULDN'T MIND IF WE WERE
GETTING ANYWHERE, BUT OF THE THREE ARRESTS WE'VE MADE IN THE LAST
COUPLE OF MONTHS, I DOUBT THAT ONE OF THEM IS A GENUINE DEATH
LATER ONLY DON'T REPEAT THAT, HARRY. HE ADDED QUICKLY, LOOKING
MUCH MORE ALARMED ALL OF A SUDDEN. THEY'RE NOT STILL HOLDING STAN
SHLIMPER, ARE THEY? ASKED HARRY. I'M AFRAID SO, SAID MR.
WEASLEY. I KNOW DUMBLEDORE'S TRIED APPEALING DIRECTLY THE
SCRIMPGEOLR ABOUT STAN. I MEAN, ANYBODY WHO HAS ACTUALLY
INTERVIEWED HIM AGREES THAT HE'S ABOUT AS MUCH A DEATH LATER AS
THIS SATISMA BUT THE TWO LEVELS WANT THE LOOK AS THOUGH
THEY'RE MAKING SOME PROGRESS, AND THREE ARRESTS SEEMS BETTER
THAN THREE MISTAKEN ARRESTS AND RELEASES BUT AGAIN, THIS IS ALL
THEY SECRET. I WON'T SAY ANYTHING, SAID HARRY. HE HESITATED
FOR A MOMENT, WONDERING HOW BEST TO EXPRESS HIS WHAT HE WANTED
THEY SAY; AS HE MARSHALLED HIS THOUGHTS, CELESTINA WARECK BEGAN A
BALLAD CALLED YOU CHARMED THE HEART RIGHT OUT OF ME. MR.
WEASLEY, YOU KNOW WHAT I TOLD YOU AT THE STATION WHEN WE WERE
SETTING OFF FOR SCHOOL? I CHECKED, HARRY, SAID MR. WEASLEY AT
ONCE. I WENT AND SEARCHED THE MALFOYS HOUSE. THERE WAS
NOTHING, EITHER KNOWN OR UNKNOWN, THAT SHOULDN'T HAVE BEEN
THERE. Yeah, I KNOW, I SAW IN THE PROPHECY THAT YOU'D LOOKED
BUT THIS IS SOMETHING DIFFERENT. WELL, SOMETHING MORE AND
HE TOLD MR. WEASLEY EVERYTHING HE HAD EVER HEARD BETWEEN MALFOY

AND SNAPE. AS HARRY SPEAK, HE SAW LUPIN'S HEAD TURN A LITTLE TOWARD HIM, TAKING IN EVERY WORD. WHEN HE HAD FINISHED, THERE WAS SILENCE, EXCEPT FOR CELESTINA'S CRYING. OH, MY POOR HEART, WHERE WAS IT GONE? IT'S LEFT ME FOR A SPELL. WAS IT BECAUSE THE YELL, HARRY, SAID MR. WEASLEY, THAT SNAPE WAS SIMPLY PRETENDING?

PRETENDING THE HATER HELP, SHE THAT HE COULD FIND OUT WHAT MALFOY'S UP TO? SAID HARRY QUICKLY. YES, I THOUGHT YOU'D SAY THAT, BUT THEN WE KNOW? IT ISN'T HIS BUSINESS TO KNOW, SAID LUPIN UNEXPECTEDLY, HE HAD TURNED HIS BACK WHEN THE FIRE RAN AND FACED HARRY ACROSS MR. WEASLEY. IT'S DUMBLEDORE'S BUSINESS. DUMBLEDORE TRUSTS SEVERUS, AND THAT MIGHT BE ALL RIGHT FOR ALL HIS. BUT, SAID HARRY, JUST SAY JUST SAY DUMBLEDORE'S WRONG ABOUT SNAPE. PEOPLE HAVE SAID IT, MANY TIMES. IT COMES DOWN TO WHETHER OR NOT YOU TRUST DUMBLEDORE'S JUDGMENT. I DO; THEREFORE, I TRUST SEVERUS. BUT DUMBLEDORE CAN MAKE MISTAKES, ARGUED HARRY. HE SAYS IT HIMSELF, AND YOU HE HEARD LUPIN STRAIGHT IN THE EYE DO YOU HONESTLY LIKE SNAPE? I NEITHER LIKE NOR DISLIKE SEVERUS, SAID LUPIN. NO, HARRY, I AM SPEAKING THE TRUTH. HE ADDED, AS HARRY PULLED A SKEPTICAL EXPRESSION. WE SHALL NEVER BE CLOSE FRIENDS, PERHAPS; AFTER ALL THAT HAPPENED BETWEEN JAMES AND SIRIUS AND SEVERUS, THERE IS TOO MUCH BITTERNESS THERE. BUT I DO NOT FORGET THAT DURING THE YEAR I TAUGHT AT HOGWARTS, SEVERUS MADE THE WHEELBARROW POTION FOR ME EVERY MONTH, MADE IT PERFECTLY, SHE THAT I DID NOT HAVE THE SLIPPER AS I USUALLY DO AT THE FULL MOON. BUT HE ACCIDENTALLY LET IT SLIP THAT YOU'RE A WEREWOLF, SHE THAT HAD THE LEAVE? SAID HARRY ANGRILY, LUPIN SMILED. THE NEWS WOULD HAVE LEAKED OUT ANYWAY, WE BOTH KNOW HE WANTED MY LIFE, BUT HE COULD HAVE WRECKED MUCH WORSE DAMAGE ON ME BY TAMPERING WITH THE POTION. HE KEPT ME HEALTHY, I MUST BE GRATEFUL. MAYBE HE DIDN'T DARE MESS WITH THE POTION WITH DUMBLEDORE WATCHING HIM? SAID HARRY. YOU ARE DETERMINED TO HATE HIM, HARRY, SAID LUPIN WITH A FAINT SMILE.

AND I UNDERSTAND; WITH JAMES AS YOUR FATHER, WITH SIRIUS AS YOUR GODFATHER, YOU HAVE INHERITED AN OLD PREJUDICE. BY ALL MEANS TELL DUMBLEDORE WHAT YOU HAVE TOLD ARTHUR AND ME, BUT DO NOT EXPECT HIM TO SHARE YOUR VIEW OF THE MATTER; DO NOT EVEN EXPECT HIM TO BE SURPRISED BY WHAT YOU TELL HIM. IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN ON DUMBLEDORE'S ORDERS THAT SEVERUS MURDERED DRACO. AND NOW

WELL YE THEN IT FLITE APART I LL TE-ANDX WELL TH GIVE BACK MY HEART!
CELESTINA ENDED HER SHING HEN A VERY LONG, HIGH-PITCHED NITE AND
WELLD APPLAISE ISSUED FLIT HF THE WIRELESS, WHICH MRS. WEASLEY
THINKD IN WITH ENTHUSIASTICALLY. REZ RET EVER? SAID FLELR WELLDY.

TE-ANDX GOODNESS, WHAT AN HORRIBLE SHALL WE HAVE A
NIGHT-LAP, THEN? ASKED MR. WEASLEY WELLDY, LEAPING THE HIS FEET.

WELL WANTS REGENEC? WHAT HAVE WELL BEEN LIP THE LATELY? F-HARRY
ASKED FLIPIN, AS MR. WEASLEY ELISTED HF THE PETCH THE REGENEC, AND
EVERYBODY ELSE STRETCHED AND KROCK INTH CONVERSATION. EH, I VE
BEEN LINDERGHELD, SAID FLIPIN, ALMHST LITERALLY. THAT S WED I
HAVEN T BEEN ABLE TH WRITE, F-HARRY, SENDING LETTERS TH WELL WELLD
HAVE BEEN SHETHING HF A CIVILWAY. WHAT DEE WELL MEAN? I VE
BEEN LIVING AMONG MY FELLHLS, MY KHLALS, SAID FLIPIN.

WEREWELVES, HE ADDD, AT F-HARRY S LHHX HF INCHMPREHENSION.

NEARLY ALL HF THEM ARE HEN VHEDEMENT S SIDE, DLMKLEDEHE WANTED A
SPY AND HERE I WAS READY-MADE. F-HR SHLND A LITTLE BITTER, AND
PERHAPS REALIZED IT, AER HE SMILED MEHR WARMLY AS HE WENT HEN. I
AM NEET CHMPLAINING; IT IS NECESSARY WHORX AND WELH CAN DEE IT BETTER
THAN I? F-HEWEVER, IT HAS BEEN DIFFICULT GAINING THEIR TRUST, I BEAR
THE UNMISTAKABLE SIGNS HF HAVING TRIED TH LIVE AMONG WIZARDS, WELL
SEE, WHEREAS THEY HAVE SHLNNED NEHRMAL SHCIETY AND LIVE HEN THE
MARGINS, STEALING AND SHETHING KILLING THE RAT. F-HW CHRE
THEY LIKE VHEDEMENT? THEY THIND THAT, LINDER HIS RULE, THEY WILL
HAVE A BETTER LIFE, SAID FLIPIN. AND IT IS HARD TH ARGLE WITH
GREYRACK FLIT THERE. WELH S GREYRACK? WELL HAVEN T HEARD

HF HIM? FLIPIN S HANDS CHESD CHNYLSTIVELY IN HIS LAP. FENRIR
GREYRACK IS, PERHAPS, THE MEHT SAVAGE WEREWELF ALIVE THDAY. F-HR
REGARDS IT AS HIS MISSION IN LIFE TH KITE AND TH CHNTAMINATE AS
MANY PEEPLE AS POSSIBLE; HE WANTS TH CREATE KNEELGH WEREWELVES
TH EVERCHME TH WIZARDS. VHEDEMENT HAS PROMISED HIM PREY IN
RETLRN AER HIS SERVICES. GREYRACK SPECIALIZES IN CHILDREN. KITE
THEM WELING, HE SAYS, AND RAISE THEM AWAY FROM THEIR PARENTS,
RAISE THEM TH HATE NEHRMAL WIZARDS. VHEDEMENT HAS THREATENED TH
UNLEASH HIM LIPEN PEEPLE S SHENS AND DALIGHTERS; IT IS A THREAT
THAT USUALLY PRODUCES CHHD RESULTS. FLIPIN PALSED AND THEN SAID,

IT WAS GREYRACK WELH KIT ME. WHAT? SAID F-HARRY, ASTENISHED.

WELH WHEN WELL WERE A BID, WELL MEAN? YES, MY FATHER HAD
HAPPENDED HIM, I DID NEET KNELH, AER A VERY LONG TIME, THE IDENTITY HF

THE WEREWOLF WHO HAD ATTACKED ME? I EVEN FELT PITY FOR HIM, THINKING THAT HE HAD HAD NO CHOICE, KNOWING BY THEN HOW IT FELT THE TRANSFORM, BUT CROCODER IS NOT LIKE THAT. AT THE SAME TIME, HE POSITIONED HIMSELF AMONG THE VICTIMS, ENSURING THAT HE IS NEAR ENOUGH TO STRIKE. HE PLANS IT ALL, AND THIS IS THE MAIN PROBLEM IS LISTING THE MARCHES OF THE WEREWOLVES. I CANNOT PRETEND THAT MY PARTICULAR BRAND OF REASONED ARGUMENT IS MAKING MUCH HEADWAY AGAINST CROCODER'S INSISTENCE THAT WE WEREWOLVES DESERVE BLAME, THAT WE WOULD GET THE REVENGE OURSELVES AND NORMAL PEOPLE. BUT WE ARE NORMAL! SAID HARRY FIRMLY. YOU'VE JUST GOT A PROBLEM

BLIPIN FIRST WENT LAUGHING. SOMETIMES YOU REMIND ME A LOT OF JAMES. HE CALLED IT MY FLORRY LITTLE PROBLEM IN COMPANY. MANY PEOPLE WERE UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT I HAD A BADLY KEPT SECRET. HE ACCEPTED A GLASS OF EGGS FROM MR. WEASLEY WITH A WORD OF THANKS, SMILING SLIGHTLY MORE CHEERFUL. HARRY, MEANWHILE, FELT A RUSH OF EXCITEMENT! THIS LAST MENTION OF HIS FATHER HAD REMINDED HIM THAT THERE WAS SOMETHING HE HAD BEEN THINKING ABOUT ASKING BLIPIN. I'VE YOU EVER HEARD OF SOMEBODY CALLED THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE? THE HALF-BLOOD WHAT?

PRINCE, SAID HARRY, WATCHING HIM CLOSELY FOR SIGNS OF RECOGNITION. THERE ARE NO WIZARDING PRINCES, SAID BLIPIN, NOW SMILING. IS THIS A TITLE YOU'RE THINKING OF ADOPTING? I SHOULD HAVE THOUGHT OF BEING THE CHOSEN ONE WOULD BE ENOUGH. IT'S NOTHING TO DO WITH ME! SAID HARRY INDIGNANTLY. THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE IS SOMEBODY WHO LIVED IN THE HOGWARTS. I'VE GOT HIS OLD POTION BOOK. HE WROTE SPELLS ALL OVER IT, SPELLS HE INVENTED. ONE OF THEM WAS LEVITICORPUS. HE, THAT ONE HAD A GREAT VOICE DURING MY TIME AT HOGWARTS, SAID BLIPIN REMINISCENTLY. THERE WERE A FEW MONTHS IN MY FIFTH YEAR WHEN YOU CHILDREN TALKED ABOUT BEING WHISTLED INTO THE AIR BY YOUR ANGEL. MY DAD USED IT, SAID HARRY. I SAW HIM IN THE PENITENT, HE USED IT ON SNAPE. HE TRIED TO SEEM CASUAL, AS THOUGH THIS WAS A TRIVIAL COMMENT OF NO REAL IMPORTANCE, BUT HE WAS NOT SURE HE HAD ACHIEVED THE RIGHT EFFECT! BLIPIN'S SMILE WAS A LITTLE MORE UNDERSTANDING. YES, HE SAID,

BUT HE WASN'T THE ONLY ONE. AS I SAY, IT WAS VERY POPULAR. YOU KNOW HOW THESE SPELLS CAME AND GO. BUT IT SEEMS LIKE IT WAS INVENTED WHILE YOU WERE AT SCHOOL. HARRY PERSISTED. NOT NECESSARILY, SAID BLIPIN. LOOKS GO IN AND OUT OF FASHION LIKE

EVERYTHING ELSE. HE LOOKED INTO HARRY'S FACE AND THEN SAID QUIETLY, JAMES WAS A POLYGLLOT, HARRY, AND I PROMISE YOU, HE NEVER ASKED US TO CALL HIM PRINCE. ABANDONING PRETENSE, HARRY SAID, AND IT WASN'T SIRIUS? HER YOU? DEFINITELY NOT. EH. HARRY STARED INTO THE FIRE. I JUST THOUGHT WELL, HE'S HELPED ME GET A LOT IN POTTENS CLASSES, THE PRINCE HAS. WHEN WAS THIS BOOK, HARRY? I DON'T KNOW, I'VE NEVER CHECKED. WELL, PERHAPS THAT WILL GIVE YOU SOME CLUE AS TO WHEN THE PRINCE WAS AT HOGWARTS, SAID LUPIN. SHORTLY AFTER THIS, FLEUR DECIDED TO IMITATE CELESTINA SINGING A CALABRESE SONG OF LOVE, STRONG LOVE, WHICH WAS TAKEN BY EVERYONE, SINCE THEY HAD GIMPSED MRS. WEASLEY'S EXPRESSION, THE WAY SHE WAS THE ONE THE RED, HARRY AND RON CLIMBED ALL THE WAY UP THE ROOF'S ATTIC BEDROOM, WHERE A LAMP HAD BEEN ADDED FOR HARRY, RON FELL ASLEEP ALMOST IMMEDIATELY, BUT HARRY DELVED INTO HIS TROUSER AND PULLED OUT HIS COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING BEFORE GETTING INTO THE BED. THERE HE TURNED ITS PAGES, SEARCHING, UNTIL HE FINALLY FOUND, AT THE FRONT OF THE BOOK, THE DATE THAT IT HAD BEEN PUBLISHED. IT WAS NEARLY FIFTY YEARS OLD. NEITHER HIS FATHER, NOR HIS FATHER'S FRIENDS, HAD BEEN AT HOGWARTS FIFTY YEARS AGO, FEELING DISAPPOINTED, HARRY THREW THE BOOK BACK INTO HIS TROUSER, TURNED OFF THE LAMP, AND ROLLED OVER, THINKING OF WEREWOLVES AND SNAPE, STAN SHLIMPER AND THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE, AND FINALLY FALLING INTO AN UNEASY SLEEP FULL OF CREEPING SHADOWS AND THE CRIES OF KITTEN CHILDREN. SHE'S GET THE RED THINKING. HARRY Woke WITH A START TO FIND A SLINGING SNEAKING LYING OVER THE END OF HIS BED. HE PLUTED HIS GLASSES AND LOOKED AROUND; THE TINY WINDOW WAS ALMOST COMPLETELY OBTURED WITH SNOW AND, IN FRONT OF IT, RON WAS SITTING UP UPRIGHT IN BED AND EXAMINING WHAT APPEARED TO BE A THICK GOLD CHAIN. WHAT'S THAT? ASKED HARRY. IT'S FROM LAVENDER, SAID RON, SHLINDING REVELED. SHE CAN'T HONESTLY THINK I'D WEAR HARRY LOOKED MORE CLOSELY AND LET OUT A SILENT OF LAUGHTER. DANGLING FROM THE CHAIN IN LARGE GOLD LETTERS WERE THE WORDS:

NICE, HE SAID, CLASSY, YOU SHOULD DEFINITELY WEAR IT IN FRONT OF FRED AND GEORGE. IF YOU TELL THEM, SAID RON, SHOWING THE NECKLACE OUT OF SIGHT UNDER HIS PILLOW, I I I

STUTTER AT ME? SAID HARRY, GRINNING. COME ON, WOULD I? WHEN WOULD SHE THINK I'D LIKE SOMETHING LIKE THAT, THOUGH? RON DEMANDED OF THIN AIR, LOOKING RATHER SHOCKED. WELL, THINK BACK,

SAID HARRY, HAVE YOU EVER LET IT SLIP THAT YOU'D LIKE THE GIN HUNT IN PUBLIC WITH THE WHIRLS MY SWEETHEART REELING YOUR NECK?

WELL WE DIDN'T REALLY TALK MUCH, SAID RON. IT'S MAINLY SNEGGING, SAID HARRY. WELL, YEAH, SAID RON, HE HESITATED A MOMENT, THEN SAID, IS HERMIONE REALLY GOING HUNT WITH MCLAGGEN? I DUNNED, SAID HARRY, THEY WERE AT SLUGGERTON'S PARTY TOGETHER, BUT I DIDN'T THINK IT WENT THAT WELL. RON SMILED SLIGHTLY MORE CHEERFUL AS HE DELVED DEEPER INTO HIS STOCKING. HARRY'S PRESENTS INCLUDED A SWEATER WITH A LARGE GOLDEN SNITCH WHIRLED INTO THE FRONT, HAND-KNITTED BY MRS. WEASLEY, A LARGE BOX OF WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEAKNESSES PRODUKTS FROM THE TWINS, AND A SLIGHTLY DAMP, MELODYSMELLING PACKAGE THAT CAME WITH A LABEL READING THE MASTER, FROM DREADFUL. HARRY STARED AT IT.

D YOU REMEMBER THIS IS SAFE THE HUNT? HE ASKED. CAN'T BE ANYTHING DANGEROUS, ALL THEIR MAIL'S STILL BEING SEARCHED AT THE MINISTRY, REPLIED RON, THOUGH HE WAS PYING THE PARCEL SUSPICIOUSLY. I DIDN'T THINK OF GIVING DREADFUL ANYTHING, DID PEOPLE USUALLY GIVE THEIR FURSE-ELVES CHRISTMAS PRESENTS? ASKED HARRY, PRODDING THE PARCEL CAUTIOUSLY. HERMIONE WOULD, SAID RON, BUT LET'S WAIT AND SEE WHAT IT IS BEFORE YOU START FEELING GUILTY. A MOMENT LATER, HARRY HAD GIVEN A LITTLE YELL AND BROPT HUNT OF HIS CAMP BED; THE PACKAGE CONTAINED A LARGE NUMBER OF MAGGOTS. NICE, SAID RON, CHUCKLING WITH LAUGHTER. VERY THOUGHTFUL. I'D RATHER HAVE THEM THAN THAT NECKLACE, SAID HARRY, WHICH SHOOKED RON UP AT ONCE. EVERYBODY WAS WEARING NEW SWEATERS WHEN THEY ALL SAT DOWN FOR CHRISTMAS LUNCH, EVERYONE EXCEPT FLEUR (WHEN WE'VE IT APPEARED, MRS. WEASLEY HAD NOT WANTED THE WASTE HERE) AND MRS. WEASLEY HERSELF, WHO WAS SPOTTING A BRAND-NEW MIDNIGHT BLUE DRESS THAT GLITTERING WITH WHAT LOOKED LIKE TINY STARLIKE DIAMONDS, AND A SPECTACULAR GOLDEN NECKLACE. FRED AND GEORGE GAVE THEM THE ME: AREN'T THEY BEAUTIFUL? WELL, WE FIND WE APPRECIATE YOU MORE AND MORE, MOM, WHEN WE'RE WASHING OUR OWN SHIRTS, SAID GEORGE, WAVING AN AIRY HAND. PARSNIPS, REMINDS? HARRY, YOU'VE GOT A MAGGOT IN YOUR HAIR, SAID GINNY CHEERFULLY, LEANING ACROSS THE TABLE TO PICK IT UP; HARRY FELT GROSS KLIMPS ERLIPT UP HIS NECK THAT HAD NOTHING TO DO WITH THE MAGGOT. HOW HORRIBLE, SAID FLEUR, WITH AN AFFECTED LITTLE SHUDDER. YES, ISN'T IT? SAID RON, GRAY, FLEUR? IN HIS EAGERNESS TO HELP HER, HE BROOKED THE

GRAVY BEAT FLYING; BILL WAVED HIS HAND AND THE GRAVY SHARED LIP IN THE AIR AND RETURNED MEEKLY THE THE BEAT. 'THEY ARE AS BAD AS ZAT THINGS,' SAID FLEUR THE DEEN, WHEN SHE HAD FINISHED MISSING BILL IN TEARFULS. SHE IS ALWAYS DRINKING. I INVITED DEAR THINGS THE CHEER ALONG TODAY, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, SETTING DOWN THE CARPETS WITH UNNECESSARY FORCE AND GLARING AT FLEUR. BUT SHE WOULDNT COME. HAVE YOU SPOKEN TO HER LATELY, PERCY? NO, I HAVEN'T BEEN IN CONTACT WITH ANYBODY VERY MUCH, SAID LUPIN. BUT THINGS HAS GOTTEN HER OWN FAMILY THE GIVE THE, HASN'T SHE? I'M SURE, SAID MRS. WEASLEY. MAYBE, I GOT THE IMPRESSION SHE WAS PLANNING TO SPEND CHRISTMAS ALONE, ACTUALLY. SHE GAVE LUPIN AN ANNOYED LOOK, AS THOUGH IT WAS ALL HIS FAULT SHE WAS GETTING FLEUR FOR A DAUGHTER-IN-LAW INSTEAD OF THINGS, BUT HARRY, GLANCING ACROSS AT FLEUR, WHO WAS NOW FEEDING BILL BITS OF TURKEY OFF HER OWN FORK, THOUGHT THAT MRS. WEASLEY WAS FIGHTING A LONG-LOST BATTLE. HE WAS, HOWEVER, REMINDED OF A MISTAKE HE HAD WITH REGARD TO THINGS, AND WHEN BETTER THE ASK THAN LUPIN, THE MAN WHO KNEW ALL ABOUT PATRONUSES? THINGS'S PATRONUS HAS CHANGED ITS FORM, HE TOLD HIM. SNAPE SAID SHE ANYWAY, I DIDN'T KNOW THAT COULD HAPPEN. WHY WOULD YOUR PATRONUS CHANGE? LUPIN TOOK HIS TIME CHWING HIS TURKEY AND SHAKELING KEPT SAYING SILENTLY, SOMETIMES A GREAT STICK AN EMOTIONAL LIFE-RAVAGE. IT LOOKED BIG, AND IT HAD FEELER LEGS, SAID HARRY, STRUCK BY A SUDDEN THOUGHT AND LOWERING HIS VOICE. YES IT COULDN'T BE? ARTHUR? SAID MRS. WEASLEY SUDDENLY. SHE HAD RISEN FROM HER CHAIR; HER HAND WAS PRESSED OVER HER HEART AND SHE WAS STARING OUT OF THE KITCHEN WINDOW. ARTHUR IT'S PERCY? WHAT? MR. WEASLEY LOOKED AROUND, EVERYBODY LOOKED QUICKLY AT THE WINDOW; GINNY STOOD UP FOR A BETTER LOOK. THERE, SURE ENOUGH, WAS PERCY WEASLEY, STRIDING ACROSS THE SNOWY YARD, HIS BROWN-RIMMED GLASSES GLINTING IN THE SUNLIGHT. HE WAS NEET, HOWEVER, ALONE. ARTHUR, HE'S HE'S WITH THE MINISTER? AND SURE ENOUGH, THE MAN HARRY HAD SEEN IN THE DAILY PROPHET WAS FOLLOWING ALONG IN PERCY'S WAKE, LIMPING SLIGHTLY, HIS MANK OF GRAYING HAIR AND HIS BLACK CLOAK FLECKED WITH SNOW. BEFORE ANY OF THEM COULD SAY ANYTHING, BEFORE MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY COULD DO MORE THAN EXCHANGE STUNNED LOOKS, THE BACK DOOR OPENED AND THERE STOOD PERCY. THERE WAS A MOMENT'S PAINFUL SILENCE. THEN PERCY SAID RATHER STIFFLY, MERRY CHRISTMAS,

MEET HER. "H-H, PERCY!" SAID MRS. WEASLEY, AND SHE THREW HERSELF INTO HIS ARMS. ROLPH SCRIMGEWELL PAUSED IN THE DOORWAY, LEANING ON HIS WALKING STICK AND SMILING AS HE OBSERVED THIS AFFECTING SCENE. "WELL MUST FORGIVE THIS INTERLUDE," HE SAID, WHEN MRS. WEASLEY WHEEZED AROUND AT HIM, KEATING AND WIPING HER EYES.

PERCY AND I WERE IN THE VICINITY, WHEEZING, "WELL, DEAR" AND THE CHILDREN TO RESIST DRIPPING IN AND SEEING "WELL" ALL. BUT PERCY SEEMED NOT SIGN OF WANTING THE GREET AND OF THE REST OF THE FAMILY. HE STOOD, PEEKER-STRAIGHT AND AHEADWARD-LOOKING, AND STARED EVER EVERYBODY ELSE'S HEADS. MR. WEASLEY, FRED, AND GEORGE WERE ALL OBSERVING HIM, STONY-FACED. "PLEASE, COME IN, SIT DOWN, MINISTER!" FLUTTERED MRS. WEASLEY, STRAIGHTENING HER HAT. "HAVE A LITTLE PLUMBER, HER SOME THINGING. I MEAN" "NEH, NEH, MY DEAR MUM," SAID SCRIMGEWELL, "HARRY GUESSED THAT HE HAD CHECKED HER NAME WITH PERCY BEFORE THEY ENTERED THE HOUSE. I DON'T WANT THE INTERLUDE, WOULD I BE HERE AT ALL IF PERCY HADN'T WANTED TO SEE "WELL" ALL SHE EASILY. "H-H, PERCY!" SAID MRS. WEASLEY TEARFULLY, REACHING UP TO KISS HIM. "WE'VE ONLY LOOKED IN FOR FIVE MINUTES, SEE I'LL HAVE A STRIMM AROUND THE YARD WHILE "WELL" CATCH UP WITH PERCY. NEH, NEH, I ASSURE "WELL" I DON'T WANT THE BUTT IN! WELL, IF ANYBODY CARED THE STIMM ME "WELL" CHARMING GARDEN. "A-H, THAT "WELL" MAN'S FINISHED, WHY DOESN'T HE TAKE A STRIMM WITH ME? THE ATMOSPHERE AROUND THE TABLE CHANGED PERCEPTIBLY. EVERYBODY LOOKED FROM SCRIMGEWELL THE "HARRY. NOBODY SEEMED TO FIND SCRIMGEWELL'S PRETENSE THAT HE DID NOT KNOW "HARRY'S NAME CONVINCING. HER FIND IT NATURAL THAT HE SHOULD BE CHOSEN TO ACCOMPANY THE MINISTER AROUND THE GARDEN WHEN GINNY, FLEET, AND GEORGE ALSO HAD CLEAN PLATES. "YEAH, ALL RIGHT," SAID "HARRY INTO THE SILENCE. HE WAS NOT FHEELED; FOR ALL SCRIMGEWELL'S TALK THAT THEY HAD JUST BEEN IN THE AREA, THAT PERCY WANTED TO LOOK UP HIS FAMILY, THIS MUST BE THE REAL REASON THAT THEY HAD COME, SEE THAT SCRIMGEWELL COULD SPREAD THE "HARRY ALONE.

IT'S FINE, HE SAID BRIEFLY, AS HE PASSED LIMPING, WHEN HE HAD HALF RISEN FROM HIS CHAIR. FINE, HE ADDED, AS MR. WEASLEY OPENED HIS MOUTH TO SPEAK. "WONDERFUL!" SAID SCRIMGEWELL, STANDING BACK TO LET "HARRY PASS THROUGH THE DOOR AHEAD OF HIM. "WE'LL JUST TAKE A TURN AROUND THE GARDEN, AND PERCY AND I'LL BE HERE, "HARRY MEN, EVERYONE!" "HARRY WALKED ACROSS THE YARD TOWARD THE WEASLEYS EVERGREEN, SNELLYVERED GARDEN, SCRIMGEWELL LIMPING SLIGHTLY AT

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HIS SIDE, HE HAD, HARRY KNEW, BEEN HEAD OF THE ALBION OFFICE; HE
LOOKED THICK AND RATTLE-SCARED, VERY DIFFERENT FROM PHILLY FUDGE
IN HIS BECKER HAT. CHARMING, SAID SCRIMGEOR, STOPPING AT THE
GARDEN FENCE AND LOOKING OUT OVER THE SNOWY LAWN AND THE
INDISTINGUISHABLE PLANTS. CHARMING. HARRY SAID NOTHING. HE
COULD TELL THAT SCRIMGEOR WAS WATCHING HIM. I'VE WANTED TO MEET
YOU FOR A VERY LONG TIME, SAID SCRIMGEOR, AFTER A FEW MOMENTS.

DID YOU KNOW THAT? NO, SAID HARRY TRUTHFULLY. YES, FOR A
VERY LONG TIME, BUT DUMBLEDORE HAS BEEN VERY PROTECTIVE OF YOU,
SAID SCRIMGEOR. NATURAL, OF COURSE, NATURAL, AFTER WHAT YOU'VE
BEEN THROUGH. ESPECIALLY WHAT HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY
HE WAITED FOR HARRY TO SAY SOMETHING, BUT HARRY DID NOT BELIEVE,
SEE HE WENT ON. I HAVE BEEN HOPING FOR AN OCCASION TO TALK TO
YOU EVER SINCE I GAINED OFFICE, BUT DUMBLEDORE HAS MOST
UNDERSTANDABLY, AS I SAY PREVENTED THIS. STILL, HARRY SAID
NOTHING, WAITING. THE RUMORS THAT HAVE BEEN AROUND? SAID
SCRIMGEOR. WELL, OF COURSE, WE BOTH KNOW HOW THESE STORIES GET
DISTORTED ALL THESE WHISPERS OF A PROPHECY OF YOU BEING THE
CHIEF ONE THEY WERE GETTING NEAR IT NOW, HARRY THOUGHT,
THE REASON SCRIMGEOR WAS HERE. I ASSUME THAT DUMBLEDORE
HAS DISCUSSED THESE MATTERS WITH YOU? HARRY DELIBERATED,
WONDERING WHETHER HE MIGHT TELL HER NOT, HE LOOKED AT THE LITTLE
GOOSE PRINTS ALL AROUND THE FLOWERS, AND THE SLOPPED-LIP PATCH
THAT MARKED THE SPOT WHERE FRED HAD CALLED THE GOOSE YOU
WEARING THE TILT AT THE TOP OF THE CHRISTMAS TREE. FINALLY, HE
DECIDED ON THE TRUTH. HE A BIT OF IT. YES, WE'VE DISCUSSED IT.

HAVE YOU, HAVE YOU SAID SCRIMGEOR. HARRY COULD SEE, OUT OF
THE CORNER OF HIS EYE, SCRIMGEOR SMILING AT HIM, SEE HE
PRETENDED TO BE VERY INTERESTED IN A GOOSE THAT HAD JUST POCKED ITS
HEAD OUT FROM UNDERNEATH A FROZEN RHODODENDRON. AND WHAT HAS
DUMBLEDORE TOLD YOU, HARRY? SHH, BUT THAT'S BETWEEN US, SAID
HARRY. HE KEPT HIS VOICE AS PLEASANT AS HE COULD, AND
SCRIMGEOR'S THEN, THEN, WAS LIGHT AND FRIENDLY AS HE SAID. YES, OF
COURSE, IF IT'S A QUESTION OF CONFIDENCES, I WOULDN'T WANT YOU TO
DIVULGE NO, NO AND IN ANY CASE, DOES IT REALLY MATTER
WHETHER YOU ARE THE CHIEF ONE OR NOT? HARRY HAD THE MIND
THAT HAD EVER FOR A FEW SECONDS BEFORE RESPONDING. I DON'T REALLY
KNOW WHAT YOU MEAN, MINISTER. WELL, OF COURSE, THE YOU IT WILL

MATTER ENTHUSIASTICALLY, SAID SCRIMPGEUR WITH A LAUGH, BUT THE THE
WIZARDING COMMUNITY AT LARGE IT'S ALL PERCEPTION, ISN'T IT? IT'S
WHAT PEOPLE BELIEVE THAT'S IMPORTANT. HARRY SAID NOTHING, HE
THOUGHT HE SAW, DIMLY, WHERE THEY WERE HEADING, BUT HE WAS NOT
GIVING THE HELP SCRIMPGEUR GET THERE. THE ENGINE UNDER THE
RE-RENDERER WAS NOW DIGGING FOR WORMS AT ITS ROOTS, AND HARRY
KEPT HIS EYES FIXED UPON IT. PEOPLE BELIEVE THEY ARE THE CHOSEN
ONE, THEY SEE, SAID SCRIMPGEUR. THEY THINK THEY BELIEVE THE HERO

WHICH, OF COURSE, THEY ARE, HARRY, CHOSEN ARE NOT? HOW MANY
TIMES HAVE THEY FACED THE-WE-TH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED WELL,
ANYWAY, HE PRESSED ON, WITHOUT WAITING FOR A REPLY, THE POINT
IS, THEY ARE A SYMBOL OF HOPE FOR MANY, HARRY. THE IDEA THAT THERE
IS SOMEHOW THAT THERE WE-TH-MIGHT BE ABLE, WE-TH-MIGHT EVEN BE
DESTINED, THE DESTINY THE-WE-TH-MUST-NOT-BE-NAMED WELL,
NATURALLY, IT GIVES PEOPLE A LIFT, AND I CAN'T HELP BUT FEEL THAT,
HENCE THEY REALIZE THIS, THEY MIGHT CONSIDER IT, WELL, ALMOST A DUTY, THE
STAND ALONGSIDE THE MINISTRY, AND GIVE EVERYONE A BOOST. THE
ENGINE HAD JUST MANAGED THE GET HOLD OF A WORM. IT WAS NOW
TUGGING VERY HARD ON IT, TRYING THE GET IT OUT OF THE FROZEN
GROUNDS, HARRY WAS SILENT SEEING THAT SCRIMPGEUR SAID, LISTENING
FROM HARRY THE THE ENGINE, FLINDY LITTLE CHAPS, AREN'T THEY? BUT
WHAT SAY YOU, HARRY? I DON'T EXACTLY UNDERSTAND WHAT YOU
WANT, SAID HARRY SILENTLY. STAND ALONGSIDE THE MINISTRY
WHAT DOES THAT MEAN? EH, WELL, NOTHING AT ALL HONESTLY, I
ASSURE YOU, SAID SCRIMPGEUR. IF YOU WERE THE BE SEEN PEEPING IN
AND OUT OF THE MINISTRY FROM TIME TO TIME, FOR INSTANCE, THAT
WOULD GIVE THE RIGHT IMPRESSION, AND OF COURSE, WHILE YOU WERE
THERE, YOU WOULD HAVE AMPLE OPPORTUNITY TO SPREAD THE GALADIN
REMARKS, MY SUCCESSOR AS HEAD OF THE ALIEN OFFICE, DEWEES
LIMBRIDGE HAS TOLD ME THAT YOU CHERISH AN AMBITION TO BECOME AN
ALIEN, WELL, THAT COULD BE ARRANGED VERY EASILY. HARRY FELT
ANGER BUBBLING IN THE PIT OF HIS STOMACH: SEE DEWEES LIMBRIDGE WAS
STILL AT THE MINISTRY, WAS SHE? SHE BASICALLY, HE SAID, AS THOUGH
HE JUST WANTED THE CLARIFY A FEW POINTS, YOU'D LIKE THE GIVE THE
IMPRESSION THAT I'M WORKING FOR THE MINISTRY? IT WOULD GIVE
EVERYONE A LIFT THE THINK YOU WERE MORE INVOLVED, HARRY, SAID
SCRIMPGEUR, SOUNDING RELIEVED THAT HARRY HAD CHATTERED ON SEE
EASILY. THE CHOSEN ONE, YOU KNOW IT'S ALL ABOUT GIVING

PEOPLE FEEL THE FEELING THAT EXCITING THINGS ARE HAPPENING.

BUT IF I KEEP RUNNING IN AND OUT OF THE MINISTRY, SAID HARRY, STILL ENDEAVOURING TO KEEP HIS VOICE FRIENDLY, WHEN THAT SEEM AS THOUGH I APPROVE OF WHAT THE MINISTRY IS UP TO? WELL, SAID SCRIMGEWORM, SMILING SLIGHTLY, WELL, YES, THAT IS PARTLY WHY WE DO LIKE. NO, I DON'T THINK THAT AT ALL, SAID HARRY PLEASANTLY.

WELL SEE, I DON'T LIKE SOME OF THE THINGS THE MINISTRY IS DOING, LOOKING UP STAN SHLIPPER, FOR INSTANCE. SCRIMGEWORM DID NOT SPEAK FOR A MOMENT BUT HIS EXPRESSION HARDENED INSTANTLY. I WOULD NOT EXPECT YOU TO UNDERSTAND, HE SAID, AND HE WAS NOT AS SUCCESSFUL AT KEEPING ANGER OUT OF HIS VOICE AS HARRY HAD BEEN.

THESE ARE DANGEROUS TIMES, AND CERTAIN MEASURES NEED TO BE TAKEN, YOU ARE SIXTEEN YEARS OLD. OLIVERBARKER IS A LITTLE OLDER THAN SIXTEEN, AND HE DOESN'T THINK STAN SHOULD BE IN AZKABAN EITHER, SAID HARRY, YOU'RE MAKING STAN A SCAPEGOAT, JUST LIKE YOU WANT TO MAKE ME A MURDERER. THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, LONG AND HARD, FINALLY SCRIMGEWORM SAID, WITH NO PRETENSE AT WARMTY, I SEE, YOU PREFER LIKE YOUR FRIEND OLIVERBARKER THE DISASSOCIATE YOURSELF FROM THE MINISTRY? I DON'T WANT TO BE LIES, SAID HARRY, SOME WOULD SAY IT IS YOUR DUTY TO BE LIES BY THE MINISTRY? YES, AND OTHERS MIGHT SAY IT IS YOUR DUTY TO CHECK THAT PEOPLE REALLY ARE DEATH EATERS BEFORE YOU CHECK THEM IN PRISON, SAID HARRY, HIS TEMPER RISING NOW, YOU'RE DOING WHAT BARTY CRATCH DID, YOU NEVER GET IT RIGHT, YOU PEOPLE, DO YOU? EITHER WE'RE GET FLICK, PRETENDING EVERYTHING IS LEVELLY WHILE PEOPLE GET MURDERED RIGHT UNDER HIS NOSE, OR WE'RE GET YOU, CHECKING THE WRITING PEOPLE INTO THE LAIR AND TRYING TO PRETEND YOU'RE GET THE CHIEFS HERE WORKING FOR YOU? SEE YOU'RE NOT THE CHIEFS HERE? SAID SCRIMGEWORM, I THOUGHT YOU SAID IT DIDN'T MATTER EITHER WAY? SAID HARRY, WITH A BITTER LAUGH, NOT THE YOU ANYWAY. I SHOULDN'T HAVE SAID THAT, SAID SCRIMGEWORM ENLIVENLY.

IT WAS TACTLESS. NO, IT WAS HONEST, SAID HARRY, ONE OF THE ONLY HONEST THINGS YOU'VE SAID TO ME, YOU DON'T CARE WHETHER I LIVE OR DIE, BUT YOU DO CARE THAT I HELP YOU CONVINCE EVERYONE YOU'RE WINNING THE WAR AGAINST VOLDMORT. I HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN, MINISTER. HE RAISED HIS RIGHT FIST. THERE, SHINING WHITE ON THE BACK OF HIS CHILD HAND, WERE THE SCARS WHICH DEATHMURDER LAMBRIDGE HAD MARKED HIM THE CARVE INTO HIS OWN FLESH: I MUST NOT TELL LIES. I

DIDN'T REMEMBER WHY WISHING THE MY DEFENSE WHEN I WAS TRYING TO
TELL EVERYONE VERDERBERT WAS BACK. THE MINISTRY WASN'T SEEN
THEIR PALS LAST YEAR. THEY STOOD IN SILENCE AS ICE AS THE GRINDING
BENEATH THEIR FEET. THE Gnome HAD FINALLY MANAGED THE EXTRICATE
HIS WHIRM AND WAS NOW SLICKING HIM IT HAPPILY, LEANING AGAINST THE
BUTTERMEREEST BRANCHES OF THE REEDHEDENBROEN BUSH. WHAT IS
DUMBLEDORE UP TO? SAID SCRIMPGEUR BULSHIVELY. WHERE DOES HE GO
WHEN HE IS ABSENT FROM HOGWARTS? NO IDEA, SAID HARRY. AND
WHY WOULDN'T TELL ME IF YOU KNOW, SAID SCRIMPGEUR, WOULD YOU?

NO, I WOULDN'T, SAID HARRY. WELL, THEN, I SHALL HAVE TO SEE
WHETHER I CAN'T FIND HIM BY OTHER MEANS. YOU CAN TRY, SAID
HARRY INDIFFERENTLY. BUT YOU SEEM CLEVERER THAN FLICK, SEE I'D
HAVE THOUGHT YOU'D HAVE LEARNED FROM HIS MISTAKES. HE TRIED
INTERFERING AT HOGWARTS. YOU MIGHT HAVE NOTICED HE'S NOT
MINISTER ANYMORE, BUT DUMBLEDORE'S STILL HEADMASTER. I'D LEAVE
DUMBLEDORE ALONE, IF I WERE YOU. THERE WAS A LONG PAUSE. WELL, IT
IS CLEAR TO ME THAT HE HAS DONE A VERY GOOD JOB OF YOU, SAID
SCRIMPGEUR, HIS EYES COLD AND HARD BEHIND HIS WIRE-RIMMED GLASSES.

DUMBLEDORE'S MAN THROUGH AND THROUGH, AREN'T YOU, POTTERT?
YEAP, I AM, SAID HARRY. GLAD WE STRAIGHTENED THAT OUT. AND
TURNING HIS BACK ON THE MINISTER OF MAGIC, HE STRIDE BACK TOWARD
THE HALLS. A SLUGGISH MEMPHY LATE IN THE AFTERNOON, A FEW DAYS
AFTER NEW YEAR, HARRY, REHN, AND GINNY LINED UP BESIDE THE
KITCHEN FIRE TO RETURN THE HOGWARTS. THE MINISTRY HAD ARRANGED
THIS ONE-OFF CONNECTION TO THE FINE NETWORK TO RETURN STUDENTS
HOMELAND AND SAFELY TO THE SCHOOL. ONLY MRS. WEASLEY WAS THERE TO
SEE OFF, AS MR. WEASLEY, FRED, GEORGE, BILL, AND PETER WERE ALL AT
WORK. MRS. WEASLEY DISSEVED INTO TEARS AT THE MOMENT OF PARTING.
ADMITTEDLY, IT TOOK VERY LITTLE TO SET HER OFF LATELY; SHE HAD BEEN
CRYING HIM AND OFF EVER SINCE PERCY HAD STORMED FROM THE HALLS ON
CHRISTMAS DAY WITH HIS GLASSES SPLATTERED WITH MASHED PARSNIP
(FOR WHICH FRED, GEORGE, AND GINNY ALL CLAIMED CREDIT). DIDN'T CRY,
MUM, SAID GINNY, PATTING HER ON THE BACK AS MRS. WEASLEY SQUEELED
INTO HER SQUILDER. IT'S OKAY. YEAP, DIDN'T WHIRRY ABOUT US,
SAID REHN, PERMITTING HIS MOTHER TO PLANT A VERY WET KISS ON HIS
CHEEK. HE ABOUT PERCY, HE'S SUCH A PRAT, IT'S NOT REALLY A LOSS, IS
IT? MRS. WEASLEY SQUEELED HARDER THAN EVER AS SHE ENVELOPED HARRY
IN HER ARMS. PROMISE ME YOU'LL BE BACK AFTER YOURSELF. STAY HIM

HE TREMBLED. I ALWAYS SEE MRS. WEASLEY, SAID HARRY, I LIKE A
 QUIET LIFE, YELL DROVE ME. SHE GAVE A WATERY CHUCKLE AND STEPPED
 BACK. HE GHEED, THEN, ALL HE YELL. HARRY STEPPED INTO THE
 EMERALD FIRE AND SHOUTED F-HEGLARTS! HE HAD ONE LAST FLEETING
 VIEW OF THE WEASLEYS' KITCHEN AND MRS. WEASLEY'S TEARFUL FACE
 BEFORE THE FLAMES ENCLOSED HIM; SPINNING VERY FAST, HE CALGHT
 BLURRED GLIMPSES OF EITHER WIZARDING RHEIMS, WHICH WERE WHIPPED
 OUT OF SIGHT BEFORE HE COULD GET A PROPER VIEW; THEN HE WAS
 SLEETING DOWN, FINALLY STOPPING SHELARLY IN THE FIREPLACE IN
 PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S OFFICE. SHE BARELY GLANCED UP FROM HER
 WORK AS HE CLANKED OUT OVER THE GRATE. EVENING, BETTER, TRY
 NOT TO GET TOO MUCH ASH IN THE CARPET. NEH, PROFESSOR, HARRY
 STRAIGHTENED HIS GLASSES AND FLATTENED HIS HAIR AS RHEIN CAME
 SPINNING INTO VIEW. WHEN GINNY HAD ARRIVED, ALL THREE OF THEM
 TRIPPED OUT OF MCGONAGALL'S OFFICE AND OFF TOWARD GRYFFINDOR
 TOWER. HARRY GLANCED OUT OF THE HALLWAY WINDOWS AS THEY PASSED;
 THE SUN WAS ALREADY SINKING OVER GREENLANDS CARPETED IN DEEPER
 SHED THAN HAD LAIN OVER THE BURNING GARDEN. IN THE DISTANCE, HE
 COULD SEE HAGRID FEEDING BLURPLE IN FRONT OF HIS CABIN. BALBLES,
 SAID RHEIN CONFIDENTLY, WHEN THEY REACHED THE FAT LADY, WHO WAS
 LOOKING RATHER PALE THAN USUAL AND WINCED AT HIS WILD VOICE.

NEH, SHE SAID, WHAT DO YOU MEAN, NEH? THERE IS A NEW
 PASSWORD, SHE SAID, AND PLEASE DON'T SHOUT. BUT WE'VE BEEN
 AWAY, HOW ARE WE SUPPOSED TO ? HARRY, GINNY, HERMIONE
 WAS HURRYING TOWARD THEM, VERY PINK-FACED AND WEARING A CLOAK,
 HAT, AND GLOVES. I GOT BACK A COUPLE OF HOURS AGO, I'VE JUST BEEN
 DOWN THE VISIT HAGRID AND BLURPLE I MEAN WITHERWINGS, SHE SAID
 BREATHLESSLY. DID YOU HAVE A GOOD CHRISTMAS? YEAH, SAID RHEIN
 AT ONCE, PRETTY EVENTUALLY, JULIUS STRIP I'VE GOT SOMETHING
 FOR YOU, HARRY, SAID HERMIONE, NEITHER LOOKING AT RHEIN NOR
 GIVING ANY SIGN THAT SHE HAD HEARD HIM. HEH, HAVE AN
 PASSWORD, ABSTINENCE. PRECISELY, SAID THE FAT LADY IN A PEERLY
 VOICE, AND SWING FORWARD TO REVEAL THE PORTRAIT PEELE. WHAT'S UP
 WITH HER? ASKED HARRY, EVERINGLED OVER CHRISTMAS,
 APPARENTLY, SAID HERMIONE, ROLLING HER EYES AS SHE LED THE WAY
 INTO THE PACKED COMMON ROOM. SHE AND HER FRIEND VIOLET DROVE
 THEIR WAY THROUGH ALL THE WINE IN THAT PICTURE OF DRUNK MENDS
 DOWN BY THE CHARMING HALLWAY. ANYWAY SHE CLIMBED IN HER

PICKET HER A MOMENT, THEN PULLED OUT A SHEET OF PARCHMENT WITH
OLIMPEDE'S WRITING ON IT. GREAT, SAID HARRY, UNFOLDING IT AT
ONCE TO DISCOVER THAT HIS NEXT LESSON WITH OLIMPEDE WAS
SCHEDULED FOR THE FOLLOWING NIGHT. I'VE GOT HEADS TO TELL HIM
AND PHIL, LET'S SIT DOWN. BUT AT THAT MOMENT THERE WAS A LILLY
SHRIEK OF WHEN-WHEN? AND LAVENDER RUSHED CAME FLUTTERING OUT OF
NOWHERE AND FLUNG HERSELF INTO RHN'S ARMS. SEVERAL HUNDREDS
SNIGGERED; FERMINE GAVE A TINKLING LAUGH AND SAID, THERE'S A
TABLE OVER HERE. CHIMING, GINNY? NO, THANKS, I SAID I'D MEET
DEAN, SAID GINNY, THOUGH HARRY COULD NOT HELP REMARKING THAT
SHE DID NOT SEEM VERY ENTHUSIASTIC, LEAVING RHN AND LAVENDER
LOOKED IN A KIND OF VERTICAL WRESTLING MATCH. HARRY LED FERMINE
OVER TO THE SPARE TABLE. SHE FELT WAS YOUR CHRISTMAS? OH,
FINE, SHE SMILED. NOTHING SPECIAL, FELT WAS IT AT WHEN-
WHEN? I'LL TELL PHIL IN A MINUTE, SAID HARRY. XXXX, FERMINE
CAN'T PHIL? NO, I CAN'T, SHE SAID FLATLY. SHE DIDN'T EVEN ASK.

I THOUGHT MAYBE PHIL KNEW, OVER CHRISTMAS. IT WAS THE FAT
LADY WHO DRANK A VAT OF FIVE-HUNDRED-YEAR-OLD WINE, HARRY, NOT
ME, SHE WHAT WAS THIS IMPORTANT NEWS PHIL WANTED TO TELL ME? SHE
SMILED THEN FIRED THE ARROW WITH AT THAT MOMENT, SHE HARRY DROPPED
THE SUBJECT OF RHN AND RECALLED ALL THAT HE HAD OVERHEARD
BETWEEN MALFOY AND SNAPE. WHEN HE HAD FINISHED, FERMINE SAT IN
THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT AND THEN SAID, DIDN'T PHIL THINK?
HE WAS PRETENDING TO OFFER HELP SHE THAT HE COULD TRICK MALFOY
INTO TELLING HIM WHAT HE'S DOING? WELL, YES, SAID FERMINE.

RHN'S DAD AND KLIPIN THINK SHE, HARRY SAID GRABBERLY. BUT THIS
DEFINITELY PROVES MALFOY'S PLANNING SOMETHING, PHIL CAN'T DENY
THAT. NO, I CAN'T, SHE ANSWERED SLEAZY, AND HE'S ACTING ON
VEHEMENT'S ORDERS, JUST LIKE I SAID! I'M DID EITHER OF THEM
ACTUALLY MENTION VEHEMENT'S NAME? HARRY FREELINED, TRYING TO
REMEMBER. I'M NOT SURE. SNAPE DEFINITELY SAID YOUR MASTER,
AND WHO ELSE WOULD THAT BE? I DIDN'T KNOW, SAID FERMINE, BITING
HER LIP. MAYBE HIS FATHER? SHE STARED ACROSS THE ROOM,
APPARENTLY LOST IN THOUGHT, NOT EVEN REMARKING LAVENDER TICKLING
RHN. FELT'S KLIPIN? NOT GREAT, SAID HARRY, AND HE TOLD HER ALL
ABOUT KLIPIN'S MISSION AMONG THE WEREWOLVES AND THE DIFFICULTIES
HE WAS FACING. HAVE PHIL HEARD OF THIS FERRIS GREYBACK? YES, I
HAVE, SAID FERMINE, SOUNDING STARTLED. AND SHE HAVE PHIL,

HARRY: WHEN, HISTORY OF MAGIC? YOU KNOW FULL WELL I NEVER LISTENED. NO, NO, NOT HISTORY OF MAGIC. MALPUS THREATENED KIRKIN WITH HIM. SAID HERMIONE, BACK IN DORSETDOWN ALLEY, DIDN'T YOU REMEMBER? FOR THE KIRKIN THAT GREYBACK WAS AN OLD FAMILY FRIEND AND THAT HE'D BE CHECKING UP ON KIRKIN'S PROGRESS? HARRY GAZED AT HER. I FORGOT? BUT THIS PROVES MALPUS'S A DEATH. LATER, HOW ELSE COULD HE BE IN CONTACT WITH GREYBACK AND TELLING HIM WHAT HE DID? IT IS PRETTY SUSPICIOUS, KEATED HERMIONE. UNLESS. EH, COME ON, SAID HARRY IN EXASPERATION, YOU CAN'T GET BEHIND THIS ONE? WELL. THERE IS THE POSSIBILITY IT WAS AN EMPTY THREAT. YOU'RE UNLIKELYABLE, YOU ARE, SAID HARRY, SHAKING HIS HEAD. WE'LL SEE WHO'S RIGHT. YOU'LL BE EATING YOUR WORDS, HERMIONE, JUST LIKE THE MINISTRY. EH, YES, I HAD A RUN WITH ROLFS SCRIMGEWORM AS WELL. AND THE REST OF THE EVENING PASSED AMICABLY WITH BOTH OF THEM ABUSING THE MINISTER OF MAGIC, FOR HERMIONE, LIKE RON, THOUGHT THAT AFTER ALL THE MINISTRY HAD PUT HARRY THROUGH THE PREVIOUS YEAR, THEY HAD A GREAT DEAL OF NERVE ASKING HIM FOR HELP NOW. THE NEW TERM STARTED NEXT MORNING WITH A PLEASANT SURPRISE FOR THE SIXTH YEARS: A LARGE SIGN HAD BEEN PINNED TO THE CHAMBER ROOM NOTICE BOARD OVERNIGHT. IF YOU ARE SEVENTEEN YEARS OF AGE, YOU WILL TURN SEVENTEEN ON THE FIRST AUGUST NEXT, YOU ARE ELIGIBLE FOR A TWELVE-WEEK COURSE OF APPARITION LESSONS FROM A MINISTRY OF MAGIC APPARITION INSTRUCTOR. PLEASE SIGN BELOW IF YOU WOULD LIKE TO PARTICIPATE. LIST: 12 CALLIENS. HARRY AND RON THOUGHT THE CREED THAT WAS MEETING AROUND THE NOTICE AND TAKING IT IN TURNS TO WRITE THEIR NAMES AT THE BOTTOM. RON WAS JUST TAKING OUT HIS INK WHEN THE SIGN AFTER HERMIONE WHEN LAVENDER CROPT UP BEHIND HIM, SLIPPED HER HANDS OVER HIS EYES, AND TRILLED. GUESS WHO, WHEN? WHEN? HARRY TURNED TO SEE HERMIONE STALKING OFF; HE CALLED UP WITH HER, HAVING NO WISH TO STAY BEHIND WITH RON AND LAVENDER, BUT THE HIS SURPRISE, RON CALLED UP WITH THEM ONLY A LITTLE WAY BEYOND THE PORTRAIT HOLE, HIS EARS BRIGHT RED AND HIS EXPRESSION DISORIENTED. WITHOUT A WORD, HERMIONE SPED UP THE WALK WITH NEVILLE. SHE APPARITION, SAID RON, HIS TONE MAKING IT PERFECTLY PLAIN THAT HARRY WAS NOT THE MENTION WHAT HAD JUST HAPPENED. SHOULD BE A LAUGH, EH? I DUNNED, SAID HARRY. MAYBE IT'S BETTER WHEN YOU DO IT YOURSELF, I DIDN'T ENJOY IT MUCH WHEN

BLUMLEBERRY THREW ME ALONG FOR THE RIDE. I MIGHTY WELL BE ALREADY
DOWN IT. I'D BETTER PASS MY TEST FIRST TIME, SAID RENN, LEERING
ANDRIELIS. FRED AND GEORGE DID. CHARLIE FAILED, THOUGH, DIDN'T HE?
YEAH, BUT CHARLIE'S BIGGER THAN ME. RENN HELD HIS ARMS OUT
FROM HIS KID AS THOUGH HE WAS A CHIMP. SEE FRED AND GEORGE
DIDN'T GET HIM ABOUT IT MUCH. NOT THE HIS FACE ANYWAY. WHEN
CAN WE TAKE THE ACTUAL TEST? SEEN AS WE'RE SEVENTEEN, THAT'S
ONLY MARCH FOR ME. YEAH, BUT WELL, WOULDN'T BE ABLE TO APPARATE
IN HERE, NOT IN THE CASTLE. NOT THE POINT, IS IT? EVERYONE
WOULD KNOW I COULD APPARATE IF I WANTED. RENN WAS NOT THE ONLY
ONE WHO WAS EXCITED AT THE PROSPECT OF APPARITION. ALL THAT DAY
THERE WAS MUCH TALK ABOUT THE FORTHCOMING LESSONS; A GREAT DEAL
OF STUFF WAS SET BY BEING ABLE TO VANISH AND REAPPEAR AT WILL.
HOW LONG WILL IT BE WHEN WE CAN LIST. SEAMUS CLIPPED HIS
FINGERS TO INDICATE DISAPPEARANCE. MY CHLISIN FERGUS DOES IT LIST
THE ANOTHER ME, WELL WAIT TILL I CAN DO IT BACK. HE'LL NEVER HAVE
ANOTHER PEACEFUL MOMENT. LIST IN VISIONS OF THIS HAPPY
PROSPECT, HE CLIPPED HIS HAND A LITTLE TOO ENTHUSIASTICALLY, SEE THAT
INSTEAD OF PROBLEMS THE MOUNTAIN OF PURE WATER THAT WAS THE
EFFECT OF TODAY'S CHARM'S LESSON, HE LET OUT A BEEPING YET THAT
REACHED THE CEILING AND KNOCKED PROFESSOR FLITWICK FLAT ON
HIS FACE. HARRY'S ALREADY APPARATED. RENN THREW A SLIGHTLY ABASHED
SEAMUS, AFTER PROFESSOR FLITWICK HAD DRIED HIMSELF OFF WITH A WAVE
OF HIS HAND AND SET SEAMUS' LINES: I AM A WIZARD, NOT A BAKED
BRANDISHING A STICK. OUM ER SOMETHING THREW HIM. SIDE-
ALONG APPARITION, WELL KNOW. WHAT? WHISPERED SEAMUS, AND
HE, DEAN, AND NEVILLE PUT THEIR HEADS A LITTLE CLOSER TO HEAR WHAT
APPARITION FELT LIKE. FOR THE REST OF THE DAY, HARRY WAS BESIEGED
WITH REQUESTS FROM THE OTHER SIXTH YEARS TO DESCRIBE THE
SENSATION OF APPARITION. ALL OF THEM SEEMED AWED, RATHER THAN
PUT OFF, WHEN HE TOLD THEM HOW UNCOMFORTABLE IT WAS, AND HE WAS
STILL ANSWERING DETAILED QUESTIONS AT TEN THE NIGHT THAT EVENING,
WHEN HE WAS FORCED TO LIE AND SAY THAT HE NEEDED THE RETURN AROUND
THE THE LIBRARY, SEE AS THE ESCAPE IN TIME FOR HIS LESSON WITH
BLUMLEBERRY. THE LAMPS IN BLUMLEBERRY'S OFFICE WERE LIT, THE
PORTRAITS OF PREVIOUS HEADMASTERS WERE SMILING GENTLY IN THEIR
FRAMES, AND THE PENSIVE WAS READY UPON THE DESK INCE MORE.
BLUMLEBERRY'S HANDS LAY ON EITHER SIDE OF IT, THE RIGHT ONE AS

BLACKENED AND BLUNT-LOOKING AS EVER. IT DID NOT SEEM THE HAVE HEALED AT ALL AND HARRY WONDERS, FOR PERHAPS THE HUNDREDTH TIME, WHAT HAD CAUSED SUCH A DISTINCTIVE INJURY, BUT DID NOT ASK. DUMBLEDORE HAD SAID THAT HE WOULD KNOW EVENTUALLY AND THERE WAS, IN ANY CASE, ANOTHER SUBJECT HE WANTED THE DISCUSS, BUT BEFORE HARRY COULD SAY ANYTHING ABOUT Snape and Malfoy, DUMBLEDORE SPEAK. I HEAR THAT YOU MET THE MINISTER OF MAGIC EVER CHRISTMAS? YES, SAID HARRY. HE IS NOT VERY HAPPY WITH ME. NO, SIGHED DUMBLEDORE.

HE IS NOT VERY HAPPY WITH ME EITHER. WE MUST TRY NOT THE SINK BENEATH OUR ANGLISH, HARRY, BUT BATTLE HIM. HARRY GRINNED. HE WANTED ME THE TELL THE WIZARDING COMMUNITY THAT THE MINISTRY IS BEING A WONDERFUL ONE. DUMBLEDORE SMILED. IT WAS FLUKE'S IDEA ORIGINALLY, YOU KNOW, DURING HIS LAST DAYS IN OFFICE, WHEN HE WAS TRYING DESPERATELY THE CLING THE HIS POST, HE SEELIGHT A MEETING WITH YOU, HOPING THAT YOU WOULD GIVE HIM YOUR SUPPORT. AFTER EVERYTHING FLUKE DID LAST YEAR? SAID HARRY ANGERILY. AFTER LIVERIDGE?

I TOLD CERNELIUS THERE WAS NO CHANCE OF IT, BUT THE IDEA DID NOT DIE WHEN HE LEFT OFFICE. WITHIN HOURS OF SCRIMGEOUR'S APPOINTMENT WE MET AND HE DEMANDED THAT I ARRANGE A MEETING WITH YOU. SHE THAT'S WHY YOU AGREE? HARRY BLURTED OUT. IT WAS IN THE DAILY PROPHET. THE PROPHET IS BEHIND THE REPORT THE TRUTH OCCASIONALLY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IF ONLY ACCIDENTALLY. YES, THAT WAS WHY WE AGREE. WELL, IT APPEARS THAT RUMORS ARE A WAY THE CORNER YOU AT LAST. HE ACCUSED ME OF BEING DUMBLEDORE'S MAN THROUGH AND THROUGH. I FELT VERY RUDE OF HIM. I TOLD HIM I WAS. DUMBLEDORE OPENED HIS MOUTH THE SPEAK AND THEN CLOSED IT AGAIN. BEHIND HARRY, FALCON THE PHOENIX LET OUT A LOW, SOFT, MUSICAL CRY. THE HARRY'S INTENSE EMBARRASSMENT, HE SUDDENLY REALIZED THAT DUMBLEDORE'S BRIGHT BLUE EYES LOOKED RATHER WATERY, AND STARED HASTILY AT HIS OWN KNEES. WHEN DUMBLEDORE SPEAK, HOWEVER, HIS VOICE WAS SLIGHT STEADY. I AM VERY THANKED, HARRY.

SCRIMGEOUR WANTED THE KNOW WHERE YOU GO WHEN YOU ARE NOT AT HOGWARTS, SAID HARRY, STILL LOOKING FIXEDLY AT HIS KNEES. YES, HE IS VERY NERVOUS ABOUT THAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NOW SOUNDING CHEERFUL, AND HARRY THOUGHT IT SAFE THE LEAN UP AGAIN. HE HAS EVEN ATTEMPTED THE HAVE ME FOLLOWED, AMUSING, REALLY. HE SET DAWDLISH THE TAIL ME. IT WASN'T KIND. I HAVE ALREADY BEEN FORCED THE HIND DAWDLISH ENCE; I DID IT AGAIN WITH THE GREATEST REGRET. SHE THEY STILL DON'T

KNOW WHERE YOU GO? ASKED HARRY, HOPING FOR MORE INFORMATION
 ON THIS INTRIGUING SUBJECT, BUT DUMBLEDORE MERELY SMILED OVER THE
 TOP OF HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES. NO, THEY DON'T, AND THE TIME IS
 NOT QUITE RIGHT FOR YOU TO KNOW EITHER. NOW, I SUGGEST WE PRESS
 ON, UNLESS THERE'S ANYTHING ELSE? THERE IS, ACTUALLY, SIR,
 SAID HARRY. IT'S ABOUT MALFOY AND SNAPE. PROFESSOR SNAPE,
 HARRY. YES, SIR, I HEARD THEM DURING PROFESSOR SLUGGERTON'S
 PARTY. WELL, I FOLLOWED THEM, ACTUALLY. DUMBLEDORE LISTENED TO
 HARRY'S STORY WITH AN IMPASSIVE FACE. WHEN HARRY HAD FINISHED
 HE DID NOT SPEAK FOR A FEW MOMENTS, THEN SAID, THANK YOU FOR
 TELLING ME THIS, HARRY, BUT I SUGGEST THAT YOU PUT IT AWAY IN YOUR
 MIND. I DO NOT THINK THAT IT IS OF GREAT IMPORTANCE. NOT OF
 GREAT IMPORTANCE? REPEATED HARRY INCREDULOUSLY. PROFESSOR, DO
 YOU UNDERSTAND? YES, HARRY, BLESSED AS I AM WITH
 EXTRAORDINARY BRAINPOWER, I UNDERSTAND EVERYTHING YOU TOLD ME,
 SAID DUMBLEDORE, A LITTLE STARKLY. I THINK YOU MIGHT EVEN CONSIDER
 THE POSSIBILITY THAT I UNDERSTAND MORE THAN YOU DID. AGAIN, I AM
 GLAD THAT YOU HAVE CONFIDED IN ME, BUT LET ME REASSURE YOU THAT
 YOU HAVE NOT TOLD ME ANYTHING THAT CAUSES ME DISQUIET. HARRY
 SAT IN SILENT SILENCE, GLARING AT DUMBLEDORE. WHAT WAS GOING
 ON? DID THIS MEAN THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD INDEED ORDERED SNAPE TO FIND
 OUT WHAT MALFOY WAS DOING, IN WHICH CASE HE HAD ALREADY HEARD
 EVERYTHING HARRY HAD JUST TOLD HIM FROM SNAPE? OR WAS HE
 REALLY WHIPPED BY WHAT HE HAD HEARD, BUT PRETENDING NOT TO BE?

SEE, SIR, SAID HARRY, IN WHAT HE SAID WAS A POLITE, CALM VOICE,
 YOU DEFINITELY STILL TRUST? I HAVE BEEN TERRIBLY PROUD OF THE
 ANSWER THAT ELDESTERN ALREADY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, BUT HE DID NOT
 SEEM VERY TERRIBLY ANYMORE. MY ANSWER HAS NOT CHANGED. I
 SHOULD THINK NOT, SAID A SNIDE VOICE; PHINEAS NIGELLUS WAS
 EVIDENTLY ONLY PRETENDING TO BE ASLEEP. DUMBLEDORE IGNORED HIM.

AND NOW, HARRY, I MUST INSIST THAT WE PRESS ON. I HAVE MORE
 IMPORTANT THINGS TO DISCUSS WITH YOU THIS EVENING. HARRY SAT
 THERE FEELING MULTITUDE. HOW WOULD IT BE IF HE REFUSED THE PERMIT
 TO CHANGE HIS SUBJECT, IF HE INSISTED UPON ARGUING THE CASE AGAINST
 MALFOY? AS THOUGH HE HAD READ HARRY'S MIND, DUMBLEDORE SHOOK
 HIS HEAD. Ah, HARRY, HOW OFTEN THIS HAPPENS, EVEN BETWEEN THE
 BEST OF FRIENDS! EACH OF US BELIEVES THAT WHAT HE HAS TO SAY IS MUCH
 MORE IMPORTANT THAN ANYTHING THE OTHER MIGHT HAVE TO

CONFIDENTLY? I DON'T THINK WHAT YOU'VE GOTTEN THE SAY IS UNIMPORTANT, SIR, SAID HARRY STIFFLY. WELL, YOU ARE ELITE RIGHT, BECAUSE IT IS NOT, SAID DUMBLEDORE KRISPLY. I HAVE TWO MORE MEMORIES THE SHOW YOU THIS EVENING, BOTH OBTAINED WITH ENORMOUS DIFFICULTY, AND THE SECOND OF THEM IS, I THINK, THE MOST IMPORTANT I HAVE COLLECTED. HARRY DID NOT SAY ANYTHING THE THIS; HE STILL FELT ANGRY AT THE RECEPTION HIS CONFIDENCES HAD RECEIVED, BUT COULD NOT SEE WHAT WAS TO BE GAINED BY ARGUING FURTHER. SHE, SAID DUMBLEDORE, IN A RINGING VOICE, WE MEET THIS EVENING THE CONTINUAL THE TALK OF THEM RIDDLE, WHEN WE LEFT LAST LESSON PHASED IN THE THRESHOLD OF HIS YEARS AT HOGWARTS. YOU WILL REMEMBER HOW EXCITED HE WAS THE HEAR THAT HE WAS A WIZARD, THAT HE REQUESTED MY COMPANY FOR A TRIP THE DIAGON ALLEY, AND THAT I, IN TURN, WARNED HIM AGAINST CONTINUED THEVERY WHEN HE ARRIVED AT SCHOOL. WELL, THE START OF THE SCHOOL YEAR ARRIVED AND WITH IT CAME THEM RIDDLE, A ELITE BOY IN HIS SECOND-YEAR BOOKS, WHO LINKED UP WITH THE OTHER FIRST YEARS THE HE STARTED. HE WAS PLACED IN SLYTHERIN HOUSE ALMOST THE MOMENT THAT THE STARTING HAT TOUCHED HIS HEAD. CONTINUED DUMBLEDORE, LAYING HIS BLACKENED HAND TOWARD THE SELF OVER HIS HEAD WHERE THE STARTING HAT SAT, ANCIENT AND UNMOVING. WHEN SCHOOL RIDDLE LEARNED THAT THE FAMOUS PHOENIX OF THE HOUSE COULD TALK THE SNAKES, I DO NOT KNOW PERHAPS THAT VERY EVENING. THE KNOWLEDGE CAN ONLY HAVE EXCITED HIM AND INCREASED HIS SENSE OF SELF-IMPORTANCE. HOWEVER, IF HE WAS FRIGHTENING OR IMPRESSING FELLOW SLYTHERINS WITH DISPLAYS OF PARSEMENTAGE IN THEIR COMMON ROOM, NO HINT OF IT REACHED THE STAFF. HE SHOWED NO SIGN OF ELITWARD ARROGANCE OR AGGRESSION AT ALL. AS AN UNUSUALLY TALENTED AND VERY GOOD-LOOKING HERPESIAN, HE NATURALLY DREW ATTENTION AND SYMPATHY FROM THE STAFF ALMOST FROM THE MOMENT OF HIS ARRIVAL. HE SEEMED POLITE, ELITE, AND THIRSTY FOR KNOWLEDGE. NEARLY ALL WERE MOST FAVORABLY IMPRESSED BY HIM. DIDN'T YOU TELL THEM, SIR, WHAT HE'D BEEN LIKE WHEN YOU MET HIM AT THE HERPESIANAGE? ASKED HARRY. NO, I DID NOT. THOUGH HE HAD SHOWN NO HINT OF REMORSE, IT WAS POSSIBLE THAT HE FELT SHAME FOR HOW HE HAD BEHAVED BEFORE AND WAS RESOLVED THE TURN OVER A FRESH LEAF. I CHOSE TO GIVE HIM THAT CHANCE. DUMBLEDORE PAUSED AND LOOKED INQUIRINGLY AT HARRY, WHO HAD OPENED HIS MOUTH THE SPREAD. THERE, AGAIN, WAS DUMBLEDORE'S TENDENCY THE TRULST PEOPLE IN SPITE OF

EVERYWHERE EVIDENCE THAT THEY DID NOT DESERVE IT! BUT THEN
HARRY REMEMBERED SOMETHING. BUT HE DIDN'T REALLY TRUST HIM,
SIR, DID HE? HE TOLD ME THE RIDDLE WHEN LAMP HLT HE THAT DIARY
SAID, DUMBLEDORE NEVER SEEMED THE LIKE ME AS MUCH AS THE OTHER
TEACHERS DID. LET US SAY THAT I DID NOT TAKE IT FOR GRANTED THAT
HE WAS TRUSTWORTHY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I HAD, AS I HAVE ALREADY
INDICATED, RESOLVED THE DEEP A CURE FOR HIM, AND SEE I DID, I
CANNOT PRETEND THAT I GAINED A GREAT DEAL FROM MY OBSERVATIONS
AT FIRST, HE WAS VERY GUARDED WITH ME; HE FELT, I AM SURE, THAT IN
THE TRILL OF DISCOVERING HIS TRUE IDENTITY HE HAD TOLD ME A LITTLE
THAT MUCH, HE WAS CAREFUL NEVER TO REVEAL AS MUCH AGAIN, BUT HE
COULD NOT TAKE BACK WHAT HE HAD LET SLIP IN HIS EXCITEMENT, NOR
WHAT MRS. LEE HAD CONFIDED IN ME, HOWEVER, HE HAD THE SENSE NEVER
TO TRY AND CHARM ME AS HE CHARMED SO MANY OF MY CHALLENGES, AS
HE MOVED UP THE SCHOOL, HE GATHERED AROUND HIM A GROUP OF
DEDICATED FRIENDS; I CALL THEM THAT, FOR WANT OF A BETTER TERM,
ALTHOUGH AS I HAVE ALREADY INDICATED, RIDDLE UNDOUBTEDLY FELT NO
AFFECTION FOR ANY OF THEM, THIS GROUP HAD A KIND OF DARK GLAMOUR
WITHIN THE CASTLE, THEY WERE A MIXED COLLECTION; A MIXTURE OF THE
WEAK SEEKING PROTECTION, THE AMBITIOUS SEEKING SOME SHARED GLORY,
AND THE FUGITIVE CRAVING TOWARD A LEADER WHO COULD SHOW
THEM MORE REFINED FORMS OF CRUELTY, IN OTHER WORDS, THEY WERE THE
FOLLOWERS OF THE DEATH EATERS, AND INDEED SOME OF THEM BECAME
THE FIRST DEATH EATERS AFTER LEAVING HOGWARTS, RIGIDLY CONTROLLED
BY RIDDLE, THEY WERE NEVER DETECTED IN OPEN REBELLION, ALTHOUGH
THEIR SEVEN YEARS AT HOGWARTS WERE MARKED BY A NUMBER OF NASTY
INCIDENTS THE WHICH THEY WERE NEVER SATISFACTORILY LINKED, THE MOST
SERIOUS OF WHICH WAS, OF COURSE, THE OPENING OF THE CHAMBER OF
SECRETS, WHICH RESULTED IN THE DEATH OF A GIRL, AS YOU KNOW,
HARRY WAS WRONGLY ACCUSED OF THAT CRIME, I HAVE NOT BEEN ABLE TO
FIND MANY MEMORIES OF RIDDLE AT HOGWARTS, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
PLACING HIS WITHERED HAND ON THE PENSIVE, FEW WHO KNEW HIM
THEN ARE PREPARED TO TALK ABOUT HIM; THEY ARE VERY TERRIFIED, WHAT
I KNOW, I LEARNED AFTER HE HAD LEFT HOGWARTS, AFTER MUCH
PAINSTAKING EFFORT, AFTER TRACING THESE FEW WHO COULD BE TRICKED
INTO SPEAKING, AFTER SEARCHING OLD RECORDS AND INTERVIEWING
MUGGLE AND WIZARD WITNESSES ALIKE, THESE WERE I COULD PERSUADE
TO TALK TOLD ME THAT RIDDLE WAS INFESTED WITH HIS PARENTAGE, THIS

IS UNDERSTANDABLE, HE THOUGHT: HE HAD GROWN UP IN AN ORPHANAGE AND NATURALLY WISHED TO KNOW HOW HE CAME TO BE THERE. IT SEEMS THAT HE SEARCHED IN VAIN FOR SOME TRACE OF THE RIDDLE SENIOR AND THE SHIELDS IN THE TROOP'S REGIMENT, AND THE LISTS OF PROJECTS IN THE OLD SCHOOL RECORDS, EVEN IN THE RECORDS OF WIZARDING HISTORY. FINALLY HE WAS FORCED TO ACCEPT THAT HIS FATHER HAD NEVER SET FOOT IN BRITAIN. I BELIEVE THAT IT WAS THEN THAT HE DROPPED THE NAME HOWEVER, ASSUMED THE IDENTITY OF LORD VERDEMORE, AND BEGAN HIS INVESTIGATIONS INTO HIS PREVIOUSLY DESPISED MOTHER'S FAMILY. THE WOMAN WITH WHOM HE WILL REMEMBER, HE HAD THOUGHT COULD NOT BE A WITCH IF SHE HAD SLICKERED THE THE STAMPEL OF HUMAN WEAKNESS OF DEATH. ALL HE HAD TO GO UPON WAS THE SINGLE NAME MARYWELL, WHICH HE KNEW FROM THE WOMAN WHO RAN THE ORPHANAGE HAD BEEN HIS MOTHER'S FATHER'S NAME. FINALLY, AFTER PAINSTAKING RESEARCH THROUGH OLD RECORDS OF WIZARDING FAMILIES, HE DISCOVERED THE EXISTENCE OF SLOTHFERN'S SURVIVING LINE. IN THE SUMMER OF HIS SIXTEENTH YEAR, HE LEFT THE ORPHANAGE THE WHICH HE RETURNED ANNUALLY AND SET OFF TO FIND HIS GALANT RELATIVES, AND NOW, HARRY, IF YOU WILL STAND DOWN FROM THE RISK, AND HARRY SAW THAT HE WAS AGAIN HOLDING A SMALL CRYSTAL KETTLE FILLED WITH SWIRLING, PEARLY MEMPHY. I WAS VERY LUCKY TO COLLECT THIS, HE SAID, AS HE PULSED THE CREAMING MASS INTO THE PENSITIVE. AS YOU WILL UNDERSTAND WHEN WE HAVE EXPERIENCED IT, SHALL WE? HARRY STEPPED UP TO THE STONE BASIN AND KEPT EMBODIMENT UNTIL HIS FACE SANK THROUGH THE SURFACE OF THE MEMPHY; HE FELT THE FAMILIAR SENSATION OF FALLING THROUGH NOTHINGNESS AND THEN LANDED UPON A DIRTY STONE FLOOR IN ALMOST TOTAL DARKNESS. IT TOOK HIM SEVERAL SECONDS TO RECOGNIZE THE PLACE, BY WHICH TIME DOWNFALL HAD LANDED BESIDE HIM. THE GALANT'S FEELING WAS NOW MORE INDESCRIBABLY FILTHY THAN ANYWHERE HARRY HAD EVER SEEN. THE CEILING WAS THICK WITH CROWDS, THE FLOOR HEATED IN GRIME; MELODY AND RHYTHM WERE LAY UPON THE TABLE AMIDST A MASS OF CRUSTED FEET. THE ONLY LIGHT CAME FROM A SINGLE GLITTERING CANDLE PLACED AT THE FEET OF A MAN WITH HAIR AND BEARD SHED EVERGREEN. HARRY COULD SEE NEITHER EYES NOR MOUTH. HE WAS SLUMPED IN AN ARMCHAIR BY THE FIRE, AND HARRY WONDERED FOR A MOMENT WHETHER HE WAS DEAD. BUT THEN THERE CAME A LEADY SOUND AND THE MAN JERKED AWAKE, RAISING A WAND IN HIS RIGHT HAND AND A SHORT KNIFE IN HIS LEFT. THE DOOR CREAKED OPEN. THERE

BY THE THRESHOLD, HOLDING AN OLD-FASHIONED LAMP, STOOD A KEY
HARRY RECOGNIZED AT ONCE: TALL, PALE, DARK-HAIRED, AND HANDSOME
THE TEENAGE VILDEBERT, VILDEBERT'S EYES MOVED SLEELY AROUND THE
HALL AND THEN FOUND THE MAN IN THE ARMCHAIR. FOR A FEW SECONDS
THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, THEN THE MAN STAGGERED UPRIGHT, THE
MANY EMPTY KETTLES AT HIS FEET CLATTERING AND TINKLING ACROSS THE
FLOOR. YELL! HE BELLEWED, YELL! AND HE FLURLED DRIVENLY AT
RIDDLE, HAND AND KNIFE HELD ALERT. STOP, RIDDLE STOPPED IN
PARSLETONGUE. THE MAN SKIDDED INTO THE TABLE, SENDING MILDY POTS
CRASHING TO THE FLOOR. HE STARED AT RIDDLE. THERE WAS A LONG
SILENCE WHILE THEY CONTEMPLATED EACH OTHER. THE MAN BROKE IT.

YELL SPEAK IT? YES, I SPEAK IT, SAID RIDDLE. HE MOVED FORWARD
INTO THE ROOM, ALLOWING THE DOOR THE SWING SLUT BEHIND HIM.
HARRY COULD NOT HELP BUT FEEL A RESSENTFUL ADMIRATION FOR
VILDEBERT'S COMPLETE LACK OF FEAR. HIS FACE MERELY EXPRESSED
DISGUST AND, PERHAPS, DISAPPOINTMENT. WHERE IS MARVELL? HE
ASKED. DEAD, SAID THE OTHER. DIED YEARS AGO, DIDN'T HE? RIDDLE
FROWNED. WHO ARE YOU, THEN? I'M MERFIN, AIN'T I? MARVELL'S
SON? COURSE I AM, THEN. MERFIN PULSED THE HAIR OUT OF HIS
DIRTY FACE, THE BETTER TO SEE RIDDLE, AND HARRY SAW THAT HE WORE
MARVELL'S BLACK-STAINED RING ON HIS RIGHT HAND. I THOUGHT YOU
WAS THAT MUGGLE, WHISPERED MERFIN. YOU LOOK MIGHTY LIKE THAT
MUGGLE. WHAT MUGGLE? SAID RIDDLE SHARPLY. THAT MUGGLE
WHAT MY SISTER THINKS A FANCY THING, THAT MUGGLE WHO LIVES IN THE BIG
HOUSE OVER THE WAY, SAID MERFIN, AND HE SPAT UNEXPECTEDLY UPON
THE FLOOR BETWEEN THEM. YOU LOOK RIGHT LIKE HIM, RIDDLE. BUT HE'S
OLDER NOW, ISN'T HE? HE'S OLDER NOW, NOW I THINK OF IT. MERFIN
LOOKED SLIGHTLY DAZED AND SWAYED A LITTLE, STILL CLUTCHING THE EDGE OF
THE TABLE FOR SUPPORT. HE CAME BACK, SEE, HE ADDED STUPIDLY.
VILDEBERT WAS GAZING AT MERFIN AS THOUGH APPRAISING HIS
POSSIBILITIES. NOW HE MOVED A LITTLE CLOSER AND SAID, RIDDLE CAME
BACK? NO, HE LEFT HER, AND SERVE HER RIGHT, MARRYING FILTH! SAID
MERFIN, SPITTING ON THE FLOOR AGAIN. BOTHERED HIS MIND, BEHOLD SHE
RAN OFF! WHERE'S THE LOCKET, EH, WHERE'S SLYTHERIN'S LOCKET?
VILDEBERT DID NOT ANSWER. MERFIN WAS WORKING HIMSELF INTO A
RAGE AGAIN; HE BRANDISHED HIS KNIFE AND SCHELTED. DISHEMPOWERED HIS
SHE DID, THAT LITTLE SLUT! AND WHO ARE YOU, COMING HERE AND ASKING
QUESTIONS ABOUT ALL THAT? IT'S NEVER, INDEED. IT'S NEVER. HE

LEHDED AWAY, STAGGERING SLIGHTLY, AND VELDREHT MOVED FORWARD, AS HE DID SEE, AN UNNATURAL DARKNESS FELL, EXTINGUISHING VELDREHT'S LAMP AND MERFIN'S CANDLE, EXTINGUISHING EVERYTHING.

OLMLEDRE'S FINGERS CLASPED TIGHTLY AROUND HARRY'S ARM AND THEY WERE SHARING EACH INTO THE PRESENT AGAIN. THE SOFT CHILDREN LIGHT IN OLMLEDRE'S OFFICE SEEMED THE DAZZLE HARRY'S EYES AFTER THAT IMPENETRABLE DARKNESS. IS THAT ALL? SAID HARRY AT ENCE.

WHY DID IT GET DARK, WHAT HAPPENED? BECAUSE MERFIN COULD NOT REMEMBER ANYTHING FROM THAT POINT FORWARD, SAID OLMLEDRE, GESTURING HARRY BACK INTO HIS SEAT. WHEN HE AWOKE NEXT MORNING, HE WAS LYING IN THE FLOOR, WHITE ASHES. MARVEEN'S RING HAD GONE. MEANWHILE, IN THE VILLAGE OF LITTLE HANGLETON, A MAID WAS RUNNING ALONG THE HIGH STREET, SCREAMING THAT THERE WERE THREE BODIES LYING IN THE DRAWING ROOM OF THE BIG HOUSE: THE RIDDLE SENIOR AND HIS MOTHER AND FATHER. THE MUGGLE ALTHURITIES WERE PERPLEXED. AS FAR AS I AM AWARE, THEY DO NOT KNOW THE THIS DAY WHEN THE RIDDLES DIED, FOR THE AYADA KEDAVRA CURSE DOES NOT USUALLY LEAVE ANY SIGN OF DAMAGE. THE EXCEPTIONS SITS BEFORE ME, OLMLEDRE ADDED, WITH A NOD TO HARRY'S SCAR. THE MINISTRY, ON THE OTHER HAND, KNOW AT ENCE THAT THIS WAS A WIZARD'S MURDER. THEY ALSO KNOW THAT A CONVICTED MUGGLE-HATER LIVED ACROSS THE VALLEY FROM THE RIDDLE HOUSE, A MUGGLE-HATER WHO HAD ALREADY BEEN IMPRISONED ENCE FOR ATTACKING ONE OF THE MURDERED PEOPLE. SEE THE MINISTRY CALLED UPON MERFIN. THEY DID NOT NEED TO BELIEVE HIM, THE LIE VERITASERUM OR LEGILIMENCY. HE ADMITTED THE MURDER ON THE SPOT, GIVING DETAILS ONLY THE MURDERER COULD KNOW. HE WAS PROUD, HE SAID, THEY HAVE KILLED THE MUGGLES, HAD BEEN AWAITING HIS CHANCE ALL THESE YEARS. HE HANDED OVER HIS WAND, WHICH WAS PREYED AT ENCE THEY HAVE BEEN USED TO KILL THE RIDDLES. AND HE PERMITTED HIMSELF TO BE LED OFF TO AZKABAN WITHOUT A FIGHT. ALL THAT DISTURBED HIM WAS THE FACT THAT HIS FATHER'S RING HAD DISAPPEARED. HE LL KILL ME FOR LOSTING IT, HE THOUGHT HIS CAPTAINS EVER AND EVER AGAIN. HE LL KILL ME FOR LOSTING HIS RING. AND THAT, APPARENTLY, WAS ALL HE EVER SAID AGAIN. HE LIVED OUT THE REMAINDER OF HIS LIFE IN AZKABAN, LAMENTING THE LOSS OF MARVEEN'S LAST HEIRLOOM, AND IS BURIED BESIDE THE PRISON, ALONGSIDE THE OTHER PRISONER SKELETONS WHO HAVE EXPIRED WITHIN ITS WALLS. SEE VELDREHT STEAL MERFIN'S WAND AND USE IT? SAID HARRY, SITTING

LIP STRAIGHT. THAT'S RIGHT, SAID DUMKLEDEERE. WE HAVE BEEN MEMORIES THE SEVEN LIS THIS, BUT I THINK WE CAN BE FAIRLY SURE WHAT HAPPENED. VILDEBERT STOLETHER HIS UNCLE, THEN HIS WARD, AND PROCEEDED ACROSS THE VALLEY THE THE BIG FELLSE EVER THE WAY THERE HE MURDERED THE MUGGLE MAN WHO HAD ABANDONED HIS WITCH MOTHER, AND, FOR GOOD MEASURE, HIS MUGGLE GRANDPARENTS, THIS ILLITERATING THE LAST OF THE LINDBERTY RIDDLE LINE AND REVENGING HIMSELF UPON THE FATHER WHO NEVER WANTED HIM. THEN HE RETURNED THE THE GALANT FIVEL, PERFORMED THE COMPLEX RIT OF MAGIC THAT WOULD IMPLANT A FALSE MEMORY IN HIS UNCLE'S MIND, LAID MERFIN'S WARD BESIDE ITS LINDBERTHUS ELDER, PICKED THE ANCIENT RING HE WORE, AND DEPARTED. AND MERFIN NEVER REALIZED HE HADN'T DONE IT? NEVER, SAID DUMKLEDEERE. HE GAVE, AS I SAY, A FLIM AND RHASTFUL CONFESSIEN. BUT HE HAD THIS REAL MEMORY IN HIM ALL THE TIME? YES, BUT IT THREW A GREAT DEAL OF SKILLED LEGILIMENCY THE CHASE IT OUT OF HIM, SAID DUMKLEDEERE, AND WHY SHOULD ANYBODY DELVE FURTHER INTO MERFIN'S MIND WHEN HE HAD ALREADY CONFESSED THE THE CRIME? HOWEVER, I WAS ABLE THE SECURE A VISIT THE MERFIN IN THE LAST WEEKS OF HIS LIFE, BY WHICH TIME I WAS ATTEMPTING THE DISCOVERY AS MUCH AS I COULD ABOUT VILDEBERT'S PAST. I EXTRACTED THIS MEMORY WITH DIFFICULTY. WHEN I SAW WHAT IT CONTAINED, I ATTEMPTED THE USE IT THE SECURE MERFIN'S RELEASE FROM AZKABAN, BEFORE THE MINISTRY REACHED THEIR DECISION, HOWEVER, MERFIN HAD DIED. BUT THEN COME THE MINISTRY DIDN'T REALIZE THAT VILDEBERT HAD DONE ALL THAT THE MERFIN? HARRY ASKED ANGERILY. HE WAS LINDBRAGE AT THE TIME, WASN'T HE? I THINK THEY COULD DETECT LINDBRAGE MAGIC? YES ARE ELITE RIGHT THEY CAN DETECT MAGIC, BUT NOT THE PERPETRATOR: YES WILL REMEMBER THAT YES WERE BLAMED BY THE MINISTRY FOR THE FEVER CHARM THAT WAS, IN FACT, CAST BY DEEKE, GROWLED HARRY; THIS INJUSTICE STILL RANDED. SEE IF YES RE LINDBRAGE AND YES DO MAGIC INSIDE AN ADULT WITCH OR WIZARD'S FELLSE, THE MINISTRY WEN'T DENY? THEY WILL CERTAINLY BE LINABLE THE TELL WHO PERFORMED THE MAGIC, SAID DUMKLEDEERE, SMILING SLIGHTLY AT THE LIND OF GREAT INDIGNATION ON HARRY'S FACE. THEY RELO ON WITCH AND WIZARD PARENTS THE ENFORCE THEIR OFFSPRING'S OBEIDENCE WHILE WITHIN THEIR WALLS. WELL, THAT'S LIKELI, SNAPPED HARRY. LIND WHAT HAPPENED HERE, LIND WHAT HAPPENED THE MERFIN? I AGREE, SAID DUMKLEDEERE. WHATEVER MERFIN WAS, HE DID NOT DESERVE THE DIE AS HE

DID, BLAMED HER MURDERS HE HAD NOT COMMITTED, BUT IT IS GETTING LATE, AND I WANT YOU TO SEE THIS EITHER MEMPHYS BEFORE WE PART.

OLIVEREDDRE THREW FROM AN INSIDE POCKET ANOTHER CRYSTAL PHIAL AND FARRY FELL SILENT AT ONCE, REMEMBERING THAT OLIVEREDDRE HAD SAID IT WAS THE MOST IMPORTANT ONE HE HAD COLLECTED. FARRY NOTICED THAT THE CONTENTS FLOWED DIFFICULTLY INTO THE PENSIVE, AS THOUGH THEY HAD CONGEALED SLIGHTLY; DID MEMPHYS GET BAD? THIS WILL NOT TAKE LONG, SAID OLIVEREDDRE, WHEN HE HAD FINALLY EMPTIED THE PHIAL. WE SHALL BE BACK BEFORE YOU KNOW IT, HEW MORE INTO THE PENSIVE, THEN AND FARRY FELL AGAIN THROUGH THE SILVER SURFACE, LANDING THIS TIME RIGHT IN FRONT OF A MAN HE RECOGNIZED AT ONCE. IT WAS A MUCH YOUNGER HERACE SLUGGISHORN, FARRY WAS SHE LISKED THE HIM BALD THAT HE FELT THE SIGHT OF SLUGGISHORN WITH THICK, SHINY, STRAW-COLOURED HAIR WHITE DISCONCERTING; IT LOOKED AS THOUGH HE HAD HAD HIS HEAD THATCHED, THOUGH THERE WAS ALREADY A SHINY GOLFEN-SIZED BALD PATCH ON HIS CROWN, HIS MUSTACHE, LESS MASSIVE THAN IT WAS THESE DAYS, WAS GINGERY-BLOND, HE WAS NOT WHITE AS RUTLAND AS THE SLUGGISHORN FARRY KNEW, THOUGH THE CHILDEN SLITHERS ON HIS RICHLY EMBROIDERED WAISTCOT WERE TAKING A FAIR AMOUNT OF STRAIN, HIS LITTLE FEET RESTING UPON A VELVET PUFF, HE WAS SITTING WELL BACK IN A COMFORTABLE WINGED ARMCHAIR, ONE HAND GRASPING A SMALL GLASS OF WINE, THE OTHER SEARCHING THROUGH A BOX OF CRYSTALIZED PINEAPPLE, FARRY LOOKED AROUND AS OLIVEREDDRE APPEARED BESIDE HIM AND SAW THAT THEY WERE STANDING IN SLUGGISHORN'S OFFICE, HALF A DOZEN KEYS WERE SITTING AROUND SLUGGISHORN, ALL ON HARDER OR SOFTER SEATS THAN HIS, AND ALL IN THEIR MIDTENS, FARRY RECOGNIZED VERDEMENT AT ONCE, HIS WAS THE MOST HANDSOME FACE AND HE LOOKED THE MOST RELAXED OF ALL THE KEYS, HIS RIGHT HAND LAY NEGLIGENTLY UPON THE ARM OF HIS CHAIR; WITH A HEAT, FARRY SAW THAT HE WAS WEARING MARVELLE'S GOLD-AND-BLACK RING; HE HAD ALREADY KILLED HIS FATHER. SIR, IS IT TRUE THAT PROFESSOR MERRYTHIGHT IS RETIRING? HE ASKED. THEM, THEM, IF I KNEW I COULDN'T TELL YOU, SAID SLUGGISHORN, WAGGING A REPROVING, SWEAR-CHEYERED FINGER AT RIDDLE, THOUGH RUINING THE EFFECT SLIGHTLY BY WINKING. I MUST SAY, I'D LIKE TO KNOW WHERE YOU GET YOUR INFORMATION, KEY, MORE KNOWLEDGEABLE THAN HALF THE STAFF, YOU ARE. RIDDLE SMILED; THE OTHER KEYS LAUGHED AND CAST HIM ADMIRING LOOKS. WHAT WITH YOUR UNUSUAL ABILITY TO KNOW THINGS YOU

SEMILOUS T, AND THEIR CAREFUL FLATTERY OF THE PEOPLE WHO MATTER
THANK YOU FOR THE PINEAPPLE, BY THE WAY, YOU'RE RIGHT, IT IS
MY FAVORITE AS SEVERAL OF THE KIDS TITTERED, SOMETHING VERY
HAD HAPPENED, THE WHEEL ROOM WAS SUDDENLY FILLED WITH A THICK
WHITE FOG, SEE THAT HARRY COULD SEE NOTHING BUT THE FACE OF
OLIMPEHRE, WHO WAS STANDING BESIDE HIM, THEN SLUGHERN'S VOICE
RANG OUT THROUGH THE MIST, UNNATURALLY LOUDLY, YOU'LL BE
WRONG, KID, MAKE MY WISHES, THE FOG CLEARED AS SUDDENLY AS IT HAD
APPEARED AND YET NOBODY MADE ANY ALLUSION TO IT, NEAR DID ANYBODY
WHEN AS THOUGH ANYTHING UNUSUAL HAD JUST HAPPENED, BEMUSED,
HARRY WHEEZED AROUND AS A SMALL CHILDEN CRIED STANDING UPON
SLUGHERN'S DESK CHIMED ELEVEN IN CLOCK, GOOD GRACIOUS, IS IT THAT
TIME ALREADY? SAID SLUGHERN, YOU'D BETTER GET GOING, KIDS, OR
WE'LL ALL BE IN TROUBLE, LESTRANGER, I WANT YOUR ESSAY BY TOMORROW
OR IT'S DETENTION, SAME CHECK FOR YOU, AVERY, SLUGHERN PULLED
HIMSELF OUT OF HIS ARMCHAIR AND CARRIED HIS EMPTY GLASS OVER TO
HIS DESK AS THE KIDS FILED OUT, WILDERMERE, HOWEVER, STAYED BEHIND,
HARRY COULD TELL HE HAD DANCED DELIBERATELY, WANTING TO BE LAST IN
THE ROOM WITH SLUGHERN, WHEN STARR, THEN, SAID SLUGHERN,
TURNING AROUND AND FINDING HIM STILL PRESENT, YOU DON'T WANT TO
BE CALLED OUT FOR BEING OUT OF SEAT, AND YOU A PRECEPT SIR, I
WANTED TO ASK YOU SOMETHING, ASK AWAY, THEN, M KID, ASK AWAY,

SIR, I WONDERED WHAT YOU WOULD ASK ABOUT THE THIRDS?
AND IT HAPPENED ALL OVER AGAIN! THE DENSE FOG FILLED THE ROOM SEE
THAT HARRY COULD NOT SEE SLUGHERN OR WILDERMERE AT ALL; ONLY
OLIMPEHRE, SMILING SERENELY BESIDE HIM, THEN SLUGHERN'S VOICE
RANG OUT AGAIN, JUST AS IT HAD DONE BEFORE, I DON'T KNOW
ANYTHING ABOUT THE THIRDS AND I WOULDN'T TELL YOU IF I DID! WHEN
GET OUT OF HERE AT ONCE AND DON'T LET ME CATCH YOU MENTIONING
THEM AGAIN! WELL, THAT'S THAT, SAID OLIMPEHRE PLACIDLY BESIDE
HARRY, TIME TO GO, AND HARRY'S FEET LEFT THE FLOOR THE FALL,
SECONDS LATER, BACK INTO THE RUG IN FRONT OF OLIMPEHRE'S DESK.

THAT'S ALL THERE IS? SAID HARRY BLANKLY, OLIMPEHRE HAD SAID
THAT THIS WAS THE MOST IMPORTANT MEMORY OF ALL, BUT HE COULD NOT
SEE WHAT WAS SO SIGNIFICANT ABOUT IT, ADMITTEDLY THE FOG, AND THE
FACT THAT NOBODY SEEMED TO HAVE NOTICED IT, WAS ALSO, BUT EITHER THAN
THAT NOTHING SEEMED TO HAVE HAPPENED EXCEPT THAT WILDERMERE HAD
ASKED A QUESTION AND FAILED TO GET AN ANSWER, AS YOU MIGHT HAVE

NOTICED, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, RESEATING HIMSELF BEHIND HIS DESK, THAT
MEMORY HAS BEEN TAMPERED WITH. TAMPERED WITH? REPEATED
HARRY, SITTING BACK BEHIND THEM. CERTAINLY, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE.

PROFESSOR SLUGGISHORN HAS MEDDLED WITH HIS OWN RECOLLECTIONS.

BUT WHY WOULD HE DO THAT? BECAUSE, I THINK, HE IS ASHAMED OF
WHAT HE REMEMBERS, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE. HE HAS TRIED THE REMOVED THE
MEMORY THE SHOW HIMSELF IN A BETTER LIGHT, ILLITERATING THESE PARTS
WHICH HE DOES NOT WISH ME TO SEE. IT IS, AS YOU WILL HAVE NOTICED,
VERY CLOUTELY DONE, AND THAT IS ALL THE THE GOOD, FOR IT SHOWS THAT
THE TRUE MEMORY IS STILL THERE BENEATH THE ALTERATIONS. AND SEE,
FOR THE FIRST TIME, I AM GIVING YOU THE REMOVED, HARRY. IT WILL BE
YOUR JOB TO PERSUADE PROFESSOR SLUGGISHORN THE DIVULGE THE REAL
MEMORY, WHICH WILL UNDOUBTEDLY BE YOUR MOST CRUCIAL PIECE OF
INFORMATION OF ALL. HARRY STARED AT HIM. BUT SURELY, SIR, HE SAID,
KEEPING HIS VOICE AS RESPECTFUL AS POSSIBLE, YOU DON'T NEED ME
YOU COULD USE LEGILIMENCY OR VERITASERUM. PROFESSOR
SLUGGISHORN IS AN EXTREMELY ABLE WIZARD WHO WILL BE EXPECTING BOTH,
SAID DUMKLEDHIRE. HE IS MUCH MORE ACCOMPLISHED AT ECLIPSEMENT
THAN PROFESSOR MURFIN CALINT, AND I WOULD BE ASTONISHED IF HE HAS NOT
CARRIED AN ANTIWITCH THE VERITASERUM WITH HIM EVER SINCE I CHARGED
HIM INTO GIVING ME THIS TRAVESTY OF A RECOLLECTION. NO, I THINK IT
WOULD BE FOOLISH THE ATTEMPT THE WREST THE TRUTH FROM PROFESSOR
SLUGGISHORN BY FORCE, AND MIGHT DO MUCH MORE HARM THAN GOOD. I DO
NOT WISH HIM THE LEAVE THEGLANTS, HOWEVER, HE HAS HIS WEAKNESSES
LIKE THE REST OF US, AND I BELIEVE THAT YOU ARE THE ONE PERSON WHO
MIGHT BE ABLE TO PENETRATE HIS DEFENSES. IT IS MOST IMPORTANT THAT
WE SECURE THE TRUE MEMORY, HARRY. HOW IMPORTANT, WE WILL
ONLY KNOW WHEN WE HAVE SEEN THE REAL THING. SEE, GOOD LUCK
AND GOOD NIGHT. A LITTLE TAKEN ABACK BY THE ABRUPT DISMISSAL,
HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET BRISKLY. GOOD NIGHT, SIR. AS HE CLOSED THE
STUDY DOOR BEHIND HIM, HE DISTINCTLY HEARD PHINEAS NIGELLUS SAY, I
CAN'T SEE WHY THE SHOULD BE ABLE TO DO IT BETTER THAN YOU,
DUMKLEDHIRE. I WOULD NOT EXPECT YOU THE, PHINEAS, REPLIED
DUMKLEDHIRE, AND FALLOWS GAVE ANOTHER LITTLE MUSICAL CRY. BIRTHDAY
SURPRISES THE NEXT DAY HARRY CONSIDERED IN BOTH ROOM AND
DETERMINE THE TASK THAT DUMKLEDHIRE HAD SET HIM, THOUGH
SEPARATELY, FOR DETERMINE STILL REFUSED TO REMAIN IN ROOM'S
PRESENCE LONGER THAN IT TOOK TO GIVE HIM A CONTEMPTUOUS LOOK.

WHICH MEANS, OF COURSE, THAT ASSUMING WE HAVE ACHIEVED
CORRECT IDENTIFICATION OF THE POTION'S INGREDIENTS BY SCARPIN'S
REVEALSPELL, OUR PRIMARY AIM IS NOT THE RELATIVELY SIMPLE ONE OF
SELECTING ANTIDOTES TO THESE INGREDIENTS IN AND OF THEMSELVES, BUT
THE FIND THAT ADDED COMPONENT THAT WILL, BY AN ALMOST ALCHEMICAL
PROCESS, TRANSFORM THESE DISPARATE ELEMENTS. RHEIN WAS SITTING
BEHIND HARRY WITH HIS MOUTH HALF OPEN, NODDING ASSENTLY IN HIS
NEW COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING. RHEIN KEPT FORGETTING THAT
HE COULD NO LONGER RELY ON HERMIONE TO HELP HIM OUT OF TROUBLE
WHEN HE FAILED TO GRASP WHAT WAS GOING ON. AND SHE, FINISHED
SLIGHTLY, I WANT EACH OF YOU TO CHIEF AND TAKE ONE OF THESE
POTIONS FROM MY DESK. YOU ARE TO CREATE AN ANTIDOTE FOR THE POISON
WITHIN IT BEFORE THE END OF THE LESSON. GOOD LUCK, AND DON'T FORGET
YOUR PROTECTIVE GLOVES! HERMIONE HAD LEFT HER STICK AND WAS
HALFWAY TOWARD SLIGHT'S DESK BEFORE THE REST OF THE CLASS HAD
REALIZED IT WAS TIME TO MOVE, AND BY THE TIME HARRY, RHEIN, AND ERNIE
RETURNED TO THE TABLE, SHE HAD ALREADY TIPPED THE CONTENTS OF HER
POTION INTO HER CALIBREIN AND WAS KINDLING A FIRE UNDERNEATH IT.

IT IS A SHAME THAT THE PRINCE WHEN TO BE ABLE TO HELP YOU MUCH WITH
THIS, HARRY. SHE SAID BRIGHTLY AS SHE STRAIGHTENED UP. YOU HAVE
THE UNDERSTAND THE PRINCIPLES INVOLVED THIS TIME. DO SHE SHORTLY HER
CREATS? ANNOYED, HARRY LINGERED THE POISON HE HAD TAKEN FROM
SLIGHT'S DESK, WHICH WAS A GARISH SHADE OF PINK, TIPPED IT INTO
HIS CALIBREIN, AND LIT A FIRE UNDERNEATH IT. HE DID NOT HAVE THE
FAINTEST IDEA WHAT HE WAS SLIPPERED TO DO NEXT. HE GLANCED AROUND
AT RHEIN, WHO WAS NOW STANDING THERE LOOKING RATHER GORMLESS,
HAVING COPIED EVERYTHING HARRY HAD DONE. YOU SURE THE PRINCE
HASN'T GOTTEN ANY TIPS? RHEIN MUTTERED TO HARRY, HARRY PULLED OUT
HIS TRUSTY COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING AND TURNED TO THE
CHAPTER ON ANTIDOTES. THERE WAS GEMPALETT'S THIRD LAW, STATED
WHICH SHE WHISPERED AS HERMIONE HAD RECITED IT, BUT NOT A SINGLE
ILLUMINATING NOTE IN THE PRINCE'S HAND TO EXPLAIN WHAT IT MEANT.
APPARENTLY THE PRINCE, LIKE HERMIONE, HAD HAD NO DIFFICULTY
UNDERSTANDING IT. NOTHING, SAID HARRY GLENNILY, HERMIONE WAS
NOW LAYING HER HAND ENTHUSIASTICALLY OVER HER CALIBREIN.
UNFORTUNATELY, THEY COULD NOT COPY THE SPELL SHE WAS DOING
BECAUSE SHE WAS NOW SHE GOOD AT NUMEROUS INCANTATIONS THAT SHE
DID NOT NEED TO SAY THE WORDS ALOUD. ERNIE MACMILLAN, HOWEVER, WAS

MUTTERING, SPECIALIS REVELIUS! EVER HIS CALIBREIN, WHICH SEEMED IMPRESSIVE, SHE HARRY AND REIN HASTENED TO IMITATE HIM. IT TOOK HARRY ONLY FIVE MINUTES TO REALIZE THAT HIS REPUTATION AS THE BEST POTION-MAKER IN THE CLASS WAS CRASHING AROUND HIS EARS. SILVERHORN HAD PEERED HOPEFULLY INTO HIS CALIBREIN IN HIS FIRST CIRCUIT OF THE DUNGEON, PREPARING TO EXCLAIM IN DELIGHT AS HE USUALLY DID, AND INSTEAD HAD WITHDRAWN HIS HEAD HASTILY, CHUCKLING, AS THE SMELL OF BAD EGGS OVERWHELMED HIM. HERMIONE'S EXPRESSION COULD NOT HAVE BEEN ANY SLEETER; SHE HAD HEATHED BEING HINDERPERFORMED IN EVERY POTION'S CLASS. SHE WAS NOW DECANTING THE MYSTERIOUSLY SEPARATED INGREDIENTS OF HER POTION INTO TEN DIFFERENT CRYSTAL PHIALS. MORE TO AVOID WATCHING THIS IRRITATING SIGHT THAN ANYTHING ELSE, HARRY KEPT EVER THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE'S BOOK AND TURNED A FEW PAGES WITH UNNECESSARY FORCE, AND THERE IT WAS, SCRAWLED RIGHT ACROSS A LONG LIST OF ANTIDOTES: HARRY STARED AT THESE WORDS FOR A MOMENT. HADN'T HE HEARD, LONG AGO, HEARD OF REZEHARS? HADN'T SNAPE MENTIONED THEM IN THEIR FIRST-EVER POTION'S LESSON? A STONE TAKEN FROM THE STOMACH OF A GIANT, WHICH WILL PROTECT FROM MOST PISONS. IT WAS NOT AN ANSWER TO THE GILPHETT PROBLEM, AND HAD SNAPE STILL BEEN THEIR TEACHER, HARRY WOULD NOT HAVE DARED DO IT, BUT THIS WAS A MOMENT FOR DESPERATE MEASURES. HE HASTENED TOWARD THE STONE CLIPBOARD AND RUMMAGED WITHIN IT, PUSHING ASIDE UNUSUAL HERBS AND TANGLES OF DRIED HERBS UNTIL HE FELT, AT THE VERY BACK, A SMALL CARDBOARD BOX IN WHICH HAD BEEN SCRIBBLED THE WORD REZEHARS. HE OPENED THE BOX ILUST AS SILVERHORN CALLED. TWO MINUTES LEFT, EVERYONE! INSIDE WERE HALF A DOZEN SPRIGGED GREEN HERBS, LOOKING MORE LIKE DRIEDUP KIDNEYS THAN REAL STONES. HARRY SEIZED ONE, PUT THE BOX BACK IN THE CLIPBOARD, AND HURRIED BACK TO HIS CALIBREIN. TIME'S UP! CALLED SILVERHORN GENIALLY. WELL, LET'S SEE HOW YOU'VE DONE! RAISE

WHAT HAVE YOU GOT FOR ME? SILENTLY, SILVERHORN MOVED AROUND THE ROOM, EXAMINING THE VARIOUS ANTIDOTES. NERVOUSLY HAD FINISHED THE TASK, ALTHOUGH HERMIONE WAS TRYING TO CRAM A FEW MORE INGREDIENTS INTO HER BOTTLE BEFORE SILVERHORN REACHED HER. REIN HAD GIVEN UP COMPLETELY, AND WAS MERELY TRYING TO AVOID BREATHING IN THE PUTRID Fumes ISSUING FROM HIS CALIBREIN. HARRY STOOD THERE WAITING, THE REZEHAR CLUTCHED IN A SLIGHTLY SWEATY HAND. SILVERHORN REACHED THEIR TABLE LAST. HE SNIPPED ERNIE'S POTION AND PASSED ON THE

DOWN WITH A GRIMACE, HE DID NOT LINGER OVER DOWN'S CALIBRE, BUT
BACKED AWAY SWIFTLY, RETCHING SLIGHTLY. AND YELL, HARRY, HE SAID.

WHAT HAVE YOU GOTTEN THE SKEW ME? HARRY HELD UP HIS HAND, THE
KEZBAR SITTING ON HIS PALM. SLUGGISHLY WHISKED DOWN AT IT FOR A FULL
TEN SECONDS. HARRY WHISPERED, FOR A MOMENT, WHETHER HE WAS CHING
THE SKEW AT HIM. THEN HE THREW BACK HIS HEAD AND REARED WITH
LAUGHTER. YOU'VE GOTTEN NERVE, KID? HE WHISPERED, TAKING THE KEZBAR
AND HOLDING IT UP SO THAT THE CLASS COULD SEE IT. HEI, YOU'RE LIKE
YOUR MOTHER. WELL, I CAN'T FAULT YOU. A KEZBAR WOULD
CERTAINLY ACT AS AN ANTIDOTE TO ALL THESE POETRIES? FERMINE, WHO
WAS SWEATY-FACED AND HAD SHEET ON HER NOSE, WHISKED LIVID. HER HALF-
FINISHED ANTIDOTE, COMPRISING FIFTY-TWO INGREDIENTS, INCLUDING A
CLUNK OF HER OWN HAIR, BUBBLED SLUGGISHLY BEHIND SLUGGISHLY, WHO
HAD EYES FOR NOTHING BUT HARRY. AND YOU THOUGHT OF A KEZBAR ALL
BY YOURSELF, DID YOU, HARRY? SHE ASKED THROUGH GRITTED TEETH.

THAT'S THE INDIVIDUAL SPIRIT A REAL POETRY-MAKER NEEDS? SAID
SLUGGISHLY HAPPILY, BEFORE HARRY COULD REPLY. JUST LIKE HIS
MOTHER, SHE HAD THE SAME INSTINCTIVE GRASP OF POETRY-MAKING, IT'S
UNBELIEVABLY SIMPLE, LIKE HE GETS IT. YES, HARRY, YES, IF YOU'VE GOTTEN
A KEZBAR TO HAND, OF COURSE THAT WOULD DO THE TRICK. ALTHOUGH
AS THEY DON'T GROW ON EVERYTHING, AND ARE PRETTY RARE, IT'S STILL
WORTH KNOWING HOW TO MIX ANTIDOTES. THE ONLY PERSON IN
THE ROOM WHOSE ANGER WAS GREATER THAN FERMINE'S WAS MALPHY, WHO
HARRY WAS PLEASED TO SEE, HAD SPILLED SOMETHING THAT LOOKED LIKE
CATSUP OVER HIMSELF. BEFORE EITHER OF THEM COULD EXPRESS THEIR
ALARM THAT HARRY HAD COME THROUGH THE CLASS BY NOT DOING ANY WORK,
HOWEVER, THE BELL RANG. TIME TO PACK UP! SAID SLUGGISHLY. AND
AN EXTRA TEN POINTS TO GRYFFINDOR FOR SHEER CHEER! STILL
CHUCKLING, HE WADDLED BACK TO HIS DESK AT THE FRONT OF THE DUNGEON.
HARRY DANDLED BEHIND, TAKING AN INDEFINITE AMOUNT OF TIME TO
TIE HIS BAG. NEITHER DOWN NOR FERMINE WISHED HIM GOOD AS THEY
LEFT; BOTH LOOKED RATHER ANNOYED. AT LAST HARRY AND SLUGGISHLY
WERE THE ONLY TWO LEFT IN THE ROOM. COME ON, NOW, HARRY, YOU'LL
BE LATE FOR YOUR NEXT LESSON, SAID SLUGGISHLY APPARENTLY, SNAPPING THE
GOLD CLASPS SHUT ON HIS DRAGON-SKIN BRIECASE. SIR, SAID HARRY,
REMINING HIMSELF IRRESISTIBLY OF VERMINE, I WANTED TO ASK YOU
SOMETHING. ASK AWAY, THEN, MY DEAR KID, ASK AWAY. SIR, I
WHISPERED WHAT YOU KNOW ABOUT ABOUT FERMINE'S? SLUGGISHLY

FREEZE. HIS BEHIND FACE SEEMED THE SINK IN LIPSHIN ITSELF. HE LICKED HIS LIPS AND SAID FEARFULLY, WHAT DID YOU SAY? I ASKED WHETHER YOU KNEW ANYTHING ABOUT HERCULES, SIR, YOU SEE. BLUNDERHOPE PUT YOU UP THE TIE, WHISPERED SLUGGISHLY. HIS VEHICLE HAD CHANGED COMPLETELY. IT WAS NOT GENIAL ANYMORE, BUT STICKED, TERRIFIED. HE CLIMBED IN HIS BREAST POCKET AND PULLED OUT A HANDKERCHIEF, MOPPING HIS SWEATING BROW. BLUNDERHOPE'S SILENCE TOLD YOU THAT THAT MEMORY, WELL? HADN'T HE? YES, SAID HARRY, DECIDING IN THE SPITE THAT IT WAS BEST NOT TO LIE. YES, HE CHIRPED, SAID SLUGGISHLY EMBITTERED, STILL DAKING AT HIS WHITE FACE. HE CHIRPED WELL, IF YOU'VE SEEN THAT MEMORY, HARRY, YOU'LL KNOW THAT I DIDN'T KNOW ANYTHING. ANYTHING. HE REPEATED THE WORD FURCULOUSLY

ABOUT HERCULES. HE SEIZED HIS DRAGON-SKIN BRIEFCASE, STUFFED HIS HANDKERCHIEF BACK INTO HIS POCKET, AND MARCHED THE THE BLINDLY DOWN. SIR, SAID HARRY DESPERATELY, I JUST THOUGHT THERE MIGHT BE A KIT MORE THE THE MEMORY. DID YOU? SAID SLUGGISHLY. THEN YOU WERE WRONG, WEREN'T YOU? WRONG! HE REMEMBERED THE LAST WORD AND, BEFORE HARRY COULD SAY ANOTHER WORD, SLAMMED THE BLINDLY DOWN BEHIND HIM. NEITHER THEN NOR HERMINE WAS AT ALL SYMPATHETIC WHEN HARRY TOLD THEM OF THIS DISASTROUS INTERVIEW. HERMINE WAS STILL SEETHING AT THE WAY HARRY HAD TRIUMPHED WITHOUT DOING THE WORD PROPERLY. THEN WAS RESENTFUL THAT HARRY HADN'T SLIPPED HIM A KEYSHAW THEN. IT WOULD BE JUST BEHIND STUPID IF WE DON'T DO IT? SAID HARRY IRRITABLY. BEHIND, I HAD THE TRY AND SEVEN HIM UP SEE I COULD ASK HIM ABOUT VERDIMENT, DIDN'T I? HE, WILL YOU GET A GRIP? HE ADDED IN EXASPERATION, AS THEN WINKED AT THE BEHIND OF THE NAME. INFLURIATED BY HIS FAILURE AND BY THEN'S AND HERMINE'S ATTITUDES, HARRY KNEWED FOR THE NEXT FEW DAYS EVER WHAT THE BE NEXT ABOUT SLUGGISHLY. HE DECIDED THAT, FOR THE TIME BEING, HE WOULD LET SLUGGISHLY THINK THAT HE HAD FORGOTTEN ALL ABOUT HERCULES; IT WAS SURELY BEST TO LULL HIM INTO A FALSE SENSE OF SECURITY BEFORE RETURNING THE THE ATTACK. WHEN HARRY DID NOT QUESTION SLUGGISHLY AGAIN, THE PEETIENS MASTER REVERTED TO HIS USUAL AFFECTUOUS TREATMENT OF HIM, AND APPEARED TO HAVE PUT THE MATTER FROM HIS MIND. HARRY AWAITED AN INVITATION TO ONE OF HIS LITTLE EVENING PARTIES, DETERMINED TO ACCEPT THIS TIME, EVEN IF HE HAD THE RESPECTABLE ELIDITCH PRACTICE. UNFORTUNATELY, HOWEVER, NO SUCH INVITATION ARRIVED. HARRY CHECKED WITH HERMINE AND

GINNY: NEITHER OF THEM HAD RECEIVED AN INVITATION AND NEER, AS FAR AS THEY KNEW, HAD ANSWERED ELSE. HARRY COULD NOT HELP WONDERING WHETHER THIS MEANT THAT SLUGGISHORN WAS NOT ELITE AS SHEETPLA AS HE APPEARED, SIMPLY DETERMINED TO GIVE HARRY NEW ADDITIONAL OPPORTUNITIES TO HURSTEN HIM. MEANWHILE, THE HOGWARTS LIBRARY HAD FAILED DETERMINE HER THE FIRST TIME IN LIVING MEMORY. SHE WAS SHE SHOCKED, SHE EVEN SHEGHT THAT SHE WAS ANSWERED AT HARRY HER HIS TRICK WITH THE BEZEL. I HAVEN'T FOUND ONE SINGLE EXPLANATION OF WHAT HURSTEN DOES SHE TOLD HIM. NOT A SINGLE ONE! I'VE BEEN RIGHT THROUGH THE RESTRICTED SECTION AND EVEN IN THE MOST HORRIBLE ROOMS, WHERE THEY TELL YOU HOW THE KNOW THE MOST CIRCUMSTANTIALS NOTHING! ALL I COULD FIND WAS THIS, IN THE INTRODUCTION THE MAGIC MASTER WILL LISTEN OF THE HURSTEN, WICKEDEST OF MAGICAL INVENTIONS, WE SHALL NOT SPEAK NEER GIVE DIRECTION. I MEAN, WHY MENTION IT THEN? SHE SAID IMPATIENTLY, SLAMMING THE OLD BOOK SHUT; IT LET OUT A GHOSTLY WAIL.

HE, SHE LIP, SHE SNAPPED, STUFFING IT BACK INTO HER BAG. THE SNOW MELTED AROUND THE SCHOOL AS FEBRUARY ARRIVED, THE ICE REPLACED BY CHILL, DREARY WETNESS. PURPLISH-GRAY CLOUDS HUNG OVER THE CASTLE AND A CONSTANT FALL OF CHILLY RAIN MADE THE LAWNES SLIPPERY AND MUDDY. THE LAST-SEE OF THIS WAS THAT THE SIXTH YEARS FIRST APPARITION LESSON, WHICH WAS SCHEDULED FOR A SATURDAY MORNING SHE THAT NEW NORMAL LESSONS WOULD BE MISSED, THEIR PLACE IN THE GREAT HALL INSTEAD OF IN THE GREENHOUSES. WHEN HARRY AND HERMIONE ARRIVED IN THE HALL (WHEN HAD COME DOWN WITH LAVENDER), THEY FOUND THAT THE TABLES HAD DISAPPEARED. RAIN LASHED AGAINST THE HIGH WINDOWS AND THE ENCHANTED CEILING SWIRLED DARKLY ABOVE THEM AS THEY ASSEMBLED IN FRONT OF PROFESSORS MCGONAGALL, Snape, FLITWICK, AND SPRELL. THE HEADS OF HOUSES AND A SMALL WIZARD WHEN HARRY THOUGHT THE THE APPARITION INSTRUCTION FROM THE MINISTRY. HE WAS EDDY CHEERLESS, WITH TRANSPARENT EYELASHES, WISPY HAIR, AND AN INSTANTIAL AIR, AS THOUGH A SINGLE GUST OF WIND MIGHT BLOW HIM AWAY. HARRY WONDERED WHETHER CONSTANT DISAPPEARANCES AND REAPPEARANCES HAD SOMEHOW DIMINISHED HIS SUBSTANCE, OR WHETHER THIS FRAIL BUILD WAS IDEAL FOR ANYONE WISHING TO VANISH. GOOD MORNING, SAID THE MINISTRY WIZARD, WHEN ALL THE STUDENTS HAD ARRIVED AND THE HEADS OF HOUSES HAD CALLED FOR QUIET. MY NAME IS WILKIE TWYCRESS AND I SHALL BE YOUR

MINISTRY APPARITION INSTRUCTIONS FOR THE NEXT TWELVE WEEKS. I
HOPED THEY WOULD BE ABLE TO PREPARE THEM FOR THEIR APPARITION TESTS IN
THIS TIME. MALPHEE, CRABBE AND PAUL ATTENTION! BARKED
PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. EVERYBODY LISTENED. MALPHEE HAD
FINISHED A BULL PUNK; HE LISTENED POLITELY AS HE STEPPED AWAY FROM
CRABBE, WITH WHOM HE APPEARED TO HAVE BEEN HAVING A WHISPERED
ARGUMENT. HARRY GLANCED QUICKLY AT SNAP, WHO WAS ALSO LISTENING
ANNOUNCED, THOUGH HARRY STRONGLY SUSPECTED THAT THIS WAS LESS
BECAUSE OF MALPHEE'S RUDENESS THAN THE FACT THAT MCGONAGALL HAD
REPRIMANDED HIM OF HIS BEHAVIOUR. BY WHICH TIME, MANY OF THEM MAY
BE READY TO TAKE THEIR TESTS. TWITCHES CONTINUED, AS THOUGH THERE
HAD BEEN NO INTERRUPTION. AS THEY MAY KNOW, IT IS USUALLY
IMPOSSIBLE TO APPARATE OR DISAPPARATE WITHIN HOGWARTS. THE
HEADMASTER HAS LIFTED THIS ENCHANTMENT, PURELY WITHIN THE GREAT
HALL, FOR ONE HOUR, SO AS TO ENABLE THEM TO PRACTICE. MAY I
EMPHASIZE THAT THEY WILL NOT BE ABLE TO APPARATE OUTSIDE THE WALLS
OF THIS HALL, AND THAT THEY WOULD BE WISE TO TRY. I WOULD LIKE
EACH OF THEM TO PLACE THEMSELVES NOW SO THAT THEY HAVE A CLEAR FIVE
FEET OF SPACE IN FRONT OF THEM. THERE WAS A GREAT SCRAMBLING AND
JOSTLING AS PEOPLE SEPARATED, RANGED INTO EACH OTHER, AND HINDERED
OTHERS FROM GETTING THEIR SPACE. THE HEADS OF HOUSES MOVED AMONG THE
STUDENTS, MARSHALLING THEM INTO POSITION AND BREAKING UP
ARGUMENTS. HARRY, WHERE ARE YOU GOING? DEMANDED HERMION.
BUT HARRY DID NOT ANSWER; HE WAS MOVING QUICKLY THROUGH THE
CREW, PAST THE PLACE WHERE PROFESSOR FLITWICK WAS MAKING
SERIOUS ATTEMPTS TO POSITION A FEW RAVENCLAWS, ALL OF WHOM
WANTED TO BE NEAR THE FRONT, PAST PROFESSOR SPRUIT, WHO WAS
TRYING TO LINE UP THE HUFFLEPUFFS INTO A LINE, UNTIL, BY DODGING AROUND ERIC
MACMILLAN, HE MANAGED TO POSITION HIMSELF RIGHT AT THE BACK OF
THE CREW, DIRECTLY BEHIND MALPHEE, WHO WAS TAKING ADVANTAGE OF
THE GENERAL UPHEAVAL TO CONTINUE HIS ARGUMENT WITH CRABBE,
STANDING FIVE FEET AWAY AND LISTENING POLITELY. I DON'T KNOW HOW
MUCH LONGER, ALL RIGHT? MALPHEE SAID AT HIM, HOWEVER, THE HARRY
STANDING RIGHT BEHIND HIM. IT WAS TAKING LONGER THAN I THOUGHT IT
WOULD. CRABBE OPENED HIS MOUTH, BUT MALPHEE APPEARED TO SECOND-
GUESS WHAT HE WAS GOING TO SAY. WELL, IT'S NONE OF YOUR BUSINESS
WHAT I'M DOING, CRABBE, YOU AND GRYFFINDOR JUST BE AS YOU'RE TOLD AND
KEEP A SHUT MOUTH! I TELL MY FRIENDS WHAT I'M UP TO, IF I WANT THEM

THE DEEP A LUNGEONIT FOR ME, FARRY SAID, ILST HELD KNELCH FOR MALPHY THE HEAR HIM, MALPHY SPLIN AREHND EN THE SPHT, HIS HAND FLYING THE HIS HAND, KLIT AT THAT PRECISE MEMENT THE FELIR HEADS HE FELISE STHELTED, ELIET? AND SILENCE FELL AGAIN, MALPHY TURNED SLEELY THE FACE THE PREHT AGAIN, THAND YELI, SAID TWYCRRESS,

NELI THEN HE WAVED HIS HAND, FELD-PAST-THEND WHEHND FHEPS INSTANTLY APPEARED EN THE PLHEH IN PREHT HE EVERY STUDENT, THE IMPHEARTANT THINGS THE REMEMER WHEN APPARATING ARE THE THREE D S: SAID TWYCRRESS, DESTINATION, DETERMINATION, DELIKERATION?

STEP ENK: FIX YELIR MIND FIRMLY WHEH THE DESIRED DESTINATION, SAID TWYCRRESS, IN THIS CASE, THE INTERIHR HE YELIR FHEH, KINDLY CHENKENTRATE WHEH THAT DESTINATION NELI, EVERYBODY WHEHED AREHND FLRTIVELY THE CHKEK THAT EVERYTHNG ELSE WAS STARING INTHE THEIR FHEH, THEN HASTILY DID AS THEY WERE TELD, FARRY GAZED AT THE CIRCULAR PATCH HE DUSTY PLHEH ENCLOSED BY HIS FHEH AND TRIED HARD THE THIND HE NETHING ELSE, THIS PREVED IMPOSSIBLE, AS HE CHELDN T STEP PLZZLING HEYER WEAT MALPHY WAS BEING THAT NEEDED LUNGEONITS,

STEP TWO, SAID TWYCRRESS, FELIS YELIR DETERMINATION THE HECLIPY THE VISUALIZED SPACE? LET YELIR YEARNING THE ENTER IT PLHEH FROM YELIR MIND THE EVERY PARTICLE HE YELIR KEH? FARRY GLANCED AREHND SLURREPTITIHELSY, A LITTLE WAY THE HIS LEFT, ERNIE MACMILLAN WAS CHENTEMPLATING HIS FHEH SE HARD THAT HIS FACE HAD TURNED PINK; IT WHEHED AS THELIGH HE WAS STRAINING THE LAY A ELIAPPLE-SIZED EGG, FARRY KIT BACK A LALCH AND HASTILY RETURNED HIS GAZE THE HIS HEH FHEH, STEP THREE, CALLED TWYCRRESS, AND ENLY WHEN I GIVE THE CHFYMAND TURN EN THE SPHT, FEELING YELIR WAY INTHE NETHINGENESS, MEYING WITH DELIKERATION? EN MY CHFYMAND, NELI ENK

FARRY GLANCED AREHND AGAIN; LETS HE PEOPLE WERE WHEHNG POSITIVELY ALARMED AT BEING ASKED THE APPARATE SE ELIICLY,

TWO FARRY TRIED THE FIX HIS THELIGHS EN HIS FHEH AGAIN; HE HAD ALREADY FHEGHTTEN WEAT THE THREE D S STEH FOR, THE-KEK; FARRY SPLIN EN THE SPHT, LEST BALANCE, AND NEARLY FELL HEYER, HE WAS NEET THE ENLY ENK, THE WHELE FALL WAS SLIDDERLY FLIM HE STAGGERING PEOPLE; NEVILLE WAS FLAT EN HIS BACK; ERNIE MACMILLAN, EN THE EHTER HAND, HAD BEEN A KIND HE PIRHELETING LEAP INTHE HIS FHEH AND WHEHED MEMENTARILY THE-ILLED, UNTIL HE CALIGHT SIGHT HE DEAN THOMAS REHARING WITH LALCHTER AT HIM, NEVER MIND, NEVER MIND, SAID TWYCRRESS DRYLY, WEH DID NEET SEEM THE HAVE EXPECTED

ANYTHING BETTER. ADJUST YOUR FEET, PLEASE, AND BACK TO YOUR ORIGINAL POSITIONS. THE SECOND ATTEMPT WAS NOT BETTER THAN THE FIRST. THE THIRD WAS JUST AS BAD. NOT UNTIL THE FOURTH DID ANYTHING EXCITING HAPPEN. THERE WAS A TERRIBLE SCREECH OF PAIN AND EVERYBODY LOOKED AROUND, TERRIFIED, TO SEE SUSAN KNEES UP FLAPFLAP WHIRLING IN HER HOP WITH HER LEFT LEG STILL STANDING FIVE FEET AWAY WHERE SHE HAD STARTED. THE FEARS OF FALISE CONVERGED ON HER; THERE WAS A GREAT RANG AND A PUFF OF PURPLE SMOKE, WHICH CLEARED THE REVEAL SUSAN SHRIeking, REUNITED WITH HER LEG BUT LOOKING TERRIFIED. SPLINKING, FOR THE SEPARATION OF RANDOM BODY PARTS, SAID WILKIE TWYTRISS DISPASSIONATELY, HILLARS WHEN THE MIND IS INSUFFICIENTLY DETERMINED, YOU MUST CONCENTRATE CONTINUOUSLY UPON YOUR DESTINATION, AND MOVE, WITHOUT HASTE, BUT WITH DELIBERATION THIS. TWYTRISS STEPPED FORWARD, TURNED GRACEFULLY ON THE SPOT WITH HIS ARMS OUTSTRETCHED, AND VANISHED IN A SWIRL OF REEKS, REAPPEARING AT THE BACK OF THE HALL.

REMEMBER THE THREE D S, HE SAID, AND TRY AGAIN ONE TWO THREE BUT AN HOUR LATER, SUSAN'S SPLINKING WAS STILL THE MOST INTERESTING THING THAT HAD HAPPENED. TWYTRISS DID NOT SEEM DISCOURAGED, FASTENING HIS CHIN AT HIS NECK, HE MERELY SAID, UNTIL NEXT SATURDAY, EVERYBODY, AND DO NOT FORGET! DESTINATION, DETERMINATION, DELIBERATION. WITH THAT, HE WAVED HIS HAND, VANISHING THE FEARS, AND WALKED OUT OF THE HALL ACCOMPANIED BY PROFESSOR MCGINAGALL. TALK BROKE OUT AT ONCE AS PEOPLE BEGAN MOVING TOWARD THE ENTRANCE HALL. FELL DID YOU DE? ASKED BEN, FLURRYING TOWARD HARRY. I THINK I FELT SOMETHING THE LAST TIME I TRIED A KIND OF TINGLING IN MY FEET. I EXPECT YOUR TRAINERS ARE THE SMALL, WEE-WEE, SAID A VOICE BEHIND THEM, AND DETERMINED STALKED PAST, SMIRKING. I DIDN'T FEEL ANYTHING, SAID HARRY, IGNORING THIS INTERRUPTION. BUT I DIDN'T CARE ABOUT THAT NOW

WHAT DO YOU MEAN, YOU DIDN'T CARE? DIDN'T YOU WANT TO LEARN THE APPARATUS? SAID BEN INCREDULOUSLY. I'M NOT FLISHED, REALLY, I PREFER FLYING, SAID HARRY, GLANCING OVER HIS SHOULDER TO SEE WHERE MALCOLM WAS, AND SPEEDING UP AS THEY CAME INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. LOOK, FLURRY UP, WILL YOU, THERE'S SOMETHING I WANT TO DO.

PERPLEXED, BEN FOLLOWED HARRY BACK TO THE GRAYFINDER TOWER AT A RUN. THEY WERE TEMPORARILY DETAINED BY PEEVES, WHO HAD JAMMED A BEER IN THE FOURTH FLOOR SHUT AND WAS REFLUSING THE LET

ANYONE PASS UNTIL THEY SET FIRE TO THEIR OWN PANTS, BUT HARRY AND BEN SIMPLY TURNED BACK AND THEN HEW OF THEIR TRUSTED SHORTCLITS. WITHIN FIVE MINUTES, THEY WERE CLIMBING THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE. ARE YOU GOING TO TELL ME WHAT WE'RE DOING, THEN? ASKED BEN, PANTING SLIGHTLY. UP HERE, SAID HARRY, AND HE CROSSED THE CHIMNEY BEAM AND LED THE WAY THROUGH THE BEHIND THE THE ROYS STAIRCASE. THEIR DORMITORY WAS, AS HARRY HAD HOPED, EMPTY. HE PULLED OPEN HIS TRUNK AND BEGAN THE UNPACKING IN IT, WHILE BEN WATCHED IMPATIENTLY. HARRY MALPHY'S LISTING CRACK AND CRACK AS UNDOING. HE WAS ARGUING WITH CRACKER JUST NOW. I WANT THE DUEL. ALA. HE HAD FOUND IT, A PIELD SHELLAR HE APPARENTLY BLANK PARCHMENT, WHICH HE NOW SMITHED HLT AND TAPPED WITH THE TIP OF HIS HAND. I SERIOUSLY SWEAR THAT I AM UP THE NEW CHIEF. HE MALPHY IS ANYWAY. AT ONCE, THE MARALDER'S MAP APPEARED ON THE PARCHMENT'S SURFACE. THERE WAS A DETAILED PLAN OF EVERY HUNK OF THE CASTLE'S PLANS AND, MOVING AROUND IT, THE TINY, LABELED BLACK DOTS THAT SIGNIFIED EACH OF THE CASTLE'S OCCUPANTS. HELP ME FIND MALPHY, SAID HARRY URGENTLY. HE LAID THE MAP UPON HIS BED, AND HE AND BEN LEANED OVER IT, SEARCHING. THERE? SAID BEN, AFTER A MINUTE OR SO. HE'S IN THE SOUTHERN CHIMNEY BEAM, WITH PARKINSON AND ZAKINI AND CRACKER AND CRACKER. HARRY LOOKED DOWN AT THE MAP, DISAPPOINTED, BUT RALLIED HIMSELF AT ONCE. WELL, I'M KEEPING AN EYE ON HIM FROM NOW ON. HE SAID FIRMLY. AND THE MOMENT I SEE HIM WORKING SOMEWHERE WITH CRACKER AND CRACKER KEEPING WATCH HLTIDE, IT'LL BE ON WITH THE OLD INVISIBILITY CHARM AND WE'LL FIND HLT WHAT HE'S. HE BROKE OFF AS NEVILLE ENTERED THE DORMITORY, BRINGING WITH HIM A STRONG SMELL OF SINGED MATERIAL, AND BEGAN UNPACKING IN HIS TRUNK FOR A FRESH PAIR OF PANTS. DESPITE HIS DETERMINATION TO CATCH MALPHY HLT, HARRY HAD NOT LOOKED AT ALL OVER THE NEXT FEW WEEKS. ALTHOUGH HE CONSULTED THE MAP AS OFTEN AS HE COULD, SOMETIMES MAKING UNNECESSARY VISITS TO THE BATHROOM BETWEEN LESSONS TO SEARCH IT, HE DID NOT ONCE SEE MALPHY ANYWHERE SUSPICIOUS. ADMITTEDLY, HE SPENTED CRACKER AND CRACKER MOVING AROUND THE CASTLE ON THEIR OWN MORE OFTEN THAN USUAL, SOMETIMES REMAINING STATUE-LIKE IN DESERTED CORRIDORS, BUT AT THESE TIMES MALPHY WAS NOT ONLY NOWHERE NEAR THEM, BUT IMPOSSIBLE TO LOCATE ON THE MAP AT ALL. THIS WAS MOST MYSTERIOUS. HARRY TOOK WITH THE POSSIBILITY THAT

MALPHEW WAS ACTUALLY LEAVING THE SCHEMEL GRIELINDS, BUT CHILD HAD NOT SEEN HIM. HE CHILD BE DOING IT, GIVEN THE VERY HIGH LEVEL OF SECURITY WHEN OPERATING WITHIN THE CASTLE. HE CHILD ONLY SUPPOSE THAT HE WAS MISSING MALPHEW AMONGST THE HUNDREDS OF TINY BLACK DOTS UPON THE MAP. AS FOR THE FACT THAT MALPHEW, CRABBE, AND GRAYLE APPEARED TO BE GOING THEIR DIFFERENT WAYS WHEN THEY WERE USUALLY INSEPARABLE, THESE THINGS HAPPENED AS PEOPLE GET OLDER. RON AND HERMION, HARRY REFLECTED SADLY, WERE LIVING PROPER, FEBRUARY MIGHT TOWARD MARCH WITH NO CHANGE IN THE WEATHER EXCEPT THAT IT BECAME WINDY AS WELL AS WET. THE GENERAL INDIGNATION, A SIGN WENT UP IN ALL CORNERS WHEN NOTICE CAME THAT THE NEXT TRIP INTO HOGSMEAD HAD BEEN CANCELED. RON WAS FLURRIED. IT WAS MY BIRTHDAY! HE SAID. I WAS LOOKING FORWARD TO THAT! NOT A BIG SURPRISE, HOWEVER, IS IT? SAID HARRY. NOT AFTER WHAT HAPPENED THE DATE. SHE HAD STILL NOT RETURNED FROM ST. MUNGUS'S, WHAT WAS MORE, FURTHER DISAPPEARANCES HAD BEEN REPORTED IN THE DAILY PROPHET, INCLUDING SEVERAL RELATIVES OF STUDENTS AT HOGWARTS.

BUT NOW ALL I'VE GOT TO LOOK FORWARD TO IS STUPID APPARITION! SAID RON GRUMPILY. BIG BIRTHDAY TREAT. THREE LESSONS IN APPARITION WAS PROVING AS DIFFICULT AS EVER, HOWEVER A FEW MORE PEOPLE HAD MANAGED TO SPLINCH THEMSELVES, FRUSTRATION WAS RUNNING HIGH AND THERE WAS A CERTAIN AMOUNT OF ILL-FEELING TOWARD WILKIE TWYFRESS AND HIS THREE D'S, WHICH HAD INSPIRED A NUMBER OF NICKNAMES FOR HIM, THE POKIEST OF WHICH WERE DEEREATH AND DINGHEAD. HAPPY BIRTHDAY, RON, SAID HARRY, WHEN THEY WERE WOKEN IN THE FIRST OF MARCH BY SEamus AND DEAN LEAVING QUIETLY FOR BREAKFAST. HAVE A PRESENT. HE THREW THE PACKAGE ACROSS INTO RON'S BED, WHERE IT LINED A SMALL PILE OF THEM THAT MUST, HARRY ASSUMED, HAVE BEEN DELIVERED BY HOUSE-ELVES IN THE NIGHT. CHEERS, SAID RON DRILLY AND, AS HE RIPPED OFF THE PAPER, HARRY GOT OUT OF BED, OPENED HIS OWN TRUNK, AND BEGAN REMINISCING IN IT FOR THE MARAUDER'S MAP, WHICH HE HAD AFTER EVERY USE. HE TURNED OUT HALF THE CONTENTS OF HIS TRUNK BECAUSE HE FOUND IT HIDING BENEATH THE ROLLED-UP STICKS IN WHICH HE WAS STILL KEEPING HIS KITTLE OF LICKY POTION, FELIX FELIX. RIGHT, HE MURMURED, TAKING IT BACK TO BED WITH HIM, TAPPING IT QUIETLY AND MURMURING, I SOLEMNLY SWEAR THAT I AM UP TO THE GILLS, SEE THAT NEVILLE, WHO WAS PASSING THE FEET OF HIS BED AT THE TIME, WOULD NOT

HEAR, NICE ONE, HARRY? SAID RON ENTHUSIASTICALLY, WAVING THE NEW PAIR OF FLIMDITCH KEEPER'S GLOVES HARRY HAD GIVEN HIM. THE PROBLEM, SAID HARRY ASSENTINGLY, AS HE SEARCHED THE SLYTHERIN HERMITRY CLOSET FOR MALFOY. EY I DONT THINK HE'S IN HIS BED. RON DID NOT ANSWER; HE WAS THEN BUSY UNWRAPPING PRESENTS, EVERY NOW AND THEN LETTING OUT AN EXCLAMATION OF PLEASURE. SERIOUSLY GOOD FALK THIS YEAR? HE ANNOUNCED, HOLDING UP A HEAVY GOLD WATCH WITH TWO SYMBOLS AROUND THE EDGE AND TINY MOVING STARS INSTEAD OF HANDS. SEE WHAT MOM AND DAD GOT ME? KIMMY, I THINK I'LL COME UP AGE NEXT YEAR THEN. CHEER, MUTTERED HARRY, SPARING THE WATCH A GLANCE BEFORE PEERING MORE CLOSELY AT THE MAP. WHERE WAS MALFOY? HE DID NOT SEEM TO BE AT THE SLYTHERIN TABLE IN THE GREAT HALL, EATING BREAKFAST. HE WAS NOWHERE NEAR SNAPE, WHO WAS SITTING IN HIS STUDY. HE WASN'T IN ANY OF THE BATHROOMS OR IN THE HOSPITAL WING. WANT MORE? SAID RON THICKLY, HOLDING OUT A BOX OF CHOCOLATE CAJIBRENS. NOT THANKS, SAID HARRY, LEERING UP. MALFOY'S GONE AGAIN? CAN'T HAVE BEEN, SAID RON, STUFFING A SECOND CAJIBREN INTO HIS MOUTH AS HE SLID OUT OF BED TO GET DRESSED. COME ON, IF YOU DONT HARRY UP, YOU'LL HAVE TO APPARATE IN AN EMPTY STOMACH. MIGHT MAKE IT EASIER, I SUPPOSE. RON LOOKED TENTATIVELY AT THE BOX OF CHOCOLATE CAJIBRENS, THEN SPOLGED AND HELPED HIMSELF TO A THIRD. HARRY TAPPED THE MAP WITH HIS WAND, MUTTERED, MISCHIEF MANAGED, THOUGH IT HADN'T BEEN, AND GOT DRESSED, THINKING HARD. THERE HAD TO BE AN EXPLANATION FOR MALFOY'S PERIODIC DISAPPEARANCES, BUT HE SIMPLY COULD NOT THINK WHAT IT COULD BE. THE BEST WAY OF FINDING OUT WOULD BE TO TALK HIM, BUT EVEN WITH THE INVISIBILITY CHARM THIS WAS AN IMPRACTICAL IDEA: HARRY HAD LESSONS, FLIMDITCH PRACTICE, HEMLOCK, AND APPARITION; HE COULD NOT AFFORD MALFOY AROUND SCHOOL ALL DAY WITH HIS ABSENCE BEING REMARKED UPON. READY? HE SAID TO RON. HE WAS HALFWAY TO THE HERMITRY WHEN HE REALIZED THAT RON HAD NOT MOVED, BUT WAS LEANING ON HIS BEDPOST, STARING OUT OF THE RAIN-WASHED WINDOW WITH A STRANGELY UNFOCUSSED LOOK ON HIS FACE. RON'S BREAKFAST. I'M NOT HUNGRY, HARRY STARED AT HIM. I THOUGHT YOU'LL JUST SAID

? WELL, ALL RIGHT, I'LL COME DOWN WITH YOU, SIGHED RON, BUT I DONT WANT TO EAT. HARRY SCRUTINIZED HIM SUSPICIOUSLY. YOU'VE JUST EATEN HALF A BOX OF CHOCOLATE CAJIBRENS, HAVEN'T YOU? IT'S

NOT THAT, RICH SIGHED AGAIN, YET YET WOULDNT UNDERSTAND,
FAIR ENOUGH, SAID HARRY, ALKOT PLIZZLED, AS HE TURNED THE OPEN
THE DEER, HARRY? SAID RICH SUDDENLY, WHAT? HARRY, I CAN T
STAND IT? YET CAN T STAND WHAT? ASKED HARRY, YET STARTING THE
FEEL DEFINITELY ALARMED, RICH WAS RATHER PALE AND WHEEZED AS THOUGH
HE WAS ABOUT THE BE SICK, I CAN T STOP THINKING ABOUT HER? SAID
RICH HARSHLY, HARRY GASED AT HIM, HE HAD NOT EXPECTED THIS AND
WAS NOT SURE HE WANTED TO HEAR IT, FRIENDS THEY MIGHT BE, BUT IF
RICH STARTED CALLING LAVENDER LAV-LAV, HE WOULD HAVE TO PUT HIS
FEET DOWN, WHY DOES THAT STOP YET HAVING BREAKFAST? HARRY
ASKED, TRYING TO INJECT A NOTE OF CHEERFUL SENSE INTO THE
PROCEEDINGS, I DONT THINK SHE KNOWS I EXIST, SAID RICH WITH A
DESPERATE GESTURE, SHE DEFINITELY KNOWS YET EXIST, SAID HARRY,
BEMILDERED, SHE KEEPS SMUGGING YET, DONT SHE? RICH BLINKED,
WHEN ARE YET TALKING ABOUT? WHEN ARE YET TALKING ABOUT?
SAID HARRY, WITH AN INCREASING SENSE THAT ALL REASON HAD DROPPED
OUT OF THE CONVERSATION, REMILDA VANE, SAID RICH SHITLY, AND HIS
WHITE FACE SEEMED TO ILLUMINATE AS HE SAID IT, AS THOUGH HIT BY A
RAY OF PUREST SUNLIGHT, THEY STARED AT EACH OTHER FOR ALMOST A
WHOLE MINUTE, BEFORE HARRY SAID, THIS IS A Joke, RIGHT? YET RE
THINKING, I THINK HARRY, I THINK I LOVE HER, SAID RICH IN A
STRANGLED VOICE, TODAY, SAID HARRY, WALKING UP TO RICH TO GET A
BETTER LOOK AT THE GLAZED EYES AND THE PALLID COMPLEXION, TODAY
SAY THAT AGAIN WITH A STRAIGHT FACE, I LOVE HER, REPEATED RICH
BREATHLESSLY, HAVE YET SEEN HER HAIR, IT S ALL BLACK AND SHINY AND
SILKY AND HER EYES? HER BIG DARK EYES? AND HER THIS IS
REALLY FLIRTY AND EVERYTHING, SAID HARRY IMPATIENTLY, BUT Joke S
EVER, ALL RIGHT? DROP IT, HE TURNED THE LEAVE; HE HAD GOTTEN TWO STEPS
TOWARD THE DEER WHEN A CRASHING WHEEL HIT HIM ON THE RIGHT EAR,
STAGGERING, HE WHEEZED AROUND, RICH S FIST WAS DRIVEN RIGHT BACK;
HIS FACE WAS COUNTERTEINTED WITH RAGE; HE WAS ABOUT TO STRIKE AGAIN,
HARRY REACTED INSTINCTIVELY; HIS HAND WAS OUT OF HIS POCKET AND
THE INCANTATION SPRANG TO MIND WITHOUT CONSCIOUS THOUGHT;
LEVITCHPOLIS? RICH YELLED AS HIS FEEL WAS WRENCHED UPWARD AND
DOWN; HE DANGLED HELPLESSLY, UPSIDE DOWN, HIS REEKS HANGING OFF
HIM, WHAT WAS THAT FOR? HARRY BELLEWED, YET INSULTED HER,
HARRY? YET SAID IT WAS A Joke; SMILED AT RICH, WHO WAS SLOWLY
TURNING PURPLE IN THE FACE AS ALL THE BLEED RUSHED TO HIS HEAD,

THIS IS INSANE! SAID HARRY, WHAT'S GETTING INTO ME? AND THEN HE SAW THE KING LYING HYPHEN HIS REIN'S RED, AND THE TRUTH HIT HIM WITH THE FORCE OF A STAMPEDEING TRAIL. WHERE DID THEY GET THESE CHOCOLATE CALIBRENS? THEY WERE A BIRTHDAY PRESENT! SHOUTED REIN, REVEALING SILENTLY IN MIDAIR AS HE STRUGGLED THE GET FREE. I HOPPED THEY HAD, DIDN'T I? THEY JUST PICKED THEM UP OFF THE FLOOR, DIDN'T THEY? THEY'D FALLEN OFF MY BED, ALL RIGHT? LET ME GO! THEY DIDN'T FALL OFF MY BED, THEY FELL, DIDN'T THEY UNDERSTAND? THEY WERE MINE, I CHUCKED THEM OUT OF MY TAILOR WHEN I WAS LOOKING FOR THE MAP, THEY'RE THE CHOCOLATE CALIBRENS REMILDA GAVE ME BEFORE CHRISTMAS, AND THEY'RE ALL SPICED WITH LOVE POTION! BUT ONLY ONE WOULD OF THIS SEEMED TO HAVE REGISTERED WITH REIN, REMILDA? HE REPEATED. DID THEY SAY REMILDA? HARRY DID THEY KNOW HER? CAN THEY INTRODUCE ME? HARRY STARED AT THE DANGLING REIN, WHOSE FACE NOW LOOKED TREMENDOUSLY IMPASSIVE, AND FELT A STRONG DESIRE TO LAUGH. A PART OF HIM THE PART CLOSEST TO HIS THROTTLE RIGHT EAR WAS WHITE WITH THE IDEA OF LETTING REIN GO AND WATCHING HIM RUN AWAY UNTIL THE EFFECTS OF THE POTION WERE OFF.

BUT ON THE OTHER HAND, THEY WERE SUPPOSED TO BE FRIENDS, REIN HAD NOT BEEN HIMSELF WHEN HE HAD ATTACKED, AND HARRY THOUGHT THAT HE WOULD DESERVE ANOTHER PUNCHING IF HE PERMITTED REIN TO DECLARE LYDING LOVE FOR REMILDA VANE. YES, I WILL INTRODUCE THEM, SAID HARRY, THINKING FAST. I'M GOING TO LET THEM GO NOW, HOW? HE SENT REIN CRASHING BACK TO THE FLOOR (HIS EAR DID NOT FEEL WHITE A BIT), BUT REIN SIMPLY REINDED TO HIS FEET AGAIN, GRINNING.

SHE IS IN SILVERMAN'S OFFICE, SAID HARRY CONFIDENTLY, LEADING THE WAY TO THE DOOR. WHY WILL SHE BE IN THERE? ASKED REIN ANXIOUSLY, FLURRYING THE DEEP LIP. HE, SHE HAS EXTRA POTIONLESSONS WITH HIM, SAID HARRY, INVENTING WILDLY. MAYBE I COULD ASK IF I CAN HAVE THEM WITH HER? SAID REIN RAGERLY. GREAT IDEA, SAID HARRY. LAVENDER WAS WAITING BESIDE THE PORTRAIT FRAME, A COMPLICATION HARRY HAD NOT FORESEEN. THEY'RE LATE, WHEN-WHEN? SHE PHUTED. I'VE GOT THEM A BIRTHDAY LEAVE ME ALONE, SAID REIN IMPATIENTLY. HARRY'S GOING TO INTRODUCE ME TO REMILDA VANE. AND WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD TO HER, HE POLISHED HIS WAY OUT OF THE PORTRAIT FRAME. HARRY TRIED TO MAKE AN APPEALING FACE TO LAVENDER, BUT IT MIGHT HAVE TURNED OUT SIMPLY APPLUSED, BECAUSE SHE LOOKED MORE OFFENDED THAN EVER AS THE FAT LADY STANDING SHEET BEHIND

THEM, HARRY HAD BEEN SLIGHTLY WORRIED THAT SLYTHEORN MIGHT BE AT BREAKFAST, BUT HE ANSWERED HIS OFFICE DOOR AT THE FIRST RING, WEARING A GREEN VELVET DRESSING GOWN AND MATCHING NIGHTCAP AND BEHINDING RATHER BLEARY-EYES. HARRY, HE MURMURED, THIS IS VERY EARLY FOR A CALL. I GENERALLY SLEEP LATE ON A SATURDAY.

PROFESSOR, I'M REALLY SORRY THE DISTURB YOU, SAID HARRY AS BRIEFLY AS POSSIBLE, WHILE RON STOOD ON TIPTOE, ATTEMPTING TO SEE PAST SLYTHEORN INTO HIS ROOM, BUT MY FRIEND RON'S SWALLOWED A LEMON POTION BY MISTAKE, YOU COULDN'T MAKE HIM AN ANTI-DOTE, COULD YOU? I'D TAKE HIM THE MADAM POMPOM, BUT WE'RE NOT SUPPOSED TO HAVE ANYTHING FROM WEASLEY'S WIZARD WEAPONS AND, YOU KNOW ALFRED ELLISTON. I'D HAVE THOUGHT YOU COULD HAVE WHIPPED HIM UP A REMEDY, HARRY, AN EXPERT POTIONEER LIKE YOU? ASKED SLYTHEORN. ER, SAID HARRY, SOMETIMES DISTRACTED BY THE FACT THAT RON WAS NOW KICKING HIM IN THE RIBS IN AN ATTEMPT TO FORCE HIS WAY INTO THE ROOM. WELL, I'VE NEVER MIXED AN ANTI-DOTE FOR A LEMON POTION, SIR, AND BY THE TIME I GET IT RIGHT, RON MIGHT BE DRINKING SOMETHING SERIOUS. HELPFULLY, RON CHOSE THIS MOMENT TO MEAN, I CAN'T SEE HER, HARRY. IS HE HIDING HER? WAS THIS POTION WITHIN DATE? ASKED SLYTHEORN, NOW LYING RON WITH PROFESSIONAL INTEREST. THEY CAN STRENGTHEN, YOU KNOW, THE LONGER THEY'RE KEPT. THAT WOULD EXPLAIN A LOT, PANTED HARRY, NOW POSITIVELY WRESTLING WITH RON TO KEEP HIM FROM KNOCKING SLYTHEORN OVER. IT'S HIS BIRTHDAY, PROFESSOR, HE ADDED IMPLORINGLY. EH, ALL RIGHT, COME IN, THEN, COME IN, SAID SLYTHEORN, RELENTING. I'VE GOT THE NECESSARY HERE IN MY BAG, IT'S NOT A DIFFICULT ANTI-DOTE. RON FIRST THROUGHT THE DOOR INTO SLYTHEORN'S HYPHEATED, CROWDED STUDY, TRIPPED OVER A TASSELED PHEETSTICK, REGAINED HIS BALANCE BY SEIZING HARRY AROUND THE NECK, AND MUTTERED, SHE DIDN'T SEE THAT, DID SHE? SHE'S NOT HERE YET, SAID HARRY, WATCHING SLYTHEORN OPENING HIS POTION KIT AND ADDING A FEW PINCHES OF THIS AND THAT TO A SMALL CRYSTAL BOTTLE.

THAT'S GOOD, SAID RON PERVENTLY. FEEL DE I LEED? VERY HANDSOME, SAID SLYTHEORN SMILETHLY, HANDING RON A GLASS OF CLEAR LIQUID. NOW DRINK THAT UP, IT'S A TONIC FOR THE NERVES, KEEP YOU CALM WHEN SHE ARRIVES, YOU KNOW. BRILLIANT, SAID RON EAGERLY, AND HE GLIMPED THE ANTI-DOTE DOWN NEUTRALLY. HARRY AND SLYTHEORN WATCHED HIM, FOR A MOMENT, RON BEAMED AT THEM, THEN, VERY SLOWLY,

THAT'S GOOD, SAID RON PERVENTLY. FEEL DE I LEED? VERY HANDSOME, SAID SLYTHEORN SMILETHLY, HANDING RON A GLASS OF CLEAR LIQUID. NOW DRINK THAT UP, IT'S A TONIC FOR THE NERVES, KEEP YOU CALM WHEN SHE ARRIVES, YOU KNOW. BRILLIANT, SAID RON EAGERLY, AND HE GLIMPED THE ANTI-DOTE DOWN NEUTRALLY. HARRY AND SLYTHEORN WATCHED HIM, FOR A MOMENT, RON BEAMED AT THEM, THEN, VERY SLOWLY,

HIS GRIN SAGGED AND VANISHED, THE BE REPLACED BY AN EXPRESSION OF
UTMOST FUROR. BACK THE NORMAL, THEN? SAID HARRY, GRINNING.
SLUGGISHN CHUCKLED. THANKS A LOT, PROFESSOR. DONT MENTION IT,
M KID, DONT MENTION IT, SAID SLUGGISHN, AS RENN COLLAPSED INTO A
NEARBY ARMCHAIR, LEEKING DEVASTATED. PICK-UP-LIP, THAT S WHAT HE
NEEDS. SLUGGISHN CONTINUED, WHEN KLUTTING EVER THE A TABLE LOADED
WITH DRINKS. I VE GET KLUTTERKEER, I VE GET WINE, I VE GET HINE LAST
BUTTLE OF THIS MAD-MATLRED MEAD HMM MEANT THE GIVE THAT THE
DUMKLEBHERE FOR CHRISTMAS AH, WELL HE SHRUGGED. HE CAN T
MISS WHAT HE S NEVER HAD! WHY DONT WE OPEN IT NOW AND CELEBRATE
MR. WEASLEY S BIRTHDAY? NOTHING LIKE A FINE SPIRIT THE CHASE AWAY
THE PAINS OF DISAPPOINTED LOVE. HE CHEERED AGAIN, AND HARRY
THINKED IN. THIS WAS THE FIRST TIME HE HAD FELT HIMSELF ALMOST
ALONE WITH SLUGGISHN SINCE HIS DISASTROUS FIRST ATTEMPT TO
EXTRACT THE TRUE MEMORY FROM HIM. PERHAPS, IF HE COULD JUST KEEP
SLUGGISHN IN A GOOD MOOD PERHAPS IF THEY GET THROUGH
ENOUGH OF THE MAD-MATLRED MEAD THERE WELL ARE THEN, SAID
SLUGGISHN, HANDING HARRY AND RENN A GLASS OF MEAD EACH BEHOLD
RAISING HIS HEAD. WELL, A VERY HAPPY BIRTHDAY, RALPH RENN

WHISPERED HARRY, BUT RENN, WHO DID NOT APPEAR TO BE LISTENING
TO THE THOAT, HAD ALREADY THROWN THE MEAD INTO HIS MOUTH AND
SWALLOWED IT. THERE WAS ONE SECOND, HARDLY MORE THAN A HEARTBEAT,
IN WHICH HARRY KNEW THERE WAS SOMETHING TERRIBLY WRONG AND
SLUGGISHN, IT SEEMED, DID NOT. AND MAY WELL HAVE MANY MORE

RENN? RENN HAD DROPPED HIS GLASS; HE HALF-ROSE FROM HIS CHAIR
AND THEN CUMPLED, HIS EXTREMITIES TROING UNCONTROLLABLY, FROM
WAS DRINKING FROM HIS MOUTH, AND HIS EYES WERE CLINGING FROM THEIR
SECRETS. PROFESSOR? HARRY BELIEVED. OH SOMETHING! BUT
SLUGGISHN SEEMED PARALYZED BY SILENCE. RENN TWITCHED AND CROOKED; HIS
SKIN WAS TURNING BLUE. WHAT BUT SPLUTTERED SLUGGISHN.
HARRY LEAPT OVER A LOW TABLE AND SPRINTED TOWARD SLUGGISHN S
OPEN MOUTH, PULLING EARTHS AND PEELERS, WHILE THE TERRIBLE
SOUND OF RENN S GARGLING BREATH FILLED THE ROOM. THEN HE FELT IT

THE SHRIELED KIDNEYLIKE STONE SLUGGISHN HAD TAKEN FROM HIM
IN MOUTH. HE FLUTTERED BACK TO RENN S SIDE, WRENCHED OPEN HIS JAW,
AND THROST THE BEZEL INTO HIS MOUTH. RENN GAVE A GREAT SLIDDER,
A RATTING GASP, AND HIS BODY BECAME LIMP AND STILL. UP TAILS SHE
ALL IN ALL, NOT ONE OF RENN S BETTER BIRTHDAYS? SAID FRED. IT WAS

EVENING; THE HOSPITAL WING WAS QUIET, THE WINDOWS CURTAINED, THE LAMPS LIT. RICH WAS THE ONLY ECLIPSED RED. FARRY, FERMINE, AND GINNY WERE SITTING AROUND HIM; THEY HAD SPENT ALL DAY WAITING OUTSIDE THE DOOR, TRYING TO SEE INSIDE WHENEVER SOMEONE WENT IN OR OUT. MADAM PEMFREY HAD ONLY LET THEM ENTER AT EIGHT O'CLOCK. FRED AND GEORGE HAD ARRIVED AT TEN PAST. THIS ISN'T THE WAY WE IMAGINED HANDING OVER OUR PRESENT, SAID GEORGE GRIMLY, PLACING DOWN A LARGE WRAPPED GIFT ON RICH'S BEDSIDE CABINET AND SITTING BESIDE GINNY. YES, WHEN WE PICTURED THE SCENE, HE WAS CONSCIOUS, SAID FRED. THERE WE WERE IN THE STRAITS, WAITING TO SURPRISE HIM. SAID GEORGE. YOU WERE IN THE STRAITS? ASKED GINNY, LEANING UP. WE WERE THINKING OF BUYING ZEPHYRUS, SAID FRED GLUMLY. A STRAITS BOAT, YOU KNOW, BUT A FAT LOT OF GOOD IT'D BE TO US IF YOU LEFT AROUND AT WEEKENDS THE WAY OUR STUFF ANYMORE. BUT NEVER MIND THAT NOW. HE DREW UP A CHAIR BESIDE FARRY AND LOOKED AT RICH'S PALE FACE. THAT EXACTLY DID IT HAPPEN, FARRY? FARRY RETOLD THE STORY HE HAD ALREADY REHEARSED, IT FELT LIKE A HUNDRED TIMES THE OTHERS, THE MCGINNAGALL, THE MADAM PEMFREY, THE FERMINE, AND THE GINNY, AND THEN I GOT THE KEYSAR DOWN HIS THROAT AND HIS BREATHING RASPED UP A BIT, SUGGESTION RAN FOR HELP, MCGINNAGALL AND MADAM PEMFREY TURNED UP, AND THEY BROUGHT RICH UP HERE. THEY RECOGNIZED HE'D BE ALL RIGHT, MADAM PEMFREY SAYS HE'D HAVE TO STAY HERE A WEEK OR SO. KEEP TAKING ESSENCE OF LIFE. QUICKLY, IT WAS LUCKY YOU THOUGHT OF A KEYSAR, SAID GEORGE IN A LOW VOICE. QUICKLY THERE WAS NONE IN THE ROOM, SAID FARRY, WHO KEPT TURNING HEAD AT THE THOUGHT OF WHAT WOULD HAVE HAPPENED IF HE HAD NOT BEEN ABLE TO LAY HANDS ON THE LITTLE STONE. FERMINE GAVE AN ALMOST INAUDIBLE SNIFF. SHE HAD BEEN EXCEPTIONALLY QUIET ALL DAY, HAVING FLIRTED, WHITE-FACED, UP THE FARRY OUTSIDE THE HOSPITAL WING AND DEMANDED THE KNOW WHAT HAD HAPPENED, SHE HAD TAKEN ALMOST NO PART IN FARRY AND GINNY'S EXCESSIVE DISCUSSION ABOUT THE RICH HAD BEEN FINISHED, BUT MERELY STOOD BESIDE THEM, CLENCH-JAWED AND FRIGHTENEDLY, UNTIL AT LAST THEY HAD BEEN ALLOWED IN TO SEE HIM. DEE MUM AND DAD KNOW? FRED ASKED GINNY. THEY'VE ALREADY SEEN HIM, THEY ARRIVED AN HOUR AGO. THEY'RE IN DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE NOW, BUT THEY'LL BE BACK SOON. THERE WAS A PAUSE WHILE THEY ALL WATCHED RICH MOVE A LITTLE IN HIS SLEEP. SHE THE PHOENIX

WAS IN THE DRINK? SAID FRED QUIETLY. YES, SAID HARRY AT ONCE. HE
COULD THINK OF NOTHING ELSE AND WAS GLAD FOR THE OPPORTUNITY TO
START DISCUSSING IT AGAIN. SLUGGISHMAN PHURED IT OUT. WOULD HE
HAVE BEEN ABLE TO SLIP SOMETHING INTO RENN'S GLASS WITHOUT HER
SEEING? PROBABLY, SAID HARRY, BUT WHY WOULD SLUGGISHMAN WANT
TO POISON RENN? NO IDEA, SAID FRED, FROWNING. WHY DIDN'T HE THINK
HE COULD HAVE MIXED UP THE GLASSES BY MISTAKE? MEANING THE GET
HER? WHY WOULD SLUGGISHMAN WANT TO POISON HARRY? ASKED
GINNY. I DON'T, SAID FRED, BUT THERE MUST BE REASONS FOR PEOPLE
WHO'D LIKE TO POISON HARRY, MUSTN'T THERE? THE CHIEF OF THE
AND ALL THAT? SHE WHY THINK SLUGGISHMAN'S A DEATH EATER? SAID
GINNY. ANYTHING'S POSSIBLE, SAID FRED DARKLY. HE COULD BE UNDER
THE IMPERIALS CURSE, SAID GEORGE. OR HE COULD BE INNOCENT, SAID
GINNY. THE POISONER COULD HAVE BEEN IN THE KETTLE, IN WHICH CASE IT
WAS PROBABLY MEANT FOR SLUGGISHMAN HIMSELF. WHO'D WANT TO KILL
SLUGGISHMAN? DUMBLEDORE REMAINS VULNERABLE WANTED SLUGGISHMAN ON
HIS SIDE, SAID HARRY. SLUGGISHMAN WAS IN HIDING FOR A YEAR BEFORE
HE CAME TO THE HOGWARTS, AND HE THOUGHT OF THE MURDER
DUMBLEDORE HAD NOT YET BEEN ABLE TO EXTRACT FROM SLUGGISHMAN. AND
MAYBE VULNERABLE WANTS HIM OUT OF THE WAY, MAYBE HE THINKS HE
COULD BE VALUABLE TO DUMBLEDORE. BUT WHY SAID SLUGGISHMAN HAD BEEN
PLANNING TO GIVE THAT KETTLE TO DUMBLEDORE FOR CHRISTMAS, GINNY
REMINDED HIM. SHE THE POISONER COULD JUST AS EASILY HAVE BEEN
AFTER DUMBLEDORE. THEN THE POISONER DIDN'T KNOW SLUGGISHMAN
VERY WELL, SAID HERMION, SPEAKING FOR THE FIRST TIME IN YEARS
AND SOUNDING AS THOUGH SHE HAD A BAD HEADACHE. ANYONE WHO
KNOWS SLUGGISHMAN WOULD HAVE KNOWN THERE WAS A GOOD CHANCE HE'D
KEEP SOMETHING THAT TASTY FOR HIMSELF. CR-MY-NICE, CREAMED RENN
UNEXPECTEDLY FROM BETWEEN THEM. THEY ALL FELL SILENT, WATCHING HIM
ANXIOUSLY, BUT AFTER MUTTERING INCOMPREHENSIBLY FOR A MOMENT HE
MERELY STARTED SNEERING. THE DORMITORY DOORS FLEW OPEN, MAKING
THEM ALL JUMP. LACRIM CAME STRIDING TOWARD THEM, HIS HAIR RAIN-
FLECKED, HIS BEARDSKIN COAT FLAPPING BEHIND HIM, A CRUSHER IN HIS
HAND, LEAVING A TRAIL OF MUDGY DEEPHIN-SIZED FOOTPRINTS ALL OVER
THE FLOOR. KIN IN THE FOREST ALL DAY? HE PANTED. ACHING & WHIRL,
I KIN READING THE HIM DIDN'T GET UP TO DINNER TILL HIS NECK AND
THEN PROFESSOR SPRELLT TOLD ME ABOUT RENN. WHO IS HE? NOT BAD,
SAID HARRY. THEY SAY HE LL BE GOOD. NO MORE THAN SIX VISITORS

AT A TIME? SAID MADAM POMPREE, HURRYING UP HER OFFICE.

HARRY MAKES SIX, GEORGE POINTED OUT. EH YES SAID MADAM POMPREE, WE SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN CHEATING HARRY AS SEVERAL PEOPLE DO THE HIS VASTNESS. THE OTHER HER CHELISHEN, SHE HURRIED OFF THE CLEAR UP HIS BLOODY FOOTPRINTS WITH HER HAND. I DON BELIEVE THIS, SAID HARRY HARSHLY, SHAKING HIS GREAT SHAGGY HEAD AS HE STARED DOWN AT HER. ITS DON BELIEVE IT LOOK AT HIM LYIN THERE. WE D WANT TO HURT HIM, EH? THAT S JUST WHAT WE WERE DISCUSSING, SAID HARRY. WE DON T KNOW. SOMEONE CHILDEN HAVE A GRUDGE AGAINST THE GRYPFINDER HOLIDITCH TEAM, CHILD THEY? SAID HARRY ANIMATEDLY. FIRST KATIE, THEN RON I CAN T SEE ANYONE TRYING TO KIDNAP A HOLIDITCH TEAM, SAID GEORGE. WHO MIGHT WE THINK THE SLYTHERINS IF HE CHILD WE GET AWAY WITH IT, SAID FRED FAIRLY. WELL, I DON T THINK IT S HOLIDITCH, BUT I THINK THERE S A CONNECTION BETWEEN THE ATTACKS, SAID HERMIONE QUIETLY. WHO D YOU HEAR THAT OUT? ASKED FRED. WELL, FOR ONE THING, THEY BOTH HIGHT TO HAVE BEEN FATAL AND WHEN T, ALTHOUGH THAT WAS PURE LUCK. AND FOR ANOTHER, NEITHER THE PRISONER NOR THE NECKLACE SEEMS TO HAVE REACHED THE PRISONER WHO WAS SUPPOSED TO BE KILLED, HE CHIRPED. SHE ADDED KEEPLY, THAT MAKES THE PRISONER BEHIND THIS EVEN MORE DANGEROUS IN A WAY, BECAUSE THEY DON T SEEM TO CARE HOW MANY PEOPLE THEY FINISH OFF BEFORE THEY ACTUALLY REACH THEIR VICTIM. BEFORE ANYBODY CHILD RESPOND TO THIS EMINENT PROMISEMENT, THE DORMITORY DOORS OPENED AGAIN AND MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY HURRIED UP THE WARD. THEY HAD BEEN FOR MORE THAN SATISFY THEMSELVES THAT RON WOULD MAKE A FULL RECOVERY IN THEIR LAST VISIT TO THE WARD; THEN MRS. WEASLEY SEIZED HER HARRY AND HUGGED HIM VERY TIGHTLY. DUMBLEDORE S TOLD US HOW YOU SAVED HIM WITH THE BEZEL, SHE SQUEEZED. EH, HARRY, WHAT CAN WE SAY? YOU SAVED GINNY YOU SAVED ARTHUR THEN YOU VE SAVED RON DON T BE I DIDN T MUTTERED HARRY ANIMATEDLY. HALF HOUR FAMILY DOES SEEM TO HAVE YOU THEIR LIVES, THEN I STOP AND THINK ABOUT IT, MR. WEASLEY SAID IN A CONSTRICTED VOICE. WELL, ALL I CAN SAY IS THAT IT WAS A LUCKY DAY FOR THE WEASLEYS WHEN RON DECIDED TO SIT IN YOUR COMPARTMENT ON THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS, HARRY. HARRY CHILD NOT THINK OF ANY REPLY TO THIS AND WAS ALMOST GLAD WHEN MADAM POMPREE REMINDED THEM THAT THERE WERE ONLY SUPPOSED TO BE SIX VISITORS AROUND RON S

RED, HE AND HERMIONE RISE AT ONCE TO LEAVE AND JACOB DECIDED TO
GO WITH THEM, LEAVING RON WITH HIS FAMILY. IT'S TERRIBLE, GRIEVED
JACOB INTO HIS BEARD, AS THE THREE OF THEM WALKED BACK ALONG THE
CORRIDOR THE MARBLE STAIRCASE. ALL THIS NEW SECURITY, AND KIDS
ARE STILL GETTING HURT. DUMBLEDORE'S BEHIND HIM. HE'D BEEN SAY
MUCH, BUT I CAN TELL. HADN'T HE GOT ANY IDEAS, JACOB? ASKED
HERMIONE DESPERATELY. I SWEAR HE'S GOT HUNDREDS OF IDEAS, KRAVIN
LIKE HIS, SAID JACOB. BUT HE DOESN'T KNOW WHEN TO STOP THAT NEEDLE
NEED NOT POISON IN THAT WINE, HEY THEY'D BE IN CALIGIT, WOULD
THEY? WHAT WORRIES ME, SAID JACOB, LOWERING HIS VOICE AND
GLANCING OVER HIS SHOULDER (HARRY, HER CHILD MEASURE, CHECKED THE
CEILING FOR PEEVES), IS HOW LONG HOGWARTS CAN STAY OPEN IF KIDS
ARE BEING ATTACKED. CHAMBER OF SECRETS ALL OVER AGAIN, ISN'T IT?
THERE'LL BE PANIC, MORE PARENTS TAKING THEIR KIDS OUTTA SCHOOL,
AND NEW THING YOU KNOW THE BOARD OF GOVERNORS JACOB
STOPPED TALKING AS THE GHOST OF A LONG-HAired WOMAN DRIFTED
SERENELY PAST, THEN RESUMED IN A HARSH WHISPER. THE BOARD OF
GOVERNORS'LL BE TALKIN' ABOUT SHUTTING US UP FOR GOOD. SURELY
NOT? SAID HERMIONE, WHISKING HERSELF. GOTTA SEE IT FROM THEIR
POINT OF VIEW, SAID JACOB HEAVILY. I MEAN, IT'S ALWAYS BEEN A BIT
OF A RISK SENDIN' A KID TER HOGWARTS, HADN'T IT? YOU EXPECT
ACCIDENTS, THEN YES, WITH HUNDREDS OF UNDERAGE WIZARDS ALL MIXED
UP TOGETHER, BUT ATTEMPTED MURDER, THAT'S DIFFERENT. I'VE NEVER
DUMBLEDORE'S ANGRY WITH SN. JACOB STEPPED IN HIS TRACKS, A
FAMILIAR, GUILTY EXPRESSION ON HIS FACE WAS VISIBLE OF HIS FACE ABOVE
HIS TANGLED BLACK BEARD. WHAT? SAID HARRY QUIETLY. DUMBLEDORE'S
ANGRY WITH SNARE? I NEVER SAID THAT, SAID JACOB, THOUGH HIS
LOOK OF PANIC COULD NOT HAVE BEEN A BIGGER GIVEAWAY. WHEN AT
THE TIME, IT'S GETTING ON FOR MIDNIGHT, I NEED TER JACOB, WHO
IS DUMBLEDORE ANGRY WITH SNARE? HARRY ASKED LOUDLY. STOP IT!
SAID JACOB, WHISKING BOTH NERVILS AND ANGRY. BEEN FEELING STUPID
LIKE THAT, HARRY, DO YOU WANT ME TO LOSE MY MIND, I'D BE
SLIPPERY YOU'D CARE, WOULD YOU, NOT NEARLY YOU'D GIVEN UP CARE OF
MAG. BEEN TRY AND MAKE ME FEEL GUILTY, IT WON'T WORK! SAID
HARRY PERCEPALLY. WHAT'S SNARE DOING? I DON'T KNOW, HARRY, I
SEEMED TO HEAR IT AT ALL! I WELL, I WAS CERTAIN OUTTA THE FINEST
THE EITHER EVENING AND I OVERHEARD EM TALKING WELL, ARGUING.
DIDN'T LIKE TO DRAW ATTENTION TO MYSELF, SEE I SHUT A SILENCE AND

TRIED NOT TO LISTEN, BUT IT WAS A WELL, A HEATED DISCUSSION AND IT WASN'T EASY TO BLIND IT OUT. WELL? HARRY LOOKED HIM, AS Hagrid shuffled his enormous feet uneasily. WELL I HAD HEARD SNAPE SAYIN' DUMBLEDORE THOUGHT THE MIGHT BE GRANTED AND MAYBE HE SNAPE DIDN'T WANT TO DO IT ANYMORE. DID WHAT? I DUNNO, HARRY, IT SEEMED LIKE SNAPE WAS FEELIN' A BIT EVERYWHERE, THAT'S ALL. ANYWAY, DUMBLEDORE TOLD HIM FLAT OUT HE'D AGREED TO DO IT AND THAT WAS ALL THERE WAS TO IT, PRETTY FIRM WITH HIM. AND THEN HE SAID SOMETHAT ABOUT SNAPE MAKIN' INVESTIGATIONS IN HIS HOUSE IN SLOTHFURN. WELL, THERE'S SOMETHIN' STRANGE ABOUT THAT? Hagrid added hastily, AS HARRY AND HERMION EXCHANGED LOOKS FULL OF MEANING. ALL THE HEADS OF HOUSES WERE ASKED TO MEET INTER THAT NIGHTLY BUSINESS. Yeah, BUT DUMBLEDORE'S NOT HAVIN' MEETS WITH THE REST OF THEM, IS HE? SAID HARRY. LOOK, Hagrid TWISTED HIS CRISPER UNCOMFORTABLY IN HIS HANDS; THERE WAS A LOUD SPLINTERING SOUND AND IT SNAPPED IN TWO. I DUNNO WHAT YOU'RE LIKE ABOUT SNAPE, HARRY, AND I DON'T WANT YOU TO BE READIN' MORE INTO THIS THAN THERE IS. LOOK OUT, SAID HERMION TERSELY. THEY TURNED INSTANTLY IN TIME TO SEE THE SHADE OF AUGUSTUS FILCH WHIMPERING OVER THE WALL BEHIND THEM BEFORE THE MAN HIMSELF TURNED THE CORNER, HUNCH-BACKED, HIS HEADS ABLIVER. HEH? HE WHIZZED. BUT HE'ED BE LATE, THIS LL MEAN DETENTION? NOT IT WHEN, FILCH, SAID Hagrid SHORTLY. THEY'RE WITH ME, AREN'T THEY? AND WHAT DIFFERENCE DOES THAT MAKE? ASKED FILCH HENDELY. I'M A RUDY TEACHER, AREN'T I, YOU SNEAKIN' SNEAK? SAID Hagrid, FIRING UP AT ONCE. THERE WAS A NASTY HISSING NOISE AS FILCH SQUELLED WITH FLURY; MRS. NORRIS HAD ARRIVED, LINGERED, AND WAS TWISTING HERSELF SINCELYLY AROUND FILCH'S SKINNY ANKLES. GET GOIN', SAID Hagrid OUT OF THE CORNER OF HIS MOUTH. HARRY DID NOT NEED TELLING TWICE; HE AND HERMION BOTH FLURRIED OFF; Hagrid'S AND FILCH'S RAISED VOICES ECHOED BEHIND THEM AS THEY RAN. THEY PASSED PEEVES NEAR THE TURNING INTO GRYFFINDOR TOWER, BUT HE WAS STREACHING HAPPILY TOWARD THE SOURCE OF THE YELLING, CACKLING AND CALLING. WHEN THERE'S STRIFE AND WHEN THERE'S TROUBLE CALL EN PEEVIE, HE LL MAKE DEBIL? THE FAT LADY WAS SNEEZING AND NOT PLEASED TO BE WOKEN, BUT SWINGING FORWARD GRIMPLY TO ALLOW THEM TO CLAMBER INTO THE MERCIFULLY PEACEFUL AND EMPTY CHAMBER ROOM. IT DID NOT SEEM THAT PEOPLE KNEW ABOUT BEEN YET; HARRY WAS VERY RELIEVED; HE HAD

BEEN INTERROGATED ENOUGH THAT DAY, HERMIONE MADE HIM GOOD NIGHT AND SET OFF FOR THE GIRLS DORMITORY, HARRY, HOWEVER, REMAINED BEHIND, TAKING A SEAT BESIDE THE FIRE AND LEANING DOWN INTO THE DYING EMBERS. THE DUMBLEDORE HAD ARGUED WITH SNAPE. IN SPITE OF ALL HE HAD TOLD HARRY, IN SPITE OF HIS INSISTENCE THAT HE TRUSTED SNAPE COMPLETELY, HE HAD LOST HIS TEMPER WITH HIM. HE DID NOT THINK THAT SNAPE HAD TRIED HARD ENOUGH TO INVESTIGATE THE SLYTHERINS OR, PERHAPS, TO INVESTIGATE A SINGLE SLYTHERIN: MALFOY? WAS IT BECAUSE DUMBLEDORE DID NOT WANT HARRY TO DO ANYTHING FOOLISH, TO TAKE MATTERS INTO HIS OWN HANDS, THAT HE HAD PRETENDED THERE WAS NOTHING IN HARRY'S SUSPICIONS? THAT SEEMED LIKELY. IT MIGHT EVEN BE THAT DUMBLEDORE DID NOT WANT ANYTHING TO DISTRACT HARRY FROM THEIR LESSONS, OR FROM PREPARING THAT MEMOIR FROM SLUGGISHORN. PERHAPS DUMBLEDORE DID NOT THINK IT RIGHT TO CONSIDER SUSPICIONS ABOUT HIS STAFF THE SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLDS. THERE THEY ARE, POUTER! HARRY LIFTED THE HIS FEET IN SHOCK, HIS WAND AT THE READY. HE HAD BEEN BLINDLY CONVINCED THAT THE CHAMBER ROOM WAS EMPTY; HE HAD NOT BEEN AT ALL PREPARED FOR A FLOODING FIGURE THE RISE SUDDENLY HILT UP A DISTANT CHAIR. A GLEAMER BEHIND SEEMED HIM THAT IT WAS HERMION MCLAUGEN.

I'VE BEEN WAITING FOR YOU TO COME BACK, SAID MCLAUGEN, DISREGARDING HARRY'S DRAINING WAND. MUST'VE FALLEN ASLEEP, DIDN'T I? SAW THEM TAKING LEASLEY UP THE THE HOSPITAL WING EARLIER, DIDN'T I? LIKE HE'LL BE FIT FOR NEXT WEEK'S MATCH. IT TOOK HARRY A FEW MOMENTS TO REALIZE WHAT MCLAUGEN WAS TALKING ABOUT. HE WAS RIGHT. SLUGGISHORN, HE SAID, PUTTING HIS WAND BACK INTO THE BELT OF HIS IRONS AND RUNNING A HAND WEARILY THROUGH HIS HAIR. YEAH,

HE MIGHT NOT MAKE IT. WELL, THEN, I'LL BE PLAYING KEEPER, WHEN T'IS SAID MCLAUGEN. YEAH, SAID HARRY. YEAH, I SUPPOSE SEE.

HE COULD NOT THINK OF AN ARGUMENT AGAINST IT; AFTER ALL, MCLAUGEN HAD CERTAINLY PERFORMED SECOND-BEST IN THE TRIALS.

EXCELLENT, SAID MCLAUGEN IN A SATISFIED VEIL. SEE WHEN'S PRACTICE? WHAT? HE THERE'S HERE TOMORROW EVENING. GOOD, LISTEN, POUTER, WE SHOULD HAVE A TALK BEFOREHAND, I'VE GOT SOME IDEAS AND STRATEGIES YOU MIGHT FIND USEFUL. RIGHT, SAID HARRY UNENTHUSIASTICALLY. WELL, I'LL HEAR THEM TOMORROW, THEN, I'M PRETTY TIRED NOW. SEE YOU. THE NEWS THAT RON HAD BEEN DISMISSED SPREAD QUICKLY NEXT DAY, BUT IT DID NOT CAUSE THE

SENSATION THAT KATIE'S ATTACK HAD BEEN. PEOPLE SEEMED TO THINK THAT IT MIGHT HAVE BEEN AN ACCIDENT, GIVEN THAT HE HAD BEEN IN THE PRINCE'S MASTER'S ROOM AT THE TIME, AND THAT AS HE HAD BEEN GIVEN AN ANTIDOTE IMMEDIATELY THERE WAS NO REAL HARM DONE. IN FACT, THE GRAYFINDERS WERE GENERALLY MUCH MORE INTERESTED IN THE UPCOMING HOLIDITCH MATCH AGAINST FLAPPLIFF, AND MANY OF THEM WANTED TO SEE ZACHARIAS SMITH, WHO PLAYED CHASER FOR THE FLAPPLIFF TEAM, FINISHED SHABLY FOR HIS COMMENTARY DURING THE OPENING MATCH AGAINST SLYTHERIN. HARRY, HOWEVER, HAD NEVER BEEN LESS INTERESTED IN HOLIDITCH; HE WAS RAPIDLY BECOMING OBSESSED WITH DRACH MALFOY, STILL CHECKING THE MARAUDER'S MAP WHATEVER HE GOT A CHANCE, HE SOMETIMES MADE DETOURS TO WHEREVER MALFOY HAPPENED TO BE, BUT HAD NOT YET DETECTED HIM DOING ANYTHING BUT THE ORDINARY, AND STILL THERE WERE THESE INEXPLICABLE TIMES WHEN MALFOY SIMPLY VANISHED FROM THE MAP. BUT HARRY DID NOT GET A LOT OF TIME TO CONSIDER THE PROBLEM, WHAT WITH HOLIDITCH PRACTICE, HIMSELF, AND THE FACT THAT HE WAS NOW BEING DUGGED WHEREVER HE WENT BY HERMION MCGONAGALL AND LAVENDER BROWN. HE COULD NOT DECIDE WHICH OF THEM WAS MORE ANNOYING. MCGONAGALL KEPT UP A CONSTANT STREAM OF HINTS THAT HE WOULD MAKE A BETTER PERMANENT KEEPER FOR THE TEAM THAN RON, AND THAT NOW THAT HARRY WAS SEEING HIM PLAY REGULARLY HE WOULD SOONLY COME AROUND THE THIS WAY OF THINKING. HE WAS ALSO BEEN TO CRITICIZE THE OTHER PLAYERS AND PROVIDE HARRY WITH DETAILED TRAINING SCHEMES, SO THAT MORE THAN ONCE HARRY WAS FORCED TO REMIND HIM WHO WAS CAPTAIN. MEANWHILE, LAVENDER KEPT SIDLING UP TO HARRY TO DISCUSS RON, WHICH HARRY FELT ALMOST MORE WEARING THAN MCGONAGALL'S HOLIDITCH LECTURES. AT FIRST, LAVENDER HAD BEEN VERY ANNOYED THAT NEKKO HAD THOUGHT TO TELL HER THAT RON WAS IN THE HOSPITAL. "I MEAN, I AM HIS GIRLFRIEND!" BUT UNFORTUNATELY SHE HAD NOW DECIDED TO PERGIVE HARRY THIS LAPSE OF MEMORY AND WAS BEEN TO HAVE LOTS OF IN-DEPTH CHATS WITH HIM ABOUT RON'S FEELINGS, A MOST UNCOMFORTABLE EXPERIENCE THAT HARRY WOULD HAVE HAPPILY PERGONE. THEN, WHY DOESN'T SHE TALK TO RON ABOUT ALL THIS? HARRY ASKED, AFTER A PARTICULARLY LONG INTERROGATION FROM LAVENDER THAT THREW IN EVERYTHING FROM PRECISELY WHAT RON HAD SAID ABOUT HER NEW DRESS REELS TO WHETHER OR NOT HARRY THOUGHT THAT RON CONSIDERED HIS RELATIONSHIP WITH LAVENDER TO BE

SERIOUSLY. WELL, I WOULD, BUT HE'S ALWAYS ASLEEP WHEN I GO AND SEE HIM! SAID LAVENDER FRETFULLY. IS HE? SAID FARRY, SURPRISED, FOR HE HAD FEELING BEEN PERFECTLY ALERT EVERY TIME HE HAD BEEN UP THE THE HOSPITAL WING, KEITH HIGHLY INTERESTED IN THE NEWS OF DUMKLEDHRE AND SNARE'S REEL AND BEEN THE ABUSE MCLAGGEN AS MUCH AS POSSIBLE.

IS FERMINE GRANGER STILL VISITING HIM? LAVENDER DEMANDED SUDDENLY. YEAH, I THINK SHE. WELL, THEY'RE FRIENDS, AREN'T THEY? SAID FARRY UNCOMFORTABLY. FRIENDS, DOESN'T MAKE ME LAUGH, SAID LAVENDER SCORNFULLY. SHE DIDN'T TALK TO HIM FOR WEEKS AFTER HE STARTED GOING OUT WITH ME! BUT I SUPPOSE SHE WANTS TO MAKE UP WITH HIM NOW HE'S ALL INTERESTING. WOULD YOU CALL GETTING PUNISHED BEING INTERESTING? ASKED FARRY. ANYWAY SHERRY, GET THE GO THERE'S MCLAGGEN COMING FOR A TALK ABOUT ELIDITCH, SAID FARRY FLURRIEDLY, AND HE DASHED SIDELWAYS THROUGH A DOOR PRETENDING TO BE ASLEEP AND SPRINTED DOWN THE STAIRCASE THAT WOULD TAKE HIM OFF THE PREMISES WHERE, THANKFULLY, NEITHER LAVENDER NOR MCLAGGEN COULD FOLLOW HIM. IN THE MORNING OF THE ELIDITCH MATCH AGAINST HUNTERFLOPP, FARRY DROPPED IN ON THE HOSPITAL WING BEFORE HEADING DOWN THE THE PITCH. REN WAS VERY AGITATED; MADAM PIERRE WOULD NOT LET HIM GO DOWN TO WATCH THE MATCH, FEELING IT WOULD OVEREXCITE HIM. SHE HAD MCLAGGEN SHAPING UP? HE ASKED FARRY NERVOUSLY, APPARENTLY FORGETTING THAT HE HAD ALREADY ASKED THE SAME QUESTION TWICE. I'VE TOLD YOU, SAID FARRY PATIENTLY. HE COULD BE WORLD-CLASS AND I WOULDN'T WANT TO KEEP HIM. HE KEEPS TRYING TO TELL EVERYONE WHAT TO DO, HE THINKS HE COULD PLAY EVERY POSITION BETTER THAN THE REST OF US. I CAN'T WAIT TO BE SEEN BY HIM. AND SPEAKING OF GETTING SEEN BY PEOPLE, FARRY ADDED, GETTING TO HIS FEET AND PICKING UP HIS FIREARM, WILL YOU STOP PRETENDING TO BE ASLEEP WHEN LAVENDER COMES TO SEE YOU? SHE'S DRIVING ME MAD AS WELL. EH, SAID REN, BLENDING SHEEPISHLY. YEAH, ALL RIGHT. IF YOU DON'T WANT TO GO OUT WITH HER ANYMORE, JUST TELL HER, SAID FARRY. YEAH, WELL, IT'S NOT THAT EASY, IS IT? SAID REN, FURTHER. FERMINE GOING TO BE IN BEFORE THE MATCH? HE ADDED CASUALLY. NO, SHE'S ALREADY GONE DOWN THE THE PITCH WITH GINNY. EH, SAID REN, BLENDING RATHER GLOOMY. RIGHT, WELL, GOOD LUCK. HOPE YOU HAMPER MCLAG I MEAN, SMITH. I'LL TRY, SAID FARRY, STRENGTHENING HIS KNEES. SEE YOU AFTER THE MATCH. HE HURRIED DOWN THROUGH THE DESERTED

CHORRIDERS; THE WHITE SCHEME WAS ELITESIDE, EITHER ALREADY SEATED IN THE STADIUM HER HEADING DOWN TOWARD IT, HE WAS WINKING OUT OF THE WINDMILLS HE PASSED, TRYING THE CALIGER FEEL MUCH WIND THEY WERE FACING, WHEN A NOISE AHEAD MADE HIM GLANCE UP AND HE SAW MALTHEY WALKING TOWARD HIM, ACCOMPANIED BY TWO GIRLS, BOTH OF WHOM WINKED SLICKY AND RESENTFUL. MALTHEY STOPPED SHORT AT THE SIGHT OF HARRY, THEN GAVE A SHORT, HUMORLESS LAUGH AND CONTINUED WALKING. WHERE ARE YOU GOING? HARRY DEMANDED. Yeah, I'm REALLY GOING TO TELL YOU, BECAUSE IT'S YOUR BUSINESS, BETTER, SNEERED MALTHEY. YOU'D BETTER HURRY UP, THEY'LL BE WAITING FOR THE CHIEF CAPTAIN THE RED WHITE SCHEME WHATEVER THEY CALL YOU THESE DAYS. HEAR OF THE GIRLS GAVE AN UNWILLING GIGGLE. HARRY STARED AT HER. SHE BLINKED. MALTHEY PUSHED PAST HARRY AND SHE AND HER FRIEND REHEATED AT A TREK, TURNING THE CORNER AND VANISHING FROM VIEW. HARRY STOOD REHITED IN THE SPOT AND WATCHED THEM DISAPPEAR. THIS WAS INSULTING; HE WAS ALREADY CUTTING IT FINE TO GET TO THE MATCH ON TIME AND YET THERE WAS MALTHEY, SKULKING OFF WHILE THE REST OF THE SCHEME WAS ABSENT! HARRY'S BEST CHANCE YET OF DISCOVERING WHAT MALTHEY WAS UP TO. THE SILENT SECONDS TRICKLED PAST, AND HARRY REMAINED WHERE HE WAS, FROZEN, GAZING AT THE PLACE WHERE MALTHEY HAD VANISHED. WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN? DEMANDED GINNY, AS HARRY SPRINTED INTO THE CHANGING ROOMS. THE WHITE TEAM WAS CHANGED AND READY; CHEATE AND PEAKES, THE BEATERS, WERE BOTH HITTING THEIR CLUBS NERVOUSLY AGAINST THEIR LEGS. I MET MALTHEY, HARRY TOLD HER BRIEFLY, AS HE PULLED HIS SCARLET RECKS OVER HIS HEAD. See? See I WANTED TO KNOW HOW COME HE'S UP AT THE CASTLE WITH A CUPLE OF GIRLFRIENDS WHILE EVERYONE ELSE IS DOWN HERE. DOES IT MATTER RIGHT NOW? Well, I'M NOT LIKELY TO FIND OUT, AM I? SAID HARRY, SEIZING HIS FIREHOLT AND PUSHING HIS GLASSES STRAIGHT. COME ON THEN! AND WITHOUT ANOTHER WORD, HE MARCHED OUT INTO THE PITCH THE DRAPEING CHEERS AND REHS. THERE WAS LITTLE WIND; THE CLOUDS WERE PATCHY; EVERY NOW AND THEN THERE WERE DAZZLING FLASHES OF BRIGHT SUNLIGHT. TRICKY CONDITIONS! MCKAGGEN SAID BRACINGLY TO THE TEAM. CHEATE, PEAKES, YOU'LL WANT TO FLY OUT OF THE SUN, SEE THEY DON'T SEE YOU COMING. I'M THE CAPTAIN, MCKAGGEN, SHUT UP GIVING THEM INSTRUCTIONS, SAID HARRY ANGERILY. JUST GET UP BY THE GOAL POSTS! HEAR MCKAGGEN HAD MARCHED OFF, HARRY TURNED TO CHEATE AND PEAKES. MAKE SURE

YELL HE FLY HEAT OF THE SUN. HE THREW THEM GRUDGINGLY. HE STRETCHED
 HANDS WITH THE FLUFFLEPUFF CAPTAIN, AND THEN, HEN MADAM FLETCHER'S
 WHISTLE, DROCKED OFF AND ROSE INTO THE AIR, HIGHER THAN THE REST OF
 HIS TEAM, STREAKING AROUND THE PITCH IN SEARCH OF THE SNITCH. IF
 HE COULD CATCH IT CHEER AND EARLY, THERE MIGHT BE A CHANCE HE COULD
 GET BACK UP THE THE CASTLE, SEIZE THE MARAUDER'S MAP, AND FIND OUT
 WHAT MALFOY WAS DOING. AND THAT'S SMITH OF FLUFFLEPUFF WITH
 THE FLUFFLE. SAID A DREAMY VOICE, ECHOING OVER THE GRUHLINGS. HE
 DID THE COMMENTARY LAST TIME, HE CHELSE, AND GINNY WEASLEY FLEW
 INTO HIM, I THINK PROBABLY HEN PURPOSE, IT LOOKED LIKE IT. SMITH
 WAS BEING WHITE RED ABOUT GRYFFINDOR, I EXPECT HE REGRETS THAT
 WHEN HE'S PLAYING THEM. HE, LOOK, HE'S LOST THE FLUFFLE, GINNY
 THREW IT FROM HIM, I DO LIKE HER, SHE'S VERY NICE. HARRY STARED
 DOWN AT THE COMMENTATOR'S PODIUM. SURELY NEEDED IN THEIR RIGHT
 MIND WOULD HAVE LET LUNA LEEVE COMMENTATE? BUT EVEN FROM
 ABOVE THERE WAS NO MISTAKING THAT LONG, DIRTY-BLOND HAIR, NEAR
 THE NECKLACE OF KLITTERKEER CHOKS. BESIDE LUNA, PROFESSOR
 MCGONAGALL WAS LOOKING SLIGHTLY UNCOMFORTABLE, AS THOUGH SHE
 WAS INDEED HAVING SECOND THOUGHTS ABOUT THIS APPOINTMENT.
 BUT WHEN THAT BIG FLUFFLEPUFF PLAYER'S GOT THE FLUFFLE FROM HER, I
 CAN'T REMEMBER HIS NAME, IT'S SOMETHING LIKE KIKKE. NEH, KLIGGINS
 IT'S CADWALLADER! SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL LUDLY FROM
 BESIDE LUNA. THE CROWD LAUGHED. HARRY STARED AROUND FOR THE
 SNITCH; THERE WAS NO SIGN OF IT. MOMENTS LATER, CADWALLADER SCREAMED.
 MCLAGGEN HAD BEEN SHELTING CRITICISM AT GINNY FOR ALLOWING THE
 FLUFFLE HEAT OF HER POSSESSION, WITH THE RESULT THAT HE HAD NOT
 NOTICED THE LARGE RED BALL SEARING PAST HIS RIGHT EAR. MCLAGGEN,
 WILL YOU PAY ATTENTION TO WHAT YOU'RE SLIPPERED TO BE DOING AND
 LEAVE EVERYONE ELSE ALONE? BELLEWD HARRY, WHEELING AROUND THE
 FACE HIS KEEPER. YOU'RE NOT SETTING A GREAT EXAMPLE! MCLAGGEN
 SHELTED BACK, RED-FACED AND FLURIELS. AND HARRY BETTER'S BEEN
 HAVING AN ARGUMENT WITH HIS KEEPER, SAID LUNA SERENELY, WHILE
 BOTH FLUFFLEPUFFS AND SLYTHERINS KEEN IN THE CROWD CHEERED AND
 IERED. I DON'T THINK THAT LL HELP HIM FIND THE SNITCH, BUT MAYBE
 IT'S A CLEVER RUSE. SWEARING ANGERILY, HARRY SPUN AROUND AND
 SET OFF AROUND THE PITCH AGAIN, SCANNING THE SKIES FOR SOME SIGN
 OF THE TINY, WINGED GOLDEN BALL. GINNY AND DEMELZA SCREAMED A CHEAL
 APIKE, GIVING THE RED-AND-GOLD-CLAD SLIPPERERS KEEN SOMETHING

THE WHIRRY ARHWT, THEN CADWALLADER SCHEED AGAIN, MAKING THINGS
LEVEL, BUT LLINA DID NOT SEEM TO HAVE NOTICED; SHE APPEARED
SINGULARLY UNINTERESTED IN SUCH MUNDANE THINGS AS THE SCHEE, AND
KEPT ATTEMPTING TO DRAW THE CREED'S ATTENTION TO SUCH THINGS AS
INTERESTINGLY SHAPED CLOTHS AND THE POSSIBILITY THAT ZACHARIAS
SMITH, WHO HAD SHE FAR FAILED TO MAINTAIN POSSESSION OF THE
FLJAFLE FOR LONGER THAN A MINUTE, WAS SLIPPING FROM SOMETHING
CALLED BUSTER & BUREY. SEVENTY-TWO THE FLJAFLEDUFF? BARRED
PROFESSOR MCGHINAGALL INTO LLINA'S MEGAPHONE. IS IT, ALREADY?
SAID LLINA VAGUELY. EH, HEED? THE GRYFFINDOR KEEPER'S GET FELD
OF HINE OF THE BEATER'S KATS. HARRY SPUN ARHWD IN MIDAIR, SLUR
ENHUGH, MCLAGGEN, HER REASONS BEST KNOWN TO HIMSELF, HAD PULLED
PEAKES & BAT FROM HIM AND APPEARED TO BE DEMONSTRATING HOW TO
HIT A BLUDGEON TOWARD AN ENCHURING CADWALLADER. WILL YELL GIVE HIM
BACK HIS BAT AND GET BACK TO THE CHAL PHIST? REARED HARRY,
PELTING TOWARD MCLAGGEN JUST AS MCLAGGEN THREW A FEROCIOUS
SWIPE AT THE BLUDGEON AND MIS-HIT IT, A BLINDING, SICKENING PAIN
A FLASH OF LIGHT DISTANT SCREAMS AND THE SENSATION OF FALLING
DOWN A LONG TUNNEL AND THE NEXT THING HARRY KNEW, HE WAS
LYING IN A REMARKABLY WARM AND COMFORTABLE BED AND WHISKING UP AT
A LAMP THAT WAS THERMING A CIRCLE OF GILDEN LIGHT BENEATH A SHADHLY
CEILING. HE RAISED HIS HEAD ALKWARDLY, THERE HIN HIS LEFT WAS A
FAMILIAR-LOOKING, FREELY, RED-HAIRED PERSON. NICE HE YELL TO DRIPP
IN, SAID BEN, GRINNING, HARRY BLINKED AND WHISKED ARHWD, HE
CHURSE! HE WAS IN THE HOSPITAL WING, THE SKY OUTSIDE WAS INDIGO
STREAKED WITH CRIMSON, THE MATCH MUST HAVE FINISHED FEELRS AGO

AS HAD ANY FEEL OF CHURNING MALTHEY, HARRY'S HEAD FELT
STRANGELY HEAVY; HE RAISED A HAND AND FELT A STIFF TUBERAN OF
BANDAGES. WHAT HAPPENED? CRACKED SKULL, SAID MADAM PEMFREY,
BLISTLING UP AND PUSHING HIM BACK AGAINST HIS PILLELS. NOTHING
THE WHIRRY ARHWT, I MENDED IT AT HINE, BUT I'M KEEPING YELL IN
EVERNIGHT. YELL SHULDON'T EVEREXERT YELLSELF FOR A FEW FEELRS. I
DIDN'T WANT TO STAY HERE EVERNIGHT, SAID HARRY ANGERILY, SITTING
UP AND THERMING BACK HIS CHEYERS. I WANT TO FIND MCLAGGEN AND
KILL HIM. I'M AFRAID THAT WOULD COME UNDER THE HEADING OF
EVEREXERTITION, SAID MADAM PEMFREY, PUSHING HIM FIRMLY BACK
BENEATH THE BED AND RAISING HER HAND IN A THREATENING MANNER. YELL
WILL STAY HERE UNTIL I DISCHARGE YELL, BETTER, FOR I SHALL CALL THE

HEADMASTER. SHE KLITLED BACK INTO HER OFFICE, AND HARRY SAND BACK INTO HIS PILLOWS, FLYING. O WELL DUNNELL FEEL MUCH WE LOST BY? HE ASKED RHN THROUGH CLINCHED TEETH. WELL, YEAH I DE, SAID RHN APPEHGETICALLY. FINAL SCORE WAS THREE HUNDRED AND TWENTY THE SIXTY. BRILLIANT, SAID HARRY SAVAGELY. REALLY BRILLIANT! WHEN I GET FEELD OF MCLAGGEN. YELL DUNN T WANT TH GET FEELD OF HIM, HE S THE SIZE OF A TRILL, SAID RHN REASHENABLY. PERSONALLY, I THINK THERE S A LIT TH EE SAID AER HEXING HIM WITH THAT THENAIL THING OF THE PRINCE S. ANDWAY, THE REST OF THE TEAM MIGHT VE DEALT WITH HIM BEFORE YELL GET FELT OF HERE, THEY RE NEET HAPPY. THERE WAS A NITE OF BADLY SUPPRESSED GLER IN RHN S VEHICLE; HARRY CHULD TELL HE WAS NEETHING SHERT OF THRILLED THAT MCLAGGEN HAD MESSED UP SEE BADLY. HARRY LAY THERE, STARING UP AT THE PATCH OF LIGHT IN THE CEILING, HIS RECENTLY MENDED SKULL NEET FLIRTING, PRECISELY, BUT FEELING SLIGHTLY TENDER LINDERNEATH ALL THE BANDAGING. I CHULD HEAR THE MATCH COMMENTARY FROM HERE, SAID RHN, HIS VEHICLE NEEL SHAKING WITH LAUGHTER. I HEPPE BLINA ALWAYS COMMENTATES FROM NEEL IN. LESSER S BLINCY. BUT HARRY WAS STILL THEE ANGRY TH SEE MUCH FLUMMER IN THE SITLIATION, AND AFTER A WHILE RHN S SNEETS SLKSIDED. GINNY CAME IN TH VISIT WHILE YELL WERE LINCENSKILLIS, HE SAID, AFTER A LONG PALISE, AND HARRY S IMAGINATION ZEEHED INTO EVERDRIVE, RAPIDLY CHNSTRUCTING A SCENE IN WHICH GINNY, WEEPING EVER HIS LIFELESS AIRM, CHNPESSED HER FEELINGS OF DEEP ATTRACTIEN TH HIM WHILE RHN GAVE THEM HIS BLESSING. SHE RECKENS YELL HNDLY ILST ARRIVED HN TIME AER THE MATCH. FEEL CHME? YELL LEFT HERE EARLY ENOUGH. EH. SAID HARRY, AS THE SCENE IN HIS MIND S EYE IMPLDED. YEAH. WELL, I SAW MALFEDY SNEADING OFF WITH A CHLIPLE OF GIRLS WEED DIDN T LINDX LIKE THEY WANTED TH EE WITH HIM, AND THAT S THE SECOND TIME HE S MADE SLIRE HE ISN T DEHN HN THE FLIDDITCH PITCH WITH THE REST OF THE SCHEEN; HE SKIPPED THE LAST MATCH THEE, REMEMBER? HARRY SIGHED. WISH I D FEELLED HIM NEEL, THE MATCH WAS SLICH A FIASCH. DUNN T EE STUPID, SAID RHN SHARPLY. YELL CHULDN T HAVE MISSED A FLIDDITCH MATCH ILST TH FEELLED MALFEDY, YELL RE THE CAPTAIN! I WANT TH DUNNELL WHAT HE S UP TH, SAID HARRY. AND DUNN T TELL ME IT S ALL IN MY HEAD, NEET AFTER WHAT I EVERHEARD BETWEEN HIM AND SNAPE. I NEVER SAID IT WAS ALL IN YELLR HEAD, SAID RHN, FEELTING HIMSELF UP HN AN EKEEL IN TURN AND FREELNING AT HARRY, BUT THERE S NEE BLIKE SAYING HNDLY

ONE PERSON AT A TIME CAN BE PLANTING ANYTHING IN THIS PLACE?
YOU'RE GETTING A BIT OBSESSED WITH MALPHY, HARRY, I MEAN,
THINKING ABOUT MISSING A MATCH LIST THE MOTHER HIM I WANT THE
CATCH HIM AT IT? SAID HARRY IN FRUSTRATION, I MEAN, WHERE'S HE
GOING WHEN HE DISAPPEARS OFF THE MAP? I DON'T KNOW HESITANTLY
SUGGESTED BEN, PAUNING, I'VE NEVER SEEN HIM GOING AWAY AND HE
THE SECRET PASSAGeways IN THE MAP, I THOUGHT THEY WERE BEING
WATCHED NEARLY ANYWAY? WELL THEN, I DON'T, SAID BEN, SILENCE FELL
BETWEEN THEM, HARRY STARED UP AT THE CIRCLE OF LAMPLIGHT ABOVE
HIM, THINKING. IF ONLY HE HAD POLICE STATIONER'S POWER, HE
WOULD HAVE BEEN ABLE TO SET A TAIL UPON MALPHY, BUT UNFORTUNATELY
HARRY DID NOT HAVE AN OFFICE FULL OF ALIBIS AT HIS COMMAND,
HE THOUGHT FRETFULLY OF TRYING TO SET SOMETHING UP WITH THE
D.A., BUT THERE AGAIN WAS THE PROBLEM THAT PEOPLE WOULD BE MISSED
FROM LESSONS; MUST HE THEM, AFTER ALL, STILL HAD FULL SCHEDULES,
THERE WAS A WHIR, RUMBLING SOUND FROM BEN'S BED, AFTER A WHILE
MADAM DEMMEYER CAME OUT OF HER OFFICE, THIS TIME WEARING A THICK
DRESSING GOWN, IT WAS EASIEST TO FEIGN SLEEP; HARRY ROLLED OVER
TOWARD HIS SIDE AND LISTENED TO ALL THE CURTAINS CHESTING THEMSELVES
AS SHE WAVED HER HAND, THE LAMPS DIMMED, AND SHE RETURNED TO HER
OFFICE; HE HEARD THE DOOR CLICK BEHIND HER AND KNEW THAT SHE WAS
OFF THE BED, THIS WAS, HARRY REFLECTED IN THE DARKNESS, THE THIRD TIME
THAT HE HAD BEEN BRUGHT TO THE HOSPITAL WING BECAUSE OF A
SLIGHTLY INJURY, LAST TIME HE HAD FALLEN OFF HIS BEDDING DUE TO THE
PRESENCE OF DEMENTORS AROUND THE PITCH, AND THE TIME BEFORE THAT,
ALL THE BONES HAD BEEN REMOVED FROM HIS ARM BY THE INCREDIBLY INEPT
PROFESSOR LECHEART. THAT HAD BEEN HIS MOST PAINFUL INJURY BY
FAR HE REMEMBERED THE AGONY OF RECOVERING AN ARMFUL OF BONES
IN ONE NIGHT, A DISCOMFORT NOT EASED BY THE ARRIVAL OF AN
UNEXPECTED VISITOR IN THE MIDDLE OF THE HARRY SAT UP RIGHT,
HIS HEART POUNDING, HIS BANDAGE TIGHTEN AROUND, HE HAD THE
SOLUTION AT LAST! THERE WAS A WAY TO HAVE MALPHY FOLLOWED
WHEN COULD HE HAVE FORGOTTEN, WHY HADN'T HE THOUGHT OF IT BEFORE?
BUT THE WORST PART WAS, WHEN TO CALL HIM? WHAT DID YOU DO? QUIETLY,
TENTATIVELY, HARRY SPEW INTO THE DARKNESS, BREACHER? THERE
WAS A VERY LOUD CRACK, AND THE SOUNDS OF SCUFFLING AND SHELTERS
FILLED THE SILENT ROOM, BEN AWOKED WITH A YELP, WHAT'S GOING
? HARRY POINTED HIS HAND HASTILY AT THE DOOR OF MADAM

PEEVES'S EYES AND MUTTERED, MUMBLING: SHE THAT SHE WOULD NOT
COME RUNNING. THEN HE SCRAMBLED TO THE END OF HIS BED FOR A BETTER
LOOK AT WHAT WAS GOING ON. TWO FISH-EYES WERE ROLLING AROUND
ON THE FLOOR IN THE MIDDLE OF THE BATHROOM, ONE WEARING A
SHRIMPEN MARCHEN JUMPER AND SEVERAL WHISKEY HATS, THE OTHER, A
FILTHY OLD RAG STYLING OVER HIS HIPS LIKE A SHINGLET. THEN THERE
WAS ANOTHER BED RAG, AND PEEVES THE PEELERIST APPEARED IN
MIDAIR ABOVE THE WRESTLING EYES. I WAS WATCHING THAT, PEETTY? HE
THUD FARRY INDIGNANTLY, POINTING AT THE FIGHT BELOW, BEFORE
LETTING OUT A LITTLE CACKLE. LOOK AT THE IDLE CREATURES SNEAKING,
KITEY KITEY, PLINCH PLINCH. KREACHER WILL NOT INSULT FARRY
PEETTER IN FRONT OF DEEY, NO HE WHEN T, HE DEEY WILL SHUT
KREACHER'S MOUTH FOR HIM? CRIED DEEY IN A HIGH-PITCHED VOICE.

KICKY, SCRATCHY? CRIED PEEVES HAPPILY, WHEN PELTING KITS OF
CLACK AT THE EYES THE ENRAGE THEM FURTHER. TWEADY, DEEY?

KREACHER WILL SAY WHAT HE LIKES ABOUT HIS MASTER, HE YES, AND
WHAT A MASTER HE IS, FILTHY FRIEND OF MURDERERS, HE, WHAT WOULD
PEETTER KREACHER'S MISTRESS SAY? EXACTLY WHAT KREACHER'S
MISTRESS WOULD HAVE SAID THEY DID NOT FIND OUT, FOR AT THAT MOMENT
DEEY SAND HIS DUNKELY LITTLE FIST INTO KREACHER'S MOUTH AND
DUNKED OUT HALF OF HIS TEETH. FARRY AND REEN BOTH LEAPT OUT OF
THEIR BEDS AND WRENCHED THE TWO EYES APART, THOUGH THEY
CONTINUED TO TRY AND KICK AND PLINCH EACH OTHER, EGGED ON BY
PEEVES, WHO SWEEPED AROUND THE LAMP SNEAKING. STICK YOUR
FINGERS UP HIS NOSE, DRAW HIS CHOK AND PULL HIS EARS!
FARRY AIMED HIS HAND AT PEEVES AND SAID, LANGLEND? PEEVES
CLUTCHED AT HIS THROAT, GLIMPED, THEN SWEEPED FROM THE ROOM
MAKING HESITANT GESTURES BUT UNABLE TO SPEAK, KNOWING THE FACT
THAT HIS THROAT HAD JUST GIVED ITSELF TO THE ROOM OF HIS MOUTH.

NICE ONE, SAID REEN APPRECIATIVELY, LIFTING DEEY INTO THE AIR SEE
THAT HIS FLAILING LIMBS NO LONGER MADE CONTACT WITH KREACHER.

THAT WAS ANOTHER PRINCE HEY, WASN'T IT? YES, SAID FARRY,
TWISTING KREACHER'S WIZENED ARM INTO A HALF NELSON. RIGHT I'M
FORBIDDING YOU THE FIGHT EACH OTHER? WELL, KREACHER, YOU'RE
FORBIDDEN THE FIGHT DEEY, DEEY, I KNOW I'M NOT ALLOWED TO GIVE YOU
ORDERS

DEEY IS A FREE FISH-EYE AND HE CAN HEY ANYONE HE
LIKES AND DEEY WILL DO WHATEVER FARRY PEETTER WANTS HIM TO DO
SAID DEEY, TEARS NOW STREAMING DOWN HIS SHRIMPEN LITTLE FACE MOUTH

HIS ILMPER. EDY THEN, SAID F-HARRY, AND HE AND REIN BOTH RELEASED THE RYVES, WHO FELL TO THE FLOOR BUT DID NOT CONTINUE FIGHTING. MASTER CALLED ME? CRASHED KREACHER, SINKING INTO A KNEE EVEN AS HE GAVE F-HARRY A LOOK THAT PLAINLY WISHED HIM A PAINFUL DEATH. YES, I DID, SAID F-HARRY, GLANCING TOWARD MADAM PHEMREY'S OFFICE WHERE THE CHIEF THAT THE MURDER SPELL WAS STILL WORKING; THERE WAS NO SIGN THAT SHE HAD HEARD ANY OF THE CHATTER. I'VE GOT A JOB FOR YOU. KREACHER WILL DO WHATEVER MASTER WANTS, SAID KREACHER, SINKING SEE WELL THAT HIS LIPS ALMOST TOUCHED HIS CHIN. REALISE KREACHER HAS NO CHOICE, BUT KREACHER IS ASHAMED TO HAVE SUCH A MASTER, YES DEEKE WILL DO IT, F-HARRY PITTER? SNEEZED DEEKE, HIS TENNIS-BALL-SIZED EYES STILL SWIMMING IN TEARS. DEEKE WOULD BE HONORED TO HELP F-HARRY PITTER? COME TO THINK OF IT, IT WOULD BE GOOD TO HAVE BOTH OF YOU, SAID F-HARRY. EDY THEN I WANT YOU TO TAIL DRACH MALTHEY. IGNORING THE LOOK OF MINGLED SURPRISE AND EXASPERATION ON REIN'S FACE, F-HARRY WENT ON. I WANT TO KNOW WHERE HE'S GOING, WHEN HE'S MEETING, AND WHAT HE'S DOING. I WANT YOU TO FOLLOW HIM AROUND THE CLOCK. YES, F-HARRY PITTER? SAID DEEKE AT ONCE, HIS GREAT EYES SHINING WITH EXCITEMENT. AND IF DEEKE DOES IT WRONG, DEEKE WILL THROW HIMSELF OFF THE TALLEST TOWER, F-HARRY PITTER?

THERE WON'T BE ANY NEED FOR THAT, SAID F-HARRY HASTILY. MASTER WANTS ME TO FOLLOW THE YOUNGEST OF THE MALTHEYS? CRASHED KREACHER. MASTER WANTS ME TO SPY UPON THE PURE-BLOOD GREAT-NEPHEW OF MY OLD MISTRESS? THAT'S THE ONE, SAID F-HARRY, APPREHENDING A GREAT DANGER AND DETERMINING TO PREVENT IT IMMEDIATELY. AND YOU'RE FORBIDDEN TO TELL HIM ANY, KREACHER, OR TO SHOW HIM WHAT YOU'RE UP TO, OR TO TALK TO HIM AT ALL, OR TO WRITE HIM MESSAGES OR OR TO CONTACT HIM IN ANY WAY. GOT IT? HE THOUGHT HE WOULD SEE KREACHER STRUGGLING TO SEE A LEAD-PIPE IN THE INSTRUCTIONS HE HAD JUST BEEN GIVEN AND WAITED. AFTER A MOMENT OR TWO, AND THE F-HARRY'S GREAT SATISFACTION, KREACHER KNEED DEEPLY AGAIN AND SAID, WITH BITTER RESENTMENT, MASTER THINKS OF EVERYTHING, AND KREACHER MUST OBEY HIM EVEN THOUGH KREACHER WOULD MUCH RATHER BE THE SERVANT OF THE MALTHEY BROTHER, YES.

THAT'S SETTLED, THEN, SAID F-HARRY. I'LL WANT REGULAR REPORTS, BUT MAKE SURE I'M NOT SURVEILLED BY PEOPLE WHO DON'T TURN UP. REIN AND FERMINE ARE EDY. AND DON'T TELL ANYONE WHAT YOU'RE DOING.

JUST STICK THE MALICE LIKE A CHLIPLE OF WART PLASTERS. LORD
 VERBEMBERT & REHLEST FARRY AND REIN LEFT THE HOSPITAL WING FIRST
 THING IN MINDAY MORNINE, RESTORED THE FULL HEALTH BY THE
 MINISTRATIONS OF MADAM PEMPPEY AND NEW ALE THE KNIFE THE
 BENEFITS OF HAVING BEEN KNICKED HILT AND PHILSHINED, THE REST OF
 WHICH WAS THAT HERMIENE WAS FRIENDS WITH REIN AGAIN. HERMIENE
 EVEN ESCORTED THEM DOWN THE BREAKFAST, BRINGING WITH HER THE NEWS
 THAT GINNY HAD ARGUED WITH DEAN. THE DRELSING CREATURE IN
 FARRY'S CHEST SLIDDERLY RAISED ITS HEAD, SNIPPING THE AIR HEEPELILLY.
 WHAT DID THEY REIN AKHILT? HE ASKED, TRYING THE SHLIND CASUAL AS
 THEY TURNED INTO A SEVENTH-FLEHER CHERRIDDER THAT WAS DESERTED KLT
 FOR A VERY SMALL GIRL WHO HAD BEEN EXAMINING A TAPESTRY OF TRELLS
 IN TWILLS. SHE LEEKED TERRIFIED AT THE SIGHT OF THE APPROACHING
 SIXTH YEARS AND DROPPED THE HEAVY BRASS SCALES SHE WAS CARRYING.
 IT'S ALL RIGHT? SAID HERMIENE KINDLY, FLIRRYING FORWARD THE HELP
 HER. HERE SHE TAPPED THE KNECKEN SCALES WITH HER HAND AND
 SAID, REPAIR. THE GIRL DID NOT SAY THANK YELL, KLT REMAINED
 RHEETED THE THE SPOT AS THEY PASSED AND WATCHED THEM HILT OF SIGHT.
 REIN GLANCED BACK AT HER. I SWEAR THEY'RE GETTING SMALLER, HE SAID.
 NEVER MIND HER, SAID FARRY, A LITTLE IMPATIENTLY. WHAT DID
 GINNY AND DEAN REIN AKHILT, HERMIENE? HEI, DEAN WAS LAUGHING
 AKHILT MCLAGGEN HITTING THAT BLIDGER AT YELL, SAID HERMIENE. IT
 MUST'VE LEEKED FLINNY, SAID REIN REASONABLY. IT DIDN'T LEEK FLINNY
 AT ALL? SAID HERMIENE HEETLY. IT LEEKED TERRIBLE AND IF CHEETE AND
 PEAKES HADN'T CALIGHT FARRY HE CHULD HAVE BEEN VERY BADLY FLIRT.
 Yeah, well, THERE WAS NO NEED FOR GINNY AND DEAN TO SPLIT UP
 EVER IT, SAID FARRY, STILL TRYING THE SHLIND CASUAL. ARE THEY
 STILL TOGETHER? YES, THEY ARE KLT WHO ARE YELL SHE INTERESTED?
 ASKED HERMIENE, GIVING FARRY A SHARP LEEK. I JUST DON'T WANT
 MY FLIDBITCH TEAM MESSED UP AGAIN? HE SAID HASTILY, KLT HERMIENE
 CONTINUED THE LEEK SUSPICIOUSLY, AND HE WAS MOST RELIEVED WHEN A
 VEHICLE BEHIND THEM CALLED, FARRY? GIVING HIM AN EXCLISE THE TURN
 HIS BACK IN HER. HEI, HI, LLINA. I WENT THE THE HOSPITAL WING THE
 FIND YELL, SAID LLINA, ALIMPAGING IN HER BAG. KLT THEY SAID YELL O
 LEFT. SHE THOUGHT WHAT APPEARED TO BE A GREEN HENHEN, A LARGE
 SPOTTED THADSTHEE, AND A CONSIDERABLE AMOUNT OF WHAT LEEKED LIKE
 CAT LITTER INTO REIN'S HANDS, FINALLY PULLING HILT A RATHER GRIKEY
 SCROLL OF PARCHEMENT THAT SHE HANDED THE FARRY. I'VE BEEN TOLD

HE GAVE HER THIS. IT WAS A SMALL REEL OF PARCHMENT, WHICH HARRY
 RECOGNIZED AT ONCE AS ANOTHER INVITATION TO A LESSON WITH
 DUMBLEDORE. TONIGHT, HE TOLD RON AND HERMION, SINCE HE HAD
 UNWOUND IT. NICE COMMENTARY LAST MATCH? SAID RON TO LUNA AS
 SHE THREW BACK THE GREEN HENRIEN, THE THADSTHEE, AND THE CAT LITTER.
 LUNA SMILED VAGUELY. YOU'RE MAKING FUN OF ME, AREN'T YOU? SHE
 SAID. EVERYONE SAYS I WAS DREADFUL. NO, I'M SERIOUS! SAID RON
 EARNESTLY. I CAN'T REMEMBER ENJOYING COMMENTARY MORE! WHAT IS
 THIS, BY THE WAY? HE ADDED, HOLDING THE HENRIEN-LIKE BECKET UP TO THE
 LIGHT. EH, IT'S A CLIMBERHOOT, SHE SAID, STUFFING THE CAT LITTER AND
 THE THADSTHEE BACK INTO HER BAG. YOU CAN KEEP IT IF YOU LIKE, I'VE
 GOT A FEW OF THEM. THEY'RE REALLY EXCELLENT FOR WARDING OFF
 CLIMBING PLIMPS. AND SHE WALKED AWAY, LEAVING RON FLUTTERING,
 STILL CLUTCHING THE CLIMBERHOOT. YOU KNOW, SHE'S GREEN IN ME,
 LUNA, HE SAID, AS THEY SET OFF AGAIN FOR THE GREAT HALL. I KNOW
 SHE'S INSANE, BUT IT'S IN A GOOD WAY. HE STOPPED TALKING VERY
 SUDDENLY. LAVENDER BROWN WAS STANDING AT THE FOOT OF THE MARBLE
 STAIRCASE WHISKING THUNDERBOLTS. HI, SAID RON NERVOUSLY. [MOM,
 HARRY MUTTERED TO HERMION, AND THEY SPED PAST, THOUGH NOT
 BEFORE THEY HAD HEARD LAVENDER SAY, WHY DIDN'T YOU TELL ME YOU
 WERE GETTING HIT TODAY? AND WHY WAS SHE WITH YOU? RON BLINKED
 BOTH SLIDELY AND ANNOYED WHEN HE APPEARED AT BREAKFAST HALF AN
 HOUR LATER, AND THOUGH HE SAT WITH LAVENDER, HARRY DID NOT SEE
 THEM EXCHANGE A WORD ALL THE TIME THEY WERE TOGETHER. HERMION
 WAS ACTING AS THOUGH SHE WAS COMPLETELY UNINVOLVED IN ALL OF THIS, BUT
 SINCE HER TWICE HARRY SAW AN INEXPLICABLE SMILE CROSS HER FACE. ALL
 THAT DAY SHE SEEMED TO BE IN A PARTICULARLY GOOD MOOD, AND THAT
 EVENING IN THE COMMON ROOM SHE EVEN CONSENTED TO READ OVER (IN
 OTHER WORDS, FINISH WRITING) HARRY'S HERMION'S ESSAY, SOMETHING
 SHE HAD BEEN RESOLUTELY REFUSING TO DO UP TO THIS POINT, BECAUSE
 SHE HAD KNOWN THAT HARRY WOULD THEN LET RON COPY HIS WORK.

THANKS A LOT, HERMION, SAID HARRY, GIVING HER A HASTY PAT ON
 THE BACK AS HE CHECKED HIS WATCH AND SAW THAT IT WAS NEARLY EIGHT
 O'CLOCK. LISTEN, I'VE GOT TO HURRY OR I'LL BE LATE FOR DUMBLEDORE.

SHE DID NOT ANSWER, BUT MERELY CROSSED HIM A FEW OF HIS FEWER
 SENTENCES IN A WEARY SHORT OF WAY. GRINNING, HARRY HURRIED OUT
 THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE AND OFF TO THE HEADMASTER'S OFFICE. THE
 GARGOYLE LEAPT ASIDE AT THE MENTION OF THEEE CLAIRS, AND HARRY

THESE THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE TWO STEPS AT A TIME, DROPPING HIM THE
DOOR JUST AS A CLICK WITHIN CHIMED RIGHT. ENTER, CALLED
DUMBLEDORE, CLUT AS HARRY PUT OUT A HAND TO PUSH THE DOOR, IT WAS
WRENCHED OPEN FROM INSIDE. THERE STOOD PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY.

AH! SHE CRIED, POINTING DRAMATICALLY AT HARRY AS SHE GLANCED AT
HIM THROUGH HER MAGNIFYING SPECTACLES. SEE THIS IS THE REASON I
AM THE ONLY LINGERER HERE FROM MY OFFICE, DUMBLEDORE!

MY DEAR SYRIL, SAID DUMBLEDORE IN A SLIGHTLY EXASPERATED VOICE,
THERE IS NO QUESTION OF TROUBLE WITH LINGERERS FROM
ANYWHERE, BUT HARRY DOES HAVE AN APPOINTMENT, AND I REALLY
DON'T THINK THERE IS ANY MORE TO BE SAID. VERY WELL, SAID
PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, IN A DEEPLY WOUNDED VOICE. IF YOU WILL NOT
BANISH THE DISTURBING NOISE, SEE IT. PERHAPS I SHALL FIND A
SOMEWHERE MY TALENTS ARE BETTER APPRECIATED. SHE PUSHED

PAST HARRY AND DISAPPEARED DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE; THEY HEARD
HER STUMBLE HALFWAY DOWN, AND HARRY GUESSED THAT SHE HAD TRIPPED
OVER ONE OF HER TRAILING SCALES. PLEASE CLOSE THE DOOR AND SIT
DOWN, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SOUNDING RATHER TIRED. HARRY
OBEYED, NOTICING AS HE TOOK HIS USUAL SEAT IN FRONT OF DUMBLEDORE'S
DESK THAT THE PENDULUM WAS BETWEEN THEM SINCE THERE, AS DID TWO MORE
TINY CRYSTAL KETTLES FULL OF SWIRLING MEMORIES, PROFESSOR

TRELAWNEY STILL ISN'T HAPPY FIRENZE IS TEACHING, THEN? HARRY
ASKED. NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE, DIVINATION IS TURNING OUT TO BE
MUCH MORE TRICKLE THAN I COULD HAVE ANTICIPATED, NEVER HAVING
STUDIED THE SUBJECT MYSELF, I CANNOT ASK FIRENZE TO RETURN TO THE
FOREST, WHERE HE IS NOW AN OUTCAST, NOR CAN I ASK SYRIL

TRELAWNEY TO LEAVE. BETWEEN THEMSELVES, SHE HAS NO IDEA OF THE
DANGER SHE WOULD BE IN OUTSIDE THE CASTLE. SHE DOES NOT KNOW
AND I THINK IT WOULD BE WISE TO ENLIGHTEN HER. THAT SHE MADE
THE PROPHECY ABOUT YOU AND VOLDMORT, YOU SEE. DUMBLEDORE
HEAVED A DEEP SIGH, THEN SAID, BUT NEVER MIND MY STAFFING
PROBLEMS, WE HAVE MUCH MORE IMPORTANT MATTERS TO DISCUSS.

FIRSTLY HAVE YOU MANAGED THE TASK I SET YOU AT THE END OF YOUR
PREVIOUS LESSON? AH, SAID HARRY, BRIGHT LIP SHEET. WHAT
WITH APPARITION LESSONS AND FLIDITCH AND REIN BEING PERISHED
AND GETTING HIS SKILL CRACKED AND HIS DETERMINATION TO FIND OUT
WHAT BRACE MALFOY WAS UP TO, HARRY HAD ALMOST FORGOTTEN ABOUT
THE MEMORY DUMBLEDORE HAD ASKED HIM TO EXTRACT FROM PROFESSOR

SILVERHORN. WELL, I ASKED PROFESSOR SILVERHORN ABOUT IT AT THE END OF THE WEEK, SIR, BUT, ER, HE WOULDN'T GIVE IT TO ME. THERE WAS A LITTLE SILENCE. I SEE, SAID OLIMPELDERE EVENTUALLY, PEERING AT HARRY EVER THE TIME OF HIS HALF-MONTH SPECTACLES AND GIVING HARRY THE USUAL SENSATION THAT HE WAS BEING X-RAYED. AND YOU FEEL THAT YOU HAVE EXPERTED YOUR VERY BEST EFFORTS IN THIS MATTER, DID YOU? THAT YOU HAVE EXERCISED ALL OF YOUR CONSIDERABLE INGENUITY? THAT YOU HAVE LEFT NO DEPTH OF CLANNING UNEXPLORED IN YOUR BELIEF THE RETRIEVE THE MEMORY? WELL, HARRY STALLED, AT A LOSS FOR WHAT TO SAY NEXT. HIS SINGLE ATTEMPT TO GET INTO THE MEMORY SLIDDERLY SEEMED EMBARRASSINGLY FEELER. WELL THE DAY WHEN SWALLOWED HAVE BEEN BY MISTAKE I THINK HIM THE PROFESSOR SILVERHORN. I THOUGHT MAYBE IF I GET PROFESSOR SILVERHORN IN A GOOD ENOUGH MIND

AND DID THAT WORK? ASKED OLIMPELDERE. WELL, YES, SIR, BECAUSE WHEN GET PHASED WHICH, NATURALLY, MADE YOU FORGET ALL ABOUT TRYING THE RETRIEVE THE MEMORY. I WOULD HAVE EXPECTED NOTHING ELSE, WHILE YOUR BEST FRIEND WAS IN DANGER. HENCE IT BECAME CLEAR THAT MR. LEASLEY WAS GOING TO MAKE A FULL RECOVERY, HOWEVER, I WOULD HAVE HOPED THAT YOU RETURNED THE TASK I SET YOU. I THOUGHT I MADE IT CLEAR TO YOU HOW VERY IMPORTANT THAT MEMORY IS. INDEED, I DID MY BEST TO IMPRESS UPON YOU THAT IT IS THE MOST CRUCIAL MEMORY OF ALL AND THAT WE WILL BE WASTING OUR TIME WITHOUT IT. A FEEL, PROUDLY FEELING OF SHAME SPREAD FROM THE TIME OF HARRY'S HEAD ALL THE WAY DOWN HIS BODY. OLIMPELDERE HAD NOT RAISED HIS VOICE, HE DID NOT EVEN SEEM ANGRY, BUT HARRY WOULD HAVE PREFERRED HIM TO YELL. THIS CHILD DISAPPOINTMENT WAS WORSE THAN ANYTHING. SIR, HE SAID, A LITTLE DESPERATELY, IT ISN'T THAT I WASN'T EITHERED OR ANYTHING, I VE JUST HAD EITHER EITHER THINGS

EITHER THINGS IN YOUR MIND. OLIMPELDERE FINISHED THE SENTENCE FOR HIM. I SEE. SILENCE FELL BETWEEN THEM AGAIN, THE MOST UNCOMFORTABLE SILENCE HARRY HAD EVER EXPERIENCED WITH OLIMPELDERE. IT SEEMED TO GO ON AND ON, PUNCTUATED ONLY BY THE LITTLE GRLINTING SMILES OF THE PORTRAIT OF ARMANDINE DIPPER EVER OLIMPELDERE'S HEAD. HARRY FELT STRANGELY DIMINISHED, AS THOUGH HE HAD SHRUNK A LITTLE SINCE HE HAD ENTERED THE ROOM. WHEN HE COULD STAND IT NO LONGER HE SAID, PROFESSOR OLIMPELDERE, I'M REALLY SORRY, I SHOULD HAVE DONE MORE. I SHOULD HAVE REALIZED YOU WOULDN'T HAVE ASKED ME TO DO IT IF IT WASN'T REALLY IMPORTANT.

THANK YOU FOR SAYING THAT, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, MAY I HOPE, THEN, THAT YOU WILL GIVE THIS MATTER HIGHER PRIORITY FROM NOW ON? THERE WILL BE LITTLE POINT IN OUR MEETING AFTER TONIGHT UNLESS WE HAVE THAT MEMORY. I'LL DO IT, SIR, I'LL GET IT FROM HIM, HE SAID EARNESTLY. THEN WE SHALL SAY NO MORE ABOUT IT JUST NOW, SAID DUMBLEDORE MORE KINDLY, BUT CONTINUE WITH OUR STORY WHERE WE LEFT OFF, YOU REMEMBER WHERE THAT WAS? YES, SIR, SAID HARRY QUIETLY. VOLDERMORT KILLED HIS FATHER AND HIS GRANDPARENTS AND MADE IT LOOK AS THOUGH HIS UNCLE MURFIN DID IT. THEN HE WENT BACK TO HOGWARTS AND HE ASKED HE ASKED PROFESSOR SLUGGEBORN ABOUT HOGWARTS, HE NODDED SAMPACKEDLY, VERY GOOD, SAID DUMBLEDORE. NOW, YOU WILL REMEMBER, I HOPE, THAT I TOLD YOU AT THE VERY ONSET OF THESE MEETINGS OF OURS THAT WE WOULD BE ENTERING THE REALMS OF GUESSTWORK AND SPECULATION? YES, SIR. THIS FAR, AS I HOPE YOU AGREE, I HAVE SEEN YOU REASONABLY FIRM SOURCES OF FACT AND MY DEDUCTIONS AS TO WHAT VOLDERMORT DID UNTIL THE AGE OF SEVENTEEN? HARRY NODDED, BUT NOW, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, NEW THINGS BECOME MIXED AND STRANGER. IF IT WAS DIFFICULT TO FIND EVIDENCE ABOUT THE RED RIBBON, IT HAS BEEN ALMOST IMPOSSIBLE TO FIND ANYONE PREPARED TO REMEMBER ABOUT THE MAN VOLDERMORT. IN FACT, I DOUBT WHETHER THERE IS A SINGLE ALIVE, APART FROM HIMSELF, WHO COULD GIVE US A FULL ACCOUNT OF HIS LIFE SINCE HE LEFT HOGWARTS, HOWEVER, I HAVE TWO LAST MEMORIES THAT I WOULD LIKE TO SHARE WITH YOU. DUMBLEDORE INDICATED THE TWO LITTLE CRYSTAL BOTTLES GLIMMING BESIDE THE PENSIVE. I SHALL THEN BE GLAD OF YOUR OPINION AS TO WHETHER THE CONCLUSIONS I HAVE DRAWN FROM THEM SEEM LIKELY. THE IDEA THAT DUMBLEDORE VALUED HIS OPINION THIS HIGHLY MADE HARRY FEEL EVEN MORE DEEPLY ASHAMED THAT HE HAD FAILED IN THE TASK OF RETRIEVING THE HOGWARTS MEMORY, AND HE SHIFTED CLIMBLY IN HIS SEAT AS DUMBLEDORE RAISED THE FIRST OF THE TWO BOTTLES TO THE LIGHT AND EXAMINED IT. I HOPE YOU ARE NOT TIRED OF DIVING INTO OTHER PEOPLE'S MEMORIES, AND THEY ARE CLEARLY REMELLCTIONS, THESE TWO, HE SAID. THIS FIRST ONE CAME FROM A VERY OLD FELLOW BY THE NAME OF HEDLEY. BEFORE WE SEE WHAT HEDLEY WITNESSED, I MUST QUIETLY RECOUNT HOW LORD VOLDERMORT LEFT HOGWARTS. HE REACHED THE SEVENTH YEAR OF HIS SCHOOLING WITH, AS YOU MIGHT HAVE EXPECTED, THE GRADES IN EVERY EXAMINATION HE HAD TAKEN. ALL AROUND HIM, HIS CLASSMATES WERE DECIDING WHICH YEARS

THEY WERE THE PLURALS SINCE THEY HAD LEFT HOGWARTS. NEARLY EVERYBODY EXPECTED SPECTACULAR THINGS FROM THE RIDDLE, PERFECT, HEAD KID, WINNER OF THE AWARD FOR SPECIAL SERVICES THE YEAR BEFORE. I KNOW THAT SEVERAL TEACHERS, PROFESSOR SLUGGERTON AMONGST THEM, SUGGESTED THAT HE JOIN THE MINISTRY OF MAGIC, OFFERED THE SET UP APPOINTMENTS, PUT HIM IN TOUCH WITH USEFUL CONTACTS. HE REJECTED ALL OFFERS. THE NEXT THING THE STAFF KNOW, VERMOREL WAS WHISKING AT KIRKIN AND KIRKES. AT KIRKIN AND KIRKES? HARRY REPEATED, STUNNED. AT KIRKIN AND KIRKES, REPEATED DUMBLEDORE CALMLY. I THINK YOU WILL SEE WHAT ATTRACTIONS THE PLACE HELD FOR HIM WHEN WE HAVE ENTERED HARRY'S MEMORY, BUT THIS WAS NOT VERMOREL'S FIRST CHOICE OF HIM. HARDLY ANYONE KNOWS OF IT AT THE TIME. I WAS ONE OF THE FEW IN WHOM THE THEN HEADMASTER CONFIDED. BUT VERMOREL FIRST APPROACHED PROFESSOR DIPPET AND ASKED WHETHER HE COULD REMAIN AT HOGWARTS AS A TEACHER. HE WANTED THE STAY HERE? WHY? ASKED HARRY, MORE AMAZED STILL. I BELIEVE HE HAD SEVERAL REASONS, THE FIRST OF WHICH HE CONFIDED NONE OF THEM TO PROFESSOR DIPPET, SAID DUMBLEDORE. FIRSTLY, AND VERY IMPORTANTLY, VERMOREL WAS, I BELIEVE, MORE ATTACHED TO THIS SCHOOL THAN HE HAS EVER BEEN TO A PERSON. HOGWARTS WAS WHERE HE HAD BEEN HAPPIEST; THE FIRST AND ONLY PLACE HE HAD FELT AT HOME. HARRY FELT SLIGHTLY UNCOMFORTABLE AT THESE WORDS, FOR THIS WAS EXACTLY HOW HE FELT ABOUT HOGWARTS THEN. SECONDLY, THE CASTLE IS A STRONGHOLD OF ANCIENT MAGIC. UNBELIEVABLY VERMOREL HAD PENETRATED MANY MORE OF ITS SECRETS THAN MOST OF THE STUDENTS WHEN PASS THROUGH THE PLACE, BUT HE MAY HAVE FELT THAT THERE WERE STILL MYSTERIES TO UNRAVEL, STORIES OF MAGIC TO TAP. AND THIRDLY, AS A TEACHER, HE WOULD HAVE HAD GREAT POWER AND INFLUENCE OVER YOUNG WITCHES AND WIZARDS. PERHAPS HE HAD GAINED THE IDEA FROM PROFESSOR SLUGGERTON, THE TEACHER WITH WHOM HE WAS ON BEST TERMS, WHO HAD DEMONSTRATED HOW INFLUENTIAL A ROLE A TEACHER CAN PLAY. I DO NOT IMAGINE FOR AN INSTANT THAT VERMOREL ENVISAGED SPENDING THE REST OF HIS LIFE AT HOGWARTS, BUT I DO THINK THAT HE SAW IT AS A USEFUL RECRUITING GROUND, AND A PLACE WHERE HE MIGHT BEGIN TO BUILD HIMSELF AN ARMY. BUT HE DIDN'T GET THE JOB, DID HE? NO, HE DID NOT. PROFESSOR DIPPET TOLD HIM THAT HE WAS THEN YOUNG AT EIGHTEEN, BUT INVITED HIM TO REAPPLY IN A FEW YEARS, IF HE STILL WISHED THE TEACH. HOW DID YOU FEEL ABOUT THAT, SIR? ASKED HARRY

HESTITANTLY, DEEPLY LINEASY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I HAD ADVISED ARMANDO AGAINST THE APPOINTMENT. I DID NOT GIVE THE REASONS I HAD GIVEN YET, MR PROFESSOR DUMPE WAS VERY FOND OF VILDEMEHT AND CONVINCED OF HIS HONESTY, BUT I DID NOT WANT LORD VILDEMEHT BACK AT THIS SCHOOL, AND ESPECIALLY NOT IN A POSITION OF POWER.

WHICH HE DID HE WANT, SIR? WHAT SUBJECT DID HE WANT THE TEACH SHEPHELL, HARRY KNEW THE ANSWER EVEN BEFORE DUMBLEDORE GAVE IT.

DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS. IT WAS KING TALENT AT THE TIME BY AN OLD PROFESSOR BY THE NAME OF CALATEA MERRYTHLIGHT, WHO HAD BEEN AT HOGWARTS FOR NEARLY FIFTY YEARS. SHE VILDEMEHT WENT OFF THE KIRGIN AND KIRKES, AND ALL THE STAFF WHO HAD ADMIRER HIM SAID WHAT A WASTE IT WAS, A BRILLIANT YOUNG WIZARD LIKE THAT, WHIRLING IN A SHIP. HOWEVER, VILDEMEHT WAS NOT MERE ASSISTANT, POLITE AND HANDSOME AND CLEVER, HE WAS SHOWN GIVEN PARTICULAR HEED OF THE TYPE THAT ONLY EXIST IN A PLACE LIKE KIRGIN AND KIRKES, WHICH SPECIALIZES, AS YET KNEW, HARRY, IN HEIKETS WITH UNUSUAL AND PHENOMENAL PROPERTIES. VILDEMEHT WAS SENT TO PERSUADE PEOPLE THE PART WITH THEIR TREASURES AND SALE BY THE PARTNERS, AND HE WAS, BY ALL ACCOUNTS, UNUSUALLY GIFTED AT DOING THIS. I AM SURE HE WAS, SAID HARRY, LINEARLY THE CERTAIN HIMSELF. WELL, ELITE, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WITH A FAINT SMILE. AND NOW IT IS TIME TO HEAR FROM HENRY THE HELLSE-ER, WHO WHORDED FOR A VERY OLD, VERY RICH WITCH BY THE NAME OF HEPZIKAH SMITH. DUMBLEDORE TAPPED A KETTLE WITH HIS WAND, THE CHORD FLEW UP, AND HE TIPPED THE SWIRLING MEMPHY INTO THE PENSIVE, SAYING AS HE DID SO. AFTER YET, HARRY, HARRY GET THE HIS FEET AND KENT HENCE MORE EVER THE RIPPLING SILVER CONTENTS OF THE STONE BASIN UNTIL HIS FACE TWITCHED THEM. HE TUMBLED TWELFTH DARK NOTHINGNESS AND LANDED IN A SITTING ROOM IN FRONT OF AN IMMENSELY FAT OLD LADY WEARING AN ELABORATE GINGER WIG AND A BRILLIANT PINK SET OF RIBBONS THAT FLEWED ALL AROUND HER, GIVING HER THE LOOK OF A MELTING ICE CAKE. SHE WAS LEANING INTO A SMALL JEWELLED MIRROR AND DARTING REVER ENTHER HER ALREADY SCARLET CHEEKS WITH A LARGE PLEDER PLUFF, WHILE THE TINIEST AND ELDEST HELLSE-ER HARRY HAD EVER SEEN LACED HER FLESHY FEET INTO TIGHT SATIN SLIPPERS. HARRY UP, HENRY? SAID HEPZIKAH IMPERIOUSLY.

HE SAID HE D CAME AT FIVE, IT S ONLY A COUPLE OF MINUTES TOO AND HE S NEVER BEEN LATE YET? SHE TUCKED AWAY HER PLEDER PLUFF AS THE HELLSE-ER STRAIGHTENED UP. THE TOP OF THE ER S HEAD BARELY REACHED

THE SEAT OF EPPZIKAH'S CHAIR, AND HER PAPERY SKIN FLING OFF HER FRAME JUST LIKE THE CRISP LINDEN SHEET SHE WHEN DRAPED LIKE A THICK, EHEW DE I WHEW? SAID EPPZIKAH, TURNING HER HEAD TO ADMIRE THE VARIOUS ANGLES OF HER FACE IN THE MIRROR. HEYER, MADAM, SEHEADED EHEW, EARRY CHULD ONLY ASSUME THAT IT WAS DEHN IN EHEW'S CONTRACT THAT SHE MUST LIE THROUGH HER TEETH WHEN ASKED THIS QUESTION, BECAUSE EPPZIKAH SMITH WHEW A LONG WAY FROM HEYER IN HIS OPINION, A TINKLING BELL RANG AND BOTH MISTRESS AND ELF LIMPED. ELICK, ELICK, HE'S HERE, EHEW? CRIED EPPZIKAH AND THE ELF SCURRED OUT OF THE ROOM, WHICH WAS SHE CRAMPED WITH OBJECTS THAT IT WAS DIFFICULT TO SEE HOW ANYBODY CHULD NAVIGATE THEIR WAY ACROSS IT WITHOUT KNOCKING OVER AT LEAST A DOZEN THINGS. THERE WERE CABINETS FULL OF LITTLE LACQUERED BOXES, CASES FULL OF CHILD-EMBRUSED BOXES, SHELVES OF BOOKS AND CELESTIAL CHAIRS, AND MANY FLESHISHING POTTED PLANTS IN BRASS CONTAINERS. IN FACT, THE ROOM WHEW LIKE A CROSS BETWEEN A MAGICAL ANTIHEW SHEP AND A CONSERVATORY. THE HEUSE-ELF RETURNED WITHIN MINUTES, FOLLOVED BY A TALL YELING MAN EARRY HAD NO DIFFICULTY WHATSOEVER IN RECOGNIZING AS VHEDEHART. HE WAS PLAINLY DRESSED IN A BLACK SLIT; HIS HAIR WAS A LITTLE LONGER THAN IT HAD BEEN AT SEHEW AND HIS CHEEKS WERE FOLLOVED, BUT ALL OF THIS SLITED HIM; HE WHEW MORE HANDSOME THAN EVER. HE PICKED HIS WAY THROUGH THE CRAMPED ROOM WITH AN AIR THAT SEHEW HE HAD VISITED MANY TIMES BEFORE AND KEHEW HOW EVER EPPZIKAH'S FAT LITTLE HAND, KISSING IT WITH HIS LIPS. I KEHEW IT YEL FLEWERS, HE SAID QUIETLY, PRODUCING A CLINK OF BOXES FROM NOWHERE. YEL WAGHITY EHEW, YEL SEHEW'DN'T HAVE? SEHEADED EHEW EPPZIKAH, THROUGH EARRY NOTICED THAT SHE HAD AN EMPTY VASE STANDING READY ON THE NEAREST LITTLE TABLE. YEL DE SPHEW THIS EHEW LADY, THEM. SIT DOWN, SIT DOWN. WHERE'S EHEW? AHEW THE HEUSE-ELF HAD COME DASHING BACK INTO THE ROOM CARRYING A TRAY OF LITTLE BOXES, WHICH SHE SET AT HER MISTRESS'S ELHEW. EHEW YELIRSEL, THEM, SAID EPPZIKAH, I KNOW EHEW YEL WHEW MY BOXES. NHEW, EHEW ARE YEL? YEL WHEW PALE. THEY HYPERWHEW YEL AT THAT SHEP, I VE SAID IT A HUNDRED TIMES. VHEDEHART SMILED MECHANICALLY AND EPPZIKAH SIMPERED. WELL, WHAT'S YELR EXCISE FOR VISITING THIS TIME? SHE ASKED, RATTING HER LASHES. MR. BLURKE WHEWLD LIKE TO MAKE AN IMPROVED OFFER FOR THE GELIN-MADE ARMOR, SAID VHEDEHART. FIVE HUNDRED GALLEONS, HE FEELS IT IS A MORE THAN

FAIR NHEW, NHEW, NEET SEE FAST, HIR I LL THINDK YELU RE HENLY HERE
AHR MY TRINKETS? PHLUTED F-JEPZIKAH. I AM HORDERED HERE RECALISE HP
THEM, SAID VHEBEMERT ELIJETLY. I AM HENLY A PHHEER ASSISTANT,
MADAM, WE-TH MUST DEE AS HE IS THELD, MR. KLARKE WISHES ME THE INEHLJIRE
HEH, MR. KLARKE, PH-HEHE? SAID F-JEPZIKAH, WAVING A LITTLE HAND.
I VE SHEMETHING THE SE-HEW YELU TH-AT I VE NEVER SE-HEW MR. KLARKE?
CAN YELU DEEP A SECRET, THEH? WILL YELU PROMISE YELU WHEN T TELL MR.
KLARKE I VE GET IT? F-JE D NEVER LET ME REST IF HE DNEW I D SE-HEW IT THE
YELU, AND I M NEET SELLING, NEET THE KLARKE, NEET THE ANYHINK? BLIT YELU,
THEM, YELU LL APPRECIATE IT AHR ITS HISTERY, NEET F-HEW MANY CALLHEENS
YELU CAN GET AHR IT. I D BE GLAD THE SEE ANYTHING MISS F-JEPZIKAH
SE-HEW ME, SAID VHEBEMERT ELIJETLY, AND F-JEPZIKAH GAVE ANEITHER
GIRLISH GIGGLE. I HAD F-JEDDY BRING IT HLT AHR ME. F-JEDDY, WE-HERE
ARE YELU? I WANT THE SE-HEW MR. RIDDLER ELIR FINEST TREASURE. IN FACT,
BRING KHEH, WE-HEW YELU RE AT IT. F-JERE, MADAM, SHELEADED THE
F-HELSE-ELF, AND F-JARRY SAW THE LEATHER SHOES, HENE HEN THEP HP THE
EHTHER, MEHVING ACROSS THE ROOM AS IF HP THEIR HENLY VEHITHEH,
THEHUGH HE DNEW THE TINY ELF WAS F-HELDING THEM HVER HER HEAD AS
SHE WENDEB HER WAY BETWEEN TABLES, PHELPPES, AND FEHTSTHEHS. NHEW,
SAID F-JEPZIKAH HAPPILY, TAKING THE SHOES FROM THE ELF, LAYING THEM
IN HER LAP, AND PREPARING THE HPEN THE THEPMEST HNE. I THINDK
YELU LL LIKE THIS, THEM. HEH, IF MY FAMILY DNEW I WAS SE-HEWING YELU,

THEY CAN T WAIT THE GET THEIR HANDS HEN THIS? SHE HPENED THE
LID, F-JARRY EGED AHRWARD A LITTLE THE GET A BETTER VIEW AND SAW WE-AT
LHEDD LIKE A SMALL GELDEN CLIP WITH THE FINELY WREHLIGHT HANDLES.

I WHENDER WE-ETHER YELU DNEW WE-AT IT IS, THEM? PICK IT UP, HAVE A
GEHD LHEH? WE-LSPERED F-JEPZIKAH, AND VHEBEMERT STRETCHED HLT A
LHNG-FINGERED HAND AND LIFTED THE CLIP BY HNE HANDLE HLT HP ITS
SNLG SILKEN WRAPPINGS. F-JARRY THEHLIGHT HE SAW A RED GLEAM IN HIS
DARK EYES. HIS GREEDY EXPRESSHEH WAS CLIRHELSLY MIRREHED HEN
F-JEPZIKAH S FACE, EXCEPT TH-AT HER TINY EYES WERE FIXED UPEN
VHEBEMERT S HANDSHEM FEATLRES. A RADER, MLYMILRED VHEBEMERT,
EXAMINING THE ENGRAVING UPEN THE CLIP. THEN THIS WAS ?

F-ELGA F-LYPLELFF S, AS YELU VERY WELL DNEW, YELU CLEVER SHE? SAID
F-JEPZIKAH, LEADING AHRWARD WITH A LHLID CREAKING HP CHESETS AND
ACTUALLY PINCHING HIS F-HEHHEW CHEEK. DIDN T I TELL YELU I WAS
DISTANTLY DESCENDED? THIS HAS BEEN HANDED DEHIN IN THE FAMILY AHR
YEARS AND YEARS, LEEVELY, LBN T IT? AND ALL SHEETS HP PHELERS IT S

SLIPPED THE PRESSURE THEM, BUT I HAVEN'T TESTED THEM THOROUGHLY, I
JUST KEEP IT NICE AND SAFE IN HERE. SHE HOOKED THE CLIP BACK OFF

VERDERMERE'S LONG FINGER AND RESTORED IT GENTLY TO ITS BOX, THEN
INTENT UPON SETTLING IT CAREFULLY BACK INTO POSITION THE NOTICE THE
SHADOW THAT CROSSED VERDERMERE'S FACE AS THE CLIP WAS TAKEN AWAY.

NEIL THEN, SAID EUPHONICALLY, WHERE'S EDDIE? EH YES,
THERE SHE IS TAKE THAT AWAY NEIL EDDIE. THE ELF OBEDIENTLY
TOOK THE BOXED CLIP, AND EUPHONICALLY TURNED HER ATTENTION TO THE
MUCH FLATTER BOX IN HER LAP. I THINK SHE'LL LIKE THIS EVEN MORE,
THEM, SHE WHISPERED. LEAN IN A LITTLE, DEAR ONE, SHE SHELL CAN SEE,
HER CHURCH, KIRK KNOWS I'VE GOT THIS ONE, I BUGHT IT FROM HIM,
AND I DARE SAY HE'D LOVE TO GET IT BACK WHEN I'M GONE. SHE SLID

BACK THE FINE SILVER CLASP AND FLIPPED OPEN THE BOX. THERE UPON
THE SMOOTH CRIMSON VELVET LAY A HEAVY GOLDEN LOCKET. VERDERMERE
REACHED OUT HIS HAND, WITHOUT INVITATION THIS TIME, AND HELD IT UP
TO THE LIGHT, STARING AT IT. SUTHERIN'S MARK, HE SAID QUIETLY, AS
THE LIGHT PLAYED UPON AN ELEGANT, SERPENTINE S. THAT'S RIGHT?
SAID EUPHONICALLY, DELIGHTED, APPARENTLY, AT THE SIGHT OF VERDERMERE
GAZING AT HER LOCKET, TRANSFIXED. I HAD THE PAY AN ARM AND A LEG
FOR IT, BUT I COULDN'T LET IT PASS, NOT A REAL TREASURE LIKE THAT, HAD
THE HAVE IT FOR MY COLLECTION, KIRK BUGHT IT, APPARENTLY, FROM A
RAGGED-LOOKING WHISKY MAN WHO SEEMED TO HAVE STELEN IT, BUT HAD NO
IDEA OF ITS TRUE VALUE. THERE WAS NO MISTAKING IT THIS TIME!

VERDERMERE'S EYES FLASHED SCARLET AT THE WORDS, AND HARRY SAW HIS
KNuckles WHITEN ON THE LOCKET'S CHAIN. I DARE SAY KIRK PAID
HER A PITTANCE BUT THERE SHE IS. PRETTY, ISN'T IT? AND AGAIN,
ALL KINDS OF FEELINGS ATTRIBUTED TO IT, THOUGH I JUST KEEP IT NICE AND
SAFE. SHE REACHED OUT TO TAKE THE LOCKET BACK, FOR A MOMENT,

HARRY THOUGHT VERDERMERE WAS NOT GOING TO LET GO OF IT, BUT THEN
IT HAD SLID THROUGH HIS FINGERS AND WAS BACK IN ITS RED VELVET
CUSHION. SHE THERE SHE IS, THEM, DEAR, AND I HOPE SHE ENJOYED
THAT! SHE LOOKED HIM FULL IN THE FACE AND FOR THE FIRST TIME,
HARRY SAW HER ELEGANT SMILE FAULTER. ARE SHE ALL RIGHT, DEAR?

EH YES, SAID VERDERMERE QUIETLY. YES, I'M VERY WELL. I
THOUGHT BUT A TRICK OF THE LIGHT, I SLIPPED SAID EUPHONICALLY,
LOOKING LINGERED, AND HARRY GUESSED THAT SHE THEN HAD SEEN THE
MOMENTARY RED GLEAM IN VERDERMERE'S EYES. THERE, EDDIE, TAKE
THESE AWAY AND LOCK THEM UP AGAIN. THE USUAL ENCHANTMENTS

TIME TO LEAVE, HARRY, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE QUIETLY, AND AS THE LITTLE ELF RERRED AWAY BEARING THE KEYS, DUMKLEDHIRE GRASPED HARRY'S HAND AGAIN ABOVE THE ELBOW AND TOGETHER THEY WENT UP THROUGH HALLWAYS AND BACK TO DUMKLEDHIRE'S OFFICE. EUPHRAIA SMITH DIED TWO DAYS AFTER THAT LITTLE SCENE, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, RESUMING HIS SEAT AND INDICATING THAT HARRY SHOULD DO THE SAME. ETHEL THE FLESH-ELF WAS CONVICTED BY THE MINISTRY OF POISONING HER MISTRESS'S EVENING CHICKEN BY ACCIDENT. NOW WHAT? SAID HARRY ANGRILY. I SEE WE ARE OF ONE MIND, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE. CERTAINLY, THERE ARE MANY SIMILARITIES BETWEEN THIS DEATH AND THAT OF THE RIDDLES. IN BOTH CASES, SOMEONE ELSE TOOK THE BLAME, SOMEONE WHO HAD A CLEAR MEMORY OF HAVING CAUSED THE DEATH. ETHEL CONFESSED? SHE REMEMBERED PLACING SOMETHING IN HER MISTRESS'S CHICKEN THAT TURNED OUT NOT TO BE SLICED, BUT A LETHAL AND LITTLE-KNOWN POISON, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE. IT WAS CONCLUDED THAT SHE HAD NOT MEANT TO DO IT, BUT BEING HED AND CONFOUSED. VERDAMPT MODIFIED HER MEMORY, JUST LIKE HE DID WITH MERLIN? YES, THAT IS MY CONCLUSION TOO, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE. AND, JUST AS WITH MERLIN, THE MINISTRY WAS PREDISPOSED TO SUSPECT ETHEL BECAUSE SHE WAS A FLESH-ELF, SAID HARRY, HE HAD RARELY FELT MORE IN SYMPATHY WITH THE SOCIETY ERMINE HAD SET UP, S.P.E.W. PRECISELY, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE. SHE WAS HED, SHE ADMITTED TO HAVING TAMPERED WITH THE DRINK, AND NOBODY AT THE MINISTRY ENTERED THE INQUIRY FURTHER, AS IN THE CASE OF MERLIN, BY THE TIME I TRACED HER AND MANAGED TO EXTRACT THIS MEMORY, HER LIFE WAS ALMOST OVER. BUT HER MEMORY, OF COURSE, PROVIDES NOTHING EXCEPT THAT VERDAMPT KNEW OF THE EXISTENCE OF THE CLIP AND THE LOCKET. BY THE TIME ETHEL WAS CONVICTED, EUPHRAIA'S FAMILY HAD REALIZED THAT TWO OF HER GREATEST TREASURES WERE MISSING. IT TOOK THEM A WHILE TO BE SURE OF THIS, FOR SHE HAD MANY HIDING PLACES, HAVING ALWAYS GUARDED HER COLLECTION MOST JEALOUSLY, BUT BEFORE THEY WERE SURE BEYOND DOUBT THAT THE CLIP AND THE LOCKET WERE BOTH GONE, THE ASSISTANT WHO HAD WORKED AT BORGIN AND BOKES, THE YOUNG MAN WHO HAD VISITED EUPHRAIA'S REGULARLY AND CHARMED HER SO WELL, HAD RESIGNED HIS POST AND VANISHED. HIS SUPERIORS HAD NO IDEA WHERE HE HAD GONE; THEY WERE AS SURPRISED AS ANYONE AT HIS DISAPPEARANCE. AND THAT WAS THE LAST THAT WAS SEEN OR HEARD OF THEM RIDDLE FOR A VERY LONG TIME. NOW, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, IF YOU DON'T MIND, HARRY, I WANT TO

PALISE HENCE MORE THE DRAW YELLER ATTENTION THE CERTAIN POINTS OF HELL
STORY. VILDEBERT HAD COMMITTED ANOTHER MURDER; WHETHER IT WAS
HIS FIRST SINCE HE KILLED THE RIDDLES, I DO NOT KNOW, BUT I THINK IT
WAS. THIS TIME, AS YELL WILL HAVE SEEN, HE KILLED NOT FOR REVENGE,
BUT FOR GAIN. HE WANTED THE TWO PARLOR'S TREASURES THAT MORE,
RESISTED, AND WHOMAN SEIZED HIM. JUST AS HE HAD HENCE REEKED THE
OTHER CHILDREN AT HIS EMPLOYMENT, JUST AS HE HAD STELEN HIS UNCLE
MERLIN'S RING, SEE HE RAN OFF WITH EZEKIEL'S CLIP AND LOCKET.
BUT, SAID HARRY, FREELING, IT SEEMS MAD. RISKING EVERYTHING,
TREASONING AWAY HIS LIFE, JUST FOR THESE MAD THE YELL, PERHAPS,
BUT NOT THE VILDEBERT, SAID OLMEDORE. I HOPE YELL WILL
UNDERSTAND IN ONE CHURCH EXACTLY WHAT THESE OBJECTS MEANT TO HIM,
HARRY, BUT YELL MUST ADMIT THAT IT IS NOT DIFFICULT TO IMAGINE THAT
HE SAW THE LOCKET, AT LEAST, AS RIGHTFULLY HIS. THE LOCKET MAKER,
SAID HARRY, BUT WHY TAKE THE CLIP AS WELL? IT HAD BELONGED TO
ANOTHER OF EZEKIEL'S FRIENDS, SAID OLMEDORE. I THINK HE
STILL FELT A GREAT PULL TOWARD THE SKETCH AND THAT HE COULD NOT
RESIST AN OBJECT HE STEPPED IN EZEKIEL'S HISTORY. THERE WERE OTHER
REASONS, I THINK. I HOPE YOU ARE ABLE TO DEMONSTRATE THEM TO YELL
IN ONE CHURCH. AND NOW FOR THE VERY LAST RECOLLECTION I HAVE THE
SEEN YELL, AT LEAST UNTIL YELL MANAGE TO RETRIEVE PROFESSOR
SLIGHTER'S MEMORY FOR US. TEN YEARS SEPARATES EZEKIEL'S MEMORY
AND THIS ONE, TEN YEARS DURING WHICH WE CAN ONLY GUESS AT WHAT
LORD VILDEBERT WAS DOING. HARRY GOT TO HIS FEET HENCE MORE AS
OLMEDORE EMPTIED THE LAST MEMORY INTO THE PENNIEVE. WHERE
MEMORY IS IT? HE ASKED. MINE, SAID OLMEDORE. AND HARRY DIVED
AFTER OLMEDORE THROUGH THE SHIFTING SILVER MASS, LANDING IN THE
VERY OFFICE HE HAD JUST LEFT. THERE WAS FALCON SLIMMERING HAPPILY
ON HIS PERCH, AND THERE BEHIND THE DESK WAS OLMEDORE, WHO
LOOKED VERY SIMILAR TO THE OLMEDORE STANDING BESIDE HARRY,
THOUGH BOTH HANDS WERE WHITE AND UNDAUNTED AND HIS FACE WAS,
PERHAPS, A LITTLE LESS LINED. THE ONE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN THE
PRESENT-DAY OFFICE AND THIS ONE WAS THAT IT WAS SNEAKING IN THE
PAST; BLACK FLOCKS WERE DRIFTING PAST THE WINDOWS IN THE DARK AND
BUILDING UP ON THE HILLSIDE LEDGE. THE YELLING OLMEDORE SEEMED
TO BE WAITING FOR SOMETHING, AND SOON ENOUGH, MOMENTS AFTER
THEIR ARRIVAL, THERE WAS A BANG ON THE DOOR AND HE SAID, ENTER.
HARRY LET OUT A HASTILY STIFLED GASP. VILDEBERT HAD ENTERED THE

THEY, HIS FEATURES WERE NOT THESE HARRY HAD SEEN EMERGE FROM THE GREAT STONE CALDBREIN ALMOST TWO YEARS AGO! THEY WERE NOT AS SNARL-LIKE, THE EYES WERE NOT YET SCARLET, THE FACE NOT YET MASK-LIKE, AND YET HE WAS NO LONGER HANDSOME THAN RIDDLE. IT WAS AS THOUGH HIS FEATURES HAD BEEN BURNED AND BURNED; THEY WERE WAXY AND HOLO DISTORTED, AND THE WHITES OF THE EYES NOW HAD A PERMANENTLY BLEEDY LOOK, THOUGH THE PUPILS WERE NOT YET THE SLITS THAT HARRY KNEW THEY WOULD BECOME. HE WAS WEARING A LONG BLACK CLOAK, AND HIS FACE WAS AS PALE AS THE SNOW GLISTENING ON HIS SHOULDERS. THE DUMBLEDORE BEHIND THE DESK SHOWED NO SIGN OF SURPRISE. EVIDENTLY THIS VISIT HAD BEEN MADE BY APPOINTMENT. GOOD EVENING, THEY SAID DUMBLEDORE EASILY. WHEN T'VELL SIT DOWN? THANK YOU, SAID VOLDMORT, AND HE TOOK THE SEAT THE WHICH DUMBLEDORE HAD GESTURED

THE VERY SEAT, BY THE LOOKS OF IT, THAT HARRY HAD JUST VACATED IN THE PRESENT. I HEARD THAT YOU HAD BECOME HEADMASTER, HE SAID, AND HIS VOICE WAS SLIGHTLY HIGHER AND CHILDER THAN IT HAD BEEN. A WORTHY CHOICE. I AM GLAD YOU APPROVE, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING.

MAY I OFFER YOU A DRINK? THAT WOULD BE WELCOME, SAID VOLDMORT. I HAVE COME A LONG WAY. DUMBLEDORE STOOD AND SWIFT OVER TO THE CABINET WHERE HE NOW KEPT THE PENSIVE, BUT WHICH THEN WAS FULL OF BOTTLES. HAVING HANDED VOLDMORT A GLASS OF WINE AND FILLED ONE FOR HIMSELF, HE RETURNED TO THE SEAT BEHIND HIS DESK. SEE, THEY THE WHAT DO I HAVE THE PLEASURE? VOLDMORT DID NOT ANSWER AT ONCE, BUT MERELY SIPPED HIS WINE. THEY DO NOT CALL ME THEM ANYMORE, HE SAID. THESE DAYS, I AM KNOWN AS

I KNOW WHAT YOU ARE KNOWN AS, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING PLEASANTLY. BUT TO ME, I'M AFRAID, YOU WILL ALWAYS BE THEM RIDDLE. IT IS ONE OF THE IRRITATING THINGS ABOUT OLD TEACHERS. I AM AFRAID THAT THEY NEVER WHITE FORGET THEIR CHARGES YET-FULL BEGINNINGS. HE RAISED HIS GLASS AS THOUGH THASTING VOLDMORT, WHOSE FACE REMAINED EXPRESSIONLESS. NEVERTHELESS, HARRY FELT THE ATMOSPHERE IN THE ROOM CHANGE SLIGHTLY! DUMBLEDORE'S REUSAL TO USE VOLDMORT'S CHOSEN NAME WAS A REUSAL TO ALLOW VOLDMORT TO DICTATE THE TERMS OF THE MEETING, AND HARRY COULD TELL THAT VOLDMORT TOOK IT AS SUCH. I AM SURPRISED YOU HAVE REMAINED HERE SO LONG, SAID VOLDMORT AFTER A SHORT PAUSE. I ALWAYS WONDERED WHY A WIZARD SUCH AS YOURSELF NEVER WISHED TO LEAVE SCHOOL. WELL, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STILL SMILING, THE A WIZARD SUCH AS

MYSELF, THERE CAN BE NOTHING MORE IMPORTANT THAN PASSING ON ANCIENT SKILLS, HELPING FRESH YOUNG MINDS. IF I REMEMBER CORRECTLY, YOU ONCE SAW THE ATTRACTION OF TEACHING THEM. I SEE IT STILL, SAID VELDREHT. I MERELY WONDERED WHY YOU. WE ARE SO OFTEN ASKED FOR ADVICE BY THE MINISTRY, AND WE HAVE TWICE, I THINK, BEEN HONORED THE POST OF MINISTER. THREE TIMES AT THE LAST CHOICE, ACTUALLY, SAID DUMLEDORE. BUT THE MINISTRY NEVER ATTRACTED ME AS A CAREER. AGAIN, SOMETHING WE HAVE IN COMMON, I THINK.

VELDREHT INCLINED HIS HEAD, LIPS SMILING, AND THEN ANOTHER SIP OF WINE. DUMLEDORE DID NOT BREAK THE SILENCE THAT STRETCHED BETWEEN THEM NOW, BUT WAITED, WITH A KIND OF PLEASANT EXPECTANCY, FOR VELDREHT TO TALK FIRST. I HAVE RETURNED, HE SAID, AFTER A LITTLE WHILE, LATER, PERHAPS, THAN PROFESSOR DUMPLEDORR EXPECTED. BUT I HAVE RETURNED, NEVERTHELESS, THE REBELLED AGAIN WHAT HE ONCE TOLD ME I WAS TOO YOUNG TO HAVE. I HAVE COME TO YOU TO ASK THAT YOU PERMIT ME TO RETURN TO THIS CASTLE, TO TEACH. I THINK YOU MUST KNOW THAT I HAVE SEEN AND DONE MUCH SINCE I LEFT THIS PLACE. I COULD SHOW AND TELL YOUR STUDENTS THINGS THEY CAN GAIN FROM NO OTHER WIZARD. DUMLEDORE CONSIDERED VELDREHT OVER THE TOP OF HIS ELON CHECKER FOR A WHILE BEFORE SPEAKING. YES, I CERTAINLY DO KNOW THAT YOU HAVE SEEN AND DONE MUCH SINCE LEAVING US, HE SAID FINALLY. NUMBERS OF YOUR THINGS HAVE REACHED YOUR OLD SCHOOL, THEN, I SHOULD BE SURE TO BELIEVE HALF OF THEM. VELDREHT'S EXPRESSION REMAINED IMPASSIVE AS HE SAID, GREATNESS INSPIRES ENVY, ENVY ENGENDERS SPITE, SPITE SPURNS LIES. YOU MUST KNOW THIS, DUMLEDORE. YOU CALL IT GREATNESS, WHAT YOU HAVE BEEN DOING, DO YOU? ASKED DUMLEDORE DELICATELY. CERTAINLY, SAID VELDREHT, AND HIS EYES SEEMED TO GLOW RED. I HAVE EXPERIMENTED; I HAVE PUSHED THE BOUNDARIES OF MAGIC FURTHER, PERHAPS, THAN THEY HAVE EVER BEEN PUSHED. OF SOME KINDS OF MAGIC, DUMLEDORE CORRECTED HIM FINALLY. OF SOME, OF OTHERS, YOU REMAIN FORGIVE ME COMPLETELY IGNORANT. FOR THE FIRST TIME, VELDREHT SMILED. IT WAS A TALIT BEER, AN EVIL THING, MORE THREATENING THAN A KIND OF RAGE. THE OLD ANGLIMENT, HE SAID SOFTLY. BUT NOTHING I HAVE SEEN IN THE WORLD HAS SLIPPERED YOUR FAMILIAR PREOCCUPATIONS THAT LOVE IS MORE POWERFUL THAN MY KIND OF MAGIC, DUMLEDORE.

PERHAPS YOU HAVE BEEN LOOKING IN THE WRONG PLACES, SUGGESTED DUMLEDORE. WELL, THEN, WHAT BETTER PLACE TO START MY FRESH

RESEARCHES THAN HERE, AT FIEGLWARTS? SAID VELDMEERT. WILL YOU LET ME RETURN? WILL YOU LET ME SHARE MY KNOWLEDGE WITH YOUR STUDENTS? I PLACE MYSELF AND MY TALENTS AT YOUR DISPOSAL, I AM YOURS THE COMMAND. OLMEDEHRE RAISED HIS EYEBROWS, AND WHAT WILL BECOME OF THESE WITH YOU COMMAND? WHAT WILL HAPPEN TO THESE WHO CALL THEMSELVES HER SON OLMEDEHRE HAS IT THE DEATH LATER? HARRY COULD TELL THAT VELDMEERT HAD NOT EXPECTED OLMEDEHRE TO KNOW THIS NAME; HE SAW VELDMEERT'S EYES FLASH RED AGAIN AND THE SLITLIKE NEUSTRILS FLARE. MY FRIENDS, HE SAID, AFTER A MOMENT'S PAUSE, WILL CARRY ME WITH YOU? I AM SURE, I AM GLAD TO HEAR THAT YOU CONSIDER THEM FRIENDS, SAID OLMEDEHRE. I WAS UNDER THE IMPRESSION THAT THEY ARE MORE IN THE ORDER OF SERVANTS. YOU ARE MISTAKEN, SAID VELDMEERT. THEN IF I WERE TO GO TO THE FINE & FEAR TONIGHT, I WOULD NOT FIND A GROUP OF THEM

NETT, REISTER, MULLIKER, DEEH-HEY AWAITING YOUR RETURN? DEVOTED FRIENDS INDEED, THE TRAVEL THIS FAR WITH YOU IN A SINGLE NIGHT, MERELY THE WISH YOU BLUR AS YOU ATTEMPTED TO SECURE A TEACHING POST. THERE COULD BE NO DOUBT THAT OLMEDEHRE'S DETAILED KNOWLEDGE OF THESE WITH WHOM HE WAS TRAVELING WAS EVEN LESS WELCOME TO VELDMEERT; HOWEVER, HE RALLIED ALMOST AT ONCE. YOU ARE HUMILIANT AS EVER, OLMEDEHRE. HE IS MERELY FRIENDLY WITH THE LOCAL KARMEN, SAID OLMEDEHRE LIGHTLY. NOW, THEN OLMEDEHRE SET DOWN HIS EMPTY GLASS AND DREW HIMSELF UP IN HIS SEAT, THE TIPS OF HIS FINGERS TOGETHER IN A VERY CHARACTERISTIC GESTURE. LET US SPEAK HONESTLY, WHY HAVE YOU COME HERE TONIGHT, SURVEILLED BY HENCHMEN, THE REEDEST & THE WE KEITH KNOW YOU DO NOT WANT? VELDMEERT LOOKED CHILDLY SURPRISED. A THE I DO NOT WANT? THEN THE CONTRARY, OLMEDEHRE, I WANT IT VERY MUCH. HE, YOU WANT TO COME BACK TO FIEGLWARTS, BUT YOU DO NOT WANT THE TRAIL AND MORE THAN YOU WANTED THE WHEN YOU WERE EIGHTEEN. WHAT IS IT YOU ARE AFTER, THEN? WHY NOT TRY AN HONEST REEDEST FOR ONCE? VELDMEERT SNICKERED. IF YOU DO NOT WANT TO GIVE ME A THE CHANCE I DON'T, SAID OLMEDEHRE, AND I DON'T THINK FOR A MOMENT YOU EXPECTED ME TO. NEVERTHELESS, YOU CAME HERE, YOU ASKED, YOU MUST HAVE HAD A PURPOSE. VELDMEERT STOOD UP, HE LOOKED LESS LIKE THE RIDDLE THAN EVER, HIS FEATURES THICK WITH RAGE. THIS IS YOUR FINAL WORD? IT IS, SAID OLMEDEHRE, ALSO STANDING. THEN WE HAVE NOTHING MORE TO SAY TO EACH OTHER. NO, NOTHING, SAID

OLMPLEBHERE, AND A GREAT SADNESS FILLED HIS FACE. THE TIME IS LONG
GONE WHEN I COULD FRIGHTEN YOU WITH A CURNING WARDROBE AND
FUR YOU THE MAKE REPAYMENT FOR YOUR CRIMES, BUT I WISH I COULD,
THEM. I WISH I COULD. FOR A SECOND, HARRY WAS IN THE VERGE
OF SPEAKING A PUNTING WARNING: HE WAS SURE THAT VERBEMERT'S
HAND HAD TWITCHED TOWARD HIS POCKET AND HIS WAND, BUT THEN THE
MOMENT HAD PASSED, VERBEMERT HAD TURNED AWAY, THE DEER WAS
BLESSING, AND HE WAS GONE. HARRY FELT OLMPLEBHERE'S HAND CLASP EVER
HIS ARM AGAIN AND MOMENTS LATER, THEY WERE STANDING TOGETHER IN
ALMOST THE SAME SPOT, BUT THERE WAS NOW SOME BUILDING IN THE
WINDING LEDGE, AND OLMPLEBHERE'S HAND WAS BLACKENED AND DEAD-
LOOKING SINCE THEN. WHY? SAID HARRY AT ONCE, LOOKING UP INTO
OLMPLEBHERE'S FACE. WHY DID HE COME BACK? DID YOU EVER FIND HIM? I
HAVE IDEAS, SAID OLMPLEBHERE, BUT NOT MORE THAN THAT. WHAT
IDEAS, SIR? I SHALL TELL YOU, HARRY, WHEN YOU HAVE RETRIEVED THAT
MEMBER FROM PROFESSOR SLIGHTHORN, SAID OLMPLEBHERE. WHEN YOU
HAVE THAT LAST PIECE OF THE PUZZLE, EVERYTHING WILL, I HOPE, BE CLEAR

THE REST OF US. HARRY WAS STILL CURNING WITH CLIMBING AND
EVEN THOUGH OLMPLEBHERE HAD WALKED THE DEER AND WAS FEELING
IT OPEN FOR HIM, HE DID NOT MOVE AT ONCE. WAS HE AFTER THE DEFENSE
AGAINST THE DARK ARTS THE AGAIN, SIR? HE DIDN'T SAY. YES, HE
DEFINITELY WANTED THE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS THE, SAID
OLMPLEBHERE. THE AFTERMATH OF YOUR LITTLE MEETING PROVED THAT,
YOU SEE, WE HAVE NEVER BEEN ABLE TO KEEP A DEFENSE AGAINST THE
DARK ARTS TEACHER FOR LONGER THAN A YEAR SINCE I REPLIED THE POST
THE LORD VERBEMERT. THE UNRELIABLE ROOM HARRY WRACKED HIS
BRAINS OVER THE NEXT WEEK AS HE FELT HE WAS THE PERSUADE
SLIGHTHORN THE HAND OVER THE TRUE MEMBER, BUT NOTHING IN THE
NATURE OF A BRAIN HAVE COLLAPSED AND HE WAS REDUCED TO DOING WHAT
HE DID INCREASINGLY THESE DAYS WHEN AT A LOSS: PHRASE OVER HIS
POTIONS BOOK, HOPING THAT THE PRINCE WOULD HAVE STRICKEN
SOMETHING USEFUL IN A MARGIN, AS HE HAD DONE SO MANY TIMES BEFORE.

YOU WON'T FIND ANYTHING IN THERE, SAID HERMIONE FIRMLY, LATE IN
SUNDAY EVENING. DON'T START, HERMIONE, SAID HARRY. IF IT HADN'T
BEEN FOR THE PRINCE, YOU WOULDN'T BE SITTING HERE NOW. HE WOULD
IF YOU'D JUST LISTENED TO THE SNAPE IN YOUR FIRST YEAR, SAID HERMIONE
DISMISSIVELY. HARRY IGNORED HER. HE HAD JUST FELT AN INCANTATION
(SECTUMSEMPRA!) SCRIBBLED IN A MARGIN ABOVE THE INTRIGUING

WHIRLS FOR ENEMIES, AND WAS ITCHING THE TROUPE IT FELT, BUT THOUGHT IT
BEST NOT TO BE IN FRONT OF HERMIONE. INSTEAD, HE SLURP-TITILIOUSLY
FISHED DOWN THE CORNER OF THE PAGE. THEY WERE SITTING BESIDE THE
FIRE IN THE COMMON ROOM; THE ONLY OTHER PEOPLE AWAKE WERE
FELLAS SIXTY YEARS. THERE HAD BEEN A CERTAIN AMOUNT OF EXCITEMENT
EARLIER WHEN THEY HAD COME BACK FROM DINNER TO FIND A NEW SIGN ON
THE NOTICE BOARD THAT ANNOUNCED THE DATE FOR THEIR APPARITION
TEST. THESE WERE WOULD BE SEVENTEEN AND HER BEFORE THE FIRST TEST
DATE, THE TWENTY-FIRST OF APRIL, HAD THE OPTION OF SIGNING UP FOR
ADDITIONAL PRACTICE SESSIONS, WHICH WOULD TAKE PLACE HEAVILY
SUPERVISED IN HOGSWARTS. RON HAD PANICKED ON READING THIS
NOTICE; HE HAD STILL NOT MANAGED TO APPARATE AND FEARED HE WOULD
NOT BE READY FOR THE TEST. HERMIONE, WHO HAD NOW ACHIEVED
APPARITION TWICE, WAS A LITTLE MORE CONFIDENT, BUT HARRY, WHO
WOULD NOT BE SEVENTEEN FOR ANOTHER FEW MONTHS, COULD NOT TAKE
THE TEST YET. READY OR NOT. AT LEAST YOU CAN APPARATE,
THOUGHT. SAID RON TENSELY, YOU'LL HAVE NO TROUBLE COME JULY?

I'VE ONLY DONE IT ONCE, HARRY REMINDED HIM; HE HAD FINALLY
MANAGED TO DISAPPEAR AND REMATERIALIZE INSIDE HIS FURROW DURING
THEIR PREVIOUS LESSON. HAVING WASTED A LOT OF TIME WHIRRYING
AROUND ABOUT APPARITION, RON WAS NOW STRUGGLING TO FINISH A
VICIOUSLY DIFFICULT ESSAY FOR Snape that HARRY AND HERMIONE HAD
ALREADY COMPLETED. HARRY FULLY EXPECTED THE RECEIPT WHEN MARKS ON
HIS, BECAUSE HE HAD DISAGREED WITH Snape ON THE BEST WAY TO TACKLE
DEMENTORS, BUT HE DID NOT CARE. SILENTLY'S MEMORY WAS THE MOST
IMPORTANT THING TO HIM NOW. I'M TELLING YOU, THE STUPID PRINCE
ISN'T GOING TO BE ABLE TO HELP YOU WITH THIS, HARRY. SAID
HERMIONE, MORE HEEDFULLY. THERE'S ONLY ONE WAY TO FORCE SOMEONE
TO DO WHAT YOU WANT, AND THAT'S THE IMPERIOUS CURSE, WHICH IS
ILLEGAL. Yeah, I KNOW THAT, THANKS, SAID HARRY, NOT LEANING
UP FROM THE SEAT. THAT'S WHY I'M LEARNING FOR SOMETHING
DIFFERENT. DUMBLEDORE SAYS VERITASERUM WHEN YOU DO IT, BUT THERE
MIGHT BE SOMETHING ELSE, A POTION OR A SPELL. YOU'RE GOING
ABOUT IT THE WRONG WAY, SAID HERMIONE. ONLY YOU CAN GET THE
MEMORY, DUMBLEDORE SAYS. THAT MUST MEAN YOU CAN PERSUADE
SILENTLY WHERE OTHER PEOPLE CAN'T. IT'S NOT A QUESTION OF
SLIPPING HIM A POTION, ANYONE COULD DO THAT. HOW'D YOU
SPELL BELLIGERENT? SAID RON, SHAKING HIS HEAD VERY HARD WHILE

STARING AT HIS PARCHEMENT, IT CAN'T BE B L M NEH IT
 ISN'T, SAID FERMINE, PULLING REH'S ESSAY TOWARD HER, AND
 ALGELY DEESN'T BEGIN EH R E EITHER, WHAT KIND OF HELLL ARE
 YELL LISTING? IT'S HERE OF FRED AND GEORGE'S SPELL-CHICK HENS
 BUT I THINK THE CHARM MUST BE WEARING OFF, YES, IT MUST, SAID
 FERMINE, POINTING AT THE TITLE OF HIS ESSAY, BECAUSE WE WERE
 ASKED WHEN WE'D DEAL WITH DEMENTHERS, NOT DUCKIES, AND I DEEN'T
 REMEMBER YELL CHANGING YELLER NAME THE RHEENIL WAZLIK EITHER.
 AH NEH? SAID REH, STARING FERRRRR-STRIKED AT THE PARCHEMENT,
 DEEN'T SAY I LL HAVE THE WRITE THE WHOLE THING HLT AGAIN? IT'S
 HEDAY, WE CAN FIX IT, SAID FERMINE, PULLING THE ESSAY TOWARD HER
 AND TAKING HLT HER HAND, I LOVE YELL, FERMINE, SAID REH,
 SINKING BACK IN HIS CHAIR, RUBBING HIS EYES WEARILY, FERMINE
 TURNED FAINTLY PINK, BUT MERELY SAID, DEEN'T LET LAVENDER HEAR YELL
 SAYING THAT, I WEN'T, SAID REH IN THE HIS HANDS, EH MAYBE I WILL
 THEN SHE LL DITCH ME WHY DEEN'T YELL DITCH HER IF YELL WANT
 THE FINISH IT? ASKED HARRY, YELL HAVEN'T EVER CHICKED ANYONE,
 HAVE YELL? SAID REH, YELL AND CHE ILST SHIRT HE FELL APART,
 YEAY, SAID HARRY WISH THAT WOULD HAPPEN WITH ME AND
 LAVENDER, SAID REH GLENNILY, WATCHING FERMINE SILENTLY
 TAPPING EACH OF HIS MISPELLED WORDS WITH THE END OF HER HAND, SEE
 THAT THEY CORRECTED THEMSELVES EN THE PAGE, BUT THE MORE I HINT I
 WANT THE FINISH IT, THE TIGHTER SHE HELDS EN, IT'S LIKE CHING HLT
 WITH THE GIANT SHLID, THERE, SAID FERMINE, SOME TWENTY
 MINUTES LATER, HANDING BACK REH'S ESSAY, THANKS A MILLION, SAID
 REH, CAN I KERRRRL YELLER HELLL FOR THE CHICKLISTING? HARRY, WHO
 HAD FELT NOTHING USEFUL IN THE HALF-BLEND PRINCE'S NOTES SHE FOR,
 BLENDING AROUND, THE THREE OF THEM WERE NOW THE ONLY HENS LEFT IN
 THE CHEMEN RHEM, SCAPUS HAVING ILST CHINE UP THE RED CURSING
 SNAPE AND HIS ESSAY, THE ONLY SHLIDS WERE THE CRACKLING OF THE
 FIRE AND REH SCRATCHING HLT HEN LAST PARAGRAPH EN DEMENTHERS
 LISTING FERMINE'S HELLL, HARRY HAD ILST CLESED THE HALF-BLEND
 PRINCE'S RHEM, YALVING, WHEN CRACK, FERMINE LET HLT A LITTLE
 SHRIEK, REH SPILLED INDE ALL OVER HIS FRESHLY COMPLETED ESSAY, AND
 HARRY SAID, DREACHER! THE FEELSE-ELF KEHED LEW AND ADDRESSED HIS
 ELIN ENARLED THEES, MASTER SAID HE WANTED REGULAR REPORTS EN
 WHAT THE MALPHY RHY IS BEING, SEE DREACHER HAS COME THE GIVE
 CRACK, DEEY APPEARED ALONGSIDE DREACHER, HIS TEA-CHY HAT ASKEW,

DREACHER HAS BEEN HELPING THEM, FARRY PITTER? HE SHELDRED, CASTING DREACHER A RESENTFUL LOOK. AND DREACHER MIGHT TELL THEM WHEN HE IS CHEMING THE SEE FARRY PITTER SHE THEY CAN MAKE THEIR REPORTS TOGETHER? WHAT IS THIS? ASKED FERMINE, STILL BLEEDING SHOCKED BY THESE SUDDEN APPEARANCES. WHAT IS GOING ON, FARRY? FARRY HESITATED BEFORE ANSWERING, BECAUSE HE HAD NOT TOLD FERMINE ABOUT SETTING DREACHER AND DRECKY THE TAIL MALPHY. FOLLY-FLYES WERE ALWAYS SUCH A THICKLY SUBJECT WITH HER. WELL THEY VE BEEN FOLLOWING MALPHY FOR ME, HE SAID. NIGHT AND DAY, CROAKED DREACHER. DRECKY HAS NOT SLEPT FOR A WEEK, FARRY PITTER? SAID DRECKY PRUDLY, STAYING WHERE HE STOOD. FERMINE BLEEDED INDIGNANT. WHY HAVEN T SLEPT, DRECKY? BUT SURELY, FARRY, WHY DIDN T TELL HIM NOT THE NO, HE CHIRSE I DIDN T, SAID FARRY BELICIOUSLY. DRECKY, WHY CAN SLEEP, ALL RIGHT? BUT HAS EITHER OF YOU FOUND OUT ANYTHING? HE HASTENED THE ASK, BEFORE FERMINE COULD INTERVENE AGAIN. MASTER MALPHY MOVES WITH A NEIGHLY THAT BEATS HIS PURE BLEED, CROAKED DREACHER AT ONCE. HIS FEATURES RECALL THE FINE LINES OF MY MISTRESS AND HIS MANNERS ARE THOSE OF

DRACH MALPHY IS A BAD KID? SHELDRED DRECKY ANGRILY. A BAD KID WHO WHO HE SHEDDERED FROM THE TASSEL OF HIS TEA CHAY THE THE THE OF HIS SHEDS AND THEN RAN AT THE FIRE, AS THOUGH ABOUT THE DIVE INTO IT; FARRY, THE WHO THIS WAS NOT ENTIRELY UNEXPECTED, CALLED HIM ABOUT THE MIDDLE AND HELD HIM FAST, FOR A FEW SECONDS DRECKY STRUGGLED, THEN WENT LIMP. THANK YOU, FARRY PITTER, HE PANTED. DRECKY STILL FINDS IT DIFFICULT TO SPEAK TO HIS OLD MASTERS.

FARRY RELEASED HIM; DRECKY STRAIGHTENED HIS TEA CHAY AND SAID DEFIANTLY TO DREACHER, BUT DREACHER SHOULD KNOW THAT DRACH MALPHY IS NOT A GOOD MASTER THE A FOLLY-FLY? YES, WE DON T NEED THE HEAR ABOUT YOU BEING IN LOVE WITH MALPHY, FARRY TOLD DREACHER. LET S GO FORWARD THE WHERE HE S ACTUALLY BEEN GOING. DREACHER BLEED AGAIN, BLEEDING FLIRTELIS, AND THEN SAID, MASTER MALPHY EATS IN THE GREAT HALL, HE SLEEPS IN A DORMITORY IN THE DUNGEONS, HE ATTENDS HIS CLASSES IN A VARIETY OF DRECKY, WHY TELL ME, SAID FARRY, CUTTING ACROSS DREACHER. HAS HE BEEN GOING ANYWHERE HE SHOULDN T HAVE? FARRY PITTER, SIR, SHELDRED DRECKY, HIS GREAT HERRING EYES SHINING IN THE FIRELIGHT, THE MALPHY KID IS BREAKING NEW RULES THAT DRECKY CAN DISCOVER, BUT HE IS STILL BEEN THE AVOID DETECTION, HE HAS BEEN MAKING REGULAR VISITS THE THE

SEVENTH FLOOR WITH A VARIETY OF OTHER STUDENTS, WHO KEEP WATCH FOR HIM WHILE HE ENTERS. THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT? SAID HARRY, SMACKING HIMSELF HARD ON THE FOREHEAD WITH ADVANCED PENTHEN-MARKING. HERMIONE AND RON STARED AT HIM. THAT'S WHERE HE'S BEEN SNEAKING OFF TO? THAT'S WHERE HE'S BEING? WHATEVER HE'S DOING? AND I GET THAT'S WHY HE'S BEEN DISAPPEARING OFF THE MAP? COME THE THING OF IT, I'VE NEVER SEEN THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT WHEN THERE? MAYBE THE MARAUDERS NEVER KNEW THE ROOM WAS THERE, SAID RON. I THINK IT LL BE PART OF THE MAGIC OF THE ROOM, SAID HERMIONE. IF YOU NEED IT THE RE UNDOUBTABLE, IT WILL BE. DICKY, HAVE YOU MANAGED TO GET IN THE HAVE A LOOK AT WHAT MALPHY'S DOING? SAID HARRY EAGERLY. NO, HARRY BETTER, THAT IS IMPOSSIBLE, SAID DICKY. NO, IT'S NOT, SAID HARRY AT ONCE. MALPHY GOT INTO HIS HEADQUARTERS THERE LAST YEAR, SEE I LL BE ABLE TO GET IN AND SPY ON HIM, NO PROBLEM. BUT I DON'T THINK YOU WILL, HARRY, SAID HERMIONE SLEELY. MALPHY ALREADY KNOWS EXACTLY HOW WE WERE LISTING THE ROOM, DIDN'T HE, BECAUSE THAT STUPID MARIETTA HAD BLABBED, HE NEEDED THE ROOM TO REFORM THE HEADQUARTERS OF THE DA, SEE IT DID, BUT YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT THE ROOM REFORMS WHEN MALPHY GOES IN THERE, SEE YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT THE ASK IT THE TRANSFORM INTO.

THERE LL BE A WAY AROUND THAT, SAID HARRY DISMISSIVELY. YOU'VE DONE BRILLIANTLY, DICKY. DREACHER'S DONE WELL TOO, SAID HERMIONE KINDLY, BUT FAR FROM BEING GRATEFUL, DREACHER AVERTED HIS FACE, BLINKED-SHUT EYES AND CRASHED AT THE CEILING. THE MUDSLIM IS SPREADING THE DREACHER, DREACHER WILL PRETEND HE CANNOT HEAR

GET OUT OF IT, HARRY SNAPPED AT HIM, AND DREACHER MADE ONE LAST DEEP BOW AND DISAPPEARED. YOU'D BETTER GO AND GET SOME SLEEP TOO, DICKY. THANK YOU, HARRY BETTER, SIR? SNEEZED DICKY HAPPILY, AND HE TOO VANISHED. HOW COME'S THIS? SAID HARRY ENTHUSIASTICALLY, TURNING TO RON AND HERMIONE THE MOMENT THE ROOM WAS UP-FREE AGAIN. WE KNOW WHERE MALPHY'S GOING! WE'VE GOT HIM CORNERED NOW! YEAH, IT'S GREAT, SAID RON GULLIBLY, WHO WAS ATTEMPTING TO MEET UP THE SHEDDEN MASS OF INK THAT HAD RECENTLY BEEN AN ALMOST COMPLETED ESSAY. HERMIONE PULLED IT TOWARD HER AND BEGAN SPOONING THE INK OFF WITH HER HAND. BUT WHAT'S ALL THIS ABOUT HIM GOING UP THERE WITH A VARIETY OF STUDENTS? SAID HERMIONE. HOW MANY PEOPLE ARE IN IN IT? YOU WOULDN'T THINK HE'D TRUST LETS OF THEM TO KNOW WHAT HE'S DOING.

Yeah, that is weird, said Harry, frowning. I heard him telling Crake it wasn't Crake's business what he was doing. She what's he telling all these all these Harry's voice tailed away; he was staring at the fire. Good, I've been stupid, he said quietly. It's inevitable, isn't it? There was a great vat of it down in the dungeons. He could've nicked some any time during that lesson. Nicked what? said Ben. Philbrick Penthren. He stole some of the Philbrick Penthren Sledgehorn shield as in his first Penthren's lesson. There aren't a whole variety of students standing guard for Malady. It's just Crake and Goolie as usual.

Yeah, it all fits! said Harry, jumping up and starting the pace in front of the fire. They're stupid enough to see what they're told even if he doesn't tell them what he's up to. But he doesn't want them to be seen working around outside the Room of Requirement, so he's got them taking Philbrick the make them look like other people. These two girls I saw him with when he missed Eliditch. Ha! Crake and Goolie! Oh well, mean the say, said Hermione in a hushed voice, that that little girl whose scales I repaired? Yeah, of course! said Harry loudly, staring at her. Of course! Malady must've been inside the Room at the time, she said. What am I talking about? He dropped the scales to tell Malady not to come out, because there was something there! And there was that girl who dropped the threadspun then! We've been walking past him all the time and not realizing it!

He's got Crake and Goolie transforming into girls? Guffawed Ben. Right. No wonder they don't look like Harry these days.

I'm surprised they don't tell him the stuff. Well, they wouldn't, would they, if he's shown them his Dark Mark? said Harry. Hmm. The Dark Mark we don't know exists, said Hermione skeptically, rolling up Ben's dried essay before it could come to any more harm and handing it to him. We'll see, said Harry confidently. Yes, we will, Hermione said, getting to her feet and stretching. But, Harry, before you get all excited, I still don't think you'll be able to get into the Room of Requirement without knowing what's there first. And I don't think you should forget. She heaved her bag onto her shoulder and gave him a very serious look. That what you're supposed to be concentrating on is getting that memory from Sledgehorn. Good.

NIGHT. HARRY WATCHED HER GO, FEELING SLIGHTLY DISORIENTED. SINCE THE OTHER THE GIRLS DORMITORIES HAD CLOSED BEHIND HER HE REHENDED HIS ROOM. WHAT SHOULD HE THINK? WISH I COULD DISAPPEAR LIKE A FLEET-FLY, SAID REEN, STARING AT THE SPOT WHERE DEEKY HAD VANISHED. I DO HAVE THAT APPARITION TEST IN THE BAG. HARRY DID NOT SLEEP WELL THAT NIGHT. HE LAY AWAKE FOR WHAT FELT LIKE HOURS, WONDERING HOW MALFOY WAS USING THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT AND WHAT HE, HARRY, WOULD SEE WHEN HE WENT IN THERE THE FOLLOWING DAY, FOR WHATEVER HERMIONE SAID, HARRY WAS SURE THAT IF MALFOY HAD BEEN ABLE TO SEE THE HEADQUARTERS OF THE DA, HE WOULD BE ABLE TO SEE MALFOY'S WHAT COULD IT BE? A MEETING PLACE? A HIDEOUT? A STOREROOM? A WORKSHOP? HARRY'S MIND WHIRLED FEVERISHLY AND HIS DREAMS, WHEN HE FINALLY FELL ASLEEP, WERE BREEZEN AND DISTURBED BY IMAGES OF MALFOY, WHO TURNED INTO SILENT, WHO TURNED INTO SNAKE. HARRY WAS IN A STATE OF GREAT ANTICIPATION OVER BREAKFAST THE FOLLOWING MORNING; HE HAD A FREE PERIOD BEFORE DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS AND WAS DETERMINED TO SPEND IT TRYING TO GET INTO THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT. HERMIONE WAS RATHER ESENTATIALLY SHOWING NO INTEREST IN HIS WHISPERED PLANS FOR FORGING ENTRY INTO THE ROOM, WHICH IRRITATED HARRY, BECAUSE HE THOUGHT SHE MIGHT BE A LIE OF HELP IF SHE WANTED TO.

WHEN HE SAID QUIETLY, LEANING FORWARD AND PLACING A HAND ON THE DAILY PROPHET, WHICH SHE HAD JUST REMOVED FROM A POST BOX, TO STOP HER FROM OPENING IT AND VANISHING BEHIND IT. I HAVEN'T FORGOTTEN ABOUT SILENT, BUT I HAVEN'T GOT A CLUE HOW TO GET THAT MEMORY OFF HIM, AND UNTIL I GET A BRAIN WAVE WHO SHOULD I FIND OUT WHAT MALFOY'S DOING? I'VE ALREADY TOLD YOU, YOU NEED TO PERSUADE SILENT, SAID HERMIONE. IT'S NOT A HOLSTEIN OF TRICKING HIM OR KIDNAPPING HIM, OR DUMBLEDORE COULD HAVE DONE IT IN A SECOND. INSTEAD OF MESSING AROUND OUTSIDE THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT SHE TOOK THE PROPHET OUT FROM UNDER HARRY'S HAND AND UNFOLDED IT TO REEN AT THE FRONT PAGE. YOU SHOULD GO AND FIND SILENT AND START APPEALING TO HIS BETTER NATURE.

ANYONE WE KNOW? ASKED REEN, AS HERMIONE SCANNED THE HEADLINES. YES, SAID HERMIONE, CALLING BOTH HARRY AND REEN TO THE CAFE FOR THEIR BREAKFAST. BUT IT'S ALL RIGHT, HE'S NOT DEAD IT'S MUNDANE, HE'S BEEN ARRESTED AND SENT TO AZKABAN! SOMETHING TO DO WITH IMPERSONATING AN IMPERILS DURING AN ATTEMPTED

KLINGLARY AND SHEPHERD CALLED ECTAVILIS PEPPER HAS VANISHED, EET, AND EEN EHRRIKE, A NINE-YEAR-OLD KID HAS BEEN ARRESTED FOR TRYING THE KILL HIS GRANDPARENTS, THEY THINK HE WAS UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE. THEY FINISHED THEIR BREAKFAST IN SILENCE, E-TERMININE SET OFF IMMEDIATELY FOR ANCIENT ROLINES, THEN FOR THE CHYMEN ROOM, WHERE HE STILL HAD TO FINISH HIS CHUCKLISHEN AND SNAP & DEMENTER ESSAY, AND E-JARRY FOR THE CHIRIDHER AND THE SEVENTH FLEER AND THE STRETCH OF WALL OPPOSITE THE TAPESTRY OF KARNARAS THE KARMY TEACHING TRILLS THE DEE KALLET, E-JARRY SLIPPED INTO HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK SINCE HE HAD FOUND AN EMPTY PASSAGE, BUT HE NEED NOT HAVE WHEATHERED, WHEN HE REACHED HIS DESTINATION HE FOUND IT DESERTED, E-JARRY WAS NOT SURE WHETHER HIS CHANCES OF GETTING INSIDE THE ROOM WERE BETTER WITH MALPHY INSIDE IT OR NOT, BUT AT LEAST HIS FIRST ATTEMPT WAS NOT GOING TO BE COMPLICATED BY THE PRESENCE OF CRABBE OR CHYDE PRETENDING TO BE AN ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD GIRL, HE CLOSED HIS EYES AS HE APPROACHED THE PLACE WHERE THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT & DEER WAS CONCEALED, HE KNEW WHAT HE HAD TO DO, HE HAD BECOME MOST ACCOMPLISHED AT IT LAST YEAR, CONCENTRATING WITH ALL HIS MIGHT HE THOUGHT, I NEED TO SEE WHAT MALPHY & DEER IS DOING IN HERE. I NEED TO SEE WHAT MALPHY & DEER IS DOING IN HERE. I NEED TO SEE WHAT MALPHY & DEER IS DOING IN HERE. THREE TIMES HE WALKED PAST THE DEER, THEN, HIS HEART POUNDING WITH EXCITEMENT, HE OPENED HIS EYES AND FACED IT BUT HE WAS STILL LOOKING AT A STRETCH OF MUNDANELY BLANK WALL, HE MOVED FORWARD AND GAVE IT AN EXPERIMENTAL POLISH, THE STONE REMAINED SHINY AND UNCHANGING, EDEAR, SAID E-JARRY ALIQUID, EDEAR I THOUGHT THE WRONG THING, HE Pondered FOR A MOMENT THEN SET OFF AGAIN, EYES CLOSED, CONCENTRATING AS HARD AS HE COULD, I NEED TO SEE THE PLACE WHERE MALPHY KEEPS HIDING SECRETLY, I NEED TO SEE THE PLACE WHERE MALPHY KEEPS HIDING SECRETLY, AFTER THREE WALKS PAST, HE OPENED HIS EYES EXPECTANTLY, THERE WAS NO DEER, EET, COME OFF IT, HE THUD THE WALL IRRITABLY, THAT WAS A CLEAR INSTRUCTION, FINE HE THOUGHT HARD FOR SEVERAL MINUTES BEFORE STRIDING OFF ONCE MORE, I NEED TO SEE THE PLACE WHERE MALPHY KEEPS HIDING SECRETLY, HE DID NOT IMMEDIATELY OPEN HIS EYES WHEN HE HAD FINISHED HIS PATROLLING, HE WAS LISTENING HARD, AS THOUGH HE MIGHT HEAR THE DEER PEEP INTO EXISTENCE, HE HEARD NOTHING, HOWEVER, EXCEPT THE DISTANT TWITTERING OF BIRDS ELTISIDE,

He opened his eyes. There was still no one. Harry swore. Something screamed. He looked around the see a gaggle of first years running back around the corner, apparently under the impression that they had just encountered a particularly unpleasant ghost. Harry tried every variation of I need the see what Draco Malfoy is doing inside your that he could think of for a while longer, at the end of which he was forced to check that Hermione might have had a point: The room simply did not want to open for him. Frustrated and annoyed, he set off for Defense Against the Dark Arts, pulling off his invisibility cloak and stuffing it into his bag as he went. Late again, Potter, said Snape coldly, as Harry hurried into the candlelit classroom. Ten points from Gryffindor. Harry scowled at Snape as he flung himself into the seat beside Ron; half the class was still on its feet, taking out books and organizing their things; he could not be much later than any of them. Before we start, I want your Remembrance essays, said Snape, waving his wand carelessly, see that twenty-five scrolls of parchment shared into the air and landed in a neat pile on his desk. And I hope your other sacks they are better than the trip I had the end of my resisting the Imperius Curse. Well, if you will all open your books the page what is it, Mr. Finnigan? Sir, said Seamus, I've been wondering, how do you tell the difference between an Imperius and a ghost? Because there was something in the paper about an Imperius. No, there wasn't, said Snape in a bored voice. But sir, I heard people talking. If you had actually read the article in Hogshead, Mr. Finnigan, you would have known that the so-called Imperius was nothing but a smelly sneeze thief by the name of Mindbender Fletcher. I thought Snape and Mindbender were on the same side, muttered Harry the Ron and Hermione. Shouldn't he be upset Mindbender has been arrested. But Potter seems to have a left the say on the subject, said Snape, pointing suddenly at the back of the room, his black eyes fixed on Harry. Let us ask Potter how we would tell the difference between an Imperius and a ghost. The whole class looked around at Harry, who hastily tried to recall what Dumbledore had told him the night that they had gone to visit Slughorn. Er well ghosts are transparent he said. Oh, very good, interrupted Snape, his lip curling. Yes, it

IS EASY TO SEE THAT NEARLY SIX YEARS OF MAGICAL EDUCATION HAVE NOT BEEN WASTED ON YET, BETTER. GHOSTS ARE TRANSPARENT. PANSY PARKINSON LET OUT A HIGH-PITCHED GIGGLE. SEVERAL OTHER PEOPLE WERE SMIRKING. HARRY TOOK A DEEP BREATH AND CONTINUED CALMLY, THOUGH HIS INSIDES WERE REILING. YES, GHOSTS ARE TRANSPARENT, BUT INFERI ARE DEAD BODIES, AREN'T THEY? SHE THEY'D BE SHED A FIVE-YEAR-OLD CHILD HAVE THEM AS MUCH, SNEERED SNAPE. THE INFERIUS IS A CORPSE THAT HAS BEEN REANIMATED BY A DARK WIZARD'S SPELLS. IT IS NOT ALIVE, IT IS MERELY USED LIKE A PUPPET THE THE WIZARD'S KIDDING. A GHOST, AS I TRUST THAT YOU ARE ALL AWARE BY NOW, IS THE IMPRINT OF A DEPARTED SOUL LEFT UPON THE EARTH AND OF COURSE, AS BETTER SHE WISELY TELLS US, TRANSPARENT. WELL, WHAT HARRY SAID IS THE MOST USEFUL IF WE'RE TRYING TO TELL THEM APART? SAID REEN. WHEN WE COME FACE-TO-FACE WITH ONE DOWN A DARK ALLEY, WE'RE GOING TO BE HAVING A SLIGHT TO SEE IF IT'S SHED, AREN'T WE, WE'RE NOT GOING TO BE ASKING, EXCUSE ME, ARE YOU THE IMPRINT OF A DEPARTED SOUL? THERE WAS A RIPPLE OF LAUGHTER, INSTANTLY SUPPRESSED BY THE LEAD SNAPE CALLED THE CLASS. ANOTHER TEN POINTS FROM GRYFFINDOR, SAID SNAPE. I WOULD EXPECT NOTHING MORE SOPHISTICATED FROM YOU, RONALD WEASLEY, THE ONLY ONE WHO CAN'T APPARATE HALF AN INCH ACROSS A ROOM. NOW, WE'VE DISCUSSED DETERMINING, CRACKING HARRY'S ARM AS HE OPENED HIS MOUTH FLURRIEDLY. THERE'S ONE POINT, YOU'LL JUST END UP IN DETENTION AGAIN, LEAVE IT! NOW OPEN YOUR BOOKS THE PAGE TWO HUNDRED AND THIRTEEN, SAID SNAPE, SMIRKING A LITTLE, AND READ THE FIRST TWO PARAGRAPHS OF THE CURRICULUM COURSE. REEN WAS VERY SILENT ALL THROUGH THE CLASS. WHEN THE BELL SOUNDED AT THE END OF THE LESSON, LAVENDER CALLED UP WITH REEN AND HARRY DETERMINED MYSTERIOUSLY MELTED OUT OF SIGHT AS SHE APPROACHED AND GLANCED SNAPE HEFTY FOR HIS LIKE ABOUT REEN'S APPARITION, BUT THIS SEEMED TO MERELY IRRITATE REEN, AND HE SENT HER OFF BY MAKING A DETOUR INTO THE BOYS' BATHROOM WITH HARRY. SNAPE'S RIGHT, THOUGH, ISN'T HE? SAID REEN, AFTER STARING INTO A CRACKED MIRROR FOR A MINUTE OR TWO. I DUNNO WHETHER IT'S WORTH ME TAKING THE TEST. I JUST CAN'T GET THE HANG OF APPARITION. YOU MIGHT AS WELL DO THE EXTRA PRACTICE SESSIONS IN HOGSWARTS AND SEE WHERE THEY GET YOU, SAID HARRY REASONABLY. IT'LL BE MORE INTERESTING THAN TRYING TO GET INTO A STUPID HIMP ANYWAY. THEN, IF YOU'RE STILL NOT YOU

KNOW AS GOOD AS YOU'D LIKE THEE, YOU CAN POSTPONE THE TEST, BE IT WITH ME EVER THE SLIP. MYRTLE, THIS IS THE KID'S BATHROOM? THE GUEST OF A GIRL HAD RISEN UP IN THE THICKET IN A CLICKLE BEHIND THEM AND WAS NOW FLEETING IN MIDAIR, STARING AT THEM THROUGH THICK, WHITE, RINGED GLASSES. EH, SHE SAID CALMLY, IT'S YOU TWO. WERE YOU EXPECTING? SAID BEN, LOOKING AT HER IN THE MIRROR. NEITHER, SAID MYRTLE, PICKING UPHELDLY AT A SPOT ON HER CHIN. HE SAID HE'D COME BACK AND SEE ME, BUT THEN YOU SAID YOU'D BE IN AND VISIT ME THEN. SHE GAVE HARRY A REPROACHFUL LOOK

AND I HAVEN'T SEEN YOU FOR MONTHS AND MONTHS, I'VE LEARNED NOT TO EXPECT THEM MUCH FROM KIDS. I THOUGHT YOU LIVED IN THAT GIRL'S BATHROOM? SAID HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN CAREFULLY THE GIVE THE PLACE A WIDE BERTH FOR SOME YEARS NOW. I DEE, SHE SAID, WITH A SLIDY LITTLE SMILE, BUT THAT DOESN'T MEAN I CAN'T VISIT EITHER PLACES, I CAME AND SAW YOU IN YOUR BATH HOUSE, REMEMBER?

VIVIDLY, SAID HARRY, BUT I THOUGHT HE LIKED ME, SHE SAID PLAINLY. MAYBE IF YOU TWO LEFT, HE'D COME BACK AGAIN. WE HAD LOTS IN COMMON. I'M SURE HE FELT IT. AND SHE LOOKED EMPHATICALLY TOWARD THE DOOR. WHEN YOU SAY YOU HAD LOTS IN COMMON, SAID BEN, SOUNDING RATHER AMUSED NOW, DO YOU MEAN HE LIVES IN AN S-BEND THEN? NO, SAID MYRTLE DEFIANTLY, HER VOICE ECHOING LOUDLY AROUND THE OLD TILED BATHROOM. I MEAN HE'S SENSITIVE, PEOPLE KILL HIM THEN, AND HE FEELS LONELY AND HASN'T GOTTEN ANYBODY TO TALK TO, AND HE'S NOT AFRAID TO SHOW HIS FEELINGS AND CRY. THERE'S BEEN A KID IN HERE CRYING? SAID HARRY CLIMBILY.

A YOUNG KID? NEVER YOU MIND? SAID MYRTLE, HER SMALL, LEADY EYES FIXED ON BEN, WHO WAS NOW DEFINITELY GRINNING. I PROMISED I WOULDN'T TELL ANYONE, AND I'LL TAKE HIS SECRET TO THE NEUT THE GRAVE, SLIP? SAID BEN WITH A SMILE. THE SEWERS, MAYBE MYRTLE GAVE A FLEET OF RAGE AND DIVED BACK INTO THE THICKET, CALLING WATER THE SLIP EVER THE SIDES AND ENTER THE FLEET. CHADING MYRTLE SEEMED TO HAVE PUT FRESH HEART INTO BEN. YOU'RE RIGHT, HE SAID, SWINGING HIS SCHEMAG RACK OVER HIS SHOULDER. I'LL DO THE PRACTICE SESSIONS IN THE SPREAD BEFORE I DECIDE ABOUT TAKING THE TEST. AND SEE THE FOLLOWING WEEKEND, BEN JOINED HERMINE AND THE REST OF THE SIXTH YEARS WHO WOULD TURN SEVENTEEN IN TIME TO TAKE THE TEST IN A FORTNIGHT. HARRY FELT RATHER IRATELY WATCHING THEM ALL GET READY TO GO INTO THE VILLAGE; HE MISSED MAKING TRIPS THERE,

AND IT WAS A PARTICULARLY FINE SPRING DAY, ONE OF THE FIRST CLEAR
DAYS THEY HAD SEEN IN A LONG TIME. HOWEVER, HE HAD DECIDED THE LATE
THE TIME THE ATTEMPT ANOTHER ASSAULT ON THE ROOM OF
REQUIREMENT. WELL DHE BETTER, SAID HERMIONE, WHEN HE CONSIDERED
THIS PLAN THE ROOM AND HER IN THE ENTRANCE HALL, THE GO STRAIGHT THE
SLUGGISH'S OFFICE AND TRY AND GET THAT MEMORY FROM HIM. I VE
BEEN TRYING! SAID HARRY CROSSLY, WHICH WAS PERFECTLY TRUE, HE HAD
LAGGED BEHIND AFTER EVERY POTIONS LESSON THAT WEEK IN AN ATTEMPT
THE CORNER SLUGGISH, BUT THE POTIONS MASTER ALWAYS LEFT THE
DUNGEON SO FAST THAT HARRY HAD NOT BEEN ABLE TO CATCH HIM. TWICE,
HARRY HAD GONE TO HIS OFFICE AND KNOCKED, BUT RECEIVED NO REPLY,
THOUGH ON THE SECOND OCCASION HE WAS SURE HE HAD HEARD THE
MURKELY STIFLED SOUNDS OF AN OLD GRAMOPHONE. HE DIDN'T WANT TO
TALK TO ME, HERMIONE! HE CAN TELL I VE BEEN TRYING TO GET HIM ON
HIS OWN AGAIN, AND HE'S NOT GOING TO LET IT HAPPEN! WELL,
WELL VE JUST GOT TO DEEP AT IT, HAVEN'T WE? THE SHORT WHILE OF
PEOPLE WAITING THE FIVE PAST FIVE, WHEN WAS DOING HIS USUAL
PROMISING ACT WITH THE SECRET SENSITIVE, MOVED FORWARD A FEW STEPS
AND HARRY DID NOT ANSWER IN CASE HE WAS OVERHEARD BY THE
CARETAKER, HE WISHED ROOM AND HERMIONE BOTH BACK, THEN TURNED
AND CLIMBED THE MARBLE STAIRCASE AGAIN, DETERMINED, HOWEVER
HERMIONE SAID, THE DEVIL AND HEELER FOR THE THE ROOM OF
REQUIREMENT, SINCE OUT OF SIGHT OF THE ENTRANCE HALL, HARRY
PULLED THE MARAUDER'S MAP AND HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK FROM HIS
BAG, HAVING CONCEALED HIMSELF, HE TAPPED THE MAP, MURMURED, I
SOLEMNLY SWEAR THAT I AM UP TO THE GOING, AND SCANNED IT CAREFULLY.
AS IT WAS SUNDAY MORNING, NEARLY ALL THE STUDENTS WERE INSIDE
THEIR VARIOUS COMMON ROOMS, THE GRYFFINDORS IN ONE TOWER, THE
RAVENCLAWS IN ANOTHER, THE SLYTHERINS IN THE DUNGEONS, AND THE
HUFFLEPUFFS IN THE BASEMENT NEAR THE KITCHENS. HERE AND THERE A
STRAY PERSON MEANDERED AROUND THE LIBRARY OR UP A CORRIDOR.
THERE WERE A FEW PEOPLE OUT IN THE GREENS AND THERE, ALONE
IN THE SEVENTH-FLOOR CORRIDOR, WAS GREGORY GOYLE. THERE WAS NO
SIGN OF THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, BUT HARRY WAS NOT WORRIED
ABOUT THAT; IF GOYLE WAS STANDING GUARD OUTSIDE IT, THE ROOM WAS
OPEN, WHETHER THE MAP WAS AWARE OF IT OR NOT. HE THEREFORE
SPRINTED UP THE STAIRS, SNEAKING DOWN ONLY WHEN HE REACHED THE
CORNER INTO THE CORRIDOR, WHEN HE BEGAN TO CREEP, VERY SILENTLY,

HEARD THE VERY SAME LITTLE GIRL, CLUTCHING HER HEAVY BRASS SCALES, THAT ERMINE HAD SHE KINDLY HELPED A NIGHTMARE REAPER. HE WAITED UNTIL HE WAS RIGHT BEHIND HER REAPER BENDING VERY LOW AND WHISPERING, "HELLO THEY'RE VERY PRETTY, AREN'T THEY?" SHE GAVE A HIGH-PITCHED SCREAM OF TERROR, THREW THE SCALES UP INTO THE AIR, AND SPRINTED AWAY, VANISHING FROM SIGHT LEAVING BEHIND THE SOUND OF THE SCALES SMASHING HAD STOPPED NOTHING AROUND THE CORRIDOR. LAUGHING, HARRY TURNED TO CONTEMPLATE THE BLANK WALL BEHIND WHICH, HE WAS SURE, BRACE MALTHEY WAS NOW STANDING FROZEN, AWARE THAT SOMEONE UNWELCOME WAS HINT THERE, BUT NOT DARING TO MAKE AN APPEARANCE. IT GAVE HARRY A MOST AGREEABLE FEELING OF POWER AS HE TRIED TO REMEMBER WHAT FORM OF WORDS HE HAD NOT YET TRIED. YET THIS UNUSUAL MIND DID NOT LAST LONG, HALF AN HOUR LATER, HAVING TRIED MANY MORE VARIATIONS OF HIS REELECT TO SEE WHAT MALTHEY WAS UP TO, THE WALL WAS JUST AS DIMLESS AS EVER. HARRY FELT FRUSTRATED BEYOND BELIEF; MALTHEY MIGHT BE JUST FEET AWAY FROM HIM, AND THERE WAS STILL NOT THE TINIEST SLICE OF EVIDENCE AS TO WHAT HE WAS DOING IN THERE. LOSING HIS PATIENCE COMPLETELY, HARRY RAN AT THE WALL AND KICKED IT. "HELLO!" HE THOUGHT HE MIGHT HAVE BROKEN HIS TOE; AS HE CLUTCHED IT AND HOPPED ON ONE FOOT, THE INVISIBILITY CURTAIN SLIPPED OFF HIM. "HARRY?" HE SPUN AROUND, ONE-LEGGED, AND THROPPED OVER. THERE, TO HIS LITTLE ASTONISHMENT, WAS TENDS, WALKING TOWARD HIM AS THOUGH SHE FREQUENTLY STRUTTED UP THIS CORRIDOR. "WHAT'RE YOU DOING HERE?" HE SAID, SCRAMBLING TO HIS FEET AGAIN; "HOW DID SHE ALWAYS HAVE THE FIND HIM LYING ON THE FLOOR?" "I CAME TO SEE DUMBLEDORE," SAID TENDS. "HARRY THOUGHT SHE LOOKED TERRIBLE: THINNER THAN USUAL, HER MELNIE-COLORED HAIR LONG." "HIS OFFICE ISN'T HERE," SAID HARRY, "IT'S BEHIND THE OTHER SIDE OF THE CASTLE, BEHIND THE GARGOYLE." "I KNOW," SAID TENDS. "HE'S NOT THERE. APPARENTLY HE'S GONE AWAY AGAIN." "HAS HE?" SAID HARRY, PUTTING HIS BOUNDED FOOT GINGERLY BACK ON THE FLOOR. "HEY THEY'DEN'T KNOW WHERE HE GOES, I SUPPOSE?" "NO," SAID TENDS. "WHAT DID YOU WANT TO SEE HIM ABOUT?" "NOTHING IN PARTICULAR," SAID TENDS, PICKING, APPARENTLY UNCONSCIOUSLY, AT THE SLEEVE OF HER DRESS. "I JUST THOUGHT HE MIGHT KNOW WHAT'S GOING ON. I'VE HEARD OTHERS PEOPLE GETTING FLIRT." "YEAH, I KNOW, IT'S ALL BEEN IN THE PAPERS," SAID HARRY. "THAT LITTLE DID TRYING TO KILL HIS THE"

PROPHET S OFTEN BEHIND THE TIMES, SAID THENDS, WHEN DIDN T SEEM THE
BE LISTENING THE HIM. YELL HAVEN T HAD ANY LETTERS FROM ANYONE IN
THE HORDER RECENTLY? SHE HUR FROM THE HORDER WRITES THE ME
ANYMORE, SAID FARRY, NOT SINCE SIRILS. HE SAW THAT HER EYES
HAD FILLED WITH TEARS. I M SORRY, HE MUTTERED ALOUDWARDLY, I MEAN

I MISS HIM, AS WELL. WHAT? SAID THENDS BLANDLY, AS THOUGH
SHE HAD NOT HEARD HIM. WELL. I LL SEE YELL ARIELING, FARRY
AND SHE TURNED ABRUPTLY AND WALKED BACK DOWN THE CORRIDOR,
LEAVING FARRY THE STARE AFTER HER. AFTER A MINUTE HER SHE HE PULLED
THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK ON AGAIN AND RESUMED HIS EFFORTS TO GET
INTO THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, BUT HIS HEART WAS NOT IN IT.
FINALLY, A FELLISH FEELING IN HIS STOMACH AND THE KNOWLEDGE THAT
REIN AND FERMINE WOULD SEEIN BE BACK FOR BLINKY MADE HIM
ABANDON THE ATTEMPT AND LEAVE THE CORRIDOR THE MALLBY WAY,
EMPERALLY, WOULD BE THEN AFRAID TO LEAVE HER SOME FEELING THE CHIEF. HE
FELT REIN AND FERMINE IN THE GREAT HALL, ALREADY HALFWAY
THROUGH AN EARLY BLINKY. I DID IT WELL, KIND HE? REIN TOLD
FARRY ENTHUSIASTICALLY WHEN HE CALLED TIGHT HE HIM. I WAS
SLEEPING THE BE APPARATING THE HILLSIDE MADAM PLUDDINGH S TEA
SHOP AND I OVERSHEET IT A BIT, ENDED UP NEAR SCRIVENS-FAST S, BUT AT
LEAST I MEVED. GOOD ONE, SAID FARRY, FELL D YELL DIE,
FERMINE? EH, SHE WAS PERFECT, HEVILISLY, SAID REIN, BEFORE
FERMINE COULD ANSWER. PERFECT DELICERATION, DIVINATION, AND
DESPERATION HE WHATEVER THE HELL IT IS. WE ALL WENT FOR A HELICK
DRINK IN THE THREE BREEMSTICKS AFTER AND YELL SEHLD VE HEARD
TWYCRASS GOING ON ABOUT HER. I LL BE SURPRISED IF HE DOESN T
POOP THE HILSTHEN SHEIN. AND WHAT ABOUT YELL? ASKED
FERMINE, IGNORING REIN. HAVE YELL BEEN UP AT THE ROOM OF
REQUIREMENT ALL THIS TIME? YEP, SAID FARRY, AND GLISS WHEN I
RAN INTO UP THERE? THENDS? THENDS? REPEATED REIN AND
FERMINE TOGETHER, LOOKING SURPRISED. YEAH, SHE SAID SHE D CHIEF
THE VISIT DUMBLEHIRE. IF YELL ASK ME, SAID REIN WHEN FARRY HAD
FINISHED DESCRIBING HIS CONVERSATION WITH THENDS, SHE S CRACKING
UP A BIT, LOSTING HER NERVE AFTER WHAT HAPPENED AT THE MINISTRY.

IT S A BIT EDD, SAID FERMINE, WHEN FOR SOME REASON LOOKED VERY
CONCERNED. SHE S SLEEPING THE BE GLARING THE SCHEM, WHY S SHE
SUDDENLY ABANDONING HER POST THE CHIEF AND SEE DUMBLEHIRE WHEN
HE S NOT EVEN HERE? I HAD A THOUGHT, SAID FARRY TENTATIVELY,

HE FELT STRANGE ABOUT VISITING IT; THIS WAS MUCH MORE FERMINE'S
TERRITORY THAN HIS. WHY DIDN'T HE THINK SHE CAN HAVE BEEN
DOWN IN LOVE WITH SIRILS? FERMINNE STARED AT HIM. WHAT HEN
EARTH MAKES YOU SAY THAT? I DON'T, SAID HARRY, SUGGESTING,
BUT SHE WAS NEARLY CRYING WHEN I MENTIONED HIS NAME AND HER
PATRONS IS A BIG FEAR-LEGGED THING NOW. I WONDERED WHETHER IT
HADN'T RECENTLY BEEN DOWN HIM. IT'S A TELL-TALE, SAID
FERMINNE SILENTLY. BUT I STILL DIDN'T KNOW WHY SHE'D BE CLIMBING
INTO THE CASTLE TO SEE DUMBLEDORE, IF THAT'S REALLY WHY SHE WAS HERE.

CHEER UP, THE WHAT I SAID, DIDN'T IT? SAID RHN, WHO WAS NOW
SMILING MASHED POTATOES INTO HIS MOUTH. SHE'S GONE A BIT FLIPPY,
LOST HER NERVE, WHEN, HE SAID WISELY TO HARRY, THEY'RE EASILY
UPSET. AND YET, SAID FERMINNE, CHIMPING OUT OF HER REVERIE, I
DON'T YOU'D FIND A WOMAN WHO SLICKED HER HAIR AN FEARFUL RECALISE
MADAM RHEMERTA DIDN'T LAUGH AT THEIR MORE ABOUT THE HOG, THE
HEALER, AND THE MIMBLIS MIMBLETHIA. RHN SIGHED, AFTER THE
BURIAL PATCHES OF BRIGHT BLUE SKY WERE BEGINNING TO APPEAR OVER
THE CASTLE TOWERS, BUT THESE SIGNS OF APPROACHING SUMMER DID NOT
LIFT HARRY'S MOOD. HE HAD BEEN THWARTED, BOTH IN HIS ATTEMPTS TO
FIND OUT WHAT MALFOY WAS DOING, AND IN HIS EFFORTS TO START A
CONVERSATION WITH SLUGGISHORN THAT MIGHT LEAD, SOMEHOW, TO
SLUGGISHORN HANDING OVER THE MEMOIR HE HAD APPARENTLY
SUPPRESSED FOR DECADES. FOR THE LAST TIME, JUST ABOUT ABOUT
MALFOY, FERMINNE TOLD HARRY FIRMLY. THEY WERE SITTING WITH
RHN IN A SUNNY CORNER OF THE CHURTYARD AFTER LUNCH. FERMINNE
AND RHN WERE BOTH CLUTCHING A MINISTRY OF MAGIC LEAFLET
CHAMPION APPARITION MISTAKES AND HOW TO AVOID THEM FOR
THEY WERE TAKING THEIR TESTS THAT VERY AFTERNOON, BUT BY AND LARGE
THE LEAFLETS HAD NOT PROVED SMOOTHING TO THE NERVES. RHN GAVE A
START AND TRIED TO HIDE BEHIND FERMINNE AS A GIRL CAME ABOUT THE
CORNER. IT ISN'T LAVENDER, SAID FERMINNE WEARILY. EH, GOSH,
SAID RHN, RELAXING. HARRY BETTER? SAID THE GIRL. I WAS ASKED TO
GIVE YOU THIS. THANKS HARRY'S HEART SANK AS HE TOOK THE
SMALL SCROLL OF PARCHMENT. HENCE THE GIRL WAS NOT OF FARSEET HE
SAID. DUMBLEDORE SAID WE WOULDN'T BE HAVING ANY MORE LESSONS
UNTIL I GET THE MEMOIR. MAYBE HE WANTS TO CHECK ON HOW
YOU'RE DOING? SUGGESTED FERMINNE, AS HARRY UNFOLLED THE
PARCHMENT; BUT RATHER THAN FINDING DUMBLEDORE'S LONG, NARRATIVE,

SLANTED WRITING HE SAW AN LENTIDY SPRAWL, VERY DIFFICULT TO READ BUT THE PRESENCE OF LARGE BLITCHES ON THE PARCHMENT WHERE THE INK HAD RUN. LOOKING AT THIS, SAID HARRY, HANDING THE SHEET TO HERMIONE. HELLO, FOR HEAVEN'S SAKE, SHE SAID, SCANNING IT QUICKLY AND PASSING IT TO RON, WHO READ IT THROUGHLY WHISKING INCREASINGLY INCREDULOUS. HE'S MENTAL! HE SAID FLURRIEDLY. THAT THING TOLD ITS MATE THE CAT HARRY AND ME? TOLD THEM TO HELP THEMSELVES? AND WHEN HAGRID EXPECTS US TO GO DOWN THERE AND TRY TO GET ITS HORRIBLE HAIRY BODY? IT'S NOT JUST THAT, SAID HERMIONE. HE'S ASKING US TO LEAVE THE CASTLE AT NIGHT AND HE KNOWS SECURITY'S A MILLION TIMES TIGHTER AND HOW MUCH TRICKIER WE'D BE IN IF WE WERE CAUGHT.

WE'VE BEEN DOWN TO SEE HIM BY NIGHT BEFORE, SAID HARRY. YES, BUT FOR SOMETHING LIKE THIS? SAID HERMIONE. WE'VE RISKED A LOT TO HELP HAGRID OUT, BUT AFTER ALL... AGRAGE'S DEAD. IF IT WERE A QUESTION OF SAVING HIM...

I'D WANT TO GO EVEN LESS, SAID RON FIRMLY. WHY DIDN'T YOU MEET HIM, HERMIONE. BELIEVE ME, KING DEAD WILL HAVE IMPROVED HIM A LOT. HARRY THREW THE SHEET BACK AND STARED DOWN AT ALL THE INKY BLITCHES ALL OVER IT. TEARS HAD CLEARLY FALLEN THICK AND FAST UPON THE PARCHMENT. HARRY, YOU CAN'T BE THINKING OF GOING, SAID HERMIONE. IT'S SUCH A POINTLESS THING TO GET DETENTIONS FOR. HARRY SIGHED. YES, I KNOW, HE SAID. I'VE THESE HAGRID WILL HAVE THE BODY AGRAGE WITH HIM. YES, HE WILL, SAID HERMIONE, LOOKING RELIEVED. LOOK, POTTIONS WILL BE ALMOST EMPTY THIS AFTERNOON, WITH US ALL OFF DOING OUR TESTS. TRY AND SHUTTEN SLEEPER UP A BIT THEN? FIFTY-SEVENTH TIME LATER, WHY THINK? SAID HARRY BITTERLY. LATER, SAID RON SLIDENLY. HARRY, THAT'S IT. GET LATER? WHAT DO YOU MEAN? USE YOUR LATER POTTIONS? RON, THAT'S... THAT'S IT? SAID HERMIONE, SOUNDING STUNNED. HELLO? WHY DIDN'T I THINK OF IT? HARRY STARED AT THEM BOTH. FELIX FELIX? HE SAID. I DON'T... I WAS SHORT OF SAYING IT. WHAT FOR? DEMANDED RON INCREDULOUSLY. WHAT ON EARTH IS MORE IMPORTANT THAN THIS MEMORY, HARRY? ASKED HERMIONE. HARRY DID NOT ANSWER. THE THOUGHT OF THAT LITTLE CHILDEN RATTLE HAD FLOATED ON THE EDGES OF HIS IMAGINATION FOR SOME TIME; VAGUE AND UNFORMULATED PLANS THAT INVOLVED GINNY SPLITTING UP WITH DEAN, AND RON SOMEHOW BEING HAPPY TO SEE HER WITH A NEW FRIEND, HAD BEEN FERMENTING IN THE DEPTHS OF HIS BRAIN, UNACKNOWLEDGED EXCEPT DURING DREAMS OR THE TWILIGHT TIME

BETWEEN SLEEPING AND WAKING. HARRY? ARE YOU STILL WITH US?
 ASKED FERMINE. WHAT? YES, HE CALLED. HE SAID, PULLING
 HIMSELF TOGETHER. WELL. TODAY, IF I CAN'T GET SLEEP, THEN THE TALK
 THIS AFTERNOON, I WILL TAKE SOME FELIX AND HAVE ANOTHER ONE THIS
 EVENING. THAT'S DECIDED, THEN, SAID FERMINE BRISKLY, GETTING THE
 HER FEET AND PERFORMING A GRACEFUL PIROUETTE. DESTINATION
 DETERMINATION DELIBERATION SHE MURMURED. HE, STOP THAT,
 RENE REGGED HER. I FEEL SICK ENOUGH AS IT IS. WHICH, HIDE ME? IT
 ISN'T LAVENDER? SAID FERMINE IMPATIENTLY, AS ANOTHER CHLOPE OF
 GIRLS APPEARED IN THE CHLARTYARD AND RENE DIVED BEHIND HER. CHEE,
 SAID RENE, PEERING OVER FERMINE'S SHOULDER THE CHECK. BLIMPY,
 THEY BEEN T LINDY HAPPY, DE THEY? THEY RE THE MENTCHERY
 SISTERS AND HE CALLED THEY BEEN T LINDY HAPPY, DIDN'T YOU HEAR WHAT
 HAPPENED THE THEIR LITTLE BROTHER? SAID FERMINE. I'M LOSTING
 TRACK OF WHAT'S HAPPENING THE EVERYONE'S RELATIVES, THE RE FINEST,
 SAID RENE. WELL, THEIR BROTHER WAS ATTACKED BY A WEREWOLF. THE
 RUMOR IS THAT THEIR MOTHER REFUSED THE HELP THE DEATH EATERS.
 ANDWAY, THE KID WAS ONLY FIVE AND HE DIED IN ST. MUNGEE'S, THEY
 CHILDEN T SAVE HIM. HE DIED? REPEATED HARRY, SHOCKED. BUT
 SURELY WEREWOLVES BEEN T KILL, THEY ILST TURN YOU INTO ONE OF
 THEM? THEY SOMETIMES KILL, SAID RENE, WHEN LINDY UNUSUALLY
 GRAVE NEED. I'VE HEARD OF IT HAPPENING WHEN THE WEREWOLF GETS
 CARRIED AWAY. WHAT WAS THE WEREWOLF'S NAME? SAID HARRY
 BLINDLY. WELL, THE RUMOR IS THAT IT WAS THAT FERRIS CRYBACH,
 SAID FERMINE. I KNEW IT. THE MANIAC WHO LIKES ATTACKING KIDS,
 THE ONE SLIPIN THRO' ME ARHIT? SAID HARRY ANGRILY. FERMINE
 LINDY AT HIM BLEADLY. HARRY, YOU'VE GOT TO GET THAT MEMORY,
 SHE SAID. IT'S ALL ARHIT STEPPING VERBEMENT, ISN'T IT? THESE
 DREADFUL THINGS THAT ARE HAPPENING ARE ALL BEHIND THE HIM. THE
 BELL RANG OVERHEAD IN THE CASTLE AND BOTH FERMINE AND RENE
 JUMPED THE THEIR FEET, LINDYING TERRIFIED. YOU'LL BE FINE, HARRY
 TOLD THEM BOTH, AS THEY HEADED TOWARD THE ENTRANCE HALL THE MEET
 THE REST OF THE PEOPLE TAKING THEIR APPARITION TEST. GOOD
 LUCK. AND YOU TOO? SAID FERMINE WITH A SIGNIFICANT LINDY, AS
 HARRY HEADED OFF THE THE BLINGEENS. THERE WERE ONLY THREE OF THEM
 IN PARTIENS THAT AFTERNOON: HARRY, ERNIE, AND GRACE MALPHY. ALL
 THEM YOU'VE THE APPARATE ILST YET? SAID SLEIGHORN GENIALLY. NOT
 TURNED SEVENTEEN YET? THEY SHOOK THEIR HEADS. AND WELL, SAID

SILVERHORN CHEERILY, AS WE RE SHE FEL, WE LL BE SOMETHING PLIN, I WANT YELL ALL THE KREW ME UP SOMETHING AMUSING! THAT SELINDS GINN, SIR, SAID ERNIE SYMPHANTICALLY, RUBBING HIS HANDS TOGETHER. MALTHEY, HEN THE OTHER HAND, DID NOT CRACK A SMILE. WHAT DE YELL MEAN, SOMETHING AMUSING? HE SAID IRRITABLY. EH, SURPRISE ME, SAID SILVERHORN AIRILY, MALTHEY OPENED HIS CHEY HE ADVANCED PHTHEN-MAKING WITH A SLODY EXPRESSION. IT CHULD NOT HAVE BEEN PLAINER THAT HE THUGHT THIS LESSON WAS A WASTE OF TIME. UNDELECTEDLY, HARRY THUGHT, WATCHING HIM OVER THE THP OF HIS ELIN KINN, MALTHEY WAS REGRADING THE TIME HE CHULD OTHERWISE BE SPENDING IN THE REHEM OF REHEIREMENT. WAS IT HIS IMAGINATION, OR DID MALTHEY, LIKE THINGS, BEHE THINNER? CERTAINLY HE BEHEED PAKER; HIS SKIN STILL HAD THAT GRAYISH TINGE, PROBABLY BECAUSE HE SHE RARELY SAW DAYLIGHT THESE DAYS, BUT THERE WAS NE AIR OF SMUGNESS, EXCITEMENT, OR SUPERIORITY; NONE OF THE SWAGGER THAT HE HAD HAD HEN THE F-HEGLARTS EXPRESS, WHEN HE HAD REASTED OPENLY OF THE MISSION HE HAD BEEN GIVEN BY VERBEMERT. THERE CHULD BE ONLY ONE CONCLUSION, IN HARRY S MIND: THE MISSION, WHATEVER IT WAS, WAS GOING BADLY. FURRED BY THIS THOUGHT, HARRY SKIMPED THROUGH HIS CHEY HE ADVANCED PHTHEN-MAKING AND FEELING A HEAVILY CORRECTED F-ALF-BLEED PRINCE S VERSTEN OF AN ELIKIN THE INDICE ELIPHERIA, WHICH SEEMED NOT ONLY THE MEET SILVERHORN S INSTRUCTIONS, BUT WHICH MIGHT HARRY S HEART LEAPT AS THE THOUGHT STRUCK HIM! PUT SILVERHORN INTO SUCH A GOOD MIND THAT HE WOULD BE PREPARED THE HAND EVER THAT MEMERY IF HARRY CHULD PERSUADE HIM THE TASTE SHEKE. WELL, NOW, THIS BEHEES ABSOLUTELY WONDERFUL, SAID SILVERHORN AN FEELER AND A FALF LATER, CLAPPING HIS HANDS TOGETHER AS HE STARED DEEN INTO THE SUNSHINE YELLOW CONTENTS OF HARRY S CALIBREIN. ELIPHERIA, I TAKE IT? AND WHAT S THAT I SMELL? MMMM YELL YE ADDED ILIST A SPRIG OF PEPPERMINT, HAVEN T YELL? UNWORTHEDDEK, BUT WHAT A STROKE OF INSPIRATION, HARRY, HE CHURSE, THAT WOULD TEND THE CHLINTERBALANCE THE OCCASIONAL SIDE EFFECTS OF EXCESSIVE SINGING AND NEER-TWEADING. I REALLY DEEN T KNOW WHERE YELL GET THESE BRAIN WAVES, MY KEEY UNLESS HARRY PUSHER THE F-ALF-BLEED PRINCE S BEHEE DEEPER INTO HIS BAG WITH HIS FEET. IT S ILIST YELLR MEETHE S GENES CHMING ELIT IN YELL? EH YEAF, MAYBE, SAID HARRY, RELIEVED. ERNIE WAS BEHEEDING RATHER GRIMPY; DETERMINED THE ELTSHINE HARRY

HER HENCE, HE HAD MOST RASHLY INVENTED HIS OWN PORTION, WHICH HAD
CLIMBED AND FORMED A KIND OF PURPLE DUMPLING AT THE BOTTOM OF HIS
CALIBREIN. MALPHE WAS ALREADY PACKING UP, SILENT-FACED. SLUGGISH
HAD PRESENTED HIS FICKLING SKELETON MERELY PASSABLE. THE
BELL RANG AND BOTH ERNIE AND MALPHE LEFT AT HENCE. SIR, HARRY
BEGAN, BUT SLUGGISH IMMEDIATELY GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER. WHEN
HE SAW THAT THE ROOM WAS EMPTY BUT FOR HIMSELF AND HARRY, HE
HURRIED AWAY AS FAST AS HE COULD. PROFESSOR PROFESSOR, THEN T
WELL WANT THE TASTE MY OWN ? CALLED HARRY DESPERATELY, BUT
SLUGGISH HAD GONE. DISAPPOINTED, HARRY EMPTIED THE CALIBREIN,
PACKED UP HIS THINGS, LEFT THE DUNGEON, AND WALKED SILENTLY BACK
UPSTAIRS TO THE COMMON ROOM. ERNIE AND HERMIONE RETURNED IN THE
LATE AFTERNOON. HARRY? CRIED HERMIONE AS SHE CLIMBED THROUGH
THE PORTRAIT HOLE. HARRY, I PASSED! WELL THEN? HE SAID, AND
ERNIE? HE JUST FAILED, WHISPERED HERMIONE, AS ERNIE CAME
SLICKING INTO THE ROOM LOOKING MOST MISERABLE. IT WAS REALLY
UNLIKELY, A TINY THING, THE EXAMINER JUST SMILED THAT HE D LEFT
HALF AN EYEBROW BEHIND. HOW DID IT GO WITH SLUGGISH? NEH
HEY, SAID HARRY, AS ERNIE JOINED THEM. BAD LUCK, MATE, BUT WELL BE
PASS NEXT TIME WE CAN TAKE IT TOGETHER. Yeah, I S PHEE, SAID
ERNIE GRIMPLY. BUT HALF AN EYEBROW? LIKE THAT MATTERS? I
KNOW, SAID HERMIONE SKEETHELY, IT DOES SEEM REALLY HARSH.
THEY SPENT MOST OF THEIR DINNER RELIANTLY ABUSING THE APPARITION
EXAMINER, AND ERNIE LOOKED FRANTICALLY MORE CHEERFUL BY THE TIME
THEY SET OFF BACK TO THE COMMON ROOM, NOW DISCUSSING THE
CONTINUING PROBLEM OF SLUGGISH AND THE MEMORY. SEE, HARRY
WELL BEING THE LIKE THE FELIX FELIXIS FOR WHAT? ERNIE DEMANDED. Yeah,
I S PHEE I D BETTER, SAID HARRY. I DONT REMEMBER I BE NEED ALL OF IT,
NOT TWELVE HOURS WORTH, IT CANT TAKE ALL NIGHT. I BE JUST TAKE
A MINUTE-PL. TWO OR THREE HOURS SHOULD DO IT. IT S A GREAT
FEELING WHEN WELL TAKE IT, SAID ERNIE REMINISCENTLY. LIKE WELL CANT
DO ANYTHING WRONG. WHAT ARE WELL TALKING ABOUT? SAID
HERMIONE, LAUGHING. WELL VE NEVER TAKEN ANY? Yeah, BUT I
THOUGHT I HAD, DIDN T I? SAID ERNIE, AS THOUGH EXPLAINING THE
EVIDENCE. SAME DIFFERENCE REALLY AS THEY HAD ONLY JUST SEEN
SLUGGISH ENTER THE GREAT HALL AND KNOW THAT HE LIKED THE TAKE
TIME OVER MEALS, THEY LINGERED FOR A WHILE IN THE COMMON ROOM,
THE PLAN BEING THAT HARRY SHOULD GO TO SLUGGISH S OFFICE HENCE

THE TEACHER HAD HAD TIME TO GET BACK THERE. WHEN THE SLIN HAD SLUNK TO THE LEVEL OF THE TREETHIPS IN THE FORBIDDEN FOREST, THEY DECIDED THE MOMENT HAD COME, AND AFTER CHECKING CAREFULLY THAT NEVILLE, DEAN, AND SEAMUS WERE ALL IN THE CHAMBER ROOM, SNEAKED UP TO THE KEYS' DORMITORY. HARRY THEN HLT THE ROLLED-UP SHEDS AT THE KITCHEN OF HIS TRUNK AND EXTRACTED THE TINY, GLAMING BATTLE.

WELL, HERE COMES, SAID HARRY, AND HE RAISED THE LITTLE BATTLE AND THEN A CAREFULLY MEASURED CLIP. WHAT DOES IT FEEL LIKE? WHISPERED HERMIONE. HARRY DID NOT ANSWER FOR A MOMENT. THEN, SILENTLY BUT SURELY, AN EXHILARATING SENSE OF INFINITE OPPORTUNITY STEAL THROUGH HIM; HE FELT AS THOUGH HE COULD HAVE DONE ANYTHING, ANYTHING AT ALL. AND GETTING THE MEMORY FROM SLEEPER SEEMED SUDDENLY NOT ONLY POSSIBLE, BUT POSITIVELY EASY.

HE GOT TO HIS FEET, SMILING, CRIMING WITH CONFIDENCE.

EXCELLENT, HE SAID. REALLY EXCELLENT. RIGHT. I'M GOING DOWN THE HAGRIDS. WHAT? SAID RON AND HERMIONE TOGETHER, LEERING AGAINST. NO, HARRY. YOU'VE GOT TO GO AND SEE SLEEPER, REMEMBER? SAID HERMIONE. NO, SAID HARRY CONFIDENTLY. I'M GOING TO HAGRIDS, I'VE GOT A GOOD FEELING ABOUT GOING TO HAGRIDS. YOU'VE GOT A GOOD FEELING ABOUT KIDNAPING A GIANT SPIDER? ASKED RON, LEERING STUNNED. YES, SAID HARRY, PULLING HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK HLT OF HIS BAG. I FEEL LIKE IT'S THE PLACE TO BE TONIGHT, YOU KNOW WHAT I MEAN? NO, SAID RON AND HERMIONE TOGETHER, BOTH LEERING POSITIVELY ALARMED NOW. THIS IS FELIX FELIX, I SLEEPER? SAID HERMIONE ANXIOUSLY, HOLDING UP THE BATTLE TO THE LIGHT. YOU HAVEN'T GOT ANOTHER LITTLE BATTLE FROM ME. I DON'T KNOW. ESSENCE OF INSANITY? SUGGESTED RON, AS HARRY SWUNG HIS CLOAK OVER HIS SHOULDERS. HARRY LAUGHED, AND RON AND HERMIONE LEERED EVEN MORE ALARMED. TELL ME, HE SAID. I KNOW WHAT I'M DOING. FOR AT LEAST HE STROLLED CONFIDENTLY TO THE DOOR. FELIX DOES. HE PULLED THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK OVER HIS HEAD AND SET OFF DOWN THE STAIRS, RON AND HERMIONE FLURRYING ALONG BEHIND HIM. AT THE FOOT OF THE STAIRS, HARRY SLID THROUGH THE OPEN DOOR. WHAT WERE YOU DOING UP THERE WITH HER? STRIPPED LAVENDER BROWN, STARING RIGHT THROUGH HARRY AT RON AND HERMIONE EMERGING TOGETHER FROM THE KEYS' DORMITORIES. HARRY HEARD RON SPOLLTERING BEHIND HIM AS HE DARTED ACROSS THE ROOM AWAY FROM THEM. GETTING THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE WAS

SIMPLE; AS HE APPROACHED IT, GINNY AND DEAN CAME THROUGH IT, AND HARRY WAS ABLE TO SLIP BETWEEN THEM. AS HE DID SO, HE COLLIDED ACCIDENTALLY AGAINST GINNY. THEN TUSH ME, PLEASE, DEAN, SHE SAID, SOUNDING ANNOYED. WELL RE ALWAYS BEING THAT, I CAN GET THROUGH PERFECTLY WELL ON MY OWN. THE PORTRAIT SLUNG CLOSED BEHIND HARRY, BUT NOT BEFORE HE HAD HEARD DEAN MAKE AN ANGRY RETORT. HIS FEELING OF PLATITUDE INCREASING, HARRY STRIDE OFF THROUGH THE CASTLE. HE DID NOT HAVE TO CREEP ALONG, FOR HE MET NOBODY ON HIS WAY, BUT THIS DID NOT SURPRISE HIM IN THE SLIGHTEST: THIS EVENING, HE WAS THE LUCKIEST PERSON AT HOGWARTS. WHY HE KNEW THAT CHOICE THE HAGRID WAS THE RIGHT THING TO DO, HE HAD NO IDEA. IT WAS AS THOUGH THE PORTIEN WAS ILLUMINATING A FEW STEPS OF THE PATH AT A TIME: HE COULD NOT SEE THE FINAL DESTINATION, HE COULD NOT SEE WHERE SLYTHERIN CAME IN, BUT HE KNEW THAT HE WAS CHOICE THE RIGHT WAY TO GET THAT MEMORY. WHEN HE REACHED THE ENTRANCE HALL HE SAW THAT FILCH HAD FORGOTTEN THE LOCK THE FRONT DOOR. BEAMING, HARRY THREW IT OPEN AND BREATHED IN THE SMELL OF CLEAN AIR AND GRASS FOR A MOMENT BEFORE WALKING DOWN THE STEPS INTO THE GARDEN. IT WAS WHEN HE REACHED THE BOTTOM STEP THAT IT OCCURRED TO HIM HOW VERY PLEASANT IT WOULD BE TO PASS THE VEGETABLE PATCH ON HIS WAY TO THE HAGRID'S. IT WAS NOT STRICTLY ON THE WAY, BUT IT SEEMED CLEAR TO HARRY THAT THIS WAS A MOMENT ON WHICH HE SHOULD ACT, SO HE DIRECTED HIS FEET IMMEDIATELY TOWARD THE VEGETABLE PATCH, WHERE HE WAS PLEASED, BUT NOT ALTOGETHER SURPRISED, TO FIND PROFESSOR SLYTHERIN IN CONVERSATION WITH PROFESSOR SPRELL. HARRY LURKED BEHIND A LOW STONE WALL, FEELING AT PEACE WITH THE WORLD AND LISTENING TO THEIR CONVERSATION. I DO THANK YOU FOR TAKING THE TIME, PERHAPS, SLYTHERIN WAS SAYING CHEERFULLY, MUST ALTERNITIVELY AGREE THAT THEY ARE AT THEIR MOST EFFICACIOUS IF PICKED AT TWILIGHT. EH, I ENJOY AGREE, SAID PROFESSOR SPRELL WARMLY. THAT ENOUGH FOR YOU? PLENTY, PLENTY, SAID SLYTHERIN, WHEN HARRY SAW, WAS CARRYING AN ARMFUL OF LEAFY PLANTS. THIS SHOULD ALLOW FOR A FEW LEAVES FOR EACH OF MY THIRD YEARS, AND SOME TO SPARE IF ANYBODY EVER STEALS THEM. WELL, GOOD EVENING TO YOU, AND MANY THANKS AGAIN! PROFESSOR SPRELL HEADED OFF INTO THE GATHERING DARKNESS IN THE DIRECTION OF HER GREENHOUSE, AND SLYTHERIN DIRECTED HIS STEPS TO THE SPOT WHERE HARRY STOOD, INVISIBLE. SEIZED WITH AN IMMEDIATE DESIRE TO REVEAL HIMSELF, HARRY

PULLED OFF THE CHAIR WITH A FLUENT, CHIEF EVENING, PROFESSOR.

MERLIN'S BEARD, HARRY, WHO MADE ME ILMP, SAID SLUGGISHLY, STEPPING DEAD IN HIS TRACKS AND WHISKING AWAY. HELL DID WHO GET HELT BY THE CASTLE? I THINK FILCH MUST BE FORGOTTEN THE WHICH THE DEERS, SAID HARRY CHEERFULLY, AND WAS DELIGHTED TO SEE SLUGGISHLY SNEEL. I AM BE REPENTING THAT MAN, HE'S MORE CONCERNED ABOUT LITTER THAN PROPER SECURITY IF WHO ASK ME. BUT WHO ARE WHO HELT HERE, HARRY? WELL, SIR, IT'S HAGRID, SAID HARRY, WHO DENIED THAT THE RIGHT THING TO DO WOULD BE TO TELL THE TRUTH. HE'S PRETTY LIPSSET. BUT WHO WHEN TO TELL ANYONE, PROFESSOR? I DON'T WANT TROUBLE FOR HIM. SLUGGISHLY'S CLARITY WAS EVIDENTLY AMPLIFIED. WELL, I CAN'T PROMISE THAT, HE SAID GRUFFLY. BUT I KNOW THAT DUMKEDORE TOLDS HAGRID THE TRUTH, SEE I'M SURE HE CAN'T BE LIP TO ANYTHING VERY DREADFUL. WELL, IT'S THIS GIANT SPIDER, HE'S HAD IT FOR YEARS. IT LIVED IN THE FOREST. IT COULD TALK AND EVERYTHING. I HEARD RUMORS THERE WERE ACROMANTULAS IN THE FOREST, SAID SLUGGISHLY SHITLY, WHISKING AWAY AT THE MASS OF BLACK TREES. IT'S TRUE, THEN? YES, SAID HARRY, BUT THIS ONE, ARACHNE, THE FIRST ONE HAGRID EVER GOT, IT DIED LAST NIGHT. HE'S DEVASTATED. HE WANTS COMPANY WHILE HE KLIRKS IT AND I SAID I'D GO.

TELLING, TELLING, SAID SLUGGISHLY ASSENTMINDFULLY, HIS LARGE DREDDY EYES FIXED UPON THE DISTANT LIGHTS OF HAGRID'S CACKIN. BUT ACROMANTULA VENOM IS VERY VALUABLE. IF THE REAST ONLY JUST DIED IT MIGHT NOT YET HAVE DRIED HELT. HE CHIRSE, I WOULDN'T WANT TO BE ANYTHING INSENSITIVE IF HAGRID IS LIPSSET. BUT IF THERE WAS ANY WAY TO PROLONG HIM. I MEAN, IT'S ALMOST IMPOSSIBLE TO GET VENOM FROM AN ACROMANTULA WHILE IT'S ALIVE. SLUGGISHLY SEEMED TO BE TALKING MORE TO HIMSELF THAN HARRY WHO. SEEMS AN AWFUL WASTE NOT TO COLLECT IT. MIGHT GET A HUNDRED GALLEONS A PINT. TOO FRANK, MY SALARY IS NOT LARGE. AND WHO HARRY SAW CLEARLY WHAT WAS TO BE DONE. WELL, HE SAID, WITH A MOST CONVINCING HESITANCY, WELL, IF WHO WANTED TO CHEER, PROFESSOR, HAGRID WOULD PROBABLY BE REALLY PLEASED. GIVE ARACHNE A BETTER SEND-OFF, WHO DENIED. YES, HE CHIRSE, SAID SLUGGISHLY, HIS EYES WHO GLAMING WITH ENTHUSIASM. I TELL WHO WHAT, HARRY, I'LL MEET WHO DOWN THERE WITH A BATTLE FOR TWO. WE'LL DRINK THE PROPER REAST'S WELL NOT HEALTH. BUT WE'LL SEND IT OFF IN STYLE, ANYWAY, SINCE IT'S KLIRIED. AND I'LL CHANGE MY TIE, THIS ONE IS A LITTLE

EXUBERANT AND THE OCCASION. HE KLITLED BACK INTO THE CASTLE, AND FARRY SPED OFF THE FARRID S, DELIGHTED WITH HIMSELF. YEH CAME, CRASHED FARRID, WHEN HE OPENED THE DOOR AND SAW FARRY EMERGING FROM THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK IN FRONT OF HIM. YEAH RHN AND FERMINE CHILDEN T, TELLCH, SAID FARRY, THEY RE REALLY SHIRY, DEEN DEEN MATTER HE D VE KIN TELLED YEH RE HERE, TELLCH, FARRY. FARRID GAVE A GREAT SHIR, HE HAD MADE HIMSELF A BLACK ARMBAND HLT HE WHAT LEEKED LIKE A RAG DIPPED IN BHHH PHLISH, AND HIS EYES WERE PLIPPY, RED, AND SWELLEN. FARRY PATTED HIM CENSURELY IN THE ELKEL, WHICH WAS THE HIGHEST POINT OF FARRID HE COULD EASILY REACH. WHERE ARE WE KLYING HIM? HE ASKED. THE FERRIST? BLIMEY, NEH, SAID FARRID, WIPING HIS STREAMING EYES IN THE KHTTCH OF HIS SHIRT. THE EITHER SPIDERS WHEN LET ME ANYWHERE NEAR THEIR WERS NEH ARACHE S GENE, TURNS HLT IT WAS IN YEH HIS HANDS THEY DIDN EAT ME? CAN YEH BELIEVE THAT, FARRY? THE HINNEST ANSWER WAS YES; FARRY RECALLED WITH PAINFUL EASE THE SCENE WHEN HE AND RHN HAD COME FACE-TO-FACE WITH THE ACHEMANTULAS: THEY HAD BEEN HLT CLEAR THAT ARACHE WAS THE ONLY THING THAT STOPPED THEM FROM EATING FARRID. NEVER KIN AN AREA IN THE FERRIST I CHILDEN GE KERRER? SAID FARRID, SHAKING HIS HEAD. IT WASN EASY, GETTING ARACHE S KEDY HLT IN THERE, I CAN TELL YEH THEY USUALLY EAT THEIR DEAD, SEE. BUT I WANTED TER GIVE IM A NICE KLIRIAL A PROPER SEND-OFF HE KROCK INTO THE SHIR AGAIN AND FARRY RESUMED THE PATTING OF HIS ELKEL, SAYING AS HE DID SEE (AFTER THE PHTTCH SEEMED TO INDICATE THAT IT WAS THE RIGHT THING TO DO), PROFESSOR SILGHEHN MET ME COMING DOWN HERE, FARRID. NHT IN TRELLER, ARE YEH? SAID FARRID, LEEKING UP, ALARMED. YEH SE-HLIDN RE HLT TA THE CASTLE IN THE EVENIN, I DKNOW IT, IT S MY FAULT NEH, NEH, WHEN HE HEARD WHAT I WAS DOING HE SAID HE D LIKE THE COME AND PAY HIS LAST RESPECTS TO ARACHE THEH, SAID FARRY, HE S GENE THE CHANGE INTO SOMETHING MORE SLITABLE, I THINK AND HE SAID HE D BRING SOME KHTLES SH WE CAN DRINK THE ARACHE S MEMERY. DID HE? SAID FARRID, LEEKING KHTH ASTHENISHED AND TELLED. THA S THA S RICH NICE OF HIM, THAT IS, AN NHT TURNIN YEH IN EITHER, I VE NEVER REALLY HAD A HLT TER DO WITH FERRACE SILGHEHN KERRER. COMIN TER SEE HLD ARACHE OFF, TELLCH, K-H WELL HE D VE LIKED THAT, ARACHE WELLD. FARRY THUGHT PRIVATELY THAT WHAT ARACHE WELLD HAVE LIKED MEET ARHLT SILGHEHN WAS THE

AMPLE AMPLINT OF EDIBLE FLESH HE PROVIDED, BUT HE MERELY MOVED THE
THE REAR WINDOW OF F-JAGRID'S FLIT, WHERE HE SAW THE RATHER
HORRIBLE SIGHT OF THE ENORMOUS DEAD SPIDER LYING ON ITS BACK
ELTIDE, ITS LEGS CLUMBED AND TANGLED. ARE WE GOING TO KILL HIM
HERE, F-JAGRID, IN YOUR GARDEN? HIS BEYOND THE PLIMPTON PATCH, I
THOUGHT, SAID F-JAGRID IN A CHERED VOICE. I'VE ALREADY DONE THE
YEN DENED GRAVE. HIS THOUGHT WE'D SAY A FEW NICE THINGS OVER
HIM. HAPPY MEMORIES, YEN DENED. HIS VOICE DELIVERED AND
KIND. THERE WAS A DENED ON THE DEED, AND HE TURNED THE ANSWER IT,
BLEWING HIS NOSE ON HIS GREAT SPOTTED HANDKERCHIEF AS HE DID SO.
SILVERHORN HURRIED OVER THE THRESHOLD, SEVERAL KETTLES IN HIS ARMS,
AND WEARING A SUMMER BLACK CLOAK. F-JAGRID, HE SAID, IN A DEEP,
GRAVE VOICE. SEE VERY SHARP THE HEAR OF YOUR LOSS. THAT'S VERY
NICE OF YOU, SAID F-JAGRID. THANKS A LOT, AND THANKS FOR NOT
GIVING F-JAGRID DETENTION EITHER. WOULDN'T I HAVE DREAMED OF
IT, SAID SILVERHORN. SAD NIGHT, SAD NIGHT. WHERE IS THE OTHER
CREATURE? FLIT HERE, SAID F-JAGRID IN A SHAKING VOICE. SHALL WE

SHALL WE DO IT, THEN? THE THREE OF THEM STEPPED FLIT INTO THE
BACK GARDEN. THE MOON WAS GLISTENING PALELY THROUGH THE TREES
NEED, AND ITS RAYS MINGLED WITH THE LIGHT SPILLING FROM F-JAGRID'S
WINDOW THE ILLUMINATE ARACHNE'S BODY LYING ON THE EDGE OF A
MASSIVE PIT BESIDE A TEN-FOOT-HIGH MOUND OF FRESHLY DUG EARTH.

MAGNIFICENT, SAID SILVERHORN, APPROACHING THE SPIDER'S HEAD,
WHERE EIGHT MILKY EYES STARED BLANKLY AT THE SKY AND TWO HUGE,
CLAWED PINNERS STOOD, MOUTHLESS, IN THE MIDDENLIGHT. F-JAGRID
THOUGHT HE HEARD THE TINKLE OF KETTLES AS SILVERHORN BENT OVER THE
PINNERS, APPARENTLY EXAMINING THE ENORMOUS HAIRY HEAD. IT'S
NOT BY ANY MEANS APPRECIATES THEM EXACTLY AS THEY ARE, SAID F-JAGRID THE
SILVERHORN'S BACK, TEARS LEADING FROM THE CORNERS OF HIS CRINKLED
EYES. I DIDN'T KNOW YOU WERE INTO RESTED IN CREATURES LIKE ARACHNE,
F-JAGRID. INTERESTED? MY DEAR F-JAGRID, I REVERE THEM, SAID
SILVERHORN, STEPPING BACK FROM THE BODY. F-JAGRID SAW THE GLINT OF A
KETTLE DISAPPEAR BENEATH HIS CHIN, THOUGH F-JAGRID, MEPPING HIS
EYES HENCE MORE, NOTICED NOTHING. WHEN SHALL WE PROCEED TO THE
BURIAL? F-JAGRID NODDED AND MOVED FORWARD. HE HEAVED THE GIGANTIC
SPIDER INTO HIS ARMS AND, WITH AN ENORMOUS GRUNT, DROPPED IT INTO
THE DARK PIT. IT HIT THE BOTTOM WITH A RATHER HORRIBLE, CLINKING
THUD. F-JAGRID STARTED TO CRY AGAIN. OF COURSE, IT'S DIFFICULT FOR

WELL, WHEN I KNOW HIM BEST, SAID SLUGGISHORN, WHEN LIKE FARRY CHILD
REACH THE HIGHER THAN FAGRID'S EYES, BUT PATTED IT ALL THE SAME.

WELL THEN I SAY A FEW WORDS? HE MUST HAVE GOTTEN A LOT OF GOOD
FELICITY WHEN FROM ARACHNE, FARRY THOUGHT, FOR SLUGGISHORN WERE
A SATISFIED SMILE AS HE STEPPED UP THE THE RIM OF THE PIT AND SAID, IN
A SILENT, IMPRESSIVE VOICE, FAREWELL, ARACHNE, KING OF ARACHNIDS,
WHOSE LONG AND FAITHFUL FRIENDSHIP THESE WHEN I KNOW WELL WHEN I
FORGET? THOUGH YOUR BODY WILL DECAY, YOUR SPIRIT LINGERS ON IN
THE HEAVEN, WIND-SPUN PLACES OF YOUR FINEST HOME, MAY YOUR MANY-
EYED DESCENDANTS EVER FLOURISH AND YOUR HUMAN FRIENDS FIND SOLACE
FOR THE LOSS THEY HAVE SUSTAINED. THAT WAS THAT WAS
REALITY! HEARD FAGRID, AND HE COLLAPSED INTO THE DEEPEST
HOLE, CRYING HARDER THAN EVER. THERE, THERE, SAID SLUGGISHORN,
WAVING HIS HAND SEE THAT THE HIGH PILE OF EARTH RISE UP AND THEN
FELL, WITH A MUFFLED SOUND OF CRASH, INTO THE DEAD SPIDER, FORMING A
SMOOTH MOUND. LET'S GET INSIDE AND HAVE A DRINK, GET ON HIS
OTHER SIDE, FARRY. THAT'S IT. UP WELL HERE, FAGRID WELL
THINK THEY DEPOSITED FAGRID IN A CHAIR AT THE TABLE, FANG, WHEN
HAD BEEN SLEEPING IN HIS BASKET DURING THE BURIAL, NOW CAME
PADDLING SILENTLY ACROSS THE THEM AND PUT HIS HEAVY HEAD INTO
FARRY'S LAP AS USUAL. SLUGGISHORN LINGERED HERE OF THE BOTTLES OF
WINE HE HAD BROUGHT. I HAVE HAD IT ALL TESTED FOR POISON, HE
ASSURED FARRY, POURING MOST OF THE FIRST BOTTLE INTO ONE OF
FAGRID'S BUCKET-SIZED MUGS AND HANDING IT TO FAGRID. FAGRID A
FELICIOUS TASTE EVERY BOTTLE AFTER WHAT HAPPENED TO THE OTHER
FRIEND RUPERT. FARRY SAW, IN HIS MIND'S EYE, THE EXPRESSION ON
FAGRID'S FACE IF SHE EVER HEARD ABOUT THIS LOSS OF FELICIOUS-
AND DECIDED NEVER TO MENTION IT TO HER. HERE FOR FARRY SAID
SLUGGISHORN, DIVIDING A SECOND BOTTLE BETWEEN TWO MUGS, AND HERE
FOR ME, WELL HE RAISED HIS MUG HIGH TO ARACHNE.

ARACHNE, SAID FARRY AND FAGRID TOGETHER, BOTH SLUGGISHORN AND
FAGRID DRANK DEEPLY, FARRY, HOWEVER, WITH THE WAY AHEAD
ILLUMINATED FOR HIM BY FELIX FELICIS, KNEW THAT HE MUST NOT DRINK,
SEE HE MERELY PRETENDED TO TAKE A GLIP AND THEN SET THE MUG BACK
ON THE TABLE BEFORE HIM. I HAD HIM FROM AN EGG, WHEN I KNOW, SAID
FAGRID MEANS. TINY LITTLE THING HE WAS WHEN HE HATCHED,
ABOUT THE SIZE OF A PERRINSE. SWEET, SAID SLUGGISHORN, USED TO
KEEP HIM IN A CLIPBOARD UP AT THE SKY UNTIL WELL

ARACHNE, SAID FARRY AND FAGRID TOGETHER, BOTH SLUGGISHORN AND
FAGRID DRANK DEEPLY, FARRY, HOWEVER, WITH THE WAY AHEAD
ILLUMINATED FOR HIM BY FELIX FELICIS, KNEW THAT HE MUST NOT DRINK,
SEE HE MERELY PRETENDED TO TAKE A GLIP AND THEN SET THE MUG BACK
ON THE TABLE BEFORE HIM. I HAD HIM FROM AN EGG, WHEN I KNOW, SAID
FAGRID MEANS. TINY LITTLE THING HE WAS WHEN HE HATCHED,

ABOUT THE SIZE OF A PERRINSE. SWEET, SAID SLUGGISHORN, USED TO
KEEP HIM IN A CLIPBOARD UP AT THE SKY UNTIL WELL

F-JAGRID'S FACE DARKENED AND F-JARRY DROVE UP! THEN RIDDLE HAD
CONTRIVED THE WAY F-JAGRID THEREON FELT HE SCHEMED, BLAMED FOR
HAPPENING THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS. SILVERHORN, HOWEVER, DID NOT SEEM
TO BE LISTENING; HE WAS LEANING UP AT THE CEILING, FROM WHICH A
NUMBER OF BRASS POTS HUNG, AND ALSO A LONG, SILKY SKIN OF BRIGHT
WHITE HAIR. THAT'S NEVER LINICORN HAIR, F-JAGRID? YES, YES,
SAID F-JAGRID INDIFFERENTLY. GETS PLUCKED FELT HE THEIR TAILS, THEY
CATCH IT IN BRANCHES AND STUFF IN THE FOREST, YES, DROVE UP BUT MY
DEAR CHAP, DO YOU KNOW HOW MUCH THAT'S WORTH? I USE IT FOR
BINDING MEN BANDAGES AND STUFF IF A CREATURE GETS INJURED, SAID
F-JAGRID, SMILING. IT'S DEAD USEFUL VERY STRONG, SEE.
SILVERHORN THEN ANOTHER DEEP DRAGHT FROM HIS MUG, HIS EYES
MOVING CAREFULLY AROUND THE LADY, LEANING, F-JARRY DROVE, FOR
MORE TREASURES THAT HE MIGHT BE ABLE TO CONVERT INTO A PLentiful
SUPPLY OF HAD-MATURED MEAD, CRYSTALIZED PINEAPPLE, AND VELVET
SMOKING JACKETS. HE REFILLED F-JAGRID'S MUG AND HIS OWN, AND
EXHIBITED HIM ABOUT THE CREATURES THAT LIVED IN THE FOREST THESE
DAYS AND HOW F-JAGRID WAS ABLE TO LEAD AFTER THEM ALL. F-JAGRID,
BECOMING EXPANSIVE UNDER THE INFLUENCE OF THE DRINK AND
SILVERHORN'S FLATTERING INTEREST, STOPPED MOPPING HIS EYES AND
ENTERED HAPPILY INTO A LONG EXPLANATION OF ELECTRICAL
HUSBANDRY. THE FELIX FELIX GAVE F-JARRY A LITTLE NUDGE AT THIS
POINT, AND HE REMARKED THAT THE SUPPLY OF DRINK THAT SILVERHORN HAD
BRIGHT WAS RUNNING OUT FAST. F-JARRY HAD NOT YET MANAGED TO
BRING OFF THE REFILLING CHARM WITHOUT SAYING THE INCANTATION
ALoud, BUT THE IDEA THAT HE MIGHT NOT BE ABLE TO DO IT TONIGHT WAS
LAUGHABLE! INDEED, F-JARRY GRINNED AT HIMSELF AS, UNNOTICED BY EITHER
F-JAGRID OR SILVERHORN (WHILE SWAPPING TALES OF THE ILLEGAL TRADE IN
DRAGON EGGS) HE POINTED HIS WAND UNDER THE TABLE AT THE EMPTYING
BOTTLES AND THEY IMMEDIATELY BEGAN TO REFILL. AFTER AN HOUR OR SO,
F-JAGRID AND SILVERHORN BEGAN MAKING EXTRAVAGANT THASTS: THE
F-JEWELRY, THE DUMPLINGS, THE ELF-MADE WINE, AND THE F-JARRY
POTTER? REMEMBERED F-JAGRID, SLEEPING SOME OF HIS SEVENTEENTH KICKET
OF WINE DOWN HIS CHIN AS HE DRAINED IT. YES, INDEED, CRIED
SILVERHORN A LITTLE THICKLY, PARRY BETTER, THE CHESSEY BEY WITH
WELL SOMETHING OF THAT SORT, HE MURMURED, AND DRAINED HIS MUG
TOO. NOT LONG AFTER THIS, F-JAGRID BECAME TEARFUL AGAIN AND PRESSED
THE WHITE LINICORN TAIL UPON SILVERHORN, WHO PICKED IT UP

CRIES HE, THE FRIENDSHIP! THE GENEROSITY! THE TEN GALLEONS A PAIR!
 AND AFTER A WHILE AFTER THAT, F-JAGRID AND SLUGG-HORN WERE SITTING SIDE
 BY SIDE, ARMS AROUND EACH OTHER, SINGING A SLEWY SAD SONG ABOUT A
 DYING WIZARD CALLED EDDIE. AARGH, THE GEMED DIED YELLING, MUTILATED
 F-JAGRID, SLUMPING DOWN BENTON THE TABLE, A LITTLE CROSS-EYED, WHILE
 SLUGG-HORN CONTINUED THE WARELE THE REMAIN. MY DAD WAS NEE AGE TEN
 GEM NEE WERE YER MUM AN DAD, F-JAGRID GREAT FAT TEARS BEEZED
 OUT OF THE CORNERS OF F-JAGRID'S CRINKLED EYES AGAIN; HE GRASPED
 F-JAGRID'S ARM AND SQUEEZED IT. YES WIZ AND WITCHARD IN THEIR AGE I
 NEVER KNOW TERRIBLE THING TERRIBLE THING AND EDDIE THE
 HERE, THEY KNEW HIM BACK HOME THE THE PLACE THAT HE'D KNOWN AS A
 LAD, SANE SLUGG-HORN PLAINLY, THEY LAID HIM THE REST WITH HIS
 HAT INSIDE OUT AND HIS HAND SNAPPED IN TWO, WHICH WAS SAD,
 TERRIBLE, F-JAGRID GRIEVED, AND HIS GREAT SLAGGY HEAD ROLLED
 SIDEWAYS BENTON HIS ARMS AND HE FELL ASLEEP, SNORING DEEPLY. SHIRRY,
 SAID SLUGG-HORN WITH A HICUP, CAN'T CARRY A TUNE THE SAVE MY LIFE,
 F-JAGRID WASN'T TALKING ABOUT YELLER SINGING, SAID F-JAGRID HEARTILY,
 HE WAS TALKING ABOUT MY MUM AND DAD DYING, EH, SAID
 SLUGG-HORN, REPRESSING A LARGE BELCH. EH DEAR, YES, THAT WAS
 WAS TERRIBLE INDEED, TERRIBLE TERRIBLE HE WINKED WHITE AT A
 BESS AFTER WHAT THE SAY, AND RESORTED THE REFILLING THEIR MUGS, I BEEN T
 BEEN T SLIPPERE YELL REMEMBER IT, F-JAGRID? HE ASKED ALONGWARDLY,
 NEE WELL, I WAS ONLY ONE WHEN THEY DIED, SAID F-JAGRID, HIS EYES
 IN THE FLAME OF THE CANDLE FLICKERING IN F-JAGRID'S HEAVY SNORES,
 BUT I VE FEELING OUT PRETTY MUCH WHAT HAPPENED SINCE, MY DAD DIED
 FIRST, DID YELL KNOW THAT? I I DIDN'T, SAID SLUGG-HORN IN A
 FLUSHED VOICE. YEAH VERDERMERT MURDERED HIM AND THEN STEPPED
 OVER HIS BODY TOWARD MY MUM, SAID F-JAGRID, SLUGG-HORN GAVE A GREAT
 SHILDER, BUT HE DID NOT SEEM ABLE TO TEAR HIS FRIGHTENED GAZE AWAY
 FROM F-JAGRID'S FACE. HE TOLD HER THE GET OUT OF THE WAY, SAID F-JAGRID
 REMORSELESSLY, HE TOLD ME SHE NEEDN'T HAVE DIED, HE ONLY WANTED
 ME, SHE COULD HAVE RUN, EH DEAR, KEATHED SLUGG-HORN, SHE
 COULD HAVE SHE NEEDN'T THAT'S AWFUL, IT IS, ISN'T IT?
 SAID F-JAGRID, IN A VOICE BARELY MORE THAN A WHISPER, BUT SHE DIDN'T
 MOVE, DAD WAS ALREADY DEAD, BUT SHE DIDN'T WANT ME THE GEM THEM, SHE
 TRIED THE PLEAD WITH VERDERMERT BUT HE JUST LAUGHED, THAT'S
 ENOUGH! SAID SLUGG-HORN SUDDENLY, RAISING A SHAKING HAND,
 REALLY, MY DEAR KID, ENOUGH I'M AN OLD MAN I BEEN T NEED THE

HEAR I DERN T WANT THE HEAR I FERGHT, LIRD F-JARRY, FELIX
FELIXIS LEADING HIM HEN. YELI LIKED HER, DIDN T YELI? LIKED HER?
SAID SILGHEARN, HIS EYES CRIMMING WITH TEARS HENCE MERE. I DERN T
IMAGINE ANYONE WITH MET HER WHELDON T HAVE LIKED HER. VERY
BRAVE VERY PLINDY IT WAS THE MOST HORRIBLE THING. BUT
YELI WHEN T HELP HER SEN, SAID F-JARRY. SHE GAVE ME HER LIFE, BUT
YELI WHEN T GIVE ME A MEMERY. F-JARRID S BLINKING SPHERES FILLED THE
CARKIN, F-JARRY WHISKED STEADILY INTO SILGHEARN S TEAR-FILLED EYES. THE
PHTHENS MASTER SEEMED LINABLE THE WHISK AWAY, DERN T SAY THAT, HE
WHISPERED, IT ISN T A HOLSTHEN IF IT WERE THE HELP YELI, HE
CHLIRSE BUT NE PLIRPHSE CAN BE SERVED IT CAN, SAID F-JARRY
CLEARLY. DUMKEDHERE NEEDS INFORMATION, I NEED INFORMATION, F-JE
DKNEL HE WAS SAFE: FELIX WAS TELLING HIM THAT SILGHEARN WOULD
REMEMBER NOTHING OF THIS IN THE MORNINE, BLINKING SILGHEARN
STRAIGHT IN THE EYE, F-JARRY LEANED FORWARD A LITTLE. I AM THE
CHHSEN HNE, I HAVE THE KILL HIM, I NEED THAT MEMERY, SILGHEARN
TURNED PALER THAN EVER; HIS SHINY THREE-HEAD GLAZED WITH SWEAT.
YELI ARE THE CHHSEN HNE? HE CHLIRSE I AM, SAID F-JARRY CALMLY,
BUT THEN MY DEAR KHY YELI RE ASKING A GREAT DEAL YELI RE
ASKING ME, IN FACT, THE AID YELI IN YELIR ATTEMPT THE DESTREY
YELI DERN T WANT THE GET RID OF THE WIZARD WITH KILLED LILY EVANS?
F-JARRY, F-JARRY, HE CHLIRSE I DEH, BUT YELI RE STARED HE LL FIND
HUT YELI HELPED ME? SILGHEARN SAID NOTHING; HE WHISKED TERRIFIED,
BE BRAVE LIKE MY METHER, PROFESSOR, SILGHEARN RAISED A PLIDY
HAND AND PRESSED HIS SHAKING FINGERS THE HIS MEELTH; HE WHISKED HER
A MOMENT LIKE AN ENTHRALLISLY HYPERGHELIN BABY, I AM NEET PREHID
HE WHISPERED THROUGH HIS FINGERS, I AM ASHAMED OF WHAT
OF WHAT THAT MEMERY STHELS. I THINK I MAY HAVE DONE GREAT
DAMAGE THAT DAY. YELI D CANCEL HUT ANYTHING YELI DID BY GIVING
ME THE MEMERY, SAID F-JARRY, IT WOULD BE A VERY BRAVE AND NEELE
THING THE DEH. F-JARRID TWITCHED IN HIS SLEEP AND SNEERED HEN.
SILGHEARN AND F-JARRY STARED AT EACH OTHER EVER THE GLITTERING
CANDLE, THERE WAS A LONG, LONG SILENCE, BUT FELIX FELIXIS THLD F-JARRY
NEET THE BREAD IT, THE WAIT. THEN, VERY SLEENLY, SILGHEARN PLIT HIS
HAND IN HIS POCKET AND PULLED HUT HIS WAND, F-JE PLIT HIS OTHER
HAND INSIDE HIS CHEAD AND THEEK HUT A SMALL, EMPTY BOTTLE. STILL
WHISKING INTO F-JARRY S EYES, SILGHEARN TWICKED THE TIP OF HIS WAND
THE HIS TEMPLE AND WITH-DREW IT, SEE THAT A LONG, SILVER THREAD OF

MEMPHY CAME ALONG THEM, CLINGING TO THE WAND TIP, LINGER AND LINGER THE MEMPHY STRETCHED UNTIL IT BROKE AND SELLING, SILVERY BRIGHT, FROM THE WAND, SILVER-HORN LOWERED IT INTO THE KETTLE WHERE IT CHILLED, THEN SPREAD, SWIRLING LIKE GAS, F-ER CHOKED THE KETTLE WITH A TREMKING HAND AND THEN PASSED IT ACROSS THE TABLE TO F-JARRY.

THANK YOU VERY MUCH, PROFESSOR. YOU'RE A GOOD KID, SAID PROFESSOR SILVER-HORN, TEARS TRICKLING DOWN HIS FAT CHEEKS INTO HIS WALRUS MUSTACHE. AND YOU'VE GOT HER EYES. JUST BEEN T-THINKING THAT BADLY IF WE HENCE YOU'VE SEEN IT. AND HE THEN PUT HIS HEAD ON HIS ARMS, GAVE A DEEP SIGH, AND FELL ASLEEP. F-JERRY COULD FEEL THE FELIX FELIX WEARING OFF AS HE CREEPT BACK INTO THE CASTLE. THE FRONT DOOR HAD REMAINED UNLOCKED FOR HIM, BUT ON THE THIRD FLOOR HE MET PEEVES AND ONLY NARROWLY AVOIDED DETECTION BY DIVING SIDELWAYS THROUGH ONE OF HIS SHORTCUTS. BY THE TIME HE GOT UP TO THE PORTRAIT OF THE FAT LADY AND PULLED OFF HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK, HE WAS NOT SURPRISED TO FIND HER IN A MOST UNHELPFUL MIND.

WHAT SHORT OF TIME DO YOU CALL THIS? I'M REALLY SORRY I HAD TO GO AWAY FOR SOMETHING IMPORTANT. WELL, THE PASSWORD CHANGED AT MIDNIGHT, SO YOU'LL JUST HAVE TO SLEEP IN THE HALLWAY, WON'T YOU? YOU'RE JOKING? SAID F-JARRY. WHY DID IT HAVE TO CHANGE AT MIDNIGHT? THAT'S THE WAY IT IS, SAID THE FAT LADY. IF YOU'RE ANGRY, GO AND TALK IT UP WITH THE HEADMASTER, HE'S THE ONE WHO'S TIGHTENED SECURITY. FANTASTIC, SAID F-JARRY BITTERLY, MURDERING AROUND AT THE HARD FLOOR. REALLY BRILLIANT, YEAH, I WOULD GO AND TALK IT UP WITH DUMBLEDORE IF HE WAS HERE, BECAUSE HE'S THE ONE WHO WANTED ME TO. HE IS HERE, SAID A VOICE BEHIND F-JARRY.

PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE RETURNED THE OTHER SCHOOL AND FEELER AGH. NEARLY HEADLESS NICK WAS GLIDING TOWARD F-JARRY, HIS HEAD WHIRLING AS USUAL UPON HIS RUFF. I HAD IT FROM THE BLEEDY KAREN, WHO SAW HIM ARRIVE, SAID NICK. HE APPEARED, ACCORDING TO THE KAREN, TO BE IN GOOD SPIRITS, THOUGH A LITTLE TIRED, IF COURSE. WHERE IS HE? SAID F-JARRY, HIS HEART LEAPING. EH, GRABING AND CLANKING UP ON THE ASTROPHYSICAL TOWER, IT'S A FAVORITE PASTIME OF HIS. NOT THE BLEEDY KAREN DUMBLEDORE? EH, IN HIS OFFICE, SAID NICK.

I BELIEVE, FROM WHAT THE KAREN SAID, THAT HE HAD BUSINESS TO ATTEND TO BEFORE TURNING IN. YEAH, HE HAS, SAID F-JARRY, EXCITEMENT BLAZING IN HIS CHEST AT THE PROSPECT OF TELLING DUMBLEDORE HE HAD SECURED THE MEMPHY. HE WHEELED AROUND AND

SPRINTED OFF AGAIN, IGNORING THE FAT LADY WHO WAS CALLING AFTER HIM. [HEE BACK! ALL RIGHT, I LIE! I WAS ANNOYED WHEN HEARD ME LIE! THE PASSWORD IS STILL TAPLEWHIM! BUT HARRY WAS ALREADY FLURTLING BACK ALONG THE CORRIDOR AND WITHIN MINUTES, HE WAS SAYING THREE CHAIRS THE DUMBLEDORE'S GARGOYLE, WHICH LEAPT ASIDE, PERMITTING HARRY ENTRANCE INTO THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE. ENTER, SAID DUMBLEDORE WHEN HARRY DESCENDED, HE SEEMED EXHAUSTED, HARRY PUSHED OPEN THE DOOR. THERE WAS DUMBLEDORE'S OFFICE, LOOKING THE SAME AS EVER, BUT WITH BLACK, STAR-STREWN SKIES BEYOND THE WINDOWS. GOOD GRACIOUS, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE IN SURPRISE. THE WHAT DO I HAVE THIS VERY LATE PLEASURE? SIR I'VE GOT IT, I'VE GOT THE MEMORY FROM SLYTHERIN. HARRY PULLED OUT THE TINNY GLASS KETTLE AND SHOWED IT TO DUMBLEDORE, FOR A MOMENT HER TWO, THE HEADMASTER LOOKED STUNNED, THEN HIS FACE SPLIT IN A WIDE SMILE.

HARRY, THIS IS SPECTACULAR NEWS! VERY WELL DONE INDEED! I KNEW YOU COULD DO IT! ALL THE LIGHT OF THE LATENESS OF THE HOUR APPARENTLY FORGOTTEN, HE FLURRIED AROUND HIS DESK, THEN THE KETTLE WITH SLYTHERIN'S MEMORY IN HIS UNFINGERED HAND, AND STRODE TOWARD THE CABINET WHERE HE KEPT THE PENSIVE. AND THEN, SAID DUMBLEDORE, PLACING THE STONE BASIN UPON HIS DESK AND EMPTYING THE CONTENTS OF THE KETTLE INTO IT. THEN, AT LAST, WE SHALL SEE. HARRY, QUICKLY HARRY RUSHED HEDIENTLY TOWARD THE PENSIVE AND FELT HIS FEET LEAVE THE OFFICE FLOOR. THENCE AGAIN HE FELL THROUGH DARKNESS AND LANDED IN HERACE SLYTHERIN'S OFFICE MANY YEARS BEFORE. THERE WAS THE MUCH YOUNGER SLYTHERIN, WITH HIS THICK, SHINY, STRAWBEARED HAIR AND HIS GINGERY-BLOND MUSTACHE, SITTING AGAIN IN THE COMFORTABLE WINGED ARMCHAIR IN HIS OFFICE, HIS FEET RESTING UPON A VELVET PUFF, A SMALL GLASS OF WINE IN ONE HAND, THE OTHER SLIPMAGING IN A BOWL OF CRYSTALIZED PINEAPPLE. AND THERE WERE THE HALF-DOZEN TEENAGE KIDS SITTING AROUND SLYTHERIN WITH THEM RIDDLE IN THE MIDST OF THEM, MARVELLUS'S GILDADE-BLACK RING GLEAMING ON HIS FINGER. DUMBLEDORE LANDED BESIDE HARRY INSTANT AS RIDDLE ASKED, SIR, IS IT TRUE THAT PROFESSOR MERRYWEIGHT IS RETIRING? THEM, THEM, IF I KNEW I COULDN'T TELL YOU, SAID SLYTHERIN, WAGGING HIS FINGER REPROVINGLY AT RIDDLE, THOUGH WINKING AT THE SAME TIME. I MUST SAY, I'D LIKE TO KNOW WHERE YOU GET YOUR INFORMATION, KID, MORE KNOWLEDGEABLE THAN HALF THE STAFF, YOU ARE. RIDDLE SMILED; THE OTHER KIDS LAUGHED AND LEFT HIM

ADMIRING LOOKS. WHAT WITH THEIR LINGERING ABILITY TO KNOW THINGS THEY SHOULDNT, AND THEIR CAREFUL FLATTERY OF THE PEOPLE WHO MATTER. THAND THEY ARE THE PINEAPPLE, BY THE WAY, THEY'RE ELITE RIGHT, IT IS MY FAVORITE. SEVERAL OF THE KIDS TITTERED AGAIN. I CONFIDENTLY EXPECT THEY'LL RISE THE MINISTER OF MAGIC WITHIN TWENTY YEARS, FIFTEEN, IF THEY KEEP SENDING ME PINEAPPLE. I HAVE EXCELLENT CONTACTS AT THE MINISTRY. THEN RIDDLE MERELY SMILED AS THE OTHERS LAUGHED AGAIN. HARRY NOTICED THAT HE WAS BY NO MEANS THE ELDEST OF THE GROUP OF KIDS, BUT THAT THEY ALL SEEMED TO VIEW HIM AS THEIR LEADER. I DONT KNOW THAT POLITICS WOULD SUIT ME, SIR, HE SAID WHEN THE LAUGHTER HAD DIED AWAY. I DONT HAVE THE RIGHT KIND OF BACKGROUND, FOR ONE THING. A GROUP OF THE KIDS AROUND HIM SMIRKED AT EACH OTHER. HARRY WAS SURE THEY WERE ENJOYING A PRIVATE Joke, UNDELETEDLY ABOUT WHAT THEY KNEW, HE SUSPECTED, REGARDING THEIR GANG LEADER'S FAMILIAR ANCESTRY.

NONSENSE, SAID SLUGGISH CRISPLY, CHILDEN T BE PLAINER THEY COME FROM DECENT WIZARDING STOCK, ABILITIES LIKE YOURS. NO, THEY'LL GO FAR, THEN, I'VE NEVER BEEN WRITING ABOUT A STUDENT YET. THE SMALL CHILDEN CLICHÉ STANDING UPON SLUGGISH'S DESK CHIMED ELEVEN IN CHIME BEHIND HIM AND HE LOOKED AROUND. GOOD GRACIES, IS IT THAT TIME ALREADY? THEY'D BETTER GET GOING, KIDS, OR WE'LL ALL BE IN TROUBLE. LE STRANGER, I WANT YOUR ESSAY BY TOMORROW OR IT'S DETENTION. SAME CHECKS FOR YOU, AVERY. ONE BY ONE, THE KIDS FILED OUT OF THE ROOM. SLUGGISH HEAVED HIMSELF OUT OF HIS ARMCHAIR AND CARRIED HIS EMPTY GLASS OVER TO HIS DESK. A MOVEMENT BEHIND HIM MADE HIM LOOK AROUND; RIDDLE WAS STILL STANDING THERE. LOOK SHARP, THEN, THEY DONT WANT TO BE CAUGHT OUT OF BED OUT OF FEELERS, AND YOU A PERFECT. SIR, I WANTED TO ASK YOU SOMETHING. ASK AWAY, THEN, M KID, ASK AWAY. SIR, I WONDERED WHAT YOU KNOW ABOUT

ABOUT HERCULES? SLUGGISH STARED AT HIM, HIS THICK FINGERS ASSENTMINDFULLY CARESSING THE STEM OF HIS WINE GLASS. PERFECT FOR DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS, IS IT? BUT HARRY COULD TELL THAT SLUGGISH KNEW PERFECTLY WELL THAT THIS WAS NOT SCHEMERING.

NOT EXACTLY, SIR, SAID RIDDLE. I CAME ACROSS THE TERM WHILE READING AND I DONT FULLY UNDERSTAND IT. NO, WELL, THEY'D BE HARD-PUISHED TO FIND A KID AT HOGWARTS THAT'LL GIVE YOU DETAILS ON HERCULES, THEN, THAT'S VERY DARK STUFF, VERY DARK INDEED, SAID SLUGGISH. BUT YOU EVIDENTLY KNOW ALL ABOUT THEM, SIR? I MEAN, A

WIZARD LIKE YELL SHIRRY, I MEAN, IF YELL CAN T TELL ME, HEVTHELISLY I ILST KNOW IF ANYONE CHULD TELL ME, YELL CHULD SH I ILST TEEHUGHT I D ASK IT WAS VERY WELL DONE, TEEHUGHT F-JARRY, THE HESITANCY, THE CASUAL TONE, THE CAREFUL FLATTERY, NONE OF IT EVERDENE, F-JE, F-JARRY, HAD HAD THEE MUCH EXPERIENCE OF TRYING THE WHEELDE INFORMATION HOLT OF RELUCTANT PEEPLE NHT THE RECHGNIZE A MASTER AT WORK, F-JE CHULD TELL THAT RIDDLE WANTED THE INFORMATION VERY, VERY MUCH; PERHAPS HAD BEEN WORKING TOWARD THIS MOMENT FOR WEEKS. WELL, SAID SLUGGISHORN, NHT LOOKING AT RIDDLE, BUT FIDDLING WITH THE RIKKEN HEN THEP OF HIS EYES OF CRYSTALIZED PINEAPPLE. WELL, IT CAN T HURT THE GIVE YELL AN OVERVIEW, OF COURSE, ILST SEE THAT YELL UNDERSTAND THE TERM. A F-JERICLIK IS THE WORD USED FOR AN EFFECT IN WHICH A PERSON HAS CONCEALED PART OF THEIR SELF. I DEN T ELITE UNDERSTAND F-HEN THAT WORDS, TEEHUGHT, SIR, SAID RIDDLE. F-HIS VOICE WAS CAREFULLY CONTROLLED, BUT F-JARRY CHULD SENSE HIS EXCITEMENT. WELL, YELL SPLIT YELLR SELF, YELL SEE, SAID SLUGGISHORN, AND HIDE PART OF IT IN AN EFFECT HLTIDE THE BODY. THEN, EVEN IF HNE S BODY IS ATTACKED OR DESTROYED, HNE CANNHT DIE, FOR PART OF THE SELF REMAINS EARTH-BIND AND UNDAAGED, BUT OF COURSE, EXISTENCE IN SUCH A FORM SLUGGISHORN S FACE CRUMPLED AND F-JARRY FELND HIMSELF REMEMBERING WORDS HE HAD HEARD NEARLY TWO YEARS BEFORE: I WAS RIPPED FROM MY BODY, I WAS LESS THAN SPIRIT, LESS THAN THE MEANEST GHOST BUT STILL, I WAS ALIVE. FEW WOULD WANT IT, THEN, VERY FEW, DEATH WOULD BE PREFERABLE. BUT RIDDLE S HLINGER WAS NHT APPARENT; HIS EXPRESSION WAS GREEDY, HE CHULD NHT HNGER HIDE HIS HNGING. F-HEN DEE YELL SPLIT YELLR SELF?

WELL, SAID SLUGGISHORN UNCOMFORTABLY, YELL MUST UNDERSTAND THAT THE SELF IS SUPPOSED TO REMAIN INTACT AND WHOLE. SPLITTING IT IS AN ACT OF VIOLATION, IT IS AGAINST NATURE. BUT F-HEN DEE YELL DEE IT?

BY AN ACT OF EVIL THE SUPREME ACT OF EVIL, BY COMMITTING MURDER, KILLING RIPS THE SELF APART. THE WIZARD INTENT UPON CREATING A F-JERICLIK WOULD USE THE DAMAGE TO HIS ADVANTAGE: F-JE WOULD ENCASE THE THORN PERTHIN ENCASE? BUT F-HEN ?

THERE IS A SPELL, DEE NHT ASK ME, I DEN T KNOW! SAID SLUGGISHORN, SHAKING HIS HEAD LIKE AN OLD ELEPHANT KENTHERED BY MESSELITHES. DEE I HND AS TEEHUGHT I HAVE TRIED IT DEE I HND LIKE A DILLER? NHT, SIR, OF COURSE NHT, SAID RIDDLE QUICKLY, I M SHIRRY I DIDN T MEAN THE HPPEND NHT AT ALL, NHT AT ALL, NHT HPPENDED, SAID SLUGGISHORN

GRUPLY. IT'S NATURAL THEY FEEL SOME CLARITY ABOUT THESE THINGS.

WIZARDS OF A CERTAIN CALIBRE HAVE ALWAYS BEEN DRAWN TO THAT ASPECT OF MAGIC. YES, SIR, SAID RIDDLE. WHAT I DON'T UNDERSTAND, HOWEVER, IS JUST WHAT OF CLARITY I MEAN, WOULD HAVE ENLIGHTENED REASON LIKE? CAN THEY ONLY SPLIT THEIR SKIN BACK? WOULD IT BE BETTER, MAKE THEM STRONGER, THEN HAVE THEIR SKIN IN MORE PIECES, I MEAN, FOR INSTANCE, ISN'T SEVEN THE MOST POWERFULLY MAGICAL NUMBER, WOULD IT BE SEVEN? MERLIN'S BARD, THEN? HELPED SILENTLY. SEVEN? ISN'T IT BAD ENOUGH THE THING OF KILLING ONE PERSON? AND IN ANY CASE BAD ENOUGH TO DIVIDE THE SKIN BUT THE RIP IT INTO SEVEN PIECES. SILENTLY BREATHED DEEPLY TREMBLED NOW: HE WAS GAZING AT RIDDLE AS THOUGH HE HAD NEVER SEEN HIM PLAINLY BEFORE, AND HARRY COULD TELL THAT HE WAS REGRETTING ENTERING INTO THE CONVERSATION AT ALL. OF COURSE, HE MUTTERED, THIS IS ALL HYPOTHETICAL, WHAT WE'RE DISCUSSING, ISN'T IT? ALL ACADEMIC. YES, SIR, HE CHIRPED, SAID RIDDLE QUICKLY, BUT ALL THE SAME, THEN KEEP IT QUIET, WHAT I'VE TOLD THAT'S THE SAY, WHAT WE'VE DISCUSSED, PEOPLE WOULD NOT LIKE THE THING WE'VE BEEN CHATTING ABOUT ENLIGHTENED REASON. IT'S A BANNED SUBJECT AT HOGWARTS, THEY KNOW. DUMBLEDORE'S PARTICULARLY FIERCE ABOUT IT. I DON'T SAY A WORD, SIR, SAID RIDDLE, AND HE LEFT, BUT NOT BEFORE HARRY HAD GLIMPSED HIS FACE, WHICH WAS FULL OF THAT SAME WILD HAPPINESS IT HAD WHEN WHEN HE HAD FIRST FELT THAT HE WAS A WIZARD, THE SORT OF HAPPINESS THAT DID NOT ENHANCE HIS HANDSOME FEATURES, BUT MADE THEM, SOMEHOW, LESS HUMAN. THANK YOU, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY. LET US GO. WHEN HARRY LANDED BACK IN THE OFFICE ALTHOUGH DUMBLEDORE WAS ALREADY SITTING DOWN BEHIND HIS DESK, HARRY SAT THERE AND WAITED FOR DUMBLEDORE TO SPEAK. I HAVE BEEN HOPING FOR THIS PIECE OF EVIDENCE FOR A VERY LONG TIME, SAID DUMBLEDORE AT LAST. IT CONFIRMS THE THEORY YOU WHICH I HAVE BEEN WORKING, IT TELLS ME THAT I AM RIGHT, AND ALSO FEELS VERY FAR THERE IS STILL THE GO. HARRY SUDDENLY NOTICED THAT EVERY SINGLE ONE OF THE OLD HEADMASTERS AND HEADMISTRESSES IN THE PORTRAITS AROUND THE WALLS WAS AWAKE AND LISTENING IN ON THEIR CONVERSATION. A COMPLACENT, RED-NOSSED WIZARD HAD ACTUALLY TAKEN THAT AN EAR TRUMPET. WELL, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, I AM SURE YOU UNDERSTAND THE SIGNIFICANCE OF WHAT WE JUST HEARD. AT THE SAME AGE AS YOU ARE NOW, GIVE HER TAKE A FEW MONTHS, THEN RIDDLE WAS

BEING ALL HE COULD THE FIND OUT WHEN HE MADE HIMSELF IMMORTAL.

WELL THEN HE SUCCEEDED THEN, SIR? ASKED HARRY. HE MADE A
MAGIC? AND THAT'S WHY HE DIDN'T DIE WHEN HE ATTACKED ME? HE
HAD A MAGIC HIDDEN SOMEWHERE? A BIT OF HIS SKIN WAS SAFE? A
BIT OF HIS MIND, SAID DUMBLEDORE. WELL HEARD VOLDMORT: WHAT HE
PARTICULARLY WANTED FROM HERACE WAS AN OPPORTUNITY WHEN HEAT WOULD
HAPPEN THE THE WIZARD WHEN HE CREATED MORE THAN ONE MAGIC, WHAT
WOULD HAPPEN THE THE WIZARD SHE DETERMINED THE EVIL DEATH THAT HE
WOULD BE PREPARED THE MURDER MANY TIMES, AND HIS SKIN REPEATEDLY,
SEE AS THE STONE IT IN MANY, SEPARATELY CONCEALED MAGICS. SHE
KNEW WOULD HAVE GIVEN HIM THAT INFORMATION. AS FAR AS I KNOW

AS FAR, I AM SURE, AS VOLDMORT KNEW THE WIZARD HAD EVER
BEEN MORE THAN TEAR HIS SKIN IN TWO. DUMBLEDORE PAUSED FOR A
MOMENT, MARSHALLING HIS THOUGHTS, AND THEN SAID, FEW YEARS AGO,
I RECEIVED WHAT I CONSIDERED CERTAIN PROOF THAT VOLDMORT HAD
SPLIT HIS SKIN. WHERE? ASKED HARRY WELL? WELL HANDED IT TO
ME, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. THE DIARY, RIDDLE'S DIARY, THE ONE
GIVING INSTRUCTIONS WHEN HE WOULD REOPEN THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS. I
DIDN'T UNDERSTAND, SIR, SAID HARRY. WELL, ALTHOUGH I DID NOT SEE
THE RIDDLE WHEN HE CAME OUT OF THE DIARY, WHAT YOU DESCRIBED TO ME WAS
A PHENOMENON I HAD NEVER WITNESSED. A MERE MEMORY STARTING THE
ACT AND THINKING FOR ITSELF? A MERE MEMORY, SAVING THE LIFE OF
THE GIRL IN HER HANDS IT HAD FALLEN? YES, SOMETHING MUCH MORE
SINISTER HAD LIVED INSIDE THAT KNEW. A FRAGMENT OF SKIN, I WAS
ALMOST SURE OF IT. THE DIARY HAD BEEN A MAGIC, BUT THIS RAISED AS
MANY QUESTIONS AS IT ANSWERED. WHAT INTRIGUED AND ALARMED ME
MOST WAS THAT THAT DIARY HAD BEEN INTENDED AS A WEAPON AS MUCH
AS A SHELTER. I STILL DIDN'T UNDERSTAND, SAID HARRY. WELL, IT
WORKED AS A MAGIC IS SUPPOSED TO WORK. IN EITHER CASES, THE
FRAGMENT OF SKIN CONCEALED INSIDE IT WAS KEPT SAFE AND HAD
UNEXPECTEDLY PLAYED ITS PART IN PREVENTING THE DEATH OF ITS OWNER.
BUT THERE COULD BE ONE POSSIBILITY THAT RIDDLE REALLY WANTED THAT DIARY
READ, WANTED THE PIECE OF HIS SKIN TO INHABIT HIS POSSESSION SOMEHOW
ELSE, SEE THAT SLYTHERIN'S MONSTER WOULD BE UNLEASHED AGAIN.

WELL, HE DIDN'T WANT HIS HARD WORK TO BE WASTED, SAID HARRY. HE
WANTED PEOPLE TO KNOW HE WAS SLYTHERIN'S HEIR, BECAUSE HE
COULDN'T TAKE CREDIT AT THE TIME. EXACTLY CORRECT, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
NEEDING. BUT DIDN'T YOU SEE, HARRY, THAT IF HE INTENDED THE DIARY TO

HE PASSED THE HER PLANTED HER, SHEER FLITING F-HEGLARTS STUDENT, HE WAS
BEING REMARKABLY WAS ABLE THAT PRECISELY FRAGMENT OF HIS SKIN
CONCEALED WITHIN IT. THE POINT OF A F-HERCULES IS, AS PROFESSOR
SILVERHORN EXPLAINED, THE DEEP PART OF THE SELF HIDDEN AND SAFE, NOT
THE PLING IT INTO THE SHADOWS ELSE A PATH AND RUN THE RISK THAT THEY
MIGHT DESTROY IT AS INDEED HAPPENED: THAT PARTICULAR FRAGMENT
OF SKIN IS NOT THERE; YET SAW THE THAT. THE CARELESS WAY IN WHICH
VILDEMEHT REGARDED THIS F-HERCULES SEEMED MOST EMINENTLY THE ME. IT
SUGGESTED THAT HE MUST HAVE MADE HER BEEN PLANNING THE MAKE
MORE F-HERCULES, SHE THAT THE LOSS OF HIS FIRST WOULD NOT BE SHE
DETRIMENTAL. I DID NOT WISH TO BELIEVE IT, BUT NOTHING ELSE SEEMED TO
MAKE SENSE. THEN YET TOLD ME, TWO YEARS LATER, THAT ON THE NIGHT
THAT VILDEMEHT RETURNED TO HIS BODY, HE MADE A MOST ILLUMINATING
AND ALARMING STATEMENT TO HIS DEATH EATERS. I, WHO HAVE GONE
FURTHER THAN ANYBODY ALONG THE PATH THAT LEADS TO IMMORTALITY,
THAT WAS WHAT YET TOLD ME HE SAID. FURTHER THAN ANYBODY, AND I
THOUGHT I KNEW WHAT THAT MEANT, THOUGH THE DEATH EATERS DID
NOT, HE WAS REFERRING TO HIS F-HERCULES, F-HERCULES IN THE
PLURAL, HARRY, WHICH I DO NOT BELIEVE ANY OTHER WIZARD HAS EVER
HAD, YET IT FITTED: LORD VILDEMEHT HAS SEEMED TO GROW LESS HUMAN
WITH THE PASSING YEARS, AND THE TRANSFORMATION HE HAS UNDERGONE
SEEMED TO ME TO BE ONLY EXPLICABLE IF HIS SKIN WAS MUTILATED BEYOND
THE REALMS OF WHAT WE MIGHT CALL USUAL EVIL. SHE HE'S MADE
HIMSELF IMPOSSIBLE TO KILL BY MURDERING OTHER PEOPLE? SAID HARRY.

WHO COULD NOT HE MAKE A SERPENT'S STEAK, HER STEAL HER, IF HE WAS
SHE INTERESTED IN IMMORTALITY? WELL, WE KNOW THAT HE TRIED TO DO
JUST THAT, FIVE YEARS AGO, SAID SILVERHORN, BUT THERE ARE SEVERAL
REASONS WHY, I THINK, A SERPENT'S STEAK WOULD APPEAL LESS THAN
F-HERCULES TO LORD VILDEMEHT. WHILE THE ELIXIR OF LIFE DOES
INDEED EXTEND LIFE, IT MUST BE DRUNK REGULARLY, FOR ALL ETERNITY, IF
THE DRINKER IS TO MAINTAIN THEIR IMMORTALITY. THEREFORE,
VILDEMEHT WOULD BE ENTIRELY DEPENDENT ON THE ELIXIR, AND IF IT RAN
OUT, HE WAS CONTAMINATED, OR IF THE STEAK WAS STOLEN, HE WOULD DIE
JUST LIKE ANY OTHER MAN. VILDEMEHT LIKES TO OPERATE ALONE,
REMEMBER. I BELIEVE THAT HE WOULD HAVE FELT THE THOUGHT OF BEING
DEPENDENT, EVEN ON THE ELIXIR, INTOLERABLE. OF COURSE HE WAS
PREPARED TO DRINK IT IF IT WOULD TAKE HIM OUT OF THE HORRIBLE
PART-LIFE TO WHICH HE WAS CONDEMNED AFTER ATTACKING YET, BUT ONLY

THE REGAIN A BODY. THEREAFTER, I AM CONVINCED, HE INTENDED THE
 CONTINUE THE REPLY WITH HIS FINGERLINGS: HE WOULD NEED NOTHING MORE,
 IF ONLY HE COULD REGAIN A HUMAN FORM. HE WAS ALREADY IMMORTAL,
 YET SEE HER AS CLEAR THE IMMORTAL AS ANY MAN CAN BE. BUT NOW,
 HARRY, ARMED WITH THIS INFORMATION, THE CRUCIAL MOMENT YET HAVE
 SUCCEEDED IN PERCUSSING HER LIPS, WE ARE CLEARER THE THE SECRET OF
 FINISHING LORD VOLDEMORT THAN ANYONE HAS EVER BEEN BEFORE. YET
 HEARD HIM, HARRY: WOULD IT BE BETTER, MAKE YET STRONGER, THE
 HAVE YET SHOWN IN MORE PIECES ISN'T SEVEN THE MOST PERFECTLY
 MAGICAL NUMBER ISN'T SEVEN THE MOST PERFECTLY MAGICAL
 NUMBER. YES, I THINK THE IDEA OF A SEVEN-PART SHIELD WOULD GREATLY
 APPEAL THE LORD VOLDEMORT. HE MADE SEVEN FINGERLINGS? SAID
 HARRY, FINGER-STRIKE, WHILE SEVERAL OF THE PORTRAITS ON THE
 WALLS MADE SIMILAR NOISES OF SHOCK AND HISTRAGE. BUT THEY COULD BE
 ANYWHERE IN THE WORLD HIDDEN BLIND HER INVISIBLE I AM
 GLAD TO SEE YET APPRECIATE THE MAGNITUDE OF THE PROBLEM, SAID
 DUMBLEDORE CALMLY BUT FIRSTLY, NOW, HARRY, NOT SEVEN FINGERLINGS:
 SIX. THE SEVENTH PART OF HIS SHIELD, HOWEVER MAINED, RESIDES INSIDE
 HIS REGENERATED BODY. THAT WAS THE PART OF HIM THAT LIVED A
 SPECTRAL EXISTENCE FOR SEVEN YEARS DURING HIS EXILE; WITHOUT
 THAT, HE HAS NO SELF AT ALL. THAT SEVENTH PIECE OF SHIELD WILL BE THE
 LAST THAT ANYBODY WISHING TO KILL VOLDEMORT MUST ATTACK THE
 PIECE THAT LIVES IN HIS BODY. BUT THE SIX FINGERLINGS, THEN, SAID
 HARRY, A LITTLE DESPERATELY, HOW ARE WE SUPPOSED TO FIND THEM?
 YET ARE FORGETTING YET HAVE ALREADY DESTROYED ONE OF THEM,
 AND I HAVE DESTROYED ANOTHER. YET HAVE? SAID HARRY EAGERLY,
 YES INDEED, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND HE RAISED HIS BLACKENED,
 CLANNED-LOOKING HAND. THE RING, HARRY, MARVELLED A RING, AND A
 TERRIBLE CLASH THERE WAS WHEN IT THUD, HAD IT NOT BEEN AVOID
 ME THE LACK OF SEEMLY MODESTY FOR MY OWN PRODIGIOUS SKILL, AND
 FOR PROFESSOR SNAPE'S TIMELY ACTION WHEN I RETURNED THE
 FINGERLINGS, DESPERATELY INJURED, I MIGHT NOT HAVE LIVED TO TELL THE
 TALE. HOWEVER, A WITHERED HAND DOES NOT SEEM AN UNREASONABLE
 EXCHANGE FOR A SEVENTH OF VOLDEMORT'S SHIELD. THE RING IS NO
 LONGER A FINGERLING. BUT HOW DID YET FIND IT? WELL, AS YET NOW
 KNOW, FOR MANY YEARS I HAVE MADE IT MY BUSINESS TO DISCOVER AS
 MUCH AS I CAN ABOUT VOLDEMORT'S PAST LIFE. I HAVE TRAVELED WIDELY,
 VISITING THESE PLACES HE ONCE KNEW. I STUMBLED ACROSS THE RING

HIDDEN IN THE RUIN OF THE GALINTS HOUSE. IT SEEMS THAT SINCE
VOLDMEERT HAD SUCCEEDED IN SEALING A PIECE OF HIS SKIN INSIDE IT, HE
DID NOT WANT TO WEAR IT ANYMORE. HE HID IT, PROTECTED BY MANY
POWERFUL ENCHANTMENTS, IN THE SHACK WHERE HIS ANCESTORS HAD
SINCE LIVED (MERTIN HAVING BEEN CAUGHT BY THE AZDARAN, OF COURSE),
NEVER GUESSING THAT I MIGHT ONE DAY TAKE THE TRIBLE TO VISIT THE
RUIN, OR THAT I MIGHT BE KEEPING AN EYE UPON THE TRACES OF MAGICAL
ENCHANTMENT. HOWEVER, WE SHOULD NOT CONGRATULATE OURSELVES
TOO HEARTILY. YOU DESTROYED THE DIARY AND I THE RING, BUT IF WE ARE
RIGHT IN OUR THEORY OF A SEVEN-PART SKIN, FOUR FINGERLOCKS
REMAIN. AND THEY COULD BE ANYTHING? SAID HARRY. THEY COULD
BE OLD TIN CANS OR, I DUNNO, EMPTY POTION BOTTLES. YOU ARE
THINKING OF POTIONES, HARRY, WHICH MUST BE ORDINARY OBJECTS, EASY
TO OVERLOOK. BUT WOULD LORD VOLDMEERT USE TIN CANS OR OLD
POTION BOTTLES TO GUARD HIS OWN PRECIOUS SKIN? YOU ARE
FORGETTING WHAT I HAVE TOLD YOU, LORD VOLDMEERT LIKED THE
COLLECT THINGS, AND HE PREFERRED OBJECTS WITH A POWERFUL MAGICAL
HISTORY, HIS PRIDE, HIS BELIEF IN HIS OWN SUPERIORITY, HIS
DETERMINATION TO CARVE FOR HIMSELF A STARTLING PLACE IN MAGICAL
HISTORY; THESE THINGS SUGGEST TO ME THAT VOLDMEERT WOULD HAVE
CHOSEN HIS FINGERLOCKS WITH SOME CARE, FAVORING OBJECTS WORTHY OF
THE HONOR. THE DIARY WASN'T THAT SPECIAL. THE DIARY, AS YOU
HAVE SAID YOURSELF, WAS PROOF THAT HE WAS THE SON OF SLOTHERIN;
I AM SURE THAT VOLDMEERT CONSIDERED IT OF SLIGHTER
IMPORTANCE. SEE, THE OTHER FINGERLOCKS? SAID HARRY. OH YOU
THINK YOU KNOW WHAT THEY ARE, SIR? I CAN ONLY GUESS, SAID
OLMEDIER. FOR THE REASONS I HAVE ALREADY GIVEN, I BELIEVE THAT
LORD VOLDMEERT WOULD PREFER OBJECTS THAT, IN THEMSELVES, HAVE A
CERTAIN GRANDEUR. I HAVE THEREFORE TRAVELED BACK THROUGH
VOLDMEERT'S PAST TO SEE IF I CAN FIND EVIDENCE THAT SUCH ARTIFACTS
HAVE DISAPPEARED AROUND HIM. THE LOCKET? SAID HARRY HEEDILY.
SLIPPERLOCK'S CLIP? YES, SAID OLMEDIER, SMILING. I WOULD BE
PREPARED TO BET PERHAPS NOT MY OTHER HAND BUT A COUPLE OF
FINGERS, THAT THEY BECAME FINGERLOCKS THREE AND FOUR. THE
REMAINING TWO, ASSUMING AGAIN THAT HE CREATED A TOTAL OF SIX, ARE
MORE OF A PROBLEM, BUT I WILL HAZARD A GUESS THAT, HAVING SECURED
OBJECTS FROM SLIPPERLOCK AND SLOTHERIN, HE SET OUT THE TRACK OF
OBJECTS OWNED BY GRAYFINDER OR RAVENCLAW, FOUR OBJECTS FROM THE

PHILIP PHINDERS WOULD, I AM SURE, HAVE EXPERTED A PHENOMENAL PULL OVER
VILDEBERT'S IMAGINATION. I CANNOT ANSWER HER WHETHER HE EVER
MANAGED THE FIND ANYTHING OF RAVENCLAW'S. I AM CONFIDENT, HOWEVER,
THAT THE ONLY KNOWN RELIC OF GRYPFINDER REMAINS SAFE.

OLMEDIER POINTED HIS BLACKENED FINGERS TO THE WALL BEHIND HIM,
WHERE A RUBY-ENCASED SWORD REPOSED WITHIN A GLASS CASE. SHE FELT
THINK THAT SHE WOULD HE REALLY WANTED THE CHIEF BACK THE FIGHTERS,
SIR? SAID LARRY. THE TRY AND FIND SOMETHING FROM HERE OF THE
OTHER PHINDERS? MY THOUGHTS PRECISELY, SAID OLMEDIER, BUT
UNFORTUNATELY, THAT DOES NOT ADVANCE US MUCH FURTHER, FOR HE WAS
TURNED AWAY, FOR SHE I BELIEVE, WITHOUT THE CHANCE THE SEARCH THE
SECRET. I AM SURE THE CONCLUSION THAT HE NEVER FULFILLED HIS AMBITION
OF COLLECTING PHILIP PHINDERS' ARTS, HE DEFINITELY HAD THEM HE
MAY HAVE FELT THAT THAT IS THE BEST WE CAN DO FOR HIM.

EVEN IF HE GOT SOMETHING OF RAVENCLAW'S OR OF GRYPFINDER'S, THAT
LEAVES A SIXTH FINGER, SAID LARRY, CLIPPING HIS FINGERS.

UNLESS HE GOT BOTH? I DON'T THINK SHE, SAID OLMEDIER. I
THINK I KNOW WHAT THE SIXTH FINGER IS, I WONDER WHAT SHE WILL
SAY WHEN I TELL HER THAT I HAVE BEEN CURIOUS FOR A WHILE ABOUT THE
BEHAVIOR OF THE SNAKE, NAGINI? THE SNAKE? SAID LARRY,
STARTLED. SHE CAN USE ANIMALS AS FINGERS? WELL, IT IS
INADVISABLE TO DO SO, SAID OLMEDIER, BECAUSE THE CHIEF A PART OF
PHILIP SHELL THE SOMETHING THAT CAN THINK AND MOVE FOR ITSELF IS
EVEN MORE A VERY RISKY BUSINESS, HOWEVER, IF MY CALCULATIONS ARE
CORRECT, VILDEBERT WAS STILL AT LEAST ONE FINGER SHORT OF HIS
GOAL OF SIX WHEN HE ENTERED PHILIP PARENTS' HOUSE WITH THE
INTENTION OF KILLING HER. HE SEEMS TO HAVE RESERVED THE PROCESS
OF MAKING FINGERS FOR PARTICULARLY SIGNIFICANT DEATHS. SHE
WOULD CERTAINLY HAVE BEEN THAT, HE BELIEVED THAT IN KILLING HER, HE
WAS DESTROYING THE DANGER THE PROPHECY HAD OUTLINED, HE BELIEVED
HE WAS MAKING HIMSELF INVINCIBLE. I AM SURE THAT HE WAS INTENDING
TO MAKE HIS FINAL FINGER WITH PHILIP'S DEATH. AS WE KNOW, HE
FAILED. AFTER AN INTERVAL OF SOME YEARS, HOWEVER, HE USED NAGINI
TO KILL AN OLD MUGGLE MAN, AND IT MIGHT THEN HAVE REVEALED TO HIM
THE TRUTH ABOUT HIS LAST FINGER. SHE UNDERLINES THE SISTERIN
CONNECTION, WHICH ENHANCES HER VILDEBERT'S MYSTIQUE; I THINK
HE IS PERHAPS AS FOND OF HER AS HE CAN BE OF ANYTHING; HE
CERTAINLY LIKES TO KEEP HER CLOSE, AND HE SEEMS TO HAVE AN UNUSUAL

AMELINT HE CHENTREH EVER HER, EVEN FOR A PARSELMOUTH. SHE SAID
 HARRY, THE DIARY IS GONE, THE RING IS GONE, THE CLIP, THE LOCKET, AND
 THE SNARE ARE STILL INTACT, AND YELL THINK THERE MIGHT BE A
 FURTHER THAT WAS HENCE RAVENCLAW'S HER CRYPTIDHER? AN
 ADMIRABLY SLICINCT AND ACCURATE SUMMARY, YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE,
 RHEWING HIS HEAD. SHE ARE YELL STILL WHEWING FOR THEM, SIR? IS
 THAT WHERE YELL VE BEEN GING WHEN YELL VE BEEN LEAVING THE
 SCHOOL? CORRECT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, I HAVE BEEN WHEWING FOR A
 VERY LONG TIME, I THINK PERHAPS I MAY BE CLOSE TO FINDING
 ANOTHER ONE, THERE ARE HOPEFUL SIGNS. AND IF YELL DO, SAID
 HARRY QUICKLY, CAN I COME WITH YELL AND HELP GET RID OF IT?
 DUMBLEDORE WHEWED AT HARRY VERY INTENTLY FOR A MOMENT BEFORE
 SAYING, YES, I THINK SHE. I CAN? SAID HARRY, TENTATIVELY TAKEN
 ABACK. EH YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SMILING SLIGHTLY, I THINK YELL
 HAVE EARNED THAT RIGHT. HARRY FELT HIS HEART LIFT, IT WAS VERY
 GOOD NOT TO HEAR WORDS OF CAUTION AND PROTECTION FOR HENCE. THE
 HEADMASTERS AND HEADMISTRESSES AROUND THE WALLS SEEMED LESS
 IMPRESSED BY DUMBLEDORE'S DECISION. HARRY SAW A FEW OF THEM
 SHAKING THEIR HEADS AND PHINEAS NIGELLUS ACTUALLY SNEEZED. DOES
 VERDMEHT KNOW WHEN A FURTHER IS DESTROYED, SIR? CAN HE FEEL
 IT? HARRY ASKED, IGNORING THE PORTRAITS. A VERY INTERESTING
 QUESTION, HARRY, I BELIEVE NOT, I BELIEVE THAT VERDMEHT IS NOW SHE
 IMMERSED IN EVIL, AND THESE CRUCIAL PARTS OF HIMSELF HAVE BEEN
 DETACHED FOR SHE LONG, HE DOES NOT FEEL AS WE DO, PERHAPS, AT THE
 POINT OF DEATH, HE MIGHT BE AWARE OF HIS LOSS BUT HE WAS NOT
 AWARE, FOR INSTANCE, THAT THE DIARY HAD BEEN DESTROYED UNTIL HE
 HEARD THE TRUTH FROM OF LUCIUS MALFOY. WHEN VERDMEHT
 DISCOVERED THAT THE DIARY HAD BEEN MUTILATED AND RUINED OF ALL ITS
 POWERS, I AM TOLD THAT HIS ANGER WAS TERRIBLE TO SEE. BUT I
 THOUGHT HE MEANT LUCIUS MALFOY TO SMUGGLE IT INTO THE HOGWARTS?
 YES, HE DID, YEARS AGO, WHEN HE WAS SURE HE WOULD BE ABLE TO CREATE
 MORE FURTHERS, BUT STILL LUCIUS WAS SLIPPED THE WAIT FOR
 VERDMEHT'S SAYING, AND HE NEVER RECEIVED IT, FOR VERDMEHT
 VANISHED SHORTLY AFTER GIVING HIM THE DIARY. NOW BELIEVE HE
 THOUGHT THAT LUCIUS WOULD NOT DARE DO ANYTHING WITH THE
 FURTHER EITHER THAN GUARD IT CAREFULLY, BUT HE WAS CHEATING THEM
 MUCH WHEN LUCIUS'S FEAR OF A MASTER WHO HAD BEEN GONE FOR YEARS
 AND WHO LUCIUS BELIEVED DEAD. HE COURSE, LUCIUS DID NOT KNOW

WHAT THE DIARY REALLY WAS, I UNDERSTAND THAT VERDERMERT HAD TOLD HIM THE DIARY WOULD CAUSE THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS TO REOPEN BECAUSE IT WAS CLEVERLY ENCHANTED, THAT LUCILIS KNEW HE HAD A PORTION OF HIS MASTER'S SKILL IN HIS HANDS, HE WOULD UNBELIEVABLY HAVE TREATED IT WITH MORE REVERENCE BUT INSTEAD HE WENT AHEAD AND CARRIED OUT THE OLD PLAN FOR HIS OWN ENDS: BY PLANTING THE DIARY WITHIN ARTHUR LEASLEY'S DAUGHTER, HE HELPED THE DISCREDIT ARTHUR AND GOT RID OF A HIGHLY INCRIMINATING MAGICAL OBJECT IN ONE STROKE, AND, PERHAPS LUCILIS WHAT WITH VERDERMERT'S FLIRTY ABOUT THE FACT THAT HE THREW AWAY THE THUNDERBOLT FOR HIS OWN GAIN, AND THE FIASCO AT THE MINISTRY LAST YEAR, I WOULD NOT BE SURPRISED IF HE IS NOT SECRETLY GLAD THE EE SAFE IN AZERKAN AT THE MOMENT, HARRY SAT IN THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT, THEN ASKED, SEE IF ALL OF HIS THUNDERBOLTS ARE DESTROYED, VERDERMERT COULD BE KILLED? YES, I THINK SEE, SAID OLMEDORE, WITHOUT HIS THUNDERBOLTS, VERDERMERT WILL BE A MORTAL MAN WITH A MAIMED AND DIMINISHED SKILL, NEVER FORGET, THOUGH, THAT WHILE HIS SKILL MAY BE DAMAGED BEYOND REPAIR, HIS BRAIN AND HIS MAGICAL POWERS REMAIN INTACT, IT WILL TAKE LINCUMPHEN SKILL AND POWER TO KILL A WIZARD LIKE VERDERMERT EVEN WITHOUT HIS THUNDERBOLTS, BUT I HAVEN'T GOT LINCUMPHEN SKILL AND POWER, SAID HARRY, BEFORE HE COULD STOP HIMSELF, YES, YOU HAVE, SAID OLMEDORE FIRMLY, YOU HAVE A POWER THAT VERDERMERT HAS NEVER HAD, YOU CAN I KNOW? SAID HARRY IMPATIENTLY, I CAN LIVE? IT WAS ONLY WITH DIFFICULTY THAT HE STOPPED HIMSELF ADDING, BIG DEAL? YES, HARRY, YOU CAN LIVE, SAID OLMEDORE, WHEN HEHEED AS THOUGH HE KNEW PERFECTLY WELL WHAT HARRY HAD JUST REFRAINED FROM SAYING, WHICH, GIVEN EVERYTHING THAT HAS HAPPENED TO YOU, IS A GREAT AND REMARKABLE THING, YOU ARE STILL THEN FEELING THE UNDERSTAND YOUR LINGUAL YOU ARE, HARRY, SEE, WHEN THE PROPHECY SAYS THAT I WILL HAVE POWER THE DARK LORD KNOWS NOT, IT JUST MEANS LIVE? ASKED HARRY, FEELING A LITTLE LET DOWN, YES JUST LIVE, SAID OLMEDORE, BUT HARRY, NEVER FORGET THAT WHAT THE PROPHECY SAYS IS ONLY SIGNIFICANT BECAUSE VERDERMERT MADE IT SEE, I TOLD YOU THIS AT THE END OF LAST YEAR, VERDERMERT SINGLED YOU OUT AS THE PERSON WHO WOULD BE MOST DANGEROUS TO HIM AND IN BEING SEE, HE MADE YOU THE PERSON WHO WOULD BE MOST DANGEROUS TO HIM? BUT IT COMES TO THE SAME NO, IT DOESN'T? SAID OLMEDORE, SOUNDING IMPATIENT NOW, POINTING AT HARRY WITH HIS

BLACK, WITHERED HAND, HE SAID, 'THEY ARE SETTING THEM MILES STONE BY THE PRINCIPLE?' BUT, SPOLLTERED FARRY, BUT THEY SAID THE PRINCIPLE MEANS IF VILDEMEHT HAD NEVER HEARD OF THE PRINCIPLE, WOULD IT HAVE BEEN FULFILLED? WOULD IT HAVE MEANT ANYTHING? HE CHIRSE NEE? OH THEY THINK EVERY PRINCIPLE IN THE FALL OF PRINCIPLE HAS BEEN FULFILLED? BUT, SAID FARRY, REWILDERED, BUT LAST YEAR, THEY SAID HERE OF LIS WOULD HAVE THE WILL THE EITHER

FARRY, FARRY, ONLY REALISE VILDEMEHT MADE A GRAVE ERROR, AND ACTED HIS PROFESSOR TRULINESS & WORDS: IF VILDEMEHT HAD NEVER MURDERED THEIR FATHER, WOULD HE HAVE IMPARTED IN THEM A FLIRTLIS DESIRE FOR REVENGE? HE CHIRSE NEE? IF HE HAD NOT FORCED THEIR MOTHER THE DIE FOR THEM, WOULD HE HAVE GIVEN THEM A MAGICAL PROTECTION HE COULD NOT PENETRATE? HE CHIRSE NEE, FARRY? THEN T THEY SEE? VILDEMEHT HIMSELF CREATED HIS WORST ENEMY, JUST AS TYRANTS EVERYWHERE DO: HAVE THEM ANY IDEA HOW MUCH TYRANTS FEAR THE PEOPLE THEY OPPRESS? ALL OF THEM REALIZE THAT, ONE DAY, AMONGST THEIR MANY VICTIMS, THERE IS SOME ONE WHO RISES AGAINST THEM AND STRIKES BACK: VILDEMEHT IS NO DIFFERENT: ALWAYS HE WAS IN THE MIDDLEST FOR THE ONE WHO WOULD CHALLENGE HIM, HE HEARD THE PRINCIPLE AND HE LEAPT INTO ACTION, WITH THE RESULT THAT HE NOT ONLY HANDICAPPED THE MAN MEET LIKELY TO FINISH HIM, HE HANDED HIM UNLIKELY DEADLY WEAPONS: BUT IT IS ESSENTIAL THAT THEY UNDERSTAND THIS: SAID GLIMMERDARE, STANDING UP AND STRIDING AHEAD THE ROOM, HIS GLITTERING RINGS SWISHING IN HIS WAIST: FARRY HAD NEVER SEEN HIM SO AGITATED. BY ATTEMPTING TO KILL THEM, VILDEMEHT HIMSELF SINGLED OUT THE REMARKABLE PERSON WHO SITS HERE IN FRONT OF ME, AND GAVE HIM THE THINGS FOR THE THE: IT IS VILDEMEHT & FAULT THAT THEY WERE ABLE TO SEE INTO HIS THOUGHTS, HIS AMBITIONS, THAT THEY EVEN UNDERSTAND THE SNARKLIKE LANGUAGE IN WHICH HE GIVES ORDERS, AND YET, FARRY, DESPITE THEIR PRIVILEGED INSIGHT INTO VILDEMEHT & WORLD (WHICH, INCIDENTALLY, IS A GIFT AND DEATH RATER WOULD KILL THEM HAVE), THEY HAVE NEVER BEEN SEDUCED BY THE DARK ARTS, NEVER, EVEN FOR A SECOND, SHOWN THE SLIGHTEST DESIRE TO REFORM ONE OF VILDEMEHT & FOLLOWERS: HE CHIRSE I HAVEN T? SAID FARRY INDIGNANTLY, HE KILLED MY MOM AND DAD: THEY ARE PROTECTED, IN SHORT, BY THEIR ABILITY TO LIVE: SAID GLIMMERDARE HEEDLY. THE ONLY PROTECTION THAT CAN POSSIBLY WORK AGAINST THE LIKE OF POWER LIKE VILDEMEHT & IN SPITE OF ALL THE TEMPTATION

THEY HAVE ENDURED, ALL THE SLIPPING, THEY REMAIN PURE OF HEART, JUST AS PURE AS THEY WERE AT THE AGE OF ELEVEN, WHEN THEY STARED INTO A MIRROR THAT REFLECTED THEIR HEART'S DESIRE, AND IT SHOWED THEM ONLY THE WAY THE THREAT LORD VEEDMERT, AND NOT IMMORTALITY HER RICHES, FARRY, HAVE THEY ANY IDEA HOW FEW WIZARDS COULD HAVE SEEN WHAT THEY SAW IN THAT MIRROR? VEEDMERT SHOULD HAVE KNOWN THEN WHAT HE WAS DEALING WITH, BUT HE DID NOT! BUT HE KNOWS IT NOW, THEY HAVE PLUTTERED INTO LORD VEEDMERT'S MIND WITHOUT DAMAGE TO THEMSELVES, BUT HE CANNOT POSSESS THEM WITHOUT ENDURING MENTAL AGONY, AS HE DISCOVERED IN THE MINISTRY, I DO NOT THINK HE UNDERSTANDS WHY, FARRY, BUT THEN, HE WAS IN SUCH A FLURRY THE MUTILATE HIS OWN SELF, HE NEVER REALISED THE UNDERSTAND THE INCOMPARABLE POWER OF A SELF THAT IS UNTARNISHED AND WHOLE.

BUT, SIR, SAID FARRY, MAKING VALIANT EFFORTS NOT THE SILENT ARGUMENTATIVE, IT ALL COMES TO THE SAME THING, DOESN'T IT? I'VE GOTTEN THE TRIP AND KILL HIM, HE GETS THEM SAID OLMEDORE. HE CHIRPS THEY'VE GOTTEN THEM BUT NOT BECAUSE OF THE PROPHECY! BECAUSE THEY, THEMSELVES, WILL NEVER REST UNTIL THEY'VE TRIED! WE BOTH KNOW IT! IMAGINE, PLEASE, JUST FOR A MOMENT, THAT THEY HAD NEVER HEARD THAT PROPHECY! THEN WOULD THEY FEEL ABOUT VEEDMERT NOW? THINK! FARRY WATCHED OLMEDORE STRIDING UP AND DOWN IN FRONT OF HIM, AND THE LIGHT, THE LIGHT OF HIS MOTHER, HIS FATHER, AND SIRILIS, THE LIGHT OF CEDRIC DIGGORY, THE LIGHT OF ALL THE TERRIBLE DEEDS HE KNEW LORD VEEDMERT HAD DONE, A FLAME SEEMED TO LEAP INSIDE HIS CHEST, SEARING HIS THROAT, I'D WANT HIM FINISHED, SAID FARRY QUIETLY, AND I'D WANT THEM TO DO IT. HE CHIRPS THEY WOULD! CRIES OLMEDORE, THEY SEE, THE PROPHECY DOES NOT MEAN THEY HAVE TO DO ANYTHING! BUT THE PROPHECY CALLED LORD VEEDMERT THE MARK THEY AS HIS KILLER. IN EITHER CASES, THEY ARE FREE TO CHOOSE THEIR WAY, EITHER FREE TO TURN THEIR BACK ON THE PROPHECY! BUT VEEDMERT CONTINUES TO SET THEM BY THE PROPHECY, HE WILL CONTINUE TO HUNT THEM WHICH MAKES IT CERTAIN, REALLY, THAT THAT END OF HIS IS GOING TO END UP KILLING THEM EITHER, SAID FARRY, YES, BUT HE UNDERSTOOD AT LAST WHAT OLMEDORE HAD BEEN TRYING TO TELL HIM, IT WAS, HE THOUGHT, THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN BEING DRAGGED INTO THE ARENA TO FACE A BATTLE TO THE DEATH AND WALKING INTO THE ARENA WITH THEIR HEAD HELD HIGH. SOME PEOPLE, PERHAPS, WOULD SAY THAT THERE WAS LITTLE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN THE TWO WAYS, BUT OLMEDORE

KNEW AND SHE DID MY PARENTS THAT THERE WAS ALL THE DIFFERENCE IN THE
 WORLD. SEXTIMSMPRA EXHAUSTED BUT DELIGHTED WITH HIS NIGHT'S
 WORK, HARRY TOLD REEN AND HERMIONE EVERYTHING THAT HAD
 HAPPENED DURING NEXT MORNING'S CHARM'S LESSON (HAVING FIRST CAST
 THE MULTIPLIATE SPELL UPON THEIR NEAREST THEM). THEY WERE BOTH
 SATISFYINGLY IMPRESSED BY THE WAY HE HAD WEEDLED THE MEMORY OUT
 OF SLUGGISH AND POSITIVELY ASKED WHEN HE TOLD THEM ABOUT
 VERBEMINT & HERCULES AND DUMBLEDORE'S PROMISE TO TAKE HARRY
 ALONG, SHOULD HE FIND ANOTHER ONE. WELL, SAID REEN, WHEN HARRY
 HAD FINALLY FINISHED TELLING THEM EVERYTHING, REEN WAS WAVING HIS
 HAND VERY VAGUELY IN THE DIRECTION OF THE CEILING WITHOUT PAYING
 THE SLIGHTEST BIT OF ATTENTION TO WHAT HE WAS DOING. WELL, WELL HE
 ACTUALLY GAVE THE GO WITH DUMBLEDORE AND TRY AND DESTROY
 WELL. REEN, WELL HE MAKING IT SURE, SAID HERMIONE PATIENTLY,
 GRABBING HIS WRIST AND REDIRECTING HIS HAND AWAY FROM THE CEILING
 FROM WHICH, SURE ENOUGH, LARGE WHITE FLAKES HAD STARTED TO FALL.
 LAVENDER BROWN, HARRY NOTICED, GLARED AT HERMIONE FROM A
 NEIGHBORING TABLE THROUGH VERY RED EYES, AND HERMIONE
 IMMEDIATELY LET GO OF REEN'S ARM. EH-YEAH, SAID REEN, LOOKING
 DOWN AT HIS SHOULDERS IN VAGUE SURPRISE. SHARRY LOOKS LIKE
 WE'RE ALL GETTING TERRIBLE DANDY, WELL. HE GRABBED SOME OF THE
 PAPER FROM HERMIONE'S SHOULDER. LAVENDER BURST INTO TEARS.
 REEN LOOKED IMMENSELY GUILTY AND TURNED HIS BACK ON HER. WE
 SPLIT UP. HE TOLD HARRY OUT OF THE CORNER OF HIS MOUTH, LAST
 NIGHT, WHEN SHE SAW ME COMING OUT OF THE DORMITORY WITH
 HERMIONE, HEAVENLY SHE COULDN'T SEE WELL, SHE SHE THOUGHT IT HAD
 JUST BEEN THE TWO OF US. AH, SAID HARRY. WELL, WELL BEEN TO
 MIND IT'S NEVER, OH WELL? NO, REEN ADMITTED. IT WAS PRETTY BAD
 WHILE SHE WAS TELLING, BUT AT LEAST I DIDN'T HAVE TO FINISH IT.

TOWARD, SAID HERMIONE, THOUGH SHE LOOKED AMUSED. WELL, IT WAS
 A BAD NIGHT FOR REMARKS ALL AROUND. GINNY AND DEAN SPLIT UP THEN,
 HARRY. HARRY THOUGHT THERE WAS A RATHER KNOWING LOOK IN HER
 EYE AS SHE TOLD HIM THAT, BUT SHE COULD NOT POSSIBLY KNOW THAT HIS
 INSIDES WERE SUDDENLY DANCING TO THE TUNGS. KEEPING HIS FACE AS
 IMPELIVE AND HIS VOICE AS INDIFFERENT AS HE COULD, HE ASKED, WELL
 COME? EH, SOMETHING REALLY SILLY. SHE SAID HE WAS ALWAYS
 TRYING TO HELP HER THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE, LIKE SHE COULDN'T

CLIMB IN HERSELF BUT THEY'VE BEEN A BIT RICKY FOR AGES. HARRY GLANCED OVER AT DEAN ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE CLASSROOM. HE CERTAINLY LOOKED UNHAPPY. OF COURSE, THIS PUTS YOU IN A BIT OF A DILEMMA, DOESN'T IT? SAID HERMIONE. WHAT DOES THAT MEAN? SAID HARRY QUICKLY. THE FLUIDITCH TEAM, SAID HERMIONE. IF GINNY AND DEAN AREN'T SPEAKING. EH? EH? YES, SAID HARRY.

FLITWICK, SAID THEN IN A WARNING TONE. THE TINY LITTLE CHARMS MASTER WAS KEEKING HIS WAY TOWARD THEM, AND HERMIONE WAS THE ONLY ONE WHO HAD MANAGED TO TURN VINEGAR INTO WINE. HER GLASS WAS FULL OF DEEP CRIMSON LIQUID, WHEREAS THE CONTENTS OF HARRY'S AND RON'S WERE STILL MURKY GREEN. WELL, WELL, BEES, SEVERED PROFESSOR FLITWICK REPROACHFULLY. A LITTLE LESS TALK, A LITTLE MORE ACTION. LET ME SEE YOU TRY. TOGETHER THEY RAISED THEIR HANDS, CONCENTRATING WITH ALL THEIR MIGHT, AND POINTED THEM AT THEIR GLASSES. HARRY'S VINEGAR TURNED TO ICE; RON'S GLASS EXPLODED. YES FOR HIMSELF, SAID PROFESSOR FLITWICK, REEMERGING FROM UNDER THE TABLE AND PULLING SEVERAL OF GLASS OUT OF THE TOP OF HIS HAT. PRACTICE. THEY HAD ONE OF THEIR RARE JOINT FREE PERIODS AFTER CHARMS AND WALKED BACK TO THE CHIMNEY ROOM TOGETHER. RON SEEMED TO BE POSITIVELY LIGHT-HEARTED ABOUT THE END OF HIS RELATIONSHIP WITH LAVENDER, AND HERMIONE SEEMED CHEERFUL, THOUGH WHEN ASKED WHAT SHE WAS GRINNING ABOUT SHE SIMPLY SAID, IT'S A NICE DAY. NEITHER OF THEM SEEMED TO HAVE NOTICED THAT A FIERCE BATTLE WAS RAGING INSIDE HARRY'S BRAIN. SHE'S RON'S SISTER, BUT SHE'S DITCHED DEAN. SHE'S STILL RON'S SISTER, I'M HIS BEST MATE. THAT'LL MAKE IT WORSE. IF I TALKED TO HIM FIRST. HE'D HIT YOU. WHAT IF I DON'T CARE? HE'S YOUR BEST MATE. HARRY BARELY NOTICED THAT THEY WERE CLIMBING THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE INTO THE SLIPPERY CHIMNEY ROOM, AND ONLY VAGUELY REGISTERED THE SMALL GROUP OF SEVENTH YEARS CLUSTERED TOGETHER THERE, UNTIL HERMIONE CRIED,

DATIE! YOU'RE BACK! ARE YOU OKAY? HARRY STARED. IT WAS INDEED DATIE KELL, LOOKING COMPLETELY HEALTHY AND SURROUNDED BY HER ILLEGITIMATE FRIENDS. I'M REALLY WELL. SHE SAID HAPPILY. THEY LET ME OUT OF ST. MUNGUS ON MONDAY, I HAD A COUPLE OF DAYS AT HOME WITH MOM AND DAD AND THEN CAME BACK HERE THIS MORNING. LEANNE WAS JUST TELLING ME ABOUT MCGAGGON AND THE LAST MATCH. HARRY,

YES, SAID HARRY, WELL, NOW YOU'RE BACK AND RON'S FIT, WE'LL HAVE A DECENT CHANCE OF THRASHING RAVENCLAW, WHICH MEANS WE

CHILD STILL BE IN THE RUNNING FOR THE CLIP, LISTEN, KATIE HE
 HAD THE PLT THE ELDESTIN THE HER AT HERCE, HIS CLIRHSITY EVEN DRIVE
 GINNY TEMPORARILY FROM HIS BRAIN, HE DROPPED HIS VEHICLE AS
 KATIE S FRIENDS STARTED GATHERING UP THEIR THINGS, APPARENTLY
 THEY WERE LATE FOR TRANSFIGURATION, THAT NECKLACE CAN YOU
 REMEMBER WHEN GAVE IT THE YOU NEEL? NO, SAID KATIE, SHAKING HER
 HEAD BLISSFULLY, EVERYONE S BEEN ASKING ME, BUT I HAVEN T GET A
 CLUE, THE LAST THING I REMEMBER WAS WALKING INTO THE LADIES IN
 THE THREE BRIMMISTICKS, YOU DEFINITELY WENT INTO THE KATHRINE,
 THEN? SAID FERMINE, WELL, I KNOW I PULSED OPEN THE DOOR, SAID
 KATIE, SHE I SUPPOSE WHENEVER IMPERILISED ME WAS STANDING JUST
 BEHIND IT, AFTER THAT, MY MEMORY S A BLANK UNTIL ABOUT TWO WEEKS
 AGO IN ST. MUNGUS, LISTEN, I D BETTER GO, I WOULDNT PUT IT PAST
 MCGINAGALL THE GIVE ME LINES EVEN IF IT IS MY FIRST DAY BACK,
 SHE CALLED UP HER BAG AND BOOKS AND HURRIED AFTER HER FRIENDS,
 LEAVING FARRY, RHN, AND FERMINE THE SIT DOWN AT A WINDY TABLE
 AND Ponder WHAT SHE HAD TOLD THEM, SHE IT MUST HAVE BEEN A GIRL
 OR A WOMAN WHEN GAVE KATIE THE NECKLACE, SAID FERMINE, THE BE
 IN THE LADIES KATHRINE, HER SOMEONE WHEN LOOKED LIKE A GIRL OR A
 WOMAN, SAID FARRY, DONT FORGET, THERE WAS A CALIBREEN FILL OF
 PHYLIC PETHIN AT FHEGWARTS, WE KNOW SOME OF IT GET STELEN,

IN HIS MIND S EYE, HE WATCHED A PARADE OF CRACKS AND CHOPS
 PRANCE PAST, ALL TRANSFORMED INTO GIRLS, I THINK I M GETTING THE
 TACK ANOTHER SWIG OF FELIX, SAID FARRY, AND HAVE A GO AT THE
 RHM OF REQUIREMENT AGAIN, THAT WOULD BE A COMPLETE WASTE OF
 PETHIN, SAID FERMINE FLATLY, PUTTING DOWN THE COPY OF
 SPELLMAN S SYLLABARY SHE HAD JUST TAKEN OUT OF HER BAG, LIKE
 CAN ONLY GET YOU SHE FAR, FARRY, THE SITUATION WITH SLIGHTEN
 WAS DIFFERENT, YOU ALWAYS HAD THE ABILITY TO PERSUADE HIM, YOU JUST
 NEEDED THE THREAD THE CIRCUMSTANCES A BIT, LIKE ISN T ENOUGH TO GET
 YOU THROUGH A POWERFUL ENCHANTMENT, TELLIG, DONT GO WASTING
 THE REST OF THAT PETHIN? YOU LL NEED ALL THE LIKE YOU CAN GET IF
 DUMPLEDRE TAKES YOU ALONG WITH HIM SHE DROPPED HER VEHICLE
 THE A WHISPER, WOULDNT WE MAKE SOME MORE? RHN ASKED FARRY,
 IGNORING FERMINE, IT D BE GREAT TO HAVE A STOCK OF IT, HAVE A
 LOOK IN THE BOOK FARRY PULLED HIS COPY OF ADVANCED PETHIN-
 MAKING OUT OF HIS BAG AND LOOKED UP FELIX FELIX, SIMPLY, IT S
 SERIOUSLY COMPLICATED, HE SAID, RUNNING AN EYE DOWN THE LIST OF

INGREDIENTS. AND IT TAKES SIX MONTHS YELL YR EHT TH LET IT STEW. TYPICAL, SAID RHN, FARRY WAS ABELT TH PLT HIS KHHK AWAY AGAIN WHEN HE NOTICED THE CHRNDR HP A PAGE FELDDE DHWN; TURNING TH IT, HE SAW THE SECTLMSEMPRA SPELL, CAPTIONED FHR ENEMIES, THAT HE HAD MARKED A FEW WEEKS PREVIOUSLY. HE HAD STILL NOT FELND HLT WHAT IT DID, MAINLY BECAUSE HE DID NOT WANT TH TEST IT ABELND FHRMHNK, BJT HE WAS CENSDERNG TRYNG IT HLT HN MCLAGGEN NEXT TIME HE CME LP BHNH HIM LNDLARS. THE ONLY PRSHN WHH WAS NOT PARTICULARLY PLEASED TH SEE KATIE BACK AT SCHHHL WAS DEAN THHMAS, BECAUSE HE WOULD NH LHNCR BE REQURD TH FILL HER PLACE AS CHASER. HE THHND THE KHHN STEILALLY KNEELCH WHEN FARRY THLD HIM, MERELY GRUNTING AND SHRLGNG, BJT FARRY HAD THE DISTINCT FEELNG AS HE WALKED AWAY THAT DEAN AND STAMLS WERE MUTTERNG MLTINHHLSY BHNH HIS BACK. THE FHHLLNG AHTNIGHT SAW THE BEST FLJIBDITCH PRACTICES FARRY HAD KNHWN AS CAPTAIN. HIS TEAM WAS SH PLEASED TH BE RID HP MCLAGGEN, SH GLAD TH HAVE KATIE BACK AT LAST, THAT THEY WERE FLYNG EXTREMELY WELL. GINDY DID NOT SEEM AT ALL UPSET ABELT THE BREADLP WITH DEAN; HN THE CONTRARY, SHE WAS THE LIFE AND SHLL HP THE TEAM. FHR IMITATIONS HP RHN ANXHHLSY BKKNG LP AND DHWN IN FRHNT HP THE CHAL PRHSTS AS THE FLWFFLE SPD THLNARD HIM, HP HP FARRY BELLHNG HNDERS AT MCLAGGEN BEHRE BNG KNHCKED HLT CHLD, BPT THEM ALL HGHLY AMUSED. FARRY, LAUGHNG WITH THE HTHRS, WAS GLAD TH HAVE AN INNOCENT REASHN TH LHHK AT GINDY; HE HAD RECEIVED SEVERAL MORE BLUDGE INJURIES DURING PRACTICE BECAUSE HE HAD NOT BEEN KEEPNG HIS EYES HN THE SNITCH. THE BATTLE STILL RAGED INSIDE HIS HEAD: GINDY HP RHN? SOMETIMES HE THHUGHT THAT THE PRST-LAVENDER RHN MIGHT NH MND THH MLCH IF HE ASKED GINDY HLT, BJT THEN HE REMEMBERED RHN S EXPRESSHNG WHEN HE HAD SEEN HER MISSNG DEAN, AND WAS SURE THAT RHN WOULD CENSDER IT BSE TREACHRY IF FARRY SH MLCH AS HLD HER HAND. YET FARRY CHLD NOT HELP HIMSELF TALKNG TH GINDY, LAUGHNG WITH HER, WALKNG BACK FRHM PRACTICE WITH HER; HHHVER MLCH HIS CENSCNCE ACHD, HE FELND HIMSELF WHNDRNG HHH BST TH GET HER HN HER HLN. IT WOULD HAVE BEEN IDEAL IF SLGHTHNN HAD GIVEN ANHTHR HP HIS LITTLE PARTIES, FHR RHN WOULD NOT BE ABELND BJT UNFHTLNATELY, SLGHTHNN SEEMD TH HAVE GIVEN THEM LP. HENCE HP TWICE FARRY CENSDERD ASKNG FHR FHRMHNK S HELP, BJT HE DID NOT THNK HE CHLD STAND SEENG THE

SMILE LIT UP HER FACE; HE THOUGHT HE CALLED IT SOMETIMES WHEN
HERMIONE SPOTTED HIM STARING AT GINNY OR LAUGHING AT HER IDEAS,
AND THE COMPLICATE MATTERS, HE HAD THE NAGGING WHIRRY THAT IF HE
DIDN'T DO IT, SOMEONE ELSE WAS SURE TO ASK GINNY OUT SOON; HE AND
RON WERE AT LEAST AGREED ON THE FACT THAT SHE WAS THE POPULAR
GIRL IN SCHOOL, ALL IN ALL, THE TEMPTATION TO TAKE ANOTHER
GLIMPSE OF FELIX FELIX WAS BECOMING STRONGER BY THE DAY, AND SURELY
THIS WAS A CASE FOR, AS HERMIONE PUT IT, 'TREADING THE
CIRCUMSTANCES'. THE BALMY DAYS SLID GENTLY THROUGH MAY, AND RON
SEEMED TO BE THERE AT HARRY'S SHOULDERS EVERY TIME HE SAW GINNY,
HARRY FEELING HIMSELF LINGERING FOR A STRIKE OF LUCK THAT WOULD
SOMEHOW CALSE RON TO REALIZE THAT NOTHING WOULD MAKE HIM
HAPPIER THAN HIS BEST FRIEND AND HIS SISTER FALLING FOR EACH OTHER
AND THE LEAVE THEM ALONE TOGETHER FOR LONGER THAN A FEW SECONDS,
THERE SEEMED NO CHANCE OF EITHER WHILE THE FINAL HOLIDAY CAMP
OF THE SEASON WAS BEHIND; RON WANTED THE TALK TACTICS WITH
HARRY ALL THE TIME AND HAD LITTLE THOUGHT FOR ANYTHING ELSE, RON
WAS NOT UNUSUAL IN THIS RESPECT; INTEREST IN THE GRYFFINDOR-
RAVENCLAW GAME WAS RUNNING EXTREMELY HIGH THROUGHOUT THE
SCHOOL, FOR THE MATCH WOULD DECIDE THE CHAMPIONSHIP, WHICH WAS
STILL WIDE OPEN, IF GRYFFINDOR BEAT RAVENCLAW BY A MARGIN OF THREE
HUNDRED POINTS (A TALL ORDER, AND YET HARRY HAD NEVER DOUBT HIS
TEAM TO BE BETTER) THEN THEY WOULD WIN THE CHAMPIONSHIP, IF THEY
WON BY LESS THAN THREE HUNDRED POINTS, THEY WOULD COME SECOND TO
RAVENCLAW; IF THEY LOST BY A HUNDRED POINTS THEY WOULD BE THIRD
BEHIND HUFFLEPUFF AND IF THEY LOST BY MORE THAN A HUNDRED, THEY
WOULD BE IN FOURTH PLACE AND NEXT, HARRY THOUGHT, WOULD EVER,
EVER LET HIM FORGET THAT IT HAD BEEN HE WHO HAD CAPTAINED
GRYFFINDOR TO THEIR FIRST KITCHEN-OF-THE-TABLE DEFEAT IN TWO
CENTURIES, THE RUN-UP TO THIS CRUCIAL MATCH HAD ALL THE USUAL
FEATURES: MEMBERS OF RIVAL HOUSES ATTEMPTING TO INTIMIDATE
OPPOSING TEAMS IN THE HALLWAYS; UNPLEASANT CHANTS ABOUT
INDIVIDUAL PLAYERS BEING REPEATED LOUDLY AS THEY PASSED; THE TEAM
MEMBERS THEMSELVES EITHER SLAGGERING ABOUT ENJOYING ALL THE
ATTENTION OR ELSE DASHING INTO BATHROOMS BETWEEN CLASSES TO
TIE UP, SOMEHOW, THE GAME HAD BECOME INEXTRICABLY LINKED IN
HARRY'S MIND WITH SUCCESS OR FAILURE IN HIS PLANS FOR GINNY, HE
COULD NOT HELP FEELING THAT IF THEY WON BY MORE THAN THREE

HUNDRED PHINTS, THE SCENES OF EUPHEMIA AND A NICE WELD AFTER-MATCH PARTY MIGHT BE JUST AS GOOD AS A HEARTY SWIG OF FELIX FELIXIS. IN THE MIST OF ALL HIS PREOCCUPATIONS, HARRY HAD NOT FORGOTTEN HIS OTHER AMBITION: FINDING OUT WHAT MALPHY WAS UP TO IN THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT. HE WAS STILL CHECKING THE MARALDER'S MAP, AND AS HE WAS UNABLE TO LOCATE MALPHY ON IT, DECIDED THAT MALPHY WAS STILL SPENDING PLenty OF TIME WITHIN THE ROOM. ALTHOUGH HARRY WAS LIVING HOPE THAT HE WOULD EVER SUCCEED IN GETTING INSIDE THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, HE ATTEMPTED IT WHENEVER HE WAS IN THE VICINITY, BUT NO MATTER HOW HE REVERSED HIS REVEREST, THE WALL REMAINED FIRMLY UNBREKABLE. A FEW DAYS BEFORE THE MATCH AGAINST RAVENCLAW, HARRY FOUND HIMSELF WALKING DOWN THE DINNERS ALONE FROM THE COMMON ROOM, THEN HAVING ALISTED OFF INTO A NEARBY BATHROOM THE THREE UP YET AGAIN, AND DETERMINING HAVING DASHED OFF THE SEE PROFESSOR VETTER ABOUT A MISTAKE SHE MIGHT HAVE MADE IN HER LAST ARTIFICIALLY ESSAY, MORE OUT OF HABIT THAN ANYTHING, HARRY MADE HIS USUAL DETOUR ALONG THE SEVENTEENTH CORRIDOR, CHECKING THE MARALDER'S MAP AS HE WENT. FOR A MOMENT HE COULD NOT FIND MALPHY ANYWHERE AND ASSUMED HE MUST INDEED BE INSIDE THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT AGAIN, BUT THEN HE SAW MALPHY'S TINY, LAKED BEET STANDING IN A BOY'S BATHROOM ON THE FIFTH FLOOR, ACCOMPANIED, NOT BY CRABBE OR GOYLE, BUT BY MEANING MYRTLE. HARRY ONLY STOPPED STARING AT THIS UNLIKELY COMPLING WHEN HE WALKED RIGHT INTO A SLIT OF ARMOR. THE WELD CRASH BRIGHT HIM OUT OF HIS REVERIE; FLIPPING FROM THE SCENE LEFT FLICK TURN UP, HE DASHED DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE AND ALONG THE PASSAGEWAY BELOW. ELTIDE THE BATHROOM, HE PRESSED HIS EAR AGAINST THE DOOR. HE COULD NOT HEAR ANYTHING. HE VERY QUIETLY PUSHED THE DOOR OPEN. DRACH MALPHY WAS STANDING WITH HIS BACK TO THE DOOR, HIS HANDS CLUTCHING EITHER SIDE OF THE SINK, HIS WHITE-BLEND HEAD BOWED.

DOWN T, CRASHED MEANING MYRTLE'S VOICE FROM ONE OF THE CLIKES, DOWN T TELL ME WHAT'S WRONG I CAN HELP YOU, NO ONE CAN HELP ME, SAID MALPHY, HIS WHOLE BODY WAS SHAKING. I CAN'T SEE IT. I CAN'T. IT WON'T WORK AND UNLESS I SEE IT SOON HE SAYS HE'LL KILL ME. AND HARRY REALIZED, WITH A SHOCK SHE FLICK IT SEEMED THE RIGHT HIM THE THE SPEET, THAT MALPHY WAS CRYING ACTUALLY CRYING TEARS STREAMING DOWN HIS PALE FACE INTO THE GRIMY BASIN. MALPHY GASPED AND CLIPED AND THEN, WITH A GREAT

SHOULDER, WHIPPED UP INTO THE CRACKED MIRROR AND SAW HARRY STARING AT HIM OVER HIS SHOULDER. MALPHY WHIPPED AROUND, DRAWING HIS WAND. INSTINCTIVELY, HARRY PULLED BACK HIS HEAD. MALPHY'S FINGER MISSED HARRY BY INCHES, SHATTERING THE LAMP ON THE WALL BESIDE HIM. HARRY THREW HIMSELF SIDELWAYS, THREATENING LEVITCHURUS' AND FLICKED HIS WAND, BUT MALPHY BLOCKED THE Jinx AND RAISED HIS WAND FOR ANOTHER. "NEH! NEH! STOP IT! SERVED MEANING MYRTLE HER VICE EATING LOUDLY AROUND THE TILED ROOM. STOP! STOP! THERE WAS A LUD RANG AND THE KIN BEHIND HARRY EXPLODED. HARRY ATTEMPTED A LEG-SLICKER CURSE THAT BACKFIRED OFF THE WALL BEHIND MALPHY'S EAR AND SMASHED THE CISTERN BENEATH MEANING MYRTLE, WHO SCREAMED LOUDLY. WATER POURED EVERYWHERE AND HARRY SLIPPED AS MALPHY, HIS FACE CONSTRICTED, CRIED, "CRUI"

SETTLING DOWN. REMOVED HARRY FROM THE FLOOR, WAVING HIS WAND WILDLY. BLOOD SPLOTTED FROM MALPHY'S FACE AND CHEST AS THOUGH HE HAD BEEN SLASHED WITH AN INVISIBLE SWORD. HE STAGGERED BACKWARD AND COLLAPSED INTO THE WATERLOGGED FLOOR WITH A GREAT SPLASH, HIS WAND FALLING FROM HIS LIMP RIGHT HAND. "NEH" GASPED HARRY, SLIPPING AND STAGGERING. HARRY GOT ON HIS FEET AND COLLINGED TOWARD MALPHY, WHOSE FACE WAS NOW SHINING SCARLET, HIS WHITE HANDS SCRABBLING AT HIS BLOOD-SHAKED CHEST. "NEH" "I DIDN'T" HARRY DID NOT KNOW WHAT HE WAS SAYING. HE FELL ON HIS KNEES BESIDE MALPHY, WHO WAS SHAKING UNCONTROLLABLY IN A POOL OF HIS BLOOD. MEANING MYRTLE LET OUT A DRAVENING SCREAM. "MURDER! MURDER IN THE BATHROOM! MURDER! THE OTHER RANGED UPON BEHIND HARRY AND HE WHIPPED UP, TERRIFIED. SNAPE HAD BURST INTO THE ROOM, HIS FACE LIVID, PUSHING HARRY RELUCTANTLY ASIDE. HE BENT OVER MALPHY, DREW HIS WAND, AND TRACED IT OVER THE DEEP WOUNDS HARRY'S CURSE HAD MADE, MUTTERING AN INCANTATION THAT SOUNDED ALMOST LIKE SING. THE FLOW OF BLOOD SEEMED TO EASE. SNAPE WIPED THE RESIDUE FROM MALPHY'S FACE AND REPEATED HIS SPELL. NOW THE WOUNDS SEEMED TO BE HEALING. HARRY WAS STILL WATCHING, FRIGHTENED BY WHAT HE HAD DONE, BARELY AWARE THAT HE TOO WAS SOAKED IN BLOOD AND WATER. MEANING MYRTLE WAS STILL SCREAMING AND WAILING EVER-HEAD. WHEN SNAPE HAD PERFORMED HIS CHLINTERCOURSE FOR THE THIRD TIME, HE HALF-LIFTED MALPHY INTO A STANDING POSITION.

YELL NEEDED THE HOSPITAL WING. THERE MAY BE A CERTAIN AMOUNT OF STARRING, BUT IF YELL TAKE BITTANY IMMEDIATELY WE MIGHT AVOID EVEN

THAT. COME. HE SLIPPERED MALPHE ACROSS THE KATH-REHEM, TURNING AT THE DOOR THE SAY IN A VEHICLE HE CHILD FLAY, AND YELL, PHTTER YELL WAIT HERE FOR ME. IT DID NOT ELLER THE FARRY FOR A SECOND THE DISHEK, HE STOOD UP SLEELY, STAKING, AND LISHED DOWN AT THE WET FLEER. THERE WERE BLEEDSTAINS FLEATING LIKE CRIMSON FLEWERS ACROSS ITS SLIPACK, HE COULD NOT EVEN FIND IT IN HIMSELF THE TELL MEANING MYRTLE THE RE BELLET, AS SHE CONTINUED THE WAIL AND SHE WITH INCREASINGLY EVIDENT ENJOYMENT. SNAPE RETURNED TEN MINUTES LATER, HE STEPPED INTO THE KATH-REHEM AND CLOSED THE DOOR BEHIND HIM. OH, HE SAID THE MYRTLE, AND SHE SLIPPED BACK INTO HER THILK AT ENCE, LEAVING A RINGING SILENCE BEHIND HER. I DIDN T MEAN IT THE HAPPEN, SAID FARRY AT ENCE, HIS VEHICLE RLEED IN THE CHILD, WATERY SPACE. I DIDN T KNOW WHAT THAT SPELL DID, BUT SNAPE IGNORED THIS.

APPARENTLY I UNDERESTIMATED YELL, PHTTER, HE SAID BELIETLY, WHEH WOULD HAVE TEHLIGHT YELL KNOW SUCH DARK MAGIC? WHEH TALIGHT YELL THAT SPELL? I READ ABELT IT SOMEWHERE, WHERE? IT WAS

A LIBRARY REHEK, FARRY INVENTED WILDLY, I CAN T REMEMBER WHAT IT WAS CALL LAR, SAID SNAPE, FARRY S T-THAT WENT DRY, HE KNOW WHAT SNAPE WAS CHING THE DE AND HE HAD NEVER BEEN ABLE THE PREVENT IT. THE KATH-REHEM SEEMED THE SHIMMER BEHRE HIS EYES; HE STRUGGLED THE BLEED FELT ALL TEHLIGHT, BUT TRY AS HE MIGHT, THE FALF-BLEED PRINCE S COPY HE ADVANCED PHTHEN-MAKING SWAY HAZILY THE THE REPRESENT HE HIS MIND, AND THEN HE WAS STARING AT SNAPE AGAIN, IN THE MIDST HE THIS WRECKED, SHAKED KATH-REHEM, HE STARED INTO SNAPE S BLACK EYES, FLEPING AGAINST FLEPE THAT SNAPE HAD NOT SEEN WHAT HE FEARED, BUT BRING ME YELLER SCHEHEK, SAID SNAPE SEETLY, AND ALL HE YELLER SCHEHEKHEKS, ALL HE THEM, BRING THEM THE ME HERE, NEEL! THERE WAS NO PHINT ARGUING, FARRY TURNED AT ENCE AND SPLASHED ELT HE THE KATH-REHEM, ENCE IN THE CHORIDHE, HE BREED INTO A BLIN THELARD GRYFFINDHE THWER, MEET PEOPLE WERE WALKING THE EITHER WAY; THEY Gaped AT HIM, DRENCHED IN WATER AND BLEED, BUT HE ANSWERED NONE HE THE ELJESTHEKS FIRED AT HIM AS HE RAN PAST, HE FELT STUNNED; IT WAS AS TEHLICH A RELIEVED PET HAD TURNED SLIDENLY SAVAGE; WHAT HAD THE PRINCE BEEN THINKING THE COPY SUCH A SPELL INTO HIS REHEK? AND WHAT WOULD HAPPEN WHEN SNAPE SAW IT? WOULD HE TELL SILVERHEM FARRY S STEMACHE

CHURNED FELL FARRY HAD BEEN ACHIEVING SUCH GOOD RESULTS IN PHTHEKS ALL YEAR? WOULD HE CONSCISE HER DESTREY THE REHEK THAT

HAD TALCUT FARRY SEE MUCH THE KID THAT HAD BECOME A KIND OF
GUIDE AND FRIEND? FARRY COULD NOT LET IT HAPPEN. HE COULD NOT

WHERE WE WERE ? WHY ARE WE SHAKING ? IS THAT KID?
HEN WAS STANDING AT THE TOP OF THE STAIRS, LOOKING BEMUSED AT
THE SIGHT OF FARRY. I NEED YOUR KID, FARRY PANTED. YOUR
POTIONS KID, ELIJAH GIVE IT TO ME BUT WHAT ABOUT THE
HALF-KID I LL EXPLAIN LATER! HEN PULLED HIS COAT OF
ADVANCED POTION-MAKING BELT OF HIS BAG AND HANDED IT OVER;
FARRY SPRINTED OFF PAST HIM AND RACED THE THE CHIMNEY ROOM. THERE,
HE SEIZED HIS SCHEMELAG, IGNORING THE AMAZED LOOKS OF SEVERAL
PEOPLE WHO HAD ALREADY FINISHED THEIR DINNER, THREW HIMSELF BACK
BELT OF THE PORTRAIT PICTURE, AND FLURLED OFF ALONG THE SEVENTH-FLOOR
CORRIDOR. HE SKIDDED TO A HALT BESIDE THE TAPESTRY OF DANCING TRELLS,
CLOSED HIS EYES, AND BEGAN THE WALK. I NEED A PLACE TO HIDE MY KID.

I NEED A PLACE TO HIDE MY KID. I NEED A PLACE TO HIDE MY KID.

THREE TIMES HE WALKED UP AND DOWN IN FRONT OF THE STRETCH OF
BLANK WALL. WHEN HE OPENED HIS EYES, THERE IT WAS AT LAST! THE DOOR
TO THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, FARRY WRENCHED IT OPEN, SLUNG
HIMSELF INSIDE, AND SLAMMED IT SHUT. HE GASPED. DESPITE HIS HASTE, HIS
PANIC, HIS FEAR OF WHAT AWAITED HIM BACK IN THE KITCHEN, HE COULD
NOT HELP BUT BE OVERAWED BY WHAT HE WAS LOOKING AT. HE WAS
STANDING IN A ROOM THE SIZE OF A LARGE CATHEDRAL, WHOSE HIGH
WINDOWS WERE SENDING STAKES OF LIGHT DOWN UPON WHAT LOOKED LIKE
A CITY WITH TWELFTH-CENTURY WALLS, KLIT OF WHAT FARRY KNEW MUST BE
OBJECTS HIDDEN BY GENERATIONS OF HOGWARTS INHABITANTS. THERE
WERE ALLEYS AND REHADS BORDERED BY TEETERING PILES OF CRACKED AND
DAMAGED FURNITURE, STOLN AWAY, PERHAPS, TO HIDE THE EVIDENCE OF
MIS-HANDLED MAGIC, OR ELSE HIDDEN BY CASTLEPROUD HOUSE-ELVES. THERE
WERE THOUSANDS AND THOUSANDS OF KIDS, NOT ONLY RANDED AND
GRAFFITIED AND STOLEN. THERE WERE WINGED CATAPULTS AND FANGED
FRISKEES, SOME STILL WITH ENOUGH LIFE IN THEM TO HEAVE
HALF-HEARTEDLY OVER THE MOUNTAINS OF OTHER FORGOTTEN ITEMS; THERE
WERE CHIPPED KETTLES OF CONGEOLED POTIONS, HATS, JEWELS, CLOAKS;
THERE WERE WHAT LOOKED LIKE DRAGON EGGSHELLS, CRACKED KETTLES
WHOSE CONTENTS STILL SHIMMERED EVILLY, SEVERAL GLISTENING SWORDS, AND
A HEAVY, BLOODSTAINED AXE. FARRY FLURIED FORWARD INTO ONE OF THE
MANY ALLEYS BETWEEN ALL THIS HIDDEN TREASURE. HE TURNED RIGHT
PAST AN ENORMOUS STUFFED TRELL, RAN ON A SHORT WAY, THEN A LEFT AT

THE KIDNAP VANISHING CABINET IN WHICH MONTAGUE HAD GOTTEN LOST THE PREVIOUS YEAR, FINALLY FALLING BESIDE A LARGE CLIPBOARD THAT SEEMED TO HAVE HAD ACID THROWN AT ITS KLISTERED SURFACE. HE EXPENDED ONE OF THE CLIPBOARD'S CREAKING DEERS: IT HAD ALREADY BEEN USED AS A HIDING PLACE FOR SOMETHING IN A CAGE THAT HAD BEEN SINCE BORN; ITS SKELETON HAD FIVE LEGS. HE STOLPED THE HALF-BLEED PRINCE'S KIDNAP BEHIND THE CAGE AND SLAMMED THE DEER. HE PALSED FOR A MOMENT, HIS HEART THUMPING FIERCELY, GAZING AROUND AT ALL THE CLITTER.

WOULD HE BE ABLE TO FIND THIS SPOT AGAIN AMIDST ALL THIS ILK? SEIZING THE CHIPPED LIST OF AN ELEGANT OLD WARRIOR FROM HIS THOUGHT OF A NEARBY CRATE, HE STOOD IT IN THE THOUGHT OF THE CLIPBOARD WHERE THE KIDNAP WAS NOW HIDDEN, PERCHED A GLISTY OLD WIG AND A TARNISHED TIARA ON THE STATUE'S HEAD THE MORE DISTINCTIVE, THEN SPRINTED BACK THROUGH THE ALLEYS OF HIS HIDDEN ILK AS FAST AS HE COULD GO, BACK TO THE DEER, BACK INTO THE CORRIDOR, WHERE HE SLAMMED THE DEER BEHIND HIM, AND IT TURNED AT ONCE BACK INTO THE STONE. HARRY RAN FLAT-OUT TOWARD THE KITCHEN IN THE FLOOR BELOW, CRAMPING WHEN HE STOPPED HE ADVANCED POTION-MAKING INTO HIS BAG AS HE DID SEE. A MINUTE LATER, HE WAS BACK IN FRONT OF SNAPE, WHO HELD OUT HIS HAND WORDLESSLY FOR HARRY'S SKINBAG. HARRY HANDED IT OVER, PARTING, A SEARING PAIN IN HIS CHEST, AND WAITED. ONE BY ONE, SNAPE EXTRACTED HARRY'S KIDNAPS AND EXAMINED THEM. FINALLY, THE ONLY KIDNAP LEFT WAS THE POTION'S KIDNAP, WHICH HE LOOKED AT VERY CAREFULLY BEFORE SPEAKING. THIS IS YOUR COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING, IS IT, POTTER? YES, SAID HARRY, STILL BREATHING HARD. YOU'RE WHITE AS A SHEET OF THAT, ARE YOU, POTTER? YES, SAID HARRY, WITH A THICK MORE DEFIANCE. THIS IS THE COPY OF ADVANCED POTION-MAKING THAT YOU PURCHASED FROM FLEURISH AND BOUTS?

YES, SAID HARRY FIRMLY. THEN WHY, ASKED SNAPE, DOES IT HAVE THE NAME RHEINIL WAZLE WRITTEN INSIDE THE FRONT COVER? HARRY'S HEART MISSED A BEAT. THAT'S MY NICKNAME, HE SAID. YOUR NICKNAME, REPEATED SNAPE. YES THAT'S WHAT MY FRIENDS CALL ME, SAID HARRY. I UNDERSTAND WHAT A NICKNAME IS, SAID SNAPE. THE CHILD, BLACK EYES WERE SHINING MORE INTO HARRY'S; HE TRIED NOT TO LOOK INTO THEM. PLEASE YOUR MIND, PLEASE YOUR MIND, BUT HE HAD NEVER LEARNED HOW TO DO IT PROPERLY. DO YOU KNOW WHAT I THINK, POTTER? SAID SNAPE, VERY QUIETLY. I THINK THAT YOU ARE A LIAR AND A CHEAT AND THAT YOU DESERVE DETENTION WITH ME

EVERY SATURDAY UNTIL THE END OF TERM. WHAT DO YOU THINK, PITTER? I I DON'T AGREE, SIR, SAID HARRY, STILL REFLIXING THE BLOOD INTO SNAPE'S EYES. WELL, WE SHALL SEE WHEN YOU FEEL AFTER YOUR DETENTIONS, SAID SNAPE. TEN HE CLICK SATURDAY MORNINE, PITTER, MY OFFICE. BUT SIR SAID HARRY, BLEEDING UP DESPERATELY. ELIADITCH THE LAST MATCH OF THE TEN HE CLICK, WHISPERED SNAPE, WITH A SMILE THAT SHOWED HIS YELLOW TEETH. PETER CROFFINDOR ALIOTH PLACE THIS YEAR, I FEAR AND HE LEFT THE KATHRENN WITHHOUT ANOTHER WORD, LEAVING HARRY THE STARE INTO THE CRACKED MIRROR, FEELING SICKER, HE WAS SURE, THAN WHEN HAD EVER FELT IN HIS LIFE. I DON'T SAY I TOLD YOU SEE, SAID HERMIONE, AN HOUR LATER IN THE CHAMBER ROOM. LEAVE IT, HERMIONE, SAID RON ANGRILY. HARRY HAD NEVER MADE IT THE DINNER; HE HAD NO APPETITE AT ALL. HE HAD JUST FINISHED TELLING RON, HERMIONE, AND GINNY WHAT HAD HAPPENED, NOT THAT THERE SEEMED TO HAVE BEEN MUCH NEED. THE NEWS HAD TRAVELED VERY FAST: APPARENTLY MARIANNE MORTLE HAD TAKEN IT UPON HERSELF TO PHP UP IN EVERY KATHRENN IN THE CASTLE TO TELL THE STORY; MALPHY HAD ALREADY BEEN VISITED IN THE HOSPITAL WING BY PANSY PARKINSON, WHO HAD LOST NO TIME IN VILIFYING HARRY FAR AND WIDE, AND SNAPE HAD TOLD THE STAFF PRECISELY WHAT HAD HAPPENED. HARRY HAD ALREADY BEEN CALLED INTO THE CHAMBER ROOM THE ENTIRE FIFTEEN HIGHLY UNPLEASANT MINUTES IN THE COMPANY OF PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, WHO HAD TOLD HIM HE WAS LUCKY NOT TO HAVE BEEN EXPELLED AND THAT SHE SUPPORTED WHOLEHEARTEDLY SNAPE'S PUNISHMENT OF DETENTION EVERY SATURDAY UNTIL THE END OF TERM. I TOLD YOU THERE WAS SOMETHING WRONG WITH THAT PRINCE PERSON, HERMIONE SAID, EVIDENTLY UNABLE TO STOP HERSELF. AND I WAS RIGHT, WASN'T I? NO, I DON'T THINK YOU WERE, SAID HARRY STUBBORNLY. HE WAS HAVING A BAD ENOUGH TIME WITHHOUT HERMIONE LECTURING HIM; THE BLOODS IN THE CROFFINDOR TEAM'S FACES WHEN HE HAD TOLD THEM HE WOULD NOT BE ABLE TO PLAY ON SATURDAY HAD BEEN THE WORST PUNISHMENT OF ALL. HE COULD FEEL GINNY'S EYES ON HIM WHEN HE DID NOT MEET THEM; HE DID NOT WANT TO SEE DISAPPOINTMENT OR ANGER THERE. HE HAD JUST TOLD HER THAT SHE WOULD BE PLAYING SEEKER ON SATURDAY AND THAT DEAN WOULD BE REMAINING THE TEAM AS CHASER IN HER PLACE. PERHAPS, IF THEY WERE, GINNY AND DEAN WOULD MAKE UP DURING THE POST-MATCH EUPHORIA. THE TWILIGHT WENT THROUGH

Harry like an icy knife. Harry, said Hermione, how can you still stick up for that when that spell will you stop harping on about the book? snapped Harry, The Prince only cheated it out! It's not like he was advising anyone the use of it! For all we knew, he was making a note of something that had been used against him! I don't believe this, said Hermione, you're actually defending. I'm not defending what I did! said Harry bluntly, I wish I hadn't done it, and not just because I've got about a dozen detentions, you know I wouldn't've used a spell like that, not even in Malfoy, but you can't blame the Prince, he hadn't written try this out, it's really good. He was just making notes for himself, wasn't he, not for anyone else.

Are you telling me, said Hermione, that you're giving the book back? And get the book? Yeah, I am, said Harry fiercely. Listen, without the Prince I'd never have won the Felix Felicis, I'd never have known how the save Ron from poisoning, I'd never have got a reputation for Potters' brilliance you don't deserve, said Hermione nastily, Give it a rest, Hermione! said Ginny, and Harry was so amazed, so grateful, he blushed up. By the sound of it, Malfoy was trying the use of an Unforgivable Curse, you should be glad Harry had something good up his sleeve!

Well, if course I'm glad Harry wasn't cursed! said Hermione, clearly stung, but you can't call that Sectumsempra spell good, Ginny, look where it's landed him! And I'd have thought, seeing what this has done to your chances in the match. He, then started acting as though you understand Sludgitch, snapped Ginny, you'll only embarrass yourself. Harry and Ron stared: Hermione and Ginny, who had always got on together very well, were now sitting with their arms folded, glaring in opposite directions. Ron blushed nervously at Harry, then snatched up a book at random and hid behind it. Harry, however, little though he knew he deserved it, felt unbelievably cheerful all of a sudden, even though none of them spoke again for the rest of the evening. His lightheartedness was short-lived. There were Slytherin talents to be endured next day, not to mention much anger from fellow Gryffindors, who were most unhappy that their Captain had got himself banned from the final match of the season. By Saturday morning, whatever he might have told

DETERMINED, HARRY WOULD HAVE GLADLY EXCHANGED ALL THE FELIX FELICES
 IN THE WORLD FOR WALKING BEHIND THE THE FLUIDITCH PITCH WITH RON,
 GINNY, AND THE WEASLEYS. IT WAS ALMOST UNBEARABLE THE TURN AWAY
 FROM THE MASS OF STUDENTS STREAMING OUT INTO THE SUNSHINE, ALL OF
 THEM WEARING HOSIERY AND HATS AND BRASS-BRANDISHING KNOTTERS AND
 SCARVES, THE DESCEND THE STONE STEPS INTO THE DUNGEONS AND WALK
 UNTIL THE DISTANT SOUNDS OF THE CHURCH WERE ALITE ECLIPSED,
 KNOWING THAT HE WOULD NOT BE ABLE TO HEAR A WORD OF COMMENTARY
 OR A CHURCH OR CHURCH. AND, PETER, SAID SNAPE, WHEN HARRY HAD
 DESCENDED HIS DEER AND ENTERED THE UNPLEASANTLY FAMILIAR OFFICE
 THAT SNAPE, DESPITE TEACHING FLAMES ABOVE HIM, HAD NOT VACATED; IT
 WAS AS DIMLY LIT AS EVER AND THE SAME SLIMY DEAD EYEGLASSES WERE
 SUSPENDED IN CHALKED PORTALS ALL AROUND THE WALLS. EMINENTLY,
 THERE WERE MANY CHALKED BOOKS PILED ON A TABLE WHERE HARRY WAS
 CLEARLY SUPPOSED TO SIT; THEY HAD AN AIR OF TENDRILS, HARD, AND
 PUNCTUALLY WERE ABOUT THEM. MR. FILCH HAS BEEN LOOKING FOR
 SOMETHING TO CLEAR OUT THESE OLD FILES, SAID SNAPE SEPTLY. THEY ARE
 THE RECORDS OF OTHER HOGWARTS WITCHES AND THEIR
 PUNISHMENTS. WHERE THE INK HAS GROWN FAINT, OR THE CARDS HAVE
 SUFFERED DAMAGE FROM MICE, WE WOULD LIKE YOU TO COPY OUT THE
 CRIMES AND PUNISHMENTS AFRESH AND, MAKING SURE THAT THEY ARE IN
 ALPHABETICAL ORDER, REPLACE THEM IN THE BOOKS. YOU WILL NOT USE
 MAGIC. RIGHT, PROFESSOR, SAID HARRY, WITH AS MUCH COUNTERPOINT AS
 HE COULD PUT INTO THE LAST THREE SYLLABLES. I THOUGHT YOU WOULD
 START, SAID SNAPE, A MALICIOUS SMILE ON HIS LIPS, WITH BOOKS ONE
 THOUSAND AND TWELVE TO ONE THOUSAND AND FIFTY-SIX. YOU WILL FIND
 SOME FAMILIAR NAMES IN THERE, WHICH SHOULD ADD INTEREST TO THE
 TASK. HERE, YOU SEE. HE PULLED OUT A CARD FROM ONE OF THE
 THIRTIEST BOOKS WITH A FLIRTY AND READ. JAMES PETER AND
 SIRILS BLACK, APPREHENDED USING AN ILLEGAL NEW LIPON KERTRAM
 ALKREY, ALKREY'S HEAD TWICE NORMAL SIZE, DELETER DETENTION.

SNAPE SMILED. IT MUST BE SUCH A COMFORT TO THINK THAT, THOUGH
 THEY ARE GONE, A RECORD OF THEIR GREAT ACHIEVEMENTS REMAINS.
 HARRY FELT THE FAMILIAR CHILLING SENSATION IN THE PIT OF HIS
 STOMACH, BITING HIS TONGUE TO PREVENT HIMSELF RETALIATING, HE SAT
 DOWN IN FRONT OF THE BOOKS AND PULLED ONE TOWARD HIM. IT WAS, AS
 HARRY HAD ANTICIPATED, USELESS, BURNING WARD, PUNCTUATED (AS SNAPE
 HAD CLEARLY PLANNED) WITH THE REGULAR PAIN IN THE STOMACH THAT

MEANT HE HAD JUST READ HIS FATHER HER SIRIUS'S NAMES, USUALLY
CHARGED TOGETHER IN VARIOUS PETTY MISDEEDS, OCCASIONALLY
ACCOMPANIED BY THESE OF REMUS LUPIN AND PETER PETTIGREW, AND
WHILE HE CHIEFLY HURT ALL THEIR VARIOUS OFFENSES AND PUNISHMENTS,
HE WONDERED WHAT WAS GOING ON HOGWARTS, WHERE THE MATCH WOULD
HAVE JUST STARTED. GINNY PLAYING SEEKER AGAINST THE HARRY
GLANCED AGAIN AND AGAIN AT THE LARGE CLOCK TICKING ON THE WALL. IT
SEEMED TO BE MOVING HALF AS FAST AS A REGULAR CLOCK; PERHAPS
SNAPPE HAD ENCHANTED IT TO GO EXTRA SLOWLY? HE COULD NOT HAVE BEEN
HERE FOR ONLY HALF AN HOUR. AN HOUR. AN HOUR AND A HALF.
HARRY'S STOMACH STARTED RUMBLING WHEN THE CLOCK STRUCK HALF
PAST TWELVE. SNAPPE, WHO HAD NOT SPOKEN AT ALL SINCE SETTING
HARRY HIS TASK, FINALLY LOOKED UP AT TEN PAST ONE. I THINK THAT
WILL DO, HE SAID COLDLY. MARK THE PLACE YOU HAVE REACHED. YOU
WILL CONTINUE AT TEN O'CLOCK NEXT SATURDAY. YES, SIR. HARRY
SLIPPED A KENT CARD INTO THE KEE AT RANDOM AND HURRIED OFF THE
DECK BEFORE SNAPPE COULD CHANGE HIS MIND, RACING BACK UP THE STONE
STEPS, STRAINING HIS EARS TO HEAR A SOUND FROM THE PITCH, BUT ALL
WAS SILENT. IT WAS EVER, THEN. HE HESITATED OUTSIDE THE
CREATED GREAT HALL, THEN RAN UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE; WHETHER
GRIFFINDOR HAD BEEN HIS BEST, THE TEAM USUALLY CELEBRATED AND
CELEBRATED IN THEIR OWN CHAMPION ROOM. ELIAD AGES? HE SAID
TENTATIVELY TO THE FAT LADY, WONDERING WHAT HE WOULD FIND INSIDE.
HER EXPRESSION WAS UNREADABLE AS SHE REPLIED, YOU'LL SEE. AND
SHE SWUNG FORWARD, A REAR OF CELEBRATION ERUPTED FROM THE FLOOR
BEHIND HER. HARRY GASPED AS PEOPLE BEGAN TO SCREAM AT THE SIGHT OF
HIM; SEVERAL HANDS PULLED HIM INTO THE ROOM. WE WHEN? YELLED
ONE, RUSHING INTO SIGHT AND BRANDISHING THE SILVER CLIP AT
HARRY. WE WHEN? FIFTY HUNDRED AND FIFTY TH A HUNDRED AND FIFTY?
WE WHEN? HARRY LOOKED AROUND; THERE WAS GINNY RUNNING
TOWARD HIM; SHE HAD A HARD, GLAZING LOOK IN HER FACE AS SHE THREW
HER ARMS AROUND HIM. AND WITHOUT THINKING, WITHOUT PLANNING
IT, WITHOUT WHISPERING ABOUT THE FACT THAT FIFTY PEOPLE WERE
WATCHING, HARRY KISSED HER. AFTER SEVERAL LONG MOMENTS. HE IT
MIGHT HAVE BEEN HALF AN HOUR. OR POSSIBLY SEVERAL SHORT DAYS
THEY BROKE APART. THE ROOM HAD BEEN VERY SILENT. THEN SEVERAL
PEOPLE WHOOPED AND THERE WAS AN OUTCRAZE OF NERVOUS
GIGGLING. HARRY LOOKED OVER THE TOP OF GINNY'S HEAD TO SEE DEAN

THOMAS HOLDING A SHATTERED GLASS IN HIS HAND, AND REMILDA VANE
 BEHIND AS THOUGH SHE MIGHT THROW SOMETHING. HERMINE WAS
 BEAMING, BUT HARRY'S EYES SHED LIGHT UPON. AT LAST HE FOUND HIM, STILL
 CLUTCHING THE CLIP AND WEARING AN EXPRESSION APPROPRIATE THE
 HAVING BEEN CLIPPED OVER THE HEAD. FOR A FRACTION OF A SECOND THEY
 LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, THEN RICH GAVE A TINY TUCK OF THE HEAD THAT
 HARRY UNDERSTOOD THE MEAN. WELL IF YOU MUST. THE CREATURE IN
 HIS CHEST BEARING IN TRIUMPH, HE GRINNED DOWN AT GINNY AND
 GESTURED WHOLEHEARTEDLY UP AT THE PORTRAIT FLEE. A LONG WALK IN THE
 GRILINDS SEEMED INDICATED, DURING WHICH IF THEY HAD TIME THEY
 MIGHT DISCUSS THE MATCH. THE SEER HEARD THE FACT THAT
 HARRY POTTER WAS GOING OUT WITH GINNY WEASLEY SEEMED THE
 INTEREST A GREAT NUMBER OF PEOPLE, MOST OF THEM GIRLS, YET HARRY
 FOUND HIMSELF NEWLY AND HAPPILY IMPERVIOUS TO Gossip OVER THE
 NEXT FEW WEEKS. AFTER ALL, IT MADE A VERY NICE CHANGE THE HE TALKED
 ABOUT BECAUSE OF SOMETHING THAT WAS MAKING HIM HAPPIER THAN HE
 COULD REMEMBER BEING FOR A VERY LONG TIME, RATHER THAN BECAUSE HE
 HAD BEEN INVOLVED IN HORRIFIC SCENES OF DARK MAGIC. YOU'D THINK
 PEOPLE HAD BETTER THINGS TO Gossip ABOUT, SAID GINNY, AS SHE SAT
 ON THE CHIMPAN CHIMP FLOOR, LEANING AGAINST HARRY'S LEGS AND
 READING THE DAILY PROPHET. THREE DEMENTOR ATTACKS IN A WEEK,
 AND ALL REMILDA VANE DOES IS ASK ME IF IT'S TRUE YOU'VE GOT A
 HIPPOGRIF TATTOOED ACROSS YOUR CHEST. RICH AND HERMINE BOTH
 BEAMED WITH DELIGHT. HARRY IGNORED THEM. WHAT DID YOU TELL
 HER? I TOLD HER IT'S A HUNGARIAN HORNTAIL, SAID GINNY,
 TURNING A PAGE OF THE NEWSPAPER IDLY. MUCH MORE MATCH.

THANKS, SAID HARRY, GRINNING. AND WHAT DID YOU TELL HER
 RICH'S GIFT? A PYGMY PUFF, BUT I DIDN'T SAY WHERE. RICH SCOWLED
 AS HERMINE ROLLED ABOUT LAUGHING. WATCH IT, HE SAID,
 POINTING WARNINGLY AT HARRY AND GINNY. I JUST BECAUSE I'VE GIVEN
 MY PERMISSION DOESN'T MEAN I CAN'T WITHDRAW IT YOUR
 PERMISSION, SCOFFED GINNY. SINCE WHEN DID YOU GIVE ME
 PERMISSION TO DO ANYTHING? ANYWAY, YOU SAID YOURSELF YOU'D
 RATHER IT WAS HARRY THAN MICHAEL HER DEAN. YEAH, I WOULD, SAID
 RICH GRUDGINGLY. AND I JUST AS LONG AS YOU DON'T START SPEECING
 EACH OTHER IN PUBLIC YOU'VE FIFTY FIFTY. WHAT ABOUT YOU
 AND LAVENDER, THRASHING ABOUT LIKE A PAIR OF EELS ALL OVER THE
 PLACE? DEMANDED GINNY, BUT RICH'S TOLERANCE WAS NOT THE BEST TESTED

MUCH AS THEY MOVED INTO LINE, HER HARRY AND CINDY'S TIME TOGETHER WAS BECOMING INCREASINGLY RESTRICTED. CINDY'S FEELINGS WERE APPROACHING AND SHE WAS THEREFORE FORCED THE STUDY HER FEELINGS INTO THE NIGHT. ON ONE SUCH EVENING, WHEN CINDY HAD RETIRED TO THE LIBRARY, AND HARRY WAS SITTING BESIDE THE WINDOW IN THE COMMON ROOM, SUPPOSEDLY FINISHING HIS FORTHRIGHTLY FORTHRIGHT BUT IN REALITY RELIVING A PARTICULARLY HAPPY FEELING HE HAD SPENT DOWN BY THE LAKE WITH CINDY AT LUNCHTIME, FERMINE DROPPED INTO THE SEAT BETWEEN HIM AND REIN WITH AN UNPLEASANTLY PURPOSEFUL LOOK ON HER FACE. I WANT TO TALK TO YOU, HARRY. WHAT ABILITY? SAID HARRY SUSPICIOUSLY. ONLY THE PREVIOUS DAY, FERMINE HAD TOLD HIM OFF HER DISTRACTING CINDY WHEN SHE HEIGHT THE RE WHIRLING HARD HER HER EXAMINATIONS. THE SO-CALLED HALF-BLOOD PRINCE.

HE, NOT AGAIN, HE GRIANED. WILL YOU PLEASE DROP IT? HE HAD NOT DARED TO RETURN THE THE REIN OF REQUIREMENT TO RETRIEVE HIS REIN, AND HIS PERFORMANCE IN POINTS WAS SLIPPING ACCORDINGLY (THOUGH SLIGHTLY, WITH APPROVED OF CINDY, HAD INCLINARLY ATTRIBUTED THIS TO HARRY BEING LIVESICK). BUT HARRY WAS SURE THAT SNAPPE HAD NOT YET GIVEN UP HIS OF LAYING HANDS ON THE PRINCE'S REIN, AND WAS DETERMINED TO LEAVE IT WHERE IT WAS WHILE SNAPPE REMAINED ON THE MERECHIT. I'M NOT DROPPING IT, SAID FERMINE FIRMLY. UNTIL YOU'VE HEARD ME OUT. WELL, I'VE BEEN TRYING TO FIND OUT A BIT ABOUT WHAT MIGHT MAKE A FEELING OF INVENTING DARK SPELLS

HE DIDN'T MAKE A FEELING OF IT HE, HE WHEN SAYS IT'S A HE? WE'VE BEEN THROUGH THIS, SAID HARRY CROSSLY. PRINCE, FERMINE, PRINCE? RIGHT? SAID FERMINE, RED PATCHES BLAZING IN HER CHEEKS AS SHE PULLED A VERY OLD PIECE OF NEWSPRINT OUT OF HER POCKET AND SLAPPED IT DOWN ON THE TABLE IN FRONT OF HARRY. LOOK AT THAT! LOOK AT THE PICTURE! HARRY PICKED UP THE CRUMBLING PIECE OF PAPER AND STARED AT THE MOVING PHOTOGRAPH, YELLOWED WITH AGE. REIN LEANED OVER HER A LOOK THEN. THE PICTURE SHOWED A SKINNY GIRL OF ABOUT FIFTEEN. SHE WAS NOT PRETTY; SHE LOOKED SIMULTANEOUSLY CROSS AND SILEN, WITH HEAVY BROWS AND A LONG, PALLID FACE. UNDERNEATH THE PHOTOGRAPH WAS THE CAPTION: RILKEN PRINCE, CAPTAIN OF THE HOGWARTS CHRISTMAS TEAM.

SHE SAID HARRY, SCANNING THE SHORT NEWS ITEM TO WHICH THE PICTURE BELONGED; IT WAS A RATHER DULL STORY ABOUT INTERSCHOOL COMPETITIONS. HER NAME WAS RILKEN PRINCE, PRINCE, HARRY. THEY

LOOKED AT EACH OTHER, AND HARRY REALIZED WHAT HERMIONIE WAS TRYING TO SAY, HE FIRST BENT LAUGHING. NO WAY. WHAT? YOU THINK SHE WAS THE HALF-BLOOD ? EH, COME ON. WELL, WHY NOT? HARRY, THERE AREN'T ANY REAL PRINCES IN THE WIZARDING WORLD! IT'S EITHER A NICKNAME, A MADE-UP TITLE SOMEBODY'S GIVEN THEMSELVES, OR IT COULD BE THEIR ACTUAL NAME, COULDN'T IT? NO, LISTEN! IF, SAY, HER FATHER WAS A WIZARD WHOSE SURNAME WAS PRINCE, AND HER MOTHER WAS A MUGGLE, THEN THAT WOULD MAKE HER A HALF-BLOOD PRINCE !

Yeah, very ingenuitish, HERMIONIE BUT IT WOULD! MAYBE SHE WAS PROBABLY BEING HALF A PRINCE? LISTEN, HERMIONIE, I CAN TELL IT'S NOT A GIRL, I CAN JUST TELL. THE TRUTH IS THAT YOU DON'T THINK A GIRL WOULD HAVE BEEN CLEVER ENOUGH, SAID HERMIONIE ANGRILY. HOW CAN I HAVE BEEN WRONG WITH YOU FOR FIVE YEARS AND NOT THINK GIRLS ARE CLEVER? SAID HARRY, STUNG BY THIS. IT'S THE WAY HE WRITES, I JUST KNOW THE PRINCE WAS A BOY, I CAN TELL. THIS GIRL HADN'T GOTTEN ANYTHING TO DO WITH IT, WHERE DID YOU GET THIS ANYWAY? THE LIBRARY, SAID HERMIONIE PREDICTABLY. THERE'S A WHOLE COLLECTION OF OLD PROPHETS UP THERE, WELL, I'M GOING TO FIND OUT MORE ABOUT RISEN PRINCE IF I CAN. ENOUGH YOURSELF, SAID HARRY IRRITABLY. I WILL, SAID HERMIONIE. AND THE FIRST PLACE I'LL LOOK, SHE SMILED AT HIM, AS SHE REACHED THE PORTRAIT HALL, IS RECORDS OF OLD PROPHETS ALREADY? HARRY SMILED AFTER HER FOR A MOMENT, THEN CONTINUED HIS CONTEMPLATION OF THE DARKENING DOOR.

SHE'S JUST NEVER GOTTEN EVER YOU WHISPERING HER IN PROPHETS, SAID RON, RETURNING THE COPY OF A THOUSAND MAGICAL HERBS AND PLANTS. YOU DON'T THINK I'M MAD, WANTING THAT BOOK BACK, DO YOU? COURSE NOT, SAID RON RECKLESSLY. HE WAS A GENIUS, THE PRINCE. ANYWAY WITH-OUT HIS REZAR TIP HE BROKE HIS FINGER SIGNIFICANTLY ACROSS HIS ELBOW THEREAT. I WOULDN'T BE HERE TO DISCUSS IT, WOULD I? I MEAN, I'M NOT SAYING THAT SPELL YOU USED FOR MALFOY WAS GREAT. NEAR AM I, SAID HARRY QUICKLY, BUT HE HEALED ALL RIGHT, DIDN'T HE? BACK ON HIS FEET IN NO TIME. Yeah, SAID HARRY; THIS WAS PERFECTLY TRUE, ALTHOUGH HIS CONSCIENCE STUNG SLIGHTLY ALL THE SAME. THANKS THE SNAPE YOU STILL GOT DETENTION WITH SNAPE THIS SATURDAY? RON CONTINUED. Yeah, AND THE SATURDAY AFTER THAT, AND THE SATURDAY AFTER THAT, SIGHED HARRY.

AND HE'S HINTING NOW THAT IF I DON'T GET ALL THE BOOKS DONE BY THE END OF TERM, WE'LL CARRY ON NEXT YEAR. HE WAS FINDING THESE

DETENTIONS PARTICULARLY IRKSOME BECAUSE THEY CUT INTO THE ALREADY LIMITED TIME HE COULD HAVE BEEN SPENDING WITH GINNY. INDEED, HE HAD FREQUENTLY WONDERED LATELY WHETHER SNAPE DID NOT KNOW THIS, AND HE WAS KEEPING HARRY LATER AND LATER EVERY TIME, WHILE MAKING PHINTED ASIDES ABOUT HARRY HAVING THE MISS THE GOOD WEATHER AND THE VARIED HOPPLETLINITIES IT OFFERED. HARRY WAS SHAKEN FROM THESE BITTER REFLECTIONS BY THE APPEARANCE AT HIS SIDE OF JIMMY PEAKES, WHO WAS HOLDING OUT A SHEET OF PARCHMENT. THANKS, JIMMY! HEY, IT'S FROM DUMBLEDORE! SAID HARRY EXCITEDLY, UNWHELLING THE PARCHMENT AND SCANNING IT. HE WANTS ME TO GO TO HIS OFFICE AS SOON AS I CAN! THEY STARED AT EACH OTHER. BLIMMY, WHISPERED PHOEN. WHY DON'T YOU GO? HE HASN'T BEEN? BETTER GO AND SEE, HADN'T I? SAID HARRY, JUMPING TO HIS FEET. HE HURRIED OUT OF THE COMMON ROOM AND ALONG THE SEVENTH FLOOR AS FAST AS HE COULD, PASSING NEARBY BUT PEAKES, WHO SLIPPED PAST IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION, THROWING HIS GLANCE AT HARRY IN A RECKLESS SHORT WAY AND CACKLING LOUDLY AS HE DROGGED HARRY'S DEFENSIVE INK. SINCE PEAKES HAD VANISHED, THERE WAS SILENCE IN THE HALLWAYS; WITH ONLY FIFTEEN MINUTES LEFT UNTIL LUNCH, MOST PEOPLE HAD ALREADY RETURNED TO THEIR COMMON ROOMS, AND THEN HARRY HEARD A SCREAM AND A CRASH. HE STOPPED IN HIS TRACKS, LISTENING. HE'D DARE WHY AAAAARGH! THE NOISE WAS COMING FROM A HALLWAY NEARBY; HARRY SPRINTED TOWARD IT, HIS HAND AT THE READY, FLUTTERED AROUND ANOTHER CORNER, AND SAW PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SPRAWLED UPON THE FLOOR, HER HEAD COVERED IN ONE OF HER MANY SHAWLS, SEVERAL SHERRY BOTTLES LYING BESIDE HER, ONE BROKEN. PROFESSOR HARRY HURRIED FORWARD AND HELPED PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY TO HER FEET. SOME OF HER GLITTERING BEADS HAD BECOME ENTANGLED WITH HER GLASSES. SHE HICCAPED LOUDLY, PATTED HER HAIR, AND PULLED HERSELF UP ON HARRY'S HELPING ARM. WHAT HAPPENED, PROFESSOR? WHY MAY WELL ASK? SHE SAID SHAKILY. I WAS STROLLING ALONG, BRENDING UPON CERTAIN DARK PORTENTS I HAPPEN TO HAVE GLIMPSED BUT HARRY WAS NOT PAYING MUCH ATTENTION. HE HAD JUST NOTICED WHERE THEY WERE STANDING! THERE ON THE RIGHT WAS THE TAPESTRY OF DANCING TRELLS, AND ON THE LEFT, THAT SMOTHERLY IMPENETRABLE STRETCH OF STONE WALL THAT CONCEALED PROFESSOR, WERE THEY TRYING TO GET INTO THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT? MEANS I HAVE BEEN VEHICULAR WHAT? SHE LOOKED SUDDENLY SHUT. THE ROOM OF

REQUIREMENT, REPEATED HARRY, WERE YOU TRYING TO GET IN THERE? I WELL I DIDN'T KNOW STUDENTS KNOW ABOUT NOT ALL OF THEM DO, SAID HARRY, BUT WHAT HAPPENED? YOU SCREAMED, IT SOUNDED AS THOUGH YOU WERE FURT, I WELL, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY, DRAWING HER SHOULDERS AROUND HER DEFENSIVELY AND STARING DOWN AT HIM WITH HER VASTLY MAGNIFIED EYES, I WISHED THE AN DEPOSIT CERTAINLY MY PERSONAL ITEMS IN THE ROOM, AND SHE MUTTERED SOMETHING ABOUT NASTY ACCUSATIONS.

RIGHT, SAID HARRY, GLANCING DOWN AT THE SHIRAZ BOTTLES, BUT YOU COULDN'T GET IN AND HIDE THEM? HE FEELING THIS VERY HOT, THE ROOM HAD OPENED FOR HIM, AFTER ALL, WHEN HE HAD WANTED TO HIDE THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE'S SHED, HE, I GOT IN ALL RIGHT, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY, GLARING AT THE WALL, BUT THERE WAS SOMEBODY ALREADY IN THERE, SOMEBODY IN ? WHO? DEMANDED HARRY, WHO WAS IN THERE? I HAVE NO IDEA, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY, LOOKING SLIGHTLY TAKEN ABACK AT THE URGENCY IN HARRY'S VOICE, I WALKED INTO THE ROOM AND I HEARD A VOICE, WHICH HAS NEVER HAPPENED BEFORE IN ALL MY YEARS OF HIDING OF USING THE ROOM, I MEAN, A VOICE? SAYING WHAT? I DIDN'T KNOW THAT IT WAS SAYING ANYTHING, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY, IT WAS WHISPERING.

WHISPERING? GLENNALLY, SHE SAID, NODDING, HARRY STARED AT HER, WAS IT MADE HER FEMALE? I WOULD HAZARD A GUESS AT MALE, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY, AND IT SOUNDED HAPPY? VERY HAPPY, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY SNIFFLY, AS THOUGH IT WAS CELEBRATING? MOST DEFINITELY, AND THEN ? AND THEN I CALLED OUT WHO'S THERE? YOU COULDN'T HAVE FEELING OUT WHO IT WAS WITHOUT ASKING? HARRY ASKED HER, SLIGHTLY FRUSTRATED, THE INNER EYE, SAID PROFESSOR TRILANEY WITH DIGNITY, STRAIGHTENING HER SHOULDERS AND MANY STRANDS OF GLITTERING BEADS, WAS FIXED UPON MATTERS WELL OUTSIDE THE MUNDANE REALMS OF WHISPERING VEHICLES.

RIGHT, SAID HARRY HASTILY; HE HAD HEARD ABOUT PROFESSOR TRILANEY'S INNER EYE ALL THESE YEARS BEFORE, AND DID THE VOICE SAY WHO WAS THERE? NO, IT DID NOT, SHE SAID, EVERYTHING WENT PITCH-BLACK AND THE NEXT THING I KNOW, I WAS BEING FLUNG HEADFIRST OUT OF THE ROOM! AND YOU DIDN'T SEE THAT COMING? SAID HARRY, UNABLE TO HELP HIMSELF, NO, I DID NOT, AS I SAY, IT WAS PITCH SHE STOPPED AND GLARED AT HIM SUSPICIOUSLY, I THINK YOU'D BETTER TELL PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE, SAID HARRY, HE MIGHT THE

KNOW MALCOLM'S CELEBRATING. I MEAN, THAT SOMEONE THREW THEM
OUT OF THE ROOM. THE HIS SURPRISE, PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY DREW
HERSELF UP AT THIS SUGGESTION, LEAVING HALICITY. THE HEADMASTER
HAD INTIMATED THAT HE WOULD PREFER FEWER VISITS FROM ME. SHE SAID
COLDLY. I AM NOT HERE TO PRESS MY COMPANY UPON THOSE WHO DO NOT
VALUE IT. IF DUMBLEDORE CHOOSES TO IGNORE THE WARNINGS THE CARDS
SHOW. HER HAND CLASPED SLIDDERLY AROUND HARRY'S WRIST.

AGAIN AND AGAIN, NO MATTER HOW I LAY THEM OUT. AND SHE
PULLED A CARD DRAMATICALLY FROM UNDERNEATH HER STALKS. THE
LIGHTNING-STRIKE THUNDER, SHE WHISPERED, CALAMITY, DISASTER,
COMING NEARER ALL THE TIME. RIGHT, SAID HARRY AGAIN. WELL

I STILL THINK YOU SHOULD TELL DUMBLEDORE ABOUT THIS VEHICLE, AND
EVERYTHING GOING DARK AND BEING THROWN OUT OF THE ROOM.

YOU THINK SHE? PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY SEEMED TO CONSIDER THE
MATTER FOR A MOMENT, BUT HARRY COULD TELL THAT SHE LIKED THE IDEA
OF RETELLING HER LITTLE ADVENTURE. I'M GOING TO SEE HIM RIGHT
NOW, SAID HARRY. I'VE GOT A MEETING WITH HIM. WE COULD GO
TOGETHER. EH, WELL, IN THAT CASE, SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WITH
A SMILE. SHE BENT DOWN, SCHEMPED UP HER STERRY KETTLES, AND DUMPED
THEM UNCONSCIOUSLY IN A LARGE BLUE-AND-WHITE VASE STANDING IN
A NEARBY NICH. I MISS HAVING YOU IN MY CLASSES, HARRY. SHE SAID
SERIOUSLY AS THEY SET OFF TOGETHER. YOU WERE NEVER MUCH OF A
SEER. BUT YOU WERE A WONDERFUL HEIKET. HARRY DID NOT REPLY;
HE HAD LEARNED BEING THE HEIKET OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S
CONTINUUAL PREDICTIONS OF DEATH. I AM AFRAID, SHE WENT ON, THAT
THE NAG. I'M SORRY, THE CENTALIR. KNOWS NOTHING OF
CARTOMANCY. I ASKED HIM. HOW SEER THE ANOTHER. HAD HE NOT,
THE, SENSED THE DISTANT VIBRATIONS OF COMING CATASTROPHIC? BUT HE
SEEMED TO FIND ME ALMOST CHEMICAL. YES, CHEMICAL. HER VOICE RISE
RATHER HYSTERICALLY, AND HARRY CALLED A POWERFUL WHIFF OF STERRY
EVEN THOUGH THE KETTLES HAD BEEN LEFT BEHIND. PERHAPS THE HORSE
HAD HEARD PEOPLE SAY THAT I HAVE NOT INHERITED MY GREAT-GREAT-
GRANDFATHER'S GIFT. THESE ALPHAS HAVE BEEN BANNED ABOUT BY THE
REALMS FOR YEARS. YOU KNOW WHAT I SAY TO SUCH PEOPLE, HARRY?
WOULD DUMBLEDORE HAVE LET ME TEACH AT THIS GREAT SCHOOL, PUT ME
MUCH TRUST IN ME ALL THESE YEARS, HAD I NOT PROVED MYSELF TO HIM?
HARRY MURMURED SOMETHING INDISTINCT. I WILL REMEMBER MY FIRST
INTERVIEW WITH DUMBLEDORE. WENT ON PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, IN

THAT'S THE POINT. HE WAS DEEPLY IMPRESSED, HE CHUCKLED, DEEPLY IMPRESSED. I WAS STAYING AT THE FINE S ROAD, WHICH I DID NOT ADVISE, INCIDENTALLY. REBELS, DEAR HARRY. BUT FOLKS WERE WELL. DUMBLEDORE DID ME THE COURTESY OF CALLING UPON ME IN MY ROOM. HE BELIEVED ME. I MUST CONFESS THAT, AT FIRST, I THOUGHT HE SEEMED ILDISPOSED TOWARD DIVINATION. AND I REMEMBER I WAS STARTING TO FEEL A LITTLE HOPE, I HAD NOT EATEN MUCH THAT DAY. BUT THEN. AND WHEN HARRY WAS PAYING ATTENTION PROPERLY FOR THE FIRST TIME, FOR HE KNEW WHAT HAD HAPPENED THEN: PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY HAD MADE THE PROPHECY THAT HAD ALTERED THE COURSE OF HIS WHOLE LIFE, THE PROPHECY ABOUT HIM AND VOLDMORT. BUT THEN WE WERE RUDELY INTERRUPTED BY SEVERUS Snape. WHAT?

YES, THERE WAS A CHIMNEYPIPE OUTSIDE THE DOOR AND IT AWOKE UP, AND THERE WAS THAT RATHER UNLIKELY BARMAN STANDING WITH Snape, WHO WAS WHISPERING ABOUT HAVING HEARD THE WHISPERING WAY UP THE STAIRS, ALTHOUGH I'M AFRAID THAT I MYSELF RATHER THOUGHT HE HAD BEEN APPROPRIATELY EAVESDROPPING ON MY INTERVIEW WITH DUMBLEDORE.

WELL, HE HIMSELF WAS SPEAKING TO ME AT THE TIME, AND HE DIDN'T MIND THE PICK UP TIPS. WELL, AFTER THAT, WHEN DUMBLEDORE SEEMED MUCH MORE DISPOSED TO GIVE ME A HEAR, AND I COULD NOT HELP THINKING, HARRY, THAT IT WAS BECAUSE HE APPRECIATED THE STRONG CONTRAST BETWEEN MY OWN UNASSUMING MANNERS AND HIS TALENT, COMPARED TO THE POLISHING, THIRSTING FEELING MAN WHO WAS PREPARED TO LISTEN AT DEPTHS. HARRY, DEAR? SHE LOOKED BACK OVER HER SHOULDER, HAVING ONLY JUST REALIZED THAT HARRY WAS NO LONGER WITH HER; HE HAD STOPPED WALKING AND THEY WERE NOW TEN FEET APART EACH OTHER. HARRY? SHE REPEATED UNCERTAINLY, PERHAPS HIS FACE WAS WHITE THE MAKE HER LOOK SEE CONCERNED AND FRIGHTENED, HARRY WAS STANDING STOCK-STILL AS WAVES OF SILENCE CRASHED OVER HIM, WAVE AFTER WAVE, ILLUMINATING EVERYTHING EXCEPT THE INFORMATION THAT HAD BEEN KEPT FROM HIM FOR SO LONG. IT WAS Snape WHO HAD HEARD THE PROPHECY. IT WAS Snape WHO HAD CARRIED THE NEWS OF THE PROPHECY TO VOLDMORT. Snape AND PETER PETTIGREW TOGETHER HAD SENT VOLDMORT HUNTING AFTER LILY AND JAMES AND THEIR SON. NOTHING ELSE MATTERED TO HARRY JUST THEN.

HARRY? SAID PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY AGAIN. HARRY. I THOUGHT WE WERE GOING TO SEE THE HEADMASTER TOGETHER? WELL, STAY HERE, SAID HARRY THOUGH NOT LIPS. BUT DEAR. I WAS GOING TO TELL

HIM WHEN I WAS ASSAULTED IN THE ROOM OF YOU STAY HERE?
FARRY REPEATED ANGRILY. SHE LOOKED ALARMED AS HE RAN PAST HER,
ARCHING THE CORNER INTO DUMKLEBHERE'S CHAIRSIDE, WHERE THE LONG
GARGOYLE STOOD SENTRY. FARRY SEIZED THE PASSAGE AT THE
GARGOYLE AND RAN UP THE MOVING SPIRAL STAIRCASE THREE STEPS AT A
TIME. HE DID NOT KNOW WHEN DUMKLEBHERE'S DOOR, HE HAMMERED; AND
THE CALM VOICE ANSWERED. ENTER AFTER FARRY HAD ALREADY FILING
HIMSELF INTO THE ROOM. FATHERS THE PHOENIX LOOKED AROUND, HIS
BRIGHT BLACK EYES GLEAMING WITH REFLECTED GOLD FROM THE SUNSET
BEYOND THE WINDOWS. DUMKLEBHERE WAS STANDING AT THE WINDOW
LOOKING OUT AT THE GRILINDS, A LONG, BLACK TRAVELING CLOAK IN HIS
ARMS. WELL, FARRY, I PROMISED THAT YOU WOULD COME WITH ME. FOR A
MOMENT HE TOLD FARRY DID NOT UNDERSTAND; THE CONVERSATION WITH
TRILANDER HAD DRIVEN EVERYTHING ELSE OUT OF HIS HEAD AND HIS
BRAIN SEEMED TO BE MOVING VERY SLOWLY. COME WITH YOU ?
ONLY IF YOU WISH IT, HE CHIRPED. IF I AND THEN FARRY
REMEMBERED WHY HE HAD BEEN EAGER TO COME TO DUMKLEBHERE'S OFFICE IN
THE FIRST PLACE. YOU'RE FEELING HUNGRY? YOU'RE FEELING A THIRST? I
BELIEVE SO. RAGE AND RESENTMENT FELIGHT SEIZED AND EXCITEMENT; FOR
SEVERAL MOMENTS, FARRY WOULD NOT SPEAK. IT IS NATURAL TO BE
AFRAID, SAID DUMKLEBHERE. I'M NOT SCARED; SAID FARRY AT ONCE, AND
IT WAS PERFECTLY TRUE; FEAR WAS ONE FEELING HE WAS NOT FEELING AT
ALL. WHICH THIRST IS IT? WHERE IS IT? I AM NOT SURE WHICH IT
IS THOUGH I THINK WE CAN LIKE THAT THE SNARE BUT I BELIEVE IT
TO BE HIDDEN IN A CAVE IN THE CHEAST MOUNTAINS FROM HERE, A CAVE I
HAVE BEEN TRYING TO LOCATE FOR A VERY LONG TIME; THE CAVE IN WHICH
THE RIDDLE ONCE TERRORIZED TWO CHILDREN FROM HIS HYPHAGOGA IN
THEIR ANNUAL TRIP; YOU REMEMBER? YES, SAID FARRY. THAT IS IT
PROTECTED? I DO NOT KNOW; I HAVE SUSPICIONS THAT MAY BE
ENTIRELY WRONG. DUMKLEBHERE HESITATED, THEN SAID, FARRY, I
PROMISED YOU THAT YOU WOULD COME WITH ME, AND I STAND BY THAT
PROMISE, BUT IT WOULD BE VERY WRONG OF ME NOT TO WARN YOU THAT
THIS WILL BE EXCEEDINGLY DANGEROUS. I'M COMING, SAID FARRY,
ALMOST BEFORE DUMKLEBHERE HAD FINISHED SPEAKING. RISING WITH
ANGER AT SNAPE, HIS DESIRE TO DO SOMETHING DESPERATE AND RISKY
HAD INCREASED TENFOLD IN THE LAST FEW MINUTES. THIS SEEMED TO SHOW
ON FARRY'S FACE, FOR DUMKLEBHERE MOVED AWAY FROM THE WINDOW AND
LOOKED MORE CLOSELY AT FARRY, A SLIGHT CREASE BETWEEN HIS SILVER

EVERYONE. WHAT HAS HAPPENED TO YOU? NOTHING, LIEG HARRY PROMPTLY. WHAT HAS LOST YOU? I'M NOT LOST. HARRY, YOU WERE NEVER A GOOD FIGHTER. THE WORD WAS THE SPARK THAT IGNITED HARRY'S FLAME. SNAPE? HE SAID, VERY QUIETLY, AND FALLOWS GAVE A SHORT SHOUT BEHIND THEM. SNAPE'S WHAT'S HAPPENED? HE TOLD VERMOREL ABOUT THE PROPHECY, IT WAS HIM, HE LISTENED BESIDE THE DEER. TRELAWNEY TOLD ME? DUMBLEDORE'S EXPRESSION DID NOT CHANGE, BUT HARRY THOUGHT HIS FACE WHITENED UNDER THE BLOOD TINGE CAST BY THE SETTING SUN. FOR A LONG MOMENT, DUMBLEDORE SAID NOTHING. WHEN DID YOU FIND OUT ABOUT THIS? HE ASKED AT LAST.

JUST NOW? SAID HARRY, WHO WAS RESTRAINING FROM YELLING WITH ENORMOUS DIFFICULTY. AND THEN, SUDDENLY, HE COULD NOT STOP HIMSELF.

AND YOU LET HIM TRASH HERE AND THE OTHER VERMOREL THE DAY AFTER MY MUM AND DAD? BREATHING HARD AS THOUGH HE WAS FIGHTING, HARRY TURNED AWAY FROM DUMBLEDORE, WHO STILL HAD NOT MOVED A MUSCLE, AND PACED UP AND DOWN THE STAIRS, RUBBING HIS KNUCKLES IN HIS HAND AND EXERCISING EVERY LAST BIT OF RESTRAINT TO PREVENT HIMSELF DOING THINGS EVER. HE WANTED THE RAGE AND STORM AT DUMBLEDORE, BUT HE ALSO WANTED THE GUY WITH HIM TO TRY AND DESTROY THE FATHERLINE. HE WANTED TO TELL HIM THAT HE WAS A FOOLISH OLD MAN FOR TRUSTING SNAPE, BUT HE WAS TERRIFIED THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD NOT TAKE HIM ALONE UNLESS HE MASTERED HIS ANGER. HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY.

PLEASE LISTEN TO ME. IT WAS AS DIFFICULT TO STOP HIS RELENTLESS PACING AS TO RESTRAIN FROM SHOUTING. HARRY PAUSED, BITING HIS LIP, AND LOOKED INTO DUMBLEDORE'S LINED FACE. PROFESSOR SNAPE MADE A TERRIBLE MISTAKE. WHEN I TELL ME IT WAS A MISTAKE, SIR, HE WAS LISTENING AT THE DEER? PLEASE LET ME FINISH. DUMBLEDORE WAITED UNTIL HARRY HAD BREATHED QUIETLY, THEN WENT ON. PROFESSOR SNAPE MADE A TERRIBLE MISTAKE. HE WAS STILL IN LORD VERMOREL'S EMPLOY WHEN THE NIGHT HE HEARD THE FIRST HALF OF PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY'S PROPHECY. NATURALLY, HE HASTENED TO TELL HIS MASTER WHAT HE HAD HEARD, FOR IT CONCERNED HIS MASTER MOST DEEPLY, BUT HE DID NOT KNOW. HE HAD NO POSSIBLE WAY OF KNOWING. WHICH WHY VERMOREL WOULD FLIRT FROM THEN ONWARD, FOR THAT THE PARENTS HE WOULD DESTROY IN HIS MURDEROUS HUNT WERE PEOPLE THAT PROFESSOR SNAPE KNEW, THAT THEY WERE YOUR MOTHER AND FATHER. HARRY LET OUT A YELL OF MIRTHLESS LAUGHTER. HE HATED MY DAD LIKE HE HATED SIRIUS?

HAVEN'T YOU NOTICED, PROFESSOR, HOW THE PEOPLE SNAPE HATES TEND THE END UP DEAD? YOU HAVE NO IDEA OF THE REMORSE PROFESSOR SNAPE FELT WHEN HE REALIZED HOW LORD VOLDEMORT HAD INTERPRETED THE PROPHECY, HARRY, I BELIEVE IT TO BE THE GREATEST REGRET OF HIS LIFE AND THE REASON THAT HE RETURNED. BUT HE'S A VERY GOOD HELLION, ISN'T HE, SIR? SAID HARRY, WHOSE VEHICLE WAS SHAKING WITH THE EFFORT OF KEEPING IT STEADY, AND ISN'T VOLDEMORT CONVINCED THAT SNAPE'S ON HIS SIDE, EVEN NOW? PROFESSOR HOW CAN YOU BE SURE SNAPE'S ON YOUR SIDE? DUMBLEDORE DID NOT SPEAK FOR A MOMENT; HE BREATHED AS THOUGH HE WAS TRYING TO MAKE UP HIS MIND ABOUT SOMETHING, AT LAST HE SAID, I AM SURE, I TRUST SEVERUS SNAPE COMPLETELY. HARRY BREATHED DEEPLY FOR A FEW MOMENTS IN AN EFFORT TO STEADY HIMSELF, IT DID NOT WORK. WELL, I DON'T, HE SAID, AS HEAVILY AS BEFORE. HE'S UP TO SOMETHING WITH DRACO MALFOY RIGHT NOW, RIGHT UNDER YOUR NOSE, AND YOU STILL. WE HAVE DISCUSSED THIS, HARRY, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND NOW HE SOUNDED STERN AGAIN, I HAVE TOLD YOU MY VIEWS. YOU'RE LEAVING THE SCHOOL TONIGHT, AND I'LL BET YOU HAVEN'T EVEN CONSIDERED THAT SNAPE AND MALFOY MIGHT DECIDE THE WHAT? ASKED DUMBLEDORE, HIS EYEBROWS RAISED.

WHAT IS IT THAT YOU SUSPECT THEM OF DOING, PRECISELY? I THEY'RE UP TO SOMETHING? SAID HARRY, AND HIS HANDS CLUTCHED INTO FISTS AS HE SAID IT. PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY WAS ILT IN THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, TRYING TO HIDE HER SKERRY KETTLES, AND SHE HEARD MALFOY WHISPERING, CELEBRATING; HE'S TRYING TO MEND SOMETHING DANGEROUS IN THERE AND IF YOU ASK ME, HE'S FIXED IT AT LAST AND YOU'RE ABOUT THE ILT WALK OUT OF SCHOOL WITH HIM. ENOUGH, SAID DUMBLEDORE, HE SAID IT ENLIGHTENED CALMLY, AND YET HARRY FELL SILENT AT ONCE; HE KNEW THAT HE HAD FINALLY CROSSED SOME INVISIBLE LINE.

DON'T YOU THINK THAT I HAVE SINCE LEFT THE SCHOOL UNPROTECTED DURING MY ABSENCE THIS YEAR? I HAVE NOT. TONIGHT, WHEN I LEAVE, THERE WILL AGAIN BE ADDITIONAL PROTECTION IN PLACE. PLEASE DON'T SUGGEST THAT I DON'T TAKE THE SAFETY OF MY STUDENTS SERIOUSLY, HARRY. I DIDN'T. MIMLED HARRY, A LITTLE ABASHED, BUT DUMBLEDORE CUT ACROSS HIM. I DON'T WISH TO DISCUSS THE MATTER ANY FURTHER. HARRY KIT BACK HIS RETORT, SCARED THAT HE HAD GONE TOO FAR, THAT HE HAD RUINED HIS CHANCE OF ACCOMPANYING DUMBLEDORE, BUT DUMBLEDORE WENT ON, DON'T YOU WISH TO COME WITH ME TONIGHT? YES, SAID HARRY AT ONCE. VERY WELL, THEN! LISTEN,

OLMPEDEHRE DREW HIMSELF UP TO HIS FULL HEIGHT. I TAKE YOU WITH ME
UNDER THESE CONDITIONS: THAT YOU HEED ANY COMMAND I MIGHT GIVE YOU AT
ONCE, AND WITHOUT DELAY. HE CHUCKLED. BE SURE YOU UNDERSTAND
ME, HARRY. I MEAN THAT YOU MUST FOLLOW EVEN SUCH ORDERS AS RUN,
HIDE, OR GET BACK. DO I HAVE YOUR WORD? I YES, HE CHUCKLED. IF
I TELL YOU TO HIDE, YOU WILL DO SO? YES. IF I TELL YOU TO FLEE, YOU
WILL HEED? YES. IF I TELL YOU TO LEAVE ME AND SAVE YOURSELF, YOU
WILL DO AS I TELL YOU? I HARRY? THEY LOOKED AT EACH OTHER
FOR A MOMENT. YES, SIR. VERY GOOD. THEN I WISH YOU TO GO AND
FETCH YOUR INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND MEET ME IN THE ENTRANCE HALL IN
FIVE MINUTES TIME. OLMPEDHRE TURNED BACK THE WHITE HILT OF THE
FIERY WINDMILL; THE SUN WAS NOW A RUBY RED GLOBE ALONG THE
HORIZON. HARRY WALKED QUICKLY FROM THE OFFICE AND DOWN THE
SPIRAL STAIRCASE. HIS MIND WAS HOPEFULLY CLEAR ALL OF A SUDDEN. HE KNEW
WHAT THE DEE, REIN AND FERMINE WERE SITTING TOGETHER IN THE
COMMON ROOM WHEN HE CAME BACK. WHAT DOES HE WANT? FERMININE
SAID AT ONCE. HARRY, ARE YOU READY? SHE ADDED ANXIOUSLY. I'M
FINE. SAID HARRY SHORTLY, RACING PAST THEM. HE DASHED UP THE
STAIRS AND INTO HIS CHAMBERS, WHERE HE FLUNG OPEN HIS TRUNK AND
PULLED OUT THE MARAUDER'S MAP AND A PAIR OF ROLLED-UP SNEAKS.
THEN HE SPED BACK DOWN THE STAIRS AND INTO THE COMMON ROOM,
SKIDDING TO A HALT WHERE REIN AND FERMININE SAT, LOOKING STUNNED.
I'VE GOT THE KEY NOW. HARRY PANTED. OLMPEDHRE THINKS I'M
GETTING MY INVISIBILITY CLOAK. LISTEN. QUICKLY HE TOLD THEM
WHERE HE WAS GOING AND WHY. HE DID NOT PAUSE EITHER FOR
FERMININE'S GASPS OF HORROR OR FOR REIN'S HASTY EXPLETIVES; THEY
COULD WORRY HIM THE FINER DETAILS FOR THEMSELVES LATER. SEE YOU
SEE WHAT THIS MEANS? HARRY FINISHED AT A GALLOP. OLMPEDHRE
WHEN I'LL BE HERE TONIGHT, SEE MALPHE'S GOING TO HAVE ANOTHER CLEAR
SHOT AT WHATEVER HE'S UP TO. NOW, LISTEN TO ME! HE HISSED ANGRILY,
AS BOTH REIN AND FERMININE SHOWED EVERY SIGN OF INTERRUPTING. I
KNOW IT WAS MALPHE CELEBRATING IN THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT.
HERE HE SHOVELED THE MARAUDER'S MAP INTO FERMININE'S HANDS.
YOU'VE GOT TO WATCH HIM AND YOU'VE GOT TO WATCH SNAPE TOO.
USE ANYONE ELSE WHEN YOU CAN RUSTLE UP FROM THE D.A., FERMININE,
THESE CONTACT CALLERS WILL STILL WORK, RIGHT? OLMPEDHRE SAYS
HE'S PUT EXTRA PROTECTION IN THE SCHOOL, BUT IF SNAPE'S INVOLVED,
HE'LL KNOW WHAT OLMPEDHRE'S PROTECTION IS, AND HOW TO AVOID IT

BUT HE WHEN T BE EXPECTING YELL LEFT THE KE HEN THE WATCH, WILL HEY
HARRY REGAN BERMINE, HER EYES FLICK WITH FEAR. I HAVEN T
GHT TIME THE ARGE, SAID HARRY CLITLY. TAKE THIS AS WELL HE
THIRST THE SHEDS INTH REN S HANDS. THANKS, SAID REN. ER
WHY DE I NEED SHEDS? YELL NEED WHAT S WRAPPED IN THEM, IT S THE
FELIX FELIXIS, SHARE IT BETWEEN YELRSSELVES AND GINDY THEE. SAY
GHHO BYE TH HER HER ME, I D BETTER GE, DUMKEDHRE S WAITING

NEH? SAID BERMINE, AS REN UNWRAPPED THE TINY LITTLE KETTLE HP
CHILDEN PETHEN, LEEKING AWESTRICK. WE DEN T WANT IT, YELL TAKE IT,
WHEN KNELS WHAT YELL BE GING THE KE PACING? I LL BE FINE, I LL BE
WITH DUMKEDHRE, SAID HARRY. I WANT THE KNEL YELL LEFT ARE HEDAY.

DEN T LEEK LIKE THAT, BERMINE, I LL SEE YELL LATER. AND HE
WAS HP, FLIRRYING BACK THRUHGH THE PORTRAIT HELL AND THEARD THE
ENTRANCE HALL. DUMKEDHRE WAS WAITING RESIDE THE HADEN FRONT
DHHS, HE TURNED AS HARRY CAME SKIDDING BLT HENTH THE THPMHST
STHNE STEP, PANTING HARD, A SEARING STICH IN HIS SIDE. I WELLD LIKE
YELL THE WEAR YELLR CHAD, PLEASE, SAID DUMKEDHRE, AND HE WAITED
UNTIL HARRY HAD THREHN IT HEN KEHRE SAYING, VERY GHHO, SHALL WE
GE? DUMKEDHRE SET HP AT HENCE DHEN THE STHNE STEPS, HIS HEN
TRAVELING CHAD BARELY STIRRING IN THE STILL SLIMPER AIR. HARRY
FLIRRIED ALHNGSIDE HIM UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CHAD, STILL PANTING
AND SWEATING RATHER A LHT. BUT WHAT WILL PEOPLE THINK WHEN THEY
SEE YELL LEAVING, PROFESSHR? HARRY ASKED, HIS MIND HEN MALPHY AND
SNAP. THAT I AM HP INTH HEGSMEAD HER A DRINK, SAID
DUMKEDHRE LIGHTLY. I SHMETIMES HFFER REHSMERTA MY CLISTH, HER ELSE
VISIT THE HEG S HEAD HER I APPAR TH. IT IS AS GHHO A WAY AS ANY
HP DISGLISING HNE S TRUE DESTINATION. THEY MADE THEIR WAY DHEN
THE DRIVE IN THE GATHERING TWILIGHT. THE AIR WAS FULL HP THE SMELLS
HP WARM GRASS, LAKE WATER, AND WHED SMHKE FROM HAGRID S CABIN. IT
WAS DIFFICULT THE BELIVE THAT THEY WERE HEADING HER ANYTHING
DANGEREHLS HER FRIGHTENING. PROFESSHR, SAID HARRY HLIETLY, AS THE
GATES AT THE KETTHEM HP THE DRIVE CAME INTH VIEW, WILL WE BE
APPARATING? YES, SAID DUMKEDHRE. YELL CAN APPARATE NEH, I
BELIVE? YES, SAID HARRY, BUT I HAVEN T GHT A LICENSE. HE FELT
IT BEST THE BE HNEST; WHAT IF HE SPHELED EVERYTHING BY TURNING LIP
A HUNDRED MILES FROM WHERE HE WAS SLIPPESSED THE GE? NEH MATTER,
SAID DUMKEDHRE, I CAN ASSIST YELL AGAIN. THEY TURNED BLT HP THE
GATES INTH THE TWILT, DESERTED LAKE THE HEGSMEAD, DARKNESS

DESCENDED FAST AS THEY WALKED, AND BY THE TIME THEY REACHED THE HIGH STREET NIGHT WAS FALLING IN EARNEST. LIGHTS TWINKLED FROM WINDOWS EVER STEPS AND AS THEY NEARED THE THREE BROOMSTICKS THEY HEARD RALPH'S SCHELTING. AND STAY HILT! SCHELTED MADAM RESMERTA, FIERCELY ERECTING A GRLEKYLHEEDING WIZARD. EH, HELLE, ALKIS YELJ RE HILT LATE. GOOD EVENING, RESMERTA, GOOD EVENING. PARDON ME, I'M OFF THE HIGH STREET. NO OFFENSE, BUT I FEEL LIKE A HELIUM BALLOON AT NIGHT. A MINUTE LATER THEY TURNED THE CORNER INTO THE SIDE STREET WHERE THE HIGH STREET SIGN CREAKED A LITTLE, THOUGH THERE WAS NO CREEK. IN CONTRAST TO THE THREE BROOMSTICKS, THE PLACE APPEARED TO BE COMPLETELY EMPTY. IT WILL NOT BE NECESSARY FOR US TO ENTER, MUTTERED DUMBLEDORE, GLANCING AROUND. AS LONG AS NEITHER OF US SEE ANY PLACE WHERE HAND UPON MY ARM, HARRY. THERE IS NO NEED TO GRIP THEM HARD, I AM MERELY GLIDING WITH YOU. THEN THE CHILL OF THREE TWO THREE HARRY TURNED. AT ONCE, THERE WAS THAT HORRIBLE SENSATION THAT HE WAS BEING SQUEEZED THROUGH A THICK RUBBER TUBE; HE COULD NOT DRAW BREATH, EVERY PART OF HIM WAS BEING COMPRESSED ALMOST PAST ENDURANCE AND THEN, INSTANTLY HE THOUGHT HE MUST SUFFocate, THE INVISIBLE BANDS SEEMED TO CLASP HIM, AND HE WAS STANDING IN TOTAL DARKNESS, BREATHEING IN BUBBLES OF FRESH, SALTY AIR. THE COLD HARRY COULD SMELL SALT AND HEAR RUSHING WAVES; A LIGHT, CHILLY BREEZE RIPPED HIS HAIR AS HE LOOKED UP AT MOUNTAIN SEA AND STAR-STREWN SKY. HE WAS STANDING UPON A HIGH PLATEAU OF DARK ROCK, WATER THAMING AND CHURNING BELOW HIM. HE GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER, A THUNDERING CLIFF STOOD BEHIND THEM, A SHEER DROP, BLACK AND FACELESS. A FEW LARGE CHUNKS OF ROCK, SUCH AS THE ONE UPON WHICH HARRY AND DUMBLEDORE WERE STANDING, LOOKED AS THOUGH THEY HAD BROKEN AWAY FROM THE CLIFF FACE AT SOME POINT IN THE PAST. IT WAS A BLEAK, HARSH VIEW, THE SEA AND THE ROCK UNRELIEVED BY ANY TREE OR SWEEP OF GRASS OR SAND. WHAT DO YOU THINK? ASKED DUMBLEDORE. HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN ASKING HARRY'S OPINION ON WHETHER IT WAS A GOOD SITE FOR A PICNIC. THEY BRIGHTENED THE KIDS FROM THE HOPPLANDAGE HERE? ASKED HARRY, WHO COULD NOT IMAGINE A LESS CHEERFUL SPOT FOR A DAY TRIP. NOT HERE, PRECISELY, SAID DUMBLEDORE. THERE IS A VILLAGE OF SHIRTS ABOUT HALFWAY ALONG THE CLIFFS BEHIND US. I BELIEVE THE HOPPLANDS WERE TAKEN THERE FOR A LITTLE SEA AIR AND A VIEW OF THE WAVES. NO, I

THINK IT WAS ONLY EVER THEM RIDDLE AND HIS VILITFUL VICTIMS WHO VISITED THIS SPOT. NO MUGGLE COULD REACH THIS ROCK UNLESS THEY WERE UNCONSCIOUSLY CARRIED MOUNTAINERS, AND THATS CANNOT APPROACH THE CLIFFS, THE WATERS AROUND THEM ARE THE DANGEROUS. I IMAGINE THAT RIDDLE CLIMBED DOWN; MAGIC WOULD HAVE SERVED BETTER THAN REEDS, AND HE BROUGHT THE SMALL CHILDREN WITH HIM, PROBABLY FOR THE PLEASURE OF TERRORIZING THEM. I THINK THE JOURNEY ALONE WOULD HAVE DONE IT, DONT YOU? FARRY LOOKED UP AT THE CLIFF AGAIN AND FELT CHISEL KLIPS. BUT HIS FINAL DESTINATION AND HOME

LIES A LITTLE FARTHER IN. HERE, DUMBLEDORE RECOGNIZED FARRY THE THE VERY EDGE OF THE ROCK WHERE A SERIES OF JAGGED NICHES MADE STEPS LEADING DOWN THE RAILERS THAT LAY HALFSUBMERGED IN WATER AND CLIMBED THE CLIFF. IT WAS A TREACHEROUS DESCENT AND DUMBLEDORE, HAMPERED SLIGHTLY BY HIS WITHERED HAND, MOVED SLOWLY. THE LOWER ROCKS WERE SLIPPERY WITH SEAWATER, FARRY COULD FEEL FLICKS OF COLD SALT SPRAY HITTING HIS FACE. LIMPING, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AS HE REACHED THE RAILER CLIMBED THE CLIFF FACE, A THOUSAND FLICKS OF COLDEN LIGHT SPARKLED UPON THE DARK SURFACE OF THE WATER A FEW FEET BELOW WHERE HE CLIMBED; THE BLACK WALL OF ROCK BESIDE HIM WAS ILLUMINATED THEN. WHY SEE? SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, HOLDING HIS WAND A LITTLE HIGHER, FARRY SAW A FISSURE IN THE CLIFF INTO WHICH DARK WATER WAS SWIRLING. WHY WILL NOT EXPECT THE GETTING A LITTLE WET? NO, SAID FARRY. THEN TAKE OFF YOUR INVISIBILITY CLOAK THERE IS NO NEED FOR IT NOW AND LET US TAKE THE FALLING. AND WITH THE SLIDEN AGILITY OF A MUCH YOUNGER MAN, DUMBLEDORE SLID FROM THE RAILER, LANDED IN THE SEA, AND BEGAN THE SWIM, WITH A PERFECT BREASTSTROKE, TOWARD THE DARK SLIT IN THE ROCK FACE, HIS LIT WAND HELD IN HIS TEETH. FARRY PULLED OFF HIS CLOAK, STUFFED IT INTO HIS POCKET, AND SWAMMED. THE WATER WAS ICY; FARRY S WATERLOGGED CLOTHES KILLED HIM AROUND HIM AND WEIGHED HIM DOWN. TAKING DEEP BREATHS THAT FILLED HIS RESTRILLS WITH THE TANG OF SALT AND SEAWeed, HE STRUCK OUT FOR THE SHIMMERING, SHINING LIGHT NOW MOVING DEEPER INTO THE CLIFF. THE FISSURE THEN OPENED INTO A DARK TUNNEL THAT FARRY COULD TELL WOULD BE FILLED WITH WATER AT HIGH TIDE. THE SLIM WALLS WERE RARELY THREE FEET APART AND GLIMMERED LIKE WET TAR IN THE PASSING LIGHT OF DUMBLEDORE S WAND. A LITTLE WAY IN, THE PASSAGEWAY CURVED TO THE LEFT, AND FARRY SAW THAT IT EXTENDED FAR INTO THE CLIFF. HE CONTINUED THE

SWIM IN DIMPLEDHERE'S LAKE, THE TIPS OF HIS REELINKED FINGERS
KNUSTING THE REELICH, WET REICH. THEN HE SAW DIMPLEDHERE RISING HLIT
OF THE WATER AHEAD, HIS SILVER HAIR AND DARK REIKES GLEAMING. WHEN
FARRY REACHED THE SPOT HE FELND STEPS THAT LED INTO A LARGE CAVE.
HE CLAMBERED UP THEM, WATER STREAMING FROM HIS SHAKING CLOTHES,
AND EMERGED, SHIVERING UNCONTROLLABLY, INTO THE STILL AND FREEZING
AIR. DIMPLEDHERE WAS STANDING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE CAVE, HIS HAND
HELD HIGH AS HE TURNED SLEEPLY IN THE SPOT, EXAMINING THE WALLS
AND CEILING. YES, THIS IS THE PLACE, SAID DIMPLEDHERE. WHEN CAN YOU
TELL? FARRY SPOKE IN A WHISPER. IT HAS DRINKEN MAGIC, SAID
DIMPLEDHERE SIMPLY. FARRY COULD NOT TELL WHETHER THE SHIVERS HE
WAS EXPERIENCING WERE DUE TO HIS SPINE-DEEP CHILLNESS OR TO THE
SAME AWARENESS OF ENCHANTMENTS. HE WATCHED AS DIMPLEDHERE
CONTINUED TO REVEAL HIM THE SPOT, EVIDENTLY CONCENTRATING ON
THINGS FARRY COULD NOT SEE. THIS IS MERELY THE ANTECHAMBER, THE
ENTRANCE HALL, SAID DIMPLEDHERE AFTER A MOMENT OF TALK. WE NEED
TO PENETRATE THE INNER PLACE. NOW IT IS LORD VILDEBERT'S
OBSTACLES THAT STAND IN OUR WAY, RATHER THAN THE NATURAL MADE.

DIMPLEDHERE APPROACHED THE WALL OF THE CAVE AND CARESSED IT
WITH HIS BLACKENED FINGERTIPS, MURMURING WORDS IN A STRANGE
TONGUE THAT FARRY DID NOT UNDERSTAND. TWICE DIMPLEDHERE WALKED
RIGHT AROUND THE CAVE, THINKING AS MUCH OF THE REELICH REICH AS HE
COULD, OCCASIONALLY PALISING, RUNNING HIS FINGERS BACKWARD AND
FORWARD OVER A PARTICULAR SPOT, UNTIL FINALLY HE STOPPED, HIS HAND
PRESSED FLAT AGAINST THE WALL. HERE, HE SAID, WE GO IN THROUGH
HERE. THE ENTRANCE IS CONCEALED. FARRY DID NOT ASK HOW
DIMPLEDHERE KNEW. HE HAD NEVER SEEN A WIZARD WHOSE THINGS HLIT LIKE
THIS, SIMPLY BY LISTENING AND THINKING; BUT FARRY HAD LONG SINCE
LEARNED THAT RANGS AND SPOKE WERE MORE OFTEN THE MARKS OF
INAPTITUDE THAN EXPERTISE. DIMPLEDHERE STEPPED BACK FROM THE CAVE
WALL AND POINTED HIS HAND AT THE REICH. FOR A MOMENT, AN ARCHED
HLITLINE APPEARED THERE, GLAZING WHITE AS THOUGH THERE WAS A
POWERFUL LIGHT BEHIND THE CRACK. YOU'VE DONE IT! SAID FARRY
THROUGH CHATTERING TEETH, BUT BEFORE THE WORDS HAD LEFT HIS LIPS
THE HLITLINE HAD GONE, LEAVING THE REICH AS DARK AND SILENT AS EVER.
DIMPLEDHERE SMILED AROUND. FARRY, I'M SEE SHARRY, I PERCEIVE, HE SAID;
HE NOW POINTED HIS HAND AT FARRY AND AT ONCE, FARRY'S CLOTHES
WERE AS WARM AND DRY AS IF THEY HAD BEEN HANGING IN FRONT OF A

BLAZING FIRE. THAND YELI, SAID HARRY GRATEFULLY, BUT DUMKLEDHIRE HAD ALREADY TURNED HIS ATTENTION BACK TO THE SHIELD CASE WALL. HE DID NOT TRY ANY MORE MAGIC, BUT SIMPLY STOOD THERE STARING AT IT INTENTLY, AS THOUGH SOMETHING EXTREMELY INTERESTING WAS WRITTEN ON IT. HARRY STAYED QUIET STILL; HE DID NOT WANT THE BREAD DUMKLEDHIRE'S CONCENTRATION. THEN, AFTER TWO SHIELD MINUTES, DUMKLEDHIRE SAID QUIETLY, EH, SURELY NOT, SHE CRUDE. WHAT IS IT, PROFESSOR? I RATHER THINK, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, PLACING HIS UNINJURED HAND INSIDE HIS REEKS AND DRAWING OUT A SHORT SILVER KNIFE OF THE KIND HARRY USED TO KEEP WITH HIS INGREDIENTS, THAT WE ARE REQUIRED TO MAKE PAYMENT TO PASS. PAYMENT? SAID HARRY. YELI WE GET TO GIVE THE OTHER SOMETHING? YES, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, BLEED, IF I AM NOT MUCH MISTAKEN. BLEED? I SAID IT WAS CRUDE, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, WITH SHOWN DISDAINFUL, EVEN DISAPPOINTED, AS THOUGH VERDAMPT HAD FALLEN SHORT OF THE STANDARDS DUMKLEDHIRE EXPECTED. THE IDEA, AS I AM SURE YELI WILL HAVE GATHERED, IS THAT YOUR ENEMY MUST WEAKEN HIM- HER HERSELF THE ENTER. HENCE AGAIN, LORD VERDAMPT FAILS TO GRASP THAT THERE ARE MUCH MORE TERRIBLE THINGS THAN PHYSICAL INJURY. YES, BUT STILL, IF YELI CAN AVOID IT SAID HARRY, WITH HIS EXPERIENCED ENOUGH PAIN NOT TO BE KEEN FOR MORE. SOMETIMES, HOWEVER, IT IS UNAVOIDABLE, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, SHAKING BACK THE SLEEVE OF HIS REEKS AND EXPOSING THE FOREARM OF HIS INJURED HAND. PROFESSOR? PROTESTED HARRY, FLIRRYING FORWARD AS DUMKLEDHIRE RAISED HIS KNIFE. I'LL DO IT, I'M HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT HE WAS GOING TO SAY YELINGER, BUT DUMKLEDHIRE MERELY SMILED. THERE WAS A FLASH OF SILVER, AND A SPURT OF SCARLET; THE RED FACE WAS PEPPERED WITH DARK, GLISTENING DROPS. YELI ARE VERY KIND, HARRY, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, WITH PASSING THE TIP OF HIS WAND OVER THE DEEP CUT HE HAD MADE IN HIS ELBOW ARM, SEE THAT IT HEALED INSTANTLY, JUST AS SNAPE HAD HEALED MALFOY'S WOUNDS. BUT YOUR BLEED IS WORTH MORE THAN MINE. AH, THAT SEEMS TO HAVE DONE THE TRICK, DOESN'T IT? THE BLAZING SILVER HIGHLIGHT OF AN ARCH HAD APPEARED IN THE WALL BEHIND MORE, AND THIS TIME IT DID NOT FADE AWAY! THE BLEED-SPATTERED RED WITHIN IT SIMPLY VANISHED, LEAVING AN OPENING INTO WHAT SEEMED TOTAL DARKNESS. AFTER ME, I THINK, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE, AND HE WALKED THROUGH THE ARCHWAY WITH HARRY ON HIS HEELS, LIGHTING HIS ELBOW WAND HASTILY AS HE WENT. AN Eerie SIGHT MET THEIR EYES: THEY WERE

STANDING ON THE EDGE OF A GREAT BLACK LAKE, SHE WAST THAT F-HARRY
CHILD NEET MAKE HOLT THE DISTANT BANKS, IN A CAVERN SHE HIGH THAT
THE CEILING THEE WAS HOLT OF SIGHT, A MISTY GREENISH LIGHT SEENE FAR
AWAY IN WHAT LEEKED LIKE THE MIDDLE OF THE LAKE; IT WAS REFLECTED IN
THE COMPLETELY STILL WATER BEEH. THE GREENISH GLEW AND THE LIGHT
FROM THE TWO WANDS WERE THE ONLY THINGS THAT BROKE THE
OTHERWISE VELVETY BLACKNESS, THOUGH THEIR RAYS DID NEET PENETRATE
AS FAR AS F-HARRY WOULD HAVE EXPECTED. THE DARKNESS WAS SOME-THIN
DENSER THAN NORMAL DARKNESS. LET US WALK, SAID DUMBLEDORE
HEARTLY. BE VERY CAREFUL NEET THE STEP INTO THE WATER. STAY CLOSE TO
ME. HE SET OFF AROUND THE EDGE OF THE LAKE, AND F-HARRY FOLLOWED
CLOSE BEHIND HIM. THEIR FOOTSTEPS MADE ECHING, SLAPPING SOUNDS
ON THE NARROW RIM OF ROCK THAT SURROUNDED THE WATER. ON AND ON
THEY WALKED, BUT THE VIEW DID NEET VARY: ON ONE SIDE OF THEM, THE
ROUGH CAVERN WALL, ON THE OTHER, THE ENDLESS EXPANSE OF
SMOOTH, GLASSY BLACKNESS, IN THE VERY MIDDLE OF WHICH WAS THAT
MYSTERIOUS GREENISH GLEW. F-HARRY FELT THE PLACE AND THE SILENCE
OPPRESSIVE, LINGERING. PROFESSOR? HE SAID FINALLY. DO YOU
THINK THE THERON IS HERE? HE YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE. YES, I M
SURE IT IS. THE HELESTIN IS, HOW DO WE GET TO IT? WE CHILDEN T
WE CHILDEN T IUST TRY A SLIPPERING CHARM? F-HARRY SAID, SURE THAT
IT WAS A STUPID SUGGESTION, BUT HE WAS MUCH DEENER THAN HE WAS
PREPARED TO ADMIT ON GETTING HOLT OF THIS PLACE AS SEEN AS
POSSIBLE. CERTAINLY WE CHILD, SAID DUMBLEDORE, STOPPING SHE
SLIDENLY THAT F-HARRY ALMOST WALKED INTO HIM. WHY DEN T YOU DO
IT? MAY HE HEAY F-HARRY HAD NEET EXPECTED THIS, BUT
CLEARED HIS THROAT AND SAID LEHLY, WAND ALERT, ACCIE THERON!
WITH A NOISE LIKE AN EXPLOSION, SOMETHING VERY LARGE AND PALE
ERUPTED HOLT OF THE DARK WATER SOME TWENTY FEET AWAY; BEFORE
F-HARRY CHILD SEE WHAT IT WAS, IT HAD VANISHED AGAIN WITH A
CRASHING SPLASH THAT MADE GREAT, DEEP RIPPLES ON THE MIRRORRED
SURFACE. F-HARRY LEAPT BACKWARD IN SHOCK AND HIT THE WALL; HIS
HEART WAS STILL THUNDERING AS HE TURNED TO DUMBLEDORE. WHAT WAS
THAT? SOMETHING, I THINK, THAT IS READY TO RESPOND SHOULD WE
ATTEMPT TO SEIZE THE THERON. F-HARRY LEEKED BACK AT THE WATER.
THE SURFACE OF THE LAKE WAS NOW MORE SHINING BLACK GLASS: THE
RIPPLES HAD VANISHED UNNATURALY FAST; F-HARRY S HEART, HOWEVER,
WAS STILL POUNDING. DID YOU THINK THAT WOULD HAPPEN, SIR? I

THEY MIGHT SOMETHING WOULD HAPPEN IF WE MADE AN UNWISDOMLY ATTEMPT
TO GET OUR HANDS IN THE THERMOS, THAT WAS A VERY GOOD IDEA,
FARRY, MUCH THE SIMPLEST WAY OF FINDING OUT WHAT WE ARE FACING.

BUT WE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT THE THING WAS, SAID FARRY, LOOKING AT
THE SINISTERLY SMELTING WATER. WHAT THE THINGS ARE, YOU MEAN,
SAID DUMKEDDRE. I DON'T KNOW MUCH THAT THERE IS ONLY ONE OF
THEM. SHALL WE WALK NOW? PROFESSOR? YES, FARRY? OH YOU
THINK WE'RE GOING TO HAVE THE CHICKEN THE LADY? IN THE IT? ONLY IF
WE ARE VERY LUCKY. YOU DIDN'T THINK THE THERMOS IS AT
THE BOTTOM? OH NO. I THINK THE THERMOS IS IN THE MIDDLE.
AND DUMKEDDRE POINTED TOWARD THE MISTY GREEN LIGHT IN THE
CENTER OF THE LAKE. SEE WE'RE GOING TO HAVE THE CROSS THE LAKE THE
GET THE IT? YES, I THINK SO. FARRY DID NOT SAY ANYTHING. HIS
THOUGHTS WERE ALL OF WATER MONSTERS, OF GIANT SERPENTS, OF DEMONS,
DEMONS, AND SPIRITS. AHA, SAID DUMKEDDRE, AND HE STEPPED
AGAIN; THIS TIME, FARRY REALLY DID WALK INTO HIM, FOR A MOMENT HE
TIPPLED ON THE EDGE OF THE DARK WATER, AND DUMKEDDRE'S UNUSUAL
HAND CLOSED TIGHTLY AROUND HIS UPPER ARM, PULLING HIM BACK. SEE
FARRY, FARRY, I SHOULD HAVE GIVEN WARNING. STAND BACK AGAINST
THE WALL, PLEASE; I THINK I HAVE FOUND THE PLACE. FARRY HAD NO
IDEA WHAT DUMKEDDRE MEANT; THIS PATCH OF DARK SAND WAS EXACTLY
LIKE EVERY OTHER BIT AS FAR AS HE COULD TELL, BUT DUMKEDDRE SEEMED
TO HAVE DETECTED SOMETHING SPECIAL ABOUT IT. THIS TIME HE WAS
RUNNING HIS HAND, NOT OVER THE ROCKY WALL, BUT THROUGH THE THIN
AIR, AS THOUGH EXPECTING TO FIND AND GRIP SOMETHING INVISIBLE.

HEH, SAID DUMKEDDRE HAPPILY, SECONDS LATER. HIS HAND HAD CLOSED
IN MIDAIR UPON SOMETHING FARRY COULD NOT SEE. DUMKEDDRE MOVED
CLOSER TO THE WATER; FARRY WATCHED NERVOUSLY AS THE TIPS OF
DUMKEDDRE'S ELONGATED FINGERS REACHED THE LIMESTONE EDGE OF THE ROCK RIM.
KEEPING HIS HAND CLENCHED IN MIDAIR, DUMKEDDRE RAISED HIS HAND
WITH THE OTHER AND TAPPED HIS FIST WITH THE POINT. IMMEDIATELY A
THICK CHOPPERY GREEN CHAIN APPEARED OUT OF THIN AIR, EXTENDING
FROM THE DEPTHS OF THE WATER INTO DUMKEDDRE'S CLENCHED HAND.
DUMKEDDRE TAPPED THE CHAIN, WHICH BEGAN TO SLIDE THROUGH HIS FIST
LIKE A SNAKE, COILING ITSELF ON THE GROUND WITH A CLINKING SOUND
THAT REBOUNDED NOISILY OFF THE ROCKY WALLS, PULLING SOMETHING FROM
THE DEPTHS OF THE BLACK WATER. FARRY GASPED AS THE GHOSTLY PREY
OF A TINY BUBBLE RODE THE SURFACE, GLOWING AS GREEN AS THE CHAIN,

AND FLUTTERED, WITH A RARELY A RIPPLE, TOWARD THE PLACE AND THE BANK WHERE HARRY AND DUMBLEDORE STOOD. "HOW DID YOU KNOW THAT WAS THERE?" HARRY ASKED IN ASTONISHMENT. "MAGIC ALWAYS LEAVES TRACES," SAID DUMBLEDORE, AS THE KEAT HIT THE BANK WITH A GENTLE KLIMP, SOMETIMES VERY DISTINCTIVE TRACES, I TALKED THEM RIDDLER, I KNOW HIS STYLE. IS IS THIS KEAT SAFE? "YES, I THINK SHE, VERDMEERT NEEDED TO CREATE A MEANS TO CROSS THE LAKE WITHOUT ATTRACTING THE WRATH OF THESE CREATURES HE HAD PLACED WITHIN IT IN CASE HE EVER WANTED TO VISIT OR REMOVE HIS "HERCULES. SEE THE THINGS IN THE WATER WHEN TO DO ANYTHING THE LIS IF WE CROSS IN VERDMEERT'S KEAT? I THINK WE MUST RESIGN OURSELVES TO THE FACT THAT THEY WILL, AT SOME POINT, REALIZE WE ARE NOT LORD VERDMEERT. THIS FAR, HOWEVER, WE HAVE DONE WELL. THEY HAVE ALLOWED US TO RAISE THE KEAT. BUT WHY HAVE THEY LET US? ASKED HARRY, WHO COULD NOT SEE THE VISION OF TENTACLES RISING OUT OF THE DARK WATER THE MOMENT THEY WERE OUT OF SIGHT OF THE BANK. VERDMEERT WOULD HAVE BEEN REASONABLY CONFIDENT THAT NONE BUT A VERY GREAT WIZARD WOULD HAVE BEEN ABLE TO FIND THE KEAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE. I THINK HE WOULD HAVE BEEN PREPARED TO RISK WHAT WAS, TO HIS MIND, THE MOST UNLIKELY POSSIBILITY THAT SOMEONE ELSE WOULD FIND IT, KNOWING THAT HE HAD SET OTHER OBSTACLES AHEAD THAT ONLY HE WOULD BE ABLE TO PENETRATE. WE SHALL SEE WHETHER HE IS RIGHT. HARRY DIPPED DOWN INTO THE KEAT. IT REALLY WAS VERY SMALL. IT DOESN'T LOOK LIKE IT WAS BUILT FOR TWO PEOPLE. WILL IT HOLD BOTH OF US? WILL WE BE TOO HEAVY TOGETHER? DUMBLEDORE CHUCKLED. VERDMEERT WILL NOT HAVE CARED ABOUT THE WEIGHT, BUT ABOUT THE AMOUNT OF MAGICAL POWER THAT CROSSED HIS LAKE. I RATHER THINK AN ENCHANTMENT WILL HAVE BEEN PLACED UPON THIS KEAT SO THAT ONLY ONE WIZARD AT A TIME WILL BE ABLE TO SAIL IN IT. BUT THEN ? I DO NOT THINK YOU WILL HEED, HARRY! YOU ARE UNDERAGE AND UNQUALIFIED. VERDMEERT WOULD NEVER HAVE EXPECTED A SIXTEEN-YEAR-OLD TO REACH THIS PLACE! I THINK IT UNLIKELY THAT YOUR FEELERS WILL REGISTER COMPARED TO MINE. THESE WORDS DID NOTHING TO RAISE HARRY'S SPIRITS; PERHAPS DUMBLEDORE KNEW IT, FOR HE ADDED, VERDMEERT'S MISTAKE, HARRY, VERDMEERT'S MISTAKE AGE IS FOOLISH AND FORGETFUL WHEN IT UNDERESTIMATES YOUTH. NOW, YOU FIRST THIS TIME, AND BE CAREFUL NOT TO THICKEN THE WATER. DUMBLEDORE STOOD ASIDE AND HARRY CLIMBED CAREFULLY INTO THE KEAT. DUMBLEDORE STEPPED IN TOO, CHILING THE

CHAIN WITH THE OTHER. THEY WERE CRAMPED IN TOGETHER; HARRY COULD NOT COMFORTABLY SIT, BUT CROUCHED, HIS KNEES LIFTING OVER THE EDGE OF THE KEEL, WHICH BEGAN TO MOVE AT ONCE. THERE WAS NO SOUND EITHER THAN THE SILKEN RUSTLE OF THE KEEL'S PIVOT LEAVING THE WATER; IT MOVED WITHOUT THEIR HELP, AS THOUGH AN INVISIBLE REEF WAS PULLING IT FORWARD TOWARD THE LIGHT IN THE CENTER. WHEN THEY COULD NO LONGER SEE THE WALLS OF THE CAVERN, THEY MIGHT HAVE BEEN AT SEA EXCEPT THAT THERE WERE NO WAVES. HARRY LOOKED DOWN AND SAW THE REFLECTED GLOW OF HIS HANDLIGHT SPARKLING AND GLITTERING IN THE BLACK WATER AS THEY PASSED. THE KEEL WAS CARVING DEEP RIPPLES UPON THE GLASSY SURFACE, GROOVES IN THE DARK MIRROR. AND THEN HARRY SAW IT, MARBLE WHITE, BUBBLING INCHES BELOW THE SURFACE. PROFESSOR? HE SAID, AND HIS STARTLED VOICE RICHED LOUDLY OVER THE SILENT WATER. HARRY? I THINK I SAW A HAND IN THE WATER. A HUMAN HAND? YES, I AM SURE YOU DID, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY. HARRY STARED DOWN INTO THE WATER, LOOKING FOR THE VANISHED HAND, AND A SICK FEELING ROSE IN HIS THROAT. SEE THAT THING THAT LIMPED OUT OF THE WATER? BUT HARRY HAD HIS ANSWER BEFORE DUMBLEDORE COULD REPLY; THE HANDLIGHT HAD SLID OVER A FRESH PATCH OF WATER AND SHOWED HIM, THIS TIME, A DEAD MAN LYING FACEUP INCHES BENEATH THE SURFACE, HIS OPEN EYES MISTED AS THOUGH WITH CRYSTALS, HIS HAIR AND HIS BEES SWIRLING AROUND HIM LIKE SMOKE. THERE ARE KIDNAPERS IN HERE? SAID HARRY, AND HIS VOICE SOUNDED MUCH HIGHER THAN USUAL AND MOST UNLIKE HIS OWN. YES, SAID DUMBLEDORE PLACIDLY, BUT WE DO NOT NEED THE WIZARDRY ABOUT THEM AT THE MOMENT. AT THE MOMENT? HARRY REPEATED, TEARING HIS GAZE FROM THE WATER THE LOOK AT DUMBLEDORE. NOT WHILE THEY ARE MERELY DRIFTING PEACEFULLY BELOW US, SAID DUMBLEDORE. THERE IS NOTHING THEY FEARED FROM A KIDNAPER, HARRY, AND MORE THAN THERE IS ANYTHING THEY FEARED FROM THE DARKNESS. LORD VOLDEMORT, WHOSE CHOICE SECRETLY FEARS BOTH, DISAGREES, BUT ONCE AGAIN HE REVEALS HIS OWN LACK OF WISDOM. IT IS THE UNKNOWN WE FEAR WHEN WE LOOK UPON DEATH AND DARKNESS, NOTHING MORE. HARRY SAID NOTHING; HE DID NOT WANT THE ANSWER, BUT HE FELT THE IDEA THAT THERE WERE KIDNAPERS BUBBLING AROUND THEM AND BENEATH THEM TERRIBLE AND, WHAT WAS MORE, HE DID NOT BELIEVE THAT THEY WERE NOT DANGEROUS. BUT WHEN HE THEM LIMPED, HE SAID, TRYING TO MAKE HIS VOICE AS LEVEL AND CALM AS DUMBLEDORE'S. WHEN I TRIED TO SLIP THEM THE FORTCLOCK, A KIDNAPER LEAPT

ELIT OF THE LAKE. YES, SAID OLMKEDDRE. I AM SURE THAT SINCE WE TAKE THE FHERCLIX, WE SHALL FIND THEM LESS PLEASABLE. FHEWVER, LIKE MANY CREATURES THAT DWELL IN CHLD AND DARKNESS, THEY FEAR LIGHT AND WARMTH, WHICH WE SHALL THEREFORE CALL TO THEIR AID SHOULD THE NEED ARISE, FIRE, FARRY, OLMKEDDRE ADDED WITH A SMILE, IN RESPONSE THE FARRY S REBILDERED EXPRESSION. EH RIGHT SAID FARRY. ELIQUALLY, HE TURNED HIS HEAD THE WARD AT THE GREENISH GLOW TOWARD WHICH THE KEAT WAS STILL INEXORABLY SAILING. HE COULD NOT PRETEND NOW THAT HE WAS NOT SCARED. THE GREAT BLACK LAKE, TEEMING WITH THE DEAD IT SEEMED FHEARS AND FHEARS AGO THAT HE HAD MET PROFESSOR TRELAWNEY, THAT HE HAD GIVEN RHN AND FERMINE FELIX FELIX. HE SUDDENLY WISHED HE HAD SAID A BETTER GOOD-BYE TO THEM

AND HE HADN'T SEEN GINNY AT ALL. NEARLY THERE, SAID OLMKEDDRE CHEERFULLY. SURE ENOUGH, THE GREENISH LIGHT SEEMED TO BE GROWING LARGER AT LAST, AND WITHIN MINUTES, THE KEAT HAD COME TO A HALT, CLIMPING GENTLY INTO SOMETHING THAT FARRY COULD NOT SEE AT FIRST, BUT WHEN HE RAISED HIS ILLUMINATED WAND HE SAW THAT THEY HAD REACHED A SMALL ISLAND OF SMOOTH ROCK IN THE CENTER OF THE LAKE. CAREFUL NOT TO TOUCH THE WATER, SAID OLMKEDDRE AGAIN AS FARRY CLIMBED UP THE KEAT. THE ISLAND WAS NOT LARGER THAN OLMKEDDRE'S OFFICE, AN EXPANSE OF FLAT DARK STONE ON WHICH STOOD NOTHING BUT THE SOURCE OF THAT GREENISH LIGHT, WHICH BEHEDED MUCH BRIGHTER WHEN VIEWED CLOSE BY. FARRY SHOOK AT IT; AT FIRST, HE THOUGHT IT WAS A LAMP OF SOME KIND, BUT THEN HE SAW THAT THE LIGHT WAS COMING FROM A STONE BASIN RATHER LIKE THE PENSIVE, WHICH WAS SET ON TOP OF A PEDESTAL. OLMKEDDRE APPROACHED THE BASIN AND FARRY FOLLOVED. SIDE BY SIDE, THEY BEHEDED DOWN INTO IT. THE BASIN WAS FULL OF AN EMERALD LIQUID EMITTING THAT PHESPHORESCENT GLOW. WHAT IS IT? ASKED FARRY QUIETLY. I AM NOT SURE, SAID OLMKEDDRE. SOMETHING MORE WEIRDISH THAN BLOOD AND BODIES, FHEWVER. OLMKEDDRE PULSED BACK THE SLEEVE OF HIS ROBE OVER HIS BLACKENED HAND, AND STRETCHED OUT THE TIPS OF HIS BURNED FINGERS TOWARD THE SURFACE OF THE POTION. SIR, NO, DON'T TOUCH. I CANNOT TOUCH, SAID OLMKEDDRE, SMILING FAINTLY.

SEE? I CANNOT APPROACH ANY NEARER THAN THIS, YOU TRY. STARING, FARRY PUT HIS HAND INTO THE BASIN AND ATTEMPTED TO TOUCH THE POTION. HE MET AN INVISIBLE BARRIER THAT PREVENTED HIM COMING WITHIN AN INCH OF IT. NO MATTER HOW HARD HE PULSED, HIS

FINGERS ENCOUNTERED NOTHING BUT WHAT SEEMED THE ICE SHEET AND INFLEXIBLE AIR. FELT HE THE WAY, PLEASE, FARRY, SAID OLMEDORE. HE RAISED HIS HAND AND MADE COMPLICATED MOVEMENTS OVER THE SURFACE OF THE POTION, MURMURING SILENTLY. NOTHING HAPPENED, EXCEPT PERHAPS THAT THE POTION GLEWED A LITTLE BRIGHTER. FARRY REMAINED SILENT WHILE OLMEDORE WORKED, BUT AFTER A WHILE OLMEDORE WITHDREW HIS HAND, AND FARRY FELT IT WAS SAFE TO TALK AGAIN. YOU THINK THE THING IS IN THERE, SIR? HE YES, OLMEDORE PEERED MORE CLOSELY INTO THE BASIN. FARRY SAW HIS FACE REFLECTED, UPSIDE DOWN, IN THE SPARKLING SURFACE OF THE GREEN POTION. BUT HOW TO REACH IT? THIS POTION CANNOT BE PENETRATED BY HAND, VANISHED, PARTED, SCHEPDED UP, HE SIGHED AWAY, NEARLY IT BE TRANSFIGURED, CHANGED, HE OTHERWISE MADE THE CHANGE ITS NATURE. ALMOST ASSENTMENTEDLY, OLMEDORE RAISED HIS HAND AGAIN, TWIRLED IT BACK IN MIDAIR, AND THEN CALLED THE CRYSTAL GEMLET THAT HE HAD CHAINED FELT HE NEARBY. I CAN ONLY CONCLUDE THAT THIS POTION IS SLOTTED THE ICE DRINK. WHAT? SAID FARRY. YES, I THINK SEE! ONLY BY DRINKING IT CAN I EMPTY THE BASIN AND SEE WHAT LIES IN ITS DEPTHS. BUT WHAT IF WHAT IF IT KILLS YOU? HE, I BELIEVE THAT IT WOULD WORK LIKE THAT, SAID OLMEDORE EASILY. LORD VERMONT WOULD NOT WANT THE DRINK THE PERSON WHO REACHED THIS ISLAND. FARRY COULD NOT BELIEVE IT. WAS THIS MORE OF OLMEDORE'S INSANE DETERMINATION TO SEE GHEED IN EVERYTHING? SIR, SAID FARRY, TRYING TO KEEP HIS VOICE REASONABLE. SIR, THIS IS LORD VERMONT WE'RE I'M SURE, FARRY; I SHOULD HAVE SAID, HE WOULD NOT WANT TO IMMEDIATELY KILL THE PERSON WHO REACHED THIS ISLAND. OLMEDORE CORRECTED HIMSELF. HE WOULD WANT TO KEEP THEM ALIVE LONG ENOUGH TO FIND OUT HOW THEY MANAGED TO PENETRATE SO FAR THROUGH HIS DEFENSES AND, MOST IMPORTANTLY OF ALL, WHY THEY WERE SO INTENT UPON EMPTYING THE BASIN. DO NOT FORGET THAT LORD VERMONT BELIEVES THAT HE ALONE KNOWS ABOUT HIS THINGS. FARRY MADE THE SPREAD AGAIN, BUT THIS TIME OLMEDORE RAISED HIS HAND AND SILENCE, FOCUSING SLIGHTLY AT THE EMERALD LIQUID, EVIDENTLY THINKING HARD. UNEXPECTEDLY, HE SAID, FINALLY, THIS POTION MUST ACT IN A WAY THAT WILL PREVENT ME TAKING THE THING. IT MIGHT PARALYZE ME, CAUSE ME TO FORGET WHAT I AM HERE FOR, CREATE SO MUCH PAIN I AM DISTRACTED, OR RENDER ME INCAPABLE IN SOME OTHER WAY. THIS BEING THE CASE, FARRY, IT WILL BE YOUR JOB TO MAKE SURE I KEEP

DRINKING, EVEN IF YOU HAVE THE TIP THE POTION IN THE MY PROTESTING MOUTH. YOU UNDERSTAND? THEIR EYES MET OVER THE BASIN, EACH PALE FACE LIT WITH THAT STRANGE, GREEN LIGHT. HARRY DID NOT SPEAK. WAS THIS WHY HE HAD BEEN INVITED ALONE? SHE THAT HE COULD FORCE-FEED OLMEDORE A POTION THAT MIGHT CAUSE HIM UNENDURABLE PAIN?

YOU REMEMBER, SAID OLMEDORE, THE CONDITIONS IN WHICH I REQUESTED YOU WITH ME? HARRY HESITATED, LOOKING INTO THE BLUE EYES THAT HAD TURNED GREEN IN THE REFLECTED LIGHT OF THE BASIN. BUT WHAT IF? YOU SAW, DID YOU NOT, THE PILLER AND COMMAND I GAVE YOU? YES, BUT I WARNED YOU, DID I NOT, THAT THERE MIGHT BE DANGER? YES, SAID HARRY, BUT WELL, THEN, SAID OLMEDORE, SHADING BACK HIS SLEEVES ONCE MORE AND RAISING THE EMPTY CUP, YOU HAVE MY ORDERS. WHY CAN I DRINK THE POTION INSTEAD? ASKED HARRY DESPERATELY. BECAUSE I AM MUCH OLDER, MUCH CLEVERER, AND MUCH LESS VULNERABLE, SAID OLMEDORE.

ONCE AND FOR ALL, HARRY, DO I HAVE YOUR WORD THAT YOU WILL DO ALL IN YOUR POWER TO MAKE ME KEEP DRINKING? CHILDEN T? DO I HAVE IT? BUT YOUR WORD, HARRY, I AM RIGHT, BUT BEFORE HARRY COULD MAKE ANY FURTHER PROTEST, OLMEDORE HELD THE CRYSTAL CUP TO THE POTION, FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HARRY HOPED THAT HE WOULD NOT BE ABLE TO TOUCH THE POTION WITH THE CUP, BUT THE CRYSTAL SANK INTO THE SURFACE AS NOTHING ELSE HAD; WHEN THE GLASS WAS FULL TO THE BRIM, OLMEDORE LIFTED IT TO HIS MOUTH. YOUR GOOD HEALTH, HARRY, AND HE DRAINED THE CUP. HARRY WATCHED, TERRIFIED, HIS HANDS GRIPPING THE RIM OF THE BASIN SEE HARD THAT HIS FINGERTIPS WERE NUMB. PROFESSOR? HE SAID ANXIOUSLY, AS OLMEDORE HELD THE EMPTY GLASS. HOW DO YOU FEEL? OLMEDORE SHOOK HIS HEAD, HIS EYES CLOSED. HARRY WONDERED WHETHER HE WAS IN PAIN. OLMEDORE PLUNGED THE GLASS BLINDLY BACK INTO THE BASIN, REFILLED IT, AND DROVE ONCE MORE. IN SILENCE, OLMEDORE DROVE THREE CUPSFUL OF THE POTION. THEN, HALFWAY THROUGH THE FOURTH CUP, HE STAGGERED AND FELL FORWARD AGAINST THE BASIN. HIS EYES WERE STILL CLOSED, HIS BREATHING HEAVY.

PROFESSOR OLMEDORE? SAID HARRY, HIS VOICE STRAINED. CAN YOU HEAR ME? OLMEDORE DID NOT ANSWER. HIS FACE WAS TWITCHING AS THOUGH HE WAS DEEPLY ASLEEP, BUT DREAMING A TERRIBLE DREAM. HIS GRIP ON THE CUP WAS SLACKENING; THE POTION WAS ABOUT TO SPILL FROM IT. HARRY REACHED FORWARD AND GRASPED THE CRYSTAL CLIP,

HOLDING IT STEADY, PROFESSOR, CAN YOU HEAR ME? HE REPEATED
LUDICRously, HIS VOICE ECHOING AROUND THE CAVERNS, OLMEDORE PANTED
AND THEN SPROKE IN A VOICE FARRY DID NOT RECOGNIZE, FOR HE HAD
NEVER HEARD OLMEDORE FRIGHTENED LIKE THIS. I DON'T WANT
DON'T MAKE ME FARRY STARED INTO THE WHITENED FACE HE KNEW SHE
WELL, AT THE CRINKLED NECK AND HALF-MOON SPECTACLES, AND DID NOT
KNOW WHAT TO DO. DON'T LIKE WANT THE STOP MEANED
OLMEDORE, YOU YOU CAN'T STOP, PROFESSOR, SAID FARRY.

YOU'VE GOT THE DEEP DRINKING, REMEMBER? YOU TOLD ME YOU HAD THE
DEEP DRINKING, HERE FATTING HIMSELF, REPLIED BY WHAT HE WAS
DOING, FARRY FORCED THE CHEEK BACK TOWARD OLMEDORE'S MOUTH
AND TIPPED IT, SHE THAT OLMEDORE DRANK THE REMAINDER OF THE
PORTWINE INSIDE. NO HE GRINNED, AS FARRY LOWERED THE CHEEK
BACK INTO THE BASIN AND REFILLED IT FOR HIM. I DON'T WANT THE. I
DON'T WANT THE. LET ME GO. IT'S ALL RIGHT, PROFESSOR, SAID
FARRY, HIS HAND SHAKING. IT'S ALL RIGHT, I'M HERE MAKE IT
STOP, MAKE IT STOP, MEANED OLMEDORE. YES YES, THIS WILL MAKE IT
STOP, LIES FARRY, HE TIPPED THE CONTENTS OF THE CHEEK INTO
OLMEDORE'S OPEN MOUTH, OLMEDORE SCREAMED; THE NOISE ECHOED
ALL AROUND THE VAST CHAMBER, ACROSS THE DEAD BLACK WATER. NO, NO,
NO, NO, I CAN'T, I CAN'T, DON'T MAKE ME, I DON'T WANT THE. IT'S ALL
RIGHT, PROFESSOR, IT'S ALL RIGHT? SAID FARRY LUDICRously, HIS HANDS
SHAKING SO BADLY HE COULD HARDLY SCHEP UP THE SIXTH CHEEKFUL OF
PORTWINE; THE BASIN WAS NOW HALF EMPTY. NOTHING IS HAPPENING THE
YOU, YOU'RE SAFE, IT ISN'T REAL, I SWEAR IT ISN'T REAL TAKE THIS,
NOW, TAKE THIS.

AND HEREDIENTLY, OLMEDORE DRANK, AS THOUGH IT
WAS AN ANTIDOTE FARRY OFFERED HIM, BUT LIPEN DRAINING THE CHEEK,
HE SAND THE HIS KNEES, SHAKING UNCONTROLLABLY. IT'S ALL MY FAULT,
ALL MY FAULT, HE SEEDED. PLEASE MAKE IT STOP, I KNOW I DID WRONG,
BUT PLEASE MAKE IT STOP AND I'LL NEVER, NEVER AGAIN THIS WILL
MAKE IT STOP, PROFESSOR, FARRY SAID, HIS VOICE CRACKING AS HE
TIPPED THE SEVENTH GLASS OF PORTWINE INTO OLMEDORE'S MOUTH.
OLMEDORE BEGAN TO CHOKER AS THOUGH INVISIBLE THROTLERS
SURROUNDED HIM; HIS FLAILING HAND ALMOST KNOCKED THE REFILLED
CHEEK FROM FARRY'S TREMBLING HANDS AS HE MEANED, DON'T FLIRT
THEM, DON'T FLIRT THEM, PLEASE, PLEASE, IT'S MY FAULT, FLIRT ME INSTEAD

HERE, DRINK THIS, DRINK THIS, YOU'LL BE ALL RIGHT, SAID FARRY
DESPERATELY, AND ONCE AGAIN OLMEDORE HURVED HIM, OPENING HIS

MOUTH EVEN AS HE KEPT HIS EYES TIGHT SHUT AND SHOOK FROM HEAD
TO FOOT, AND WHEN HE FELL FORWARD, SCREAMING AGAIN, HAMPERING HIS
FISTS UPON THE GROUND, WHILE FARRY FILLED THE NINTH CUPLET.

PLEASE, PLEASE, PLEASE, NEH NEET THAT, NEET THAT, I LL DIE ANYTHING
ILST DRINK, PROFESSOR, ILST DRINK OLIMEDHRE DRANK LIKE A
CHILD DYING OF THIRST, BUT WHEN HE HAD FINISHED, HE YELLED AGAIN AS
THOUGH HIS INSIDES WERE ON FIRE. NEH MORE, PLEASE, NEH MORE
FARRY SCHEEPED UP A TENTH CUPLET ALL OF PENTHEN AND FELT THE CRYSTAL
SCRAPE THE BOTTOM OF THE BASIN. WE ARE NEARLY THERE, PROFESSOR,
DRINK THIS, DRINK IT. HE SLIPPED OLIMEDHRE'S SHOULDERS AND
AGAIN, OLIMEDHRE DRAINED THE GLASS; THEN FARRY WAS ON HIS FEET
HENCE MORE, REFILLING THE CUPLET AS OLIMEDHRE BEGAN THE SCREAM IN
MORE ENGLISH THAN EVER. I WANT THE DIE! I WANT THE DIE! MAKE IT
STOP, MAKE IT STOP, I WANT THE DIE! DRINK THIS, PROFESSOR, DRINK
THIS. OLIMEDHRE DRANK, AND NEH SHEENER HAD HE FINISHED THAN HE
YELLED, KILL ME! THIS THIS ONE WILL! GASPED FARRY. ILST
DRINK THIS IT LL BE EVER ALL EVER! OLIMEDHRE CLIMBED AT THE
CUPLET, DRAINED EVERY LAST DROP, AND THEN, WITH A GREAT, RATTLING
GASP, REELLED OVER ONTO HIS FACE. NEH! SHOUTED FARRY, WHO HAD
STOOD TO REFILL THE CUPLET AGAIN; INSTEAD HE DROPPED THE CUP INTO
THE BASIN, FELLING HIMSELF DOWN BESIDE OLIMEDHRE, AND HEAVED HIM
OVER ONTO HIS BACK; OLIMEDHRE'S GLASSES WERE ASKED, HIS MOUTH
AGAPE, HIS EYES CLOSED. NEH, SAID FARRY, SHAKING OLIMEDHRE, NEH,
WELL BE NOT DEAD, WELL SAID IT WASN'T POISON, WAKE UP, WAKE UP
RENNERYATE! HE CRIED, HIS HAND POINTING AT OLIMEDHRE'S CHEST;
THERE WAS A FLASH OF RED LIGHT BUT NOTHING HAPPENED. RENNERVATE

SIR PLEASE OLIMEDHRE'S EYELIDS FLICKERED; FARRY'S HEART
LEAPT. SIR, ARE YOU? WATER, CREAMED OLIMEDHRE. WATER,
PANTED FARRY. YES HE LEAPT TO HIS FEET AND SEIZED THE CUPLET
HE HAD DROPPED IN THE BASIN; HE BARELY REGISTERED THE CHILDBEN WHISPER
LYING CRAWLED BENEATH IT. AGGIAMENTI! HE SHOUTED, LAKING THE
CUPLET WITH HIS HAND. THE CUPLET FILLED WITH CLEAR WATER; FARRY
DROPPED TO HIS KNEES BESIDE OLIMEDHRE, RAISED HIS HEAD, AND
BREILIGHT THE GLASS TO HIS LIPS BUT IT WAS EMPTY. OLIMEDHRE
GRIANED AND BEGAN TO PANT. BUT I HAD SOME WAIT
AGGIAMENTI! SAID FARRY AGAIN, POINTING HIS HAND AT THE CUPLET.
HENCE MORE, FOR A SECOND, CLEAR WATER CREAMED WITHIN IT, BUT AS HE
APPROACHED OLIMEDHRE'S MOUTH, THE WATER VANISHED AGAIN. SIR,

I M TRYING, I M TRYING! SAID HARRY DESPERATELY, BUT HE DID NOT THINK THAT DUMBLEDORE COULD HEAR HIM; HE HAD REELLED HENTH HIS SIDE AND WAS DRAWING GREAT, RATTLING BREATHS THAT SOUNDED AGONIZING.

AGLIAMENTI AGLIAMENTI AGLIAMENTTI! THE GHEKET FILLED AND EMPTIED HENCE MORE, AND NOW DUMBLEDORE'S BREATHING WAS FADING, HIS BRAIN WHIRLING IN PANIC, HARRY KNEW, INSTINCTIVELY, THE ONLY WAY LEFT TO GET WATER, BECAUSE VOLDEMORT HAD PLANNED IT SEE HE FELLING HIMSELF OVER THE THE EDGE OF THE ROCK AND PLUNGED THE GHEKET INTO THE LAKE, BRINGING IT UP FULL THE THE BRIM OF ICE WATER THAT DID NOT VANISH. SIR HERE! HARRY YELLED, AND BLINGING FORWARD, HE TIPPED THE WATER CLUMSILY OVER DUMBLEDORE'S FACE. IT WAS THE BEST HE COULD DO, FOR THE ICE FEELING ON HIS ARM NOT HOLDING THE CLIP WAS NOT THE LINGERING CHILL OF THE WATER. A SLIMY WHITE HAND HAD GRIPPED HIS WRIST, AND THE CREATURE THE WHEN IT REVENGED WAS PULLING HIM, SURELY, BACKWARD ACROSS THE ROCK. THE SURFACE OF THE LAKE WAS NOW LONGER MIRRORSOMEETH; IT WAS CHURNING, AND EVERYWHERE HARRY LOOKED, WHITE HEADS AND HANDS WERE EMERGING FROM THE DARK WATER, MEN AND WOMEN AND CHILDREN WITH SLINDEN, SIGHTLESS EYES WERE MOVING TOWARD THE ROCK; AN ARMY OF THE DEAD RISING FROM THE BLACK WATER. PETRIFICUS PECTUS! YELLED HARRY, STRUGGLING THE CLING THE THE SMOOTH, SHADEN SURFACE OF THE ISLAND AS HE POINTED HIS HAND AT THE INFERIUS THAT HAD HIS ARM! IT RELEASED HIM, FALLING BACKWARD INTO THE WATER WITH A SPLASH; HE SCRAMBLED THE HIS FEET, BUT MANY MORE INFERI WERE ALREADY CLIMBING HENTH THE ROCK, THEIR BONY HANDS CLAWING AT ITS SLIPPERY SURFACE, THEIR BLANK, FROSTED EYES LIPEN HIM, TRAILING WATERLOGGED RAGS, SLINDEN FACES BEERING. PETRIFICUS PECTUS! HARRY REHELED AGAIN, BACKING AWAY AS HE SWIPED HIS HAND THROUGH THE AIR; SIX OR SEVEN OF THEM CRUMPLED, BUT MORE WERE CHIMING TOWARD HIM. IMPEDIMENTA! INCARCERUS! A FEW OF THEM STUMBLED, HENCE OR TWO OF THEM REELING IN REPPES, BUT THESE CLIMBING HENTH THE ROCK BEHIND THEM MERELY STEPPED OVER HER ON THE FALLEN REPPES. STILL SLASHING AT THE AIR WITH HIS HAND, HARRY YELLED,

SECTIMSEMPRA! SECTIMSEMPRA! BUT THOUGH GASHES APPEARED IN THEIR SHEDDEN RAGS AND THEIR ICE SKIN, THEY HAD NOT BLEED THE SPILL; THEY WALKED ON, LINGERING, THEIR SPINDLING HANDS ELTSTRETCHED TOWARD HIM, AND AS HE BACKED AWAY STILL FARTHER, HE FELT ARMS ENCLOSE HIM FROM BEHIND, THIN, FLESHLESS ARMS COLD AS DEATH, AND HIS

FEET LEFT THE GRIDLING AS THEY LIFTED HIM AND BEGAN TO CARRY HIM, SURELY AND SURELY, BACK TO THE WATER, AND HE KNEW THERE WOULD BE NO RELEASE, THAT HE WOULD BE DROWNED, AND RESEMBLE MORE DEAD GUARDIAN OF A FRAGMENT OF VILLAGERS' SHATTERED SHILL. BUT THEN, THROUGH THE DARKNESS, FIRE ERUPTED: CRIMSON AND GOLD, A RING OF FIRE THAT SURROUNDED THE REEDS SO THAT THE INFERI HOLDING LARRY SO TIGHTLY STUMBLERED AND FALTERED; THEY DID NOT DARE PASS THROUGH THE FLAMES TO GET TO THE WATER. THEY DROPPED LARRY; HE HIT THE GRIDLING, SLIPPED ON THE REEDS, AND FELL, GRAZING HIS ARMS, BUT STRUGGLED BACK UP, RAISING HIS HAND AND STARING AHEAD. DUMKLEBERG WAS ON HIS FEET AGAIN, PALE AS ANY OF THE SURROUNDING INFERI, BUT TALLER THAN ANY THEM, THE FIRE DANCING IN HIS EYES; HIS HAND WAS RAISED LIKE A TORCH AND FROM ITS TIP EMANATED THE FLAMES, LIKE A VAST LASSIE, ENCIRCLING THEM ALL WITH WARMTH. THE INFERI CLIMBED INTO EACH OTHER, ATTEMPTING, BLINDLY, TO ESCAPE THE FIRE IN WHICH THEY WERE ENCLOSED. DUMKLEBERG SCRAMLED TO THE BANK FROM THE RHYTHM OF THE STONE BASIN AND STUCK IT INSIDE HIS REEDS. UNHESITANTLY, HE GRABBED THE LARRY TO HIMSELF, DISTRACTED BY THE FLAMES, THE INFERI SEEMED UNAWARE THAT THEIR HELPER WAS LEAVING AS DUMKLEBERG LED LARRY BACK TO THE REEDS, THE RING OF FIRE MOVING WITH THEM, AROUND THEM, THE BEMODERED INFERI ACCOMPANYING THEM TO THE WATER'S EDGE, WHERE THEY SLIPPED GRATEFULLY BACK INTO THEIR DARK WATERS. LARRY, WHO WAS SHAKING ALL OVER, THOUGHT FOR A MOMENT THAT DUMKLEBERG MIGHT NOT BE ABLE TO CLIMB INTO THE REEDS; HE STAGGERED A LITTLE AS HE ATTEMPTED IT; ALL HIS EFFORTS SEEMED TO BE GOING INTO MAINTAINING THE RING OF PROTECTIVE FLAME AROUND THEM. LARRY SEIZED HIM AND HELPED HIM BACK TO HIS SEAT. SINCE THEY WERE BOTH SAFELY LAMPEL INSIDE AGAIN, THE REEDS BEGAN TO MOVE BACK ACROSS THE BLACK WATER, AWAY FROM THE REEDS, STILL ENCIRCLED BY THAT RING OF FIRE, AND IT SEEMED THAT THE INFERI SWARMING AROUND THEM DID NOT DARE RESURFACE. SIR, PANTED LARRY, SIR, I FORGET ABOUT FIRE THEY WERE CHASING AT ME AND I PANICKED. ELITE UNDERSTANDABLE, MURMURED DUMKLEBERG. LARRY WAS ALARMED TO HEAR HIS FAINT VOICE WAS. THEY REACHED THE BANK WITH A LITTLE CLIMB AND LARRY LEAPT UP, THEN TURNED QUICKLY TO HELP DUMKLEBERG. THE MOMENT THAT DUMKLEBERG REACHED THE BANK HE LET HIS HAND FALL; THE RING OF FIRE VANISHED, BUT THE INFERI DID NOT EMERGE AGAIN FROM THE WATER. THE LITTLE REED

SANK INTO THE WATER BEHIND ME; CLANKING AND TINKLING, ITS CHAIN SLITHERED BACK INTO THE LAKE THEN, OLIMPEDEHE GAVE A GREAT SIGH AND LEANED AGAINST THE CAVERN WALL. I AM DEAD. HE SAID. THEN T WHIRRY, SIR, SAID F-JARRY AT ONCE, ANXIOUS ASHET OLIMPEDEHE'S EXTREME PALLOR AND BY HIS AIR HE EXHAUSTIVEN. THEN T WHIRRY, I LL GET US BACK. LEAN IN ME, SIR. AND PULLING OLIMPEDEHE'S UNINJURED ARM AROUND HIS SHOULDERS, F-JARRY GLIDED HIS HEADMASTER BACK AROUND THE LAKE, BEARING MEET UP HIS WEIGHT. THE PROTECTION WAS AFTER ALL WELL-DESIGNED, SAID OLIMPEDEHE FAINTLY. ONE ALONE COULD NOT HAVE DONE IT. YELL DID WELL, VERY WELL, F-JARRY.

THEN T TALK NEEL, SAID F-JARRY, FEARING YELL SLURRED OLIMPEDEHE'S VOICE HAD BECOME, YELL MUCH HIS FEET DRAGGED. SAVE YELL'S ENERGY, SIR. WE LL SEEIN RE HLT UP HERE. THE ARCHWAY WILL HAVE SEALED AGAIN. MY KNIFE THERE'S NO NEED, I GET CLT IN THE ROCK, SAID F-JARRY FIRMLY. ILL TELL ME WHERE.

HERE F-JARRY WIPED HIS GRAZED FOREARM UPON THE STONE; HAVING RECEIVED ITS TRICKLE OF BLEED, THE ARCHWAY REOPENED INSTANTLY. THEY CROSSED THE HILTER LAKE, AND F-JARRY HELPED OLIMPEDEHE BACK INTO THE ICE SEALWATER THAT FILLED THE CREVICE IN THE CLIFF. IT'S GOING TO BE ALL RIGHT, SIR, F-JARRY SAID OVER AND OVER AGAIN, MORE WHIRRED BY OLIMPEDEHE'S SILENCE THAN HE HAD BEEN BY HIS WEAKENED VOICE. WE'RE NEARLY THERE. I CAN APPARATE US BOTH BACK. THEN T WHIRRY. I AM NOT WHIRRED, F-JARRY, SAID OLIMPEDEHE, HIS VOICE A LITTLE STRONGER DESPITE THE FREEZING WATER.

I AM WITH YELL. THE LIGHTNING-STRIKE TOWER HENCE BACK UNDER THE STARRY SKY, F-JARRY HEAVED OLIMPEDEHE INTO THE THIP OF THE NEAREST SHOULDER AND THEN TO HIS FEET. SHEDDEN AND SHIVERING, OLIMPEDEHE'S WEIGHT STILL UPON HIM, F-JARRY CONCENTRATED HARDER THAN HE HAD EVER DONE UPON HIS DESTINATION: F-JESSMEADE. CLOSING HIS EYES, GRIPPING OLIMPEDEHE'S ARM AS TIGHTLY AS HE COULD, HE STEPPED FORWARD INTO THAT FEELING OF TERRIBLE COMPRESSION, HE KNEW IT HAD WHIRRED BEFORE HE OPENED HIS EYES: THE SMELL OF SALT, THE SEA BREEZE HAD GONE, HE AND OLIMPEDEHE WERE SHIVERING AND DRIPPING IN THE MIDDLE OF THE DARK F-IGH STREET IN F-JESSMEADE. FOR ONE TERRIBLE MOMENT F-JARRY'S IMAGINATION SHOWED HIM MORE INFERI CREEPING TOWARD HIM AROUND THE SIDES OF SHEEPS, BUT HE BLINKED AND SAW THAT NOTHING WAS STIRRING; ALL WAS STILL, THE DARKNESS COMPLETE BUT FOR A FEW STREETLAMPS AND LIT UPPER

WINDMILLS. WE DID IT, PROFESSOR! HARRY WHISPERED WITH DIFFICULTY; HE SUDDENLY REALIZED THAT HE HAD A SEARING STITCH IN HIS CHEST. WE DID IT! WE GOT THE FURCULON! DUMBLEDORE STAGGERED AGAINST HIM. FOR A MOMENT, HARRY THOUGHT THAT HIS INEXPERT APPARITION HAD THROWN DUMBLEDORE OFF BALANCE; THEN HE SAW HIS FACE, PALER AND DAMPER THAN EVER IN THE DISTANT LIGHT OF A STREETLAMP. SIR, ARE YOU ALL RIGHT? I'VE BEEN BETTER, SAID DUMBLEDORE WEARILY, THOUGH THE CORNERS OF HIS MOUTH TWITCHED. THAT PORTION WAS NOT HEALTHY DRINK. AND THEN HARRY'S FURCULON, DUMBLEDORE SAID INTO THE GRIND. SIR IT'S OKAY, SIR, YOU'RE GOING TO BE ALL RIGHT, DON'T WORRY. HE LUNGED AHEAD DESPERATELY FOR HELP, BUT THERE WAS NOBODY THERE SEEN AND ALL HE COULD THINK WAS THAT HE MUST SOMEHOW GET DUMBLEDORE QUICKLY TO THE HOSPITAL WING. WE NEED THE GET YOU UP THE THE STAIRS, SIR. MADAM POMFREY NO, SAID DUMBLEDORE. IT IS PROFESSOR SNAPE WHOM I NEED. BUT I DON'T THINK I CAN WALK VERY FAR JUST YET. RIGHT SIR, LISTEN I'M GOING TO BRING YOU A CHAIR, FIND A PLACE YOU CAN STAY THEN I CAN RUN AND GET MADAM SEVERUS, SAID DUMBLEDORE CLEARLY. I NEED SEVERUS. ALL RIGHT THEN, SNAPE BUT I'M GOING TO HAVE TO LEAVE YOU FOR A MOMENT SO I CAN REFRESH. HARRY COULD MAKE A MOVE, HOWEVER, HE HEARD RUNNING FEETSTEPS. HIS HEART LEAPT! SOMEHOW HAD SEEN, SOMEHOW KNEW THEY NEEDED HELP AND LUNGING AHEAD HE SAW MADAM RHEMERTA SLURPING DOWN THE DARK STREET TOWARD THEM IN HIGH-HEELED, ALFAY SLIPPERS, WEARING A SILK DRESSING GOWN EMBROIDERED WITH DRAGONS. I SAW YOU APPARATE AS I WAS PULLING MY BEDROOM CURTAINS! THAND GOODNESS, THAND GOODNESS, I COULDN'T THINK WHAT THE BUT WHAT'S WRITING WITH ALEXIS? SHE CAME TO A HALT, PANTING, AND STARED DOWN, WIDE-EYED, AT DUMBLEDORE. HE'S FLIRT, SAID HARRY. MADAM RHEMERTA, CAN HE COME INTO THE THREE BROOMSTICKS WHILE I GO UP THE THE STAIRS AND GET HELP FOR HIM? YOU CAN'T GO UP THERE ALONE! DON'T YOU REALIZE HAVEN'T YOU SEEN ? IF YOU HELP ME SLIPPER HIM, SAID HARRY, NOT LISTENING TO HER, I THINK WE CAN GET HIM INSIDE. WHAT HAS HAPPENED? ASKED DUMBLEDORE. RHEMERTA, WHAT'S WRITING? THE THE DARK MARK, ALEXIS, AND SHE POINTED INTO THE SKY, IN THE DIRECTION OF HOGWARTS. DREAD FLEWED HARRY AT THE SOUND OF THE WORDS. HE TURNED AND LUNGED. THERE IT WAS, HANGING IN THE SKY ABOVE THE STAIRS! THE BLAZING

GREEN SKULL WITH A SERPENT TWINGLE, THE MARK DEATH EATERS LEFT
BEHIND WHEREVER THEY HAD ENTERED A BUILDING. WHEREVER THEY HAD
MURDERED. WHEN DID IT APPEAR? ASKED DUMBLEDORE, AND HIS HAND
CLENCHED PAINFULLY UPON HARRY'S SHOULDER AS HE STRUGGLED THE HIS
FEET. MUST HAVE BEEN MINUTES AGO, IT WASN'T THERE WHEN I PUT THE
CAT HOLT, BUT WHEN I GOT UPSTAIRS. WE NEED THE RETURN THE THE
CASTLE AT ONCE, SAID DUMBLEDORE. REMEMTA AND THOUGH HE
STAGGERED A LITTLE, HE SEEMED WHOLLY IN CHARGE OF THE SITUATION.

WE NEED TRANSPORT. KREEM. I'VE GOT A CHURCH BEHIND
THE BAR, SHE SAID, LOOKING VERY FRIGHTENED. SHALL I RUN AND FETCH
? NO, HARRY CAN DO IT. HARRY RAISED HIS HAND AT ONCE.

ALLIE REMEMTA'S KREEM. A SECOND LATER THEY HEARD A LOUD
BANG AS THE FRONT DOOR OF THE PLACE BURST OPEN; TWO KREEMS HAD
SHOT OUT INTO THE STREET AND WERE RACING EACH OTHER THE HARRY'S
SIDE, WHERE THEY STOPPED DEAD, BULGING SLIGHTLY AT WAIST HEIGHT.

REMEMTA, PLEASE SEND A MESSAGE THE THE MINISTRY, SAID
DUMBLEDORE, AS HE MOUNTED THE KREEM NEAREST HIM. IT MIGHT BE
THAT NEARLY WITHIN HOGWARTS HAS YET REALIZED ANYTHING IS WRONG.

HARRY, PUT ON YOUR INVISIBILITY CLOAK. HARRY PULLED HIS
CLOAK OUT OF HIS POCKET AND THREW IT OVER HIMSELF BEFORE
MOUNTING HIS KREEM. MADAM REMEMTA WAS ALREADY TETHERING BACK
TOWARD HER PLACE AS HARRY AND DUMBLEDORE DICKED OFF FROM THE
GRADING AND ROSE UP INTO THE AIR, AS THEY SPED TOWARD THE CASTLE,
HARRY GLANCED SIDELONG AT DUMBLEDORE, READY TO GRAB HIM SHOULD HE
FALL, BUT THE SIGHT OF THE DARK MARK SEEMED TO HAVE ACTED UPON
DUMBLEDORE LIKE A STIMULANT: HE WAS KENT WELL OVER HIS KREEM, HIS
EYES FIXED UPON THE MARK, HIS LONG SILVER HAIR AND BEARD FLYING
BEHIND HIM IN THE NIGHT AIR, AND HARRY THEN LOOKED AHEAD AT THE
SKULL, AND FEAR SWELLED INSIDE HIM LIKE A VENGEFUL KICKLE,
COMPRESSING HIS LINGS, DRIVING ALL OTHER DISCOMFORT FROM HIS MIND.

HOW LONG HAD THEY BEEN AWAY? HAD BEEN, FERMINE, AND
GINNY'S LICK RUN OUT BY NOW? WAS IT ONE OF THEM WHEN HAD CALLED
THE MARK TO BE SET OVER THE SCHOOL, OR WAS IT NEVILLE, OR LUNA, OR
SOME OTHER MEMBER OF THE DA? AND IF IT WAS HE WAS THE ONE
WHEN HAD TOLD THEM THE PATROL THE CORRIDORS, HE HAD ASKED THEM TO
LEAVE THE SAFETY OF THEIR BEDS. WOULD HE BE RESPONSIBLE, AGAIN,
FOR THE DEATH OF A FRIEND? AS THEY FLEW OVER THE DARK, TWISTING
LANE BEHIND WHICH THEY HAD WALKED EARLIER, HARRY HEARD, OVER THE

WHISTLING IN THE NIGHT AIR IN HIS EARS, DUMKLEDHIRE MUTTERING IN SOME STRANGE LANGUAGE AGAIN. HE THOUGHT HE UNDERSTOOD WHY AS HE FELT HIS KNEES SHIVER WHEN THEY FLEW OVER THE BOUNDARY WALL INTO THE GREENS: DUMKLEDHIRE WAS WONDING THE ENCHANTMENTS HE HIMSELF HAD SET AROUND THE CASTLE SO THEY COULD ENTER AT SPEED. THE DARK MARK WAS GLITTERING DIRECTLY ABOVE THE TOWER, THE HIGHEST OF THE CASTLE. DID THAT MEAN THE DEATH HAD OCCURRED THERE? DUMKLEDHIRE HAD ALREADY CROSSED THE CRENELLATED RAMPARTS AND WAS DISMOUNTING; HARRY LANDED NEXT TO HIM SECONDS LATER AND LOOKED AROUND. THE RAMPARTS WERE DESERTED. THE DOOR TO THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE THAT LED BACK INTO THE CASTLE WAS CLOSED. THERE WAS NO SIGN OF A STRUGGLE, OF A FIGHT OR THE DEATH, OF A BODY. WHAT DOES IT MEAN? HARRY ASKED DUMKLEDHIRE, LOOKING UP AT THE GREEN SKILL WITH ITS SERPENT'S TONGUE GLINTING EVILLY ABOVE THEM. IS IT THE REAL MARK? HAS SOMEONE DEFINITELY BEEN PROPHESSED? IN THE DIM GREEN GLOW FROM THE MARK, HARRY SAW DUMKLEDHIRE CLUTCHING AT HIS CHEST WITH HIS BLACKENED HAND. OH AND WAKE SEVERUS, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE FAINTLY BUT CLEARLY. TELL HIM WHAT HAS HAPPENED AND BRING HIM THE MEAT. DO NOTHING ELSE, SPEAK THE NECESSARY ELSE, AND DO NOT REMOVE YOUR HEAD. I SHALL WAIT HERE. BUT WHY WOULD THE MEAT ME, HARRY? OH? HARRY FLURRIED OVER TO THE DOOR LEADING TO THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE, BUT HIS HAND HAD ONLY JUST CLOSED UPON THE IRON RING OF THE DOOR WHEN HE HEARD RUNNING FEETSTEPS ON THE OTHER SIDE. HE LOOKED AROUND AT DUMKLEDHIRE, WHO GESTURED HIM TO RETREAT. HARRY BACKED AWAY, DRAWING HIS WAND AS HE DID SO. THE DOOR FIRST OPENED AND THEN SWUNG OPENED THROUGHLIGHT IT AND SHUTTED.

EXPELLIARMIS? HARRY'S BODY BECAME INSTANTLY RIGID AND IMMILE, AND HE FELT HIMSELF FALL BACK AGAINST THE TOWER WALL, PREPPED LIKE AN UNSTEADY STATUE, UNABLE TO MOVE OR SPEAK. HE COULD NOT UNDERSTAND WHY IT HAD HAPPENED. EXPELLIARMIS WAS NOT A FREEZING CHARM. THEN, BY THE LIGHT OF THE MARK, HE SAW DUMKLEDHIRE'S WAND FLYING IN AN ARC OVER THE EDGE OF THE RAMPARTS AND UNDERSTOOD. DUMKLEDHIRE HAD WERDLESSLY IMMILIZED HARRY, AND THE SECOND HE HAD TAKEN THE PERFORM THE SPELL HAD LEFT HIM THE CHANCE OF DEFENDING HIMSELF. STANDING AGAINST THE RAMPARTS, VERY WHITE IN THE FACE, DUMKLEDHIRE STILL SHOWED NO SIGN OF PANIC OR DISTRESS. HE MERELY LOOKED ACROSS AT HIS DISARMER AND SAID, GOOD EVENING, DRAGON. MALFOY STEPPED FORWARD, GLANCING AROUND QUICKLY

THE CHECK THAT HE AND DUMBLEDORE WERE ALONE. HIS EYES FELL UPON THE SECOND ROOM. WHAT ELSE IS HERE? A HURSTON I MIGHT ASK YELL. ARE YOU ACTING ALONE? HARRY SAW MALFOY'S PALE EYES SHIFT BACK TO DUMBLEDORE IN THE GREENISH GLARE OF THE MOON. NO, HE SAID. I'VE GOTTEN BACKLIP. THERE ARE DEATH EATERS HERE IN YOUR SCHEMETHING. WELL, WELL, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AS THOUGH MALFOY WAS SHOWING HIM AN AMBITIOUS FURROWED FOREHEAD. VERY GOOD INDEED, YOU FIND A WAY TO LET THEM IN, DID YOU? YES, SAID MALFOY, WHO WAS PANTING. RIGHT UNDER YOUR NOSE AND YOU NEVER REALIZED! INCREDIBLE, SAID DUMBLEDORE. BUT FERGUSON ME WHERE ARE THEY NOW? YOU SEEM UNSLIPPERED. THEY MET SOME OF YOUR GUARDS. THEY'RE HAVING A FIGHT DOWN BELOW. THEY WENT TO BE LING. I CAME IN AHEAD. I I'VE GOTTEN A LITTLE TOO. WELL, THEN, YOU MUST GET IN AND DO IT, MY DEAR BOY, SAID DUMBLEDORE SHYLY. THERE WAS SILENCE. HARRY STOOD IMPRISONED WITHIN HIS OWN INVISIBLE, PARALYZED BODY, STARING AT THE TWO OF THEM, HIS EARS STRAINING THE HEAR SOUNDS OF THE DEATH EATERS DISTANT FIGHT, AND IN FRONT OF HIM, DRACHE MALFOY DID NOTHING BUT STARE AT ALBUS DUMBLEDORE. WHO, INCREDIBLY, SMILED. DRACHE, DRACHE, YOU ARE NOT A KILLER. HOW DO YOU KNOW? SAID MALFOY AT ONCE. HE SEEMED TO REALIZE HOW CHILDISH THE WORDS HAD SOUNDED. HARRY SAW HIM FLUSH IN THE MOON'S GREENISH LIGHT. YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT I'M CAPABLE OF, SAID MALFOY MORE FIERCELY. YOU DON'T KNOW WHAT I'VE DONE? YES, I DO, SAID DUMBLEDORE MILDLY. YOU ALMOST KILLED KATIE BELL AND RICHARD WEAVER. YOU HAVE BEEN TRYING, WITH INCREASING DESPERATION, TO KILL ME ALL YEAR. FERGUSON ME, DRACHE, BUT THEY HAVE BEEN FEELER ATTEMPTS. SEE FEELER, THE RE FINEST, THAT I WONDER WHETHER YOUR HEART HAS BEEN REALLY IN IT. IT HAS BEEN IN IT! SAID MALFOY VIOLENTLY. I'VE BEEN WORKING ON IT ALL YEAR, AND TONIGHT SOMEWHERE IN THE DEPTHS OF THE CASTLE BELOW HARRY HEARD A MUFFLED YELL. MALFOY STIFFENED AND GLANCED OVER HIS SHOULDER. SOMEBODY IS PUTTING UP A GOOD FIGHT, SAID DUMBLEDORE CONVERSATIONALLY. BUT YOU WERE SAYING YES, YOU HAVE MANAGED TO INTRODUCE DEATH EATERS INTO MY SCHEMETHING, WHICH, I ADMIT, I THOUGHT IMPOSSIBLE. HOW DID YOU DO IT? BUT MALFOY SAID NOTHING! HE WAS STILL LISTENING TO WHATEVER WAS HAPPENING BELOW AND SEEMED ALMOST AS PARALYZED AS HARRY WAS. PERHAPS YOU MIGHT GET IN WITH THE OTHERS ALONE, SUGGESTED DUMBLEDORE. WHAT IF YOUR

BACKLIP HAS BEEN THWARTED BY MY GUARD? AS YOU HAVE PERHAPS REALIZED, THERE ARE MEMBERS OF THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX HERE TONIGHT TOO. AND AFTER ALL, YOU DON'T REALLY NEED HELP. I HAVE MY HAND AT THE MOMENT. I CANNOT DEFEND MYSELF. MALPHY MERELY STARED AT HIM. I SEE, SAID DUMBLEDORE KINDLY, WHEN MALPHY NEITHER MOVED NOR SPOKE. YOU ARE AFRAID TO ACT UNTIL THEY JOIN YOU.

I'M NOT AFRAID! SNARLED MALPHY, THOUGH HE STILL MADE ME MOVE THE FLIRT DUMBLEDORE. IT'S YOU WHO SHOULD BE SCARED! BUT WHY? I DON'T THINK YOU WILL KILL ME, DRAGON. KILLING IS NOT NEARLY AS EASY AS THE INNOCENT BELIEVE. SHE TELL ME, WHILE WE WAIT FOR YOUR FRIENDS. HOW DID YOU SNEAKLE THEM IN HERE? IT SEEMS YOU HAVE TAKEN YOU A LONG TIME TO WORK OUT HOW TO DO IT. MALPHY LOOKED AS THOUGH HE WAS FIGHTING WITH THE LARGER THE SKELETON, FOR THE WHIM. HE CLIMBED AND TOOK SEVERAL DEEP BREATHS, GLARING AT DUMBLEDORE, HIS HAND POINTING DIRECTLY AT THE LATTER'S HEART. THEN, AS THOUGH HE COULD NOT HELP HIMSELF, HE SAID, I HAD THE MIND THAT KROKEN VANISHING CABINET THAT YOU HAD LISTENED FOR YEARS. THE ONE MENTAGLE GET LOST IN LAST YEAR. AAAA. DUMBLEDORE'S SIGH WAS HALF A GRIAN. HE CLOSED HIS EYES FOR A MOMENT. THAT WAS CLEVER.

THERE IS A PAIR, I TAKE IT? IN KROKEN AND KROKEN, SAID MALPHY, AND THEY MAKE A KIND OF PASSAGE BETWEEN THEM. MENTAGLE TOLD ME THAT WHEN HE WAS STUCK IN THE HOGWARTS ONE, HE WAS TRAPPED IN LIKE BUT SOMETIMES HE COULD HEAR WHAT WAS GOING ON AT SCHOOL, AND SOMETIMES WHAT WAS GOING ON IN THE STREET, AS IF THE CABINET WAS TRAVELING BETWEEN THEM, BUT HE COULD NOT MAKE ANYONE HEAR HIM. IN THE END, HE MANAGED TO APPARATE OUT, EVEN THOUGH HE'D NEVER PASSED HIS TEST. HE NEARLY DIED DOING IT. EVERYONE THOUGHT IT WAS A REALLY GOOD STORY, BUT I WAS THE ONLY ONE WHO REALIZED WHAT IT MEANT. EVEN KROKEN DIDN'T KNOW. I WAS THE ONE WHO REALIZED THERE COULD BE A WAY INTO HOGWARTS THROUGH THE CABINETS IF I FIXED THE KROKEN ONE. VERY GOOD, MURMURED DUMBLEDORE. SHE THE DEATH EATERS WERE ABLE TO PASS FROM KROKEN AND KROKEN INTO THE SCHOOL TO HELP YOU. A CLEVER PLAN, A VERY CLEVER PLAN. AND, AS YOU SAY, RIGHT UNDER MY NOSE.

YES, SAID MALPHY, WHO BIZARRELY SEEMED TO DRAW COURAGE AND CONFIDENCE FROM DUMBLEDORE'S PRAISE. YES, IT WAS. BUT THERE WERE TIMES, DUMBLEDORE WENT ON, WHEN THERE, WHEN YOU WERE NOT SURE YOU WOULD SUCCEED IN MENDING THE CABINET? AND YOU RESORTED

THE CRUDE AND RABIDLY ILL-CONSIDERED MEASURES SUCH AS SENDING ME A CURSED
NECKLACE THAT WAS KILLING THE REACH THE WRITHING HANDS FINISHING
MEAD THERE WAS ONLY THE SLIGHTEST CHANCE I MIGHT DRINK.

Yeah, well, you still didn't realize we had been that stupid, did
you? sneered Malfoy, as Dumbledore slid a little down the
ramparts, the strength in his legs apparently fading, and Harry
struggled fruitlessly, futilely, against the enchantment binding
him. As a matter of fact, I did, said Dumbledore, I was sure it was
you. Why didn't you stop me, then? Malfoy demanded. I tried,
Draco, Professor Snape has been keeping watch over you and my
orders. He hasn't been doing your orders, he promised my
mother. He knows that is what he would tell you, Draco, but

He's a double agent, you stupid old man, he isn't working
for you, you just think he is! We must agree to differ on that,
Draco, it seems happens that I trust Professor Snape. Well,
you're losing your grip, then? sneered Malfoy, He's been
helping me plenty of help. Wanting all the glory for himself
wanting a bit of the action. What are you doing? Did you see
the necklace, that was stupid, it could have killed everything
but I haven't told him what I've been doing in the Room of
Requirement, he's going to wake up tomorrow and it'll all be
over and he won't be the dark lord's favorite anymore, he'll be
nothing compared to me, nothing! Very gratifying, said
Dumbledore mildly. We all like appreciation for how hard
work, he knows, but you must have had an accomplice, all the
same. Someone in the castle, someone who was able to slip
past the the AAAA! Dumbledore closed his eyes again
and nodded, as though he was about to fall asleep. He knows

Remus, how long has he been under the Imperius Curse?
Get there at last, have you? Malfoy taunted. There was
another yell from below, rather louder than the last. Malfoy
leaped nervously over his shoulder again, then back at
Dumbledore, who went on: She said Remus was forced to live
in her own bathroom and pass that necklace to any Hogwarts
student who entered the room unaccompanied. And the poisoned
mead. Well, naturally, Remus was able to poison it for you
before she sent the little the Silverhorn, believing that it was the
my Christmas present. Yes, very neat very neat. Poor Mr.

FILCH WOULD NOT, HE CHOOSE, THINK THE CHIEF A BITTLE OF RESMERTA'S. TELL ME, HOW HAVE YOU BEEN COMMUNICATING WITH RESMERTA? I THOUGHT WE HAD ALL METHODS OF COMMUNICATION IN AND OUT OF THE SCHOOL MENTHERED. ENCHANTED CHINS, SAID MALFOY, AS THOUGH HE WAS COMPELLED THE DEEP TALKING, THOUGH HIS HAND HAND WAS SHAKING BADLY. I HAD ONE AND SHE HAD THE OTHER AND I COULD SEND HER MESSAGES. ISN'T THAT THE SECRET METHOD OF COMMUNICATION THE

GRIMLP THAT CALLED THEMSELVES DUMBLEDORE'S ARMY USED LAST YEAR? ASKED DUMBLEDORE, HIS VOICE WAS LIGHT AND CONVERSATIONAL, BUT HARRY SAW HIM SLIP AN INCH LOWER DOWN THE WALL AS HE SAID IT.

YES, I GOT THE IDEA FROM THEM, SAID MALFOY, WITH A TWISTED SMILE. I GOT THE IDEA OF FINISHING THE ROAD FROM THE MURDERED GRANGER AS WELL, I HEARD HER TALKING IN THE LIBRARY ABOUT FILCH NOT RECOGNIZING POTIONES. PLEASE DO NOT USE THAT OFFENSIVE WORD IN FRONT OF ME, SAID DUMBLEDORE, MALFOY GAVE A HARSH LAUGH. YOU CARE ABOUT ME SAYING MURDERED WHEN I M ABOUT THE BILL YOU?

YES, I DO, SAID DUMBLEDORE, AND HARRY SAW HIS FEET SLIDE A LITTLE ON THE FLOOR AS HE STRUGGLED TO REMAIN UPRIGHT. BUT AS FOR BEING ABOUT THE BILL ME, DRACH, YOU HAVE HAD SEVERAL LONG MINUTES NOW, WE ARE ALIVE ALONE, I AM MORE DEFENSELESS THAN YOU CAN HAVE DREAMED OF FINDING ME, AND STILL YOU HAVE NOT ACTED. MALFOY'S MOUTH CONTRACTED INVOLUNTARILY, AS THOUGH HE HAD TASTED SOMETHING VERY BITTER. NOW, ABOUT TONIGHT, DUMBLEDORE WENT ON.

I AM A LITTLE PLUTZLED ABOUT HOW IT HAPPENED. YOU KNOW THAT I HAD LEFT THE SCHOOL? BUT OF COURSE, HE ANSWERED HIS OWN QUESTION, RESMERTA SAW ME LEAVING, SHE TIPPED YOU OFF USING YOUR

INGENIOUS CHINS, I'M SURE. THAT'S RIGHT, SAID MALFOY. BUT SHE SAID YOU WERE JUST GOING FOR A DRINK, YOU'D BE BACK. WELL, I CERTAINLY DID HAVE A DRINK AND I CAME BACK AFTER A FASHION, MURDERED DUMBLEDORE. SHE YOU DECIDED TO SPRING A TRAP FOR ME? WE DECIDED TO PUT THE DARK MARK OVER THE THICKER AND GET YOU THE FLIRRY UP HERE, THE SEE WHEN D BEEN KILLED, SAID MALFOY. AND IT WORKED? WELL YES AND NO SAID DUMBLEDORE. BUT AM I TO TAKE IT, THEN, THAT NEROBY HAS BEEN MURDERED? SOMEONE'S DEAD, SAID MALFOY, AND HIS VOICE SEEMED TO GO UP AN OCTAVE AS HE SAID IT.

ONE OF YOUR PEOPLE I DON'T KNOW WHEN IT WAS DARK. I STEPPED OVER THE BODY. I WAS SLIPPED THE BE WAITING UP HERE WHEN YOU GOT BACK, ONLY YOUR PRESENCE LEFT GET IN THE WAY.

YES, THEY DO THAT, SAID DUMBLEDORE, THERE WAS A RANG AND SHEETS FROM BELOW, LARGER THAN EVER; IT SEEMED AS THOUGH PEOPLE WERE FIGHTING IN THE ACTUAL SPIRAL STAIRCASE THAT LED TO WHERE DUMBLEDORE, MALFOY, AND HARRY STOOD, AND HARRY'S HEART THUNDERED UNHEARD IN HIS INVISIBLE CHEST. SOMETHING WAS DEAD, MALFOY HAD STOPPED OVER THE BODY BUT WHAT WAS IT? THERE IS LITTLE TIME, HERE WAS HER ANSWER, SAID DUMBLEDORE, SHE LET HIS DISCUSS THEIR EPTIHENS, DRACHE. MY EPTIHENS? SAID MALFOY HEILIGLY, I'M STANDING HERE WITH A WAND I'M ABOUT TO KILL YOU. MY DEAR KID, LET US HAVE NO MORE PRETENSE ABOUT THAT, IF YOU WERE GOING TO KILL ME, YOU WOULD HAVE DONE IT WHEN YOU FIRST DISARMED ME, YOU WOULD NOT HAVE STOPPED FOR THIS PLEASANT CHAT ABOUT WAYS AND MEANS. I HAVEN'T GOTTEN ANY EPTIHENS? SAID MALFOY, AND HE WAS SUDDENLY WHITE AS DUMBLEDORE, I'VE GOTTEN THE DEED IT? HE'LL KILL ME? HE'LL KILL MY WHOLE FAMILY? I APPRECIATE THE DIFFICULTY OF YOUR POSITION, SAID DUMBLEDORE, WHY ELSE DO YOU THINK I HAVE NOT COMMITTED YOU BEFORE NOW? BECAUSE I KNEW THAT YOU WOULD HAVE BEEN MURDERED IF LORD VOLDEMORT REALIZED THAT I SUSPECTED YOU, MALFOY WINKED AT THE SOUND OF THE NAME. I DID NOT DARE SPEAK THE NAME OF THE MISTRESS WITH WHICH I KNEW YOU HAD BEEN ENTRUSTED, IN CASE HE USED LEGILIMENCY AGAINST YOU, CONTINUED DUMBLEDORE, BUT NOW AT LAST WE CAN SPEAK PLAINLY TO EACH OTHER, NO HARM HAS BEEN DONE, YOU HAVE NOT NEEDED, THOUGH YOU ARE VERY LUCKY THAT YOUR UNINTENTIONAL VICTIMS SURVIVED. I CAN HELP YOU, DRACHE, NO, YOU CAN'T, SAID MALFOY, HIS WAND HAND SHAKING VERY BADLY INDEED, NEEDED CAN, HE TOLD ME THE DEED IT HE'LL KILL ME, I'VE GOTTEN NO CHANCE. COME OVER TO THE RIGHT SIDE, DRACHE, AND WE CAN HIDE YOU MORE COMPLETELY THAN YOU CAN POSSIBLY IMAGINE, WHAT IS MORE, I CAN SEND MEMBERS OF THE ORDER TO YOUR MOTHER TONIGHT TO HIDE HER LIKEWISE, YOUR FATHER IS SAFE AT THE MOMENT IN AZKABAN, WHEN THE TIME COMES, WE CAN PROTECT HIM TOO, COME OVER TO THE RIGHT SIDE, DRACHE YOU ARE NOT A KILLER, MALFOY STARED AT DUMBLEDORE, BUT I GOTTEN THIS FAR, DIDN'T I? HE SAID SILENTLY, THEY THOUGHT I'D DIE IN THE ATTEMPT, BUT I'M HERE AND YOU'RE IN MY POWER. I'M THE ONE WITH THE WAND, YOU'RE AT MY MERCY, NO, DRACHE, SAID DUMBLEDORE QUIETLY, IT IS MY MERCY, AND NOT YOURS, THAT MATTERS NOW, MALFOY DID NOT SPEAK, HIS MOUTH WAS OPEN, HIS WAND HAND STILL TREMLING, HARRY THOUGHT HE SAW IT

DRIPP BY A FRACTURE. BUT SUDDENLY FEETSTEPS WERE THUNDERING UP THE STAIRS, AND A SECOND LATER MALFOY WAS KICKED OUT OF THE WAY AS FLEUR DEEULE IN BLACK DRESS FIRST THROUGHT THE DOOR INTO THE RAMPARTS. STILL PARALYZED, HIS EYES STARING UNBLINKINGLY, HARRY GAZED IN TERROR UPON FLEUR STRANGERS: IT SEEMED THE DEATH EATERS HAD WHEN THE FIGHT BEGAN. A LIMPY-LOOKING MAN WITH AN EDD WHEP-SIDED BEER GAVE A WEEZY GIGGLE. DUMBLEDORE CHINNED: HE SAID, AND HE TURNED TO A STOCKY LITTLE WOMAN WHO LOOKED AS THOUGH SHE COULD BE HIS SISTER AND WHO WAS GRINNING RAGERLY. DUMBLEDORE WANDLESS, DUMBLEDORE ALONE! WELL DONE, BRACE, WELL DONE! GOOD EVENING, AMPLIS, SAID DUMBLEDORE CALMLY, AS THOUGH WELCOMING THE MAN TO A TEA PARTY, AND YELL YE BRIGHT ALICE THEE.

CHARMING. THE WOMAN GAVE AN ANGRY LITTLE TITTER. THINK FLEUR LITTLE INDEXES LL HELP YELL HEN FLEUR DEATH-KED THEN? SHE IERED.

INDEXES? NEE, NEE, THESE ARE MANNERS, REPLIED DUMBLEDORE. DEE IT, SAID THE STRANGER STANDING NEAREST THE HARRY, A BIG, RANGY MAN WITH MATTED GRAY HAIR AND WHISKERS, WHOSE BLACK DEATH-EATER S DRESS LOOKED UNCOMFORTABLY TIGHT. HE HAD A VOICE LIKE NONE THAT HARRY HAD EVER HEARD: A RASPING BARK OF A VOICE. HARRY COULD SMELL A PEEPERFUL MIXTURE OF DIRT, SWEAT, AND, UNMISTAKABLY, OF BLEED CHIMING FROM HIM. HIS FILTHY HANDS HAD LONG YELLOWISH NAILS. IS THAT YELL, FENRIR? ASKED DUMBLEDORE. THAT S RIGHT, RASPED THE OTHER. PLEASED THE SEE ME, DUMBLEDORE? NEE, I CANNOT SAY THAT I AM. GREYBACK GRINNED, SHOWING POINTED TEETH. BLEED TRICKLED DOWN HIS CHIN AND HE LICKED HIS LIPS SLEENLY, HESITENTLY. BUT YELL KNOW HOW MUCH I LIKE DIDS, DUMBLEDORE. AM I THE TAKE IT THAT YELL ARE ATTACKING EVEN WITHOUT THE FULL MEEN NEE? THIS IS MEET UNUSUAL. YELL HAVE DEVELOPED A TASTE FOR HUMAN FLESH THAT CANNOT BE SATISFIED SINCE A MONTH? THAT S RIGHT, SAID FENRIR GREYBACK. STICKS YELL THAT, DEES IT, DUMBLEDORE? FRIGHTENS YELL?

WELL, I CANNOT PRETEND IT DEES NOT DISGUST ME A LITTLE, SAID DUMBLEDORE. AND, YES, I AM A LITTLE SHOCKED THAT BRACE HERE INVITED YELL, OF ALL PEOPLE, INTO THE SCHOOL WHERE HIS FRIENDS LIVE. I DIDN T, BREATHE MALFOY, HE WAS NOT LOOKING AT FENRIR; HE DID NOT SEEM TO WANT THE EVEN GLANCE AT HIM. I DIDN T KNOW HE WAS CHING THE CHIME. I WOULDN T WANT THE MISS A TRIP TO THE HOGWARTS,

DUMBLEDORE, RASPED GREYBACK. NOT WHEN THERE ARE THREATS TO BE RIPPED OUT. DELICIOUS, DELICIOUS. AND HE RAISED A YELL

FINGERNAIL AND PICKED AT HIS FRONT TEETH, LEERING AT DUMKLEDHIRE. I
COULD SEE WHY HE AFTERED DUMKLEDHIRE. NOW, SAID THE FORTY-DEATH
LATER SHARPLY, HE HAD A HEAVY, KILLING FACE. WE VE GOT
HORDERS, DRACH S GHT TH DH IT, NOW, DRACH, AND ELICELY, MALPHY WAS
SEEMING LESS RESOLUTION THAN EVER, HE LOOKED TERRIFIED AS HE
STARED INTO DUMKLEDHIRE S FACE, WHICH WAS EVEN PALER, AND RATHER
WIDER THAN USUAL, AS HE HAD SLID SEE FAR DOWN THE RAMPART WALL.

HE S NOT BEING FOR THIS WORLD ANYWAY, IF YOU ASK ME? SAID THE
LIMP-SIDED MAN, THE THE ACCOMPANIMENT OF HIS SISTER S LAZZING
GIGGLES, LOOK AT HIM WHAT S HAPPENED TO YOU, THEN, DUMKY?

HE, WEAKER RESISTANCE, SLOWER REFLEXES, AMYLLIS, SAID DUMKLEDHIRE.
OLD AGE, IN SHORT ONE DAY, PERHAPS, IT WILL HAPPEN TO YOU
IF YOU ARE LUCKY. WHAT S THAT MEAN, THEN, WHAT S THAT

MEAN? YELLED THE DEATH LATER, SUDDENLY VIOLENT, ALWAYS THE SAME,
WEREN T YOU, DUMKY, TALKING AND DOING NOTHING, NOTHING, I DONT
EVEN KNOW WHY THE DARK LORD S ENTHRONE THE WILL YOU? COME ON,
DRACH, DO IT? BUT AT THAT MOMENT THERE WERE REVEALED SHADOWS OF
SLIPPING FROM BEHIND AND A VOICE SHOUTED, THEY VE REACHED THE
STAIRS REDUCED REDUCED? HARRY S HEART LEAPT! SEE THESE
FLOOR HAD NOT ELIMINATED ALL HOPESTHIN, BUT MERELY BROKEN
THROUGH THE FIGHT THE THE THE OF THE TOWER, AND, BY THE SHIELD OF IT,
CREATED A BARRIER BEHIND THEM NOW, DRACH, ELICELY? SAID THE

KILLING-FACED MAN ANGRILY, BUT MALPHY S HAND WAS SHAKING SEE BADLY
THAT HE COULD BARELY AIM. I LL DO IT, SNARLED FENRIR, MOVING
TOWARD DUMKLEDHIRE WITH HIS HANDS OUTSTRETCHED, HIS TEETH BARED. I
SAID NO! SHOUTED THE KILLING-FACED MAN; THERE WAS A FLASH OF LIGHT
AND THE WEREWOLF WAS BLASTED OUT OF THE WAY; HE HIT THE RAMPARTS
AND STAGGERED, WHIRLING FLURIELIS. HARRY S HEART WAS HARTERING SEE
HARD IT SEEMED IMPOSSIBLE THAT NEKKED CHILD HEAR HIM STANDING
THERE, IMPRISONED BY DUMKLEDHIRE S SPELL IF HE COULD ONLY MOVE,

HE COULD AIM A CURSE FROM UNDER THE CHAIR DRACH, DO IT HE
STAND ASIDE SEE ONE OF US SCREAMED THE WERMAN, BUT AT THAT
PRECISE MOMENT, THE DOOR THE RAMPARTS FIRST OPEN HENCE MORE
AND THERE STOOD SNAPE, HIS HAND CLUTCHED IN HIS HAND AS HIS BLACK
EYES SWEEP THE SCENE, FROM DUMKLEDHIRE SLIPPED AGAINST THE WALL, THE
THE FORTY-DEATH LATER, INCLUDING THE ENRAGED WEREWOLF, AND MALPHY.

WE VE GOT A PROBLEM, SNAPE, SAID THE LIMPY AMYLLIS, WHOSE EYES
AND HAND WERE FIXED ALIKE UPON DUMKLEDHIRE, THE WHY DOESN T SEEM

ABLE BUT SOMETHING ELSE HAD SPOKEN SNAPE'S NAME, ELITE SILENTLY.

SEVERUS THE SILENT FRIGHTENED HARRY KNOWING ANYTHING HE HAD EXPERIENCED ALL EVENING, FOR THE FIRST TIME, DUMBLEDORE WAS PLEADING. SNAPE SAID NOTHING, BUT WALKED FORWARD AND PUSHED MALFOY RELUCTANTLY OUT OF THE WAY. THE THREE DEATH EATERS FELL BACK WITH A WHIRL. EVEN THE WEREWOLF SEEMED CHASED. SNAPE GAZED FOR A MOMENT AT DUMBLEDORE, AND THERE WAS REVULSION AND HATRED ETCHED IN THE HARSH LINES OF HIS FACE. SEVERUS PLEASE SNAPE RAISED HIS HAND AND POINTED IT DIRECTLY AT DUMBLEDORE. AVADA KEDAVRA! A JET OF GREEN LIGHT SHOT FROM THE END OF SNAPE'S WAND AND HIT DUMBLEDORE SQUARELY IN THE CHEST. HARRY'S SCREAM OF HORROR NEVER LEFT HIM; SILENT AND LIMPING, HE WAS FORCED TO WATCH AS DUMBLEDORE WAS BLASTED INTO THE AIR, FOR A SPLIT SECOND, HE SEEMED TO HANG SUSPENDED BENEATH THE SHINING SKULL, AND THEN HE FELL SILENTLY BACKWARD, LIKE A GREAT RAG DOLL, OVER THE BATTLEMENTS AND OUT OF SIGHT. FLIGHT OF THE PRINCE HARRY FELT AS THOUGH HE THEN WERE FLUTTERING THROUGH SPACE; IT HAD NOT HAPPENED. IT COULD NOT HAVE HAPPENED. BUT HE HERE, SILENTLY, SAID SNAPE. HE GRABBED MALFOY BY THE SCUFF OF THE NECK AND FORCED HIM THROUGH THE DOOR ALONG WITH THE REST; GRYFACED AND THE SILENT KITCHEN AND SISTER FOLLOWED, THE LATTER BOTH PANTING EXCITEDLY. AS THEY VANISHED THROUGH THE DOOR, HARRY REALIZED HE COULD MOVE AGAIN. WHAT WAS NOW HOLDING HIM PARALYZED AGAINST THE WALL WAS NOT MAGIC, BUT HORROR AND SHOCK. HE THREW THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK ASIDE AS THE BLOOD-FACED DEATH EATER, LAST TO LEAVE THE TOWER TOWER, WAS DISAPPEARING THROUGH THE DOOR. PETRIFICUS TOTALIS! THE DEATH EATER KICKED AS THOUGH HIT IN THE BACK WITH SOMETHING SOLID AND FELL TO THE GROUND, RIGID AS A WAXEN DOLL, BUT HE HAD RARELY HIT THE FLOOR WHEN HARRY WAS CLAMBERING OVER HIM AND ROLLING DOWN THE DARKENED STAIRCASE. TERROR THERE AT HARRY'S HEART. HE HAD TO GET THE DUMBLEDORE AND HE HAD TO CATCH SNAPE. SOMEHOW THE TWO THINGS WERE LINKED. HE COULD REVERSE WHAT HAD HAPPENED IF HE HAD THEM BOTH TOGETHER. DUMBLEDORE COULD NOT HAVE DIED. HE LEAPT THE LAST TEN STEPS OF THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE AND STOPPED WHERE HE LANDED, HIS WAND RAISED! THE DIMLY LIT HALLWAY WAS FULL OF DUST; HALF THE CEILING SEEMED TO HAVE FALLEN IN; AND A RATTLE WAS RAGING BEFORE HIM, BUT EVEN AS HE ATTEMPTED TO MAKE BUT HE WAS FIGHTING WITH HIM, HE HEARD THE HATED VOICE SILENT. IT'S NEVER, TIME TO GO! AND

Saw SNAPE DISAPPEARING AROUND THE CORNER AT THE FAR END OF THE HALLWAY; HE AND MALFOY SEEMED TO HAVE FORCED THEIR WAY THROUGH THE FIGHT UNSCATHED, AS HARRY COLLINGED AFTER THEM, ONE OF THE FIGHTERS DETACHED THEMSELVES FROM THE FIGHT AND FLEW AT HIM: IT WAS THE WEREWOLF, PENTON, HE WAS IN THE OF HARRY BEFORE HARRY COULD RAISE HIS WAND: HARRY FELL BACKWARD, WITH FILTHY MATTED HAIR IN HIS FACE, THE STENCH OF SWEAT AND BLOOD FILLING HIS NOSE AND EYES, HE HEARD GROSS BREATH AT HIS THROAT PETRIFICUS TOTALIS! HARRY FELT PENTON COLLAPSE AGAINST HIM; WITH A STUPIDOUS EFFORT HE PUSHED THE WEREWOLF OFF AND HEARD THE FLOOR AS A LOT OF GREEN LIGHT CAME FLYING TOWARD HIM; HE CLIMBED AND RAN, HEADFIRST, INTO THE FIGHT, HIS FEET MET SOMETHING SLIPPERY AND SLIPPERY IN THE FLOOR AND HE STUMBLED: THERE WERE TWO BODIES LYING THERE, LYING FACEDOWN IN A POOL OF BLOOD, BUT THERE WAS NO TIME TO INVESTIGATE, HARRY WHEN SAW RED HAIR FLYING LIKE FLAMES IN FRONT OF HIM: GINNY WAS LOCKED IN COMBAT WITH THE LIMPY DEATH EATER, AMULUS, WHO WAS THROWING HER AFTER HER AT HER WHILE SHE DODGED THEM: AMULUS WAS GIGGLING, ENJOYING THE SPORT: CRACK CRACK WHO CAN'T DANCE ANYMORE, PRETTY IMPEDIMENTA! YELLED HARRY, HIS HAND HIT AMULUS IN THE CHEST: HE GAVE A PIGLIKE SHRIEK OF PAIN, WAS LIFTED OFF HIS FEET AND SLAMMED INTO THE OPPOSITE WALL, SLID DOWN IT, AND FELL INTO HIS SIGHT BEHIND REIN, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND LUPIN, EACH OF WHOM WAS BATTLING A SEPARATE DEATH EATER, BEYOND THEM, HARRY SAW THREE FIGHTING AN ENORMOUS BLOOD WIZARD WHO WAS SENDING CURSES FLYING IN ALL DIRECTIONS, SEE THAT THEY REBOUNDED OFF THE WALLS AROUND THEM, CRACKING STONE, SHATTERING THE NEAREST WINDOW

HARRY, WHERE DID YOU COME FROM? GINNY CRIED, BUT THERE WAS NO TIME TO ANSWER HER, HE PUT HIS HEAD DOWN AND SPRINTED FORWARD, NEARLY AVOIDING A BLAST THAT ERUPTED OVER HIS HEAD, SHOWERING THEM ALL IN BITS OF WALL, SNAPE MUST NOT ESCAPE, HE MUST CATCH UP WITH SNAPE TAKE THAT! SHOUTED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, AND HARRY GLIMSED THE FEMALE DEATH EATER, ALKETH, SPRINTING AWAY DOWN THE HALLWAY WITH HER ARMS OVER HER HEAD, HER RIGHTER RIGHT BEHIND HER, HE LAUNCHED HIMSELF AFTER THEM BUT HIS FEET CALLED ON SOMETHING, AND NEXT MOMENT HE WAS LYING ACROSS SOMEONE'S LEGS, LIMPING AROUND, HE SAW NEVILLE'S PALE, REELING FACE FLAT AGAINST THE FLOOR, NEVILLE, ARE YOU? M ALL RIGHT, MUTTERED NEVILLE, WHO WAS CLUTCHING HIS STOMACH, HARRY

SNAPE AND MALFOY RAN PAST I KNOW, I'M IN IT! SAID
HARRY, AIMING A FIRE FROM THE FLAME AT THE ENORMOUS BLEND DEATH
LATER WHICH WAS CAUSING MOST OF THE CHAOS. THE MAN GAVE A SHOUT OF
PAIN AS THE SPELL HIT HIM IN THE FACE! HE WHEELED AROUND,
STAGGERED, AND THEN PHUNDED AWAY AFTER THE BROTHER AND SISTER.
HARRY SCRAMBLED UP FROM THE FLAME AND BEGAN THE SPRINT ALONG THE
CORRIDOR, IGNORING THE BANGS ISSUING FROM BEHIND HIM, THE YELLS OF
THE OTHERS THE CHASE BACK, AND THE MUTE CALL OF THE FIGURES ON THE
GALLERIES WHICH HE DID NOT YET KNOW. HE SKIDDED AROUND THE
CORNER, HIS TRAINERS SLIPPERY WITH BLOOD. SNAPE HAD AN IMMENSE
HEAD START. WAS IT POSSIBLE THAT HE HAD ALREADY ENTERED THE CABINET
IN THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT, OR HAD THE ORDER MADE STEPS TO
SECURE IT, TO PREVENT THE DEATH EATERS RETREATING THAT WAY? HE
COULD HEAR NOTHING BUT HIS OWN PHUNING FEET, HIS OWN
HAMMERING HEART AS HE SPRINTED ALONG THE NEXT EMPTY CORRIDOR,
BUT THEN SPOTTED A BLOODY FOOTPRINT THAT SPOKE AT LEAST ONE OF
THE FLEEING DEATH EATERS WAS HEADING TOWARD THE FRONT DOORS
PERHAPS THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT WAS INDEED BLOCKED. HE
SKIDDED AROUND ANOTHER CORNER AND A CLASH FLEW PAST HIM; HE DIVED
BEHIND A SLIT OF ARMOR THAT EXPLODED. HE SAW THE BROTHER AND
SISTER RUNNING DOWN THE MARBLE STAIRCASE AHEAD AND AIMED INDICES
AT THEM, BUT MERELY HIT SEVERAL BEWIGGED WITCHES IN A PORTRAIT ON
THE LANDING, WHICH RAN SCREECHING INTO NEIGHBORING PAINTINGS. AS
HE LEAPT THE WRECKAGE OF ARMOR, HARRY HEARD MORE SHOUTS AND
SCREAMS; OTHER PEOPLE WITHIN THE CASTLE SEEMED TO HAVE AWOKEN.
HE PELTED TOWARD A SHORTCUT, HOPING TO OVERTAKE THE BROTHER AND
SISTER AND CHASE IN ON SNAPE AND MALFOY, WHICH MUST SOONLY HAVE
REACHED THE GALLERIES BY NOW. REMEMBERING THE LEAP THE VANISHING
STEP HALFWAY DOWN THE CONCEALED STAIRCASE, HE CLIMBED TREMULOUSLY A
TAPESTRY AT THE RECTOR AND FELL INTO A CORRIDOR WHERE A NUMBER OF
BEWILDERED AND PALM-CLAD FLUFFYPOYS STOOD. HARRY! WE HEARD A
WHISPER, AND SOMEONE SAID SOMETHING ABOUT THE DARK MARK. BEGAN
ERNE MACMILLAN. FELL OF THE WAY? YELLED HARRY, BENDING THE
KEYS ASIDE AS HE SPRINTED TOWARD THE LANDING AND DOWN THE
REMAINDER OF THE MARBLE STAIRCASE. THE DARK FRONT DOORS HAD BEEN
BLASTED OPEN, THERE WERE SPEARS OF BLOOD ON THE FLAGSTONES, AND
SEVERAL TERRIFIED STUDENTS STOOD Huddled AGAINST THE WALLS, ONE OF
THEM STILL CHEWING WITH THEIR ARMS OVER THEIR FACES. THE GIANT

GRYPFINDER'S HELMGLASS HAD BEEN HIT BY A CURSE, AND THE RUIES
WITHIN WERE STILL FALLING, WITH A LUD RATTLE, BENTH THE FLAGSTONES
BEHIND. HARRY FLEW ACROSS THE ENTRANCE HALL AND HLT INTO THE DARK
GRHLINDS: HE HELD IUST MAKE HLT THREE FIGURES RACING ACROSS THE
LAWN, HEADING FER THE GATES BEYOND WHICH THEY HELD DISAPPARATE

BY THE WINKS OF THEM, THE FLGE BLEND DEATH LATER AND, SHEER WAY
AHEAD OF HIM, SNAPE AND MALFOY. THE CHILD NIGHT AIR RIPPED AT
HARRY'S CLOES AS HE THERE AFTER THEM; HE SAW A FLASH OF LIGHT IN
THE DISTANCE THAT MOMENTARILY SILHETTED HIS HELMARRY. HE DID NOT
KNOW WHAT IT WAS BUT CONTINUED THE RUN, NOT YET NEAR ENOUGH THE
GET A GOOD AIM WITH A CURSE. ANOTHER FLASH, SHOTS, RETALIATORY
ITS OF LIGHT, AND HARRY UNDERSTOOD: HAGRID HAD EMERGED FROM HIS
LAKIN AND WAS TRYING THE STOP THE DEATH LATER'S ESCAPING, AND
THOUGH EVERY BREATH SEEMED TO SHRED HIS CLOES AND THE STITCH IN
HIS CHEST WAS LIKE FIRE, HARRY SPED UP AS AN UNKIDEN VEHICLE IN HIS
HEAD SAID: NOT HAGRID. NOT HAGRID THEN. SOMETHING CALIGHT
HARRY HAD IN THE SMALL OF THE BACK AND HE FELL FORWARD, HIS FACE
SMACKING THE GRHLIND, BLEND FEELING HLT OF KEETHE NESTRILS: HE
KNEW, EVEN AS HE ROLLED OVER, HIS HAND READY, THAT THE BROTHER AND
SISTER HE HAD EVERTAKEN LISTING HIS SHIRTCLIT WERE CHEESING IN BEHIND
HIM. IMPEDIMENTA! HE YELLED AS HE ROLLED OVER AGAIN,

CRUELCHING CHESE THE THE DARK GRHLIND, AND MIRACULOUSLY HIS HAND
HIT ONE OF THEM, WHO STUMBLER AND FELL, TRIPPING UP THE OTHER;
HARRY LEAPT THE HIS FEET AND SPRINTED ON AFTER SNAPE, AND WHEN HE
SAW THE VAST SILTLINE OF HAGRID, ILLUMINATED BY THE LIGHT OF THE
CRESCENT MOON REVEALED SLIDDERLY BEHIND CLOES; THE BLEND DEATH
LATER WAS AIMING CURSE AFTER CURSE AT THE GAMEDKEEPER; BUT
HAGRID'S IMMENSE STRENGTH AND THE THICKENED SKIN HE HAD
INHERITED FROM HIS GIANTESS MOTHER SEEMED TO BE PROTECTING HIM.
SNAPE AND MALFOY, HOWEVER, WERE STILL RUNNING; THEY WOULD SHEER
BE BEYOND THE GATES, ABE THE DISAPPARATE. HARRY THERE PAST
HAGRID AND HIS MPPHMENT, THEIR AIM AT SNAPE'S BACK, AND YELLED,

STUPEFY! HE MISSED; THE IET OF RED LIGHT SHARED PAST SNAPE'S
HEAD; SNAPE SHELTED, RUN, BRACE! AND TURNED. TWENTY YARDS
APART, HE AND HARRY WINKED AT EACH OTHER BEFORE RAISING THEIR
HANDS SIMULTANEOUSLY. CRUK. BUT SNAPE PARRIED THE CURSE,
KNECHING HARRY BACKWARD OFF HIS FEET BEFORE HE HELD COMPLETE IT;
HARRY ROLLED OVER AND SCRAMBLER BACK UP AGAIN AS THE FLGE DEATH

LATER BEHIND HIM YELLED, INCENDIO! HARRY HEARD AN EXPLOSIVE RANG AND A DANKING STRANGE LIGHT SPILLED OVER ALL OF THEM; JACRID'S FUELISH WAS HIS FIRE. FANG'S IN THERE, VERY EVIL : JACRID KILLED.

CRACK YELLED HARRY FOR THE SECOND TIME, AIMING FOR THE FIGURE AHEAD ILLUMINATED IN THE DANKING FIRELIGHT, BUT SNAPE REJECTED THE SPELL AGAIN. HARRY COULD SEE HIM SNEERING. THE UNPREDICTABLE CURSES FROM THE, PITTER! HE SHOUTED OVER THE GLISTENING OF THE FLAMES, JACRID'S YELLS, AND THE WILD YELPING OF THE TRAPPED FANG.

THEY HAVEN'T GOT THE NERVE FOR THE ABILITY INKAR HARRY REARED, BUT SNAPE DEFLECTED THE SPELL WITH AN ALMOST LAZY FLICK OF HIS ARM. FIGHT BACK! HARRY SCREAMED AT HIM. FIGHT BACK, THE CHALLENGE CHALLENGED CHALLENGED, DID YOU CALL ME, PITTER? SHOUTED SNAPE.

YOUR FATHER WOULD NEVER ATTACK ME UNLESS IT WAS YOUR OWN HONOR, WHAT WOULD YOU CALL HIM, I WONDER? STUPID KICKED AGAIN AND AGAIN AND AGAIN UNTIL YOU LEARN THE DEEP YOUR MOUTH-SHOUT AND YOUR MIND CHASED, PITTER! SNEERED SNAPE, DEFLECTING THE CURSE HENCE MORE. WHY COME! HE SHOUTED AT THE FLYING DEATH LATER BEHIND HARRY. IT IS TIME TO BE GONE, BEFORE THE MINISTRY TURNS UP

IMPED BUT BEFORE HE COULD FINISH THIS LONG, EXHAUSTING PAIN HIT HARRY; HE DROPPED OVER IN THE GRASS. SOMEONE WAS SCREAMING, HE WOULD SURELY DIE OF THIS AGONY, SNAPE WAS CHING THE THREATENING HIM THE DEATH FOR MADNESS THE REARED SNAPE'S WHILE AND THE PAIN STOPPED AS SUDDENLY AS IT HAD STARTED; HARRY LAY CLIMBED IN THE DARK GRASS, CLUTCHING HIS WAND AND PANTING; SOMEWHERE OVERHEAD SNAPE WAS SHOUTING, HAVE YOU FORGOTTEN YOUR HONORS? PITTER KEEPS THE DARK LORD WE ARE THE LEAVE HIM! GO! GO! AND HARRY FELT THE GRUELING SLIDDER UNDER HIS FACE AS THE BROTHER AND SISTER AND THE ENORMOUS DEATH LATER BEYOND, RUNNING TOWARD THE GATES. HARRY LITTERED AN INARTICULATE YELL OF RAGE! IN THAT INSTANT, HE CARED NOT WHETHER HE LIVED OR DIED. PUSHING HIMSELF TO HIS FEET AGAIN, HE STAGGERED BLINDLY TOWARD SNAPE, THE MAN HE NOW HATED AS MUCH AS HE HATED HIMSELF. SETTLING : SNAPE FLICKED HIS WAND AND THE CURSE WAS REPELLED YET AGAIN; BUT HARRY WAS FEET AWAY NOW AND HE COULD SEE SNAPE'S FACE CLEARLY AT LAST! HE WAS NO LONGER SNEERING OR JEERING; THE BLAZING FLAMES SHOWED A FACE FULL OF RAGE, GLISTENING ALL HIS FEELERS OF CONCENTRATION, HARRY THOUGHT, LEVI THE PITTER! SCREAMED SNAPE. THERE WAS A BLIND RAGE AND HARRY WAS

SHARING BACKWARD, HITTING THE GREHLIND HARD AGAIN, AND THIS TIME HIS WAND FLEW OUT OF HIS HAND. HE COULD HEAR HAGRID YELLING AND FANG WHINING AS SNAPE CHASED IN AND LUNGED DOWN ON HIM WHERE HE LAY, HANDLESS AND DEFENSELESS AS DUMBLEDORE HAD BEEN. SNAPE'S PALE FACE, ILLUMINATED BY THE FLAMING CROWN, WAS SUPPLISHED WITH HATRED JUST AS IT HAD BEEN BEFORE HE HAD CHASED DUMBLEDORE. WHY DARE USE MY OWN SPELLS AGAINST ME, PETER? IT WAS I WHO INVENTED THEM. I, THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE! AND WHY DO I TURN MY INVENTIONS ON ME, LIKE YOUR FILTHY FATHER, WHO'D YOU? I DON'T THINK SHE NEEDS. HARRY HAD DIVED FOR HIS WAND; SNAPE SAW A FLASH AT IT AND IT FLEW FEET AWAY INTO THE DARKNESS AND OUT OF SIGHT. KILL ME THEN, PANTED HARRY, WHO FELT NO FEAR AT ALL, BUT ONLY RAGE AND CONTEMPT. KILL ME LIKE YOU KILLED HIM, YOU COWARD. THEN IT SCREAMED SNAPE, AND HIS FACE WAS SUDDENLY DEMENTED, INHUMAN, AS THOUGH HE WAS IN AS MUCH PAIN AS THE YELPING, WHINING BEAST STUCK IN THE BURNING HEATH BEHIND THEM. CALL ME COWARD! AND HE SLASHED AT THE AIR; HARRY FELT A WHITE-HEAT, WHIPLIKE SOMETHING HIT HIM ACROSS THE FACE AND WAS SLAMMED BACKWARD INTO THE GREHLIND. SPOTS OF LIGHT BURST IN FRONT OF HIS EYES AND FOR A MOMENT ALL THE BREATH SEEMED TO HAVE GONE FROM HIS BODY, THEN HE HEARD A RUSH OF WINGS ABOVE HIM AND SOMETHING ENORMOUS ENVELOPED THE STARS. BLACKBEARD HAD FLEW AT SNAPE, WHO STAGGERED BACKWARD AS THE RAZOR-SHARP CLAWS SLASHED AT HIM, AS HARRY RAISED HIMSELF INTO A SITTING POSITION, HIS HEAD STILL SWIMMING FROM ITS LAST CONTACT WITH THE GREHLIND, HE SAW SNAPE RUNNING AS FAST AS HE COULD, THE ENORMOUS BEAST FLAPPING BEHIND HIM AND SCREECHING AS HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD HIM SCREECH. HARRY STRUGGLED TO HIS FEET, LUNGING AHEAD GREGGILY FOR HIS WAND, HOPING TO GIVE CHASE AGAIN, BUT EVEN AS HIS FINGERS FLIMMERED IN THE GRASS, DISCARDING TWIGS, HE KNEW IT WOULD BE TOO LATE, AND SURE ENOUGH, BY THE TIME HE HAD LOCATED HIS WAND, HE TURNED ONLY TO SEE THE HIPPOGRYFF CIRCLING THE GATES. SNAPE HAD MANAGED TO DISAPPEAR JUST BEFORE THE SCREAMING BEHINDARIES. HAGRID, MUTTERED HARRY, STILL DAZED, LUNGING AHEAD. HAGRID? HE STUMBLERED TOWARD THE BURNING HEATH AS AN ENORMOUS FIGURE EMERGED FROM OUT OF THE FLAMES CARRYING FANG ON HIS BACK. WITH A CRY OF TERRIFIEDNESS, HARRY SAWED TO HIS KNEES; HE WAS SHAKING IN EVERY LIMB, HIS BODY ACHED ALL OVER, AND HIS BREATH CAME IN PAINFUL STABS. YES ALL RIGHT, HARRY? YES ALL RIGHT? SPEAK

TER ME, HARRY. HAGRID'S FLICK-HAIRY FACE WAS SMILING ABOVE
HARRY, BLINKING HEAT THE STARS. HARRY COULD FEEL BLUNT WIND AND
DHC HAIR. HE PUT HEAT A HAND AND FELT PANG'S REASSURINGLY WARM
AND ALIVE KID'S HOLYERING RESIDE HIM. I'M ALL RIGHT, PANTED HARRY.

ARE YOU? COURSE I AM TAKE MEIN IN THAT TER FINISH ME.
HAGRID PUT HIS HANDS UNDER HARRY'S ARMS AND RAISED HIM UP WITH
SUCH FORCE THAT HARRY'S FEET MOMENTARILY LEFT THE GRILING KEITH
HAGRID SET HIM UPRIGHT AGAIN. HE COULD SEE BLIND TRICKLING DOWN
HAGRID'S CHEEK FROM A DEEP CUT UNDER ONE EYE, WHICH WAS SWELLING
RAPIDLY. WE SHOULD PUT HEAT YOUR HEISE, SAID HARRY, THE
CHARM'S AGUMENTI KNEW IT WAS SUPPAT LIKE THAT,
MILKED HAGRID, AND HE RAISED A SMOLDERING PINK, FLICKERY LAMPRELLA
AND SAID, AGUMENTI! A LOT OF WATER FLEW HEAT OF THE LAMPRELLA TIP,
HARRY RAISED HIS HAND ARM, WHICH FELT LIKE LEAD, AND MILKED

AGUMENTI THEM. TOGETHER, HE AND HAGRID PULSED WATER IN THE
HEISE UNTIL THE LAST FLAME WAS EXTINGUISHED. I MEET THEM BAD, SAID
HAGRID HOPEFULLY A FEW MINUTES LATER, BLINKING AT THE SMOKING
WRECK. WITHIN DUMBLEDORE WHEN HE ABLE TO PUT RIGHT HARRY
FELT A SEARING PAIN IN HIS STOMACH AT THE SOUND OF THE NAME. IN
THE SILENCE AND THE STILLNESS, HEARD HER INSIDE HIM. HAGRID

I WAS KINDIN UP A CHURCH IN BENTRICKS LEGS WHEN I HEARD EM
CHIN, SAID HAGRID SADLY, STILL STARING AT HIS WRECKED CABIN.
THEY LL BE KIN BLUNT TER TWIGS, FEWER LITTLE THINGS. HAGRID
BUT WHAT HAPPENED, HARRY? I LL SAW THEM DEATH EATERS
BLINDIN DOWN FROM THE CASTLE, BUT WHAT THE RIDDY HELL WAS SNAPE
DOWN WITH EM WHERE'S HE GONE WAS HE CHASIN THEM? HE
HARRY CLEARED HIS THROAT; IT WAS DRY FROM PANIC AND THE SMOKE.

HAGRID, HE KILLED KILLED? SAID HAGRID HEILY, STARING DOWN
AT HARRY. SNAPE KILLED? WHAT RE YOU HEIN ASKIN, HARRY?
DUMBLEDORE, SAID HARRY. SNAPE KILLED DUMBLEDORE. HAGRID
SIMPLY BLINKED AT HIM, THE LITTLE OF HIS FACE THAT COULD BE SEEN
COMPLETELY BLANK, UNCOMPREHENDING. DUMBLEDORE WHA, HARRY?
HE'S DEAD, SNAPE KILLED HIM. THEN SAY THAT, SAID HAGRID
RELIGIOUSLY. SNAPE KILL DUMBLEDORE THEN BE STUPID, HARRY, WHA'S
MADE YOU SAY THAT? I SAW IT HAPPEN. YOU COULDN'T HAVE. I SAW
IT, HAGRID. HAGRID SHOOK HIS HEAD; HIS EXPRESSION WAS
DISBELIEVING BUT SYMPATHETIC, AND HARRY KNEW THAT HAGRID
THOUGHT HE HAD SUSTAINED A BLEW TO THE HEAD, THAT HE WAS

CONVULSED, PERHAPS BY THE AFTEREFFECTS OF A HIND. WHAT MUSTA
HAPPENED WAS, DIMPLEDHERE MUSTA THED SNARE TER GH WITH THEM
DEATH EATERS. FJAGRID SAID CONFIDENTLY, I SUPPOSE HE S GETTA DEEP
HIS CHEER. LHHH, LET S GET YEH BACK UP TER THE SCHEHH. CHMP HN,
FJARRY. FJARRY DID NEET ATTEMPT THE ARGUE HER EXPLAIN. HE WAS
STILL SHAKING UNCONTROLLABLY. FJAGRID WOULD FIND HLT SHEEN
ENHUGH, THE SHEEN. AS THEY DIRECTED THEIR STEPS BACK TOWARD THE
CASTLE, FJARRY SAW THAT MANY OF ITS WINDMILLS WERE LIT NHH. HE COULD
IMAGINE, CLEARLY, THE SCENES INSIDE AS PEOPLE MOVED FROM ROOM TO
ROOM, TELLING EACH OTHER THAT DEATH EATERS HAD GET IN, THAT THE
MARD WAS SHINING EVER FJELHARTS, THAT SOMEONE MUST HAVE BEEN
KILLED. THE HAD FRONT DOORS STOOD OPEN AHEAD OF THEM, LIGHT
FLOODING HLT INTO THE DRIVE AND THE LAWN. SLEELY, UNCERTAINLY,
DRESSING-GOWNED PEOPLE WERE CREEPING BEHIN THE STEPS, WHISPERING
AROUND NERVOUSLY FOR SOME SIGN OF THE DEATH EATERS WHO HAD FLED
INTO THE NIGHT. FJARRY S EYES, HOWEVER, WERE FIXED UPON THE
GROUNDS AT THE FOOT OF THE TALLEST TOWER. HE IMAGINED THAT HE COULD
SEE A BLACK, HILDED MASS LYING IN THE GRASS THERE, THOUGH HE WAS
REALLY THE FAR AWAY TO SEE ANYTHING OF THE SORT. EVEN AS HE STARED
WORDLESSLY AT THE PLACE WHERE HE THOUGHT DIMPLEDHERE S BODY MUST
LIE, HOWEVER, HE SAW PEOPLE BEGINNING TO MOVE TOWARD IT. WHAT RE
THEY ALL WHISPERING AT? SAID FJAGRID, AS HE AND FJARRY APPROACHED THE
CASTLE FRONT, FANG KEEPING AS CLOSE AS HE COULD TO THEIR ANKLES.

WHAT S THAT, LYIN HN THE GRASS? FJAGRID ADDED SHARPLY, HEADING
NOW TOWARD THE FOOT OF THE ASTROPHORY TOWER, WHERE A SMALL
CROWD WAS GATHERING. SEE IT, FJARRY? RIGHT AT THE FOOT OF THE
TOWER? UNDER WHERE THE MARD BLIMEY YEH BEEN THIND
SOMEONE GET TOWARD ? FJAGRID FELL SILENT, THE THOUGHT
APPARENTLY THE TERRIBLE THE EXPRESS AHEAD. FJARRY WALKED
ALONGSIDE HIM, FEELING THE ACRES AND PAINS IN HIS FACE AND HIS LEGS
WHERE THE VARIOUS BLOWS OF THE LAST HALF HOUR HAD HIT HIM,
THOUGH IN AN EDDY DETACHED WAY, AS THOUGH SOMEONE NEAR HIM
WAS SLIPPING THEM. WHAT WAS REAL AND INESCAPABLE WAS THE AWFUL
PRESSING FEELING IN HIS CHEST. HE AND FJAGRID MOVED, DREAMLIKE,
THROUGH THE MURMURING CROWD TO THE VERY FRONT, WHERE THE
DIMPSTRIKE STUDENTS AND TEACHERS HAD LEFT A GAP. FJARRY HEARD
FJAGRID S MURMUR OF PAIN AND SILENCE, BUT HE DID NOT STOP; HE WALKED
SLEELY FORWARD UNTIL HE REACHED THE PLACE WHERE DIMPLEDHERE LAY

AND CRUMBLING DOWN BESIDE HIM. HE HAD KNOWN THERE WAS NO HOPE FROM THE MOMENT THAT THE SMALL BODY-KIND CLING DUMKLEHIRE HAD PLACED UPON HIM LIFTED, KNOWN THAT IT COULD HAVE HAPPENED ONLY BECAUSE ITS MASTER WAS DEAD, BUT THERE WAS STILL NO PREPARATION FOR SEEING HIM HERE, SPREAD-EAGLED, KNOWN: THE GREATEST WIZARD HARRY HAD EVER, HIS WOULD EVER, MEET. DUMKLEHIRE'S EYES WERE CLOSED, BUT FOR THE STRANGE ANGLE OF HIS ARMS AND LEGS, HE MIGHT HAVE BEEN SLEEPING. HARRY REACHED OUT, STRAIGHTENED THE FALLEN SPECTACLES UPON THE CRUMBLING NOSE, AND WIPED A TRICKLE OF BLOOD FROM THE MOUTH WITH HIS OWN SLEEVE. THEN HE GAZED DOWN AT THE WISE OLD FACE AND TRIED TO ASSESS THE ENORMOUS AND INCOMPREHENSIBLE TRUTH: THAT NEVER AGAIN WOULD DUMKLEHIRE SPEAK TO HIM, NEVER AGAIN COULD HE HELP.

THE CHILD MURMURED BEHIND HARRY. AFTER WHAT SEEMED LIKE A LONG TIME, HE BECAME AWARE THAT HE WAS KNEELING UPON SOMETHING HARD AND LINED DOWN. THE BUCKET THEY HAD MANAGED TO STEAL SHE MANY HOURS BEFORE HAD FALLEN OUT OF DUMKLEHIRE'S POCKET. IT HAD OPENED, PERHAPS DUE TO THE FORCE WITH WHICH IT HIT THE GROUND, AND ALTHOUGH HE COULD NOT FEEL MORE THAN HIS OWN SADNESS THAN HE FELT ALREADY, HARRY KNEW, AS HE PICKED IT UP, THAT THERE WAS SOMETHING WRONG. HE TURNED THE BUCKET OVER IN HIS HANDS. THIS WAS NEITHER AS LARGE AS THE BUCKET HE REMEMBERED SEEING IN THE PENITENT, NOR WERE THERE ANY MARKINGS UPON IT, NO SIGN OF THE MARK THAT WAS SLIPPED TO BE SLYTHERIN'S MARK. HOWEVER, THERE WAS NOTHING INSIDE BUT FOR A STRAP OF OLD PARCHMENT WEDGED TIGHTLY INTO THE PLACE WHERE A PORTRAIT SHOULD HAVE BEEN. AUTOMATICALLY, WITHOUT REALLY THINKING ABOUT WHAT HE WAS DOING, HARRY PULLED OUT THE FRAGMENT OF PARCHMENT, OPENED IT, AND READ BY THE LIGHT OF THE MANY CANDLES THAT HAD BEEN KEPT LIT BEHIND HIM: HARRY NEITHER KNEW NOR CARED WHAT THE MESSAGE MEANT. ONLY ONE THING MATTERED: THIS WAS NOT A JOKE. DUMKLEHIRE HAD WEAKENED HIMSELF BY DRINKING THAT TERRIBLE POISON FOR NOTHING. HARRY CRUMPLED THE PARCHMENT IN HIS HAND, AND HIS EYES FILLED WITH TEARS AS BEHIND HIM FANG BEGAN TO HOWL. THE PHOENIX LAMENT [HERE, HARRY NO.

YOU CAN STAY HERE, HARRY. COME ON, NOW. NO. HE DID NOT WANT TO LEAVE DUMKLEHIRE'S SIDE, HE DID NOT WANT TO MOVE ANYWHERE. HAGRID'S HAND ON HIS SHOULDER WAS TREMBLING. THEN ANOTHER VOICE SAID, HARRY, COME ON. A MUCH SMALLER AND WARMER HAND HAD

ENCLOSED HIS AND WAS PULLING HIM UPWARD. HE KEPT ITS PRESSURE WITHHOLD REALLY THINKING ABOUT IT. ONLY AS HE WALKED BLINDLY BACK THROUGH THE CORRIDOR DID HE REALIZE, FROM A TRACE OF SWIFT SCENT IN THE AIR, THAT IT WAS CINDY WHO WAS LEADING HIM BACK INTO THE CASTLE. INCOMPREHENSIBLE VOICES BATTERED HIM, SHES AND SHUTS AND NAILS STABBED THE NIGHT, BUT HARRY AND CINDY WALKED ON, BACK UP THE STEPS INTO THE ENTRANCE HALL. FACES SWAM IN THE EDGES OF HARRY'S VISION, PEOPLE WERE PEERING AT HIM, WHISPERING, WHISPERING, AND GRYFFINDOR RUMORS GLISTENED IN THE FLICKER LIKE DRIPS OF BLOOD AS THEY MADE THEIR WAY TOWARD THE MARBLE STAIRCASE.

WE'RE GOING TO THE HOSPITAL WING, SAID CINDY. I'M NOT FLIRT, SAID HARRY. IT'S MCGONAGALL'S ORDERS, SAID CINDY. EVERYTHING'S UP THERE, RON AND HERMION AND LUPIN AND EVERYONE. FEAR STIRRED IN HARRY'S CHEST AGAIN: HE HAD FORGOTTEN THE INERT FIGURES HE HAD LEFT BEHIND. CINDY, WHO ELSE IS DEAD? DON'T WHISKY, NONE OF US. BUT THE DARK MARCH MALFOY SAID HE STOPPED EVER A BODY. HE STOPPED EVER BILL, BUT IT'S ALL RIGHT, HE'S ALIVE.

THERE WAS SOMETHING IN HER VOICE, HOWEVER, THAT HARRY KNEW SOUNDED ILL. ARE YOU SURE? OF COURSE I'M SURE. HE'S A KIT OF A MESS, THAT'S ALL. CREEPBACK ATTACKED HIM, MADAM POMFREY SAYS HE WHEN T. WHEN T. WHEN T. THE SAME ANYWHERE. CINDY'S VOICE TREMBLED A LITTLE.

WE DON'T REALLY KNOW WHAT THE AFTEREFFECTS WILL BE. I MEAN, CREEPBACK BEING A WEREWOLF, BUT NOT TRANSFORMED AT THE TIME. BUT THE OTHERS. THERE WERE OTHER BODIES IN THE CORRIDOR. NEVILLE AND PROFESSOR FLITWICK ARE BOTH FLIRT, BUT MADAM POMFREY SAYS THEY'LL BE ALL RIGHT. AND A DEATH EATER'S DEAD, HE GET HIT BY A KILLING CURSE THAT FELICE BLEND HINE WAS FIRING OFF EVERYWHERE.

HARRY, IF WE HADN'T HAD YELLER FELIX PHOTON, I THINK WE'D ALL HAVE BEEN KILLED, BUT EVERYTHING SEEMED THE LIST MISS US. THEY HAD REACHED THE HOSPITAL WING, PUSHING OPEN THE DOORS, HARRY SAW NEVILLE LYING, APPARENTLY ASLEEP, IN A BED NEAR THE DOOR. RON, HERMION, LUNA, TENDS, AND LUPIN WERE GATHERED AROUND ANOTHER BED NEAR THE FAR END OF THE WARD. AT THE SOUND OF THE DOORS OPENING, THEY ALL LOOKED UP. HERMION RAN TO HARRY AND HUGGED HIM; LUPIN MOVED FORWARD THEN, LOOKING ANXIOUS.

ARE YOU ALL RIGHT, HARRY? I'M FINE. FELIX'S KILL? NEARLY ANSWERED, HARRY LOOKED OVER HERMION'S SHOULDER AND SAW AN UNRECOGNIZABLE FACE LYING IN BILL'S PILLOW, SHE EASILY SLASHED AND

RIPPED THAT HE WISHED CRISTENHLE, MADAM PEMFREY WAS DARING AT HIS WOUNDS WITH SOME HARSH-SPELLING GREEN OINTMENT. HARRY REMEMBERED WHEN SNAPE HAD MENDED MALFOY'S SEPTUAGINTA WOUNDS SO EASILY WITH HIS HAND. CAN'T YOU FIX THEM WITH A CHARM OR SOMETHING? HE ASKED THE MATRON. NO CHARM WILL WORK ON THESE, SAID MADAM PEMFREY. I'VE TRIED EVERYTHING I KNOW, BUT THERE IS NO CLUE FOR WEREWOLF BITES. BUT HE WASN'T BITTEN AT THE FULL MOON, SAID RON, WHO WAS GAZING DOWN INTO HIS BROTHER'S FACE AS THOUGH HE COULD SOMEHOW SENSE HIM THE MEND INST BY STARING.

GRYFFINDOR HADN'T TRANSFORMED, SHE SURELY KNEW WHEN TO BE A REAL ? HE WISHED UNCERTAINLY AT LUPIN. NO, I DON'T THINK THAT KILL WILL BE A TRUE WEREWOLF, SAID LUPIN, BUT THAT DOES NOT MEAN THAT THERE WON'T BE SOME CONTAMINATION. THESE ARE CURSED WOUNDS. THEY ARE LIKELY EVER TO HEAL FULLY, AND AND KILL MIGHT HAVE SOME WOLFISH CHARACTERISTICS FROM NOW ON.

OLIMPIUS MIGHT KNOW SOMETHING THAT I DON'T, THOUGH, RON SAID. WHERE IS HE? KILL MIGHT THINK MANIACS ARE OLIMPIUS'S HOUNDS, OLIMPIUS HATES HIM, HE CAN'T LEAVE HIM IN THIS STATE

RON OLIMPIUS IS DEAD, SAID GINNY. NO? LUPIN WISHED WILDLY FROM GINNY TO HARRY, AS THOUGH HOPING THE LATTER MIGHT CONTRADICT HER, BUT WHEN HARRY DID NOT, LUPIN COLLAPSED INTO A CHAIR BESIDE KILL'S BED, HIS HANDS OVER HIS FACE. HARRY HAD NEVER SEEN LUPIN LIKE THAT BEFORE; HE FELT AS THOUGH HE WAS INTRUDING UPON SOMETHING PRIVATE, INDICENT. HE TURNED AWAY AND CALLED RON'S EYE INSTEAD, EXCHANGING IN SILENCE A LOOK THAT CONFIRMED WHAT GINNY HAD SAID. HOW DID HE DIE? WHISPERED TONKS. HOW DID IT HAPPEN? SNAPE KILLED HIM, SAID HARRY. I WAS THERE, I SAW IT. WE ARRIVED BACK ON THE ASTROPHYSICAL TOWER BECAUSE THAT'S WHERE THE MARK WAS. OLIMPIUS WAS ILL, HE WAS WEAK, BUT I THINK HE REALIZED IT WAS A TRAP WHEN WE HEARD FOOTSTEPS RUNNING UP THE STAIRS. HE IMMobilIZED ME, I COULDN'T DO ANYTHING, I WAS UNDER THE INVISIBILITY CLOAK AND THEN MALFOY CAME THROUGH THE DOOR AND DISARMED HIM. HERMION CLAPPED HER HANDS TO HER MOUTH AND RON GRIEVED, LUNA'S MOUTH TREMBLED.

MORE DEATH EATERS ARRIVED AND THEN SNAPE AND SNAPE DID IT. THE AVADA KEDAVRA. HARRY COULDN'T SEE HIM. MADAM PEMFREY BURST INTO TEARS. NERVOUSLY PAID HER ANY ATTENTION EXCEPT GINNY, WHO WHISPERED, SHE'S LISTENING. CLIPPING, MADAM PEMFREY PRESSED

HER FINGERS THE HER MOUTH, HER EYES WIDE. SOMEWHERE OUT IN THE DARKNESS, A PHOENIX WAS SINGING IN A WAY HARRY HAD NEVER HEARD BEFORE: A STRICKEN LAMENT OF TERRIBLE REALITY. AND HARRY FELT, AS HE HAD FELT ABOUT PHOENIX SONG BEFORE, THAT THE MUSIC WAS INSIDE HIM, NOT WITH HIM: IT WAS HIS OWN GRIEF TURNED MAGICALLY THE SONG THAT REACHED ACROSS THE GREENS AND THROUGH THE CASTLE WINDOWS. FEELING THEY ALL STOOD THERE, LISTENING, HE DID NOT KNOW, NOR WHY IT SEEMED THE CASE THEIR PAIN A LITTLE THE LISTEN THE THE SOUND OF THEIR MOURNING, BUT IT FELT LIKE A LONG TIME LATER THAT THE HOSPITAL DOOR OPENED AGAIN AND PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL ENTERED THE WARD, LIKE ALL THE REST, SHE BORE MARKS OF THE RECENT BATTLE: THERE WERE GRAZES ON HER FACE AND HER REEKS WERE RIPPED. MELLY AND ARTHUR ARE ON THEIR WAY, SHE SAID, AND THE SPELL OF THE MUSIC WAS BROKEN: EVERYONE RELEASED THEMSELVES AS THOUGH CHIMING OUT OF TRANCES, TURNING AGAIN THE LOOK AT BILL, HER ELSE THE RISE THEIR OWN EYES, SHAKE THEIR HEADS. HARRY, WHAT HAPPENED? ACCORDING TO HAGRID THEY WERE WITH PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WHEN HE WHEN IT HAPPENED, HE SAYS PROFESSOR SNAPE WAS INVOLVED IN SOME SNAPE KILLED DUMBLEDORE, SAID HARRY. SHE STARED AT HIM FOR A MOMENT, THEN SWAYED ALARMINGLY; MADAM PUMFREY, WHO SEEMED TO HAVE PLUCKED HERSELF TOGETHER, RAN FORWARD, CHAIRING A CHAIR FROM THE AIR, WHICH SHE PLUSHED UNDER MCGONAGALL. SNAPE, REPEATED MCGONAGALL FAINTLY, FALLING INTO THE CHAIR. WE ALL WHISPERED BUT HE TRUSTED ALWAYS SNAPE I CAN'T BELIEVE IT.

SNAPE WAS A HIGHLY ACCOMPLISHED MAGICIANS, SAID LUPIN, HIS VOICE UNCHARACTERISTICALLY HARSH. WE ALWAYS KNEW THAT, BUT DUMBLEDORE WHERE HE WAS ON HIS SIDE? WE WHISPERED THINGS. I ALWAYS THOUGHT DUMBLEDORE MUST KNOW SOMETHING ABOUT SNAPE THAT WE DIDN'T. HE ALWAYS HINTED THAT HE HAD AN IRRECLAD REASON FOR TRUSTING SNAPE, MUTTERED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, NEW DAKING AT THE CORNERS OF HER LEADING EYES WITH A TARTAN-EDGED HANDKERCHIEF.

I MEAN WITH SNAPE'S HISTORY OF CHILD PEOPLE WERE BEHIND THE WHISPER BUT DUMBLEDORE TOLD ME EXPLICITLY THAT SNAPE'S REPENTANCE WAS ABSOLUTELY GENUINE. WE DIDN'T HEAR A WORD AGAINST HIM: I'D LOVE TO KNOW WHAT SNAPE TOLD HIM TO CONVINC HIM, SAID THINGS. I KNOW, SAID HARRY, AND THEY ALL TURNED THE LOOK AT HIM. SNAPE PASSED VERBEMENT THE INFORMATION THAT MADE VERBEMENT FLINT BEHIND MY MOM AND DAD. THEN SNAPE TOLD

BLURPLEDHEERE HE HADN'T REALIZED WHAT HE WAS DOING, HE WAS REALLY
SHARRY HE'D DONE IT, SHARRY THAT THEY WERE DEAD. THEY ALL STARED AT
HIM. AND BLURPLEDHEERE BELIEVED THAT? SAID LUPIN INCREDBLY.

BLURPLEDHEERE BELIEVED SNAPE WAS SHARRY JAMES WAS DEAD? SNAPE HATED
JAMES. AND HE DIDN'T THINK MY MOTHER WAS WORTH A DAMN

EITHER, SAID HARRY, BECAUSE SHE WAS MUGGLE-BORN. MURDERED,
HE CALLED HER. NEHEEDY ASKED WHEN HARRY KNEW THIS, ALL OF THEM

SEEMED TO BE LOST IN HORRIFIED SILENCE, TRYING TO DIGEST THE
MINUTIAE TRUTH OF WHAT HAD HAPPENED. THIS IS ALL MY FAULT,

SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SUDDENLY. SHE LOOKED DISORIENTED,
TWISTING HER WET HANDKERCHIEF IN HER HANDS. MY FAULT, I SENT

FILIBUS TO FETCH SNAPE TONIGHT, I ACTUALLY SENT HIM HIM THE CUP AND
HELP US! IF I HADN'T ALERTED SNAPE TO WHAT WAS GOING ON, HE MIGHT

NEVER HAVE IMAGINED THINGS WITH THE DEATH EATERS, I DIDN'T THINK HE
KNEW THEY WERE THERE BEFORE FILIBUS TOLD HIM, I DIDN'T THINK HE KNEW

THEY WERE COMING. IT ISN'T YOUR FAULT, MINERVA, SAID LUPIN
FIRMLY. WE ALL WANTED MORE HELP, WE WERE GLAD TO THINK SNAPE WAS

ON HIS WAY. SHE WHEN HE ARRIVED AT THE FIGHT, HE IMAGINED IN HIM
THE DEATH EATERS SIDE? ASKED HARRY, WE WANTED EVERY DETAIL OF

SNAPE'S DILIGENCE AND INFAITH, FEVERISHLY COLLECTING MORE REASONS
TO HATE HIM, THE SWEAR VENGEANCE. I DIDN'T KNOW EXACTLY WHEN IT

HAPPENED, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DISTRACTEDLY. IT'S ALL SHE
CONSIDERING. BLURPLEDHEERE HAD TOLD US THAT HE WOULD BE LEAVING THE

SCHOOL FOR A FEW HOURS AND THAT WE WERE TO PATROL THE CORRIDORS
JUST IN CASE REMUS, BILL, AND SYMPHONY WERE THE IMAGINING

AND SHE WAS PATROLLING, ALL SEEMED QUIET, EVERY SECRET PASSAGEWAY HILT
OF THE SCHOOL WAS COVERED, WE KNEW NEHEEDY COULD FLY IN, THERE

WERE PLETHORIC ENCHANTMENTS AND EVERY ENTRANCE INTO THE CASTLE, I
STILL DIDN'T KNOW WHEN THE DEATH EATERS COULD POSSIBLY HAVE ENTERED.

I DO, SAID HARRY, AND HE EXPLAINED, BRIEFLY, ABOUT THE PAIR OF
VANISHING CABINETS AND THE MAGICAL PATHWAY THEY FORMED. SHE

THEY GOT IN THROUGH THE ROOM OF REQUIREMENT. ALMOST AGAINST
HIS WILL HE GLANCED FROM WHEN THE HERMITAGE, KEITH OF WHEN LOOKED

DEVASTATED. I MESSED UP, HARRY, SAID WHEN CLEARLY. WE DID LIKE WHEN
TOLD US! WE CHECKED THE MARAUDER'S MAP AND WE COULDN'T SEE

MALPHEUS IN IT, SHE WAS THOUGHT HE MUST BE IN THE ROOM OF
REQUIREMENT, SHE ME, GINNY, AND NEVILLE WENT TO KEEP WATCH IN IT

BUT MALPHEUS GOT PAST US. HE CAME HILT OF THE ROOM ABOUT AN

FEELER AFTER WE STARTED KEEPING WATCH, SAID GINNY, HE WAS IN HIS
ELBOW, CLUTCHING THAT AWFUL SHRIVELED ARM HIS HAND OF
GLORY, SAID RHN. GIVES LIGHT ONLY THE THE FEELER, REMEMBER?

ANYWAY, GINNY WENT ON, HE MUST HAVE BEEN CHECKING WHETHER
THE CHAST WAS CLEAR THE LET THE DEATH EATERS BLIT, BECAUSE THE
MOMENT HE SAW US HE THREW SOMETHING INTO THE AIR AND IT ALL WENT
PITCH-BLACK

PERUVIAN INSTANT DARKNESS FEELER, SAID
RHN BITTERLY, FRED AND GEORGE S, I M GOING THE BE HAVING A WORD
WITH THEM ABOUT WHEN THEY LET BUY THEIR PRODUCTS, WE TRIED
EVERYTHING, FLAMES, INCENDIE, SAID GINNY, NOTHING WOULD
PENETRATE THE DARKNESS, ALL WE COULD DO WAS GRASP EACH OTHER AND BLIT IN
THE CORRIDOR AGAIN, AND MEANTHILE WE COULD HEAR PEOPLE RUSHING
PAST US, HEVILISLY MALPHY COULD SEE BECAUSE OF THAT HAND THING
AND WAS GUIDING THEM, BUT WE DIDN T DARE USE ANY CURSES OR
ANYTHING IN CASE WE HIT EACH OTHER, AND BY THE TIME WE D REACHED A
CORRIDOR THAT WAS LIGHT, THEY D GO. LUCKILY, SAID BLIPIN

HEARSELY, RHN, GINNY, AND NEVILLE RAN INTO US ALMOST
IMMEDIATELY AND TOLD US WHAT HAD HAPPENED, WE FEELING THE DEATH
EATERS MINUTES LATER, HEADING IN THE DIRECTION OF THE ASTROPHONY
TOWER, MALPHY HEVILISLY HADN T EXPECTED MORE PEOPLE TO BE IN
THE WATCH, HE SEEMED TO HAVE EXHAUSTED HIS SUPPLY OF DARKNESS
FEELER, AT ANY RATE, A FIGHT BROKE OUT, THEY SCATTERED AND WE GAVE
CHASE, FIVE OF THEM, GIKKEN, BROKE AWAY AND HEADED UP THE TOWER
STAIRS

THE SET OFF THE MARK? ASKED HARRY, HE MUST HAVE
BEEN, YES, THEY MUST HAVE ARRANGED THAT BEFORE THEY LEFT THE ROOM
OF REQUIREMENT, SAID BLIPIN, BUT I DONT THINK GIKKEN LIKED THE
IDEA OF WAITING UP THERE ALONE FOR DUMBLEDORE, BECAUSE HE CAME
RUNNING BACK DOWNSTAIRS TO REJOIN THE FIGHT AND WAS HIT BY A
KILLING CURSE THAT JUST MISSED ME. SEE IF RHN WAS WATCHING THE
ROOM OF REQUIREMENT WITH GINNY AND NEVILLE, SAID HARRY,
TURNING THE HERMION, WERE YOU ? ELTISIDE SNAPE S OFFICE,
YES, WE WHISPERED HERMION, HER EYES SPARKLING WITH TEARS, WITH
LUNA, WE FLYING AROUND FOR AGES ELTISIDE IT AND NOTHING HAPPENED.

WE DIDN T KNOW WHAT WAS GOING ON UPSTAIRS, RHN HAD TAKEN
THE MAP. IT WAS NEARLY MIDNIGHT WHEN PROFESSOR FLITWICK CAME
SPRINTING DOWN INTO THE DUNGEONS, HE WAS SHOOTING ABOUT DEATH
EATERS IN THE CASTLE, I DONT THINK HE REALLY REGISTERED THAT LUNA
AND I WERE THERE AT ALL, HE JUST BLURST HIS WAY INTO SNAPE S OFFICE

AND WE HEARD HIM SAYING THAT SNAPE HAD THE CHEE BACK WITH HIM AND
HELP AND THEN WE HEARD A HEAVY THUMP AND SNAPE CAME FLYING
HIT BY HIS REINS AND HE SAW US AND WHAT? HARRY
URGED HER. I WAS SHE STUPID, HARRY? SAID HERMION IN A HIGH-
PITCHED WHISPER. HE SAID PROFESSOR FLITWICK HAD COLLAPSED AND
THAT WE SHOULD GO AND TAKE CARE OF HIM WHILE HE WHILE HE WENT
TO HELP FIGHT THE DEATH EATERS SHE COVERED HER FACE IN SHAME
AND CONTINUED THE TALK IN THE HER FINGERS, SHE THAT HER VEHICLE WAS
MISSED. WE WENT INTO HIS OFFICE TO SEE IF WE COULD HELP PROFESSOR
FLITWICK AND FIND HIM LINGERING IN THE FLIGHT AND HE, IT'S
SHE HEAVILY NEAR, SNAPE MUST HAVE STOPPED FLITWICK, BUT WE DIDN'T
REALIZE, HARRY, WE DIDN'T REALIZE, WE JUST LET SNAPE GO. IT'S NOT
YOUR FAULT, SAID LUPIN FIRMLY. HERMION, HAD SHE NOT SEEN
SNAPE AND GET HIT BY THE WAY, HE PROBABLY WOULD HAVE KILLED HER
AND LUNA. SHE THEN HE CAME UPSTAIRS, SAID HARRY, WHEN WAS
WATCHING SNAPE RUNNING UP THE MARBLE STAIRCASE IN HIS MIND'S
EYE, HIS BLACK ROBES KILLING BEHIND HIM AS EVER, PULLING HIS WAND
FROM UNDER HIS CLOAK AS HE ASCENDED, AND HE FOUND THE PLACE WHERE
SHE WERE ALL FIGHTING. WE WERE IN TROUBLE, WE WERE LOSING,
SAID TONKS IN A LOW VOICE. GIBBY WAS DOWN, BUT THE REST OF THE
DEATH EATERS SEEMED READY TO FIGHT THE DEATH. NEVILLE HAD BEEN
HURT, KILL HAD BEEN SAVAGED BY CROOKSHANK IT WAS ALL DARK
CLOTHES FLYING EVERYWHERE THE MALFOYS HAD VANISHED, HE
MUST HAVE SLIPPED PAST, UP THE STAIRS THEN MORE OF THEM RAN
AFTER HIM, BUT ONE OF THEM BLOCKED THE STAIR BEHIND THEM WITH SOME
KIND OF CURSE. NEVILLE RAN AT IT AND GET THROWN UP INTO THE
AIR WHEN HE WAS BREAD THROUGH, SAID RON, AND THAT
MASSIVE DEATH EATER WAS STILL FIRING OFF INKES ALL OVER THE PLACE,
THEY WERE BOUNCING OFF THE WALLS AND BARELY MISSING US, AND
THEN SNAPE WAS THERE, SAID TONKS, AND THEN HE WASN'T I
SAW HIM RUNNING TOWARD US, BUT THAT HUGE DEATH EATER'S INK JUST
MISSED ME RIGHT AFTERWARD AND I CLIMBED AND LOST TRACK OF THINGS,
SAID GINNY. I SAW HIM RUN STRAIGHT THROUGH THE CURSED BARRIER
AS THOUGH IT WASN'T THERE, SAID LUPIN. I TRIED TO FOLLOW HIM, BUT
HE WAS THROWN BACK JUST LIKE NEVILLE. HE MUST HAVE KNOWN A
SPELL WE DIDN'T, WHISPERED MCGONAGALL. AFTER ALL HE WAS THE
DEFENSE AGAINST THE DARK ARTS TEACHER. I JUST ASSUMED THAT HE
WAS IN A HURRY TO CHASE AFTER THE DEATH EATERS WHEN HE ESCAPED UP

THE THE THEWER. HE WAS, SAID HARRY SAVAGELY, BUT THE HELP THEM, NOT THE STOP THEM AND I'LL BET YOU'VE HAD THE HAVE A DARK MARK THE GET THROUGH THAT BARRIER SEE WHAT HAPPENED WHEN HE CAME BACK DOWN? WELL, THE BIG DEATH EATER HAD JUST FIRED OFF A HEX THAT CAUSED HALF THE CEILING TO FALL IN, AND ALSO KNOCKED THE CLOSE BLECKING THE STAIRS, SAID KLIPIN. WE ALL RAN FORWARD THESE OF US WHO WERE STILL STANDING ANYWAY AND THEN SNAPE AND THE KID EMERGED OUT OF THE DUST HEAVILY, NEENE OF US ATTACKED THEM

WE JUST LET THEM PASS, SAID THEIRS IN A FELLOW VOICE. WE THOUGHT THEY WERE BEING CHASED BY THE DEATH EATERS AND NEXT THING, THE OTHER DEATH EATERS AND GREYBACK WERE BACK AND WE WERE FIGHTING AGAIN I THOUGHT I HEARD SNAPE SAY SOMETHING, BUT I DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HE SAID, IT'S OVER, SAID HARRY.

HE'D THINK WHAT HE'D MEANT THE DEE. THEY ALL FELL SILENT, FALDER'S LAMENT WAS STILL ECHOING OVER THE DARK GREENLANDS HILLSIDE, AS THE MUSIC REVERBERATED UPON THE AIR, LINKEDEN, LINKEDEN THOUGHTS SLID INTO HARRY'S MIND. HAD THEY TAKEN DUMBLEDORE'S BODY FROM THE FEET OF THE THEWER YET? WHAT WOULD HAPPEN THE IT NEXT? WHERE WOULD IT REST? HE CLENCHED HIS FISTS TIGHTLY IN HIS POCKETS. HE COULD FEEL THE SMALL CHILD LUMP OF THE FADDER THROCKLE AGAINST THE BONES OF HIS RIGHT HAND. THE DEERS OF THE HOSPITAL WING FIRST OPEN, MAKING THEM ALL JUMP! MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY WERE STRIDING UP THE WARD, FLEET JUST BEHIND THEM, HER BEAUTIFUL FACE TERRIFIED.

MELLY ARTHUR SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, LIMPING UP AND HURRYING TO GREET THEM. I AM SO SORRY KILL, WHISPERED MRS. WEASLEY, DARTING PAST PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL AS SHE CAUGHT SIGHT OF KILL'S MANGLED FACE. EH, KILL! KLIPIN AND THEIRS HAD GET UP FASTLY AND RETREATED SEE THAT MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY COULD GET NEARER THE THE RED, MRS. WEASLEY KENT OVER HER SHOULDER AND PRESSED HER LIPS TO HIS BLEEDY FOREHEAD. YOU SAID GREYBACK ATTACKED HIM? MR. WEASLEY ASKED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL DISTRACTEDLY. BUT HE HADN'T TRANSFORMED? SEE WHAT DEES THAT MEANS? WHAT WILL HAPPEN THE KILL?

WE DIDN'T YET KNOW, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, LOOKING HELPLESSLY AT KLIPIN. THERE WILL PROBABLY BE SOME CONTAMINATION, ARTHUR, SAID KLIPIN. IT IS AN ODD CASE, POSSIBLY UNUSUAL. WE DIDN'T KNOW WHAT HIS BEHAVIOUR MIGHT BE LIKE WHEN HE AWAKENS. MRS. WEASLEY THREW THE NASTY-SMELLING MINTMENT FROM MADAM POMFREY AND BEGAN DARTING AT KILL'S WOUNDS. AND DUMBLEDORE

SAID MR. WEASLEY, MINERVA, IS IT TRUE IS HE REALLY ? AS PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL NEEDED, HARRY FELT GINNY MOVE BESIDE HIM AND LOOKED AT HER, HER SLIGHTLY NARROWED EYES WERE FIXED UPON FLEUR, WHO WAS GAZING DOWN AT KILL WITH A FROZEN EXPRESSION ON HER FACE. DUMBLEDORE THEN, WHISPERED MR. WEASLEY, BUT MRS. WEASLEY HAD EYES ONLY FOR HER ELDEST SON; SHE BEGAN THE SILENT TEARS FALLING DOWN KILL'S MUTILATED FACE. HE HOWEVER, IT DOESN'T MATTER WHEN HE LOOKS. IT'S NOT REALLY IMPORTANT BUT HE WAS A VERY HANDSOME LITTLE BOY ALWAYS VERY HANDSOME AND HE WAS GOING TO BE MARRIED! AND WHAT DID YOU MEAN BY THAT? SAID FLEUR SUDDENLY AND BOLDLY. WHAT DID YOU MEAN, I WAS GOING TO BE MARRIED? MRS. WEASLEY RAISED HER TEAR-STAINED FACE, LOOKING STARTLED. WELL ONLY THAT YOU THINK KILL WILL NOT WISH TO MARRY ME ANYMORE? DEMANDED FLEUR. YOU THINK, BECAUSE OF THESE KITES, HE WILL NOT LOVE ME? NO, THAT'S NOT WHAT I

BECAUSE I WILL! SAID FLEUR, DRAWING HERSELF UP TO HER FULL HEIGHT AND TURNING BACK HER LONG MANE OF SILVER HAIR. IT WOULD TAKE MORE THAN A WEREWOLF TO STOP KILL LOVING ME! WELL, YES, I'M SURE, SAID MRS. WEASLEY, BUT I THINK IT PERHAPS GIVEN WHEN WHEN HE YOU THINK I WOULD NOT WISH TO MARRY HIM? HER PERIODS, YOU THINK? SAID FLEUR, HER NOSTRILS FLARING. WHAT DID I CARE WHEN HE LOOKS? I AM CONSIDERING ENOUGH FOR BOTH OF US, I THINK! ALL THESE STARS SHOW IS THAT MY HUSBAND IS BRAVE! AND I SHALL BE THAT! SHE ADDED FIRMLY, PUSHING MRS. WEASLEY ASIDE AND SNATCHING THE HINTMENT FROM HER. MRS. WEASLEY FELL BACK AGAINST HER HUSBAND AND WATCHED FLEUR MOPPING UP KILL'S TEARS WITH A MOST CLIMACTIC EXPRESSION UPON HER FACE. NEVER SAID ANYTHING; HARRY DID NOT DARE MOVE. LIKE EVERYBODY ELSE, HE WAS WAITING FOR THE EXPLOSION. ELIA GREAT-ANTIE MURIEL, SAID MRS. WEASLEY AFTER A LONG PAUSE, HAS A VERY BEAUTIFUL TIARA GEMMA-MADE WHICH I AM SURE I COULD PERSUADE HER TO LEND YOU FOR THE WEDDING. SHE IS VERY FOND OF KILL, YOU KNOW, AND IT WOULD BECOME BEAUTIFUL WITH YOUR HAIR. THANK YOU, SAID FLEUR STIFFLY. I AM SURE THAT WILL BE BEAUTIFUL. AND THEN, HARRY DID NOT HAVE TO SEE WHEN IT HAPPENED, BOTH WOMEN WERE CRYING AND HUGGING EACH OTHER, COMPLETELY BEMUSED, WONDERING WHETHER THE WORLD HAD GONE MAD, HE TURNED AROUND; WHEN LOOKED AS STUNNED AS HE FELT AND GINNY AND HERMIONIE WERE EXCHANGING STARTLED LOOKS. YOU SEE? SAID A STRAINED VOICE.

THENDS WAS GLARING AT LLIPIN. SHE STILL WANTS TO MARRY HIM, EVEN THOUGH HE'S BEEN BITTEN? SHE DOESN'T CARE? IT'S DIFFERENT, SAID LLIPIN, BARELY MOVING HIS LIPS AND LOOKING SLIDENLY TENSE. KILL WILL NOT BE A FULL WEREWOLF. THE CASES ARE COMPLETELY BUT I DON'T CARE EITHER, I DON'T CARE? SAID THENDS, SEIZING THE FRONT OF LLIPIN'S SHOULDERS AND SHAKING THEM. I'VE TOLD YOU A MILLION TIMES.

AND THE MEANING OF THENDS'S PATRONS AND HER MELT-COLOURED HAIR, AND THE REASON SHE HAD COME RUNNING THE FIRST DUMKLEDHIRE WHEN SHE HAD HEARD A RUMOUR SOMEONE HAD BEEN ATTACKED BY GRYBACK, ALL SLIDENLY BECAME CLEAR TO HARRY. IT HAD NOT BEEN SURPRISE THAT THENDS HAD FALLEN IN LOVE WITH AFTER ALL. AND I'VE TOLD YOU A MILLION TIMES, SAID LLIPIN, REPLACING THE MEET HER EYES, STARING AT THE FLOOR, THAT I AM THE ONLY ONE YOU, THE OTHER THE DANGEROUS. I'VE SAID ALL ALONG YOU'RE TAKING A RIDICULOUS

LINE IN THIS, REMUS, SAID MRS. WEASLEY EVER FELTER'S SHOULDERS AS SHE PATTED HER ON THE BACK. I AM NOT BEING RIDICULOUS, SAID LLIPIN STEADILY. THENDS DESERVES SOMEHOW FEELING AND WEIR. BUT SHE WANTS YOU, SAID MR. WEASLEY, WITH A SMALL SMILE. AND AFTER ALL, REMUS, FEELING AND WEIR MEN DO NOT NECESSARILY REMAIN THE. HE GESTURED SADLY AT HIS SON, LYING BETWEEN THEM. THIS IS NOT THE MOMENT TO DISCUSS IT, SAID LLIPIN, AVOIDING EVERYBODY'S EYES AS HE LOOKED AROUND DISTRACTEDLY. DUMKLEDHIRE IS DEAD. DUMKLEDHIRE WOULD HAVE BEEN HAPPIER THAN ANYBODY TO THINK THAT THERE WAS A LITTLE MORE LOVE IN THE WORLD. SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL CLUTCHING, JUST AS THE HOSPITAL DOORS OPENED AGAIN AND HARRY WALKED IN. THE LITTLE OF HIS FACE THAT WAS NOT HIDDEN BY HAIR OR BEARD WAS SHADING AND SWELLING. HE WAS SHAKING WITH TEARS, A VAST, SPOTTED HANDKERCHIEF IN HIS HAND. I'VE I'VE DONE IT, PROFESSOR, HE CHUCKED. MOVING HIM. PROFESSOR SPRELLT'S GOT THE KIDS BACK IN BED. PROFESSOR FLITWICK'S LYING DOWN, BUT HE SAYS HE'LL BE ALL RIGHT IN A MINUTE, AND PROFESSOR SLUGGISHORN SAYS THE MINISTRY'S BEEN INFORMED.

THANK YOU, HARRY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL, STANDING UP AT ONCE AND TURNING THE HEAD AT THE GIRL AROUND KILL'S BED. I SHALL HAVE TO SEE THE MINISTRY WHEN THEY GET HERE. HARRY, PLEASE TELL THE HEADS OF HOUSES. SLUGGISHORN CAN REPRESENT SLYTHERIN THAT I WANT TO SEE THEM IN MY OFFICE FORTHWITH. I WOULD LIKE YOU TO BE THERE. AS HARRY NEEDED, TURNED, AND SLIPPED OUT OF THE ROOM AGAIN, SHE LOOKED DOWN AT HARRY. BEFORE I MEET THEM I

WOULD LIKE A HELIX WIND WITH YOU, HARRY, IF YOU LL COME WITH ME.

HARRY STOOD UP, MURMURED SEE YOU IN A MIN THE ROOM, HERMIONE, AND GINNY, AND FOLLOWED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL BACK DOWN THE HALL. THE CORRIDORS OUTSIDE WERE DESERTED AND THE ONLY SOUND WAS THE DISTANT PHOENIX SONG. IT WAS SEVERAL MINUTES BEFORE HARRY BECAME AWARE THAT THEY WERE NOT HEADING FOR PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL'S OFFICE, BUT FOR DUMBLEDORE'S, AND ANOTHER FEW SECONDS BEFORE HE REALIZED THAT HE CHOOSE, SHE HAD BEEN DEPUTY HEADMISTRESS. APPARENTLY SHE WAS NOW HEADMISTRESS. SHE THE ROOM BEHIND THE GARGOYLE WAS NOW HIS. IN SILENCE THEY ASCENDED THE MOVING SPIRAL STAIRCASE AND ENTERED THE CIRCULAR OFFICE. HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT HE HAD EXPECTED: THAT THE ROOM WOULD BE DRAPED IN BLACK, PERHAPS, OR EVEN THAT DUMBLEDORE'S BODY MIGHT BE LYING THERE. IN FACT, IT LOOKED ALMOST EXACTLY AS IT HAD BEEN WHEN HE AND DUMBLEDORE HAD LEFT IT MORE FEELS PREVIOUSLY: THE SILVER INSTRUMENTS WHIRRING AND PLOPPING ON THEIR SPINDLE-LEGGED TABLES, GRYFFINDOR'S SCARF IN ITS GLASS CASE GLEAMING IN THE MIDDNIGHT, THE SHIRTING THAT ON A SHELF BEHIND THE DESK, BUT FALGERS'S PERCH STOOD EMPTY, HE WAS STILL CRYING HIS LAMENT TO THE GRIFFINDORS, AND A NEW PORTRAIT HAD HUNG THE HANDS OF THE DEAD HEADMASTERS AND HEADMISTRESSES OF HOGWARTS: DUMBLEDORE WAS SLIMMERING IN A GOLDEN FRAME OVER THE DESK, HIS HALF-MOON SPECTACLES PERCHED UPON HIS CRINKLED NOSE, LOOKING PEACEFUL AND UNTRoubLED. AFTER GLANCING ONCE AT THIS PORTRAIT, PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL MADE AN EDD MOVEMENT AS THOUGH STEELING HERSELF, THEN WHINNED THE DESK THE LOOK AT HARRY, HER FACE TALT AND LINED. HARRY, SHE SAID, I WOULD LIKE TO KNOW WHAT YOU AND PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE WERE DOING THIS EVENING WHEN YOU LEFT THE SCHOOL. I CAN T TELL YOU THAT, PROFESSOR, SAID HARRY, HE HAD EXPECTED THE ELDESTERN AND HAD HIS ANSWER READY. IT HAD BEEN HERE, IN THIS VERY ROOM, THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD TOLD HIM THAT HE WAS THE CHANCE THE CONTENTS OF THEIR LESSONS TO THE NEWLY BUT ROOM AND HERMIONE. HARRY, IT MIGHT BE IMPORTANT, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. IT IS, SAID HARRY, VERY, BUT HE DIDN T WANT ME TO TELL ANYONE. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL GLARED AT HIM. BETTER HARRY REGISTERED THE REVELED LIE OF HIS SURNAME

IN THE LIGHT OF PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE'S DEATH, I THINK YOU MUST SEE THAT THE SITUATION HAS CHANGED SOMEWHAT I DON T THINK SHE, SAID HARRY, SHRUGGING. PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE NEVER

TELL ME THE STAFF FOLLOWING HIS ORDERS IF HE DIED. BUT THERE'S
ONE THING YOU SHOULD KNOW BEFORE THE MINISTRY GETS HERE,
THOUGH. MADAM PRESHMATA'S UNDER THE IMPERILUS CURSE, SHE WAS
HELPING MALFOY AND THE DEATH EATERS, THAT'S WHY THE NECKLACE AND
THE POISONED MEAD. PRESHMATA? SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL
INCREDULOUSLY, BUT BEFORE SHE COULD GO ON, THERE WAS A KNOCK ON
THE DOOR BEHIND THEM AND PROFESSORS SPRETT, FLITWICK, AND
SLUGGORN TRAIPSED INTO THE ROOM, FOLLOWED BY FLOAGRID, WHO WAS
STILL WEeping EMPHATICALLY, HIS HUGE FRAME TREMBLING WITH GRIEF.

SNAPE? EXCLAIMED SLUGGORN, WHO LOOKED THE MOST SHAKEN, PALE
AND SWEATING. SNAPE? I TAUGHT HIM? I THOUGHT I KNEW HIM? BUT
BEFORE ANY OF THEM COULD RESPOND TO THIS, A SHARP VOICE SPoke
FROM HIGH ON THE WALL: A SALLER-FACED WIZARD WITH A SHORT BLACK
FRINGE HAD JUST WALKED BACK INTO HIS EMPTY CANVAS. MINERVA, THE
MINISTER WILL BE HERE WITHIN SECONDS, HE HAS JUST DISAPPEARED
FROM THE MINISTRY. THANK YOU, EVERARD, SAID PROFESSOR
MCGONAGALL, AND SHE TURNED QUICKLY TO HER TEACHERS. I WANT THE
TALK ABOUT WHAT HAPPENS THE FOLLOWING BEFORE HE GETS HERE, SHE
SAID QUICKLY. PERSONALLY, I AM NOT CONVINCED THAT THE SCHOOL
SHOULD REOPEN NEXT YEAR. THE DEATH OF THE HEADMASTER AT THE
HANDS OF ONE OF OUR COLLEAGUES IS A TERRIBLE STAIN UPON
HOGWARTS'S HISTORY. IT IS HORRIBLE. I AM SURE DUMBLEDORE WOULD
HAVE WANTED THE SCHOOL TO REMAIN OPEN, SAID PROFESSOR SPRETT.

I FEEL THAT IF A SINGLE PUPIL WANTS TO COME, THEN THE SCHOOL
MIGHT REMAIN OPEN FOR THAT PUPIL. BUT WILL WE HAVE A SINGLE
PUPIL AFTER THIS? SAID SLUGGORN, NOW DABBLING HIS SWEATING BROW
WITH A SILKEN HANDKERCHIEF. PARENTS WILL WANT TO KEEP THEIR
CHILDREN AT HOME AND I CAN'T SAY I BLAME THEM. PERSONALLY, I DON'T
THINK WE'RE IN MORE DANGER AT HOGWARTS THAN WE ARE ANYWHERE
ELSE, BUT YOU CAN'T EXPECT PARENTS TO THINK LIKE THAT. THEY DO
WANT TO KEEP THEIR FAMILIES TOGETHER, IT'S ONLY NATURAL. I
AGREE, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. AND IN ANY CASE, IT IS NOT
TRUE TO SAY THAT DUMBLEDORE NEVER ENVISAGED A SITUATION IN WHICH
HOGWARTS MIGHT CLOSE. WHEN THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS REOPENED HE
CONSIDERED THE CLOSURE OF THE SCHOOL. AND I MUST SAY THAT
PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE'S MURDER IS MORE DISTURBING TO ME THAN THE
IDEA OF SLYTHERIN'S MINISTER LIVING UNDETECTED IN THE REELS OF THE
CASTLE. WE MUST CONSULT THE GOVERNORS, SAID PROFESSOR

FLITWICK IN HIS SELEADY LITTLE VEHICLE; HE HAD A LARGE KRUISE ON HIS
 THREE-HEAD BUT SEEMED OTHERWISE UNSCATHED BY HIS COLLAPSE IN
 SNAPE'S OFFICE. WE MUST FOLLOW THE ESTABLISHED PROCEDURES, A
 DECISION SHOULD NOT BE MADE HASTILY. HARRY, WHO HAD NOT SAID
 ANYTHING, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. WHAT ARE YOUR VIEWS,
 ALIGHT HOGWARTS THE REMAIN OPEN? HARRY, WHO HAD BEEN WEAVING
 SILENTLY INTO HIS LARGE, SPOTTED HANDKERCHIEF THOUGHTFUL THIS
 CONVERSATION, NOW RAISED PLUMPY RED EYES AND CRIED, I DUNN
 PROFESSOR THAT I PER THE HEADS OF HOUSE AND THE HEADMISTRESS
 TO DECIDE PROFESSOR DUMBLEDORE ALWAYS VALUED YOUR VIEWS,
 SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL KINDLY, AND SHE DID I. WELL, I'M
 STAYING, SAID HARRY, HIS TEARS STILL LEADING HIM TO THE CORNERS OF
 HIS EYES AND TRICKLING DOWN INTO HIS TANGLED BEARD. IT'S MY HOME,
 IT'S MY HOME SINCE I WAS THIRTEEN, AND IF THERE'S ANY WAY I CAN
 MAKE THEM TEACH ME, I'LL DO IT, BUT I DUNN HOGWARTS WITH
 DUMBLEDORE HE GLIMPSED AND DISAPPEARED BEHIND HIS HANDKERCHIEF
 ONCE MORE, AND THERE WAS SILENCE. VERY WELL, SAID PROFESSOR
 MCGONAGALL, GLANCING HIM IN THE WINDING AT THE GREENS, CHECKING
 TO SEE WHETHER THE MINISTER WAS YET APPROACHING, THEN I MUST
 AGREE WITH FILIS THAT THE RIGHT THING TO DO IS TO CONSULT THE
 GOVERNORS, WHO WILL MAKE THE FINAL DECISION. NOW, AS THE GETTING
 STUDENTS HOME THERE IS AN ARGUMENT FOR DOING IT SOONER
 RATHER THAN LATER, WE COULD ARRANGE FOR THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS TO
 COME THROUGH IF NECESSARY WHAT ABOUT DUMBLEDORE'S
 FUNERAL? SAID HARRY, SPEAKING AT LAST. WELL SAID PROFESSOR
 MCGONAGALL, LEANING A LITTLE ON HER KRUISENESS AS HER VEHICLE STOPPED.
 I I KNOW THAT IT WAS DUMBLEDORE'S WISH THAT HE LAID TO REST HERE,
 AT HOGWARTS THEN THAT'S WHAT WILL HAPPEN, ISN'T IT? SAID
 HARRY FIRMLY. IF THE MINISTRY THINKS IT APPROPRIATE, SAID
 PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. NEITHER HEADMASTER NOR HEADMISTRESS
 HAS EVER BEEN NEITHER HEADMASTER NOR HEADMISTRESS EVER
 GAVE MORE TO THIS SCHOOL, CRIED HARRY. HOGWARTS SHOULD BE
 DUMBLEDORE'S FINAL RESTING PLACE, SAID PROFESSOR FLITWICK.
 ABSOLUTELY, SAID PROFESSOR SPRUIT, AND IN THAT CASE, SAID
 HARRY, WHO SHOULD NOT SEND THE STUDENTS HOME UNTIL THE FUNERAL IS
 OVER. THEY WILL WANT TO SAY THE LAST WORD CALLED IN HIS
 THROAT, BUT PROFESSOR SPRUIT COMPLETED THE SENTENCE FOR HIM.
 GOOD-BYE, WELL SAID, SELEADED PROFESSOR FLITWICK. WELL SAID

INDEED? THEIR STUDENTS SHOULD PAY TRIBUTE, IT IS FITTING. WE CAN
ARRANGE TRANSPORT HOME AFTERWARD. SECONDED, BARRED PROFESSOR
SPARKS. I SUPPOSE YES SAID SLIGHTLY IN A RATHER AGITATED
VOICE, WHILE HARRY LET HIM A STRANGLED SILENT. HE S
HEMING, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL SUDDENLY, GAZING DOWN INTO
THE GROUND. THE MINISTER AND BY THE LOOKS OF IT, HE S
KNOWS A DELEGATION CAN I LEAVE, PROFESSOR? SAID HARRY AT
ONCE. HE HAD NO DESIRE AT ALL THE SEE, HE BE INTERROGATED BY, ALICE
SCURRYING THROUGHT. WELL MAY, SAID PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL.

AND QUICKLY, SHE STRODE TOWARD THE DOOR AND HELD IT OPEN FOR
HIM. HE SPED DOWN THE SPIRAL STAIRCASE AND OFF ALONG THE DESERTED
CORRIDOR; HE HAD LEFT HIS INVISIBILITY CLOAK AT THE TOP OF THE
ASTRONOMY TOWER, BUT IT DID NOT MATTER; THERE WAS NOBODY IN THE
CORRIDORS TO SEE HIM PASS, NOT EVEN FICK, MRS. DUMBLEDORE, OR PERCY.
HE DID NOT MEET ANYONE UNTIL HE TURNED INTO THE PASSAGE
LEADING TO THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM. IS IT TRUE? WHISPERED
THE FAT LADY AS HE APPROACHED HER. IT IS REALLY TRUE? DUMBLEDORE

DEAD? YES, SAID HARRY. SHE LET HIM A WAIL AND, WITHOUT
WAITING FOR THE PASSWORD, SWUNG FORWARD TO ADMIT HIM. AS HARRY
HAD SUSPECTED IT WOULD BE, THE COMMON ROOM WAS JAMPACKED. THE
ROOM FELL SILENT AS HE CLIMBED THROUGH THE PORTRAIT HOLE. HE SAW
DEAN AND SEamus SITTING IN A CHAIR NEARBY. THIS MEANT THAT THE
DORMITORY MUST BE EMPTY, HE NEARLY SAW, WITHOUT SPEAKING TO
ANYBODY, WITHOUT MAKING EYE CONTACT AT ALL, HARRY WALKED
STRAIGHT ACROSS THE ROOM AND THROUGH THE DOOR TO THE BOYS
DORMITORIES. AS HE HAD HOPED, RON WAS WAITING FOR HIM, STILL FULLY
DRESSED, SITTING ON HIS BED. HARRY SAT DOWN ON HIS OWN FOUR-POSTER
AND FOR A MOMENT, THEY SIMPLY STARED AT EACH OTHER. THEY RE
TALKING ABOUT LEAVING THE SCHOOL, SAID HARRY. LUPIN SAID THEY
WOULD, SAID RON. THERE WAS A PAUSE. SHE SAID RON IN A VERY LOW
VOICE, AS THOUGH HE THOUGHT THE FURNITURE MIGHT BE LISTENING IN.

DID YOU FIND HER? DID YOU GET IT? A A THICKLY? HARRY SHOOK
HIS HEAD. ALL THAT HAD TAKEN PLACE AROUND THAT BLACK LAKE SEEMED
LIKE AN OLD NIGHTMARE NOW; HAD IT REALLY HAPPENED, AND ONLY
FEELS AS IF? YOU DIDN'T GET IT? SAID RON, LEANING CRESTFALLEN. IT
WASN'T THERE? NO, SAID HARRY. SOMEONE HAD ALREADY TAKEN IT
AND LEFT A PAPER IN ITS PLACE. ALREADY TAKEN ? WHERELESSLY,
HARRY PULLED THE PAPER PACKET FROM HIS POCKET, OPENED IT, AND

PASSED IT THE RHIN. THE SMALL STARRY CHILD WAIT. IT DID NOT MATTER
TENTH NIGHT. NOTHING MATTERED EXCEPT THE END, THE END OF THEIR
PAINLESS ADVENTURE, THE END OF DUMBLEDORE'S LIFE. RAZ,
WHISPERED RHIN, BUT WHAT WAS THAT? DUNNIE, SAID HARRY, LYING
BACK IN HIS BED FULLY CLOTHED AND STARING BLANKLY UPWARDS, HE FELT
NEW CLARITY AT ALL ABELT RAZ. HE BELIEVED THAT HE WOULD EVER
FEEL CLARITY AGAIN. AS HE LAY THERE, HE BECAME AWARE SUDDENLY THAT
THE GRIFINDORS WERE SILENT, FALLOWS HAD STOPPED SINGING, AND HE
KNEW, WITHOUT KNOWING HOW HE KNEW IT, THAT THE PHOENIX HAD
GONE, HAD LEFT HOGWARTS AND GONE, JUST AS DUMBLEDORE HAD LEFT THE
SCHOOL, HAD LEFT THE WORLD. HAD LEFT HARRY. THE WHITE TIE ALL
LESSONS WERE SUSPENDED, ALL EXAMINATIONS POSTPONED. SOME
STUDENTS WERE HURRIED AWAY FROM HOGWARTS BY THEIR PARENTS OVER
THE NEXT FEW DAYS. THE PATIL TWINS WERE GONE BEFORE
BREAKFAST IN THE MORNING FOLLOWING DUMBLEDORE'S DEATH, AND
ZACHARIAS SMITH WAS ESCORTED FROM THE CASTLE BY HIS HALCYON-
LOOKING FATHER. SEamus FINNIGAN, ON THE OTHER HAND, REFUSED
PAINFULLY THE ACCOMPANY HIS MOTHER HOME; THEY HAD A STUNNING
MATCH IN THE ENTRANCE HALL THAT WAS RESOLVED WHEN SHE AGREED
THAT HE SHOULD REMAIN BEHIND FOR THE FUNERAL. SHE HAD DIFFICULTY IN
FINDING A BED IN HOGSMEADE. SEamus TOLD HARRY AND RHIN, FOR
WIZARDS AND WITCHES WERE POURING INTO THE VILLAGE, PREPARING TO
PAY THEIR LAST RESPECTS TO DUMBLEDORE. SOME EXCITEMENT WAS CAUSED
AMONG THE YOUNGER STUDENTS, WHO HAD NEVER SEEN IT BEFORE, WHEN A
PHEASANT-BLUE CARRIAGE THE SIZE OF A HILL, PULLED BY A DOZEN GIANT
WINGED PHEASANTS, CAME SHARING OUT OF THE SKY IN THE LATE
AFTERNOON BEFORE THE FUNERAL AND LANDED ON THE EDGE OF THE FOREST.
HARRY WATCHED FROM A WINDOW AS A GIANTIC AND HANDSOME OLIVE-
SKINNED, BLACK-HAIRED WOMAN DESCENDED THE CARRIAGE STEPS AND
THREW HERSELF INTO THE WAITING HAGRID'S ARMS. MEANWHILE A
DELEGATION OF MINISTRY OFFICIALS, INCLUDING THE MINISTER OF MAGIC
HIMSELF, WAS BEING ACCOMMODATED WITHIN THE CASTLE. HARRY WAS
DILIGENTLY AVOIDING CONTACT WITH ANY OF THEM; HE WAS SURE THAT,
WHENEVER HE LATER, HE WOULD BE ASKED AGAIN THE QUESTION FOR
DUMBLEDORE'S LAST EXCURSION FROM HOGWARTS. HARRY, RHIN,
HERMION, AND GINNY WERE SPENDING ALL OF THEIR TIME TOGETHER.
THE REALISTIC WEATHER SEEMED TO MIX THEM; HARRY COULD IMAGINE
HOW IT WOULD HAVE BEEN IF DUMBLEDORE HAD NOT DIED, AND THEY HAD

HAD THIS TIME TOGETHER AT THE VERY END OF THE YEAR, GINNY'S EXAMINATIONS FINISHED, THE PRESSURE OF HOMEWORK LIFTED AND FILLER BY FILLER, HE PLIT OFF SAYING THE THING THAT HE KNEW HE MUST SAY, BEING WHAT HE KNEW WAS RIGHT THE DEE, BECAUSE IT WAS THEE HARD THEE HENCE HIS BEST SHOT OF CHANCE. THEY VISITED THE HOSPITAL WING TWICE A DAY: NEVILLE HAD BEEN DISCHARGED, BUT KILL REMAINED UNDER MADAM POMPREE'S CARE, HIS SCARS WERE AS BAD AS EVER IN TRUTH, HE NEEL HAD A DISTINCT RESEMBLANCE THEE MAD-LYR MEEH, THOUGH HANDSOMELY WITH KEETH EYES AND LEGS BUT IN PERSONALITY HE SEEMED JUST THE SAME AS EVER. ALL THAT APPEARED THEE HAVE CHANGED WAS THAT HE NEEL HAD A GREAT LIKING FOR VERY RARE STEAKS. SHE EET RES LUCKY E IS MARRYING ME, SAID FILLER HAPPILY, PLOMPING UP KILL'S PILLOWS, BECAUSE ZE BRITISH OVERCOOK THEIR MEAT, I AVE ALWAYS SAID THIS. I SUPPOSE I M JUST BEING THEE HAVE THEE ACCEPT THAT HE REALLY IS BEING THEE MARRY HER, SIGHED GINNY LATER THAT EVENING, AS SHE, HARRY, REEN, AND HERMIONE SAT BESIDE THEE OPEN WINDOWS OF THE GRYFFINDOR COMMON ROOM, LOOKING OUT OVER THE TWILIT GREENS. SHE S NEET THAT BAD, SAID HARRY, LGLY, THOUGH, HE ADDED HASTILY, AS GINNY RAISED HER EYEBROWS, AND SHE LET OUT A RELUCTANT GIGGLE. WELL, I SUPPOSE IF MUM CAN STAND IT, I CAN.

ANYONE ELSE WE KNOW DIED? REEN ASKED HERMIONE, WHO WAS PERUSING THE EVENING PROPHET, HERMIONE WINCED AT THE FORCED BRIGHTNESS IN HIS VOICE. NEH, SHE SAID REPRISINGLY, HOLDING UP THE NEWSPAPER. THEY RE STILL LOOKING FOR SNAPE BUT NEH SIGN

OF COURSE THERE ISN'T, SAID HARRY, WHO BECAME ANGRY EVERY TIME THIS SUBJECT CROPPED UP. THEY WEN'T FIND SNAPE TILL THEY FIND VERBEMERT, AND SEEING AS THEY VE NEVER MANAGED THEE DEE THAT IN ALL THIS TIME I M BEING THEE GET THEE RED, YALINED GINNY, I HAVEN'T BEEN SLEEPING THAT WELL SINCE WELL I COULD DEE WITH SOME SLEEP.

SHE KISSED HARRY (REEN LOOKED AWAY PHINTEDLY), WAVED AT THE OTHER TWO, AND DEPARTED FOR THE GIRLS' DORMITORIES. THE MOMENT THE DEER HAD CLOSED BEHIND HER, HERMIONE LEANED FORWARD TOWARD HARRY WITH A MOST HERMIONELISH LOOK ON HER FACE. HARRY, I FEELING SOMETHING OUT THIS MORNING, IN THE LIBRARY. RAB? SAID HARRY, SITTING UP STRAIGHT. HE DID NEET FEEL THE WAY HE HAD SEEN HETEN FELT BEFORE, EXCITED, CLUTTERED, BURNING THEE GET THEE THEE BATTERED OF A MYSTERY; HE SIMPLY KNEW THAT THE TASK OF DISCOVERING THE TRUTH ABOUT THE REAL HERCULES HAD THEE BE COMPLETED BEFORE HE COULD MOVE A

LITTLE FARTHER ALONG THE DARK AND WINDING PATH STRETCHING AHEAD OF HIM, THE PATH THAT HE AND DUMBLEDORE HAD SET OUT TOGETHER, AND WHICH HE NOW KNEW HE WOULD HAVE THE HONOUR ALONE. THERE MIGHT STILL BE AS MANY AS FIFTY THIRDSOME OUT THERE SOMEWHERE, AND EACH WOULD NEED TO BE FOUND AND ELIMINATED BEFORE THERE WAS EVEN A POSSIBILITY THAT VOLDEMORT COULD BE KILLED. HE KEPT RECITING THEIR NAMES TO HIMSELF, AS THOUGH BY LISTING THEM HE COULD BRING THEM WITHIN REACH: THE LICKET THE CLIP THE SNAKE

SOMETHING OF GRYPFINDER'S HER RAVENCLAW'S THE LICKET THE CLIP THE SNAKE SOMETHING OF GRYPFINDER'S HER RAVENCLAW'S THIS MANTRA SEEMED TO PULSE THROUGH HARRY'S MIND AS HE FELL ASLEEP AT NIGHT, AND HIS DREAMS WERE FILLED WITH CLIPS, LICKETS, AND MYSTERIOUS OBJECTS THAT HE COULD NOT quite REACH, THOUGH DUMBLEDORE HELPFULLY OFFERED HARRY A ROPE LADDER THAT TURNED THE SNAKES THE MOMENT HE BEGAN TO CLIMB. HE HAD SEEN HERMIONE THE NIGHT INSIDE THE LICKET THE MORNING AFTER DUMBLEDORE'S DEATH, AND ALTHOUGH SHE HAD NOT IMMEDIATELY RECOGNIZED THE INITIALS AS BELONGING TO THE SAME MISERABLE WIZARD ABOUT WHOM SHE HAD BEEN READING, SHE HAD SINCE BEEN FLIPPING OFF THE THE LIBRARY A LITTLE MORE OFTEN THAN WAS STRICTLY NECESSARY FOR SOMEONE WHO HAD NO HOMEWORK TO DO. NO, SHE SAID SADLY, I'VE BEEN TRYING, HARRY, BUT I HAVEN'T FOUND ANYTHING. THERE ARE A COUPLE OF REASONABLY WELL-KNOWN WIZARDS WITH THESE INITIALS ROSALIND ANTIQUE KLINGS RUPERT AMERANGER BRIGHTSTANTON

BUT THEY DON'T SEEM TO FIT AT ALL. JUDGING BY THAT NIGHT, THE PERSON WHO STOLE THE THIRDSOME KNEW VOLDEMORT, AND I CAN'T FIND A SHRED OF EVIDENCE THAT KLINGS OR AMERANGER EVER HAD ANYTHING TO DO WITH HIM. NO, ACTUALLY, IT'S ABOUT WELL, SNAPE. SHE BLINKED NERVOUSLY EVEN SAYING THE NAME AGAIN. WHAT ABOUT HIM? ASKED HARRY HEAVILY, SLUMPING BACK IN HIS CHAIR. WELL, IT'S JUST THAT I WAS SORT OF RIGHT ABOUT THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE BUSINESS, SHE SAID TENTATIVELY. DO YOU HAVE THE BOOK IT IN, HERMIONE? YES DO YOU THINK I FEEL ABOUT THAT NOW? NO NO HARRY, I DIDN'T MEAN THAT! SHE SAID FASTLY, BLINKING AROUND THE CORNER THAT THEY WERE NOT BEING OVERHEARD. IT'S JUST THAT I WAS RIGHT ABOUT KILN PRINCE BEING ALONG THE ROAD, YOU SEE SHE WAS SNAPE'S MOTHER! I THOUGHT SHE WASN'T MUCH OF A LEADER, SAID BEN. HERMIONE IGNORED HIM. I WAS GOING THROUGH THE REST OF THE

PROPHECIES AND THERE WAS A TINY ANNOUNCEMENT ABOUT EILEEN PRINCE
 MARRYING A MAN CALLED THEODAS SNAPE, AND THEN LATER AN
 ANNOUNCEMENT SAYING THAT SHE'D GIVEN BIRTH TO A
 MURDERER, SPAT HARRY, WELL YES, SAID HERMIONE, SHE I WAS
 SHORT OF RIGHT, SNAPE MUST HAVE BEEN PROBABLY HER KING HALF A
 PRINCE, WHY SEE? THEODAS SNAPE WAS A MUGGLE FROM WHAT IT SAID IN
 THE PROPHECY, YES, THAT FITS, SAID HARRY, HE'D PLAY UP THE
 PURE-BLOOD SIDE SHE HE COULD GET IN WITH BLAIR'S MOTHER AND THE REST
 OF THEM, HE'S JUST LIKE VANDERBILT, PURE-BLOOD MOTHER, MUGGLE
 FATHER ASKED OF HIS PARENTAGE, TRYING TO MAKE HIMSELF FEARED
 LISTENING TO DARK ARTS, GAVE HIMSELF AN IMPRESSIVE NEW NAME
 LORD VANDERBILT THE HALF-BLOOD PRINCE HE COULD
 DUMBLEDORE HAVE MISSED? HE KNEW HER, REMEMBERING THAT THE
 WINDS, HE COULD NOT STOP HIMSELF DREAMING UPON DUMBLEDORE'S
 INEXHAUSTIBLE TRUST IN SNAPE BUT AS HERMIONE HAD JUST
 INADVERTENTLY REMINDED HIM, HE, HARRY, HAD BEEN TAKEN IN JUST THE
 SAME, IN SPITE OF THE INCREASING NASTINESS OF THESE STRICKLED
 SPELLS, HE HAD REFUSED TO BELIEVE IN THE END WHEN HAD BEEN SHE
 CLEVER, WHEN HAD HELPED HIM SHE MUCH, HELPED HIM IT WAS AN
 ALMOST UNDENIABLE TRUTHFULNESS, I STILL DON'T GET WHY HE DIDN'T
 TURN UP IN HER LISTING THAT KNEW, SAID HERM, HE MUST BE KNOWN
 WHERE THEY WERE GETTING IT ALL FROM, HE KNEW, SAID HARRY
 BITTERLY, HE KNEW WHEN I USED SECTIMSEMPRA, HE DIDN'T REALLY NEED
 LEGILIMENCY, HE MIGHT EVEN HAVE KNOWN BEFORE THEN, WITH
 SLUGGISHORN TALKING ABOUT HOW BRILLIANT I WAS AT PARTIES,
 SHOULDN'T HAVE LEFT HIS HEAD KNEW IN THE BATTERED OF THAT CLIPBOARD,
 SHOULD HE? BUT WHY DIDN'T HE TURN UP IN? I DON'T THINK HE
 WANTED TO ASSOCIATE HIMSELF WITH THAT KNEW, SAID HERMIONE, I
 DON'T THINK DUMBLEDORE WOULD HAVE LIKED IT VERY MUCH IF HE'D
 KNOWN, AND EVEN IF SNAPE PRETENDED IT HADN'T BEEN HIS, SLUGGISHORN
 WOULD HAVE RECOGNIZED HIS WRITING AT ONCE, ANYWAY, THE KNEW WAS
 LEFT IN SNAPE'S HAND CLASSROOM, AND I'M BET DUMBLEDORE KNEW HIS
 MOTHER WAS CALLED PRINCE, I SHOULD BE SHOWN THE KNEW THE
 DUMBLEDORE, SAID HARRY, ALL THAT TIME HE WAS SHOWING ME HOW
 VANDERBILT WAS EVIL EVEN WHEN HE WAS AT SCHOOL, AND I HAD PROOF
 SNAPE WAS THE EVIL IS A STRONG WORD, SAID HERMIONE
 QUIETLY, THEY WERE THE ONE WHEN KEPT TELLING ME THE KNEW WAS
 DANGEROUS? I'M TRYING TO SAY, HARRY, THAT THEY'RE PLOTTING THEM

MUCH BLAME ON HIMSELF, I THOUGHT THE PRINCE SEEMED TO HAVE A
NASTY SENSE OF HUMOUR, BUT I WOULD NEVER HAVE GUESSED HE WAS A
POTENTIAL KILLER. WHEN OF HIS CHILD WE GUESSED SNAPE WOULD

WHY DON'T, SAID REIN. SILENCE FELL BETWEEN THEM, EACH OF THEM
LOST IN THEIR OWN THOUGHTS, BUT HARRY WAS SURE THAT THEY, LIKE
HIM, WERE THINKING ABOUT THE FOLLOWING MORNING, WHEN
DUMBLEDORE'S BODY WOULD BE LAID TO REST. HE HAD NEVER ATTENDED A
FUNERAL BEFORE; THERE HAD BEEN ONE BODY THE DAY WHEN SIRILIS HAD
DIED, BUT HE DID NOT KNOW WHAT TO EXPECT AND WAS A LITTLE NERVOUS
ABOUT WHAT HE MIGHT SEE, ABOUT HOW HE WOULD FEEL. HE WONDERED
WHETHER DUMBLEDORE'S DEATH WOULD BE MORE REAL TO HIM BECAUSE IT WAS
EVER. THOUGH HE HAD MEMENTS WHEN THE HORRIBLE FACT OF IT
THREATENED TO OVERWHELM HIM, THERE WERE BLANK STRETCHES OF
NUMBNESS WHERE, DESPITE THE FACT THAT SOMEONE WAS TALKING ABOUT
ANYTHING ELSE IN THE WHITE CASTLE, HE STILL FELT IT DIFFICULT TO
BELIEVE THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD REALLY GONE. ADMITTEDLY HE HAD NOT, AS
HE HAD WITH SIRILIS, LOOKED DESPERATELY FOR SOME KIND OF COMFORT, BUT
THERE WAS THAT DUMBLEDORE WOULD COME BACK. HE FELT IN HIS
POCKET FOR THE CHAIN OF THE FATE CHARM, WHICH HE NOW
CARRIED WITH HIM EVERYWHERE, NOT AS A TALISMAN, BUT AS A REMINDER
OF WHAT IT HAD LOST AND WHAT REMAINED STILL TO BE. HARRY RISE
EARLY THE MORNING THE NEXT DAY; THE HOGWARTS EXPRESS WOULD BE
LEAVING AN HOUR AFTER THE FUNERAL. DOWNSTAIRS, HE FELT THE MIND
IN THE GREAT HALL SLIDING. EVERYONE WAS WEARING THEIR DRESS ROBES
AND NOW HE SEEMED VERY ELEGANT. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HAD LEFT
THE THREE-LEGGED CHAIR IN THE MIDDLE OF THE STAFF TABLE EMPTY.
HARRY'S CHAIR WAS DESERTED TOO; HARRY THOUGHT THAT PERHAPS HE
HAD NOT BEEN ABLE TO FACE BREAKFAST, BUT SNAPE'S PLACE HAD BEEN
UNCOMFORTABLY FILLED BY ROLAND STIMPSON. HARRY AVOIDED HIS
YELLOWISH EYES AS THEY SCANNED THE HALL; HARRY HAD THE
UNCOMFORTABLE FEELING THAT STIMPSON WAS LOOKING FOR HIM.
AMONG STIMPSON'S ENTERTAINING HARRY SPOTTED THE RED HAIR AND
HORN-RIMMED GLASSES OF PERCY WEASLEY. REIN GAVE HIM SIGN THAT HE
WAS AWARE OF PERCY, APART FROM STARRING PIECES OF BIPPER WITH
UNWANTED VIBES. EVER AT THE SOUTHERN TABLE CRABBE AND GOYLE
WERE MUTTERING TOGETHER. FOLLOWING THEM THOUGH THEY WERE, THEY
LOOKED HOPELESSLY UPON THE TALL, PALE FIGURE OF MALFOY
BETWEEN THEM, KISSING THEM ABOUT. HARRY HAD NOT SPARED MALFOY

MUCH TWILIGHT, HIS ANIMOSITY WAS ALL HER SHARE, BUT HE HAD NOT FORGOTTEN THE FEAR IN MALPHY'S VOICE WHEN THAT TERROR THROU, WHEN THE FACT THAT HE HAD LOWERED HIS HAND BEFORE THE HITLER DEATH PATERS ARRIVED. HARRY DID NOT BELIEVE THAT MALPHY WOULD HAVE KILLED DUMBLEDORE. HE DESPISED MALPHY STILL FOR HIS INFATUATION WITH THE DARK ARTS, BUT WHEN THE TINIEST DROP OF PITY MINGLED WITH HIS DISLIKE. WHERE, HARRY WONDERED, WAS MALPHY NOW, AND WHAT WAS VULNERABLE MAKING HIM BE UNDER THREAT OF KILLING HIM AND HIS PARENTS? HARRY'S THOUGHTS WERE INTERRUPTED BY A NOISE IN THE RISE FROM CINNY. PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL HAD RISEN TO HER FEET, AND THE MELLONIAN FILM IN THE HALL DIED AWAY AT ONCE. IT IS NEARLY TIME, SHE SAID. PLEASE FOLLOW YOUR SEATS OF SEATBELTS INTO THE GREENHouses, GRYFFINDORS, AFTER ME. THEY FILED INTO FROM BEHIND THEIR BENCHES IN NEAR SILENCE. HARRY GLIMPSED SLUGGISHORN AT THE HEAD OF THE SLYTHERIN CHAIRMAN, WEARING MAGNIFICENT, LONG, EMERALD GREEN ROBES EMBROIDERED WITH SILVER. HE HAD NEVER SEEN PROFESSOR SPURRIT, HEAD OF THE FLAMEPOLES, LOOKING SO CLEAN; THERE WAS NOT A SINGLE PATCH ON HER HAIR, AND WHEN THEY REACHED THE ENTRANCE HALL, THEY FOUND MADAM PINCE STANDING BESIDE FILCH, SHE IN A THICK BLACK VEIL THAT FELL TO HER KNEES, HE IN AN ANCIENT BLACK SLIT AND TIE RECKING OF MINT-BALLS. THEY WERE HEADING, AS HARRY SAW WHEN HE STOPPED INTO THE STONE STEPS FROM THE FRONT DOORS, TOWARD THE LAKE. THE WARMTH OF THE SUN CARESSED HIS FACE AS THEY FOLLOWED PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL IN SILENCE TO THE PLACE WHERE HUNDREDS OF CHAIRS HAD BEEN SET INTO IN ROWS, AN AISLE RAN DOWN THE CENTER OF THEM. THERE WAS A MARBLE TABLE STANDING AT THE FRONT, ALL CHAIRS FACING IT. IT WAS THE MOST BEAUTIFUL SUMMER'S DAY, AN EXTRAORDINARY ASSORTMENT OF PEOPLE HAD ALREADY SETTLED INTO HALF OF THE CHAIRS; SHAGGY AND SMART, OLD AND YOUNG, MOST HARRY DID NOT RECOGNIZE, BUT A FEW HE DID, INCLUDING MEMBERS OF THE ORDER OF THE PHOENIX: KINGSLEY SHACKLEBOLT; MAD-EYE Moody; THUNDERS, HER HAIR MIRACULOUSLY RETURNED THE VIVIDEST PINK; REMUS LUPIN, WITH WHOM SHE SEEMED TO BE HOLDING HANDS; MR. AND MRS. WEASLEY; BILL SLIPPONATED BY FLEUR AND FOLLOWED BY FRED AND GEORGE, WHO WERE WEARING JACKETS OF BLACK DRAGON SKIN. THEN THERE WAS MADAME MAXIME, WHO THROU UP TWO AND A HALF CHAIRS ON HER OWN; THEN, THE LANDLORD OF THE LEADY CALDERON IN LONDON; ARABELLA FIGG, HARRY'S SHELVE NEIGHBOR; THE FAIRY BASS PLAYER FROM THE WIZARDING GRIMM

THE WEIRD SISTERS; ERNIE PRANG, DRIVER OF THE KNIGHT BUS; MADAM MALDIN, OF THE THREE SHEEP IN DIAGEN ALLEY; AND SOME PEOPLE WHOM HARRY MERELY KNEW BY SIGHT, SUCH AS THE BARMAN OF THE FIVE S HEAD AND THE WITCH WHO PULSED THE TROLLY IN THE FIVEWARTS EXPRESS. THE CASTLE GUESTS WERE THERE TOO, BARELY VISIBLE IN THE BRIGHT SUNLIGHT, DISCERNIBLE ONLY WHEN THEY MOVED, SHIMMERING INSTANTANEOUSLY IN THE GLASSING AIR. HARRY, RICH, FERMINE, AND GINNY FILED INTO SEATS AT THE END OF A ROW BESIDE THE LAKE. PEOPLE WERE WHISPERING TO EACH OTHER; IT SEEMED LIKE A BREEZE IN THE GRASS, BUT THE KIDSHINE WAS LOUDER BY FAR. THE CROWD CONTINUED TO SWELL; WITH A GREAT GLISH OF AFFECTION FOR BOTH OF THEM, HARRY SAW NEVILLE KING HELPED INTO A SEAT BY LUNA. NEVILLE AND LUNA ALONE OF THE D.A. HAD RESPONDED TO FERMINE'S SUMMONS THE NIGHT THAT DUMBLEDORE HAD DIED, AND HARRY KNEW WHY: THEY WERE THE ONES WHO HAD MISSED THE D.A. MEET PROBABLY THE ONES WHO HAD CHECKED THEIR CHINS REGULARLY IN THE HOPE THAT THERE WOULD BE ANOTHER MEETING. CHERNILLIS FLICKER WALKED PAST TOWARD THE FRONT ROWS, HIS EXPRESSION MISERABLE, TWIRLING HIS GREEN BELLER HAT AS USUAL; HARRY NEXT RECOGNIZED RITA SKEETER, WHO, HE WAS INFORMED THE SEE, HAD A NEUTRAL CLUTCHED IN HER RED-TAILED HAND, AND THEN, WITH A WHIRL OF FLAIR, DEBBIES L'JERIDGE, AN UNCONVINCING EXPRESSION OF GRIEF UPON HER THROATLINE FACE, A BLACK VELVET BEL SET AROUND HER IRON-CHEELED CLIPS. AT THE SIGHT OF THE CENTRAL FIRENZE, WHO WAS STANDING LIKE A SENTINEL NEAR THE WATER'S EDGE, SHE GAVE A START AND SLURRIED HASTILY INTO A SEAT A GOOD DISTANCE AWAY. THE STAFF WAS SEATED AT LAST. HARRY COULD SEE SCRIMPHELIAR LEADING GRAVE AND DIGNIFIED IN THE FRONT ROW WITH PROFESSOR MCGONAGALL. HE WONDERED WHETHER SCRIMPHELIAR HAD ANY OF THESE IMPORTANT PEOPLE WERE REALLY SURE THAT DUMBLEDORE WAS DEAD, BUT THEN HE HEARD MUSIC, STRANGE, OTHERWORLDLY MUSIC, AND HE FORGOT HIS DISLIKE OF THE MINISTRY IN LEADING AROUND FOR THE SHELVE OF IT. HE WAS NOT THE ONLY ONE: MANY HEADS WERE TURNING, SEARCHING, A LITTLE ALARMED. IN THERE, WHISPERED GINNY IN HARRY'S EAR, AND HE SAW THEM IN THE CLEAR GREEN SLINKIT WATER, INCHES BELOW THE SURFACE, REMINDING HIM FEARFULLY OF THE INFERI: A CHERLIS OF MURDERERS SINGING IN A STRANGE LANGUAGE HE DID NOT UNDERSTAND, THEIR PALLID FACES RIPPLING, THEIR PURPLISH HAIR FLOWING ALL AROUND THEM. THE MUSIC MADE THE HAIR ON HARRY'S NECK STAND UP, AND YET IT WAS NOT

UNPLEASANT. IT SPoke VERY CLEARLY OF LOSS AND OF DESPAIR. AS HE
 LOOKED DOWN INTO THE WILD FACES OF THE SINGERS, HE HAD THE FEELING
 THAT THEY, AT LEAST, WERE SHINY FOR DUMBLEDORE'S PASSING. THEN
 GINNY NUDGED HIM AGAIN AND HE LOOKED AROUND. FJAGRID WAS
 WALKING SILENTLY UP THE AISLE BETWEEN THE CHAIRS. HE WAS CRYING
 SILENTLY, HIS FACE GLEAMING WITH TEARS, AND IN HIS ARMS,
 WRAPPED IN PURPLE VELVET SPANGLED WITH GOLDEN STARS, WAS WHAT
 HARRY KNEW THE DE DUMBLEDORE'S BODY. A SHARP PAIN RISE IN
 HARRY'S THROAT AT THIS SIGHT: FOR A MOMENT, THE STRANGE MUSIC
 AND THE KNOWLEDGE THAT DUMBLEDORE'S BODY WAS SO CLOSE SEEMED TO
 TAKE ALL WARMTH FROM THE DAY. THEN HE LOOKED WHITE AND STILLED.
 TEARS WERE FALLING THICK AND FAST INTO BOTH GINNY'S AND
 HERMIONE'S LAPS. THEY COULD NOT SEE CLEARLY WHAT WAS HAPPENING
 AT THE FRONT. FJAGRID SEEMED TO HAVE PLACED THE BODY CAREFULLY UPON
 THE TABLE. THEN HE RETREATED DOWN THE AISLE, BLEWING HIS NOSE WITH
 A LOUD TRUMPETING NOISE THAT DREW STANDALIZED LOOKS FROM SOME,
 INCLUDING, HARRY SAW, DEANES LEMBRIDGE. BUT HARRY KNEW THAT
 DUMBLEDORE WOULD NOT HAVE CARED. HE TRIED TO MAKE A FRIENDLY
 GESTURE TO FJAGRID AS HE PASSED, BUT FJAGRID'S EYES WERE SO SWOLLEN
 IT WAS A WONDER HE COULD SEE WHERE HE WAS GOING. HARRY GLANCED AT
 THE BACK WHEN THE WHICH FJAGRID WAS HEADING AND REALIZED WHAT WAS
 GUIDING HIM, FOR THERE, DRESSED IN A JACKET AND TROUSERS EACH THE
 SIZE OF A SMALL MARBLE, WAS THE GIANT GRALP. HIS GREAT WILD
 CHILDERLIKE HEAD BOWED, DENSE, ALMOST HUMAN. FJAGRID SAT DOWN NEXT
 TO HIS HALF-BROTHER, AND GRALP PATTED FJAGRID HARD ON THE HEAD, SO
 THAT HIS HAIR LIES SAND INTO THE GRIDLING. HARRY HAD A WONDERFUL
 MOMENTARY LURE TO LAUGH, BUT THEN THE MUSIC STOPPED, AND HE
 TURNED THE FACE THE FRONT AGAIN. A LITTLE TWISTY-FAIRED MAN IN PLAIN
 BLACK ROBES HAD GOTTEN HIS FEET AND STOOD NOW IN FRONT OF
 DUMBLEDORE'S BODY. HARRY COULD NOT HEAR WHAT HE WAS SAYING. FIVE
 WORDS FLEWED BACK TO THEM OVER THE HUNDREDS OF HEADS. SERILITY
 OF SPIRIT INTELLECTUAL CONTRADICTION GREATNESS OF HEART

IT DID NOT MEAN VERY MUCH. IT HAD LITTLE TO DO WITH DUMBLEDORE
 AS HARRY HAD KNOWN HIM. HE SUDDENLY REMEMBERED DUMBLEDORE'S IDEA
 OF A FEW WORDS, NITWIT, MOMENT, KILCKER, AND TREAD, AND
 AGAIN HAD TO SUPPRESS A GRIN. WHAT WAS THE MATTER WITH HIM?
 THERE WAS A SOFT SPLASHING NOISE TO HIS LEFT AND HE SAW THAT THE
 MERPEOPLE HAD BREKEN THE SURFACE TO LISTEN THEM. HE REMEMBERED

OLMKEDEHE CRUELCHING AT THE WATER S EDGE TWO YEARS AGH, VERY
CLOSE THE WHERE FARRY NEHL SAT, AND CHNVERSING IN MERMISH WITH
THE MERCHIEPTAINNESS, FARRY WHNDERED WHERE OLMKEDEHE HAD
LEARNED MERMISH. THERE WAS SH MUCH HE HAD NEVER ASKED HIM, SH
MUCH HE SHOULD HAVE SAID. AND THEN, WITH-ELT WARNING, IT SWPT
EVER HIM, THE DREADFUL TRUTH, MORE COMPLETELY AND LINDENIABLY THAN
IT HAD UNTIL NEHL. OLMKEDEHE WAS DEAD, CHNE. HE CLUTCHED THE
CHILD LOCKET IN HIS HAND SH TIGHTLY THAT IT HURT, BUT HE CHILD NEET
PREVENT HET TEARS SPILLING FROM HIS EYES: HE LEEKED AWAY FROM
GINNY AND THE OTHERS AND STARED ELT EVER THE LAKE, THEWARD THE
FOREST, AS THE LITTLE MAN IN BLACK DRENED HEN. THERE WAS
MOVEMENT AMONG THE TREES, THE CENTALIRS HAD COME THE PAY THEIR
RESPECTS THEE. THEY DID NEET MEVE INTO THE HEDEN BUT FARRY SAW
THEM STANDING ELITE STILL, HALF HIDDEN IN SHADELS, WATCHING THE
WIZARDS, THEIR KEELS HANGING AT THEIR SIDES. AND FARRY REMEMBERED
HIS FIRST NIGHTMARISH TRIP INTO THE FOREST, THE FIRST TIME HE HAD
EVER ENCOUNTERED THE THING THAT WAS THEN VELDERT, AND HEN HE
HAD FACKED HIM, AND HEN HE AND OLMKEDEHE HAD DISCUSSED FIGHTING A
LEETING BATTLE NEET BEING THEREAFTER. IT WAS IMPERTANT, OLMKEDEHE
SAID, THE FIGHT, AND FIGHT AGAIN, AND DEEP FIGHTING, FOR HENLY THEN
CHILD EVIL BE DEPT AT EAY, THELIGHT NEVER ELITE ERADICATED. AND
FARRY SAW VERY CLEARLY AS HE SAT THERE LINDER THE HET SUN HEN
PEOPLE WHO CARED ABELT HIM HAD STEED IN FRONT OF HIM HEN BY HEN,
HIS MOTHER, HIS FATHER, HIS CHDFAHER, AND FINALLY OLMKEDEHE, ALL
DETERMINED THE PROTECT HIM; BUT NEHL THAT WAS EVER, HE CHILD NEET
LET ANYBODY ELSE STAND BETWEEN HIM AND VELDERT; HE MUST
ABANDEN FOREVER THE ILLUSION HE ELIGHT THE HAVE BEET AT THE AGE OF
HEN, THAT THE SHELTER OF A PARENT S ARMS MEANT THAT NOTHING
CHILD HURT HIM. THERE WAS NE WAKING FROM HIS NIGHTMARE, NE
CHMPERTING WHISPER IN THE DARK THAT HE WAS SAFE REALLY, THAT IT
WAS ALL IN HIS IMAGINATION; THE LAST AND GREATEST OF HIS
PROTECTERS HAD DIED, AND HE WAS MORE ALONE THAN HE HAD EVER BEEN
BEFORE. THE LITTLE MAN IN BLACK HAD STEPPED SPREADING AT LAST AND
RESUMED HIS SEAT. FARRY WAITED FOR SOMEBODY ELSE THE GET THE THEIR
FEET; HE EXPECTED SPEECHES, PROBABLY FROM THE MINISTER, BUT NEEBODY
MEVED. THEN SEVERAL PEOPLE SCREAMED, BRIGHT, WHITE FLAMES HAD
ERUPTED AROUND OLMKEDEHE S BODY AND THE TABLE UPON WHICH IT LAY;
HIGHER AND HIGHER THEY ROSE, ERSCLING THE BODY, WHITE SMOKE

SPIRALED INTO THE AIR AND MADE STRANGE SHAPES: F-JARRY T-H-I-G-H-T, A-H-E-R H-E-N-E H-E-A-R-T-S-T-E-P-P-I-N-G M-E-M-E-N-T, T-H-A-T H-E S-A-W A P-E-N-N-I-X F-L-Y I-M-P-U-L-S-I-V-L-Y I-N-T-H-E B-L-I-Z-E, B-U-T N-E-X-T S-E-C-O-N-D T-H-E F-I-R-E H-A-D V-A-N-I-S-H-E-D. I-N I-T-S P-L-A-C-E W-A-S A W-H-I-T-E M-A-R-K-L-E T-H-E-R-E, E-N-C-A-S-I-N-G D-I-M-P-L-E-D-H-I-R-E S-K-I-N-A-N-D T-H-E T-A-B-L-E H-E-N W-H-I-C-H H-E H-A-D R-E-S-T-E-D. T-H-E-R-E W-E-R-E A F-E-W M-O-R-E C-R-I-E-S H-E-S-I-M-I-L-A-R AS A S-H-E-E-R H-E-A-R-N-E-L-S S-H-A-R-E-D T-H-R-O-U-G-H T-H-E A-I-R, B-U-T T-H-E-Y F-E-L-L F-A-R S-H-O-R-T H-E-T-H-E C-R-E-E-L-D. I-T W-A-S, F-JARRY D-E-N-E-W, T-H-E C-E-N-T-A-L-I-R-S T-R-I-B-U-T-E: F-H-E S-A-W T-H-E-M T-U-R-N T-A-I-L A-N-D D-I-S-A-P-P-E-A-R B-A-C-K I-N-T-H-E C-H-I-I-L T-R-E-E-S. L-I-K-E-W-I-S-E, T-H-E M-E-R-P-E-O-P-L-E S-A-N-D S-L-I-E-D B-A-C-K I-N-T-H-E G-R-E-E-N W-A-T-E-R A-N-D W-E-R-E L-E-S-T F-R-O-M V-I-E-W. F-JARRY L-O-O-K-E-D A-T G-I-N-N-Y, R-E-E-N, A-N-D F-H-E-R-M-I-N-E: R-E-E-N S F-A-C-E W-A-S S-T-R-E-W-E-D U-P A-S T-H-E-L-I-G-H-T W-E-R-E B-L-I-N-D-I-N-G H-I-M. F-H-E-R-M-I-N-E S F-A-C-E W-A-S G-L-A-Z-E-D W-I-T-H T-E-A-R-S, B-U-T G-I-N-N-Y W-A-S N-E-E H-I-N-G-E-R C-R-Y-I-N-G. S-H-E M-E-T F-JARRY S G-A-Z-E W-I-T-H T-H-E S-A-M-E H-A-R-D, B-L-A-Z-I-N-G L-O-O-K T-H-A-T H-E H-A-D S-E-E-N W-H-E-N S-H-E H-A-D F-L-I-G-E-E-D H-I-M A-F-T-E-R W-I-N-N-I-N-G T-H-E E-L-I-D-I-T-T-E-H C-U-P I-N H-I-S A-B-S-E-N-C-E, A-N-D H-E D-K-N-E-W T-H-A-T A-T T-H-A-T M-E-M-E-N-T T-H-E-Y U-N-D-E-R-S-T-O-O-D E-A-C-H O-T-H-E-R P-E-R-F-E-C-T-L-Y, A-N-D T-H-A-T W-H-E-N H-E T-E-L-D H-E-R W-H-A-T H-E W-A-S G-I-V-I-N-G T-H-E D-E-E-N N-E-E-L, S-H-E W-O-U-L-D N-E-E-T S-A-Y, B-E C-A-R-E-F-U-L, H-E-R D-E-E-N T D-E-E I-T, B-U-T A-C-C-E-P-T H-I-S D-E-C-I-S-I-O-N, B-E-C-A-U-S-E S-H-E W-O-U-L-D N-E-E-T H-A-V-E E-X-P-E-C-T-E-D A-N-Y-T-H-I-N-G L-E-S-S H-E-H-I-M. A-N-D S-H-E S-T-E-E-L-E-D H-I-M-S-E-L-F T-H-E S-A-Y W-H-A-T H-E H-A-D D-E-E-N-E-D H-E M-U-S-T S-A-Y E-V-E-R S-I-N-C-E D-I-M-P-L-E-D-H-I-R-E H-A-D D-I-E-D. G-I-N-N-Y, L-I-S-T-E-N H-E S-A-I-D V-E-R-Y S-O-F-T-L-Y, A-S T-H-E B-L-I-Z-Z H-E C-O-N-V-E-R-S-A-T-I-O-N G-R-E-W L-O-U-D-E-R A-R-O-U-N-D T-H-E-M A-N-D P-E-O-P-L-E B-E-G-A-N T-H-E G-E-T T-H-E T-H-E-I-R F-E-E-T, I C-A-N T B-E I-N-V-O-L-V-E-D W-I-T-H Y-E-L-L A-N-Y-M-O-R-E. W-E V-E G-E-T T-H-E S-T-E-P S-E-E-I-N-G E-A-C-H O-T-H-E-R, W-E C-A-N T B-E T-O-G-E-T-H-E-R. S-H-E S-A-I-D, W-I-T-H A-N H-O-D-D-Y T-W-I-S-T-E-D S-M-I-L-E, I-T S A-H-E S-E-E-M S-T-U-P-I-D, N-E-E-K-L-E R-E-A-S-O-N, I-S-N T I-T? I-T S K-E-E-N L-I-K-E L-I-K-E S-O-M-E-T-H-I-N-G H-E-L-T H-E S-O-M-E-T-H-I-N-G E-L-S-E S L-I-F-E, T-H-E-S-E L-A-S-T F-E-W W-E-E-K-S W-I-T-H Y-E-L-L, S-A-I-D F-JARRY, B-U-T I C-A-N T W-E C-A-N T I V-E G-E-T T-H-I-N-G-S T-H-E D-E-E A-L-O-N-E N-E-E-L. S-H-E D-I-D N-E-E-T C-R-Y, S-H-E S-I-M-P-L-Y L-O-O-K-E-D A-T H-I-M. V-E-R-D-E-M-E-N-T L-I-K-E-S P-E-O-P-L-E H-I-S E-N-E-M-I-E-S A-R-E C-L-O-S-E T-H-E, F-H-E S A-L-R-E-A-D-Y L-I-S-E-D Y-E-L-L A-S B-A-I-T H-I-N-C-E, A-N-D T-H-A-T W-A-S I-L-I-S-T B-E-C-A-U-S-E Y-E-L-L R-E M-Y B-E-S-T F-R-I-E-N-D S S-I-S-T-E-R. T-H-I-N-K F-H-E-L-M-I-C-H D-A-N-G-E-R Y-E-L-L W-I-L-L B-E I-N I-F W-E D-E-E-P T-H-I-S U-P, F-H-E W-I-L-L D-E-E-N, H-E W-I-L-L F-I-N-D H-E-L-T, F-H-E W-I-L-L T-R-Y A-N-D G-E-T T-H-E M-E T-H-R-O-U-G-H Y-E-L-L. W-H-A-T I-F I D-E-E-N T C-A-R-E? S-A-I-D G-I-N-N-Y F-I-R-C-E-L-Y, I C-A-R-E, S-A-I-D F-JARRY, F-H-E-L-M D-E-E Y-E-L-L T-H-I-N-K I D F-E-E-L I-F T-H-I-S W-A-S Y-E-L-L-I-R F-U-N-E-R-A-L A-N-D I-T W-A-S M-Y F-A-L-I-T. S-H-E L-O-O-K-E-D A-W-A-Y F-R-O-M H-I-M, E-V-E-R T-H-E L-A-K-E. I N-E-V-E-R R-E-A-L-L-Y G-A-V-E U-P H-E-N Y-E-L-L, S-H-E S-A-I-D, N-E-E-T R-E-A-L-L-Y, I A-L-W-A-Y-S H-E-E-P-E-D. F-H-E-R-M-I-N-E T-E-L-D M-E T-H-E G-E-T H-E-N W-I-T-H L-I-F-E, M-A-Y-B-E G-E-H H-E-L-T W-I-T-H S-O-M-E O-T-H-E-R P-E-O-P-L-E, R-E-L-A-X A-B-I-T A-R-O-U-N-D Y-E-L-L,

BECAUSE I NEVER LIED THE HEARD THE TALK IF THEY WERE IN THE ROOM,
 REMEMBER? AND SHE THOUGHT THEY MIGHT TAKE A KIT MORE NOTICE IF I
 WAS A KIT MORE MYSELF. SMART GIRL, THAT HERMION, SAID
 HARRY, TRYING THE SMILE. I JUST WISH I'D ASKED THEM SOMETHING, WE
 COULD'VE HAD AGES MONTHS YEARS MORE. BUT THEY'VE BEEN
 THERE LONGER SAYING THE WIZARDING WORLD, SAID GINNY, HALF LAUGHING.
 WELL I CAN'T SAY I'M SURPRISED, I KNEW THIS WOULD HAPPEN IN
 THE END, I KNEW THEY WOULDN'T BE HAPPY UNLESS THEY WERE HUNTING
 Voldermort, MAYBE THAT'S WHY I LIKE THEM SO MUCH. HARRY COULD
 NOT HEAR THE HEAR THESE THINGS, NOR DID HE THINK HIS RESOLUTION
 WOULD HOLD IF HE REMAINED SITTING BESIDE HER. THEN, HE SAW, WAS HE
 HOLDING HERMION AND STROKING HER HAIR WHILE SHE SLEPT INTO HIS
 SHOULDER, TEARS DRIPPING FROM THE END OF HIS NOSE BEING THERE. WITH
 A MISERABLE GESTURE, HARRY GOT UP, TURNED HIS BACK ON GINNY AND
 ON DUMBLEDORE'S TABLE, AND WALKED AWAY AROUND THE LAKE. MOVING
 FELT MUCH MORE BEARABLE THAN SITTING STILL, JUST AS SETTING OUT AS
 SOON AS POSSIBLE THE TRACK DOWN THE HILLSIDES AND KILL Voldermort
 WOULD FEEL BETTER THAN WAITING THE DAY IT. HARRY? HE TURNED,
 RUFUS SCRIMGEOR WAS LIMPING RAPIDLY TOWARD HIM AROUND THE
 LAKE, LEANING ON HIS WALKING STICK. I'VE BEEN HEARING THE HAVE A
 WORD DO YOU MIND IF I WALK A LITTLE WAY WITH YOU? NO, SAID
 HARRY INDIFFERENTLY, AND SET OFF AGAIN. HARRY, THIS WAS A DREADFUL
 TRAGEDY, SAID SCRIMGEOR QUIETLY. I CANNOT TELL YOU HOW
 APPALLED I WAS THE HEAR OF IT, DUMBLEDORE WAS A VERY GREAT WIZARD,
 WE HAD OUR DISAGREEMENTS, AS YOU KNOW, BUT NOT MORE KNOWS BETTER
 THAN I. WHAT DO YOU WANT? ASKED HARRY FLATLY. SCRIMGEOR
 SMILED ANNOYED, BUT AS BEFORE, HASTILY MODIFIED HIS EXPRESSION THE
 MORE HE SHOWED HIS UNDERSTANDING. YOU ARE, OF COURSE, DEVASTATED,
 HE SAID. I KNOW THAT YOU WERE VERY CLOSE TO DUMBLEDORE, I THINK
 YOU MAY HAVE BEEN HIS FAVORITE PUPIL EVER. THE BOND BETWEEN THE
 TWO OF YOU. WHAT DO YOU WANT? HARRY REPEATED, CHEERING THE A
 PAUSE. SCRIMGEOR STOPPED THEM, LEANED ON HIS STICK, AND STARED AT
 HARRY, HIS EXPRESSION STARK AND NEW. THE WORD IS THAT YOU WERE
 WITH HIM WHEN HE LEFT THE SCHOOL THE NIGHT THAT HE DIED. WHERE
 WERE? SAID HARRY. SOMEHOW SLEEPED A DEATH LATER ON THE
 THE TOWER AFTER DUMBLEDORE DIED. THERE WERE ALSO TWO KITCHENSTICKS
 UP THERE. THE MINISTRY CAN ADD TWO AND TWO, HARRY. GLAD TO
 HEAR IT, SAID HARRY. WELL, WHERE I WENT WITH DUMBLEDORE AND

WHAT WE DID IS MY BUSINESS, HE DIDN'T WANT PEOPLE TO KNOW. SUCH
LOYALTY IS ADMIRABLE, HE CHURCH, SAID SCRINGHELM, WHO SEEMED TO BE
RESTRAINING HIS IRRITATION WITH DIFFICULTY, BUT DUMBLEDORE IS GOING
HARRY, HE'S GOING. HE WILL ONLY BE GOING FROM THE SCHOOL WHEN
WHEN THERE ARE LEADS TO HIM, SAID HARRY, SMILING IN SPITE OF
HIMSELF. MY DEAR BOY EVEN DUMBLEDORE CANNOT RETURN FROM THE

I AM NOT SAYING HE CAN, YET WHO WOULD NOT UNDERSTAND, BUT I'VE
GIVEN NOTHING TO TELL YET. SCRINGHELM HESITATED, THEN SAID, IN WHAT
WAS EVIDENTLY SUPPOSED TO BE A TONE OF DELICACY, THE MINISTRY CAN
OFFER YET ALL SORTS OF PROTECTION, YET KNOW, HARRY, I WOULD BE
DELIGHTED TO PLACE A CHURCH OF MY ALIENS AT YOUR SERVICE

HARRY LAUGHED. VERMOREL WANTS TO KILL ME HIMSELF, AND ALIENS
WHEN I STOP HIM, SEE HANDS FOR THE OFFER, BUT NOT HANDS. SEE,
SAID SCRINGHELM, HIS VOICE HAD BEEN, THE REQUEST I MADE OF YET AT
CHRISTMAS WHAT REQUEST? HEY YEAH THE ONE WHERE I TELL

THE WORLD WHAT A GREAT THE YET BE DOING IN EXCHANGE FOR
FOR RAISING EVERYONE'S MIND? SNAPPED SCRINGHELM, HARRY
CONSIDERED HIM FOR A MOMENT. RELEASED STAN SHINDLER YET?
SCRINGHELM TURNED A NASTY PURPLE COLOR HIGHLY REMINISCENT OF
UNCLE VERMOREL. I SEE YET ARE DUMBLEDORE'S MAN THROUGH AND
THROUGH, SAID HARRY, THAT'S RIGHT. SCRINGHELM GLARED AT HIM
FOR ANOTHER MOMENT, THEN TURNED AND LIMPED AWAY WITHOUT
ANOTHER WORD, HARRY COULD SEE PERCY AND THE REST OF THE MINISTRY
DELEGATION WAITING FOR HIM, CASTING NERVOUS GLANCES AT THE
SHAKING HAGRID AND GRABP, WHO WERE STILL IN THEIR SEATS, RON AND
HERMIONIE WERE HURRYING TOWARD HARRY, PASSING SCRINGHELM
GOING IN THE OPPOSITE DIRECTION, HARRY TURNED AND WALKED SLOWLY
ON, WAITING FOR THEM TO CATCH UP, WHICH THEY FINALLY DID IN THE
SHADE OF A REEF TREE UNDER WHICH THEY HAD SAT IN HAPPIER TIMES.

WHAT DID SCRINGHELM WANT? HERMIONIE WHISPERED. SAME AS HE
WANTED AT CHRISTMAS, SHRIEKED HARRY. WANTED ME TO GIVE HIM
INSIDE INFORMATION ON DUMBLEDORE AND BE THE MINISTRY'S NEW
PETER BOY. RON SEEMED TO STRUGGLE WITH HIMSELF FOR A MOMENT,
THEN HE SAID LOUDLY TO HERMIONIE, HEED, LET ME GO BACK AND HIT
PERCY? NO, SHE SAID FIRMLY, GRABBING HIS ARM. IT'LL MAKE ME FEEL
BETTER? HARRY LAUGHED, EVEN HERMIONIE GRINNED A LITTLE, THOUGH
HER SMILE FADED AS SHE WHEEZED UP AT THE CASTLE. I CAN'T BEAR THE IDEA
THAT WE MIGHT NEVER COME BACK, SHE SAID SLEETLY. WHO CAN

HOGWARTS CHIEF? MAYBE IT WHEN T, SAID REIN. WE'RE NOT IN ANY
 MORE DANGER HERE THAN WE ARE AT HOME, ARE WE? EVERYWHERE'S THE
 SAME NOW. I'D EVEN SAY HOGWARTS IS SAFER, THERE ARE MORE WIZARDS
 INSIDE THE DEFEND THE PLACE. WHAT'D YOU RECKON, HARRY? I'M NOT
 COMING BACK EVEN IF IT DOES REOPEN, SAID HARRY. REIN GAZED AT HIM,
 BUT HERMIONIE SAID SADLY, I KNOW YOU WERE GOING TO SAY THAT, BUT
 THEN WHAT WILL YOU DO? I'M GOING BACK TO THE DURSLEYS SINCE
 MORE, BECAUSE DUMBLEDORE WANTED ME TO, SAID HARRY. BUT IT'LL BE A
 SHORT VISIT, AND THEN I'LL BE GOING FOR GOOD. BUT WHERE WILL YOU
 GO IF YOU DON'T COME BACK TO SCHOOL? I THOUGHT I MIGHT GO BACK
 TO GENDRIK'S SCHOOL, HARRY MUTTERED. HE HAD HAD THE IDEA IN HIS
 HEAD EVER SINCE THE NIGHT OF DUMBLEDORE'S DEATH. FOR ME, IT STARTED
 THERE, ALL OF IT, I'VE JUST GOT A FEELING I NEED TO GO THERE, AND I CAN
 VISIT MY PARENTS' GRAVES, I'D LIKE THAT. AND THEN WHAT? SAID
 REIN. THEN I'VE GOT THE TRACK BEHIND THE REST OF THE THIRTLIXES,
 HAVEN'T I? SAID HARRY, HIS EYES UPON DUMBLEDORE'S WHITE TOMB,
 REFLECTED IN THE WATER ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE LAKE. THAT'S WHAT
 HE WANTED ME TO DO, THAT'S WHY HE TOLD ME ALL ABOUT THEM, IF
 DUMBLEDORE WAS RIGHT AND I'M SURE HE WAS THERE ARE STILL
 FEWER OF THEM LEFT THERE, I'VE GOT TO FIND THEM AND DESTROY THEM, AND
 THEN I'VE GOT TO GO AFTER THE SEVENTH BIT OF VOLDERMORT'S SKELETON, THE
 BIT THAT'S STILL IN HIS BODY, AND I'M THE ONE WHO'S GOING TO KILL
 HIM, AND IF I MEET SEVERUS Snape ALONG THE WAY, HE ADDED, SEE
 MUCH THE BETTER FOR ME, SEE MUCH THE WORSE FOR HIM. THERE WAS A
 LONG SILENCE. THE CROWD HAD ALMOST DISPERSED NOW, THE STRAGGLERS
 GIVING THE MEMORIAL FIGURE OF GRAND A WIDE BERTH AS HE CLIMBED
 HARRY, WHOSE FEELS OF GRIEF WERE STILL ECHOING ACROSS THE WATER.
 WE'LL BE THERE, HARRY, SAID REIN. WHAT? AT YOUR ALMA AND
 UNCLE'S HOUSE, SAID REIN. AND THEN WE'LL GO WITH YOU WHEREVER
 YOU'RE GOING. NO SAID HARRY QUIETLY; HE HAD NOT CLIMBED
 WHEN THIS, HE HAD MEANT THEM TO UNDERSTAND THAT HE WAS
 UNDERTAKING THIS MOST DANGEROUS JOURNEY ALONE. YOU SAID THE LIS
 HOUSE BEFORE, SAID HERMIONIE QUIETLY, THAT THERE WAS TIME TO TURN
 BACK IF WE WANTED TO. WE'VE HAD TIME, HAVEN'T WE? WE'RE WITH YOU
 WHATEVER HAPPENS, SAID REIN. BUT MATE, YOU'RE GOING TO HAVE TO
 COME BEHIND MY MOM AND DAD'S HOUSE BEFORE WE DO ANYTHING ELSE,
 EVEN GENDRIK'S SCHOOL. WHY? BILL AND FLEUR'S WEDDING,
 REMEMBER? HARRY LOOKED AT HIM, STARTLED; THE IDEA THAT ANYTHING

AS NORMAL AS A WEDDING CHILD STILL EXIST SEEMED INCREDIBLE AND YET
WUNDERFUL. YEAH, WE SHOULDNT MISS THAT, HE SAID FINALLY, HIS
HAND CLOSED ALTERNATIVELY AROUND THE FADE FINGERLOCK, BUT IN SPITE
OF EVERYTHING, IN SPITE OF THE DARK AND TWISTING PATH HE SAW
STRETCHING AHEAD FOR HIMSELF, IN SPITE OF THE FINAL MEETING WITH
VEHDEMEHT HE KNEW MUST COME, WHETHER IN A MONTH, IN A YEAR, OR
IN TEN, HE FELT HIS HEART LIFT AT THE THOUGHT THAT THERE WAS STILL
HIS LAST CHILDEN DAY OF PEACE LEFT TO ENJOY WITH RICH AND HERMINE.
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